Catra and Glimmer - Queens of the Horde

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30439506.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra)

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season 4, Enemies to Lovers, Hurt/Comfort, Revenge, Drama, queen glimmer, Queen Catra, Evil Glimmer, Evil Catra, Evil Queen Glimmer, Evil Queen Catra, Machiavellian Glimmer, Machiavellian Catra, Power of Love, But in a bad way, Powerplay, God Save us from the Queens, Fanart, Illustrated, Eating Disorders, Body Horror, War Story, War Drama, Horror Elements, Self Harm, Mutilation, Political Drama

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Part 3 of Evil Queen Glimmer

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Catra and Glimmer - Queens of the Horde

by Bagge

Summary

Betrayed, cast out and pissed off, Glimmer and Catra set out together to reclaim their lost queenhoods and get revenge on those who wronged them.

The story is set in late Season 4 when the stakes are up in the sky and both Catra and Glimmer are indulging their very darkest sides. In this version, instead of helping each other see the error of their ways, they will enable each other. Look out world!

Notes

Can fanfics have trailers? Sure! Why not.

This will be my most ambitious fic yet, and I have great hope for it. It's a story in five parts, where I will finish the next part before I start updating so I can keep an even schedule. So stay tuned to summer 2021 when I will start publishing Part One - Queens of the Broken Thrones.

With thanks to The_Frank for invaluable help sorting out the plot and character motivations.

Edit: This fic has a tvtrope page now, thanks to the amazing SanaNaryon. Don't hesitate to add to it!

Awesome poster art commissioned from Lorvikk.

Trailer



Darkness. A single circle of light on an otherwise empty stage.

Out of the smoke, Adora comes strolling with a cocksure expression.

A spotlight lights up. Glimmer stands alone, hugging herself, looking at her feet.

"The poor princess," Adora says with mocking voice. "The world on her shoulders and no one to help her carry it. Her friends..." - she smugly indicates herself - "don't trust her. Her allies betray her..." Adora's features briefly changes into those of the sorceress Shadow Weaver, looking thoughtfully at Glimmer, shadows reaching out towards the lone queen.

On the other end of the stage, another spotlight lights up. Catra stands in a similar pose as Glimmer, claws biting into her arms as she hugs herself tightly.

"My poor kitten," Adora mocks. "Alone, betrayed, unloved..." she takes a step forward and stage whispers towards the audience - "I hear she is a *bad friend*."

Chuckling, Adora takes a step back and shakes her head in insincere pity, gaze wandering between Glimmer and Catra.

"The poor dears. Who will they turn to? Who will help them now? With no friends left, maybe..." -Adora takes a step back with arms outstretched, her predatory smile wider than one would think possible- "they could turn to their enemies?"

As if prompted by Adora's outstretched arms, Glimmer and Catra hesitantly walks towards the middle of the stage. They stop a few steps from each other, eyeing each other with suspicion.

"If those you trusted are not there to keep you warm at night, how about the one who gets your blood boiling every time?"

Catra and Glimmer take a step closer, into the personal space of the other. Their eyes lock, their mouth form furious snarls.

"If those you fought for cast you aside" - Adora's features briefly change into those of the warlord Hordak, glaring at Catra with a superior scowl- "how about the one who was there for you every step of the way, and who faced equal betrayal?"

Catra and Glimmer tentatively take each other's hand. After a brief hesitation they start to smile, self-assured, confident smiles in mutual recognition.

"There is no one for them," Adora goes on, "except the other. They have nothing, except their grievance. They will stop at nothing until they get their revenge."

Adora turns her gaze to the audience, and her features change into the green, smooth skin of the artist and spy Double Trouble.

"And what a riveting revenge it will be," they drawl, a wide grin showing their sharp teeth. "Force Captain Catra and Queen Glimmer working at cross purpose nearly tore the world apart. Working together... why, there is nothing they can't do, no line they can't cross, no enemy they can't utterly *crush*."

Catra and Glimmer still stare into the eyes of the other, grins triumphant, blind and deaf for everything around them. Double Trouble gives them a proud look before they turn to the audience again.

"Does that little yarn perchance pique your interests? If so, I invite you to join me in the tale I like to call..."

The curtain opens. Behind it, amidst the smoke and red light, the angular throne of the Fright Zone can be seen, tall and proud and adorned with the Horde emblem. Hand in hand Glimmer and Catra ascends the steps and sit down, looking at the audience with a superior expression.

"Catra and Glimmer - Queens of the Horde," Double Trouble proclaims, arm held high.

"Passion! Danger! Catra killing people with cool one-liners. Glimmer blowing things up in righteous anger. Both of them taking turn standing in protective fury over the broken body of the other."

Double Trouble winks.

"There might even be some kissing and holding hands in it for us, should we be so lucky."

With a flourished movement, Double Trouble steps to the side, raising their hand towards the couple on the thrones. Glimmer looks Catra in the eyes.

"They wronged us, Kitten," she says with soft voice, nevertheless hinting of steel. "But we will make them pay."

"We will make them all pay, Sparkles," Catra answers with a proud, bloodthirsty grin.

They lean forward and meet in a kiss.

Double Trouble wait for a few moments for dramatic effect, then they take a step forward and stage whispers to the audience again.

"Brought to you by the writer of We Won't Die Here, the Evil Glimmer series, Double Trouble in Trouble" -they wink- "and that one weird Ducktales crossover. Coming this summer to Bagge's fanfic page at archive of our own. Poster illustration commissioned from Lorvikk (@Lorvikk at Tumblr dot com)."

The stage lights dim down. Only Double Trouble's grinning face remains illuminated.

"And scene."

Act One - Queens of the Broken Thrones

Chapter Notes

> Warning: This story features Glimmer and Catra who start in a bad place and keep digging. At it's core, this story is me looking at the two of them suffering in the end of Season Four and thinking "hmmmm, what if we could prolong this and make it worse".
>
> There will be an ongoing exploration of the concept of power, how to gain it, how to keep it, how to wield it and how to loose it - sometimes resulting in scenes that are downright brutal or cruel. There will be descriptions of depression, panic attacks, self harm behavior, body horror, what might be constructed as analogues to eating disorders, bad coping mechanisms and not entirely healthy co-dependence. Some of the more disturbing parts are coated in fantastic metaphors, and the focus is on our girls *overcoming* their obstacles - internal and external - but there will be some grim themes down the line. I'll try to give a fair warning for each chapter so you know what you're in for. Please let me know if you feel they are inadequate.
>
> There are no character deaths of the protagonists of THIS story, i.e. Catra and Glimmer. The people who get in their way, however, have no such protection, regardless of their canon status. But I do promise that there will be a happy ending - for both our girls - because however cruel the world might be, the power of love is stronger.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Welcome, welcome good folks," Double Trouble leer as they strut back and forth on the empty stage. "I'm so glad you made it. Our little show is just about to begin so why don't you make yourself... *comfortable*.

Somehow they manage to work quite a lot of innuendo into that simple word. They put a hand to their ear in a pretend attempt to hear a comment from the audience.

"Ah, I see some of you hoped to catch the *midnight* show. Sorry, this one is rated T only, but we make it count," they drawl. "I'm sure you caught the warning by the door. Don't worry about it, it won't only be drama. We will manage to work in *quite* a bit of kissing between the angst." Their grin widen. "It will make the inevitable mood-shift so much more juicy."

They chuckle and take a few steps back, seemingly collecting their thoughts.

"Now, let me set the stage for you. I'm sure you all remember Brightmoon in late Season Four. *Former* Queen Angella dead, her throne hardly cold before *Queen* Glimmer is forced to place her cute little backside on it. Oh, the poor Queen," they leer. "Fighting a loosing battle against the Horde, resisting temptations thrown her way by Shadow Weaver, trying to keep her friends together despite *someone* seemingly attempting to drive a wedge between them..."

They take the guise of the sprite Flutterina and opens their eyes wide.

"I'm *sure* Adora didn't mean to make you feel useless by overshadowing you at every turn, Glimmer, despite that being the very thing you are insecure about," they pipe with high pitched voice. "After all, everyone knows you are the *weak* princess."

Laughing, Double Trouble take their own form again and takes a few steps to the side, followed by the single spotlight.

"Meanwhile," they drawl, "over in the Fright Zone our kitten is living the high life. Her enemies fear her, her former comrades obey her, even Hordak grudgingly respects her. Who has time for regrets then? Even if she *did* send one of her only friends to die a

horrible death on Beast Island and the other one doesn't seem to take her calls any more."

"Who needs friends," Double Trouble leers, "when you are *winning*?"

They stop their prancing in the middle of the stage and suddenly seem much more poised and focused. They let their gaze sweep over the audience.

"That's the stage," they say, voice for once clear and precise. "But what will be the pebble to set events in motion? What will be the nucleus for this story to crystallize around? The *spark* if you so will to light the powder keg?"

They smiles.

"Who would have thought that the dark story you are about to partake in would be started by such a wholesome event as the nicest of princesses setting out on the most noble of quests - to learn the true meaning of friendship?"

Slowly, not looking away from the audience, they take the guise of princess Scorpia.

"Oh, gosh, Emily," they say and turns to a cardboard cutout of a spherical bot a stagehand moves with a string. "We made it to Brightmoon. Let's sneak up to the chamber where the princesses hold council. I'm sure they will be happy to see us."

Double Trouble mimes sneaking up a few steps of an invisible staircase, and then they take their own form again. They take a several steps forward, to the very edge of the stage.

"And thus," they says and let their gaze sweep over the audience. "The stage is set, the spark is lit and all we have to do is to sit back, relax and watch the drama that will unfold."

They raise their hands towards the heavens.

"I give you..." they proclaim, "Act one: 'Catra and Glimmer - Queens of The Broken Thrones!'"

Behind them, the curtain rises. The scene depicted is the royal garden of Brightmoon, lit by multiple paper moons high in the night sky.

"I hope it will be to your... *satisfaction*," Double Trouble smirks as they slink away towards the side of the stage.

Chapter End Notes

NEXT chapter I promise the story will start for real, and have quite a different tone to it. Turns out, writing Double Trouble being melodramatic on stage is the funniest shit I've ever done so you can expect them to return during intermissions between the acts.

Final chapter numbers to be updated continuously as the story evolves. The story will be updated weekly.

Scorpia

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Scorpia.

In Brightmoon.

This changed the equation.

Shadow Weaver watched the princesses retreating towards the castle with their 'prisoner'. The plumerian princess fussed over her while the brat from the Kingdom of Snow tried to act tough. Micah's daughter had pulled away Adora and that annoying archer for another shouting match, leaving Shadow Weaver alone in the garden with her thoughts and her plans.

The granddaughter of the Scorpion King.

In Brightmoon.

Things had been going well. The Horde pushing for territory had put the young queen on edge. The strife caused by the spy had been most useful to create an opening for Shadow Weaver to win her trust, and the recent loss of Salineas (Shadow Weaver grudgingly admitted she might have to extend a thankful thought to Catra for that one, undeserving as the insolent creature was of it) had been very useful to nudge the queen towards the idea to make use of the power squirrelled away by the first ones in the Heart of Etheria.

How helpful of dear Adora to open up that opportunity.

But the plans had not included Scorpia, and they most certainly did not include the possibility of the tech princess of Dryl being saved from Beast Island and returned to the rebellion. Shadow

Weaver's plans did not allow for Glimmer to be given options other than those presented to her by Shadow Weaver herself.

Time to put the thumb on the scale.

Time to be proactive.

Shadow Weaver bent down and plucked a flower from her garden. One by one, she crushed the petals in her fingers and dropped them in a small bowl. She added a liquid from a bottle she had on her person.

There were many secrets in her garden they did not teach in Mystacor.

She watched the dark patterns swirl and swell. Shadows rose around her.

- - -

Glimmer stepped up to Bow and took his hand.

"Bow, you understand what I'm trying to say. Tell her." Adora looked at them with anger, fear and frustration written in her expression, arms crossed.

Bow looked down at their intertwined fingers, her thumb softly caressing his skin. For a moment his features softened.

"No! You weren't there. We need Entrapta. We need to disable the weapon."

Glimmer looked at him with wet eyes.

"Why can't you trust me in this."

"Because you are wrong!" he shouted.

He pulled his hand back.

Glimmer stared at him in disbelief.

She took several steps back.

"You think I'm wrong?" the betrayal in her voice was evident. Her hands shook. Bow looked like he was going to cry, but he stood his ground.

"Fine," she said, a hard edge to her voice. "But I am still queen. And as queen I am ordering you. No one is going to Beast Island. You're not to set foot outside this castle unless I say so. End of discussion."

"Glimmer..." Bow pleaded, his own eyes full of tears.

"I SAID end of discussion!" Glimmer snarled. She took a step forward, her body language poised for a fight, light dancing at her fingertips.

"Glimmer..!" Adora said, much more of a challenge in her voice. Unconsciously or not she shifted her body weight. Bow looked back and forth between them with dread in his eyes.

"Yes, Adora?" Glimmer said sweetly, voice hardly shaking.

For a dangerous moment their eyes met.

Then Adora took a step back.

"Come, Bow," she muttered. With Bow in tow she stomped out of the room. Bow gave Glimmer a sad look before Adora slammed the door, leaving the fuming queen to her own devices.

- - -

Catra looked over the map again. Three units were scheduled to push south, two east and why was the new shipment of bots delayed this time?

"Scorpia!" she snarled in her comm badge. "Figure out what excuse the workshop has for not having the bots ready, and then

tell them to get over their shit and get it done. You can be scary if you want to."

Yeah, as if.

Scorpia didn't answer. She had been late at getting back to Catra. Catra threw the map from the table in frustration. Everything was falling apart. The bots were breaking down and the troops were slow to follow order and the Force Captains were openly hostile and even Lonnie gave her lip.

Catra made a mental note of doing something about that.

Hordak, at least, pulled his weight, getting the coastal towns under control, but that was just another of Catra's problems.

Horde Prime could be here any day now. Hordak seemed pretty sure of it.

She harbored no illusions as to what her 'leader' thought of her. She had attacked him, humbled him, *threatened* him.

The rules of the Horde were laid down by Hordak, but in extension they were only a formalization of rules that were much older, and much more primitive.

You had what power you could hold, simply enough.

And those rules that did not permit challengers to remain alongside the challenged.

Right now they needed each other, which meant that right now they had been able to form an uneasy coalition.

But it would break down, soon. The day the troops stopped being too tired to notice, the day they both stopped being so busy on different fronts that they had time to make their move. The day Horde Prime arrived, by which time only one leader of the Etherian branch of the Horde would remain standing.

Catra harbored no illusions of what it would take, for her to survive that day.

Hordak's neck. Preferably severed, but at the very least under her heel.

Brightmoon.

That was the key. Who could bring down the princess alliance? Who could beat the opposition? Who could take the beacon of resistance that remained?

If Catra could take the city before Hordak, she would have shown him. She would have shown them. She would have shown the rest of the Horde. She would have shown all of Etheria. Even Horde Prime would have to take notice.

...even Adora would...

No.

She forced that thought away.

Why the hell doesn't Scorpia answer?"

She made her way down to the Force Captain's quarters, thumbing her comm pad as she did. Double Trouble was late reporting. She told herself that was only to be expected. The changeling was under deep cover, and this was a sensitive stage. If anyone could give Catra the edge she needed it was the changeling. That she missed them was hardly a reason to break radio silence. She told herself to be patient.

"Scorpia!" she cried, but no one answered. The door wasn't locked so she pushed it open, telling herself that she could go wherever she wanted to and forcing the little pang of guilt and anxiety down.

The room was empty.

Her eyes were drawn to a note on the bed.

She tore it open, and read it. Then she threw it away. Then she picked it up and forced herself to read it again.

She tore it to pieces and sank to the floor, screaming.

The note had said just one single word, but yet it said everything.

Sorry.

- - -

The hour Adora had spent in the gym punching sacks until they split in the seams and her cracked knuckles stained them with blood had done nothing to take the edge of her anger. How could Glimmer be so blind? How dared she order her around? How dared she be so certain that Adora was wrong...

...what if Adora was wrong?

Unbidden, the sight of the smoking ruins of Salineas rose up in Adora's brain. Just a taste of what were to come if they didn't stop the Horde.

But at the same time, Mara's last words still rang in her ears.

Light Hope was the bad guy.

Glimmer had to see that.

They had to go to Beast Island.

Right?

"Adora," a voice said. The smooth cool voice of her childhood dreams and nightmares.

She spun around.

"Shadow Weaver!" she spat. "What are you doing here? Where are your guards?"

"The Queen has seen fit to give them other duties than attending me. Apparently she doesn't consider me a threat." Adora could practically *hear* the smug smile through the mask.

"Well, I know better, don't I?"

"Yes, you do. So it will be up to you to save your dear friend from the wicked witch. My, it's just like the old days, you, me, Catra... how did it go, again, saving her from the Horde?"

Adora didn't move or react to Shadow Weavers words, but it was out of self control, not for lack of want.

"What do you want," she said between clenched teeth.

"The only thing I ever wanted, my dear. I want to help you."

"I don't want your help."

"Adora, you wound me. I *love* you."

"Well, I *hate* you," Adora snarled. "You treated Catra like she was nothing our entire childhood and now you are trying to ruin *Glimmer* too."

If Adora's outburst in any way faced Shadow Weaver, she didn't show it. But smugness practically dripped from her next words.

"Ah, Queen Glimmer. So much potential. So lost without parents, the poor dear. So much in need of... guidance. You do realize she will never allow you to save Entrapta, right?"

"Glimmer is my *friend*."

"Of course she is," Shadow Weaver tutted. "She's only trying to do what she thinks is right, after all." She smiled. "Just like you." She paused for a micro second before she went on. "Just like Catra."

This time Adora did not hold her punch. Shadow Weaver had expected it and easily avoided it.

"I do fear for Scorpia, though," she said as if the outburst hadn't happened.

"Scorpia?"

Shadow Weaver reached forward and touched Adora's head. For a moment, Adora allowed the familiar hands caress her hair, for a moment leaning in to the all too familiar sense of comfort, then she remembered herself and forcibly drew back. Shadow Weaver shrugged slightly.

"Scorpia is as invested in saving Entrapta as you," she said as if nothing had happened, "and I fear that with if you were to go and Glimmer were to figure out where you were going... Scorpia would simply not be safe here. She *is* from the Horde after all, and as you well know, Glimmer will never be able to fully forgive horde soldiers... even those who claim to have switched side, however much she like to pretend to be their friend. I fear her mother's unfortunate death has affected her deeply."

She looked out through the window, seemingly lost in thoughts.

"Such a shame, really, that you didn't try harder. If Queen Angella had still been alive, everything would have been different. But alas..."

When Adora stormed off, she did not notice the extra shadow that clung to her like spiderweb.

- - -

Glimmer walked down the corridor, feeling terrible. Bow hated her. Adora hated her. She hated herself. Everyone wanted her - desperately needed her - to do the impossible and she felt she was letting everybody down.

She almost longed for fighting with Catra again. She knew where she stood with the Horde second in command. They would fight, hurl insults, feel the blood flowing. Every heartbeat counted. Every split second decision relevant, every step in their dance...

Dance?

Glimmer couldn't help smiling. She really missed the action, but there were no reason romanticizing her life-or-death struggles with the terrifying feline, *even if she likes the way I taste*.

Do you think they appreciated her sense of taste in Salineas too? she sternly asked the part of herself that couldn't stop thinking of Catra. That shut it down.

Princess Frosta stood guard outside the cell (guest room), ice spear in hand. She gave Glimmer a guarded look that made the queens heart cramp. Had she really given Frosta - young, enthusiastic, worshipping-the-ground-she-walked-on Frosta reason to be wary about her?

Of course she had.

Even if she had never raised her voice to her fellow princesses, they had all heard her yell at Adora.

If it weren't for you, my mother would still be alive.

Glimmer forced herself to smile at the young princess.

"You are up late," she said. Frosta forced a smile in return.

"Guarding the prisoner," she simply stated. Glimmer nodded.

"Good job," she replied and cringed inwards at the banality of the statement, like if her fellow princess was just another Brightmoon guard.

"Frosta..." she added, "Thanks for helping me through all this. It means a lot and... well, you know."

Frosta nodded. She knew.

"Are you OK, Glimmer?" she asked with a frankness that took Glimmer off guard. But it probably shouldn't have. Frosta had not yet faced enough betrayal to learn to be careful with her words.

"Sure," she lied. "I'm just going to talk to Scorpia, OK?"

Frosta gave her a hesitant look.

"Do you want me to come with you?"

"No, that won't be necessary," Glimmer said with a voice that made a decent job of pretending to sound light hearted. "We will just talk. But if you stand guard out here we can call if we need you, OK?"

and you can stop me if I...

Glimmer didn't finish that thought.

She quickly opened the door and entered the room before Frosta had time to object.

Scorpia and her robot was still ensnared in vines, surrounded by a veritable mountain of cushions and trying - with very low rate of success - to eat a salad.

Bless Perfuma.

She looked up at Glimmer and gave her a genuine smile.

"Hi, Glimmer! I just wanted to say thanks again for letting me stay here. Everyone has been so nice to me and I'm really... uh... are you OK?"

Glimmer blinked furiously, forcing her face to hide her emotions behind the neutral, queenly mask.

She was getting better and better at it.

"I'm glad you like it," she said. She pulled up a chair and sat down, a little bit from the prisoner. Her fingers absent-mindedly painted patterns in the air.

She was so tired.

"Is it really true?" she asked in a low voice. Scorpia gave her a confused look.

"You defecting from the Horde?" Glimmer muttered. "Entrapta on Beast Island. You turning up here, in the perfect moment to cause Adora to drop everything to run away on a wild goose chase the moment the Horde is on our doorstep and we really could use She-Ra to defend us?"

Scorpia looked guilty.

"Oh... gosh. Sorry, I didn't really think of it like that... yeah, I suppose I defected. And Entrapta is absolutely on Beast Island. I helped send her there..." She shuddered.

"Sorry about Adora," she added after a moment of thought. "I didn't want to cause you guys any trouble."

Glimmer nodded in a resigned manner. If Scorpia had noticed the truth spell clinging to her, she didn't show it. And anyway, Glimmer couldn't imagine the woman ever think of uttering a falsehood.

So... manipulated?

Or even worse, sincere.

Glimmer starred in front of her without seeing.

Entrapta was rejected by the Horde.

Alone in the most nightmarish place Glimmer had ever heard about.

Probably dead, but not necessarily.

No princess left behind...

Glimmer had regretted a thousand times that they had not gone back for Entrapta when they had the chance.

We couldn't' have known she was alive," Bow had tried to plead with her.

A queen should have known

Well, now she had the chance.

But the Horde was gaining ground every day.

One more push, and they would be in Brightmoon.

Glimmer couldn't leave her people undefended.

But she couldn't just leave Entrapta either.

There was no right choice.

And no matter which wrong choice were made, she would have to be the one to make it.

And Bow and Adora would hate her for it.

"...um, Glimmer? Are you OK?" Scorpia looked at her with a worried expression.

"no," Glimmer whispered, not managing to hide the tears any more, and before she knew it Scorpia had scooped her up in a gentle hug (wasn't she tied up a moment ago?).

"Sssssh, it will be OK," Scorpia whispered. Glimmer looked up at her through the tears.

"Do you really think so?"

Scorpia hesitated.

"I mean... I don't really know what's going on here, but you're the guys who have it all together? Right? I mean, over there" -she did a vague gesture- "it's a mess. Catra's running everyone ragged and half of the time no one knows if it's her or Hordak who gives the order anyway. You guys like... love and respect each other? Oh, sorry... I said the wrong thing. I'm not good at this."

Glimmer buried her face in Scorpia's chest until she got the crying under control.

"I thought we loved and respected each other," she whispered, still not letting go of the scorpion woman. "But we're still losing. What if love and respect is not enough?"

"Um..."

"Scorpia... when you said Catra was a 'bad friend'... what did she do?"

"Oh... uh..." Scorpia looked away, face sad. "She.... well, I suppose she was more of a taker than a giver, you know. I tried to be everything for her but didn't get as much as a thanks... she got more and more intense in the end. Like, earlier we could at least relax and have fun at times, but at the end it was only about winning."

Scorpia sighed.

"It was like I was just there to help her with her... like big thing, no matter the stuff that... mattered to me. And then it was this thing with Entrapta where I thought that... OK, so we did a bad thing but maybe we can, like, fix it? So I tried to get her to help, but it was like she'd rather forget about the thing than make it better, and that of course made it worse, and in the end I had to face that if the thing were to be done at all, I would have to do it without her."

Glimmer watched her, white in the face. She stumbled to her feet.

"Thanks, Scorpia," she whispered.

"Um... Sure! Any time. I hope you'll be OK?"

"I'm not sure I will be, but... thanks. I hope you find what you're looking for," Glimmer said with small voice.

She left the room.

Scorpia looked at the closed door. She felt bad. Maybe the hug had been a mistake.

On the other hand, maybe, she hadn't hugged the sad queen enough.

She heard the door open again. Scorpia looked up. She hoped it would be Frosta or - she felt a funny tingling in her stomach - Perfuma. She was anxious it would be Glimmer again. But instead it was...

"Scorpia," Shadow Weaver said, voice smooth and smothering as velvet. "We should talk."

Chapter End Notes

Maybe she wants to give her cookies?

The leader of the Horde

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Scorpia," Shadow Weaver said, expression unreadable under the mask.

Scorpia chuckled nervously.

"Oh, hi, Shadow Weaver... so... you look... good?"

"My escape from the Horde prison was not without personal cost," Shadow Weaver said with smooth voice and walked up to Scorpia who did her best not to recoil. "Much like your own, I would imagine. However, with time and dedication, I have regained lost strength."

"Oh... yeah... I pretty much just walked out," Scorpia said with an apologetic smile. She brightened up. "Emily helped!"

Both their gazes turned to the robot who beeped happily.

"Of course it did," Shadow Weaver said, disdain dripping from her voice. She reached out a hand and put it on Scorpia's hair. For a moment, shadows danced around it.

"It's fortunate you are here. Your presence, however trivial in cause, might be instrumental for a greater purpose."

Scorpia tried to make herself smaller under Shadow Weaver's hands. Emily beeped protectively.

"It... might?" she asked. A thought struck her. "Are... are you allowed to be in here? Are we prisoners even allowed in each others cells? Wasn't Frosta guarding me?"

"The princess of the Kingdom of Snow, alas, seems to have succumbed to the late hour and fallen asleep. and you should know by now that I am allowed wherever I please," Shadow Weaver said with absolute confidence. "*You* on the other hand has outstayed your welcome." Scorpia blinked a few times.

"I... have?" she said. Shadow Weaver slowly started to walk in a circle around her.

"You have some nerve, coming here after everything you have done."

"I mean, I mostly tried to..."

"Kidnapping Adora in the Crimson Waste... poor Glimmer rushing to her rescue, Catra opening the portal... did you know that Glimmer's mother *died* trying to close it again?"

Scorpia recoiled.

"I didn't..."

"No, you didn't." Shadow Weaver hissed. "And you didn't for a moment think that *maybe* you would not be *welcome* here."

Scorpia looked like she was about to cry. Shadow Weaver smiled, an insincere smile and took a step closer.

"Glimmer, bless her heart, wants you to feel included."

"She really is nice," Scorpia answered, hoping against hope that the conversation would not turn ugly again.

"She *is* really nice," Shadow Weaver agreed, voice insidiously soft. "And she deserves people around her she can *trust*."

"I..."

"She needs the princess alliance. She needs the power of the runestones."

Shadow Weaver bent closer, her mask almost touching Scorpia's cheek.

"You know that you will never connect with the Black Garnet, don't you?" she whispered, false sympathy dripping from her voice. Scorpia hung her head.

"Yeah... I mean, I..."

"After all, it's not like you're a *real* princess."

"Well technically..."

Shadow Weaver reached out and touched Scorpia's head again. Scorpia looked like she wanted to recoil, but she stayed, frozen in place as Shadow Weaver started to pluck with strands of her hair.

"You know that you will never be what they need, what they deserve," she whispered with oily voice. "You will never be anything but a disappointment"

Scorpia hung her head.

"...I suppose not."

Shadow Weaver smiled, a thin little smile.

"Good. Now let's talk about what a *horrible* friend you have been to poor Entrapta. Fortunately, I know a way to make it up to her..."

- - -

"...Horde Prime?" Glimmer whispered, her eyes wide with fear.

"Indeed, Darling!" Double Trouble said with a smug smile. "And let me tell you - if you poor lambs have problems dealing with Hordak you will be helpless against Horde Prime."

Glimmer stumbled backwards towards the wall. She half sank down to the floor.

"Curtain for the young queen and her plucky little alliance," Double Trouble taunted. "So sad, but hey - tragedies make for the best drama."

"Why are you doing this?" Glimmer whispered.

The shape-shifter raised an eyebrow.

"Me? I'm just a facilitator, darling. Here for the show... plus the money is good," they added with a faux modest tilt of their head.

"Money?" Glimmer whispered. "You are tearing us apart just for profit? Where did you hope to spend it after the Horde takes over?" Double Trouble laughed.

"Astute, yet native question, my 'queen'. Truth is, there will always be places for exchange, even under the heel of a tyrant. And of course, the money is just a way of keeping score." Glimmer stared at them.

"This is a *game* to you?"

"Everything is," they shrugged. "Please don't take that as me diminishing you or your concerns. See it as a sign of respect. I could hardly be expected to play without a worthy opponent. Or without valid stakes."

"Do you think it was a game to the people of Salineas?" Glimmer snarled, anger building up in her voice.

Double Trouble gave her a very direct look. "Yes. And they lost."

"*I* lost," Glimmer cried. "They trusted *me* and *I* failed them."

"No shame, sugar-top. Kitten played you fair and square. And of course, you had little *moi* peeking at your cards."

Glimmer actually chuckled.

"Catra plays 'fair' now?" Double Trouble gave her a an approving smile.

"I *knew* mentioning the kitten would cheer you up."

"If you're trying to cheer me up you are doing a poor job," Glimmer muttered, but she had to admit she felt better. The spy was her enemy, they toyed with her and withheld crucial information, but talking with them did not leave her with the same sinking pit in her stomach as when she pleaded with Adora or the other princesses. There was something in their sassy irreverence that made her feel better.

"Ooooh, is that a challenge?" Double Trouble drawled. "Fine, let's play a little game. I'll try to cheer you up and you will do a little something for me."

"What 'little something'?" Glimmer asked with suspicious voice.

"A kiss?" they asked, eyelashes fluttering.

Glimmer stared at them, too flabbergasted to speak for a heartbeat, then she started to laugh.

"I'm good at what I do," Double Trouble commented with a smug grin.

"You are an impertinent buffoon," Glimmer said between laughs. "Well, I'll have to give it to you, you did cheer me up. But I'm not in the habit of kissing the enemy." Double Trouble's smile grew wider.

"Really, now? Dare to make it a bet?" Glimmer gave them an incredulous look.

"A bet?"

"I bet," Double Trouble drawled, "That one month from now you will have kissed the enemy."

"You think I'll be alive a month from now?" Glimmer asked, suddenly serious. Double Trouble gave her a sour look.

"Way to spoil the mood, Sparkles. Just as we were getting somewhere, too."

"Oh, I know what you're trying to do," Glimmer said with calm voice.

"Do you, now?"

"You are stalling for time."

Double Trouble made a little 'well played'-gesture.

"Very well, Sparkles. You got me. Your truth spell is still running, you didn't let me distract you. So ask your questions."

Glimmer frowned for a moment, gathering her thoughts.

"You say that Hordak's leader is coming, bringing with him the rest of the Horde. A force that could utterly destroy us."

"That's the truth, sugar plumb," Double Trouble confirmed.

"...but these last few weeks the Horde has doubled their efforts. They work their soldiers to the bone. They are taking territory they can't hold. Why? Why not just wait for reinforcement and roll us over when it arrives?"

Double Trouble's smiled widened.

"Aaaah! A *good* question."

"Then give me a good answer," Glimmer shot back.

The spy nodded approvingly at her.

"It's simple, really, and it's the same old answer. You're thinking of the Horde as a machine, or a monster, working as a unit, but it's not. It's people. People with different agendas."

Glimmer looked at them with narrow eyes.

"Go on."

Double Trouble scrutinized their nails.

"The Force Captains are jocking for position, the soldiers just try to get by, the kitten..." They let the sentence trail off.

"Yes?" Glimmer urged. Double Trouble looked up at them with a mischievous grin.

"Do you want to know what she says about you?"

"What?" Glimmer blustered, suddenly taken back.

"She's been *quite* interested to hear what I can tell her about 'the Glitter bomb' - her words. Why is that, do you think?"

"I think you're stalling again," Glimmer said pointedly. "Now tell me why they don't wait for Horde Prime."

Double Trouble pouted, but the magic tugged at them and they hurriedly went on talking.

"The kitten is angling for a promotion. Once Horde Prime arrives, she can go over Hordak's head and show him how *she* conquered the world. Hordak is trying the same play. Trying to prove himself 'worthy'."

"They are not secure of their position in the Horde..." Glimmer whispered, examining the thought from different angles. "And Catra wants to try the same play for someone's approval *again*. Didn't work out too well for her when she brought me in shackles to the Fright Zone. Shadow Weaver took all the credit for that one."

"The kitten is ambitious, but not much of a people pleaser," Double Trouble noted. Glimmer ignored them.

"But Hordak still lets her practically run things." she mused. "He must really rely on her..."

"Or...?" Double Trouble prompted. She shot them an annoyed look.

"Or be afraid of trying to get rid of her." She met the eyes of the spy.

"Which one is it?"

They shrugged.

"Eh, a bit of the one, a bit of the other. The kitten is not the most obedient of Force Captains, if that's what you are asking."

"I'm asking for details on their relationship and how to best exploit it," Glimmer said frankly.

Double Trouble licked their lips.

"Hordak plans to outdo the kitten, to be the one proven worthy in the field of battle, sort of thing. Catra simply doesn't plan for Hordak to be around, once Horde Prime comes to check the score."

Glimmer gave them a sharp look.

"Treason?"

Double Trouble laughed.

"Why so surprised? It's pretty much a national hobby in the Fright Zone. Just ask hair poof, or the witch in the garden. Hordak has only ever valued those around him by the use they are to him. Why should Catra measure him by any other stock?"

"Do you have proof?" she asked, not entirely able to contain the hope in her voice.

"As it happens," Double Trouble drawled, "I have a complete signed confession right here... of course I haven't. The kitten is not stupid. What did you hope to do with it anyway? Tuck it under Hordak's door and have him get rid of the kitten for you? It's not like he isn't expecting it. He just think he'll be able to take her when she comes for him."

"Will he?" Glimmer muttered, trying to hide her disappointment with Double Trouble shooting down her brief hope.

Double Trouble pondered that.

"I don't know," they confessed. "It depends on a lot of factors, not the least what you, in all your sparkly majesty, will do the next few days. For the moment they seems content to work together. Once Brightmoon falls... it will be a free for all. I will say this though - bad things happen to people who underestimate the kitten. Again, ask hair poof about that one."

Glimmer nodded thoughtfully.

"What would you do?" She suddenly asked. Double Trouble looked at her in surprise.

"I'm not sure a spy working for the enemy is the most trustworthy source for strategic advice, darling," they said. Glimmer shrugged.

"Why not? You said it yourself. You work for the winning side." Double Trouble scoffed.

"And that is you?"

"Yes," Glimmer said simply.

"I just told you about Horde Prime," Double Trouble replied.

"Yes, you did," Glimmer said, voice sincere. "We are struggling as it is, and like you said, if we can't even stop the Horde as we know it, what chance do we have against Horde Prime?"

"So..."

"So the stakes have changed," Glimmer said calmly. "We need to match them."

"Oooooh, now that sounds interesting," Double Trouble drawled. "I presume you're talking about this precious 'Heart of Etheria'?"

Glimmer nodded.

"With access to the heart we will have magic enough to defend ourself against any threat, even whatever terror Horde Prime might rain on us from the sky. We will be unstoppable"

She smiled, a sardonic smile.

"And once that happens, what chance do you think plain old Hordak will have against us? Who would you bet on then? Catra?"

She leaned closer, sparks dancing by her fingertips.

"...or me?"

Double Trouble gave her a pensive look.

"I'm impressed, Sparkles. I didn't think you had it in you. Now, I'm not so sure."

"So who is the winning side, then?" Glimmer said with deadly calm in her voice. Double Trouble gave her a long look.

"You might have the gumption, Sweet-cake, but that doesn't mean you can get to the Heart in time."

"You are underestimating me?" Glimmer said with voice that didn't waver. "You might live to see how bad things happen to those that do."

"The princesses will side with you?"

"Against a threat such as Horde Prime? You bet. They are already on the fence. They won't be once I bring Horde Prime to the table."

"And what about hair poof and your little boy wonder?" Double Trouble asked. Glimmer had to steady her voice before she answered.

"Adora and Bow will be angry at me, but at least they will be around to be angry."

Double Trouble smirked.

"You seem to have it all figured out, cotton candy,"

Glimmer stared at them. She opened her mouth to snap something back, but no words came out. A shiver went through her.

"Darling...?" Double Trouble said, uncharacteristic concern in their voice.

Glimmer took a deep gulp of air and glared in fury at Double Trouble trough eyes filled with tears. Her hand suddenly held a ball of lighting and she hurled it with full force at the wall, just behind her prisoner.

"You can mock me as much as you like," she screamed, "but the ugly truth is that it simply doesn't *matter* if I have it figured out or not. It's still up to me. I still have to act. And if I have to burn the Fright Zone and everyone in it to *ash* to stop the Horde from taking Brightmoon, that's what I will do."

A white, blinding glow formed around her fist. Double Trouble recoiled to the other edge of the circle as Glimmer took a step forward.

"So I ask you yet again, mercenary," she said, her suddenly calm voice only serving to highlight the fury that still boiled below it. "Who do you swear loyalty to? Who is the winning side?"

Double Trouble quickly composed themself and did a rushed curtsy.

"Queen Glimmer!" They croaked. "Queen Glimmer is the winning side."

"Good!" Glimmer spat. She forced herself to take a deep breath, and the glow died down. Double Trouble dared to start breathing again.

"Don't go anywhere," Glimmer gruffed as she walked to the door. "We have a lot to discuss about how you will help me take down the Horde."

She slammed the door, leaving Double Trouble staring after her, still trapped in the magic circle.

"Ooooh! Plot twist," they mumbled to themselves. "I like it!"

- - -

Shadow Weaver walked through the corridors in a good mood. Those who met avoided her or glared at her in anger and silence. Hate and fear. So predictable. So useful.

She found Micah's daughter outside the archers room, trying to work up the courage to knock on the door.

Good thing Shadow Weaver got there in time.

"My queen," she said with a jovial voice and put her hands on Glimmer's shoulders. "I wish to congratulate you."

Glimmer looked up at her with blank eyes. With visible effort she kept her voice steady.

"Congratulate?"

"On the war effort, my queen."

Glimmer looked nonplussed, then angry.

"Are you *mocking* me?"

"Far from it, my queen. You have now in the hand the last piece you need to once and for all change the tide of the war."

"What are you talking about?" Glimmer exclaimed.

Shadow Weaver looked at her, her expression as always unreadable through her mask.

"The key to the heart of Etheria. I know where to find it."

Glimmer stared at her.

"How could you possibly know that?"

Shadow Weaver smiled. She held out her hand.

"Walk with me, my queen."

Glimmer allowed Shadow Weaver to take her hand, and together they strolled down the corridor.

Away from the door.

"I know many secrets they don't teach in Mystacor," Shadow Weaver said conversationally. "As Light Hope no doubt could have told Adora, had she known to ask, the Heart is connected to the magic of Etheria, and that magic is connected to..." she glanced towards the window.

"The Moonstone," Glimmer said. Shadow Weaver nodded.

"That, and the other runestones. That magic flow, however, is out of balance and has been so for generations."

"Since Hordak got here," Glimmer answered.

Shadow Weaver chuckled softly.

"Yes, that would be the conventional wisdom, as if Hordak could disturb the flow of magic of an entire planet just by walking on it. Believe you me, my queen - he is not quite the figure of evil omnipotence your childhood nightmare would have it once you get to know him."

Glimmer's eyes narrowed.

"What, then?"

"Life in the Fright Zone was not pleasurable," Shadow Weaver answered loftily, "but it gave me access to study material no other sorcerer has seen. The flow of magic has been out of balance, not since Hordak's arrival but since the last Scorpion King yielded to the nascent Horde. He lost his family name. He lost his kingdom. He lost his runestone. And he lost his daughter and granddaughter."

She almost heard the wheels turning in Glimmer's head.

"The scorpion king... you are talking about the Black Garnet." She gasped. "Scorpia..."

"The only elemental princess not connected to her runestone." Shadow Weaver said with a smooth voice. "The only thing that prevents the magic of Etheria to balance. You are looking for the key to the heart of Etheria, my Queen." In a flourished moment she pointed down the corridor. "She's a guest under your own roof."

Glimmer looked at her with an astonished expression.

"Are you saying we can get to the Heart?"

"I'm saying we *could* have a way to the Heart, my queen, if we had access to the Black Garnet. Sadly, the full might of the Horde stands between it and us.

"Yes..." Glimmer said thoughtfully. "But perhaps that is something we could do something about." She gave Shadow Weaver a

confident look. "I think it is time for me to have another talk with little 'Flutterina'."

Glimmer walked down the corridor with purpose in her steps.

- - -

"Catra," Lonnie said, arms crossed. "We have worked triple shifts already. Everyone is tired. You keep this up, we're going to fall apart all by ourselves. No need for the princesses to do anything."

Catra barred her fangs. She had to remind herself that she was practically the leader of the Horde. Lonnie couldn't threaten to beat her up when Adora wasn't looking any more. But Lonnie stood her ground. Catra decided to go for the weak link.

"If the job is too hard for Kyle," she sneered, "maybe you should do a better job keeping him in check."

"I look out for Kyle, don't you worry," Lonnie said, deadly, low voice. "I look out for all my boys, and right now that means telling *you* that *we* can't keep up with this tempo. The Horde is an army that runs on *people*. Us. The soldiers need downtime. Rest. These order" -she didn't say 'your orders'- "threatens the soldiers. That threatens the Horde."

"You're saying that you can't follow orders?" Catra said with equally soft voice. She looked Lonnie in the eyes.

Neither blinked.

"Where is Force Captain Scorpia?" Lonnie said, stress on the last word. Catra physically recoiled.

"Wha-at does that have to do with anything?"

"She's part of our unit? Isn't she? She's our direct commanding officer, isn't she? Can't expect the high and mighty Catra, Hordak's right hand, to micromanage a little unit such as ours, can we? So where is she?"

"I... she... has been given other orders. Don't you worry about her."

"I worry about our unit not being given the proper resources to carry out *our* orders," Lonnie hissed.

"Do you think this is *easy*?" Catra snarled. "We are taking over the world here. Hordak is out gallivanting wherever he pleases. Everyone in the supply line sits on their hands until I personally threaten to beat them up. Every idiot in the field needs me to tell them which foot to lift in which order. How do you think this is for me?"

"Are you saying that you can't carry out your orders, Force Commander?" Lonnie said with deadly calm.

Catra stopped herself from snarling back at her. For such an insubordination Lonnie should loose her eye or worse. But right here, right now Catra needed her, and Lonnie knew it. Lonnie was her underling, but she was strong, capable and no coward, and Catra knew better than most how far that could take someone.

No one in the Horde had ever expected Shadow Weaver to be replaceable either, and look at Catra now.

She forced herself to calm down.

"Lonnie..." she said, forcing the tension out of her voice. "I did not fully appreciate the problematic position the lack of the proper command structure put you in. I do want to thank you for bringing this to my attention. I will immediately take steps to address the issue." The words sounded as false leaving her mouth as they did in her brain, but at least they stopped her from going for Lonnie's throat.

Lonnie gave her a hard look, trying to work out Catra's new angle.

"We all care about the proper workings of the Horde," Catra went on, voice smooth. "We all need the machine to work smoothly. But

as you know, we are in the final stages of the offensive. Can't expect everything to follow the manuals, then."

"Still, we can't..." Lonnie began. Catra cut her off.

"And that's where the Force Captains come in, isn't it. A capable officer, right in the operative unit, ready to think on their feet, ready to do what's needed. Ready to step up when the Horde so demands. Isn't that right, *Force Captain Lonnie*?"

Lonnie had been ready with an angry retort. Now she gave Catra a look in pure shock. Catra smiled. She had won this round.

"You are more than capable. You are competent, you are *loyal*" - she put stress on that word- "And you don't hesitate to stand up even to me when it's needed. You have more than deserved a promotion."

"You... you can't be serious?" Lonnie said, staring at Catra in confusion.

"Why not? Don't tell me you haven't dreamt of this day."

"Only Hordak can promote us to Force Captains," Lonnie protested. Catra smirked.

"Is that so?" Catra held up Scorpia's comm badge.

She had carried it with her for... reasons.

Lonnie's eyes locked on it, suspicion and misgivings fighting with ambition.

Catra decided to give her ambition a little push.

"Walk with me, Force Captain Lonnie," Catra said in an unconscious imitation of Shadow Weaver.

Hiding the badge in her hand, she turned and started to walk, without waiting to see if Lonnie would follow her. After a moment

she did. Catra smirked.

"Listen, Catra..." she begun.

"Tell me what you see," Catra interrupted as she pushed a door open. Lonnie rolled her eyes but did as she said.

"Lots of old junk." Catra smirked again.

They looked at the Black Garnet in silence, surrounded by discarded tools and half broken tech equipment.

"That's a pretty respectless way of addressing the work of princess Entrapta, don't you think?"

Lonnie gave her a careful look, took in her grinning face, before she answered.

"I'm not in the habit of paying respects to princesses, Force Commander Catra."

"Even if said princess once was the right hand of Hordak?" Catra said with soft voice.

"By his own count, she's a traitor," Lonnie said without hesitating. Catra nodded, rewarding her with that little gesture for the correct answer.

"And what about Shadow Weaver?" Catra went on. "This was her 'inner sanctum' after all."

"Shadow Weaver is cosying up with the enemy in Brightmoon."

Lonnie refrained from doing any comparison to another former Horde soldier now cosying up with the enemy in Brightmoon. Catra took note of it.

"Seems to be an awful lot of traitors around here..." Catra said, letting the sentence trail out.

Lonnie said nothing.

"Both Entrapta and Shadow Weaver seemed to think the key to victory lied in that rock," Catra went on conversationally. "You don't share their opinion, Force Captain Lonnie?"

"The key to victory lies not in princess tricks. It lies in the machine," Lonnie said without hesitation. "The tanks, the, bots, the soldiers working together as cogs."

She gave Catra a direct look.

"Machines need downtime. Soldiers need rest."

Catra nodded.

"Duly noted, Force Captain. If you feel it's necessary, we will slow down the push enough to squeeze in some downtime. I'll leave it to you to sort out the details... but Force Captain Lonnie?"

They exchanged a long look.

"Yes, Force Commander, Catra?"

"I'm not giving you a vacation here. I still expect results. We can't afford to lose pressure on the princesses."

It was not what Lonnie had asked for, but it was better than she had expected. And it came with a promotion.

Lonnie recognized a good deal when she saw it.

And knew enough to be suspicious of it.

"Catra, can I be frank with you?"

"Feel it's your place, do you?" Catra shot back, working in enough of a growl in her voice to communicate a threat.

"If a Force Captain can't speak freely with her commanding officer, what use would I be?" Lonnie answered with a level voice.

Catra nodded in acquiesce.

"Very well. Be frank with me, Lonnie."

"What's the deal with Hordak?" Lonnie asked. Catra gave her a long look.

"There are a good many questions you could have asked me," Catra murmured, but you went straight to the point. I like that."

Lonnie said nothing.

"You could have asked me why we suddenly started a huge push. You could have asked me what's the hurry. You could have asked me why Hordak suddenly left his lab to go out in the field..."

Catra left a few other things Lonnie could have asked unsaid.

"...but you asked me about Hordak himself. Very good, Force Captain Lonnie. Because that's the answer to the questions you didn't ask. What changed? Hordak changed. Him waiting for the next big vanity project or princess trick to pay off. That stopped. Now we're winning the war the *right* way. You said it, Lonnie. Machines and bots and soldiers. Not waiting for a mad princess or sorceress to cook up the next big thing. Now we're out there doing the work, taking the rebellion's ground one town at stronghold at the time."

"What caused Hordak to change his mind?" Lonnie asked.

Catra smirked.

"We had a little chat."

Lonnie nodded. A lot of things didn't have to be said.

She held out her hand. Catra pressed the badge in it.

"Will the other Force Captains accept this?" Lonnie asked. "Will Octavia?"

"If she values her remaining eye, she will," Catra snarled.

"What about Hordak?" Lonnie asked.

"The leader of the Horde values *results*," Catra said with steady voice.

"Understood," Lonnie said after a short pause. Catra held her gaze.

"This is the final push, Lonnie," she said. "This is the win or break moment for all of us."

"I won't let you down, Catra," Lonnie said, her hand holding the comm badge hard.

"You better not, Force Captain Lonnie. Now go out there and force me a path to Brightmoon."

Lonnie nodded and walked out of the door.

She closed it after her.

Catra waited until her steps in the corridor had disappeared until she sank down to the floor, threw her mask into the corner and screamed, letting out the fear, frustration and anxiety she couldn't afford to anyone else to see.

She wished she were fighting with Sparkles instead of being here. With the pink princess she knew where she stood. They bantered, they tried to kill each other, and in the end of the day she got back up and they could have another go. With her Catra didn't have to worry about supply lines or Horde politics or being a *bad friend*.

Catra cried bitter tears of anguish, letting out at least some of her inner turmoil.

In the Horde, you were taught from an early age not to cry, not to show signs of weakness, least someone saw and used it against you.

But there was no one left to see her.

- - -

"Scorpia...?" Glimmer said, just a bit uncertain. "I need your help. You are the only person who can save Etheria. I need you to connect to the Black..."

She stopped.

The room was empty. No Scorpia. No robot. Just an uneaten salad, a lot of cushions and a note.

Stuck to the wall with an arrow.

With sinking heart Glimmer took it. She already knew what it would say.

Just one word, with Bow's neat handwriting.

Sorry.

Chapter End Notes

I feel like such a jerk for having Shadow Weaver be mean to Scorpia like this.

The Queen of Brightmoon

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shadow Weaver wandered through the flower beds in her garden, deep in thought. She snipped a stem here, tied up a shoot there.

Coming to Brightmoon had been the right move. She felt like she stood in the middle of a great wheel, spokes turning and turning, centred around her.

Power.

It had never been about anything else.

Would never be about anything but that.

The Horde had been useful - might still find it's use in her unfolding plans - but she felt in her bones that Brightmoon was where the true potential rested.

She smiled behind her mask.

A movement like a shooting star caught her eyes. She watched Mara's old space ship move over the sky in silence.

A shadow coiled around her arms, playing like a pet animal would around the arms of its master.

She stroke it affectionately.

Adora would not come back from her journey anytime soon, not when her shadows had finished their work, sabotaging that old derelict space ship.

Even if they did reach their destination... well, no one leaves Beast Island, as her dear Micah could attest to.

Adora, the archer and the failed princess would not disturb her work with Micah's daughter again.

Behind her, the frantic Queen poofed into existence. Much too late, of course.

A feeling of triumph washed over Shadow Weaver.

Coming to Brightmoon had indeed been the right call.

"You can still stop them," she said to queen. She saw the girl force herself to stand tall, to prevent herself from showing her inner turmoil.

"Let them go," Glimmer said, voice almost steady. "If they don't trust me, I don't trust them."

Ah, a job well done.

"They took Scorpia," Glimmer whispered. Shadow Weaver looked at her, eyebrow raised under the mask.

"That is most unfortunate, my queen."

"That means it's over..." Glimmer said, with the same, detached voice. "I can't unlock the Heart, I can't stop the Horde, I can't even help Bow and Adora. All I can do now is wait."

"That is not *quite* true my queen," Shadow Weaver said smoothly. Glimmer gave her a sharp look.

"What do you mean?"

Shadow Waver took her time finishing her work with her plants before she answered.

"All runestones need to be connected for the Heart of Etheria to be accessed. Typically, that means it needs to be bonded to an elemental princess..."

"Typically?"

"Scorpia" -Shadow Weaver didn't even try to hide the scorn in her voice- "has never had a bond with the Black Garnet, and neither has her mother. Her claim to the title as a princess is measly at best, and to the runestone itself even less."

Shadow Weaver did a gesture, and magic glowed in the air.

"...unlike someone else. Someone who has painstakingly wrestled secrets untold from the Black Garnet. Spent more time meditating on its many aspects than any other now living elemental princess has been *alive*, who has already formed a true bond."

"You are talking about yourself," Glimmer said. Shadow Weaver took a short step to the side, positioning herself between Glimmer and the Moonstone.

"Yes. Myself. Forming a true connection to the Black Garnet - one that would satisfy the conditions required to balance Etheria and access the Heart - would be one step further. It would require the help of you and the moonstone. It would be dangerous. It would not come without risk for me personally, but I am willing to risk it. For your sake, and for mine."

"You want to be a princess?" Glimmer gasped.

"Yes." Shadow Weaver answered. "For all our sake. And you, Queen Glimmer, can help me."

She sank to her knee in front of the flabbergasted queen.

"Grant me this boon, my queen, and I will swear loyalty to your princess alliance, as both its youngest and oldest member. Grant me this boon, and I will bring you such power as this world has not seen since the days of the First Ones. Grant me this boon, and we will eradicate the Horde from Etheria and swat even Horde Prime from the sky, should he dare to enter the dimension Despondos. Grant me this boon, queen Glimmer, and I will give you something the princess alliance has not seen in your lifetime. Victory. And Peace."

Glimmer could only stare at her.

"That has been your plan all along?"

"I have always seen the potential, my queen," Shadow Weaver said with a smooth voice. "And now when the need arises..."

"...the need arises. A threat on the doorstep. Unprecedented rituals. Untold power..."

"Just as you say my queen."

"This is what you told my father," Glimmer whispered in horror. "You are playing the same game."

"I do not play games, my queen," Shadow Weaver said somewhat sharply. "I device strategy. Something you among the princesses seem unique in your ability to appreciate."

"Have you learnt nothing from what happened the first time around."

"I have learnt a great many things, my Queen," Shadow Weaver said with hard voice. Chief among them that I was *right*. Had I been allowed to use the power I gained, been given the support and respect I was due rather than been cast aside, we could have stopped Hordak there and then. There would have been no *need* for a second princess alliance. Salineas would not have fallen. We would not have the Horde on Brightmoons doorstep, or Horde Prime threatening us in the sky. You and your friend would have known nothing but peace." She looked Glimmer straight in the eyes. "And your parents would still be alive."

"The Horde is at our doorstep partly because *you* helped them," Glimmer cried.

"Yes." Shadow Weaver said with a lofty voice. "Because I was cast aside by those who should have known better. Don't make their mistake."

"Are you threatening me, Shadow Weaver?"

"I'm *warning* you, my queen. You are standing by a cross-road, and your actions will have consequences. Choose which consequences you prefer, and do so carefully."

Glimmer gave her a downright hostile look.

"Do you somehow think I have *missed* that? Do you somehow think I have harboured the illusions of being able to lead a nation and an alliance in war, without making sacrifices?"

"Then tell me, Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon," Shadow Weaver spat, "what sacrifices are you prepared to make?"

"What sacrifices am I prepared to make?" she blustered. "In the war that took my father, my mother, my friends and which is now threatening all of my kingdom, all of my *planet*? Everything I got, obviously. But the question you pretend to ask is not the question you really are asking."

They stood very close now, angry faces just a short distance apart.

"And what then, if I may be so bold to ask, is the real question, my queen?"

"You are asking me the same question as everyone else. You are asking me to pick *side*. 'Do i trust you?' 'Do I trust Bow?', as if this was a question of *loyalty*."

"It is not?"

"Not for me!" Light flared around Glimmer as she screamed at the witch. "I am the *Queen*. I am what you swear loyalty *to*."

"Loyalty is for the ones under the boot, not the one wearing it, is that it?" Shadow Weaver answered, her voice cold. "You would have fit well in with the Horde, *my Queen*."

"You should know," Glimmer spat back. "And no, as you well know, loyalty is a luxury not afforded to everyone. Adora gets it, you know. She is terrified of it, but she gets it."

"Gets *what*?" Shadow Weaver asked between gritted teeth.

"That sometimes you don't have the luxury of following. Sometimes you don't have the absolution that comes from standing in the shadow of someone else. Sometimes you can't just follow orders, because there are no one to give them to you. And if you are the *Queen*, you NEVER have that luxury - you are the one other leans on to learn what to do."

"It might surprise you to hear that I, too, have given some thought to the relationship between power and responsibility," Shadow Weaver said.

"Good," Glimmer said with aloof voice. "Then I don't need to remind you what I am, what my duty is. To my allies, to my people, to my throne and to *that rock*." Glimmer held up her hand, and the Moonstone flared up. Shadow Weaver had to avert her eyes.

"Any pirate captain or bandit leader or even Hordak himself can lead a ship or an army or a country. Brightmoon is full of people more capable, more ambitious and more eager than me to be its leader. But none of them have the connection to the runestone I have. None of them have the bond to this world, the magic that flows between every living thing, great or small. None of them are a *princess* and neither are *you* Shadow Weaver."

The light from the Moonstone abruptly died down, but Glimmer herself kept glowing, like a moon reflecting light from a sun hidden on the other side of the planet.

"But I am." Glimmer said in steady voice. "I am an elemental princess of Etheria, and mine is the responsibility to preserve and balance this world. I am the leader of the princess alliance, and mine is the responsibility to protect our people from the Horde. I

have power, that is true. But more than that, and much more importantly than that, I have a *duty*. What is your duty, Shadow Weaver?"

"To you, my Queen," Shadow Weaver said with low voice.

"I do appreciate your offer," Glimmer sternly said, "And I do accept your tutelage, your advice and your help. But do not think us equals. And do not think me naive. I am not my father, and I do not intend to repeat his mistakes. Neither am I Hordak, Shadow Weaver. I do not give away what is not mine. And the runestone you crave belongs to *princess* Scorpia."

"Scorpia is a weakling, an imbecile, a blubbering romantic," Shadow Weaver hissed. "She is not *worthy* of the runestone. I *am*."

"You are?" Glimmer snapped. "By what virtue."

"By the virtue of work rather than birth," Shadow Weaver hissed. "Skill rather than blood. Determination rather than having things handed to you on a silver platter just because of who squeezed you into this world."

"Like it has been for me," Glimmer filled in with low, deadly voice. Shadow Weaver realized her mistake just a few moments too late.

"My queen, of course I did not wish to imply..."

"There was no need for you to imply it," Glimmer snarled. "You spoke plainly enough. Begrudge me all you want, it still won't change the fact that *I* am the princess, and I don't have the luxury to pick a side or blindly following instructions."

"Then what do you suggest, my Queen?" Shadow Weaver asked sullenly.

"You know the answer. You have led me long enough down the road to know the next step. To fulfil my duty I need power. To gain that power I need knowledge. To gain that knowledge..."

"I'm happy to offer you that knowledge, for free, my Queen."

"I'm sure you are," Glimmer scoffed. "And for no other price then feeding me exactly what nudges of information *you* deem to be most advantageous for *you* and no one else. Sorry, Shadow Weaver, but that is a higher price than I can afford."

"There is no one else who can teach you what I can!" Shadow Weaver cried.

"Oh, isn't there?" Glimmer said, voice sweet like poisoned honey. "We will see about that, won't we?"

She teleported out, leaving Shadow Weaver to fume, alone in the garden.

- - -

There is a special smell to burning houses. Catra knew, because she wouldn't get it out of her furs for days. She couldn't even remember the name of this little town. It didn't really matter anyway. They just needed it out of the way for the push so they wouldn't have to worry about the princesses getting creative about hiding soldiers about the civilians.

Not that the princesses getting creative seemed to be an overhanging danger. Even after Salineas, they just stayed home in their castle to mope. On one hand, it made Catra's job easy. On the other side, she had really hoped for more from...

A crash was heard, and Catra's ears perked up. A tall woman ran towards her from one of the burning buildings, and for a moment Catra's heart started racing.

Then the woman came closer and she saw that it was just another civilian or pirate or whoever. Catra groaned in disappointment and dodged the initial blow from the woman's sword. With contemptuous ease she jumped a step backwards and lashed out with her whip. The woman blocked her and

pressed forward, but Catra danced around her, taking quick shots until the woman lost her balance - just for a moment.

Then it was over.

The woman's face still had a surprised expression as her body fell to the ground.

There were blood on Catra's claws.

Catra could feel a headache coming on. None of this was what she had thought it would be.

She was winning, but this didn't taste like victory.

Well, no need to get sloppy.

"Hey, you," Catra sneered to the goat-woman that she had brought with her from the Crimson Waste. "Get over here."

The soldier carefully stepped over to Catra. She and her fellow band of brigadiers hadn't manage integrate well in the Horde. They lacked discipline and training and mostly kept by themselves. It suited Catra perfectly. They were far more likely to take orders from her - who had personally bullied them into it - than some other Force Captain or a distant evil figure on a throne they barely knew.

"Having fun?" Catra sneered. The soldier nodded uncertainty, waiting to see what shoe would drop.

"Well, the fun has just begun," Catra smiled, stepping closer. I've got a little job for you...

Chapter End Notes

> Glimmer out-speechifying Shadow Weaver was very satisfying to write.

Princess council

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Wait, are we not going to wait for Adora and Bow?" Perfuma asked.

"Adora and Bow are gone," Glimmer said flatly.

Frosta looked away.

"...gone?" Perfuma asked, a little shiver to her voice.

"Adora apparently has her own ideas of how to deal with this situation. And who are we to stop her? She's She-Ra after all."

Glimmer almost managed to keep her voice steady.

Perfuma took a small, tentative step forward.

"Glimmer..."

"That doesn't matter," Glimmer interrupted. "She has made her choice. We have to make our."

She looked around the room. Attempting to meet the eyes of every single other person in there.

"I say we use the heart of Etheria. I have the key."

"What key?" Netossa asked.

Glimmer met her eyes.

"For the time being, I think it's best if I kept that information to myself, don't you?"

They looked into each other's eyes in silence. Netossa looked away first.

"Say that you can do it," Spinnerella asked. "Then what? We take the fight to the Horde?"

"The Horde will come to us," Glimmer said with confidence. "Once they realize that She-Ra has left..." -she did a valiant effort to keep the bitterness out of her voice- "And that the princesses has left, they will jump at the opportunity to break the city."

"We are leaving?" Mermista asked with a raised eyebrow.

Glimmer smiled.

"Yes. You are. And when Hordak is coming, you will be ready for him along the way."

"How will the Horde even know we are leaving?" Perfuma asked, struggling to keep up.

Glimmer gave her a knowing look.

"The Horde always seems to be one step ahead of us, don't they? If I didn't know better I'd say there is a spy in Brightmoon..."

She let the sentence trail out. The other princesses watched her in confusion, until Mermista suddenly let out a short laugh.

"Hah! Turning their own card against them. Not bad, Glimmer. That could work."

Frosta frowned.

"I don't get it."

"Glimmer is talking about making a deal with Double Trouble," Mermista explained. "Feed misinformation back to the Horde. Let them know what we want them to know."

Perfuma gave her an anxious look.

"Isn't that dangerous?"

Glimmer opened her mouth, but Mermista answered in her stead.

"Double Trouble is a mercenary, Glimmer knows to make it worth their while to side with us."

"More than that," Glimmer said with a thankful look at princess without a kingdom. "Double Trouble is an opportunist. They know better than to turn down an offer from the winning side."

"We are the winning side?" Frosta asked.

Glimmer didn't answer. She just smiled. A smile that radiated confidence and menace.

"I *like* it!" Mermista said, much more excited than usual. "Turn their spy against them. Hand them what looks like certain victory to lure them in a trap."

"Wait!" Frosta exclaimed. "You want *us* to lay in ambush for the entire Horde? Don't get me wrong, I like punching bots, but I don't think..."

"Once I have accessed the heart of Etheria even one of us would be more than enough," Glimmer said with a soft voice. She looked around the other princesses. "Did you know that they tell ghost stories about the princesses? Mad, power hungry creatures of untold power that must be put down, least we destroy them all."

Perhaps unconsciously she took a step back, so she became framed by the fireplace. Flames flickered around her features.

"It's time for the stories to become true. It's time for the Horde to meet the full might of the princess alliance. And if there is someone even worse out there, searching for us from across the night... well, then they will learn who are the guardians of Etheria. Learn it the hard way."

Frosta whooped! Mermista looked downright gleeful. Netossa and Spinnerella nodded. Only Perfuma looked more and more frightened.

"This all seems so... uncertain. What if you fail to unlock the heart? What if we won't be enough to stop the Horde? What if... something else happens."

"Then maybe *She-Ra* will swoop down from the sky to save us," Glimmer snapped with venom in her voice. Perfuma recoiled.

Realizing the effect of her words, Glimmer held up her hand in a placating gesture.

"Sorry," she said. "This is stressful for us all. Who knows, maybe Adora and Bow *will* return in the nick of time. Maybe they will bring Entrapta with them. Maybe she will press a button and all our troubles will go away." She shrugged. "Stranger things have happened. But right now, *they aren't here*, and we can't count on them to come back in time."

The 'or at all' hung unsaid in the air.

Glimmer made a helpless little gesture.

"If I fail... if we can't access the heart, if the magic isn't what we have been lead to believe, then..." -she swallowed- "then I have failed you. Then I won't be coming back either."

She met Perfuma's horrified look with compassion.

"If that happens, my suggestion is that you retreat to the kingdom of Snow. If we fail, Brightmoon is sure to fall, and without Salineas and Brightmoon I don't see how you could defend Plumeria for long. But Snow..." she put a warm hand on Frosta's shoulder. "The Horde won't get to you easily with this powerhouse of a queen protecting you."

Frosta looked at her with a mixture of pride and fear.

"And after that," Glimmer went on... "After that *you* will be the princess alliance, and the decisions will be yours. I won't be around to make any more mistakes."

She sighed. She looked around and met each of their eyes in turn.

"This is a high stakes gamble, I realize that. We might lose, and if we do, we lose everything. But we can't do nothing." She looked directly at Mermista. "Doing nothing cost us Salineas."

Steel crept into her voice.

"I'm not making that mistake again. The Heart is full to the brim with the magic of Etheria. We are the elemental princesses. That magic is our duty. That magic is our *right*. I will unlock the heart. I will bring that magic to you and with it we will crush the Horde, once and for all."

Glimmer sighed, and the hard edge to her voice and features disappeared. She looked at them with an open, vulnerable expression.

"I'm scared too. I can't do nothing, and I can't do this by myself. You are my friends. I need you. I trust you. Please help me."

She had them.

One by one they hugged her, pleaded their support, their allegiance, filtered out to do her bidding. Glimmer waited until Perfuma left, one last worried glance at Glimmer before she closed the door, and then the queen of Brightmoon was alone.

Glimmer sank down to the floor and cried for a long, long time, cried like her heart would break.

Because now she truly had no one left.

- - -

Catra truly had no one left.

She had bought herself some time with Lonnie, bought herself some shreds of loyalty with the promotion, but she could practically hear the gears turning in the new Force Captain's head every time she looked at Catra. She would stay with her if and only if Catra could deliver, and when the time came to settle things with Hordak...

Catra would better hope she ended up on top fast in that conflict if she hoped to retain the loyalty of Lonnie and the other Force Captains.

Octavia was keeping busy at sea, but Hordak was pushing inland. At this rate he would reach Brightmoon before her. That meant she would have to go through the Whispering Woods if she would have any hope of getting there in time. She would have to time it just right. If Hordak made the first move and drew out Adora, then she could make her final push and take the city before anyone was the wiser. But if she got stuck with Adora and that annoying pink princess...

...well, she'd have to time it just right.

She forced herself to let out a breath. She was just so tired. She couldn't remember when she last slept. She hadn't eaten in days except for a few quick bites of ration bars and if she tried to relax for a few moments...

Scorpia's face shimmered in front of her eyes for a short moment. She snarled.

This was not the time to relax. She was so close. She would *win* and then everything, *everything* would...

...be worth it.

She heard the comm pad beep. It would be one of the Force Captains, or possibly Hordak. Every fibre of her body screamed at her to ignore it, to break the stupid thing and it's stupid beeping, to just stay, right here, with her hate and self-pity until she died.

But she still forced herself to dry her eyes, to put on her mask and to press the button.

"Hi, Kitty-cat! I figured it was time we had a little talk!" Glimmer said to her with a taunting smile. Catra stared at the pink appearance on the screen.

"Double Trouble!" Catra whispered. "You came back?"

The shape-shifter laughed and took their own form.

"Sorry for the radio silence, Kitten. Things have been moving fast and you know me - can't resist the spotlight."

"Never mind that, I'm just glad to see you," Catra blubbed with relief in her voice, and then - a moment later, anger. "I hope you have something good to show for yourself after all this time."

"I do indeed, Kitten," Double Trouble drawled. "Or how about the little tidbit that Adora have left Brightmoon. The princess alliance has fallen apart. Everyone is returning to their own kingdom and little miss Sparklepants is desperately trying to keep things together."

They grinned.

"Brightmoon is ripe for the taking, Catra. Just thought you'd like to know."

- - -

"Shadow Weaver," Glimmer said.

"My Queen," Shadow Weaver answered, voice cold and neutral.

Glimmer sighed.

"I'm sorry," she said. "I shouldn't have yelled at you. You are helping me a lot and I want you to know that I *am* thankful for it."

Shadow Weaver gave her a disdainful look.

"You’re plan has already fallen apart, has it? Very well. There is still time for me to connect to the Black Garnet."

"No, Shadow Weaver. We are not doing that. I thought I made myself clear."

"Then I don’t quite understand your meaning, my queen."

Glimmer gave Shadow Weaver a bewildered look.

"People never say sorry to you?"

"People who know what’s good for them often do," Shadow Weaver said smoothly, "but since you do not seem inclined to follow my advice, I don't see how..."

Glimmer gave her a compassionate look.

"Apologies are not the same thing as subservience," she said softly.

Shadow Weave gave her a disdainful look.

"I trust you are not here to waste my time with trivialities."

"I trust you don't deem The Heart of Etheria a trivial matter," Glimmer countered.

"I already told you what you have to do."

"I already told you there is another way."

Shadow Weaver snorted.

"Sure, run to you dear auntie Castaspella. Dig through whatever dusty archives of Mystacor you can find. I promise you that..."

"I'm not talking about Mystacor," Glimmer interrupted. "I'm not talking about another sorceress or princess or other now living being. I'm talking about the First Ones. They should know, right? After all, they *built* the Heart."

"There are no First Ones left," Shadow Weaver snapped, but then she abruptly silenced.

"The hologram." She stated.

Glimmer nodded.

"Will she talk to you, without Adora?" Shadow Weaver asked.

Glimmer smiled.

"I will make her talk."

"Interesting. I will follow you. Together we can..."

"You will do no such thing," Glimmer interrupted again. "I will go alone."

"But my queen, I..."

"*You* are my prisoner, and you would do well not forgetting that," Glimmer snapped. "I will wrestle the key to the Heart of Etheria from the hologram of the First Ones. I will unlock its secrets and bring magic back to the princesses. I will stop the Horde and when Horde Prime shows up I will let him know in no uncertain terms that he is *trespassing*. I don't need Adora for this, and I most certainly don't need you."

"My Queen, wait."

Glimmer gave her an annoyed look.

"YES?"

"If you are serious in facing this... creature alone, at least take my advice and do so from a position of strength."

"You too think me weak, huh?" Glimmer said, a dangerous edge to her voice.

"I think no such thing, my Queen," Shadow Weaver said. "But neither do I think you a fool. Your growth in strength has been tremendous, thanks in part to you listening to my wisdom. I beg you, do not throw it away now."

Glimmer gave her a suspicious look.

"What did you have in mind?"

For answer, Shadow Weaver started to weave a magic circle. She worked slowly, methodically. Glimmer recognized Shadow Weaver's teaching mode and focused on taking in each detail.

"I know this frame-work," she said after awhile.

"I should hope so," Shadow Weaver answered. "I don't like repeating myself."

"This is the spell you used when you first allowed us to draw magic from each other. But there are more... connections?"

"Very good, my Queen. Can you tell me to what?"

Glimmer frowned.

"I would say lesser, transient power sources, but..."

"Yes, that is what would be normally expected from a spell like this."

"...but it's the same underlying pattern repeating again and again. Not multiple power sources, but one. Multiple connections to one power source."

Glimmer gave her a careful look.

"Which power source could possibly need that many connections?"

"Which power source indeed, my Queen?"

Shadow Weaver finished the spell. The circle shimmered between them in the air, oozing menace and potential. Then she slashed at it, destroyed it.

Glimmer gave her a quizzical look.

"That spell is not for me, my Queen, but for you - should you choose to use it."

Glimmer gave Shadow Weaver a long, thoughtful look.

"The Moonstone."

It was not a question.

"Very good."

"Why would I want to do that? I already am connected to the Moonstone."

"Of course you are, oh princess. But this spell would enhance the process. You would draw more energy than you are used to. Much more. You wouldn't be able to hold it for long, of course, but for a few hours you would carry with you power of an order of a magnitude higher than usual. Even the hologram of the First One would find you quite a match, my queen."

Glimmer felt a warm feeling in her stomach. There was a way forward, after all.

"Won't that drain the Moonstone?" She asked. Shadow Weaver shrugged.

"For a short time, maybe. But it's connected to all the magic of Etheria. It will refill soon enough."

Glimmer nodded.

"Show me how to do the spell again," she asked. "Please."

Shadow Weaver did so. Glimmer practiced the motions again and again.

Eventually she took a deep breath. She looked Shadow Weaver in the eyes.

"I will not fail," Glimmer said with steady voice.

"I know," Shadow Weaver answered.

Glimmer drew her circle. It shimmered in the air between them. She took a step forward.

The Moonstone flared up. The light poured into Glimmer like bronze in a mold. She gasped for breath, but after a moment she started to laugh.

Light emitted from her skin, from her mouth, from her eyes. The air around her was alive with sparks. She held up her hand and her staff materialized, shining like a beacon.

"I'll go get the key to the Heart of Etheria," she said with self assured voice. "I will balance the magic of the planet. I will stop the Horde. I will not shrink on my duty."

She teleported out.

There were no princess left in Brightmoon.

Shadow Weaver was alone in the garden. Left to her own designs.

She looked up at the Moonstone, shining weak and faint against the night sky. Soon its power would refill again.

But not soon enough.

Shadow Weaver smiled behind her mask.

Things were finally falling into place.

She took a bottle from her robe and poured the content in a silver bowl. She added a few drops from another bottle and waved a magical construct. She glanced around her to make sure she was alone.

When she was satisfied, she released the construct, and the surface of the liquid shimmered and changed. Instead of her own masked reflection she saw the grim face of her old master, standing by a Horde vehicle. He abruptly looked up when he sensed her presence and roared in fury.

"Hordak," she said with a smooth voice, not taking notice of his furious snarl or his arm canon taking aim at her reflection. "We need to talk. There are some things you should know about your *dear* princess Entrapta…"

Chapter End Notes

I'm pretty proud of the princess council scene. I figure *something* like that must have happened in canon.

Skin the cat

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The temple of the First Ones shimmered like a gem among the trees and rocks of the Whispering Woods.

Equally shiny was the Queen of Brightmoon walking up to the entrance with measured pace.

Hidden in the shadows of the undergrowth, Force Captain Catra of the Horde was nothing you could call shiny at all, which was rather the point.

Only the tiniest glint of light against the pipe of a weapon warned the queen and allowed her to teleport away before the projectile hit. She materialized a few steps away and immediately teleported again.

"Got you!" Catra screamed and let her whip fly. When Glimmer materialized again, Catra managed to give her a glancing lash, and the fight was on.

"Missed me?" Catra mocked as she dodged a ball of lighting. "Couldn't' stand the thought of you being lonely so I thought I would drop in."

"Couldn't get enough of me, could you?" Glimmer leered. "How did you know I would be here," she asked, teleporting out of reach from Catra's whip.

"Someone tattled. Maybe you should have been more careful with who you let into your pretty little castle."

"What?" Glimmer laughed. "*Scorpia* betrayed me? Don't be ridiculous."

Catra scoffed at that.

"Scorpia? You can't be serious. No, I'm..." Suddenly she blinked.

"Scorpia is in Brightmoon?" she hissed. Glimmer gave her a bewildered look.

"You didn't know?" Her expression changed into insincere pity as Glimmer realized the material she had been given..

"Oh, Kitty," she said with velvet voice. "Scorpia betrayed you and you didn't even know?"

"Shut up," Catra whispered. Glimmer took a step closer.

"Do you want to know what she said about you?" she said, voice full of honey and venom.

"Shut up!" Catra hissed. Glimmer's face split up in a broad grin.

"She said that you were a *bad friend*," she taunted. "Can't imagine where she got that impression but... well those were her words."

Catra lunged straight towards Glimmer, claws out. Glimmer had been prepared for her and a beam of light met her. Catra managed to change course in the last minute and jumped to the side. Glimmer let the scorching beam follow her and laughed mocking laugh.

"Poor kitty," she half-sang. "First Adora, then Shadow Weaver, then Entrapta, now Scorpia. Won't there be anyone left for you?"

"Shut up!" Catra cried from behind a tree. Glimmer promptly blew it up.

"Who wants to stay with the baaaad friend," she asked out in the air. Catra snarled in animal fury, and Glimmer unleashed another ball of energy towards the sound.

"Don't worry, kitty." Glimmer snarled, all faux concern gone from her voice. "I will keep you warm." She teleported to the spot where she last had heard Catra's voice and landed with fists full of Glitter. Catra wasn't there, but Glimmer barely had time to register that before she felt the sting of a whip winding itself around her arm. She snarled and unleashed her magic, grounding it through the rope the way Shadow Weaver had taught her.

Only a moment too late she realized that the whip were limp on the ground and no one was holding the other end. The magic grounded itself harmlessly into the soil.

Where was Catra?

It was instinct, pure and simple that allowed her to sense the approaching threat a moment before it connected and thrust her staff backwards to counter Catra's claws.

Catra jumped to the side and easily dodged Glimmer's counter attack. Then she jumped upwards and disappeared among the canopies. Glimmer tried to track her for a moment before she realized she was a sitting target. She teleported away, and the moment after she did, Catra landed on the spot she just vacated, claws first.

"Baaaaad friend," Glimmer's voice echoed through the glade.

Catra screamed in fury and ducked behind a tree. She tore her comm padd out of a pocket and punched a rapid series of commands, and then scrambled to get clear as the bots attacked.

- - -

"You have ordered your forces to advance?"

It had not been a question.

"Gotta keep the pressure on," Catra had answered.

There had been a short moment of silence as Hordak glared at her.

"Good," he had said eventually. "Your forces can press on. In the meanwhile I have a *special* assignment to you."

She had felt herself tense up.

"I have to stay with the troops," she protested. He had almost smirked at that.

"Your new Force Captain can surely manage on her own for a few hours. She seems... ambitious. You trust her, don't you."

"Of course," Catra had answered, alarm bells ringing.

"Then you shouldn't have a problem to run this little *errand* for me. You can regroup with your troops afterwards."

"What do you want me to do?" Catra had asked, sourly.

Hordak had smiled.

"I have reliable intel on the location of the princess of Brightmoon. In the Whispering Woods. Not far from your location. Take the new shipment of bots and kill her."

Catra's ears had perked up.

"Sparkles is here? Why?"

"My sources did not see fit to inquire of her itinerary for the day," Hordak had answered with disdainful voice.

"Just what are your sources," Catra had demanded. Hordak had smirked, for real this time.

"You don't think you are the only one with a link to little 'Flutterina', do you?"

Catra's blood had frozen at that.

But she had left the troops with Lonnie - who had given her a long suspicious look but hadn't argued - and moved to the indicated spot, thinking furiously all the time.

How much more had Double Trouble told Hordak?

- - -

"Oooops, so sorry for breaking your toys," Glimmer gloated as the beam of lighting that poured from her hands melted yet another bot to slag. She stood in the middle of the glade, surrounded by the destroyed husks of more than half of the bots that had attacked her. As the remaining bots kept firing, she raised a shimmering shield around her, blocking the lasers with disdainful ease. Then she destroyed yet another bot.

Catra swore. How had the princess become this powerful? She had been a nightmare last time they fought, and this was way worse.

She had never paid much attention to the ghost stories the cadets used to whisper to each other late at night about the mad princesses waiting to suck their blood or whatever. Adora had eaten them up, but Catra had plenty of nightmares much more close to home to worry about. Still, there was something with seeing Glimmer now, glowing with light and power, flinging death around her with almost contemptuous ease that started to resemble those nightmares to a disturbing degree. And Catra knew that she held back, showed off. Glimmer was making herself a easy target rather than teleporting around, flaunting that she *could* take anything that Catra dished out.

That promised for things to get very messy, very quickly, once Glimmer grew tired of the game and went on the offensive.

But it also gave Catra time to play some cards of her own.

If Glimmer was truly stupid enough to underestimate her - powered up or not - it would just be rude of Catra not to take advantage of the fact, wouldn't it?

"No Adora?" she taunted. "It's almost like she doesn't want to hang out with you any more?"

"Speaking from experience?" Glimmer answered with sweet voice, and Catra swore silently for herself. Points to Sparkles.

Catra got in position in the spot she had picked for ambush, crouched and pressed a button on her remote. The bombs she had planted in the glade went off.

They were not *big* as bombs go, but they did throw up and impressive amount of dirt and debris, not to mention smoke from canisters. Catra readied herself and stared intently in the ensuing chaos, waiting to spot any sign of the princess teleporting in.

It took a few moments before she realized that the princes stood just where Catra last had seen her, in the middle of the glade, protected from debris and shrapnel by a pink force field.

The princess smiled.

Yikes!

Catra quickly interrupted her attack, crouched lower, making sure not to be seen and quickly pushed buttons on her com pads, ordering the next wave of bots to step out of the smoke and into the glade.

Glimmer laughed and unleashed her beams of light again, exploding the bots one after another.

Catra frantically pushed buttons and activated the hologram emitters - a goodbye present from Entrapta - and suddenly the number of bots in the glade multiplied. Between the smoke and debris and rapid fire, it was next to impossible to tell which were real and which were just holograms.

Glimmer let out a surprised gasp and quickly erected the force field again. For a moment she just seemed to gather her

thoughts, then she did a quick, jabbing motion and the force field rushed outwards.

Catra yelped and pressed herself to the ground, feeling her fur tingle as the pink energies passed above her. As it reached the bots, they fizzled and died, together with the hologram emitters.

Double Yikes.

But for a few moments, Glimmer breathed heavily and sunk to one knee.

Catra saw her chance. She picked a metal ball from her pocket and threw it as high as she could, and then - without a sound - she got to her feet and on all fours crept forward through the debris, positioning herself behind the princess.

The ball reached its highest point in the arc and exploded in a multitude of tiny metal birds that rapidly started to flap around, emitting loud noises. Glimmer summoned her lighting again and tried to get a fix of the quickly moving birds. It took her a few moments to realize that they were a distraction rather than a threat.

A few moments were plenty of time for Catra to strike. Glimmer must have sensed her coming because she scrambled to her feet and tried to aim her magic at her assailant.

But Catra was faster.

With a leap she was close enough to reach Sparkles. She feinted, ducked as a lighting ball whooshed past her ears and then she gave the princess a vicious kick to the legs. As both of them scrambled on the ground Catra swiped for the neck of her opponent and felt her hand connect. Her claws drew blood.

It was so close, there and then. If Catra only had struck a finger's width to the left, if her claws had been only a fraction more unsheeted, she would have torn Glimmer's windpipe and the princess would be dead, magic or not.

But Catra must have missed her aim.

Glimmer snarled and pressed her hand to the wound, and at the same time she teleported out. Catra didn't stop to see where she would re-materialize. She ran through the smoke and the debris to put some distance between herself and the last place Sparkles had seen her.

The moment after she cleared the area, a ball of lighting hit from straight above, and the entire glade exploded in an inferno of light and debris.

When Catra could see again, Glimmer stood in the middle of the glade, one hand to her neck the other radiating light.

"Here kitty, kitty, kitty," she snarled. Catra hid deeper in the hollow she had found.

"So, how's arrow boy?" she casually asked, more as a distraction than anything else. She made sure to throw her voice but also to move away from her last hiding place just in case.

"Shut up," Glimmer growled with a venom in her voice that told Catra she had found her target. She let out a little scornful laugh.

"No Adora, no Bow, no friends, only you by the creepy old temple..." Catra taunted. "What are you trying to pull here anyway, Sparkles?"

Glimmer frowned.

"What are *you* trying to pull?"

"Me?" Catra said innocently. "I just popped by to say hi, that all."

"You are trying to delay me," Glimmer slowly said. "That's why you're here. You know what I'm doing..." Suddenly her face formed a perfect mask of horror. "...You *know*."

"Of course I know, Sparkles," Catra taunted, not being exactly sure what the queen was getting at.

"The princesses..." Glimmer whispered, face still rigid with fear. Catra smirked. This was material she could work with. She risked taking a step forward, out in the open.

"Poor little lonely queen," Catra taunted. "Where are your friends? All the other little princesses went home and didn't want to play any more?"

Glimmer frowned.

"Don't worry about being lonely in that big castle of yours," Catra pushed on. "The Horde will soon come and keep you company..."

"Catra," Glimmer said, and her voice was suddenly filled with suspicion rather than rage. "How did you know I was coming here?"

"Let's just say there's a little bird in Brightmoon that tells me just what's going on."

Glimmer stared at her. She knew what she had told Double Trouble… but she also knew what she had NOT told them. And she knew what Double Trouble had been supposed to Catra.

What else had Double Trouble told Catra?

Or not told Catra?

"Catra..." she slowly said. "*What* do you think I'm here to do?"

"Well, obviously..." Catra faltered. "You..."

"How could you know *where* I would be but now *why*?" Glimmer pressed. Catra frowned.

"Hey, I'm not knocking your spies, am I?" We are doing what we can with limited intel.

"Did you talk directly to your spy?" Glimmer demanded. Catra snorted.

"Naughty, naughty," Catra snickered. "Want me to reveal my sources, do you? Worried it will be someone you trust?"

"I want to figure out why you only know part of my plan," Glimmer said, an increasing amount of panic in her voice.

She sounded genuinely worried. Catra gave her a suspicious glance.

"What are you talking about, Sparkles?"

Glimmer stared at Catra, obviously doing mental calculation very fast. Catra did the same thing.

"Anyone who *could* have told you half the truth could also have told you the whole truth," Glimmer said slowly. "If they didn't, that's because..." her voice faltered.

They stared at each other in silence for a moment, the sound of burning bots the only thing that could be heard.

"...because they are playing their own game," Catra filled in, thinking of Hordak's expression.

"Why?" Glimmer blurted out. "Either they want for me to fail or for..."

"...or for you to get rid of me," Catra filled in, suspicions of her own bubbling to the surface of her mind.

"Or both?" Glimmer whispered.

They stared at each other.

"There are not that many people with a direct channel to both of us, Sparkles," Catra said tentatively.

"I can only think of one or two..." Glimmer said just as carefully.

They stood only a few steps from each other now, both holding their hands in non-threatening positions (as if that meant much, coming from either of them).

Catra forced herself to think.

"What's the part of the plan I don't know?" she tried. Glimmer gave her an annoyed look.

"If they haven't told you, I obviously won't."

They...

"You know about Double Trouble?" Catra blurted out. Glimmer gave her a frustrated look.

"We caught them, all right. Far too late for comfort, but we figured it out in the end."

"But they checked in with me less than a day ago..."

Catra's voice trailed off.

Glimmer actually looked guilty when she saw the devastated look on Catra's face.

"Did they tell you I was coming here?" Glimmer urged. Catra gave her a distracted look.

"Well..."

"Did they?"

"No... not directly."

"Catra..." Glimmer said. "What game are they playing?"

In perfect synchrony, both their eyes turned to one of the remaining bots. It had drilled itself to the ground and was now blinking rapidly.

"Catra...?" Glimmer carefully said.

Catra looked at her comm pad in confusion.

"Hey, it's not supposed to do that," she muttered.

The bot now emitted a high pitched noise.

"Turn it off!" Glimmer yelled. Catra frantically pushed buttons at her comm pad.

"It doesn't respond!" she screamed.

Glimmer gave her a long, suspicious look, but the pure terror in Catra's face convinced her. She teleported just next to the bot and just as it exploded, enclosed it in a pink force field.

Catra had to turn her eyes away because of the intense light. When she could see again, the bot was gone and where it had stood was a crater shaped exactly as the bottom part of the force field. Glimmer sat on the ground, breathing hard.

"What was that for?" she demanded. Catra gave her a bewildered look.

"I don't know. It just... activated, and I couldn't control it."

Glimmer gave her an exasperated look.

"What are you up to here, Catra?"

"Me? Nothing? I'm not the one playing games."

"Well," Glimmer snarled. "Someone is. And I don't have time for this any more." She stood up and started to walk, a bit unsteadily, towards the first one's temple.

"Sparkles! Look out!"

Catra heard herself yell, and then she started to run before her brain had registered what her ears had already picked up. She

leapt and roughly tackled Glimmer to the ground. For a moment it looked like Glimmer would attack her, but then the laser shots of a horde rifle hit the spot just where she had stood.

They looked up.

Force Captain Octavia gave them an almost happy grin as she took aim again. Behind her they could hear the sound of engines as a large number of vehicles and bots made their way towards them through the woods.

"Hordak says goodbye, Catra," she said with a smug smile. "Seems he isn't your *friend* anymore."

She pressed the trigger.

Just as the rifle fired, Glimmer teleported them away, into the First Ones' temple.

Chapter End Notes

Ah! No! Betrayal!

Administrator Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They materialized inside the First Ones' temple, surrounded by crystals. For a moment they clung to each other, then at once they let go. Glimmer snarled and prepared a ball of lighting in her hand. Catra made a startled yelp and jumped to the side as it went past her.

"Are you crazy?" she spat. "Why did you bring us in *here*?"

"We're not likely to be followed," Glimmer snarled back. "Unless your friends out there have an elemental princess to carry them, of course. The exit is just behind us. Leave whenever you want. Say hi to Octavia from me."

Catra gave her a sour look.

"Yeah, they aren't too happy with me out there."

"My heart is truly bleeding for you, Horde Scum," Glimmer said and carefully started to walk further into the temple.

"Just 'scum', now apparently," Catra muttered. She gave the exit a longing look, then she slowly started to follow Glimmer.

"What are you doing in here anyway?"

"We're not friends," Glimmer pointed out. "Just a minute ago we tried to kill each other."

"Yeah, that's still on the table," Catra shot back. "Right now I just try to figure out if I'm more likely to die out there or in here."

"Just let me know if you want me to even the odds," Glimmer said pointedly. She gathered another ball of lighting in her hand. Catra

quickly jumped behind a large crystal structure.

"What did you do to piss them off anyway?" Glimmer asked.

Catra shrugged.

"This week? Dunno. I've stopped counting."

"Why am I not surprised," Glimmer smirked.

Even in her current mood, Catra laughed at that.

"Double Trouble told you I was coming here, then?" Glimmer demanded as she kept walking, carefully looking around for any sign of spiders. Catra trailed after her. Her face grow dark at the mention of the spy.

"Not directly, no. But Hordak told me they told *him*."

"And then he sent that pirate to take you down," Glimmer filled in. Catra shrugged.

"Octavia has itched for an excuse to take a swing at me since forever."

"Has Hordak and Double Trouble talked before?" Glimmer wondered.

"Not as far as I know," Catra said, "But I wouldn't put it past either of them." She gave Glimmer a sour look. "Apparently Double Trouble is not above switching sides."

"If it's any comfort, I had to lean on them pretty hard before that happened," Glimmer shot back.

"Do you think that's why they set us up?" Catra mused. "Getting rid of both of us with one stone."

"If so they are doing a sloppy job of it," Glimmer answered. "You have not so much 'stopped' me as 'annoyed' me."

"Presumably Hordak wanted you to take me out," Catra shrugged. "And then Octavia to clean up whatever of you I missed. With us out of the way, he will be free to take Brightmoon at his leisure."

Glimmer mused on that.

"He isn't, though. That hinges both on you being able to stop me, and on the other princesses not stopping *him*."

Catra sharply looked up.

"I thought they left for their own kingdoms."

Glimmer carefully studied her expression.

"Yes, that was what you were meant to think. And so does Hordak, apparently."

Catra frowned.

"What does that mean?"

Glimmer breathed out, a tired, frustrated sigh.

"That means that from my perspective, nothing has changed. Whatever games Double Trouble is playing, the Horde is still coming for my home. That means that my plan is still on, I still have things to do, and I have no need for *you*."

She abruptly turned around and released a ball of lighting towards Catra. Catra yelped and jumped to the side. Glimmer followed her with a beam of light that shattered crystals and threw up a cloud of shards and debris in the temple.

"What are you doing?" Catra cried.

"Ringing the doorbell," Glimmer said with calm voice. "I suggest you run if you don’t want to be here when someone opens."

At the same time a red light started shining and from the corridor behind them a screech of spiders could be heard.

"Too late," she went on in the same tone of voice. "Goodbye, Kitten."

Catra snarled and ran after her.

"Think you can just run away from me, princess?"

She ran through the shards and debris, struggling to keep track of Glimmer.

Catra's thoughts were furiously swirling in her head.

Hordak had made his move. She had known he would sooner or later. Had known there was always a knife waiting for her back from the moment she had accepted the badge on her chest.

She knew it. Knew it would come.

Had thought of plans and counter-plans for this day.

And now when the day was here... when it was time to enact the plans...

She always had imagined Hordak would be the one challenging her in person rather than sending a lackey - Octavia of all people - to do the dirty deeds.

Or imagined there to be *someone* in her corner. Like Double Trouble. Or Scorpia.

She shuddered.

Life in the Horde was hard but it was simple. Kick down, grovel up - until it was time to bite.

Well, the thing with reaching the top is that there is no more 'up'.

But there sure is a whole lot of down.

Not that she was in the Horde any longer.

Catra had lost, it was as simple as that.

She had lo...

NO!

She forced her thoughts away.

There must be another way. Another angle.

Because if she lost, then she wouldn't have the Horde any longer. She wouldn't have her hard earned position of power, her respect, her title. And if she hadn't, then everything she had done to get here, all her betrayals, all her violence, all the friends she had hurt would have been completely...

...pointless.

She felt as if she was trying to move through water. Felt like it threatened to drown her completely.

She looked down. To her sudden shock, she realized that her legs were almost entirely snared in webs.

With a snarl she slashed at it, and barely managed to jump to the side as the spiders descended upon her. She managed to free her legs, and then she had to retreat into a side path.

She swore for herself. Several more spiders were hunting her and she saw more of them ahead. Maybe she could...

Without any warning whatsoever, the wall panel just next to her became transparent, and spiders poured out of the opening. Catra screamed in fear and anger. She jumped to the side but her arms got stuck in net. a spider's jaw caught her leg and she fell to the ground. She tried rolling to the side but...

The entire world became white.

Catra desperately held her eyes closed and felt the heat wash over her. She heard the spiders hiss, and then abruptly fall silent.

The only sound that remained were the clangs and thuds of parts of spiders falling to the floor.

And the measured steps of Glimmer walking up to her through the wreckage, shining like a star.

Catra stared at her.

"Have I mentioned how hot you are when you do things like that?" she gasped. Glimmer rolled her eyes.

"Don't get used to it," she answered, voice dry.

They looked at each other.

"Get out of here," Glimmer said with tired voice. "There really isn't a need for you to get caught up in this."

"Get out *where*?" Catra snarled. "To the warm embrace of Octavia?"

Glimmer shrugged.

"If you prefer the spiders, be my guest I suppose. But don't count on me to dig you out again."

She turned and walked into the gloom again.

Catra stared after her.

She turned and looked towards the exit. She'd probably make it there, if she hurried, if she got lucky, if Sparkles held the interest of the Spiders just a little bit longer.

And then she would be out. She could probably dodge Octavia. Slip past the bots, through whatever net her soldiers tried to make.

Good luck to them, trying to find her on the road. Just another Horde reject in a world increasingly full of them.

And then...

And then she wouldn't have the Horde any longer.

She wouldn't *be* of the Horde any longer.

And then...

NO!

There must be another way.

She hurried after Glimmer through the creepy temple corridors

Suddenly, as from out of nowhere, the queen stood before her again. Her hands were busy weaving a spell.

"Glimmer?" Catra asked. She didn't like the look in the queens eyes.

"Looks like it's your lucky day," she said with a sweet smile. "I've got this rune I want to try out."

Catra backed off, but the wall behind her blocked her path.

"I haven't practised this one as much," Glimmer snarled, holding the spell just in front of Catra's face. "I'm still getting the hang of it. It's a truth spell if it works." She put stress on the last syllable.

Catra didn't dare tear her eyes from the glowing lines just in front of her.

"Sparkles..." she said carefully.

"...but if it fails it can be extremely painful," Glimmer went on, taking no notice of her. There was a gleam in the queens eyes that Catra had never seen before.

"I don't know what game Double Trouble and Hordak plays," Catra yelped. "They turned on me, just as much as you. I don't know anything more."

"I think you do," Glimmer spat and pushed the spell into Catra's face.

Catra screamed.

- - -

"Light Hope!" Glimmer cried. "I can kill spiders all day if that's what you want, but I'm here to talk to you. Show yourself."

A soft laughter was heard. Glimmer instinctively took a step back.

From the smoke and debris Catra came walking, knife in hand, smirking. Glimmer prepared a new ball of lighting, but Catra dodged it with contemptuous ease.

"I thought you were smart enough to leave me alone," Glimmer snarled and prepared her magic again. Catra laughed. A throaty laugh were she threw her head backwards and shook with mirth.

And then, without any warning whatsoever, she struck.

A quick leap, and suddenly she was very, very close to Glimmer, fangs barred, knife at Glimmer's throat. Glimmer froze.

"So, here's the thing," Catra said in conversational tone. "I've done this. The whole 'threatening people' bit, the intimidation. I've been there. And I just don't care anymore."

"Catra..." Glimmer said.

The knife pressed harder at Glimmer's throat. She abruptly fell silent, tried not to move, staring in shock into Catra's narrow eyes.

"Some people have a bad day," Catra hissed. "I've had a bad *life*. If I want something, it's taken from me. If I win a fight, I lose the

war. Threats only work on someone who has something to lose. But me?"

She stood back and effortlessly stabbed a spider that was creeping closer.

"I've already lost it all."

She strolled back into the smoke, leaving Glimmer to stare after her with a beating heart.

- - -

Catra carefully crept through the smoke. She knew this place was bad news. It messed with her head again.

Glimmer stood in the middle of the room. The red light flickered around her like flames. Catra carefully edged closer.

"Maybe your 'best' is not good enough," Glimmer snarled.

Catra recoiled from the venom in the queen's voice.

"If it weren't for you my mother would still have been alive!" Glimmer cried. Catra looked at her in shock, but the gasp that was let out were not from her throat.

When she turned around, she saw Adora staring at Glimmer with large, tear filled eyes. Catra and Glimmer both, semi unconsciously, stretched out their arms towards her, but Adora turned around and ran. Catra watched Glimmer sink down to her knees.

- - -

"Admit it, Adora," Catra taunted. "The world would still be standing if you had never come through that portal in the first place." She took a step forward towards the horrified Adora.

Glimmer watched them in shock, seemingly unable to turn her gaze away.

"You made me this," Catra snarled. "You took everything from me. You broke the world, and it is all your fault."

"No..." Glimmer whispered.

"No," Adora said, voice shivering at first, but rapidly growing more steady. "It's not." She took a step forward, towards Catra, and towards Glimmer who was now standing just behind her.

"I didn't make you pull the switch," Adora said. "I didn't make you do anything. I didn't break the world, but I am gonna fix it. And you? You made your choice. Now *live with it*."

A half strangled sound emerged from Glimmer's throat.

- - -

"Quickly now."

Catra watched as transfixed the scene in front of her. Shadow Weaver stood under Moonstone, in a circle of power. She draw a spell in the air and reached out her hand to Glimmer.

"GLIMMER, NO!" Catra cried. She tried to run forward, but it was like running through water.

With a determined expression, Glimmer took the hand. In horror Catra saw her disappear in a flash of light and darkness.

- - -

"CATRA, NO!" Glimmer cried. She tried to run forward, but it was like running through water.

With a cruel expression, Catra pulled the lever. The portal activated.

- - -

It was a completely white void. No features, no entrances and most importantly, no exits.

Catra and Glimmer stared at each other in tense anticipation.

They both had tears in their eyes.

A moment passed, then another one.

They blinked.

"Get it over with," Catra grumbled. "What is it this time?"

"Same," Glimmer answered. "Any other delightful little scene you want to share?"

"Not in particular, no," Catra muttered.

They look at each other for a few moments more.

"This is the real you, then?" Glimmer asked.

Catra shrugged.

"As far as I can tell. And you are certainly annoying enough to be the real you."

"Goodie," Glimmer muttered.

They looked at each other.

"What, not trying to kill me?" Catra asked after a moment.
Glimmer shrugged.

"Don't feel excluded, I'm sure I'll get back to it," she muttered, but her heart was not in it.

"Ceasefire?" Catra suggested.

Glimmer shrugged noncommittally.

"Whatever," she said, maybe with just a touch of Mermista's inflections to the word.

They both breathed out, a bit of tension leaving their bodies.

"Why are we here anyway?" Catra asked out loud, her eyes searching the void.

"*I'm* here because I try to save my planet," Glimmer said. "*You* are here to annoy me, as far as I can tell."

"Fair enough," Catra admitted. "But I thought more of here as in *here*. In this white whatever."

Glimmer looked around.

"Dunno. Maybe the system's running low on power again. Adora said that happened a few times previously."

Catra groaned.

"Great. So how do we get out from here?"

Glimmer shrugged.

"We could wait... we could try to figure out the rules of this place and find an exit within them... or we just start fucking shit up."

She gave Catra a direct look.

"I'm done with taking the stubtle approach."

Catra gave her an admiring look.

"*Sparkles!* Why didn't you lead with that. I'm your gal."

She held out her hand.

Glimmer took it.

They shared a smirk.

Glimmer held up her staff, and a blinding light radiated from it. Catra shielded her eyes and carefully looked around.

"There!" she shouted and pointed in the direction where she had seen textures and shadows differ from the rest of the room. Glimmer smiled, a hard smile, and discharged a huge blast in that direction. When they could see again, a crack could be seen. The effect was pretty much like being on the inside of a gigantic egg, with a crack in the shell.

Without a word, Glimmer and Catra rushed up to it and Catra gave it a few slashes with her claws, and then a vicious kick, dislodging a large enough piece for them to climb through.

Catra took a half step back and did a little sarcastic bow.

"Princesses first," she said. Glimmer snorted and climbed through. Catra followed hot on her heels.

After all the strange sights they had seen, the room they were in now seemed relatively mundane, at least by 'creepy alien temple' standard. Only a few broken panels and dull crystals.

"I hate this place," Catra groaned and sank to the floor. Glimmer sat down next to her, cradling her head.

They sneaked glances at each other. Neither of them were downright hostile, but both had a body language that suggested that hostility was still on the table.

"Well, had a fun romp through my past?" Catra asked.

"Not particularly, no," Glimmer snorted.

Catra gave her a thoughtful look.

"Shadow Weaver, huh?" she asked with low voice.

Glimmer rolled her eyes.

"Not you too. Adora is on me about her all the time."

"Yeah, because Adora knows what she is," Catra said frankly.

Glimmer rolled her eyes harder.

"I know what she is."

"No, you don't," Catra said without force. "If you did you'd find a rock and kill her with it first chance."

"Why?" Glimmer answered, just as frankly. "She'll be dead soon anyway, just like the rest of us, once the Horde reaches Brightmoon."

"No she won't," Catra muttered. "She'll slink away, or weasel back into Hordak's good grace, but I get your point."

Glimmer gave her a direct look.

"Do you? Do you really? Because Adora sure doesn't."

That actually made Catra laugh.

"Of course she doesn't. Adora is all about winning the game. Can't do that if you break the rules."

Glimmer smirked at that.

"Now there's the truth."

Catra gave her a pensive look.

"That's why you are here, then? One of Shadow Weavers bids for power? She will use you, you know."

"Of course I know," Glimmer said with tired voice. "Everyone keeps reminding me. Also, this is not *her* scheme."

"It helps to tell yourself that," Catra said with almost sympathetic voice, earning herself a glare.

"Tell me something," Glimmer asked pointedly. "If you could go back in time and stop yourself from pulling that lever, opening that portal, would you?"

Catra hesitated.

Glimmer gave her a few moments, then she nodded and made a little shrug.

"I get it, you know," she said without force. "You were in a corner. You found a way out." She chuckled. "Maybe not the most *constructive* way out, but hey, we've all been angry and wanted to smash things."

Catra laughed.

"Bet you've never smashed the whole world, Sparkles."

"Give me time," Glimmer answered with a wistfulness in her voice that for some reason sent shivers up Catra's spine.

Glimmer stood up.

"The Horde really threw you out, huh?" she asked. Catra jumped to her feet as well.

"Not first time it happens," she answered, her flippant voice not entirely managing to hide the bitterness.

"For what it's worth, I'm glad I won't have to kill you," Glimmer said and started walking. Catra hesitated, and then followed her.

"I'm sure you'll get back to it," she said. Glimmer smirked.

They followed the corridor in silence for a little while.

"So... this 'scheme' of yours...?" Catra asked, voice trailing off.

Glimmer didn't answer. Catra sighed.

"I get it, too, Sparkles. We've put *you* in a corner. You have your hands on your own portal lever."

Glimmer made an uncommitted shrug.

"Smashing things aren't always as fun as it seems," Catra said, silently.

Glimmer glanced at her.

"Advice? From you?" she asked, scorn in her voice.

Catra shrugged.

"That's what you asked for, wasn't it?"

Glimmer sighed.

"Fine, advice me. The Horde is at my doorstep. Everything I've fought for my entire life is about to crumble into dust. Everyone hates me. What would you have me do?"

"Run?" Catra suggested. "Your buddy the ice kid has a nice shiny kingdom it will take the Horde ages to get to. You can hang out there."

"Can I?" Glimmer shot back. "Even when Horde Prime gets here?"

Catra hesitated.

"See, that's what *you* don't get," Glimmer said, a bit more force in her voice. "I have a duty to my kingdom - to this entire world. I can't just run. For you, it's never been about duty or loyalty. You just stick with the Horde because that's what you know and it gives you a chance to piss off Adora."

"You think you know me so well," Catra shot back.

"Tell me I'm wrong," Glimmer said loftily.

"You *are* wrong," Catra snapped. "I'm with the Horde because shitty as it is, I can be someone there."

"Could," Glimmer corrected, more pedantic than strictly necessary. Catra growled.

"You princess types don't like it, but the Horde is nothing unusual. Everyone is kicking at those below and looking for an edge on those above. It's the same everyone. Only difference is, in the Horde I had a headstart."

"It's not like that in Brightmoon," Glimmer protested. Catra gave her a snide look.

"Sure it is. Only place you can't see it from is the top."

"Funny," Glimmer said with cold voice. "Shadow Weaver told me the same thing."

"She's evil," Catra shot back. "Not stupid."

"And what about Adora?" Glimmer snapped "Is she evil or stupid? Because she sure ran as far as she could from the Horde the moment she got one good look at it from the outside."

"Yeah, and how's that working out for her?" Catra snarled. For a moment Glimmer looked like she was going to attack her, then she turned away and picked up her pace.

They entered a larger room. Light flooded in from crystals along the walls. Glimmer calmly walked up to a large crystal slab in the middle of the room.

"Sparkles..." Catra slowly said, eyeing the multiple openings in the wall with distrust. Glimmer turned around and gave Catra a direct look.

"I don't mind admitting that I don't hate you as much as I thought I would, Catra," she said with flat voice. "I might even like you.

You're fun to hang out with. We can bullshit, we can be upfront, I like how I don't have to pussyfoot around you."

"Yeah, real best friends material, the two of us," Catra answered carefully, taking a small step back, her eyes never leaving Glimmer's.

Glimmer took a small step forward.

"And I do appreciate the fact that with Hordak turning on you, you are not actively fighting for the Horde right now," Glimmer went on. She leaned her staff just a fraction in Catra's direction.

Catra took another small step backwards, her hands moving just a fraction towards a defensive position.

"I'm practically on the side of the angels already," she shot back.

Glimmer smiled, a cold smile that never touched her eyes.

"But don't make the mistake to think I would allow you to get in my way. I'm in a corner, Catra - you said so myself. A corner *you* helped put me in. I'm getting us out of it. All of us. You can stick around to watch the fireworks if you like, but if I for a second think you're entertaining thoughts of making my life difficult, I will make your life *quite* uncomplicated indeed for the last few moments that would remain of it."

"Duly noted," Catra said, doing her best to keep her voice steady despite her rising fear.

She knew the look in Glimmer's eyes.

She had felt that way herself often enough.

Glimmer held her eyes for a moment, then she turned around, and just as if the conversation had never taken place, she walked into the centre of the room.

Catra followed her with her eyes.

"Light Hope!" Glimmer cried. When she got no response, she unleashed a large blast of magic that shook the chamber and caused Catra to nervously back away from the openings.

"Light Hope!" Glimmer cried again. "The Queen of Brightmoon needs to speak to you."

For a moment everything was quiet.

Then spiders poured from the wall.

- - -

"You have the best plans, Sparkles," Catra grumbled, poking at a dead spider. Glimmer ignored her.

"Light Hope!" she cried again. She banged her staff at the slab.

"I hope you like spiders," Catra muttered, but at the same time the hologram sprung into life.

"Unauthorized presence detected," she stated. Glimmer held up her hand.

"I'm Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon, elemental princess of Etheria and leader of the princess alliance. I'm here on the behalf of the people of Etheria to access the Heart of Etheria. The First Ones stole it from *my* people. I want to put it to use. Please, help me."

There was a moment of absolute silence.

Catra caught herself holding her breath.

"User 'Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon' not recognized," Light Hope stated. "Status of Elemental Princess of the Moonstone: Not connected. Security system activated."

Chapter End Notes

Uh oh!

Kill the witch

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Come *on* Sparkles!"

Catra more or less had to drag Glimmer with her as they crawled through the narrow space. The spiders were still searching for them, but this duct seemed to be free of the security pests, at least for the moment.

"I... failed," Glimmer whispered, white in her face. Catra made an annoyed sound.

"Yeah, yeah. Welcome to the club. We can all whine about it later. But right now you need to get us out of here before..."

As on cue a screaming spider emerged from the gloom in front of them. Catra dropped Glimmer and pulled out a knife. She attacked the spider with vicious force and managed to put it down. She panted heavily for a moment, then carefully looked forward. It seemed to be clear for now.

Glimmer reluctantly followed her through the corridor. They found an unguarded passage and crept on in the general direction of where Catra hoped the exit was.

"So, things didn't quite work out according to plan...?" Catra carefully asked. Glimmer gave her an annoyed look.

"It's OK," Catra went on with soft voice. "I know the feeling."

"Do you, now?" Glimmer muttered.

"You are not the only one who lost something today, princess," Catra shot back.

Glimmer made a sound between a laugh and a sob.

"Yeah, I guess... Sorry about it."

Catra gave her a surprised look.

"Thank you Sparkles."

Glimmer made an uncommiting grunt.

She started to say something. Something sarcastic, something with a bite.

But no words came.

Instead she did something that rocked Catra to the core.

She started to weep. Tears flowed down her cheeks as she buried her head in her hand, without even trying to stop herself.

"Sparkles!" Catra cried, completely at a loss for what to do. Glimmer just shook her head and kept crying. Now, when the floodgates had opened there seemed to be no stopping them.

"Glimmer!" Catra cried. "I get this is a big deal for you, but we have to *leave*"

Glimmer just kept crying. Catra nervously looked over shoulder. Something moved in the gloom.

"Right... I've wanted to do this forever anyway," she muttered and slapped Glimmer in the face, hard.

The pure shock of the blow made Glimmer look up, tears momentarily forgotten. For a moment, sparks danced at her finger tips and she showed her teeth.

"There's the Sparkles I know," Catra leered. "Come at me if you think you still got it in you, big girl."

For a moment it looked like Glimmer would do just that, but then she slumped back towards the wall again.

"Sure," she muttered. "Have your fun, be my guest. Taunt me as much as you like."

"I'd love to," Catra countered, "but first of all we need to get out of here."

"What's the point?" Glimmer sighed.

"Not being eaten by spiders are good enough for me," Catra shot back.

"Yeah, yeah." Glimmer took a deep breath. "I'm sorry."

She had to blink away a few tears at that.

They crept down another corridor, and then another.

Catra could just hope they were moving in the right direction.

"So, what happens now?" Catra asked after a little while.

Glimmer gave her a look that she tried to keep hard, but the despair shone through.

"I... don't know."

Catra waited for a moment, but Glimmer's voice trailed off.

"You're going back to Brightmoon, right?" Catra prompted.

Glimmer crept on.

"Kicking Double Trouble's fine green, ass, rallying your fellow princesses, a last act of defiance?"

Glimmer didn't meet Catra's gaze.

"Giving Hordak hell from the castle walls?" Catra tried. "I'll cheer for you, for whatever it's worth."

Glimmer stopped.

"...Sparkles?" Catra asked.

Glimmer sank down to her knees. Catra took a hesitant step closer.

Glimmer looked up at her, eyes completely blank.

"There is no Brightmoon to return to," Glimmer whispered. "I failed."

"Melodramatic, much," Catra said, ill at ease from The vulnerability in Glimmer's voice. To her great relief Glimmer gave her an angry look.

"Really, you think so? *You* of all people should know how close the Horde is to overrun the city."

"Closer than I might have thought, if Hordak is in cahoots with Double Trouble," Catra mused.

Glimmer laughed, a bitter laugh.

"Double Trouble? That's who you think I'm up against?"

Catra frowned.

"If not Double Trouble, then who..."

Glimmer gave her a sardonic look.

"Adora warned me from the moment she showed up in Brightmoon, you know," she said with bitter voice. "Don't listen to her, don't trust her, she will lieeee to you, poor innocent princess."

Catra looked at her in slow realization. After the briefest moment of hesitation, she stretched out a hand and patted Glimmer on the

arm. The gesture was so unused, so much a parody of real support, that Glimmer didn't even find it in herself to get angry about it.

"It's a bitch when Adora is right, isn't it?" Catra said with sincere pity in her voice.

Glimmer couldn't stop herself from letting out a short laughter at that.

"I'll tell her I'm sorry and buy her a pony when she comes back." her face soured. "If she comes back."

Catra gave her a worried look.

"She will though, right?" Glimmer shrugged.

"You said it yourself. No one leaves Beast Island. Now, Adora has survived everything you have thrown at her, but..."

"...but this time it's Shadow Weaver she's up against," Catra filled in.

They looked each other in the eyes.

"You really think she's still working with Hordak?" Catra asked, the smallest of shivers in her voice.

Glimmer nodded.

"That's the only explanation I can think of that connects all the dots. *Something* messed up Light Hope's ability to sense my connection to the Moonstone, and I bet it was the spell Shadow Weaver taught me... it seemed like a good idea at the time," she protested when she saw the look Catra gave her.

Catra made a little 'we've all been there' gesture but didn't interrupt.

"*Someone* tipped Hordak of when I went for the temple, and he sure didn't waste any time trying to get rid of *you* afterwards."

"I might owe Double Trouble an apology," Catra mused.

"Not really," Glimmer said offhandedly. "They still betrayed *you*, they just don't seem to have betrayed *me* as well."

"Yeah, I get that a lot," Catra muttered. Glimmer ignored her.

"So do you still think I've got a Brightmoon to return to?" she asked, more of a sting to her voice. "I came here to bring something to turn the tide, and instead I lost everythi... everything," she finished with a whisper.

"Bummer," Catra said noncomittingly.

Glimmer sank down to the floor, back against the wall. She hugged her knees and desperately tried to prevent a sob from escaping.

Catra looked at her uncertainly for a little while, then she sat down next to her.

"Sparkles," she tried. "I know you're having a moment, but we kinda need to stick together to get out of here, and the spiders could find us at any moment."

"Let them," Glimmer whispered. "Won't make any difference."

"Believe you me, I know that feeling," Catra said. "But that's bullshit. You just don't give up. You don't give them the satisfaction."

Glimmer didn't answer.

"Listen, I know what you tried to do here," Catra said. "This whole 'Heart of Etheria' thing. You tried to amp up your princess power. And Shadow Weaver fucked that up for you. That sucks."

Glimmer still didn't answer.

"Thing is," Catra went on, edging a bit closer, "that's the same shit Hordak and Shadow Weaver tried for the longest time. One big bid for power. One big trick. Get all the power you ever need. Win, once and for all."

Glimmer made a snarling sound, Catra carefully peaked at her.

"That's not how it works," Catra went on. "It's the sum of the blows that count, not the flashy finishing one."

That actually made Glimmer laugh, an angry, venomous laugh.

"Like that *portal*?"

"Hey, Sparkles..."

"I'm not talking about you and whatever spiteful, toxic drive you have to get one over Adora," Glimmer snarled." I'm talking about Hordak. He got his message out. I'm talking about *Horde Prime*."

She turned to look at Catra. Her eyes were dark. The tears only made the rage even more pronounced.

"We have barely held the Horde at bay with you guys, and you have been fighting each other every step at he way. And now, at any time, the sky may tear apart to let let in a Horde big enough to *swallow* us. How is *that* for a finishing blow?"

"Don't you get it Catra?" Glimmer barred her teeth like she was going to fly at Catra's throat. "I *lost*. Adora and Bow ran away on their fools errand, the princesses are being slaughtered as we speak, if they don't have enough sense to run away which I don't count on. They were counting on me. *Me*. Opening the Heart was our one chance. Our *only* chance. Or *last* chance. Everyone on this planet is doomed, and it's *my fault.*"

"Hey, don't flatter yourself," Catra spat back, refusing to be faced by the princess' fury. I got myself in the shit without your help.

You don't think I'm fucked too, when Horde Prime gets here? Probably before that, if Hordak gets what he want. And if its like you're saying, if he has Shadow Weaver to open the Brightmoon gates for him, then I can't even count on the last push to slow him down. He'll have plenty of time to come after me to settle old scores before big brother shows up."

"Well hooray for us failures," Glimmer muttered and slumped down to the wall.

Catra watched her with a frown.

"That's it?" she demanded. Glimmer's lethargy filled Catra with unease for reasons she wasn't fully able to articulate. Glimmer gave her a tired look.

"What would you have me do?" she sighed.

"Not this!" Catra spat. "Not just slinking away to die in a hole."

"What then?" Glimmer asked, voice still tired. "Going out there and pick a fight with Octavia until one of the bots get in a lucky hit? Rushing back to Brightmoon to do a noble last stand in front of the gates? What difference does it make?"

Catra looked at her like Glimmer was speaking a foreign language.

"What difference does it make? You gotta *show them*, Sparkles. They fucked you over. No one fucks over Princess Sparklepants without her making them regret it." She gave her a sly look. "You have given me all sorts of hell any time we have met. Don't you *dare* let those goons get off any easier."

Glimmer looked at her nonplussed for a moment, then, unbidden, a deep, rich laughter emerged. She laughed like crazy there in the first ones temple sitting slumped to a wall next to her arch enemy.

"You want me to get up and back to the fight out of *spite*?" she asked when she got her voice under control.

Catra grinned.

"Best reason there is, Glimmer." Her face got more serious. Her grin more blood thirsty. "Take it from me, Sparkles. You are new to this. New to loosing everything. For me, it's old hat. And let me tell you - spite is where it's at. Despair gets you nowhere. Churning over your mistakes just keeps you down. But spite now... spite can get you *anywhere*."

Deep in her chest, Glimmer felt a small warm feeling steadily growing hotter.

Suddenly, out of nowhere, Catra slapped her hard in her face again.

"Shadow Weaver betrayed you," Catra snarled. "You gave her your trust. You gave her your hand, and she *stabbed* you in the back."

Glimmer just about burnt Catra's face off, but before she managed, Catra took a step back and held up her hands in a placating gesture.

"She took your castle, Glimmer," Catra vent on in confident, soft voice. "She took your runestone. She took your *victory*. You should not be here in a hole with me. You should be out there slinging mighty magic at Hordak and having every Horde soldier run for the hills while wetting their pants. You should have *me* beaten. You should have Adora be forced to admit you were right all along." She looked Glimmer in the eyes. "Shadow Weaver *stole* that from you."

The hot feeling was larger than her chest could contain. Glimmer felt a growl working itself up her throat.

"So who cares if you 'lost' or whatever," Catra snarled. "She fucked you over. No one does that. You go back there and show that witch what happens to anyone who *dares* messing with Queen Glimmer of fucking Brightmoon."

In hindsight, maybe they should perhaps have kept their voices down, because at that point multiple spiders came pouring at them from both ends of the corridor.

On the other hand, Catra reflected, it was probably for the best that Glimmer suddenly got another target than Catra herself to vent her anger at.

Glimmer screamed in rage and frustration, and white hot beams of pure death flowed out from her hands, tearing through the spiders like if they were paper and leaving deep cracks in the walls.

Yikes.

Hands still glowing she gave Catra a penetrating stare, eyes almost completely dark of crying and rage.

"Thanks for the pep-talk, kitty-cat," she growled. Catra forced herself not to slink back. She couldn't stop herself from trembling, though.

"I have to ask, however," Glimmer went on, same voice trembling with fury but managing to stay almost steady. "What's your angle in this?"

Catra forced her voice to remain calm as she put on a blood thirsty grin.

"You're not the only one fucked over by Hordak and Shadow Weaver, princess. I've got plenty of spite, too. Get me inside the castle walls and I will have a little *talk* with Shadow Weaver about that. There are a *lot of things I wish to discus with her." She gave Glimmer a little smile. "For what it's wort, I think this is a more constructive way of dealing with losing than just moping away."*

Glimmer grinned at her.

"From you, that means... honestly, I don't know what that means," Glimmer said with low voice. Catra grinned.

"Most likely that you are about to do a horrible mistake."

For some reason, Glimmer seemed to take comfort in that.

"Well, if I do it will at least be my mistake."

Catra laughed.

They met each other's gazes.

"Kill the witch?"

"Kill the witch."

They shared a toothy grin.

"I like this side of you, Sparkles," Catra said.

Glimmer laughed.

"Tell you a secret, Kitten... No one else does. It's all hugs and flowers in Brightmoon, and when it's time for hard decisions everyone wrings their hands and leave it to me."

"I kinda thought you were into the whole 'hugs and flowers' thing," Catra said, just a tad carefully.

Glimmer sighed.

"I... am, I suppose. Me and Bow..." she trailed off.

Catra knew enough not to push.

"...hey, Sparkles?"

Glimmer met Catra's eyes. Catra almost looked a bit embarrassed.

"Thanks for not killing me," Catra muttered. "That means a lot to me."

Glimmer smiled.

"Don't worry about it, Horde scum. You're still on my list, only not at the top at the moment."

"Ouch, I'm devastated."

They smirked at the joke, but their eyes conveyed a completely different, and much more complex understanding between them.

Glimmer reached out her glowing hand.

Bracing herself for possible burns, Catra took it.

Huh, the sparks were still there, but they didn't hurt her, they were only pretty too look at.

Kinda like claws.

Catra decided she didn't want too much introspection on that topic at the moment.

Glimmer teleported them out of the temple, out in the Whispering Woods.

A cold wind was blowing

Snow was falling.

That's when Octavia opened fire on them.

- - -

They ran together through the forest. Glimmer had teleported them out of the initial ambush, but the Force Captain knew what she head to deal with and had positioned bots and soldiers in a wide net around the temple.

"Look out," Catra cried, and Glimmer jumped to the side, dodging the bot that came crashing towards them. Catra jumped up on it, and a quick slash from her claws destroyed the power source. Glimmer gave her an appreciating nod.

"Thank you Ca..."

That was as far as she got before the next bot opened fire.

With a quick gesture she summoned a shield, and as she blocked the incoming fire, she rushed forward, towards the bot. She made a quick series of attacks as she danced around it. None of them seriously threatening, but enough to keep the bot's attention solely on herself.

Which gave Catra an open target.

"Thank you, Sparkles," Catra said as she stood up from the wrecked bot.

"Think nothing of it," Glimmer smirked. "Hear any more bots?"

Catra focused for a moment, ears twitching.

"No, but we'd better get moving. They will have noticed we took these two out by now."

"Lead the way, Kitty-cat."

"My pleasure, Princess."

Grinning at each other like naughty cadets out on a forbidden nightly adventure, they went on through the Whispering Woods.

Glimmer felt light-headed as she crept on through the frozen forest with Catra by her side and the Horde soldiers behind them. This was bonkers. This was madness. This was borderline treason. But it felt so much better than bickering with the princesses or shouting at Adora.

She had no hope, no plan, hardly a goal to speak of. Even if Catra didn't betray her - which she still thought more likely than not, they still only had the slimmest chance of actually succeeding.

She and Catra were going up against Shadow Weaver and Hordak - who clearly had planned this for awhile - with only a few sparks and Catra's devil-may-care attitude.

That last part made Glimmer feel much better.

She shouldn't be doing this. She should leave Catra to her own desperate last minute efforts, and then retreat and regroup. She should find the other princesses and explain that she hadn't been able to access the heart, that she had -

Failed.

Glimmer clenched her fists.

Then she should see if she could find Adora and Bow and retreat to Mystacor or Snow or something and plan their next move.

As if there would be a chance for a 'next move' with Brightmoon fallen to the Horde and Horde Prime threatening to burst out of the empty sky at any moment.

Unbidden her thoughts went to her mother. A tall, queenly figure sitting on the throne Glimmer's entire childhood, playing it safe, minimizing loss, defending, supporting, but ultimately fighting a loosing battle.

Shadow Weaver had asked her what kind of Queen she wanted to be, and in her heart Glimmer had known the answer.

She would not be her mother.

Well, her mother would never in her immortal life have considered something like this.

Glimmer felt like she swam in the one bright spot in an otherwise dark ocean without land in any direction. At any time, unseen dangers could drag her under, and in time the fatigue was sure to get her, but right here, right now, she could actually enjoy the rolling of the waves.

She had to admit that there was something very comforting about sneaking through a dark forest full of enemies together with technically-still-her-enemy Catra. Every threat was direct, every action she had to take immediately. She didn't have to worry about future Glimmer's problems, all she had to do was bring her there in one piece.

No reason why she couldn't enjoy herself as she did so.

She sneaked a bit closer to Catra.

After a few minutes, Catra abruptly halted. Glimmer crouched down besides her.

"Soldiers," Catra mouthed. Glimmer nodded and they sank down in the undergrowth together.

After a moment Glimmer heard them too, the trampling boots, the crushed branches. She glanced at Catra. The former Force Commander was very close to her, grinning a blood thirsty grin. She caught Glimmer's eyes and winked. Glimmer felt herself blush.

Blush?

Focus, Glimmer!

Then the soldiers moved on, and the moment passed. Catra nodded, and together they silently rose and sneaked up after the soldiers.

To Glimmer's great annoyance it was she who made the noise that made the soldiers turn around, but by then they were within reach of her staff, and it was a moment's work to knock them out. Catra gave her an appreciating look.

"Not bad, Sparkles."

"Impressing you, am I Kitty-cat?"

"I wouldn't go that far."

"No? I better step up my game then."

"Do that and I'll truly be in trouble."

They suddenly realized two things.

The first was that their faces were very close to each other.

The second was that the sound of engines suddenly could be heard over the background sound of the forest, and they were rapidly getting louder.

"Look out!" Catra cried and roughly pushed Glimmer to the side just as a laser shot tore up the tree just next to them. She desperately tried to scramble to her feet, but a second shot forced her back to the ground. They saw the glider bikes descend on them, and in desperation Glimmer grabbed Catra and teleported away.

They materialized some distance away. Glimmer breathed heavily.

"That's was close," she said. "How did they find us so quickly."

"They must have equipped the new detectors," Catra muttered, but they were not supposed to be finished yet."

Glimmer opened her mouth, but before she had the time to say something sardonic, another voice cried out.

"PRINCESS!"

They heard people run towards them through the forest and they quickly slipped away in the undergrowth.

"They told me we were all out of magic detectors too," Catra mused bitterly as they sneaked on. "Seems like someone got first dibs on the toys."

"The Horde not encouraging people to help each other," Glimmer retorted. "I'm shocked."

"Don't complain, Sparkles," Catra shot back. "If I'd all these toys I'd totally got you outside of the temple before Octavia even showed up."

"Dream on, Horde Scum," Glimmer answered with light voice. Then they had to duck under a fallen tree as a bot stomped by.

Catra took the opportunity to bop a few times on her comm pad.

"This way," she whispered and started walking again.

"You find your way through the Whispering Woods now?" Glimmer asked with an eyebrow raised. Catra shrugged.

"We HAVE been planning an invasion for some time now," Catra countered.

Glimmer had to give her that one.

"What's wrong with the forest anyway?" Catra muttered, shivering in the cold wind.

Glimmer frowned.

"I haven't seen it like this since Entrapta hacked the Black Garnet. Something must have put the flow of magic seriously out of whack."

"What could have done that?" Catra asked, trepidation in her voice.

"Maybe the same thing that made Light Hope unable to find my connection to the Moonstone," Glimmer mused.

She gave Catra a direct look.

"Could Hordak have recreated whatever Entrapta did to the Black Garnet?"

The question took Catra aback.

"I... I don't know," she confessed. "It's not like he has access to her notes" -if Glimmer noticed the guilt that flittered over Catra's face, she didn't comment on it. "But they were pretty chummy for a while there. Who knows what she told him."

"Well, let's hope that's what's going on," Glimmer sighed.

Catra arched an eyebrow.

"Really? That would be a good thing?"

"The alternative would be worse," Glimmer said, just a tad enigmatically, and moved on through the forest.

Catra frowned at the comm pad.

Just a handful of messages from Lonnie, all several hours old.

She had to assume Lonnie, together with 'her boys' and the rest of the unit had been given other orders by now.

And been smart enough to follow them.

Catra really hoped they had been smart enough to follow them.

No answer from her special little Crimson Waste unit.

She had not counted on it. She had tried to get them out of the way, tried to keep them in reserve for when things went south. Now when things had gone south, she just hoped they stayed out of the heat.

She should be with them. Should try to get back her command. Take out Octavia, rally her own forces, show Lonnie who was still the boss, bring the fight to Hordak. Instead she was sneaking around the Whispering Woods with a sparkle princess. Which, cute as the princess might be, was frankly bonkers.

Well, if Adora gets to run away with a princess, so can I.

Adora...

Now, there was a thought to sour her mood.

At least Adora had ran away from Glimmer as well now, and for a big, spiteful part of Catra's heart, that made it feel better.

Spite.

Catra smirked in the darkness.

Yes.

They had tried to get rid of her again. Tried to use her as a prop. Again.

Well, they had not got rid of her. They would learn that the hard way when she returned to fuck up their shit. All their carefully laid, 'oh so important' plans crushed by one angry feline with nothing left to loose.

Catra liked that part. Especially since she wasn't doing it alone this time around.

And this time, she would not just put Shadow Weaver in a cell she could worm herself out of.

She might see Catra coming for her. She would not see her and the princess ganging up.

Time to pay the witch back. With interest.

She sneaked a little bit closer Glimmer and, on impulse, took her hand. The princess gave her a surprised look but didn't pull her hand back.

Catra really liked this part.

They moved on through the frozen forest. They managed to get quite some distance before they finally reached the edge of the

Whispering Woods. In the far distance they could see the gleaming city of Brightmoon, illuminated by the Moonstone.

It looked paler than usual.

"Something is wrong," Glimmer muttered. She touched her temples. Catra frowned.

"Yeah, I thought we had established that. The entire forest is fucked up."

"No, it's something else," Glimmer said with increasingly worried voice. "It's..."

Her comm pad suddenly beeped. She tore it up and pressed a button to make it stop.

"Queen Glimmer!" General Juliet's panic filled face filled the screen. "The Moonstone. Shadow Weaver has done... something to it."

Castaspella's face suddenly entered the screen.

"She's attuned to it. I've no idea how. We're trying to evacuate, but..."

"Do not return to Brightmoon," General Juliet cut her off. "The city is not safe. Do not return to Brightmoon."

Just the moment before the tablet turned off, it turned to show the Moonstone on its pedestal. It was pitch black and shadows boiled from it, engulfing the surrounding castle grounds.

In the distance, the light from the Moonstone changed. Even from this far away, they saw the shadows boil and churn.

For a moment Glimmer just stared at the empty screen. Then she started to scream, a high pitched, feral scream of pain. She fell to the ground, thrashing around with no control of her movement as purple lighting surrounded her.

She felt Catra's arms around her. The last thing she saw before she gave in to the pain and the darkness was how the shadows that boiled out from the Moonstone reached the surrounding city.

Chapter End Notes

My writing tend to be dialogue focused, but I do feel that last scene is properly cinematic.

Lost

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer shivered from the cold. Her torn prom dress was a poor protection from the damp air in the Fright Zone. She tried fighting against her restraints, but the purple energy from the Black Garnet held her and stopped her from teleporting out. Every time she tried to reach for her power, the purple tendrils of magic blocked her, *hurt* her. She screamed, she thrashed around, she tried again and again to reach for her power, to no avail. All the time she saw Shadow Weaver watch her, attentively, dispassionately from behind her mask.

- - -

No, this was wrong. She escaped that, didn't she? She broke free, she beat Shadow Weaver down, she escaped with Adora and... Catra had let them go? Given them the sword back?

Glimmer felt the biting cold against her skin. She felt Catra's strong shoulders under her as the former Force Captain carried her through the frozen remains of the Whispering Woods.

- - -

Glimmer saw the magic circle take form around Shadow Weaver, under the Moonstone. She saw herself stepping forward. She took Shadow Weaver's hand.

The purple magic clung to her body.

Her eyes lingered on the scene even after the group of princesses (including herself) disappeared together with Shadow Weaver and the princesses. She saw her mother come flying as fast as she could, but still far too late.

Far too late.

- - -

Sounds of an engine. Some sort of Horde vehicle? She was roughly thrown to the ground and heard rather than saw a quick struggle taking place. Then Catra was there again, lifted her with strong arms and threw her in the back of the one-person vehicle. There was blood on the seat, just next to her. Catra started the engine and they rushed through the woods, dodging trees and energy blasts.

Glimmer felt the pain pulse through her body with every heart beat.

- - -

"I can't believe you trust *Shadow Weaver* of all people!" Adora cried.

"I don't *trust* her," Glimmer protested. "I just thought that you would trust *me*."

"Of course we trust you," Bow pleaded. "But you need to let us help you. We're your friends, Glimmer. Trust *us*"

'Trust *me*,' Shadow Weaver had said, voice smooth and dark.

Glimmer had taken her hand. Purple magic trailing up along her arm.

- - -

They were in an abandoned building, Glimmer did not know where. She was under a bed, propped in blankets and old rags. Catra had hid her as well as she could and now tried to remove every trace they had left around the building. Outside she heard footsteps from the Horde soldiers that were looking for them. Pain surged through her body and she bit hard in the old leather pouch Catra had propped in her mouth to stop her from screaming.

Catra's worried face filled her vision.

"Just keep it together a little longer, Sparkles," she hissed. "I'll get us out of here, but you have to be silent so they don't find us."

Glimmer indulged her as well as she could, despite the pain that had embedded itself in the very core of her being. Why not? Doing so was easier than not to, and she couldn't deny there was something romantic in just leaving everything behind and running away with a cute catgirl - enemy or not.

It was just a distraction, however, a fleeting flight of fancy to divert her from the horrible, overwhelming truth - a truth that hurt much more than any magic ever could.

She had nothing to return to. Nothing back home to defend. No fallback plan to enact.

She had left her friends stranded, her allies defenceless, her kingdom in the hands of an adversary she herself had invited.

Glimmer had lost.

Chapter End Notes

> This concludes act one of our thrilling adventure. Now we will take a few weeks rest before we dive into the next act of our tale that will start updating in October: *Queens of No Land.*
>
> In the meantime, check out this tumblr exclusive interview with the cast :-)
> http://baggebythesea.tumblr.com/post/660099971365863424/behind-the-scenes-interview-with-the-cast

Act Two - Queens of No Land

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The light in the theater dims, a single spot remains on the stage. Double Trouble enters from behind the curtain, a smarmy smirk on their lips.

"Welcome back, welcome back," they drawl. "I hope you are all properly 'refreshed'."

Somehow they manage to make the last word sound much more dirty than it should.

"We are now about to begin our second act of our epic drama." They let their gaze travel over the audience.

"As I'm sure you remember, we left our girls in quite a predicament." They chuckle. "No thrones, no allies, no friends, no magic... surrounded by enemies on all fronts, cast out, wounded, beaten and on the run."

Their smile grows wider.

"But at least they have each other."

Their expression grows serious. They take a few steps forward, to the very edge of the state.

"No, but seriously," they say. "What can two women on the run really hope to achieve against foes that have them so thoroughly beaten? What do Hordak and Shadow Weaver have to fear at this point, when their victory seem almost complete?"

Their face split up in a toothy grin again.

"The answer, of course, is *everything*."

Their voice is suddenly smooth as honey.

"It would be a fool indeed, to bet against the power of love."

They hold the silence for a few moments, then they suddenly take an acrobatic jump backwards to the middle of the stage.

"So without further ado - let us open the curtain for act two: Queens of No Land!"

They hold up their hand in a dramatic gesture, and the curtain rises.

Double trouble leers at the audience.

"And mercy to the poor souls that will stand in their way as Glimmer and Catra claw their way back."

They slink off the stage as the light turns on, revealing the set designed to look like a market square with stalls, tables and extras milling around. Horde flags decorate the scene. A hooded figure enters the stage and deftly takes an apple from a stall.

Chapter End Notes

Aaaaaand we're back.

No Home Girls

Chapter Notes

> Warning: Some pretty disturbing body horror, panic attacks and what can be seen as analogues to eating disorder or self harm behaviour in this chapter. It's about Glimmer's relationship to her magic, so there is no direct description of real-life disorders, but the imagery is there.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The crowd moved carefully through the streets. Shopkeepers kept shop, bakers baked and everyone went through their business of the day. You could almost imagine this to be just another day in another little peaceful village - at least until you took in the hungry and desperate faces of the many refugee that aimlessly milled on the streets and saw the Horde flag flying over the main square.

A small figure in a cloak moved gracefully between the market stalls. She ducked under an arm here, stepped to the side to avoid a crowd there. If she happened to push into some other shopper at one point - who could blame her? And if someone would later happen to find a purse missing or a newly bought piece of bread being misplaced from their bag - well, desperate times breeds lots of thieves. No reason to put blame any particular direction.

After having listened to the gossip and news of the Horde soldiers and the refugees for a while, the figure moved away from the village centre. She moved in an leisurely pace, until she suddenly ducked between two houses and ran through a narrow alleyway, out on the other side, through a storage house and out into the fields outside the village where she crouched into a ditch and ran on all fours until she was satisfied no one has followed her.

Eventually she found her way to an old, abandoned shed. She checked the door and grunted in satisfaction once she was sure it

hadn't been tampered with.

Catra pulled off the cloak and stepped in.

"Breakfast, Sparkles!" she said with carefree voice and closed the door behind her. Then she stopped and narrowed her eyes.

There was no light source in the shed, and most of the light that filtered in from outside was absorbed on the way. The inside of the shed was heavy with shadows.

Glimmer was not on the pile of sacks they used as a makeshift bed. Catra swept her eyes over the little room. The pile of planks, part of some old harvesting equipment, the crates in the corner...

For a moment she felt like wanting to bolt, or pretend she hadn't seen. Weakness was not encouraged in the Horde after all.

But... if she didn't help? Then who? It wasn't like Scorpia was around to take care of all those icky-sticky friendship things any longer.

Also, she was not in the Horde any longer.

Catra sighed and dropped the bundle of 'liberated' items on the ground. She carefully stepped up to the crates. She moved slowly, deliberately and held her hands in front of her, palms up, in what she hoped was a pacifying gesture.

She had been just a kitten, scared of the dark. Even then, she had been good at finding those little corners, those little hideouts where you had the security of a wall against your back to give you at least the illusion of protection against the shadows.

Adora had came to her then, slowly creeping forward, much like Catra tried to emulate now, hands in front of her and her soft worried face whispering comforting nonsense.

"It's OK, Sparkles," Catra whispered, faking confidence. "I'm here. It's just the two of us here."

Adora had approached her slowly, made sure not to block the only way out if Catra felt the need to bolt. Moving too quickly was a sure way for her to be scratched, as both of them knew by now.

"Sparkles," Catra whispered, slowly inching forward, making sure to leave a path for Glimmer to scramble away if she felt the need. "It's me, Catra. I'm right here. I'm back from town. Only the two of us here, OK?"

Adora had finally worked up the courage to touch her, and after a tense moment Catra let her. She didn't scratch, she didn't bolt. She allowed Adora to hug her. After all these years Catra still remembered Adora's warm little body against her in the darkness, how in the sea of fear and shadows there still was one thing she could cling to. One thing that had made it all possible to endure.

"Sparkles?" Catra whispered. "I'm reaching out my hand now, OK? I will touch your arm. It's OK, it's just me."

She didn't know if Glimmer had heard her. The princess was curled up in the corner, making herself as small as possible. Her entire body shivered and she forced herself to keep her sobs as silent as she could. Her blank eyes stared unseeing at whatever shadows danced in front of them. When Catra touched her she bit down on a scream and recoiled as far as she could among the crates.

Catra bit her lip in frustration. She was not good at this. This was a job for Adora, or Scorpia. Not Catra. She could hurt things, that was about it.

Problem was, Glimmer had plenty of hurt already.

"Sparkles!" she whispered, a bit more loudly. "It's me, Catra. "I'm here. I brought food. All right?"

Glimmer didn't answer, but at least she didn't keep scrambling away.

OK.

So...

She could work with this.

Catra took a deep breath.

"If you tease me about this, I'm breaking your arm, just so you know," she muttered.

Then she started to sing.

Catra's voice was low but rich. Singing was one of those skills not encouraged in the Horde, but to her own great surprise Catra had realized she was good at it, those few times opportunity had presented itself. Her range was narrow but her notes clear and unwavering. She sang a silly little bedtime song about scorpion fairies she had overheard Scorpia sing a few times back when they were the 'Super Pal Trio' (before she had betrayed the other two). She didn't remember all the words, but she inserted her own, and when the song was over she looped back from the beginning.

She sang it five times, to her own great surprise feeling more relaxed then she had for a long time, despite her worry for Glimmer. She took her time, slowed down the tempo slightly for each time and in the end let the final note die out in the dim gloom of the shed.

Then she felt a trembling hand on her arm.

She looked up and saw Glimmer staring at her with eyes full of tears, but properly focusing this time.

"Come here," Catra said and held out her arms. Glimmer thankfully plopped down in them and buried her face against Catra's chest. Catra sat with her back against a corner of a crate and suspected it would be seriously painful after awhile, but she told her body to respectfully shut up and take it. She was not about to shift away from Sparkles now.

Glimmer cried. Erratically at first, but in time, as she got her breathing under control there were proper tears and proper sobs. Catra held her in silence, only muttering some words of comforting nonsense now and then and patting Glimmer on the back.

Eventually, Glimmer peaked up at Catra and gave her an almost shy look.

"Thanks," she mumbled and sat up. Catra took the opportunity to stretch and move muscles that had started to cramp.

"Don't worry about it," she said.

"It was worse this time," Glimmer said with low voice. "It was not only pain this time. There were fear... so much of it. Like, being trapped in a nightmare with no way of waking up. The shadows..."

"Yeah, yeah, I know." Catra interrupted. "Shadow Weaver likes her little tricks. You're awake now, so that's OK."

Glimmer took a deep breath and sat up more properly.

"So, this is what 'OK' feels like, is it?"

"This is what *alive* feels like," Catra grumbled, partly to hide her relief that Glimmer was back to herself again. "Which is more than you would feel if I hadn't dragged your useless royal ass all the way here from Brightmoon."

"Yeah, such a bummer *someone* decided to invade *my* city, isn't it?" Glimmer shot back.

They glared at each other.

After a moment, both of them looked away.

"Did you find something to eat?" Glimmer asked after a moment.

"Sure," Catra answered with a somewhat sharp voice. "Do the princess wish for honey dipped croutons with whipped cream?"

Glimmer rolled her eyes.

"You think I'm completely useless, do you?"

Catra barred her teeth.

"Do you really want me to answer that question?"

"Get over here and I'll show you who's useless," Glimmer hissed. Catra laughed, feeling much better at the princess' sign of aggression.

"Well, if the princess feel like roughing it like us common folks, I do have bread and I do have a piece of pie and if you are really good you can even have" -she put her hand in the sack and held it there a moment for suspense- "An *apple*." She held up the slightly lumpy fruit for inspection. Glimmer gasped in mock excitement.

"Surely you don't expect me to eat an apple without my proper embodied napkin?"

"Suit yourself," Catra shrugged and took a bite of the apple herself. Glimmer gave her a look of such hurt and betrayal that Catra had to laugh. She tossed Glimmer the apple, and Glimmer caught it deftly.

"You're sure no one saw you?" Glimmer asked. Catra gave her a smug grin.

"These bozos? Come on. They don't exactly put the brain trust on pacifying little villages." Glimmer nodded and settled down with her apple and a piece of bread.

"Where are we anyway?"

Catra shrugged.

"'Three meadows'. Never heard of the place before. We're still going east to hide among the refugees."

"Three meadows..." Glimmer mused. "One of my guards was here once on a harvest festival. She told me there was an acrobat who could balance on a barrel as he juggled bottles."

"No one was juggling now," Catra noted.

Glimmer sighed.

"I suppose not."

"Plenty of refugees from Brightmoon, so it seems a lot of people got out," Catra said. Glimmer nodded with a sad expression.

"The Horde is not really pushing this direction, except for some units holding what they already have, and some strike tropes looking for people like us."

"Always good to be wanted," Glimmer commented with a wry smile. Catra chuckled.

"Seems like Hordak and most of their forces are busy with the remains of the princesses up north. Some say Snow, some say Plumeria. A few think he's preparing to move on Brightmoon again."

"Didn't he already take Brightmoon?" Glimmer asked with a raised eyebrow.

Catra shrugged.

"Shadow Weaver took Brightmoon. She's apparently holding the city herself, without letting in Horde forces. No one knows what the deal is between her and Hordak."

"Could we be so lucky they were to take out each other?" Glimmer mused.

"Doubt it," Catra said. "At least not until they got the rest of the world under control."

Glimmer nodded.

"What about Horde Prime?" she asked.

Catra made a show of looking upwards.

"Not here yet," she simply said.

Glimmer frowned thoughtfully.

"What's keeping him?"

"Dunno," Catra shrugged. "Maybe punching a hole from the outside is harder than when Entrapta did it from the inside. Maybe he's dragging his feet. Maybe Hordak isn't such a big deal for Horde Prime as he made it out to be, after all."

"Maybe Hordak lied to you," Glimmer gently suggested. "Maybe he lied to everyone about Horde Prime."

Catra did a little noncommitting gesture.

"It's possible, I suppose, but I can't really figure out why. *He* sure seemed to believe we were on a deadline to take the world before space-dad showed up to score his effort."

"Well, he's not here yet, so at least that's something," Glimmer concluded.

Catra nodded.

They ate their bread. Catra had 'found' some strong, gingery drink to wash it down with.

"I don't suppose..." Glimmer begun tentatively. Catra shook her head.

"No one has heard anything about She-Ra, or Adora, or Scorpia, or Entrapta - or about your precious boy for that matter. It's like they are swallowed by the sea."

"No one returns from Beast Island," Glimmer recited darkly.

Catra gave Glimmer a thoughtful look.

"You really think Shadow Weaver got her?"

"I don't know," Glimmer sighed. "From what I hear that place is dangerous all in itself, and it's not like Mara's spaceship held together well anyway. Anything could have happened."

"Well, whatever the reason, people are getting pretty resigned out there," Catra said. The Horde is taking over, no shiny hero, no princess alliance - sorry, Sparkles. As far as people are concerned, Hordak has won."

Glimmer took a big bite of the bread so she didn't have to answer.

"What's the plan?" she said eventually.

"Wait until it's dark, then we move on," Catra answered. "We can probably stick to settled areas for now where it's easier to get food and blend into the crowd."

Glimmer made a face as a bolt of pain soared through her.

"Sounds good to me. I'll try to get some sleep until then."

She laid down on the sacks and pulled an old soldier's coat over her for warmth. She breathed in and out a few times to get the pain under control. Catra leaned back against the wall, preparing herself to wait.

"Hey, Catra," Glimmer whispered after a moment. "Thanks again for lugging my useless royal ass around."

"Doesn't really seem to be anyone else signing up for the job," Catra answered, a bit of a barb to her voice. "Hey, what happened to that famous princess friendship thing? I don't see them around to lend a hand."

"Why don't you ask Scorpia, Horde Scum" Glimmer shot back. "She sure was eager to leave the Fright Zone to learn about it."

They glared at each other for a moment, but after a week on the roads, their insults started to loose their sting.

"Whatever," Catra muttered. "I'm between jobs. It's not like I have anything better to do right now. Just don't get any ideas. It's not like I like you or anything," she quickly amended.

"Don't worry about it," Glimmer growled. "I don't like you either. But I *am* happy to be your fallback project," she added, her tone light but the meaning sincere. "And I'm glad for your company. Being an exile seems like it would be boring on my own."

"Can't have your life be *boring* now, can we?" Catra leered. Glimmer chuckled.

She put her head down again. Catra leaned back against the wall, prepared to wait for the evening.

"Catra...?" Glimmer whispered a moment later.

"Yeah?"

"Sing me a lullaby?"

"Shut up, Sparkles."

Glimmer laughed and pulled the sack over her head.

- - -

They waited until night until Catra carefully peaked outside the shed.

"No clouds tonight, so there's a change. Three moons out, two of them full," she muttered. "It will be a bit more light than I would have preferred, but it will have to do.

Glimmer gave the night sky a worried glance and wrapped the hood tighter around her head. Catra took a few steps out from the shed and sniffed in the air.

"All right, Sparkles. I think the coast is clear, let's..."

She was interrupted by a primal cry of pain and fear. Catra spun around.

Glimmer was screaming and clawing and her face. From ever orifice - eyes, nose, mouth, ears - light poured.

Catra stared at her in horror. Glimmer sunk to her knees and tried to force eyes and mouth closed, but the light just kept coming.

"What's happening, Sparkles?" Catra cried and rushed forward. The light stung, but she had endured much worse.

"Moons!" Glimmer spat out between gritted teeth. "Channel the Moonstone. My powers recharge."

"That should be a good thing, right?" Catra asked, desperately trying to keep the spasming Glimmer from bashing her head against the ground.

"She's done *something* to my..." -Glimmer had to force her mouth shut to keep down another scream- "to my connection to the Moonstone."

Catra didn't have to ask who 'she' was.

"What do I do, Sparkles? *What do I do?*".

"Away... from the light," Glimmer hissed, and then her face contorted in another spasm and she let out a long, guttural scream.

Catra managed to get a grip of her and dragged her into the shed again and slammed the door. Glimmer stood on all fours, vomiting out her entire stomach content mixed with glittering light. Her very skin was emitting sparks.

"Now what?" Catra cried in panic.

Glimmer tried to answer, but as she opened her mouth she started to gag and tried to vomit again. This time only a small trickle of light emerged from her mouth.

"We can't stay here," Catra yelled. "Even if no one saw your light show, every magic detector in this sector will have picked it up."

"I'll be..." Glimmer began, but whatever she would be she didn't have a chance to say it before her entire body convulsed and she screamed again, a primal sound of pain and fear. She started clawing at her eyes as more light emerged. Catra dashed forward and managed to her hands away. She stared at Glimmer in helpless desperation.

"I'm actually sorry about this," Catra whispered. Then her hands crashed down on Glimmer's head. Hard. Glimmer fell down in a dark and mercifully pain-free abyss and promptly lost her consciousness.

- - -

When Glimmer woke up again, they were in a hunters cabin in the Whispering Woods. Catra never told her the details of how they got there, but her fur was singed as if from a laser shot.

She hurt. Her entire body ached, her throat was raw and her eyes felt like they were too large for their sockets.

"You're still glowing," Catra pointed out. "Not as much as before, though."

"Magic is still leaking in, so I need to get rid of it," Glimmer muttered. "Not as much as in moonlight, but I'm still absorbing

the magic of the world."

"What happened back there?" Catra exclaimed.

Glimmer made a grimace of pain.

"My magic. It's... tainted, somehow."

Catra gave her a very careful look.

"It's like..." -Glimmer fumbled for words- "like eating something that makes you sick. You can tolerate some of it, but when it becomes too much..."

Catra nodded grimly.

"And the moons are... what? Force feeding you?"

"Yeah," Glimmer sighed. "It's not like I can stop absorbing the magic of the world. Also, she tricked me doing a spell to increase my sensitivity to it. The moons are connected to the moonstone, just as I am. It's not as bad as the real thing would be, but..."

Catra gave her a downright pitying look.

"And she's piggybacking on the signal?"

"And she's piggybacking on the signal," Glimmer said. "I'm getting better at blocking her, but she's out there, at the edge of my consciousness."

"Being an elemental princess is just an endless bundle of fun, isn't it?" Catra said, trying to keep her voice dry to hide how worried she was.

"You don't know the half of it," Glimmer said. She caught Catra's gaze. "Thanks for getting me out of there."

"If poisoning the well for you is part of *her* plans, I don't mind making it harder for her."

They traded a look.

"For spite," Glimmer said and managed a faint smile.

"For spite," Catra echoed with a smirk that almost reached her eyes.

Catra handed Glimmer a mug of water and Glimmer eagerly drank. Catra handed her a piece of ration bar.

"See if you can keep anything down this time," she said. "You'll need the strength."

Glimmer nodded. She made a face when she tasted the foul bar, but didn't complain.

"Will that happen every time you walk out at night?" Catra asked with low voice. Glimmer shook her head.

"Full moons is the worst. If it's cloudy I should be OK." she took another gulp of water. "Also, I had let the magic build up. If I expel it a little all the time it will not overflow like that."

Glimmer took a deep breath, and as she breathed out, sparkles surrounded her in a quickly dispersing cloud.

She shuddered.

"Hurts, does it?" Catra asked. Glimmer glanced at her and nodded.

"Not as much as my pride," she muttered, trying to take the edge of things. "She got me, Catra. I gave her this whole speech on how I was onto her and wouldn't fall for her tricks, and she just smiled and nodded and stabbed me in the back, all in one fluent motion."

Catra sighed.

"She does that. Did she ever tell you how she escaped the Fright Zone?" Glimmer raised a curious eyebrow. Catra chuckled and moved up to the bunk.

"Scoot over, Sparkles, and I'll tell you. You might get a kick out of it. If nothing else, misery likes company, right?"

The slight stress on the 'right' was not lost on Glimmer.

The bunk was small and there was not much space for both of them. In the end it was easiest for Catra to sit on one end and Glimmer to put her head in her lap.

To the surprise of both of them, neither of them felt the need to protest the intimacy. It felt like the most natural thing in the world, Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon resting her head in the lap of Force Commander Catra of the Horde.

No, actually, they were not those things any longer.

They were just Catra and Glimmer. It was just the two of them in this old cabin, and right here, right now, none of that other stuff mattered. The war, the hurt, the fight, the betrayals... they were just Glimmer, with her head in Catra's lap, and Catra, with her hand idly playing with Glimmer's hair while she talked in slow, low voice.

She told her about her cocky she had been after throwing Shadow Weaver in a cell, how she had kept coming back to gloat, but how before she knew it Shadow Weaver had wormed her way back into her mind.

"Yeah, she did the same to me," Glimmer muttered. "Not that I made it hard for her. Finally someone paying attention, someone believing in me."

"I know, right!" Catra sighed. "I was practically skipping to her cell that last time, 'Oooh, look at me mommy, have I made you proud?'" She laughed, a strained laugh, and Glimmer hesitantly joined in.

Catra made a sudden face like she had bitten in something sour. "And then I found out she was gone. She just used me."

"Yeah, like you said, that's what she does," Glimmer answered. She closed her eyes a moment as another surge of pain exploded through her nerves.

Catra sighed. She did a little 'things are what they are' gesture and Glimmer nodded.

She got it.

Glimmer didn't move her head from Catra's lap.

Catra went on talking. She talked about... a lot of things. About life in the Fright Zone. About the drills, the routines, the mess hall, about the squads, about friends. Glimmer listened without comment, just glad to have something to focus on to distract her from the turmoil in the very essence of her soul.

Catra talked about Scorpia, about Adora. To her own big surprise, she could do so without bitterness. The hurt was still there. The regret. The abysmal existential loneliness... but for whatever reason even the reminder of Adora's betrayal, of Scorpia's parting message, of Catra being the *bad friend*, lost some of it's sting when she was with Glimmer.

As Catra talked, she felt like the life she talked about wasn't her own. It was some other poor, lonely woman who was stuck in the Fright Zone and really should get her shit together while Catra herself was here, on the run and on the roads and free to go wherever she pleased with her plucky sparkle princess. She could explore that other woman's life, talk about it, but it didn't have to impact herself any longer.

So she talked. Long after Glimmer dosed off again, Catra sat there, muttering and chuckling and crying for herself, stories and anecdotes and observations and insider jokes she had not had anyone to tell since Adora left. Say what you will about the princess, this one was good company. Catra was honest enough

with herself to admit that she would miss her. Still no, reason she couldn't enjoy it while it lasted.

Whatever 'it' was.

When Glimmer finally woke up it was night again. She felt Catra pressed against her in the small bunk, sleeping more heavily than Glimmer had ever seen the feline do in their short time together. She smiled, a fond smile. So far she had Catra just where she needed her. She just hoped it would last. It was a strange feeling to depend on a woman who in many ways was still technically her enemy, but in other ways it felt just right.

Carefully she extracted herself. She managed to slip out of the bed without waking the other woman.

She stood up and stretched cramped muscles. She glanced at her skin. The glow had died down. Still, she was in the Whispering Woods and the level of background magic was high. She felt it trickling into her. An ever present, unstoppable rill. Not strong but persistent.

Dripping water hollows out stone, not through force but through persistence.

It was something Castaspella had said once.

Well, Glimmer was not known to be anything but persistent.

She took a few steps away from the bunk - about as far as the small hut allowed - and took a deep breath.

She exhaled and at the same time expelled a cloud of glittering magic.

She repeated the process, again and again, emptying herself of elemental force that threatened to build up in her body. She gathered a ball of lighting in her hand and packed it like you might a snowball. When it was dense enough for her liking she

grounded it into the earth, were it glowed for a few moments before it died down.

Glimmer gritted her teeth. The emptier she made herself, the more eager was the magic that surrounded her to flood back in. She tried to hold back, but that only worked for so long, and in the meantime it *hurt*.

Fine.

Unbidden, images flashed before Glimmer's eyes. Salineas. Brightmoon. Desperate people begging for her help. Help she hadn't given them.

Because she had not been strong enough.

She gritted her teeth.

She would not fail them again.

Glimmer took off her clothes. They were in a sorry state, sweat and grime and blood and vomit all mixing into a smell that Catra had been polite enough not to comment on, but that Glimmer was sure was not the usual lavender shampoo people had come to associate with the Queen of Brightmoon.

She did one more effort to push out the magic that had gathered, her entire body starting to glow. Catra whined a little in her sleep, but didn't wake up.

The magic rushed back in.

Glimmer expelled it again, with the same result.

Fine.

Gritting her teeth, she opened the door and naked stepped out in the moonlight.

The magic hit her like a hammer. She forced it out, her entire body glowing like a miniature sun. The magic flowed back in. She screamed and feel to her knees, forcing the magic out. Her hands formed a beam wide as a tree-trunk that scorched the vegetation around her. She barely registered as she started to vomit again, the few pieces of ration bar she had managed to swallow mixed with bile and glittery slime.

The moons shone bright.

Glimmer screamed and forced the magic out.

Catra rushed up to her.

"What are you doing, Sparkles," she cried in panic. She threw a blanket on the naked woman and started to drag her into the cabin again.

Glimmer screamed in pain and rage and frustration and vomited out another glob of sparkles. Her eyes and ears and nose emitted floods of light.

Catra managed to get her inside and closed the door.

"What are you trying to do?" she screamed? "Get yourself killed?"

"I'm trying to get my *magic* back," Glimmer snarled. She shuddered and started vomiting again.

"OK, I get it," Catra yelled. "The witch took something from you. Something of yourself. We'll figure it out, but not like this."

"I'm *fine* Glimmer said between gritted teeth, forcing even more magic out through her hands, leaving burnt marks on the floor.

"Glad to hear it," Catra snarled back, "because that little stunt cost us our hideout. She threw a thick cloak with a hood at Glimmer. "Get dressed princess, and get ready to *run*."

- - -

It had been a few days. Glimmer's pain came and went but never completely disappeared. Catra was truly sorry for her, which was a very strange situation for both of them.

"I know what it's like to be in the receiving end of *her* attention," she muttered as explanation.

One evening it was extra bad, with Glimmer crying and trashing around. It was not just pain any longer. It was fear. It was shame. It was dark voices whispering on the edge of her consciousness. Magic poured into her like golden metal into a mold, and she expelled it through every orifice as well as she could.

Please, please, she begged Catra to knock her unconscious again, even if both of them were starting to worry about lasting damage.

"OK...." Catra seemed to talk herself into something. "OK, I'm really sorry about this, Sparkles, but it kind of worked sometimes with me and Adora and I... um..."

And then she kissed Glimmer.

It wasn't that impressive as kisses go, but the pure shock of it crashed into Glimmer like a meteor and made her completely forget everything about magic or pain or shame or evil witches. Catra let go and took a step back.

"Sorry," she babbled. "I just didn't know what to do, and I thought it might help and I wanted you to..."

"Again," Glimmer interrupted.

Catra looked at her with big eyes.

"*Again*," Glimmer pleaded with glittering tears in her eyes.

Catra needed no further encouragement.

Chapter End Notes

There was only one bunk!

Bad Friends together

Chapter Notes

> Warning: Hardship and violence. More 'fun' with Glimmer's magic, which can be read as analogues to eating disorder or self harm behaviour.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

What was she doing?

Horde commander Catra, second in command only to Hordak, poised and ready to push him aside and take over the Horde, currently on the run, on the back roads, playing nurse to a defect princess?

Catra had learnt the hard way that introspection was a fools game, but she still felt the situation warranted a few pointed questions.

She should not be here.

She had taken a beating, sure. She had lost the rush to Brightmoon. But thanks to Shadow Weaver, that was most likely to be considered a draw anyway. So what? She had been down before. She could come back. She *should* come back. Sneak back to the Fright Zone, find a way to Hordak's sanctum, take him out once and for all. Head on a pike, gloat over his beaten body, all the fun stuff.

Then it would be only her on that throne.

She would have shown them.

Only...

OK, time for honesty. She had been absolutely miserable these last few months, and it had been far worse since Scorpia left.

Was she really that eager to get back to all that?

Sure, without Hordak she would be the top dog... cat... whatever. But she still would have to deal with people like Octavia and Lonnie giving her lip and looking for an opening. She *could* do it, sure. But - when it really came down to it - did she really *want* to?

Was the Horde really worth that to her?

Because - and this was the strange thing, this was the completely *baffling* thing - Catra wasn't miserable now. She had fun bantering with Glimmer, avoiding patrols and living on what they could steal. It was like an extended field exercise, only without anyone telling her what they should or shouldn't do, and without having to worry about what would happen once they got back to the Fright Zone.

Because Catra didn't have to go back to the Fright Zone.

She looked at that thought again, examined it from different angles, smelled it, tasted it.

She didn't have to go back.

She didn't have to go back.

It was as strange as it was liberating.

And then there was the princess...

Catra smiled.

Sparkles was completely insufferable, sure, but they had fun together. She could take what Catra dished out and pay her back with the same coin. It was the same rush Catra had felt fighting her. Turns out, a few barbed comments could serve just as well as claws or sparks. And it was not only the fighting and the bantering. It was also the... vulnerability.

Catra shook her head. This *really* didn't make any sense.

Taking care of Glimmer, taking care of someone who absolutely, desperately *needed* her, completely depended on her... it was something she had never experienced before. Glimmer slowed her down. Glimmer held her back, but still, ever time she saw the princess crawled up in a corner, fighting off whatever nasty thoughts Shadow Weaver sent her way, whenever she gave Catra that soppy look she usually did, there was something moving in Catra's chest. Something warm. Something she never had knew existed, and she never knew she wanted.

She idly wondered if being an idiot was contagious. That would certainly explain some things.

"If I wanted a pet, maybe I should have started with something more low maintenance than a princess," she muttered for herself, and then she smirked at the mental images *that* train of thought led to.

And then there was that kiss...

Catra shook her head. Just the needs of the moment, just a way to shock Glimmer out of her current attack. Nothing more (however much like glitter she tasted). Nothing to keep thinking about.

Catra kept thinking about it.

The thing was... the thing Catra kept coming back to, was that this couldn't last. Playing house with the princess was fun and all, but it was only a matter of time before things got not-fun.

She really should ditch the princess before then.

Catra slipped back down into the hut and just stared.

"Breakfast, Kitten?"

Instead of the sleeping Glimmer she had expected or the panicky Glimmer she had feared, she was greeted by... breakfast?

Most of it was based on ration bars and water from their canteens, but given everything that Glimmer had done with it - sprinkles, berries, cute shapes, dainty little stone plates - the first impression was of some sort of fancy-pansy princess picknick (granted, Catra based that impression mostly on heresy and memories from Princess Prom) rather than a desperate meal for fugitives scrounged together of what was at hand.

Glimmer beamed at her, all smug and proud and just a teensy bit anxious for Catra's reaction and - glowing.

For some reason, it didn't look as horrific as before. Light emitting from her skin suited her.

"Look!" Glimmer said, pointing at a metal implement obvious crafted from scrap metal. "I even made you a special crouton fork.

"Well, well, princess," Catra drawled. "Seems like someone is finally remember their etiquette. I assume there will be embroidered napkins?"

Glimmer's proud smile widened.

"*Of course* there are embroidered napkins."

She presented two large leaves, cut into heart patterns and with some red flowers stuck into them.

"You seem to have performed up to code," Catra admitted. She slipped closer to Glimmer, who slipped closer to her, and suddenly they were *very* close.

"Do you really think so," Glimmer whispered, her warm lips very close to Catra's, her bright eyes shining from within.

"Errrhm, yeah. Thanks," Catra said, suddenly unsure what to do with herself.

- - -

There were many refugees on the road, most of which with good reasons to avoid the Horde, so two women in cloaks travelling together was nothing out of the ordinary. Even so, they made a point of avoiding larger groups and get out of the way anytime Catra anticipated Horde patrols or checkpoints. Most of the time, she was right.

Glimmer trudged on as well as she could. She traded a few quips with Catra in the beginning of the day, but the longer they walked, the more monotone her answers got. The good morning mood was soon gone, and eventually all her focus went to put one foot in front of the other.

Catra tried to carry her backpack for her, but Glimmer snarled at her in a way Catra would have found almost comically familiar if the circumstances hadn't been so dire.

Eventually Catra turned to a side-path and walked up towards the woods. Glimmer followed her without comments. They found a glade far enough from the road and sat down to share a ration bar and the last of the water they had in their canteen.

Glimmer found a flat surface of ground and did a quick magic circle around her. It started to glow.

"Not as much magic during the day," she muttered as answer to Catra's raised eyebrow, "but it's still worth getting as much of it as possible out of my system. The less I build up, the less the risk will be for overload."

Catra took a bite of her half of the ration bar and frowned thoughtfully.

"Most of the refugees are heading east, following the forest edge," she mused. "We could probably stick with them for a while longer if we like..."

"Or?" Glimmer filled in, making a small gesture to force magic into the circle.

Catra shrugged.

"Or south, I suppose. Crimson Waste. Huge on that whole 'avoiding the Horde' thing."

"I like the sound of it already," Glimmer sad with the voice of someone waiting for the other shoe to drop. Catra sighed. Not much use delaying the inevitable row.

"Or north," she said without changing her tone of voice. "We've got through the Whispering Woods before, we can do it again. I can't think of a worse place for the Horde to try to find us."

"Why on earth would we want to go north?" Glimmer shot back. Catra sought her eyes.

"To get help," she gently said. Glimmer scoffed.

"Oh yeah? Just waltzing up to the Fright Zone, are we? 'Hey, Hordak, Catra forgot to clean out her locker. Also, could we have some purple ration bars, please?'"

"No," Catra said with level voice. "I was thinking more of Plumeria, or some of the villages. The Horde's there, but if we are careful we can stay under the radar."

"Or we are discovered and have the Horde come knocking at an innocent village just for the crime of us sneaking around there," Glimmer said with the same flat voice hiding a lot of emotions. I'm not exactly a fan of that idea, Catra."

Catra made a little acquiescing gesture.

"Maybe Mystacor? Isn't your aunt some kind of hotshot there?"

"She was in Brightmoon when it fell," Glimmer answered and managed to keep her voice level. "I don't even know if she made it out."

"Yeah, that's a bummer. But they know all about fancy magic, right? They should be able to sort you out."

Glimmer sighed.

"You think Mystacor is safe? From *her?*"

Catra made a frustrated snarl.

"Of course it's not safe. *Here* is not safe. *Nowhere* is safe from Shadow Weaver. But we have to *do* something."

Glimmer shuddered slightly as she expelled a cloud of magic.

"For all we know, Mystacor has fallen by now," she simply said.

"Not as far as the rumour mill has it," Catra countered. "Hordak seem to be busy with the princesses and Shadow Weaver keeps to Brightmoon. Mystacor is as hidden as ever."

"That won't stop Shadow Weaver, and anyway they would still find us on the way there," Glimmer said.

"They'll find us *here*," Catra said in frustration. "Once reports start to filter back they will send the heavy guns."

"They'd have to get past the mighty Catra to get to me," Glimmer said dismissively. Catra caught her eyes.

"Yeah, and eventually they will. You get that, right, Sparkles?"

"Why? It's not like we ever did."

"You held back," Catra said with level voice. "They won't."

Glimmer nodded, conceding the point.

"Still, we'll be much safer on the road than that close to the Fright Zone, that close to Brightmoon."

"Fine," Catra said, "what about Snow, then? Your fellow princesses should be able to help."

"No," Glimmer said with flat voice. Catra gave her a long look.

"Not up for reunion with the princess alliance, are you?"

"No," Glimmer repeated. She made a face. "It's not like they could help anyway. I'm the one who knows magic out of us."

"Well, what do *you* suggest then, oh mighty magician?" Catra gruffed.

Glimmer made a frustrated face.

"I'll just have to get *better*. Better at blocking. Better at controlling." She drew a circle in the air. It glowed for a moment and than faded. "I'm used to work with all the power of the Moonstone. Now I'm back to square one. Worse, because now my magic works against me. But I *can* fix it. I can build from here."

Catra gave her a long, thoughtful look.

"What?" Glimmer snarled.

"I'm just trying to figure out if you sound more like Adora or Shadow Weaver," Catra said matter-of-factly. Glimmer gave her a death glare which Catra ignored.

"Very funny," she muttered.

"I didn't try to be funny," Catra answered. She sighed.

"Believe you me, Sparkles. I get wanting to be self-sufficient. Because in the end of the day, you're all there is on team you. But right now, you need *help*, and I can't give it."

"What do you care anyway," Glimmer shot back. "I thought you didn't *like* me."

"Maybe I don't," Catra hissed back. "Doesn't mean you get to be an idiot about things."

They glared at each other.

Glimmer looked away first.

"I need *time*," she said. Her features softened and she gave Catra a thankful look. "Which you *are* giving me."

She took Catra's hand, after some reluctance, Catra allowed her to hold it. Glimmer starting gently caressing her fingers.

"What I'm going through is scary," she said with soft voice. "For me and for you. I get it Catra. And you want to look after me. That's..."

"Don't say adorable," Catra hissed.

Glimmer smirked.

"That's thoughtful," she said instead.

Catra made a face.

"But the thing is," Glimmer went on, looking Catra in the eyes, "this is a temporary setback. This is me... heaving to learn to get around a disability. You don't expect a soldier with a war wound to be back in the field the day after, do you? You'd give them time to heal, to learn, to work around their problem."

"I'd send them to the medic." Catra said flatly.

"Not many doctors around for what I'm experiencing," Glimmer shot back.

Catra gave her a frustrated look.

"Things are not getting better, Sparkles. They are getting worse."

Catra's tried to keep her voice level, but her eyes betrayed how worried she was.

"I will get through this," Glimmer said, and there was a hint of steel in her voice. Catra did an annoyed gesture, but didn't answer.

Glimmer inhaled. She exhaled a cloud of magic. She shuddered. Catra fidgeted with her claws for a moment.

"I don't suppose... Adora?"

Glimmer gave her a sharp look.

"*What*?"

"She has those weird healing powers, doesn't she? Do you think she could..."

"Adora is not here."

"No shit, Sparkles. I doubt we'd spend our days kissing in a shed every time you were down if she were. But If she could help you, maybe we should..."

"What?" Glimmer demanded. "Steal a boat and go to Beast Island? Flap our wings and fly? Wish really hard for her to come back?"

"Nah," Catra said deadpan. "I've tried that last one, doesn't work. The first one has potential though."

"I thought no one returns from Beast Island," Glimmer said.

"Yeah, because the Horde doesn't want them to," Catra countered. "Doesn't stop us from going there to have a look."

"We can't, the Horde controls the sea now, remember? After Salineas fell?"

The venom in Glimmer's voice was clear. Catra actually looked a bit ashamed at that.

"I think we could run a blockade if we put our mind to it, Sparkles," she carefully said.

Glimmer ejected another cloud of magic, more forceful this time.

"Then we can surely outwith some backwater Force Captains on the road."

"Yeah, we can. But not forever."

"It doesn't have to be forever. Just until..." -Glimmer let out a final cloud of sparks and stood up- "...until I'm better."

Catra gave Glimmer another frustrated look, but she didn't argue.

They sulked in silence for a few moments as Glimmer stretched.

"Got it all out?" Catra asked eventually. "You know they can track that shit."

"Sure," Glimmer said offhandedly. "Let's go, furball. Time to hit the road."

A few minutes later they sneaked through the woods again, on their way to their next hideout. Catra kept stealing worried glances at Glimmer, that Glimmer kept ignoring.

- - -

They were alone on the road for most of the day. Without having discussed it further, they were walking south. This was grazing country and the villages were few and the farms lonely and dispersed. They found water, and even some stunted trees with some ugly pears that were almost ripe.

The sky was cloudy and Glimmer was in better mood. She chatted as they walked and Catra felt less worried than she had for quite

some time.

"...and you wouldn't believe Adora's expression when she realized it was you behind the attack. She was all 'Oh no! My arch nemesis back to taunt me yet again.'"

"She's so easy to rile up it's almost cute," Catra laughed.

"It *is* cute," Glimmer laughed. "She always hoped you would just show up one day and be all 'oh Adora, I've seen the error of my ways, let me join you and we can always be together.'"

They laughed again, a little less carefree this time.

"If I had, things would have been different," Catra noted with the air of someone poking unstable ground with a stick to see if it's going to turn into a sinkhole or not.

"Well, if you had, we wouldn't be out here like this, now would we," Glimmer shot back, with carefree voice. "So it all turned out for the best."

Catra couldn't help laughing at the absurdity of that statement. Glimmer joined her.

"It's OK," she said as she 'happened' to brush up against Catra's arm. "I didn't exactly treat her right either. We are both trash. At least we can be trash together."

As they walked on, a warmth Catra rarely had experienced slowly spread through her chest.

They found a sheep-herder's hut for night, not in use this season. As Catra busied herself with their gear, Glimmer poked around and found them some old blankets that she insisted on forming to what to Catra more than anything looked like a bird's nest.

She hesitated, long enough for Catra to take notice. But then she seemed to make up her mind. She gave Catra a faux-sultry look.

"Come to bed, sweetie," Glimmer said. Catra felt her heart start beating fast.

"Seems like the princess is in a good mood," she commented, stalling for time. Glimmer grinned.

"Whaaaaat? I'm freezing." She faked a shiver. "You'd better come warm me up, Catra."

"I can keep you warm, all right," Catra answered with more bravado than she felt, silently telling herself that she was a tough bully of an alpha cat who in no way would allow herself to be flustered by a pretty princess fluttering her eyelashes at her.

Catra stepped up to bed.

Glimmer caught her eyes, a look in her face that Catra did not quite know what to do with, and without breaking eye-contact, Glimmer started to wriggle out of her dress.

Catra suddenly felt like someone who might be flustered by a pretty princess fluttering her eyelashes at her.

A moment later, the moment was destroyed by the sound of engines. Catra's head snapped up and she grabbed her new stun baton.

"Sparkles, outside, *now*!" she snarled and dove out through the door. The moment later, it exploded as a grenade hit it. Glimmer screamed in pain as she teleported out in the last second.

She materialized just outside the building, and had no sooner got her bearings before she saw two soldiers in Horde gear bear down on her. She managed to get into her dress again and materialize her staff and, forcing the pain away, steady her footing enough to trip the first soldier. The other hit her with a blow from their staff and Glimmer fell to the ground. She rolled away, avoiding a second blow by the width of a hair.

Glimmer summoned a handful of sparkles and threw them in the soldiers face and manage to get to her feet before they had sorted out their vision. The second soldier scrambled to their feet as well, and Glimmer took a deep breath and found her balance, facing them with staff in hand.

In the corner of her eye she saw more soldiers rushing towards them, and Catra furiously clawing at a bot. There were at least three glider bikes circling them.

This was not good.

Catra screamed in rage, finished the bot and dove to the side before one of the soldiers managed to catch her with a net. She scrambled up on the remains of the roof of the hut and from that vantage point got an overview over the area.

She allowed herself a moment to swear.

This was really not good.

She caught sight of the commanding officer and jumped off the roof, the moment before it exploded. If she took out their commander, a badly trained and organized unit might fall to pieces.

However, she seriously doubted that was what they had to deal with.

She got in a swipe at the officer, who sadly turned out to be fully capable of holding her own. Then she had to go on defensive as the officer swiped back with a baton of her own. Her opponent fell back and Catra knew what it meant. She managed to jump out of the way before the expected blast hit the area she had just vacated.

She swore again.

For many reasons.

Right. Around the hut. It wasn't much as protection went, but at least it prevented line of sight. She saw Glimmer in furious struggle against two of the soldiers and decided to register a complaint.

Crashing in with a low kick she took out the first soldier before they had even noticed her, then Glimmer made short work of the other.

They shared a quick, scared look.

"Start running, Sparkles, Catra panted. "I'll keep them busy."

"What? By yourself?" Glimmer protested. Catra grimaced.

"I'll steal a glider or something and come pick you up. Just you wait, it'll be super romantic. Just get running!"

Then she hadn't time to say anything else, as the solders came running around the hut and started circling them. Catra picked one of them at random and, claws and tooth, fought her way out. She could only hope Glimmer had been doing the same, as she now had to defend herself against another bot. With a sinking feeling in her stomach she saw the commanding officer speak in a comm pad, and she knew what that meant.

"SPARKLES!" she yelled. "There'll be more of them. Get *away*."

She jumped the bot, ignoring the blasts that signed her fur, and she started to run as quickly as she could towards the gliders. To her great relief she saw one of them unguarded and driver-less and she ran towards it as fast as she could. She got a headstart, and neither the bot nor the soldiers managed to catch up with her.

It wasn't until the very last minute she realized how very suspicious that was, and with a yelp she changed direction the moment before the ground between her and the glider exploded, showering her in a cloud of dirty and stones. She knew she was running towards the other soldiers but hopefully she could...

That's when a blow as forceful as a piston caught her straight in the chest and she fell backwards. The large bulking shape of a lizard solider stepped up to her through the dust and pinned her to the ground. She desperately tried to force her body to move, despite the air being knocked out of her and the solider raised his fist and...

Time seemed to stand still as Catra felt her mind flash back to countless training sessions in the gym, countless times she had seen those exact movements, those exact muscles at play.

"Rogelio?" she panted.

A grunt was the only answer as the soldier pinned her to the ground.

"Catra's down, focus on the princess!" she heard the commander - heard *Lonnie* cry into the comm pad. "Rogelio, hold her until we've got cuffs on her, you know how slippery she is."

"Don't you dare hurt Glimmer," Catra snarled as she tried in futile frenzy to wriggle out of Rogelio's grip.

"Oh, we won't," Lonnie said in calm, reasonable voice as she stepped out of the cloud of dust, flanked by two bots. "Not as long as you don't give us any trouble, Catra. Otherwise there will be quite a bit of hurt going around."

Catra opened her mouth to answer, to spit back a curse or a wove of defiance. But when it came, it was not in her voice.

"Oh, don't you worry about me," Glimmer's voice said from close by. "You should be much more worried about yourself."

Then the bots exploded.

Magical beams, as bright as the sun, scorched the ground around them. Lonnie swore and threw herself to the side. Rogelio tried to keep a hold of Catra, but she managed to claw herself free. She sprung to her feet, looking widely around.

Then Glimmer was there, light pouring from her eyes, from her hands, from her skin.

"Sorry to break up your little reunion," she said between gritted teeth.

She grabbed Catra and promptly teleported them away.

They emerged not far away, by the other gliders. Glimmer tried to say something, but then the magic got the better of her and she fell to the ground, body spasming.

For a moment, Catra just stared at Glimmer. Then she snapped back in focus. She pointed at one of the glider bikes.

"In there," she cried and jumped into the driver's seat. Glimmer managed to stop vomiting and crawled in on the passenger's seat. Catra fiddled with the controls for a moment, did a neat little bypass that utilized a security flaw she had been really furious with the workshop for not fixing before the final push, and then she and Glimmer tore off over the landscape.

A blaster shot took out part of the side plating of the glider.

She could see Kyle staring after them, aiming for another shot.

"Out of sparks, were you?" she pointedly said.

Glimmer looked away.

"Got any left now?" Catra asked.

Glimmer silently shook her head.

"Then you better grab a rifle and slow down the bikes following us."

Glimmer did so. She was not an accomplished shot, but she had training in hitting moving targets, and it only took a few near hits for the pursuers to start prioritizing their own safety over speed.

Catra had no such limitations.

They rushed through the landscape like a thunderbolt.

All the time Catra swore, riding the rush of adrenaline.

Lonnie.

Hordak had sent *Lonnie* after her.

And she had found them.

That meant a lot of things, and none of them good.

"Catra..." Glimmer tried, but Catra just snarled at her.

Things had just become much more deadly.

- - -

It took them a long, long time to shake off the Horde soldiers following them, but eventually they felt confident parking the glider and continuing on foot. Glimmer shivered and obviously had to dredge up reserves she didn't know she had for each step, but they finally managed to get enough distance from the bike that Catra felt they dared trying to lay low for the night.

They found a dry ditch that served well enough for shelter, at least if your idea of 'shelter' was to be surrounded by dirt but at least somewhat out of sight.

Catra and Glimmer sank down on the ground, neither of them capable of doing much else than just breathing for a long time.

Everything hurt. They were dead tired, and despite all that had happened, magic was *still* leaking from Glimmer's eyes.

Catra threw her a blanket.

"See if you can get some protection from the moons," she muttered.

Glimmer took the blanket and wrapped it around her as well as she could. She gave Catra an almost frightened look.

"Sorry," she whispered.

"Lonnie's smart," Catra growled. "She'll find us again. Not much we can do about it."

"I... you trusted me," Glimmer said with low voice, "And I betrayed you."

Catra turned her head towards Glimmer and watched her with an expression she couldn't read.

"I... didn't rid myself of magic as... completely as I might have said," Glimmer whispered. "That's how they found us, wasn't it?"

Catra said nothing.

"Sorry," Glimmer said again.

"Sparkles," Catra said, voice curiously flat. "Open my backpack."

Glimmer did so, hesitantly looking at Catra who remained leaning against the side of the ditch.

The backpack was full of bits and pieces and things Catra had deemed useful at the time. Glimmer rummaged in it, not immediately understanding what Catra wanted her to see.

"The pad," Catra impatiently said. Glimmer frowned and picked it up. It was slightly larger than the comm pads she was used to and made in Horde standard issue material. She gave Catra a quizzical look and turned it on.

The screen lit up in what Glimmer recognized as a detection grid, centred on the pad. She looked at it a few moments, saw some dots lit up stochastically over the screen, then suddenly a burst right in the centre.

Right where she sat.

She gave Catra a long look.

"After all the shit I gave the workshop about not finishing the magic detectors in time, it seemed rude not to grab one when I had the chance," Catra said with just a hint of a smirk.

"How long have you known?" Glimmer asked with quiet voice.

"That you're hoarding magic?" Catra shrugged. "Pretty much since you started doing it. I didn't think it would be enough for the Horde to track us, not that close to the Whispering Woods, but here we are."

Glimmer kept looking at her, lots of mixing feelings fighting for dominance.

"I thought..."

"Thought what?" Catra spat. "That I would bolt if you hurt my delicate feelings? I'm not Scorpia or Adora, Sparkles. I'm not one of your precious princesses. You don't have to treat me with kid gloves."

Glimmer gave her a thoughtful look but didn't say anything.

"Why do you think I'm sticking with you, Sparkles?" Catra said. "Because I fancy hanging out? Because I like your kisses and hope you'll ask me to princess prom?"

Glimmer raised an eyebrow, and Catra quickly looked away. Glimmer smirked and Catra hurried on.

"I'm sticking with you because you and me are in the same shit," Catra snarled. "Because we're both scrambling up the same hill and because I know what it's like to be in the receiving end of *her* attention." She pressed a finger at Glimmer's forehead.

"Catra..." Glimmer begun, but Catra interrupted her.

"So if you think I'm gonna skip on you because you have a few secrets, think again. *I* have secrets, and I promise you that yours are tame in comparison. It's you and me against the world, Sparkles, and I count on you holding your own. I'm not running away because you are a *bad friend* or whatever."

Catra realized that she had been shouting. Glimmer watched her with an expression that made her decidedly uncomfortable so she decided she'd better cut it short.

But before she had time to leave, Glimmer reached out and took her hand.

Glimmer's hand was warm and soft. For a moment Catra considered tearing herself free but she didn't.

Because of... reasons.

"I'm not leaving you either, Catra," Glimmer said with soft voice, and suddenly it was very important for Catra to look anywhere except at the large, lavender eyes of the princess. "I wouldn't make this without you, you get that, right? I'm not going to poof away and leave you behind one day. You..." she made a frustrated face, trying to find the right words.

"You get it," she landed on. "Get what it takes. What we have to do. Mom didn't. The princesses didn't. Not even after Salineas. Bow didn't. Adora... she kinda got it, but she wished she didn't. With you..." -she grinned- "with you I don't have to find excuses."

"Scorpia and Entrapta didn't get it either, you know," Catra said, her voice finding her strength. "It was like it was a game for them... until it wasn't."

"I won't leave you, Catra," Glimmer said, looking Catra in the eyes. "Even if you are a 'bad friend'. *I'm* a bad friend, so I won't hold it against you."

Catra looked at Glimmer, eyes swimming with emotions.

"We can be bad friends together?" she whispered.

Glimmer held out her arms, and after a moment of hesitation, Catra gave her a hard, unused hug.

"We can be bad friends together," Glimmer affirmed.

Despite hear best efforts, tears trickled down Catra's cheeks.

"Promise?" she asked with small voice.

Glimmer held her hands in a steady grip. She looked her in the eyes again.

"I promise," she said.

And before she knew it, Catra cried like a child in Glimmer's arms.

They hugged for quite some time.

The ditch was hardly a Brightmoon bedroom, but they were weary to the bone and almost as soon as they were lying down, they felt themselves starting to drift towards sleep.

The ditch was narrow and the night was cold. Laying just side by side was perfectly reasonable under the circumstances, to share body heat and...

Yeah.

"Catra..." Glimmer whispered.

"Yeah?" Catra answered.

"Once this is over, once we find our way to whatever is on the other side... can I ask you for something?"

"What?" Catra said, voice wavering slightly.

"Do you want to go to princess prom with me?" Glimmer said with large eyes and vulnerable voice.

For a moment Catra just stared at her, then she saw the smirk lurking in the corner of Glimmer's mouth.

She started to laugh.

Glimmer laughed as well. Pressed against each other they laughed like crazy in their ditch.

"You really think there is an 'other side' to this?" Catra snickered, still with tears in her eyes.

"I don't know," Glimmer answered. "But I intend to find out. With you." She caught Catra's eyes again. "If you let me."

"I said I would, Sparkles," Catra answered.

Hidden from the moons and from the world, from all those that hunted them and meant them harm, they shared a proud, affirming smile.

They would get through this.

They would get back from this.

Together.

And then it would be everyone else that had to hide.

Chapter End Notes

And then it would be everyone else that had to hide.

Piece of cake

Chapter Notes

Warning: Glimmer's magic keeps acting up.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Breakfast, Sparkles!"

Catra opened the door the the abandoned and burnt out horde troop transport vehicle they had made their makeshift shelter this time. Catra was happy to see the princess was in the bunk where she had left her. She was sitting up, doing a breathing exercise, forcing out excess magic. Her face was pained and sparks jumped from her brow, grounding themselves in the frame of the vehicle.

She looked up at Catra and took a deep breath. She forced herself to form a vry smile.

"Strawberries with whipped cream for me, please."

Her voice was only slightly strained.

Catra snorted.

"Better up, princess."

Glimmer opened her eyes wide in faux-excitement.

"What could possibly be better than strawberries?"

Catra tossed a dense, rectangular object to Glimmer.

"Ration bars! The blue kind which is totally the best kind except for purple, and you only get those on the ships."

Glimmer gave the crumbly object in her hand a very doubtful look.

"I suppose they don't come with whipped cream...?"

Catra did a mock sympathetic gesture.

"No luck there."

Glimmer sighed and took a bite from the ration bar. She made a face.

"All I have, Catra went on, putting her hand in her bag again, is *this*."

She pulled out a little glass container. It was still cold to the touch after having been stored in a fridge. There was condensation on the inside of the glass.

In the container was a piece of cake. Creamy and fluffy and sweet and with a dainty little cherry on top.

Glimmer stared at it.

In their current situation it was about as alien an object as if Catra suddenly had presented her with her childhood toy dog Mrs Snuffulus.

Catra placed the container on the bed next to the speechless princess with a smug smile. In utter disbelief Glimmer touched the cold glass.

"No whipped cream, princess," Catra drawled. "I understand if it is far too plebeian for your liking, but this is how we rough it in the field."

Glimmer made a squeaky little noise. Catra smirked at her.

"Everything to your liking, your majesty?"

"You brought me *cake*?" Glimmer whispered still staring at the frosty container without being able to believe her eyes.

"The officers always squirrel away the best stuff for themselves!" Catra said smugly.

"You got it from the Horde camp?" Glimmer gasped. "What if they had seen you?"

"They totally didn't!" Catra smiled, not able to contain her proud grin any longer. "Look, I even got a new toy!" She held up a stun baton.

Glimmer stared at her with open mouth.

"You raided a horde camp, stole from the officer and you brought me *cake*."

"Anything for my princess," Catra laughed with a mocking little bow. Glimmer looked at her with tears in her eyes.

"Catra... that's it... I've never..."

"Don't sweat it Sparkles," Catra laughed. "Your face right now made it totally worth it."

Glimmer made another adorable little sound and sunk back in her blanket. She started to cry softly, tears mingling with sparks of glitter. Catra gave her a worried glance.

"Sparkles? Are you..."

"I'm fine, you dolt," Glimmer whispered for answer. "I just didn't expect... this. Not here. Not from *you*."

"Glad to hear I'm capable of surprising you," Catra drawled. Glimmer laughed, voice still full of tears.

"You truly are, Horde Scum. You truly are."

She carefully lifted the glass cap and took out the cake. She took a little piece of it and put in her mouth. She closed her eyes, and her entire being shuddered.

"Well?" Catra said impatiently. "Was it any good?"

"It's perfect," Glimmer whispered, not opening her eyes. "it's..."

Then, without any warning whatsoever, her entire body convulsed. She dropped the cake to the floor and screamed, cake and glitter spraying out of her mouth. Catra rushed up to her and tried to get a grip of her hands as Glimmer started to claw at her face.

"Sparkles!" she cried. She managed to lower Glimmer to the floor.

Glimmer forced her mouth shut and breathed through her nose. After a few painful moments, she started to relax somewhat. Catra dared to breath out, and let go of Glimmer's hands.

Glimmer kept her eyes shut for another ten or twenty breaths, then she opened them and slowly sat up.

"Sorry about the cake," she said with flat voice.

"Forget the cake," Catra spat. "What about *you*?"

"What about me?" Glimmer said with the same voice, hidden anger lurking beneath the surface. "You can just kiss me and make it better if I act up, can't you?"

"That's not funny!" Catra snarled.

"Does it look like I'm laughing?" Glimmer shot back.

Catra growled and stalked out of the cabin. Glimmer joined her not soon after.

"Sparkles..." Catra begun.

"I'm OK, Catra," Glimmer interrupted, not looking at her. "It's OK. Let's just go."

And without giving Catra time to answer, she quickly started to walk away from their resting place for the night. Catra shot one last, forlorn look at the cake, still lying smashed on the dirty floor. Then she followed Glimmer.

- - -

Catra had made them walk quicker since their confrontation with Lonnie, covering more ground each day. Glimmer felt her feet would kill her, but she did her best not to complain. They kept walking south, towards the Crimson Waste, but they often took detours and changed directions.

"Best keep her guessing," Catra said, and Glimmer didn't comment.

Eventually they got to a village - even if that was a gross overstatement. Just a few houses were two roads met. A few small farms, a well, a trading station/pub/town hall and a horde patrol.

Catra and Glimmer lurked behind a nearby hill, taking turns spying on the soldiers.

"They don't seem to be in a hurry to go anywhere," Glimmer remarked after awhile.

"They have no reason to," Catra remarked. They're in the perfect place to catch people like us trying to get through and to keep an ear out for local gossip."

"So... we walk around them?" Glimmer asked. Catra looked at the flat moorland with a frown.

"Not hard for them to discover us, and then we look really guilty trying to sneak past a patrol."

"So, we try to bluff our way through?"

"We could, but Lonnie has surely told them what to look for by now."

"So, we take them out, and then we have a vehicle?"

"We'll also have told Lonnie exactly where we are."

Glimmer gave her a side-glance.

"She really has you spooked, hasn't she?"

"*Yes*, Sparkles," Catra said with exasperated voice. "She has me spooked. I've known Lonnie since I was a kid. Tough as a nut and smart enough not to brag about how good she was. Would probably have been top of our unit it it hadn't been for Adora, but she was bright enough to know that under Shadow Weaver, it wouldn't go any other way."

Glimmer watched her in thoughtful silence.

"She didn't exactly rise in the ranks the moment Adora left," she commented.

"No she *didn't*," Catra snarled, "because she's *smart*. Things've been pretty crazy there in the Fright Zone these last few years, let me tell you. Me and Scorpia, and then Entrapta, pushing out Shadow Weaver. Entrapta stealing my place under Hordak, me taking her out, me and Hordak circling each other... and all the time there's Lonnie just biding her time. Now Shadow Weaver's gone, Entrapta gone, Scorpia's gone, I'm gone... but Lonnie is still around. If she plays her cards right and sails under the radar of the old hands like Octavia, she'll be Force Commander within a month."

"Well, hooray for Force Commander Lonnie," Glimmer said. "But I don't quite get what that has to do with *us*."

"She has known *me* since I was a kid too," Catra explained between gritted teeth. She knows how I tick, knows how I think, knows when I jab and when I feint."

Glimmer tilted her head slightly.

"So? So does Adora and we always had to run to keep up with you."

Catra rolled her eyes.

"Adora fights fair. Lonnie doesn't. Adora doesn't want to hurt me. Lonnie won't hesitate. Adora fights to *win*. Lonnie fights to take out her opponent."

Glimmer pondered for a moment.

"Yikes," she concluded.

"Yikes, indeed, Sparkles."

Glimmer looked attentively at Catra's face.

"So, you've known her since a kid. You're not an idiot and you apparently don't underestimate her. How do we beat her?"

Catra raised an eyebrow.

"You really have that much fate in me, huh, Sparkles?"

Glimmer shrugged.

"I've fought Lonnie. I've fought you. Lonnie wasn't the one who scared the panties off me."

Catra felt her train of thoughts derail.

"Now... that was a turn of phrase," she mumbled. Glimmer smirked.

"Thought you'd like it. But seriously, Catra. It's not like we try to beat her in the ring or something. We just try to slip past her to hide in the waste. How hard could it be?"

Catra gave her a long look.

"You really had to ask, didn't you?"

"Well, how hard *could* it be? We can slip past the brain-trust down there if we try."

"Of course we can," Catra agreed. "And we may or may not slip up, and we may or may not give Lonnie information enough to figure out our *next* move and set up the *next* ambush. And I promise you, the next one will be harder."

"Surely, you know her weak spots as well?" Glimmer said. Catra made a grimace.

"Yeah..." she muttered.

Glimmer waited for a moment.

"...and?"

"Forget it," Catra said, not meeting Glimmer's eyes. "It's like you said, all we have to do is slip past some field patrols and then we're out in the desert. Lonnie could search for us for years in the Crimson Waste without finding us."

Glimmer watched her intently.

"OK," she said after a few moments. "Piece of cake."

"Yeah," Catra agreed, "Piece of cake."

They watched each other for another moment.

"So... the road, then?" Glimmer asked casually. Catra nodded.

"Might as well. There are other refugees on the road. We should blend in. Just keep your hood up, Sparkles."

"You're no fun," Glimmer pouted. Catra sniggered.

Hand in hand they went down the hill. They waited until the next group had passed them, and then they sneaked up on the road behind them.

- - -

"All hail Hordak, your savoir."

The soldier sounded bored and seemingly didn't even care about the lack of lip service he got from the refuges on the road.

"Seen any princesses on the road," another soldier asked, a woman not older than Catra or Glimmer. She poked one of the older refuges in the stomach. "You hiding a princess in there?"

The comedian was rewarded with a snigger from her comrades as the refuges looked down, resigned to endure whatever abuse might come their way until the guards got bored with them.

One of the refugees who was dressed in a cloak - a child, by the look of it - tried to hide behind the others, a reasonable attitude by any measure. Unfortunately one of the soldiers were a bit more sharp-eyed than the others and spotted his tail.

"Now, now, now, what have we here," she drawled. She roughly pushed the other refugees to the side and tore the hood of the frightened cat-child. "Trying to smuggle a cat past us, are you? Just as we are told to be on the lookout for one."

"You don't think *that's* former Force Commander Catra, do you?" the comedian objected. The soldier who had grabbed the child leered at her.

"Still, he might know something. I think we should ask some *serious* questions here."

"Please, let me go!" the child cried with frightened voice, which just made the soldier, like any good bully, enjoy the situation more.

"I don't think so," she said. "I don't think so at all. Not when we have such an *interesting* conversation going on."

She held up a stun baton and made sure the child saw it. The refuges gasped as she flicked a switch and the power started crackling.

Catra and Glimmer did not exchange any form of communication. No shared glance, no little tactile question, no nod of confirmation. They simply started to move at the same time.

"Well," Catra said a remarkably short time later. "I suppose we're driving, then."

"Just as well," Glimmer said and dragged the last of the unconscious soldiers out of the way. "I was tired of walking." She jumped into the soldiers' vehicle.

"Don't knock it, Sparkles," Glimmer warned. "We'll have a lot of walking to do before we are out of the fire."

"That's a problem for Glimmer and Catra tomorrow," Glimmer countered. "Today we can just enjoy the ride.

They waved goodbye to the refugees - after Catra gave the cat-kid the stun baton and the adults some constructive ideas of how to avoid Horde patrols from now on - and tore away on the road.

They felt pretty good about themselves.

"Can't you make this thing go any faster?" Glimmer yelled in Catra's ear, and then gasped as Catra kicked in a lower gear and tore through a bend in the road in simply outrageous speed.

"Fast enough for you, princess," Catra leered. Glimmer laughed in exhilaration.

"It will do for now," she shot back and then she shrieked. "Look out for the diiiiiitch!"

Laughing like a maniac Catra manoeuvred the tortured vehicle - designed for patiently lug soldiers and their gear through weeks after week of dull, steady marches, not rushing through the countryside like a flaming comet carrying two manic refugees bent on causing trouble - towards a little boulder just next to the path, and with a scream of complete, unaltered adrenaline they flew through the air and landed on the other side of the ditch,

undoubtedly breaking *something* important in the vehicle as they did, but not caring in the least. Glimmer clung on to Catra for dear life and laughed like she would burst.

"So what will tactical genius Lonnie do now?" Glimmer asked as she clung to Catra a bit closer than strictly necessary in the quickly moving vehicle.

"There will still be some time before anyone notices that the patrol doesn't check in as it's supposed to," Catra shouted back. "As soon as that happens, Lonnie will send another patrol, also, she'll see if she can pick up the signal from their vehicle's sender.

"That would be the thing you hung around the neck of that sheep?" Glimmer asked. Catra sniggered.

"So, as soon she's figured that, we're halfway to the Crimson Waste, right?" Glimmer said. Catra laughed.

"Oh Sparkles, don't start thinking like Adora now. No, as soon as she's figured that out, we'll already have run into one of the detectors she's planted, picking up on a lone Horde vehicle breaking pattern."

"Oh, so we ditch the vehicle, then?" Glimmer said with disappointment in her voice.

"Yup, next time we get to a crossroad."

"We ditch the vehicle by the crossroad?"

"No, we ditch it *after* the crossroad, and then we make clear tracks in all four directions. Give her something to think of."

"So then we've lost her?"

"No, then we have given her a limited sets of roads to put blocks on, which she will, and a limited sets of alternative paths to patrol, which she can do."

Catra turned and gave Glimmer a level look.

"She knows where we're going, Sparkles. Only a limited number of ways to get there. She'll find us."

"So you keep saying," Glimmer countered once Catra looked at the road again. "We just got past one block. Surely we can slip past a few more."

"Sure," Catra drawled, "unless we make a mistake."

Glimmer gasped in faux-shock.

"But that's so unlike us," she said, eyes wide. Catra smirked at her.

"Lonnie will keep pressure on us," she said simply. "She has magic detectors, she has a big enough team to cast a big enough net, and since we just sprung one of its threads, she can now narrow her search. Every such mistake we make will make it so much easier for her, until the trap is sprung."

"Then what?" Glimmer asked.

"Then we better hope *she'll* make a mistake or two of her own."

"The way you talk about her, it doesn't seem very likely," Glimmer commented. Catra shrugged.

"No one said life would be easy."

Glimmer pressed closer against her.

"Well, I'm glad you are here to make things *complicated* together with me."

Catra grinned at her.

"I'm not exactly known to make things easy either."

Glimmer laughed.

Catra really liked her laugh.

- - -

Catra felt restless that evening, so as Glimmer made herself comfortable in the ruined stone building they had found after they ditched their vehicle, she decided to take an evening stroll and scout ahead, looking for food and water but more importantly an excuse to stretch her legs and scratch whatever itch had been emerged from having Glimmer clinging close to her in the Horde vehicle, laughing in exhilaration as they took tight corners.

She didn't find anything to eat, but at least there was a well to refill their water bottles, so that's something.

Catra sauntered back. She took her time. Glimmer would probably need some drain time. There were so many smells out here, so many sounds Catra was not used to. She was used to the humming of the engines and the smells and sounds of people all living their lives within the confines of the machine that was the Horde. Out here it was... different.

There were insects and birds and earthy smells and what few people were about all kept to themselves.

In the Horde, Catra had always been included. More often than not grudgingly so, and more often than not being 'included' was synonymous to being 'targeted', but she had had a place. There had been expectations on her. Obligations (which she fulfilled, or not). Even the occasional privilege. She had been a part of the system.

Out here no one knew who she was. No one expected anything of her except to stay out of their business. There was no one to bully, no one to impress, no one to keep *scores*.

Catra could do whatever she wanted to. She could go wherever she wanted to. *Be* whoever she wanted.

There was a freedom there she had rarely experienced.

She remembered her brief time in the Crimson Waste (she forced away a guilty, stray memory of Scorpia's face). It had been the same feeling. Just her, whoever would follow her, the open desert and whatever she could take.

Catra was good at taking things. Keeping them... ah, that was a trick she still hadn't figured out.

She had fucked it up in the end, of course, just like she fucked up everything. But it had been fun. More than that, it had been... different. It had been a glimpse of a life where the Horde truly didn't matter.

She wondered if that was what Adora had felt, back when she ran away.

To a life where Catra didn't matter.

She forced herself to take a deep breath. She closed her eyes. She felt her claws dig into her palms.

Whatever.

Adora wasn't here.

But Catra was.

The world was her to take.

She looked around. She could see the road they had followed stretching east and west. There were other paths too, most of them just whatever trail the occasional cow had seen fit to follow, but still perfectly passable paths from *here* to *somewhere else*.

And Catra could follow any of them.

Wherever she wanted to go.

Where did she want to go?

She had mostly reacted, done the thing just in front of her. Since Hordak backstabbed her... even further back than that, actually. She hadn't really stopped to ask herself what she wanted to to achieve.

What did she want to do?

Who did she want to be?

Catra looked at the paths and roads and possible futures stretching out in all directions and shuddered.

That was quite enough introspection for now, she decided, and hurried back to Sparkles.

She came back to the ruin and stopped just by the wall. She took a moment to steady herself before she slunk in to the dark corner where she and Glimmer had put up camp. She never knew what state Glimmer would be in when she returned.

To her relief and surprise, Glimmer sat up with her back against the wall. She looked up when she heard Catra and smiled at her.

"Hi Kitty-cat!" she said with pleasant voice.

"Hi sparkle-pants," Catra shot back. "Feeling well?"

"Much better, thanks," Glimmer said. She raised an eyebrow.

"What? No three course dinner?"

"The royal chef is feeling under the weather," Catra drawled. Glimmer laughed, a glittering laugh.

That is, a laugh that sounded like the way glitter looks, not a laugh mixed with the emissions of horrible magic injuries.

"Probably just as well," Glimmer mused. "The way you are going, you'd spoil me rotten in a fortnight."

"Oh no," Catra drily remarked. "A princess spoiled rotten. We wouldn't want to see *that* now, would we?"

Glimmer laughed again.

Catra liked it when she got Glimmer to laugh.

"Catra..." Glimmer said, suddenly serious.

"Yes?" Catra asked, only slight trepidation in her voice.

"There is something I'd like to ask of you."

Glimmer patted on the bedroll next to her. With hesitation Catra sat down next to her, not meeting her gaze.

"I slept better last night than I have in days," Glimmer said with low voice. "I have drained myself of magic. The moons are not up yet. *She* is as far from hurting me as she can ever be for the moment. This, right here, is just me. No shadows, no magic, no pain. Just Glimmer." Glimmer took Catra's hand.

"I want to ask you to do something for me, Catra. It's OK for you to say no."

Catra looked up in trepidation and met Glimmer's eyes. Glimmer gave her an encouraging smile.

"I want you to kiss me."

A blush slowly crept up Catra's face.

"I... I mean, I don't..."

Glimmer shook her head a fraction and raised a finger to her lips.

"Ssssh. Don't say anything. Just do it, if you want to. I want you to." She lifted her head slightly, her lips moving very close to Catra's. She closed her eyes.

The silence hang in the air like a ton of rocks. Catra looked like Glimmer's expectant face in panic and for a moment she looked like she was about to bolt. Glimmer's soft grip on her hands could just as well have been vices for all Catra was able to break it.

The moment dragged out for a heartbeat, and then another one. Glimmer's expression changed slightly, becoming a tiny bit more disappointed. She started to move her head away.

"All ri..." she begun. That was as far as she got before Catra's lips crashed into hers. For a moment they just pressed their lips against each other. Then, as the initial shock wore off, Glimmer smirked a little and gave Catra's lower lip a quick, mischievous nibble. Catra bit back, slightly harder and after that they felt the ice was broken enough for them to start exploring each other properly.

It was quite some time before they emerged from the kiss.

Catra gave glimmer a shy look.

"Well, I hope that's what you wanted, princess."

Glimmer smiled back, slightly more smugly, Catra thought.

"I had hoped I made *that* perfectly clear."

She gave Catra a tender look.

"I know it... worried you, how we only kiss when I'm having my... attacks. I get it." She laughed, a tad embarrassed. "That was hardly how I imagined our first kiss to go either. But I just wanted to show you that it's just fine to kiss without my magical mishaps." She sought Catra's eyes. "It's more then fine," she whispered.

Catra felt her face heat up. Glimmer laughed her glittering laughter again and brushed her lips against Catra's.

"Well, did you like it? Do you want more?"

Catra did.

- - -

The moons were up shining when Glimmer woke up. She made sure to stay under her hood as she felt around with one hand.

No Catra?

Carefully she turned around and crept as far out of their little shadowy corner as she dared.

"Catra!" she hissed, and to her relief she got an answer almost immediately.

"I'm here, Sparkles," Catra said in low voice. she was sitting outside of their little hut, back against the wall, looking at the night sky. The moonlight gave her an eerie look.

"Couldn't sleep?" Glimmer asked. Catra shrugged.

"I was thinking..." she begun.

"Don't strain yourself," Glimmer interjected and earned herself a little growl.

"I was thinking about something Double Trouble told me," Catra went on, not about to be deterred.

Glimmer felt the sincerity in Catra's voice and nodded.

"About... the portal. How it closed," Catra said with the same low, somewhat detached voice.

Glimmer felt a lump of ice in her stomach.

"Yes?" she managed, her voice dropping to a growl.

Catra turned her head and looked Glimmer in the eyes.

"Sorry for killing your mom, Sparkles."

Glimmer felt it like she had received a physical blow. She wanted to scream, to yell, to attack Catra with fists and teeth there and then, but no words came out.

"Hardly does the job, does it?" Catra said with the same calm voice. "I felt it should be said anyway. It's not like I *tried* to kill her, but hey, I was the one who pulled the lever."

"And now you are really, really sorry?" Glimmer hissed.

"Sure, why not?" Catra shrugged.

"And I'm supposed to just..."

"I don't know what you are *supposed* to do," Catra hissed, a bit more emotions to her voice now. "That's up to you. Me saying sorry won't bring your mom back. I just felt that if we're getting cosy or whatever, it shouldn't be something we pussyfooted around."

Glimmer bit back a sharp reply. She took a moment to look closer at the woman in the moonlight. Behind her calm facade, she was clearly trembling. Her eyes were red, there were traces of tears on her face.

Oh, Catra.

"Sure," Glimmer said after a few moments, and managed to calm down her voice to a growl. "By all means, let's be upfront." She sought Catra's eyes. "You killed my mom," she went on. "Big deal. I bet you killed lots of moms in Salineas too."

She saw Catra shudder in the moonlight.

"You're not exactly making me feel better here," Catra muttered.

"Did I say I was going to try to make you feel better?" Glimmer shot back.

She sighed.

"It's war. People die in war. You know it, I know it, my mom knew it, as much as she tried to hide from that fact."

Catra made a snorting little sound.

"What? That's it. People die in war, so sad, too bad."

"Why not?" Glimmer shot back. "You guys got my dad too and you don't see me whining about that." She leaned forward, dangerously close to the moonlight and snarled.

"How many moms did the Horde kill in Elberon? How many in Erelandia? How many in Brightmoon when Shadow Weaver took over? Do you think you are *special* because you've killed a mom? Think again, Kitten. Lots of people have killed moms."

"Yeah," Catra shot back. "And I'm the one who got yours."

"Are you?" Glimmer hissed. "Entrapta built the machine. Hordak designed it. Me and Shadow Weaver pushed you in a corner, and you found a way out. Mom found herself trapped in a situation that sprung from the war. She acted on it. She's not the first mom to find herself in that situation, nor the last, as long as the Horde is still around."

"I did a lot more than just 'pulling a lever', Sparkles!" Catra hissed. "I was the one who talked Entrapta into staying in the Horde. I stopped her from pulling the plug on the machine once she realized it would destroy reality. I caught you guys in the Crimson Waste and brought Adora and her sword to Hordak. Without me, Hordak would never have finished his vanity project."

She abruptly sat up and spun around, putting her face very close to Glimmer's, just around the corner.

"I *wanted* the portal open," she snarled, canines visible, "because I wanted Adora, and you and *everyone* to *hurt*. I didn't know *your* mom would die, but I sure wanted *someone* to. Maybe even *everyone*."

"Well, congratulations," Glimmer growled, her face very close to Catra's, dangerously close to the moonlight. "You got what you wanted. Hope you're *happy*."

They glared at each other, and suddenly, unexpectedly both of them started to laugh at the sheer absurdity in that statement.

"Yeah, sure," Catra said. "Barrels of laugh, my life."

"Well, there you are then," Glimmer shot back. "Mom's sacrifice was not completely in vain if you got a good laugh out of it."

Catra took a deep breath.

"Glimmer..." she begun.

Glimmer shook her head.

"I get it, Kitten. You did something bad and you feel bad. That sucks. I've done plenty of bad things too and I feel plenty of bad about them."

She sighed.

"The thing is... the really weird, really unfair, really absurd thing... is that life goes on."

"Not for your mom," Catra drily commented, committed to keep prodding the wound. Glimmer shot her an angry look.

"*Obviously* not for my mom," she snarled. "But for me. For you. My mom sat on her hands half my life because she was afraid of repeating the mistakes that got my dad killed. One of Bow's dads came home from the first war with the Horde, during the first princess alliance, and swore never to get involved again. But the war didn't *care* about them. It doesn't care about us. It's still there and we still have to *do* something about it."

Catra surprised herself with another laugh.

"You're stuck on the run with me, Sparkles, you're glitching and you'll more likely than not run into something we can't handle sooner rather than later. Do you still feel it's up to you to take out the entire Horde?"

"Yes," Glimmer answered with steady voice, and there was something in her tone that made a shiver move down Catra's spine. "So you will excuse me if I'm a bit too busy with trying to stop the *next* mom from dying to keep too close a score of who killed the last one."

"Glimmer..." Catra said.

Glimmer put a finger to her lips.

"So if you're feeling bad... that sucks. I'm not about to forgive you, if that's what you're asking about but I'm not going to poof away in a huff either. There are plenty of people in the world I'm not eager to forgive, and two of them are right here. Doesn't mean I can't live with them."

Catra gave her a long look with very wet eyes.

"And it doesn't feel... weird us being... close? Given what I have done...?"

Glimmer smirked.

"I'll tell you one thing, Kitten. My mother would absolutely have *hated* for the two of us to get together, which is a good enough reason to me."

She slid down the wall again and patted the bedroll next to her.

"So come back in here this instance and let's make my mom disappointed. It's not like she's around to complain."

Catra stared at her.

"You truly are something special, aren't you, Sparkles?" she whispered.

"Don't you know it," Glimmer smirked.

Catra knew it.

Chapter End Notes

I'm trying to hit that sweet spot just between 'D'awww' and 'Yikes' for their relationship. How am I doing so far?

Will the real Force Captain please stand up

Chapter Notes

> Warning: Hardship, vicious fighting and mutilation. Glimmer's magic keeps acting up.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Breakfast, Sparkles!"

Glimmer sat up from their little nest on the floor, looking sleepily around. She shuddered as a pang of nausea moved through her. She forced it down.

"We've got food left?" she asked.

"Sure we got," Catra drawled. "You don't think I neglected to steal the rations from the guys we beat up the other day, do you?"

"Yum, ration bars!" Glimmer squeaked in faked enthusiasm. "You sure know how to put a smile on the face of a girl."

"Oh, is that what we are doing now?" Catra smirked. "I thought that what yesterday was for."

Glimmer blushed and Catra laughed.

"Don't be shy now, princess! You sure seemed eager enough to make me happy last night."

Glimmer caught her eyes and slowly licked her lips. To her immense irritation, Catra felt a blush creeping up her neck. Glimmer laughed, a pearly, happy laugh.

"Do I make you happy, Kitten," Glimmer whispered in husky voice.

Catra was about to offer up something flippant, but for whatever reason, the words didn't come out.

Instead she watched Glimmer with a fond expression. Glimmer, sensing the shift in the mood looked up at her and calmly met her eyes.

"Do I make you happy?" Glimmer repeated, voice serene now.

Catra felt her heart starting to beat harder. Her throat was thick, her breathing shallow. She couldn't have got a word out if she wanted to.

"You make me happy," Glimmer said in a matter-of-fact voice. "Things are all kinds of shit, but that you are here with me makes it all worth it."

Catra stared at her with large eyes. Glimmer made a little satisfied smirk at her reaction and mercifully looked away to busy herself with her ration bar. She cut it in little dainty pieces and even used one of the blankets as a napkin.

Catra got her breathing under control and ate her own piece of the ration bar with much less elegance. They stole little glances at each other as they ate.

When they finally started walking they held hands.

- - -

The Horde camp was small, just a collection of tents and vehicles.

On a small hill, some distance away from the Horde camp, Catra and Glimmer lurked.

"So, we're heading for the Crimson Waste," Glimmer said in conversational tone.

"Yup!" Catra agreed.

"An enormous desert with few roads and fewer destinations," Glimmer went on.

"Pretty much," Catra nodded.

"We could enter it at any point from this badly patrolled wasteland."

"We sure could."

"So explain to me again why we are trying to sneak past the one Horde camp in these parts?"

Catra grinned.

"Because they have something we need, Sparkles."

"Bad attitude?"

Catra put on a faked hurt expression.

"I'm not bad enough for you?"

Glimmer grinned and bit her lips for an answer. Catra winked at her.

"No, Sparkles. Fun as it is flirting with you, that's not what we're looking for here. We're heading for a desert. We'll need supplies."

"And with supplies you mean..."

Catra grinned again.

"Ration bars."

"You sure know how to show a girl a good time."

"Just you wait, Sparkles. With some luck we might even get some water."

"You say the most romantic things."

"Thank, you," Catra said with a smug smile. "I try."

"So what do you want me to do?" Glimmer asked, with a business-oriented voice.

Catra showed her teeth.

"I want you to bleed."

- - -

"You think my *blood* is magical?" Glimmer asked.

"Magical enough to set of the detectors, i bet," Catra answered, carefully looking at the red liquid they had collected.

"So we pour it on the ground next to the detectors and leg it? Couldn't I just sparkle at the detector and call it a day?"

"The whole point is that we want them to believe we are where we are *not*," Catra shot back. "And if you teleport away, the detectors closer to camp will trigger once you emerge. We'll set up a remote detonator instead."

Glimmer nodded slowly.

"You think she'll buy it?"

Catra sighed.

"Who knows? I'm too used to fight people stupid enough to fall for stunts like this."

"Hey!" Glimmer protested and Catra sniggered at her.

"Don't worry about it. Even if they catch on to the trick, they will only know where we are *not*. We'll have plenty of time to grab what we need and get away."

"Just as that, huh?" Glimmer drily remarked.

"Just like that!" Catra said with jovial voice that in no way matched the anxiety she felt.

- - -

Lonnie frowned over the map. It had been helpful of Catra to beat that patrol up, but since then the reports from the patrols had all been annoyingly vague. A lot of 'maybes' and probably-false-leads that nevertheless had to be checked out.

There were a thousand places Catra and the princess could slip into the waste, and Lonnie would only have one shot at them before that happened.

She wowed not to miss that shot.

"Why did she steal a *cake*?" she wondered out loud. "I get the stun baton, but why risk raiding a horde camp for *cake*?"

"Maybe the princess likes cake?" Kyle suggested. Rogelio made a grunt and chuckled.

Lonnie glared at them.

"Why don't the two of you make yourself useful instead. Go check if..."

Suddenly the comm pad in Kyle's hands started to beep. He looked at it with a frown and pushed a few buttons.

"Um... those magic detectors we put up by the road? They seem to have picked up something..."

Lonnie tore the pad from his hands and studied it carefully. She took a deep breath.

This was it. Catra had gone for the bait.

Now she just had to hope the hook and line would hold.

- - -

Catra watched the vehicles leave the camp. Yes! She'd been right. The blood they had sprinkled around the magic detectors had

been enough to make them act up. Lonnie had taken the bait. The camp was ripe for taking.

Like a shadow, Catra sneaked through the empty camp. She grinned. Good ol' Lonnie. Everything was by the book. The storage tent was in the usual place, with the usual box with the usual ration bars. Just to sneak in and grab what she wanted. So easy. So predictable...

Catra didn't catch up with her own thoughts until a moment too late. She slammed the lid back on the box she just had opened and threw herself to the ground the moment the flash grenade inside the box went off. She tried to cover her ears and eyes as well as she could but was still temporary blinded. She desperately started to run. Somewhere. Anywhere. She heard the sound of engines roaring and Glimmer banging a stick on an old tin can as they had agreed on as a signal.

'*Yeah, got it, thanks Sparkles*,' Catra thought as she desperately blinked to get at least some eyesight back.

"Why hello, Catra," she heard Lonnie's cold voice. "How nice of you to drop in."

Shit.

Catra jumped to the side and felt more than saw the staff whirling dangerously closed. She closed her eyes tightly and ran in the direction she thought would lead her away from Lonnie.

Low on eyesight, hardly any hearing. What was left?

Smell?

Fine, that had to do. She ran the fastest she could, avoiding obstacles as they entered her limited field of vision and waited until...

It was not that Rogelio smelt *bad* per se, but an entire adolescence in the same dorm, and Catra had learnt to pick out

the smell of lizard people.

Besides, she knew Lonnie's style. She *could* take Catra on a her own, in a fair fight, on a good day - but she was not going to chance it. Not when she had the opportunity to set up a perfectly good ambush.

The moment she smelled the first whiff of Rogelio she abruptly halted. She slowly turned her head around until she saw the shadow betraying his whereabouts, and then she leapt. He took a quick sidestep and she missed him, but she hadn't expected anything else. The important thing was that now she knew where he was.

"Got anything to say to me?" she snarled, and even managed a little smirk. "No, wait. No one cares what you say."

Rogelio, now dimly visible in her slowly expanding field of vision, growled but took a slow step back, holding his staff in a defensive gesture. Catra gritted her teeth. Things would have been much easier if she had managed to provoke him to attack. She didn't know how much time she had until Lonnie would catch up with them, but she assumed "not enough" was in the right ballpark.

Right. She'd have to do things the not-easy way, then. As if there would ever have been another way.

"Speak up!" she cried (not her best quip, but it'd have to do), and she lounged herself right at him.

They had fought each other hundreds of times, growing up. In the dorm, in the ring, in the training ground.

He was stronger, she was faster.

He fought by the book, she fought dirty.

He only had to hold her for a few moments, she had to win *now*.

There really was nothing else to it.

Sometimes real life really was just like what they had trained for.

...only, nothing like it.

Catra went low, forcing his staff down, and then in one fluent movement she switched direction and went for his eyes, claws out.

Maiming was frowned upon during Horde training, but out here anything was on the table.

But he easily blocked her and followed up with a quick blow of his own. Nothing fancy, just a strike with the tip of the staff that immediately went back to defensive position.

Of course "nothing fancy" by Rogelio standard was still enough to dent a tank, and Catra had no immediate wish to figure out what it would do to her.

She made a quick feint and managed to slip past hist defence enough to scratch him over the chest. The scales meant it was hardly more than a love tap for him, and she was forced back. But it gave him enough confidence that when Catra attempted the same feint a moment later, he assumed she wouldn't go for his chest again.

She did.

And this time she brought up the stun baton.

Rogelio roared in pain and confusion as he recoiled, which gave Catra the opportunity to grab the blaster in his belt.

"Sorry, still didn't catch what you said," she panted, gave him a vicious kick to get some distance in and then spun around and fired the blaster just in time to force the quickly approaching Lonnie into cover behind a crate.

"How did you know I'd come this way?" Catra shouted to Lonnie to buy herself some time as she tried to get a clean shot.

"You never passed up an opportunity to cut in line in the mess hall," Lonnie shot back. "I figured you wouldn't say no to some free supplies, so it wasn't much of a stress to figure out that you'd find a way to trip our sensors. And here you are."

"Yeah, here I am," Catra countered and took a step to keep Rogelio in her line of sight. Catra had recovered more of her sight and hearing now and quickly looked around. Lonnie covered behind the crates, Rogelio had limped behind a tent. Neither seemed very interested in making a move. That left...

There was no warning whatsoever, just a thump, a sudden pain in her back and Catra fell to the ground, snared in a tight net that quickly enveloped her. She unleashed her claws and furiously cut at the tough material, but before she could cut the strands Lonnie's staff gave her a hard stab, and she quickly withdrew her hands.

"They always forget Kyle, don't they?" Lonnie said loftily. Rogelio growled in agreement. Then he bent down and put his face just next to Catra's.

He growled, a complicated string of syllables, that ended in smug smirk.

Yeah, she had to give him that one.

"Nice shot, Kyle," she shouted over her shoulder with sarcastic voice. She saw Kyle lower the net-gun with a frightened look.

You'd better look scared, Kyle. You're on my radar now.

"Yes, it was a nice shot," Lonnie said with low, cold voice. "And we got you, Catra. Will you come quietly or do we have *insist*."

"You know me," Catra quipped. She was going to follow it up, but before she had the chance, she received a hard blow in her stomach from Lonnie's staff.

"Yes, I know you," Lonnie said as Catra gasped for air. "I know force is the only thing you'll ever respect, and I know you'll be a complete nightmare if we don't establish ground rules here and now."

She raised her staff again.

"So I'm asking you one more time," she went on in the same tone of voice. "Will you come quietly or not?"

Suddenly Rogelio growled in sudden agitation and pointed at the comm pad he was studying. Lonnie swore and looked around in anticipation.

They all focused on Kyle as he let out a quick gasp of fear, that was just as quickly silenced as Glimmer grabbed his arm and held him hard, a knife in her hand.

"Catra's not going anywhere with you," she said with sweet voice. She pressed her knife hard against Kyle's throat. "If you want both of 'your' boys with you back home to the Fright Zone, that is."

"Sparkles, no!" Catra cried. Glimmer ignored her.

"The two of you, back off," she spat. "Catra, get out of the net and get over here."

"Not bad, princess," Lonnie said with cold voice. "Of course, you realize that if you harm him you'll be dead before you have the chance to teleport out."

"People keep underestimating me," Glimmer said just as coldly and increased the pressure on the knife. "People keep ending up dead. What will it be, Force Captain?"

Lonnie's eyes narrowed. Rogelio's muscles tensed. Catra fought to get out of the net. Preferably before things went very bad.

"It's OK, Lonnie," Kyle said with nervous, but unexpectedly steady voice. "She won't hurt me."

"Really," Glimmer sneered. "And what makes you think that?"

"I remember when you were our prisoner after Princess Prom," he said with compassion in his voice. "I remember how the archer talked about you. The person he described would not kill anyone in cold blood."

For a moment, Glimmer stood completely frozen, then a convulsion of remorse and self loathing went through her body. It didn't last for more than a moment, but that was enough for Kyle to tear himself free with a little 'sorry' and run over to Rogelio who quickly stepped in front of him, staff ready.

Glimmer snarled in fury and was about to lounge herself after the fleeing Kyle, but Catra had managed to free herself from the net and ran up to her.

"Don't, Sparkles!" she cried. "I'm out, it's OK."

"Is it, though?" Lonnie said, pointedly holding up her blaster. Catra quickly spun around, pointing her own blaster at Lonnie.

They stared at each other.

Catra and Lonnie ready to fire.

Glimmer and Rogelio ready to jump each other.

Kyle looking from face to face with a worried frown.

No one dared breathing.

It was Catra who broke the silence.

She started to laugh.

The sound was unexpected enough for Lonnie to lower her blaster somewhat. Catra paid her back with the same token.

"You got beaten by *Kyle*, Sparkles," she laughed. "That's one to brag about."

Kyle actually looked proud, as he hid behind Rogelio.

"Glad you enjoyed it," Lonnie interjected. "You'll have plenty of time to reminiscence about it, on your way to the Fright Zone."

"I don't think so, Lonnie," Catra leered. "Haven't you heard, I'm done with that dump."

"So I heard," Lonnie shot back. You left us for a *princess*," Lonnie shook her head in mock bewilderment. "The same one Adora ran off with. She must be a hell of a kisser."

Dire as the circumstances were, Glimmer allowed herself a little smirk.

"That's what Hordak told you?" Catra scoffed. "He had Octavia turn on me because he was afraid I'd out-do him."

"Or that you would stab him first," Lonnie countered.

Catra shrugged.

"Can't take criticism for shit, that guy." She met Lonnie's eyes. "Makes you think..."

"I did think, Catra," Lonnie said and met her eyes without blinking. "You had your shot. You lost."

"Just like that?" Catra said. "What happened to comradely? Unity? I didn't leave you guys. I'm not Adora or Scorpia. I was cast out. You're OK with that?"

"Like we were asked to be OK with Entrapta being sent to Beast Island?" Lonnie said with steady voice.

Catra looked like she had been slapped.

"How did you..." she began.

Lonnie shrugged.

"Wasn't too hard to figure out, once I started putting the pieces together. I didn't tell Hordak, if that's what you're wondering." She looked Catra in the eyes. "But someone did. That's when he sent Octavia for you. You betrayed him, Catra, and it came back to bite you in the ass. Don't try to pin that on us. And don't you dare pretending you cared about us. You treated us like *shit*. You used us. You nearly dragged us down with you. Only time you pretended to care was when you needed us."

"Well, the coin has flipped now," Catra shot back. "So show me how you're any different, *Force Captain* Lonnie."

Lonnie gave her badge a short, guilty glance.

"Being Force Captain was never enough for you," Lonnie sad with low voice. "Things would have been different if you had been willing to stay within the lines."

"Yeah, I'd have been bullied by people like you," Catra snarled. "I get why you'd have preferred that."

"What I prefer has nothing to do with it," Lonnie cried with angry voice. "This is how the Horde *works*. How the *world* works. You of all people should know that by now."

"Don't you dare make speeches at me," Catra growled with angry voice. "You coming hunting for me, waving the badge *I* gave you, tells me everything I need to know."

"I suppose it does. Too bad I didn't find you," Lonnie said with low voice, watching Catra intently.

Catra gave her a sharp look.

"...what?"

"Too bad I didn't find you," Lonnie repeated. "You gave me the slip the last minute. Laid low. Just another deserter in the Crimson

Waste. No chance finding you now."

They watched each other in silence.

"Hordak won't be happy with you if you come back empty-handed," Catra said, voice neutral.

"I won't be empty-handed," Lonnie said, not breaking eye contact.

Silence.

"No."

There was a slight shift in Catra's stance. A slight change in her tone of voice. Those who didn't know her might not have seen the difference.

For those who did know her, it was the difference between a cornered woman with very little to loose who prepared to run, and one who prepared to kill.

Lonnie knew Catra very well.

"Why?" she asked silently. "She's a princess. A fallen princess at that. She's of no use to you."

"If things would have been different," Catra answered, barely managing to contain the growl in her voice, if it would have been me standing there all tall and mighty with my shiny badge, and you here in front of me, and I asked you to give one of your 'boys' up, what would you have answered?"

Silence.

"You'd risk your life for *her*?" Lonnie asked.

"You'd risk your life for Kyle," Catra replied. A statement, not a question.

Silence.

"Hordak won't be happy if I were to come back empty-handed," Lonnie said.

"You won't be empty-handed," Catra answered, voice only wavering slightly.

It took Glimmer a moment too long to understand Catra's meaning. When she started to run it was already too late.

Catra made a clean cut with her blaster, and something small fell to the ground.

For a moment, they all just stared at Catra. She held her wounded hand tightly, the wound neatly cauterised by the blast. Catra forced herself to keep the scream at bay.

"Well, there you have it," she hissed between gritted teeth. "You cornered me, but I blew myself up rather than allowed you to take me alive. All you found was a finger."

Kyle and Rogelio just stared. Lonnie looked downright ill.

"Stars, Catra," she breathed. "I didn't..."

"Shut up, *Force Captain*," Catra hissed. "You had your orders, you followed them. Good enough for you?"

"Ye-yeah," Lonnie mumbled, still staring transfixed at the severed finger on the ground.

Catra smirked.

"Don't feel too bad about it. I've always wanted to give Hordak the finger."

She was the only one who laughed.

With the help of Glimmer, Catra turned and started to walk away, towards the Crimson Waste. Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle stared after them as they walked.

Chapter End Notes

Sometimes when I write, I'm just as much as a loss to what will happens as the characters. "What do you mean, they won't be empty-handed, Catra?" I muttered as I wrote that line, and then I followed the thought to its conclusion. "Oh... no, shit, Catra you don't..."

Narrative gravity can be a bummer, sometimes.

A little place just for the two of us

Chapter Notes

> Warning: Hardship, wounds and creepy crawlies (entomophobia). Glimmer's powers keep giving her grief.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Breakfast, Sparkles?"

"Mmmmmm."

"Would you prefer the honey crusted pheasant or the gold plated cherry cake?"

"What? No cremé pastry plate?"

"For breakfast? What are you? Some kind of uncouth ex horde soldier?" Catra leered at her.

"Sorry, Kitten, you know me, all I know is ration bars. Want a puke green or slime yellow one for breakfast?"

"Do you have the sparkly ones?"

"Those are only for Force Captains and you know it."

"Just my luck."

They trudged on in silence for a while.

"Actually..." Glimmer asked. "Did you actually *have* sparkly ration bars?"

"Nope," Catra answered. Sometimes we saved some green ones so we could mix it with the grey, though. Looked pretty."

"Some green flakes counts as a happy childhood memory for you?"

"Of course not. Shadow Weaver would punish me for 'messing with my food'."

"Of course she would."

They walked on.

"...we don't have any more ration bars, do we?"

"Nope. All out," Catra answered.

"Any other food?"

"Nope."

"Water?"

"There is still some sloshing in my canteen, but I figure we save it for when we really need it."

"Prudent."

"Prudent is my middle name."

"Suits you."

"Does it?"

"Not at all. 'Maniac' or 'Savage' would suit you better."

"Why, thank you, Sparkles."

"It wasn't meant as a compliment."

"I'm devastated. Look, I'm pointing my finger at you."

"Stop it."

Glimmer looked away with an discomforted expression. Catra quickly lowered her hand. She took a step closer to the princess.

"Glimmer..."

"I still can't believe you cut off your *finger*," Glimmer shuddered.

"What? I've got nine more."

Glimmer gave her a disapproving look.

"You can count yourself lucky if it doesn't get infected. Not much I can do about it if it does."

"Relax, Sparkles. I've seen plenty of blaster wounds. They heal right up, no problem."

"No problem in a Horde field hospital, perhaps. We can't even clean it properly."

"I'm sure if it acts up you could kiss it and make it better. Oooooh! Or you could sparkle at it."

Glimmer's frown deepened.

"That's not funny."

"Isn't it?" Catra grinned. "Shame you didn't hear Double Trouble's report back when we sent those pulse bots for you. They did a great impression of you. 'Growl! Angry sparkles!'"

Catra laughed.

Glimmer didn't.

They walked.

"Too mean?" Catra asked after a little while.

"Well, yeah, but what else is new," Glimmer muttered.

"Hey, Sparkles, you worry about me. I get it. It's cute. But little scraps like this will happen on the road. It's OK."

"It's not OK," Glimmer countered. "You could have *died* back there."

"From loosing a finger? Come on, Sparkles."

"No, not just from the finger," Glimmer said with exasperated voice. "The entire setup. They trapped us, they *had* us."

"Yeah, I noticed."

"We could have gotten out of there."

"I *did* get us out of there."

Glimmer gave Catra an angry glare.

"By cutting of part of your hand? That's not what I count as a success."

"Sure it is! We lived to tell the tale, didn't we."

Glimmer stopped.

"Catra!"

Catra stopped and turned to face the princess. She sighed.

"Listen, Sparkles..."

"You could have *died*. They could have killed you."

"Yeah, that's life as a fugitive."

Glimmer looked her steadily in the eyes.

"I have seen you fight. I have fought you. You could have gotten us out of there without loosing a finger. *I* could have gotten us out of there, and you know it."

Catra turned her gaze away.

"So why didn't you?" Glimmer demanded. "Why resort to mutilation."

Catra sighed.

"Because... Lonnie needed a win," she muttered.

Glimmer had an angry retort on her tongue, but suddenly it died down. She stared at Catra in confusion.

"What?"

Catra shrugged.

"Why do you think Hordak sent her and the boys for me? It was a test of loyalty. Either they're loyal, and then they get the job done, or they're still with me and then they would drag their feet. If they came home empty handed they would either be punished outright or sent straight to whatever is the most likely part of the front to get them killed. I had to give her *something*."

"You could have given me to her," Glimmer said silently.

Catra gave her a steady look.

"No, I couldn't."

They watched each other in silence for a long moment.

"Why does it matter to you what Hordak does to Lonnie?" Glimmer asked with quiet voice.

Catra fidgeted for a moment, looking for the right words.

"I've been the one left behind," she settled on eventually. "I know what it's like."

Glimmer watched her for a long moment again.

Then she held out her arms.

"Hug?"

Catra leaned in and the tension left the moment as they hugged in the middle of the desert.

"I have underestimated you, Kitten," Glimmer said as they separated. Catra shrugged.

"People usually do. Sometimes it's useful."

"You still better keep that wound clean."

"Of course, princess. I'll just put on my pink swim suit and slip down to the royal bath."

Glimmer lowered her gaze.

"I... I actually had a pink swimsuit."

Catra laughed.

"Of course you did. With little frills and sequins and everything."

Glimmer gave her a faux scandalized expression.

"*Catra*," she exclaimed. "I can't believe you peaked at me in the bath."

"Savour the thought, princess," Catra growled.

Glimmer gave Catra a very direct look that for whatever reason made Catra's knees feel wobbly.

"Oh, I am, Kitten. I am."

Glimmer had the immense satisfaction of seeing a blush creep up Catra's neck.

They held hands a little while as they trudged on.

The sun was high on the sky.

The 'road' was not much more than the track where a vehicle had driven - who knows where. Still, following it was better than just walking aimlessly in the desert.

They found shelter eventually. Just a sand dune, but there was a hollow in the shade large enough for them to settle down for a few hours.

They drank from the canteen. Glimmer took a gulp and then watched Catra with a worried frown as she held it to her lips.

"You only pretended to drink," Glimmer said accusingly.

"I didn't," Catra lied.

Glimmer sighed tiredly.

"Please, Catra. Just take a sip. I promise you'll be in better shape saving me from the ills of the world if you get some water in you."

Catra rolled her eyes, but she gave in under the onslaught of Glimmer's worried eyes, and she took a proper gulp from the canteen before she carefully replaced the lid.

"Get some sleep, Glimmer," Catra said with soft voice. "We'll continue once the sun gets lower."

Glimmer nodded and laid down in the little hollow. She took a few deep breaths, expelled some magic in what was now getting a familiar ritual of relaxation and put her head on her backpack.

"Don't do anything stupid while I sleep," she murmured.

"Would I ever?" Catra grinned.

"Probably," Glimmer muttered.

Soon she didn't say anything because she was sleeping, exhausted from the heat and the long day.

Catra waited until she was sure Glimmer slept properly, then she slunk away to do something stupid.

- - -

They were not the only refugees in the Crimson Waste. Catra had noticed the track from the other group cross their just some little while ago.

There had been many of them - a large enough group to carry a lot of food and water - but not *too* many - not a large enough group to properly defend themselves.

She found the tracks and started to follow them, over the dunes. She did not have to follow them for long.

Catra sneaked, silent like a shadow over the next ridge. The tracks were easy to follow. Five people. Heavy with burdens. And the tracks were fresh.

Her ears perked up as she heard voices.

They had found temporary shelter behind a rock outcrop. They didn't even think of keeping watch. Catra snorted for herself and sneaked closer.

She saw them a moment after. Five people, huddling together, sharing the content of one single canteen. By the look of how carefully they handled the canteen, they were not spoiled for an excess of water either.

They were armed, but none of them had their weapons ready. It would be a child's play for Catra to ambush them, snatch the canteen - and that very interesting food package they had put on the ground between them - and be gone before they were any wiser.

And speaking of child's play...

Up until now Catra had managed to dismiss how much smaller two of the pair of footprints were than the others.

She watched the group in silence for a little while, watched the children slowly drink as it was their turn with the canteen, watched their dirty faces look longingly at the bottle as they passed it on.

She turned and silently walked back to where she had left Glimmer. She was awake and waiting for her.

"No luck?" the princess asked.

"No luck," Catra said.

Neither felt the need to elaborate.

- - -

They walked for a few more hours, after which they both had splitting headaches and neither had the energy for even the most basal quips. There was not a single cloud in the sky, and the moons were going to be a serious problem. Eventually they found some sort of abandoned shelter - an old hunters hut or the like - and they decided that would be as good a resting place for the night as any they had seen. Catra found a few grubby plants and they managed to squeeze some bitter tasting water from them. Glimmer emptied herself of magic as well as she could.

She felt like she had not had more than a few moments of sleep when Catra shook her awake.

"Wsz?" she muttered.

"Engines," Catra explained. "Still some way off, but I'd like to be on the safe side."

"Wouldn't us moving about make us *more* visible than us laying low here," Glimmer objected.

"Sure, unless they already know where we are," Catra replied. She pointedly looked at Glimmer's hand's that were leaking faint traces of light.

"Hey, I've drained myself properly this time," Glimmer protested. "I'm a *good girl*.

"Sure you are," Catra muttered. "Hopefully that will be enough. The further we get from the Whispering Woods, the more you will stand out."

"I chose to take that as a compliment," Glimmer said loftily.

"For now, we'd better stay put," Catra thought aloud as she peered out into the moonlight. "But if we hear them closing in we should be prepared to bolt."

"Fine by me," Glimmer yawned. Then Catra saw how the quality of the light in the little hut changed.

Like the soft glow emitting from Glimmer's skin had suddenly become more luminous.

Or perhaps, like the surface area emitting the light had suddenly increased.

Like, as if areas of soft, warm, glowing skin that had previously been covered now were not.

Catra suddenly experienced a very strong feeling of trepidation what she would see when she turned around.

"Why don't we see if we can figure out a way to past the time while we wait?" Glimmer said with velvet voice.

Catra turned around.

Glimmer stood as tall as she could in the tiny hut, naked and glowing, a smile on her lips Catra had no idea what to do with. Challenging. Alluring. *Inviting*. Catra's eyes desperately darted

between different parts of her body, seeking somewhere, *anywhere* it felt safe for her gaze to reside.

She settled for the face. Not that it felt even remotely safe, not with Glimmer smiling like that and - Oh stars! - now taking a small step towards her, but at least it kept her eyes away from soft curves, glowing breasts and... Catra forced her eyes upwards again.

"What do you say, Catra?" Glimmer purred - yes, really. "Is there something you'd want to do with me while we wait?"

And then Glimmer stood just before her, and somehow Catra's hands had found their way to Glimmer's back - her skin was just as warm and soft as Catra had imagined it to be - and their faces were oh so very close to each other.

"Don't try to tell me you haven't thought about it," Glimmer murmured. Her hands had found Catra's face. "I know for sure *I* have dreamt of this." She got a wicked glint in her eyes. "Dreamt of it quite a lot, actually."

Her mouth planted a soft little kiss on Catra's mouth, and then after a moment of hesitation, a series of little pecks down her cheek until her mouth found Catra's neck. Catra gasped when she felt Glimmer's teeth against her skin.

"What's the matter, Kitten?" Glimmer murmured, mouth pressed against her neck. "Not used to be on the receiving end of a bite?"

"I hear *someone* is angling for a nibble of her own," Catra mumbled, finally finding her voice. She felt Glimmer's mouth form a satisfied grin against her skin.

"I do indeed! Teach me your ways, Kitty-cat."

As it turned out, Catra had quite a few things to learn herself.

- - -

Wow.

Just wow.

Catra watched the half-sleeping Glimmer in amazement. Even now she was emitting low levels of light, even now having a smug smirk on her lips.

OK, Catra had to admit - the princess had earned it.

Like, wow.

Glimmer snuggled closer still and put an arm around Catra. Catra didn't protest.

The princess smelled earthy, like forest soil on a sunny day. Her grip was tight, and even if she shivered slightly, feeling her close was comforting.

Catra closed her eyes, trying to relax even if that made the headache hit full force. Her hand hurt, a throbbing, dull, persistent ache. She focused on Glimmer's hand around her waist - all right, slightly higher than her waist - and her mouth close to her neck.

She felt the small spasm that went through Glimmer's body as she drifted closer to sleep. Poor thing must be exhausted.

So was Catra, but that didn't mean she could sleep. Too many thoughts in her head. Too many years of habit telling her that sleep made her vulnerable.

Thanks, Shadow Weaver.

Out here, there was always danger nearby.

But she did manage to fall into some sort of half-slumber where at last her headache started to give way and her mind was starting to drift.

She felt Glimmer's rhythmic breaths against her neck. Her hand had travelled even further up and Catra didn't mind the least.

She smiled to herself.

Look at me now, Adora. Who's having an adventure with the pretty princess now?

She idly wondered how long they would survive. They could make it another few days without food. Water on the other hand...

There were ways, she knew. Springs and plants and the right place to dig, if you knew. Or the tried and true method to find the people who knew and bully them into helping them.

Preferably people without kids.

But any stunt like that they tried would mean attention, and attention would mean increased risk of another little visit from the Horde, or worse.

Oh well. That was future Catra's problem. Right now, right here, the world could be small. Just her, and Glimmer, and the little hole they had crawled down into.

She smirked. Life was not without its little ironies.

Outside, light poured over the dunes and one of the largest moons rose over whatever ridge it had been lurking behind. Glimmer whimpered slightly in her sleep and Catra tried to move even closer to her, doing her best to cover the princess from any stray ray of light that might hit her.

If it had been soldiers coming for Glimmer, or monsters hunting her, or mad old machines crawling towards her she could have killed them or destroyed them or evaded them.

But how could she ever hope to protect the sleeping woman against something that was so embedded in her very being as the magic of Etheria?

It was not like she could hurt the moons if they came to pick a fight with her princess.

Catra felt something old and familiar, something hot with teeth and claws, raise in her throat. Images flickered through her mind, half forgotten drawings she had seen on Entrapta's comm pad. Diagrams of rockets and lasers and things that went boom.

If the moons kept being assholes to her princess like this, she would be damned sure to find a way to hurt them.

Her princess?

That, perhaps, was a thought she should explore.

Catra dismissed it immediately. Overthinking relationships had never given her anything but grief. Enjoy it as long as it lasted, that was the melody.

She didn't have any illusions that this would last.

She would not make the same mistake she had made with Adora.

But she was honest enough with herself to admit that she *did enjoy it. Enjoyed it a lot, actually.*

She moved slightly to give the largest moon a rude gesture and was for a moment extremely annoyed when she realized that she now only had one hand with the proper set of digits to do so with.

Those little sacrifices we make.

She snuggled closer to the sleeping Glimmer, making sure their blankets covered as much of her as possible.

The stump that was all that was left of her missing finger ached, a dull, throbbing ache.

She knew she would not get much sleep tonight, but if Glimmer could get some rest, some respite from her pain and suffering,

that was enough for Catra.

She felt the princess' warm hand on her breast, felt her chest move rhythmically as she breathed, felt her hot breath on her neck, with just a tiny sting from the exhaled magic.

Catra felt her mind drift, and after a while she realized to her great surprise that she heard a low purring sound.

She realized it came from herself.

- - -

The sun was shining bright on the sky and had apparently been doing so for a while as Catra woke up and blinked in confusion. The shock from loosing her finger must have hit her harder than she thought, if she had fallen unconscious like that. Her nostrils told her that something was smelling wonderful, but at the same time her searching hands told her that Glimmer was not in the hut with her any longer.

Glimmer!?

Catra quickly bolted up from the shelter, her eyes small slits not to be blinded by the strong light. For a moment everything was a blur, she just saw the sand, and a shape sitting on the dune, and heard the sound of fire and...

"Morning, sleepy-head! I've got breakfast for you."

Catra blinked.

Glimmer was sitting by the fire, a piece of cloth over her head to avoid the worst of the sun (it was a piece torn of from their blanket, but somehow the princess still managed to make it look cute and dainty. She was holding what Catra realized was her stun baton over the flickering flames. On it was the cleaned body of a portion of a snake. Catra saw the rest of the snake - almost as long as her tail - on a rock next to them.

"You caught a snake?" she asked, flabbergasted. Glimmer shrugged.

"It was sniffing around the opening of the shelter, so I thought it best not to encourage them. Also, I found water!"

She held up the canteen with a proud smile. Catra took it. It was almost full. She gave it a suspicious taste. Sandy but perfectly drinkable.

"How did you do that?" she asked in wonder.

"Oh, you just have to know where to dig," Glimmer said dismissively, her would-be modesty somewhat ruined by the fact that she was still beaming with pride. "I have been here before, you know."

"Sure, so have I," Catra said. "Doesn't mean I know where to dig. Scorpia handled that stuff."

"Well, Scorpia's not here, so you'll have to do with little ol' me," Glimmer said and fluttered her eyelashes.

Catra shook her head and started to chuckle.

"Well, someone's feeling sassy today," she muttered.

Glimmer laughed.

"Just kiss me and eat your snake," she said, handing the now roasted piece over to Catra who caught it with her claws not to burn herself. "There's plenty more where that came from."

Catra kissed her and ate her snake.

She was feeling much better today. Her hand still hurt but her head felt surprisingly OK. The snake tasted good and the water was a blessing. Glimmer was in a good mood, and it was catching. She hummed and sang as she moved around the fire, trying to

figure out if any of the local plants made good seasoning for roasted snake (they didn't). Catra watched her and felt content.

They had food, they had water, they had shelter and they had each other. Nothing was hunting them right now, nothing was trying to hurt them. They had nothing they had to do, nowhere they had to be. All the expected shit had already hit all the expected fans.

They were off the hook.

Part of her wanted to stay here - right here - and just live each day after the other. A hard life, but an easy life. Snakes and and hardship and Glimmer.

She chuckled. A fun fantasy and nothing more, of course. But still, part of her really wished she could have that life.

"We should get going," Glimmer said as if she had read Catra's mind and wanted to pre-emptively avoid an argument about the merits of a life eating sand snakes.

Catra didn't argue.

She finished her snake, helped Glimmer pack the rest of it and hide the remains of their camp, took a deep gulp of water and they got going.

They took it easy this day. They walked in a leisurely pace through the barren landscape. It's not like they were in a hurry after all. They took their time, and they talked.

...about everything.

Glimmer told Catra some select anecdotes of her childhood, that soon deteriorated into just explaining her childhood. A lonely and spoiled princess in a castle of light and crystal was about as alien an experience for the unwanted Horde child soldier in her busy dorm as anything on Etheria.

"Hold up, Sparkles. You tell me your bed is hanging up in the ceiling?"

"Great motivation not to roll around in your sleep!"

Catra told Glimmer about the rough camaraderie of the Horde dorm, where privacy was unheard of, where everything was a challenge, where weakens was punished but - as soon as the pecking order was established - there were a certain amount of a sense of unity, because when it came down to it they had to be there for each other because no one else in the world was.

"Unless we run away with a pink princess, of course," Catra said in a voice which amazingly sounded more flippant than bitter.

"This whole time we tried fighting you guys," Glimmer answered with light voice. "I should just have seduced you all instead, one by one. Should I do Lonnie next?"

She laughed at Catra's outraged expression.

"My, you really are smitten with me," she smiled. She put a light hand on Catra's arm. "I promise not to seduce Lonnie without your expressed permission," she teased.

"You better not," Catra shut back, trying without success to hide her blush. "Kyle and Rogelio would have your head."

Glimmer took a mocking step back and pretended to look ashamed.

"I promise to be good," she said in a voice that said the opposite. She caught Catra's eyes and licked her lips. "...unless you prefer me to be bad of course."

Catra snarled as she felt her face heating up. Glimmer's glittering (yes, really) laughter followed her as she stalked away to cool down.

When the day turned too hot they found shadow by the foot of an enormous cactus. The shooed away some giant beetles, large as dogs, that had burrowed by its foot. Then they ate lunch (roasted snake) and kept talking.

They talked about Adora.

"She really made googly eyes at Huntara?" Catra gasped. Glimmer laughed.

"She has a type, and it isn't us... it isn't only us," Glimmer quickly amended when she saw Catra's expression.

"If she can't have sneaky and sexy, apparently it's the muscles that does it for her," Catra muttered. She suddenly let out a laugh.

"Well, if she's truly stranded on Beast Island with Scorpia, maybe they'll hook up."

Glimmer gave her a look of pure shock.

"Scorpia? You can't be serious."

Catra laughed again.

"Nah, she's too much of a goody two-shoe. Adora likes her girls with a little bite," she showed her canines for effect. Glimmer smirked.

They shared a look.

Oh yes. A little bite indeed.

"Too bad for Adora, really," Catra said flippantly. "She doesn't know what she's missing with Scorpia. That woman is pure devotion."

To her immense satisfaction, Catra saw Glimmer's eyes widen and a blush emerge on her cheeks.

"What? Does that surprise you, Sparkles? Me and Scorpia used to rule these parts. We had to do something to keep warm at night."

Glimmer giggled.

"I wish I had known when she came to Brightmoon. I would have high fived her so hard."

"Bad idea," Catra remarked. "Those claws cut through anything."

Glimmer raised an eyebrow.

"That might have made things awkward."

Catra's grin widened.

"What can I say?" She bent forward slightly and caught Glimmer's eyes. "Some of us like it rough," she hissed, causing Glimmer to blush again.

Catra liked it when Glimmer blushed.

Talking about Adora - talking about Adora like that - should have hurt, Catra reflected as they trudged on once the sun had sunk low enough on the sky for them to brave the sand again. It should have hurt a lot, like in screaming-and-killing-hurt a lot.

But for whatever reason it didn't.

Maybe it was like when she thought back to her life in the Horde, that all those things that had seemed so important, that had hurt so much, had more to do with Catra of the past than with herself.

Or maybe it had more to do with the pink princess stoically walking with her.

Catra slowed down so she walked slightly after Glimmer. Good habit. That allowed Glimmer to set the tempo and reduced the risk of her overstraining herself.

Yup, those were the only reasons, Catra reflected and let her gaze linger on Glimmer's butt.

Their chatter died down as they grew more tired, but they didn't drain themselves as much this day as they had the day before. It was easier to for Glimmer to get rid of excess magic here than in the Whispering Woods, but Glimmer still felt the background magic of the desert trickling back into her body.

They sat just next to each other and ate dinner (roasted snake) and drank from the canteen. There were only few drops left, and Catra expressed concerns.

"I'll just dig for more," Glimmer said dismissively and gave Catra a nonchalant smile.

As the sun went down, they dug themself down in a dune and covered Glimmer with all available fabrics to shield her from the moon. The heat quickly radiated away from the sand. Glimmer started to shiver slightly.

"Cold?" Catra asked.

"Everyone's not blessed with fur," Glimmer shot back and snuggled closer to Catra.

"Yeah, you try to get the snags out of your tail after a day in the field, then we will see how 'blessed' you feel."

Glimmer giggled.

"You get bad hair days too, Kitty? Like, all over?"

Catra smirked.

"If you're good I'll let you brush it for me."

Glimmer gasped in pretend excitement.

"I will bath you and I will towel you and I will brush you and I will put a little bow on your tail and you will be so pretty," she said in high pitched voice.

They laughed.

Glimmer edged closer, and she gave Catra a long look, expression sincere.

"Look at me, Catra," she said with low voice.

Catra raised an eyebrow but obliged. Glimmer caught her eyes and slowly bent forward and suddenly Catra's face felt very warm, and not from the sun.

But instead of the kiss Catra had hoped for, Glimmer slowly reached up and placed her hands on the sides of her mask. Catra gave her a guarded look.

"You're not going to scratch my eyes out, are you?" Glimmer asked, half-teasing. Then she carefully took the mask off and placed it in the sand next to them.

"Why, hello beautiful," she murmured to Catra who was still sitting absolutely still, not knowing what to do next.

Glimmer patted her legs.

"Here, give me your face."

Before she had quite understood she was doing it, Catra was lying down with her head in Glimmer's lap. She looked up at Glimmer's lavender eyes and felt her hands tracing her face. First she just stroke her skin, her hair, but then she started to slowly, gently massage Catra's face.

Her fingers were soft but firm. Catra felt the fleeting pain as they softened muscles that had been stiff for far too long. Glimmer's fingers worked in a pattern, tracing the edges where Catra had carried her mask and working inwards. The queen's lap was

warm. There was food (roasted snake) in Catra's stomach. Her hand hurt, but she didn't care. All the problems she had ever had or would ever have belonged to either Catra in the past or Catra in the future.

Right here, Right now, it was only Glimmer and her hands on Catra's face.

Catra felt it coming and did nothing to stop it when she started to purr, quietly at first, but soon more and more loud. Let the princess tease her if she liked. In fact, Catra welcomed it. She liked their banter.

But the princess didn't tease her. She just sat there, looking down at her as her fingers worked with an expression that made Catra fell very strange.

And made her feel she would do anything, anything at all, if it made Glimmer keep looking at her like that.

That other Catra, the one in the past with all her hurt and hate and guilt and pain... she didn't know what she was missing.

Slowly, without any rush, without any need for doing when it was perfectly sufficient just being, Catra fell asleep. The last thing she was aware of seeing was Glimmer's warm, loving eyes.

...Loving?

Maybe, just maybe, Catra-of-the-present was perfectly able of getting into some problems of her own.

She wouldn't want it any other way.

- - -

Glimmer waited until Catra's breathing was deep and rhythmic. The poor thing must have been exhausted. Good thing she could finally get some proper sleep.

That made this next part so much easier.

Glimmer gave the sleeping cat-girl a fond smile and stood up, flexing her stiff muscles. She felt a pang of guilt for leading Catra on. The poor woman was so starved for affection it was hardly fair.

It couldn't be helped. Glimmer needed her, and she couldn't afford Catra leaving to pursue her own agenda just yet.

She would not make the same mistake she had made with Bow and Adora.

Glimmer sighed.

That was one more sin on her already blotted record, but she had gone too far to back down now.

She had to succeed.

Or else it would have all been for nothing.

She stepped out in the moonlight and shuddered as the magic entered her. Shadow Weaver's dark poison followed, dark whispers, dark shadows at the edge of her vision, but she ignored it. She breathed deeply a few times.

Then she took a deep breath and forced out a steady stream of magic. The magic of the moon, the magic of the world. She felt it enter the dry land around her, follow paths and trails laid out when the land was new, and renewed ever since.

She felt the magic ground itself in the sand, in the rocks, in the tiny creatures that lived in the ground.

And in water.

A deep, dark reservoir that absorbed her magic like if it had snuffed out a flame.

Glimmer shuddered and opened her eyes. She followed the magical trail she had laid out to a depression between two dunes.

She took the foldable shovel from the pack and started to dig.

In the land of the thirsty, the one with the water is queen.

Glimmer couldn't afford Catra leaving her just yet.

- - -

"Morning, Kitten! Breakfast."

Catra blinked away the sleep and gave Glimmer a fond look. The princess yet again managed to look absolutely stunning while preparing breakfast in the middle of a friggin' desert. The sweat and sunburn made her look radiant rather than clammy. The sand that stuck everywhere just made her look extra sparkly, which was no mean feat. The dainty little piece of cloth on her head made her look silly, but in the most endearing way possible.

Her smile...

Her smile made Catra's legs feel week.

The affectionate little kiss she gave Catra as she shuffled up from their sleeping nook did nothing to alleviate that feeling.

They ate their breakfast (roasted snake) and drank from the now refilled canteen. Catra didn't comment, just lifted an eyebrow, and Glimmer beamed in reply.

Glimmer spent some time fussing over Catra's hand. It was starting to show signs of infection, despite the antiseptics, and despite the brave face she put on, Catra started to be worried.

Still, not a whole lot they could do about it out here.

They spent some time kissing before they got moving.

They made decent pace, starting to get used to the constant exercise. They saw more of the same beetles as yesterday, slowly shuffling around in the shade. Catra was more agitated than precious days. Something kept nagging at the edges of her attention. She often stopped to listen, or smell the air. At one point she spent a solid minute with her ear pressed against the ground.

Then she led them on a long detour, towards rockier ground.

"I think I heard engines again," She explained to Glimmer.

"The Horde?" Glimmer asked in trepidation and Catra shrugged.

"Mabe. Or refugees, or bandits. Could be a lot of things, very few of them good."

Glimmer saw the wisdom in that and trudged on next to Catra without complaining.

They stopped for lunch (roasted snake) in the shade of a huge rock. There were more beetles here, and Glimmer spent some time throwing rocks at them until they got the point and ambled away. Catra climbed the rock and sat motionless for a long time, watching the horizon.

"There are at least two groups," she said when she finally came down, "And I think they work in unison."

Glimmer frowned.

"Can they track us?"

"I could have," Catra said for answer.

"Do we hide or do we fight?" Glimmer asked, earning herself an admiring look from Catra.

"You're ready to take on two group of soldiers?"

Glimmer grinned.

"We only need to take one group, then we have a lot of gear to take the second."

Catra laughed.

"Tempting," she admitted. "But I'm not ready to fight us past every asshole with something to prove in the Crimson Waste just yet. Let's see if we can loose them in the hills."

"You're the boss!" Glimmer said teasingly, causing Catra to turn her face away to hide a blush.

She liked it when Glimmer said things like that, in a voice like that.

They reached higher ground. Catra led them on a long, winding path which she deemed would make it harder to track them. Glimmer didn't complain, even when she was clearly tiring.

Suddenly Catra stopped. She carefully sniffed the air. She turned around and gave Glimmer a mischievous smile.

"Hey, Sparkles," she whispered with a glint in her eyes. "Do you want to see something cool?"

"Sure," Glimmer said - out of breath from the treck. "Impress me."

Catra grinned at her.

"Then stand aaaabsolutely still," she said and took a step forward.

And another one.

And a third.

Her foot hit what Glimmer could have sworn was as rock just as any other... and the ground exploded in an inferno of gravel, scales and fangs. Glimmer gasped and stumbled backwards as a gigantic, three-headed snake emerged from the ground. It

snapped after Catra, but she had jumped the moment her foot touched the rock, and she was already coming for the middle head, claws first. A few quick slashes, and she had clawed its eyes out.

Catra jumped again as the two other heads crashed into the middle in their eagerness to get to her, causing even further damage. She got a grip on the back of the snake and quickly scrambled upwards. The snake felt her coming and threw itself backwards to crush her against the rock, but Catra was faster.

Snicker-snack, and the snake had only one functional head left.

Clearly realising it was at a disadvantage, the snake tried to retreat. Catra jumped off, landed on a rock and jumped hard on it. Once. Twice. At the third attempt it dislodged, crashing down towards the snake that tried to slink back to its hole.

The rock didn't hurt it exactly. But it slowed it down.

And that turned out to be fatal once Catra came for it.

Glimmer just stared, mouth open. It hadn't been more than a few heartbeats since the snake emerged. Now Catra stood beside it with a proud grin as the tail still lashed, still not realizing the heads were dead.

"Impressed you, did I?" Catra said.

Glimmer laughed.

"I'm glad you like my cooking, Kitty-cat, but I don't think we can carry this much."

"I love your cooking," Catra drawled. "Beats ration bars every time."

Glimmer laughed again - and what a beautiful sound it was - and walked up to Catra and the still trashing snake. She grabbed her head and gave her a long, hard kiss.

"Then I will cook for you," she said with soft voice, holding Catra's gaze. "For as long as you like."

The after-reaction from the fight suddenly hit Catra hard. She felt warm and cold and tired and like she could lift a mountain all at the same time. Glimmer kissed her again - this time just a little peck on her cheek - and then she took in the gash at Catra's leg.

"You're hurt?" she gasped.

Catra laughed.

"This scratch? Don't you go soft on me, Sparkles. Just one of the heads that got a lucky bite in."

"Still, we better clean it and bandage it," Glimmer said with a worried frown.

"Want to play doctor with me again?" Catra leered. Glimmer laughed a bit embarrassed and smacked her on the tail.

"And encourage you to keep doing stupid stunts like this? Doesn't seem like a good idea."

"If it were good ideas you were after you wouldn't be here with me, now would you, princess?" Catra said. It had been intended to be flippant, but by the end of the sentence she realized she was looking Glimmer in the eyes, silence hanging heavy in the air for a moment.

Glimmer looked down a bit coquettishly.

"I suppose not," she admitted.

A smile lit up her face and Catra's heart.

"I suppose I might be up for some bad ideas, after all," Glimmer said. "Together with you."

They smirked at each other.

"So, what bad ideas do you want to get into next?" Catra asked, partly to cover her own embarrassment.

"Preferably ideas that mean you won't get an infection," Glimmer said with a pointed look at Catra's leg. Catra smirked.

"I don't think you get the point of being a bad girl," Catra laughed. Glimmer gave her a decidedly challenging look.

"Oh? I'm lucky to have you to teach/i> me then, don't I?"

Catra suddenly had to get very busy with her backpack to dig out the first aid kit.

Glimmer cleaned the wound as well as she could with the small amount of antiseptics they had left and then she took a long time fussing over the bandage to get it just right. Catra liked the attention so she didn't complain.

Eventually Glimmer seemed happy with her work. She put the first aid kit together again and gave the snake a thoughtful look.

"I'll see if I can figure out what parts of this makes for good eating. Think you can help me cutting it up?

"Anything for my princess," Catra drawled, causing Glimmer to blush.

She liked it when Catra said things like that.

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They ended up cutting as large chunks of meat as they could carry, and decided to walk some distance before they lit the fire. They wanted to get away in case the fight had attracted attention.

The beetles they had seen earlier showed up in larger groups and descended on the corpse of the snake as they left.

"That should keep them busy," Glimmer said. Catra frowned but didn't answer.

They built a fire and roasted their snake. It had a tougher texture than the one Glimmer had caught the day before, and there was a bitter taste to it, but they didn't complain.

Glimmer wanted to settle for the night, but Catra hurried them on. She wanted to move them further away from the dead snake and from their cooking fire. So they walked for another hour, until Glimmer's feet screamed in protest and she started to be seriously worried about the moon rising. Finally Catra found a cave to her liking. She roughly ushered Glimmer into it.

"You're not coming?" Glimmer asked, too tired to add even the tiniest amount of teasing to her voice. Catra irritably shook her head.

"Too much noise. Too many smells. I'll keep watch."

So she did, while Glimmer tossed and turn throughout the night.

When Catra shook her awake it was still night.

"No breakfast?" Glimmer mumbled and tried to blink her eyes open.

"We might be the breakfast," Catra hissed, which was motivation enough for Glimmer to wake up all in one go.

"More snakes?" she whispered. Catra shrugged.

"Something. Something big. And more of those damned beetles. Let's get away from here. Can you handle the moons?"

Glimmer gave her a careful look.

"There are some clouds, and only one moon is up. I think I can handle it."

"Then let's go."

Glimmer wrapped the cloak tightly around her, and they started walking. Catra led them on a long winded path through the rocky landscape. She often stopped to hide them behind a rock while she tried to figure out the best way forward.

Glimmer trudged after her. She saw the beetles here and there in the landscape - there seemed to be more of them now - and at some points she heard something large shuffling past - but most of the time she did not know what they were hiding from.

There was something comforting in that. For once, just for this night, it was not all up to her. All she had to do was follow. Let Catra handle the danger, let Catra tell her what to do. Let Catra be the responsible one.

"Something funny, Sparkles?" Catra hissed in a voice that indicated she didn't see much humour in their current predicament. Glimmer just shook her head and hid her smile.

They sneaked on.

Glimmer felt the moonlight pour into her, despite the cloak. She felt the sting as the pressure built up. She tried releasing some of it. Catra frowned as she saw the sparks dissipating, but she didn't comment.

"Right," Catra said after what felt like an eternity. "That's long enough. Sparkles, see if you can find a hole to let out some glitter. I'll scout ahead."

"Wait? You're leaving me by myself?" Glimmer asked, suddenly anxious. Catra gave her a grim look.

"I'll cover more ground on my own, and if you stay out in the light much longer we're back to you vomiting rainbows."

"What about the beetles?" Glimmer protested.

"If they give you grief, pay them back," Catra simply said, and she was off.

She left her stun baton with Glimmer, however.

Glimmer found herself a promising rock that gave her enough shelter from the moon that she was confident she would be able release magic faster than it flowed back in.

It would still hurt, though.

She took a deep breath, steadied herself and exhaled in the now familiar routine of releasing magic in a cloud of stinging sparks.

One, two three breaths, each accompanied by a quickly dissipating sparkles. Glimmer felt the internal pressure ease somewhat and started to move around to ease up her joints.

She heard a shuffling noise.

She looked up to see one of the beetles crawling towards her over the rocky ground. It would probably have been pretty, had she been in a position to properly appreciate gleaming carapaces and sharp legs. As it was, it just looked revolting. The antennas flittered through the air, and Glimmer saw the beetle amble straight towards the place where she had last been exhaling.

It stopped to examine the rocks where the sparks had dissipated.

Glimmer watched it with a sinking feeling in her stomach.

To test her growing suspicion, she let out another cloud of sparks, and the beetle immediately jerked and started to move, straight towards her.

It was met by her stun baton. One zap and it turned and scurried away as fast as it could (not very). Glimmer watched it go.

There would be more where it came from.

- - -

Catra frowned. Something was definitely up. She heard more critters moving about, some of them as monstrous as anything she had ever seen in the Whispering Woods.

At least she had found a ravine leading in roughly the right direction, where Glimmer should be shielded from the moons, so that was something.

Catra allowed herself a worried thought of Glimmer, struggling against her very nature to remain functional.

Shadow Weaver always knew how to find someone's week spot, didn't she?

Catra aimed to prove to her that she was a good student, whatever the witch might think.

As she came closer to the spot where she had left Glimmer, she realized something was wrong.

There were way too many beetles, for one thing.

And way too few glitter princesses.

Catra froze and stopped to take in the the surroundings. Nose, ears and eyes all twitching, data flowing into her brain in a manner that was almost pure instinct, but honed by a lifetime in a place where someone was plotting against you at any given time.

She heard the scratches of beetle legs against rock. Smelt the sour stench of the pheromones they released to communicate. The oily smell of burnt insect flesh...

Oh, Sparkles.

She quickly ran towards the source of the smell. It wasn't hard to find. All she had to do was following the beetles.

Glimmer was perched on a rock, surrounded by a pile of dead or dying beetles, with hundreds of more scrambling over the bodies of their fallen comrades to get closer to her.

The face of the princess contorted in a furious snarl. Light streamed from every orifice. In her hand was the stun baton, which she used as a conduit for her powers. As Catra watched, she jabbed it at yet another beetle, an explosion of sparks was seen and it fell twitching to the ground. Glimmer cried out in pain and rage and sent another pulse of magic through the instrument, frying another beetle. Catra saw how the beetles that were closest to the discharge didn't pull back, like any ordinary animal would, but instead turned their antenna straight towards the flying sparks, trying to catch them before it was there turn to burn.

Oh Sparkles!

Catra ran closer. She had to run past - and in some cases over - the tide of beetles, but they ignored her completely. Their full attention was on the magic leaking from the crying princess.

"Sparkles!" Catra shouted as she came closer, nearly getting a stun baton in her face for her trouble. Glimmer stared at her with large, glowing eyes, for a moment hardly seeming to realise who she was.

Then she dropped the stun baton with a sob.

"Catra!" she whimpered and threw herself around the neck of the other woman. Catra managed to catch her, balance her gear and swat away the closest beetle, all in one movement.

"It's OK, Sparkles," she whispered. "I'm here. Let's get out of here."

"They... just keep coming," Glimmer sobbed. Catra tried her best to manoeuvrer the cloak so it would cover more of Glimmer's skin, keep as much of the moonlight out as possible.

"Sssssh," Catra tried and added some tutting noises just in case. For whatever reason, that seemed to do the trick and Glimmer buried her face deeper in her fur as her ragged breathing became more steady. the beetles tried to amble closer, but without Glimmer actively discharging magic, their efforts became less urgent. Catra glanced at the stun baton on the ground, but it was completely burnt out. She drew her knife instead and slashed at the closest pair of antenna until its owner got the point.

"I thought... you... thought you wouldn't come back..." Glimmer sobbed.

Catra held her harder.

"Of course I came back," she whispered with gentle voice. "I won't leave you."

She realized she meant it.

She lifted Glimmer to her feet as gently as she could and guided her away from the battleground. She had to kick her way past the beetles. Most were still scrambling to get to the stun baton, but many of them also took an interest in Glimmer and had to be dissuaded.

"Try to keep it in for a few minutes, Sparkles," Catra hissed. To her immense relief Glimmer gave her an annoyed look.

"It's not as easy as I make it look," she hissed between gritted teeth.

Catra grinned at her.

"Isn't it now? And here I thought for a moment that I was talking to the mighty queen Sparklepants of Brightmoon."

She made a short pause for effect and to slash at another beetle, while Glimmer spluttered as she tried to shift her brain into the correct gear for an angry rebuttal. Before she managed to find one, Catra cut her off.

"Because I didn't think Queen Glimmer would let some space rocks or a bunch of insects be the boss of her."

Glimmer growled.

"You don't..." she began with venom in her voice and Catra gave her an appreciating grin and a gentle bump with her fist.

"That's the spirit, Sparkles. Now direct that anger where it belongs."

She flicked a telescopic baton so it unfolded and gave it to Glimmer. She looked her in the eyes.

"They're not the boss of you," she said.

Glimmer hesitated for a moment, fear and fatigue, anger and gratitude all competing for attention.

"They're not the boss of me," she repeated eventually with a growl. She gave the closest beetle a vicious blow. Catra nodded in appreciation.

"Damn right they're not."

She kicked away another beetle, and they kept walking. It took them a little while to get out of the thickest throng of the insects, but eventually they got to the ravine Catra had found. There were still beetles, but there were less of them and they were easier to ignore when they didn't come right at them.

Glimmer let out a sigh of relief as she found some shade from the moon, and that made Catra relax a little as well.

"Thanks," Glimmer said with unsteady voice without looking at Catra. There were tears in her eyes.

"Don't mention it," Catra drawled. "I'll give you a kick in the rear any time you need it."

Glimmer smiled. Suddenly both of them felt much better.

"Then you're in for the long haul, Kitten," she whispered.

"Wouldn't want it any other way," Catra shot back.

After that they walked in silence, both of them suddenly having complex feelings to ponder.

Chapter End Notes

Me and Catra both misses the simpler days of the Beast Island story. Sorry, Catra. That's not what we are doing this time.

The return of the Queen of the Crimson Waste

Chapter Notes

> Warning: Drowning, hardship, near-death, death, killing, brutal beatings and more "fun" with Glimmer's magic.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"I don't suppose you want any breakfast, Sparkles?"

"Let me guess, roasted snake?"

"Nope, the beetles got it all."

"Good, I was getting fed up with snake."

"Yeah, me too. Just wanted to spare your feelings."

"You don't care about my feelings, Catra. That's what I like about you."

The blatant falsehood of that statement dispersed over the sand dunes for a few moments. Neither of the women walking through the desert chose to comment on it.

"So... anything else?"

"Sand."

"I'm good, thanks."

"Thought so."

Walk, walk, walk.

"Any water?"

"Just a few gulps left."

"Well, that's something."

Catra glanced at Glimmer.

"I don't suppose you'd know a good spot to dig for more...?"

Glimmer shot Catra a sour look and made of a point of looking around in a theatrical fashion.

"Wow, no, there doesn't seem to be one right here. Too bad."

"Oh well, thanks for looking, Sparkles."

"Don't mention it, Kitten."

They trudged on.

A wind had started to blow, and was gaining in strength. The smooth sand were everywhere, and the longer they went on the harder it was to see where they were going.

Catra glanced at Glimmer who walked next to her with jaw clenched.

"I saw some more beetles when I scouted..." she opened.

Glimmer gave her an angry look and didn't answer.

"So, seems like they're drawn to your magic, huh?" Catra went on.

Glimmer went on not saying anything.

"Is that, like, a common thing, or...?"

"*No*," Glimmer snapped. "Princess magic is not usually known to summon *insects*."

"Hey," Catra said with forced light voice. "I'm raised on Horde propaganda, you know. Princesses summoning beetles would be perfectly in line with the stuff they told us."

She chuckled. Glimmer didn't.

"At least we know how to deal with it now," Catra went on. "Do your sparkly thing a bit before we stop the night, give them something to sniff for a bit away from where we sleep."

"Yes, I got it myself," Glimmer said between gritted teeth. Catra did a little apologizing gesture, and then neither of them said something for a little while.

The wind kept increasing in strength.

"Hey," Catra said after awhile. "You remember that time up in the frozen waste?"

"Good times," Glimmer growled, looking straight in front of her. "We should do it again some time."

"I'll pass, thanks," Catra shot back. "I got a cold that lasted for a week."

She mimed a sneeze, that actually made Glimmer smirk a little. Catra counted that as progress.

"We came back to the Fright Zone, Entrapta was completely lost in figuring out the tech we brought back and I naturally did the sensible thing and found myself a nook to tough out the cold in."

"Very sensible," Glimmer answered. If Catra noticed the sarcasm in her voice, she didn't comment on it.

"Thing is, Scorpia just wouldn't let it lie. She sniffed me out wherever I hid. She saw through all my excuses, and in the end I just shouted at her that I was sick. Do you know what she did?"

"No," Glimmer said, intrigued despite herself. "What did she do."

"She gave me *soup*," Catra exclaimed and shook her head. "I have no idea how she found the ingredients in the Fright Zone.

She probably roped Entrapta into it, because those little bowls were *tiny*."

Glimmer looked at her with a frown.

"Yes?"

Catra shrugged.

"Like, you would think she would make fun of me, or use it to her advantage, or at least blackmail me to keep me being vulnerable a secret, but instead she just... *took care* of me."

"I really can't see Scorpia do any of that stuff," Glimmer commented. Catra shrugged again.

"Of course not, she's an idiot. But you see where I'm getting with this? She... helped me. She had my back. She was in my corner. Even covered for me to Hordak at one point. I was back in the ring way faster than if I'd had to tough it out myself."

She looked expectantly at Glimmer, who walked in silence for a few steps with a thoughtful frown.

"You know," Glimmer said eventually, "When Adora first came to Brightmoon, I never knew when she pulled my leg with all the 'life in the Fright Zone is horrible' stuff. It took me awhile to realize that she never did."

Catra gave her a confused look.

"Yeah, the Fright Zone sucks and Adora is a lousy liar, what else is new?"

Glimmer sighed.

"Whenever I got sick, Bow would plop me down in a pile of pillows large enough for me to drown in, then he would feed me ten kinds of soup, three flavours of ice cream and read my

favourite books for me until I got fed up with being pampered and declared myself good to go again."

Catra gave her a bewildered look.

"I'll never come up with any insult to you that's more ridiculous than the truth, will I?"

Glimmer smirked.

"Probably not."

She grew serious again.

"Thing is, 'not trying to tough out the disease yourself' is not the amazing novel discovery you might think it is."

Catra shrugged.

"It sure was news for me. But I'm glad to hear you're onboard with the general idea..."

She let her voice trail off and looked hopefully at Glimmer.

After a few moments the princess snorted.

"So what? You want to hold my hand and feed me ice cream next time I bleed magic?"

"That would be nice," Catra answered with deadpan voice. "But I thought more like... Sparkles, you know you can talk to me, right?"

"You're not exactly known for shutting up," Glimmer answered drily, but Catra ignored the attempted deflection.

"What I mean is, I'm in your corner, Glimmer. You don't have to hide whatever weird shit is going on with your magic this day. If I can't help... hey, that's fair. My standard method for dealing with magic is hitting it, and that cure might be worse than the disease."

"Hey, you might be onto something there," Glimmer muttered, not meeting Catra's gaze.

"Yeah, so I'm not pretending to have any answers for you, but you can at least bounce stuff on me, and I can look suitably confused. Or like, if you need... something I could... get it for you?"

Catra's voice trailed off. She really didn't know how to handle this kind of stuff. For the millionth time she wished Scorpia was here.

Glimmer still didn't look at Catra. She was walking with her fists clenched and trying her best to keep in a sob.

Catra had no idea of it was a good sign or not.

"If nothing else, you don't have to hide it from me. You get that, right Sparkles? I... I want to help you, if I can. And if I can't... well, yeah, I can at least plop you in a pile of pillows and read you a bedtime story. Or not. Whatever. Just don't feel you have to tough it out yourself. The Fright Zone sucks, Sparkles. You don't have to emulate it."

Glimmer took a deep breath. She turned to Catra and did her best to blink away the tears in her eyes.

"It's awfully nice of you, Catra," she said with forced cheerful voice. "It really is. But you don't have to worry about me. This is just a temporary setback. As soon as I get a few good nights sleep and some time to get used to the... extra challenges, I'll be good to go again. I'm already getting much better."

Catra gave her a pleading look.

"Are you getting better, Glimmer? It sure didn't feel like that last night."

"I'm usually not under siege from *beetles*," Glimmer shot back, her voice getting more heated.

Catra sighed.

"Fine, sure. I just wish there were something I could do to help."

"Just get us out of this desert," Glimmer muttered with more venom than she had intended.

"Sparkles..." Catra begun with patient voice. As she spoke, she took another step, and then she was gone.

Glimmer stared in shock. She barely had time to register the startled and frightened look on Catra's face before the quicksand swallowed her, just leaving a few ripples behind.

Catra was *gone*.

Glimmer started moving before she made a conscious decision. Her fingers drew the circle as she ran, opening up connections she had been very determined to keep closed. She finished the spell the moment she dove into the pit, and magic poured into her. She desperately tried to stop herself from screaming, but as the magic surged through her she felt the sparks form and pour out from her eyes ears and mouth. Sand entered in the same speed, and she desperately tried not to get it down her throat.

She fumbled around until she felt Catra, who was frantically trying to get hold of something, anything. Her claws dug deep into Glimmer's arm and she couldn't stop herself from letting out a scream. She managed to teleport them out, and as Catra blinked in surprise and shock, Glimmer stumbled forward and threw up sand and bile and magic.

"Glimmer!" Catra screamed and looked in horror at the shining woman retching on the ground. Glimmer shook her head and fumbled to create another spell, to close the connections she had torn open.

It took her three attempts, and all the time magic kept pouring into her, grounding itself as light. But eventually she managed to form the circle, release the spell and close the connections.

The flow of magic ceased and Glimmer sank down on the ground, body still spasming from release of excess magic.

She felt Catra's strong hands lifting her, putting her in a stable position that prevented her airways from clogging. Then she felt the cold metal of a canteen to her lips.

She drank with grateful gulps, but all too soon the water was gone. She steadied her breathing, breath by breath, expelling excess magic a little at the time while Catra held her.

"Sparkles," Catra whispered with fear and pity in her voice. Glimmer pressed her face closer to Catra's stomach. She hurt all over. She just wanted to stay in this moment, where Catra held her and she didn't have to think and she didn't have to do anything.

Catra held her. She was shaking from her own shock. Seeing Glimmer in this state felt like a knife being twisted in her breast but there was nothing she could do to help her.

So she just held her, for a long, long time, while Glimmer's sobs slowly turned into regular breaths.

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The wind was still picking up. Catra wrapped the cloak around her to avoid being blistered by the sand. She half carried Glimmer, who was lifting her feet mechanically. The princess was still glowing by excess magic and occasionally a spasm was shaking her body. She didn't say anything, but she whimpered a few times, and every time Catra felt like she couldn't breath.

They had to get away. Find shelter. Find water. Keep a distance between themselves and the beetles, who would surely come sniffing now after Glimmer's latest light show.

Catra's throat hurt. She had not had any water since the day before. The quicksand had left her mouth dry as tinder. Glimmer was in worse shape than ever.

Quicksand.

Catra could kick herself. She should have been more careful. She should have seen the shift in the terrain. She shouldn't have had to be rescued like a cadet. But she just *had* to fall down that hole, and that had forced Glimmer to tear up whatever weird princess-wound she had fought so hard to keep closed, and now magic flowed out like blood.

Catra was a bit hazy on how Glimmer's connection to the magic of the world worked and the general mechanics of whatever Shadow Weaver had done to her, but she know that Glimmer was hurting, worse than ever.

And that it was Catra's fault.

She *should* have known better than falling into quicksand.

Slowly, one step at the time, they moved forward. The sand was stinging like biting insects. Every breath tore in her chest. Glimmer felt like she would fall down at any moment.

Shelter.

They had to get out of the storm.

Catra tried to remember her last good look at the terrain, before the sandstorm covered everything. There had been a rock formation slightly to the right of their path, hadn't it?

That was the direction they were walking now, right?

In her heart she knew there was just one chance in a thousand they were walking in the right direction.

She also knew it wouldn't matter, because even if they DID walk in the right direction, they would never make it there.

She made an angry growl. That was quitter's talk. She hadn't dragged her princess all the way out here to die from a little *wind*.

They would find the rocks. They would rest. They would find water, and if any oversized bug had anything to say about it Catra would be *happy* to field some little constructive criticism of her own.

She thought of the beetles descending on Glimmer, the princess' frantic efforts to keep them away, and the anger fuelled Catra to drag them on another ten or twenty steps.

Who did they think they were? Messing with *her* princess like that?

Who did Shadow Weaver think she was? Messing with Glimmer's magic?

Catra thought back to when she had fought with Glimmer in the warehouse. It had given her quite a shock, the princess showing up from nowhere, fists full of power, ready to *wreck* the place. She smiled at the memory.

She had been scared enough to jump out of her skin, but damn if it hadn't been hot. Proud, powerful, furious, passionate Glimmer, ready to give Catra her *undivided* attention.

She smirked.

Well, now she had it.

She knew from Double Trouble how insecure Glimmer had been about her position in Brightmoon. How people dismissed her, looked down on her, coddled her. The weak princess. The brittle Queen.

At the time, Catra had mostly filed it away for material for manipulation, but she could relate. No one (well... no one except one, but Catra forced her thoughts away from that memory) had ever valued Catra for more than what she could *do*, and most people thought preciously little of that. But Catra had clawed her way up. She had showed them.

And Hordak had snatched that away from her.

Just like Shadow Weaver had snatched Glimmer's magic away from her.

Glimmer's magic was a part of her. Part of her heritage, part of her identity, part of what made her Glimmer. She didn't *deserve* what Shadow Weaver had done to her. She shouldn't have to ration her sparks like a miser and force the magic out of her just because a crazy old witch had decided to mess with her source. She deserved better.

She deserved better than being stuck in a desert with Catra.

She deserved better than Catra.

Catra had forced her way forward the last few minutes, fuelled by anger on Glimmer's behalf, but now her steps faltered.

Well. It was true, but what else was new.

She forced herself to take another step.

If, by some miracle, they didn't die out here, if they managed to find there way back to civilization, if Glimmer managed to get her magic under control...

She would surely have better things to do than to hang out with a had-been mess of a catgirl. She'd have fancy princess friends and pretty archers and *Adora*.

Catra felt the familiar pains of rejection flow through her. She used it to push her legs another few steps.

Glimmer leaned more heavily on her now. Her breathing was steady, but heavy. Her eyes were closed. She just walked wherever Catra pointed her.

Trusting her.

Catra didn't *deserve* that trust.

Another step. Another jolt of pain.

But again, it was the truth.

Catra knew it, had known it all along.

Glimmer was... amazing. She was brave, she was beautiful, she was powerful, she took no shit, she had almost single-handedly rebuilt the princess alliance.

Catra held the stumbling princess a bit closer.

Oh yeah, and she smelled nice.

And Catra was a bad friend.

Step, step, step.

Suddenly the sand didn't feel as bad.

This wouldn't last. Of course. It *shouldn't* last. Glimmer deserved *better*.

Catra gritted her teeth.

She would make damned sure Glimmer GOT something better.

She wouldn't die here.

Glimmer should have her magic back, her revenge, her kingdom, her much better friends and her happily ever after.

Whoever she might have it with.

Catra snarled in fury as images of a tall woman with golden hair flowing in the wind danced before her eyes.

That image alone fuelled her for ten more steps.

Right.

If that was how it would be, then so be it.

And if Catra literately had to drag Glimmer through the desert to make it happen, than that was what she would do.

Maybe, just maybe, a *bad friend* was what Glimmer needed right now.

After all, none of her good friends were here to get the job done.

For a little time, whatever might come after, Glimmer was her to care for.

So she would.

For Glimmer.

For herself.

And for... another reason.

Catra managed a few more steps.

She never knew if it was she or the princess who stumbled first.

She only knew that they suddenly were on the ground.

That sand was covering them.

And that her entire body screamed at her to just... let go.

Close her eyes.

Sleep.

Don't have to worry about anything again.

Catra knew that if she gave in now, there was a very real chance she would never wake up again.

"Glimmer!" she hissed.

But the princess didn't answer.

Her breathing was shallow, her eyes were closed. Even her light emissions had died down. She was fast asleep.

Catra tugged at her arm, to no avail.

She couldn't carry Glimmer. Not when she could hardly stand on her feet herself.

Right.

So this had to do for shelter. If they got covered with sand they would be out of the way for the wind. That was just logic.

Water...

Maybe Glimmer could find water when she woke up?

If she woke up.

Catra shivered. She propped up their cloaks as well as she could, try to create as large of an air pocket as possible as the sand piled up.

Then she laid down next to Glimmer, shielding her face with her body as well as she could.

The darkness took her almost immediately.

Sorry, Adora. I kept her as safe as I could. Turns out I'm not very good at this either.

- - -

Catra woke up.

Glimmer was still breathing.

Everything was dark. Everything hurt.

She managed to crawl out from the sand that had piled over them. She gasped for air.

The sand storm had ceased. The sun was setting.

A few more hours, and then the moons would be up.

"Glimmer," she whispered between cracked lips, but the princess didn't move. Catra tried shaking her, but to no avail.

Water.

She desperately needed water.

She tried standing up, but her legs failed her almost immediately.

She should stay with Glimmer.

But she couldn't.

Not if they were to have any chance.

Catra started crawling. One step at the time, slowly moving further away from the princess.

Part of her protested. Told her she should stay with Glimmer.

But another part nagged her about that thing she had seen. That thing that she even without consciously making the decisions she had start crawling towards.

A plume of dust.

People travelling through the desert.

People with water.

She crawled another step.

Presumably she would have to do something to get the water from the people kicking up the plume. Preferably she should have some kind of plan.

But right now, that was far too complicated. Just keep crawling, that was the ticket.

Get to the people, get water, save Gimmer. Solid plan right there. She could sort out the details down the line.

She just had to get to them.

One step at the time, she crawled over the dunes. For every step she just focused on the next.

She could do this.

Simple. Manageable. Small chunks.

It took her a little while to take in when things changed. When the distant and slowly growing noise of voices and people moving were not so distant any longer.

When the ground trembled from footsteps very close.

When her field of vision were not filled by sand any longer, but by a pair of sturdy boots.

Catra stared at them in confusion. They blocked her path. She could not keep crawling.

Boots... boots suggested people.

People suggested water.

Right.

Time for step two.

She followed the boots with her eyes to a pair of legs. She followed them upwards.

She recoiled from a blow that struck her face and would have caused her mouth to bleed, were it enough water left in her for more than a trickle.

"Well, well, well," a rough voice cackled. "Look what the cat dragged in."

"She's alone," another voice protested. "She should have the princess with her."

"Just follow her trail," the first voice said. "Call in the other team use the magic detectors. She probably has her tucked away somewhere. But we'll find her."

A grinning, scaled face entered Catra's field of vision. She vaguely recognized it even if she couldn't put a name to it right now.

"And then we will be handsomely rewarded by the Shadow Queen of Brightmoon," the face leered. "We have to thank you for delivering her to us, Catra."

"You know her?" Another voice said, and the first voice laughed.

"Know her? I used to *serve* her. This is the woman who took out Tung Lashor and took over my old gang. Haven't you heard?" the mocking voice said. "'Catra is the strongest in the Crimson Waste'."

The bandit aimed a heavy kick at Catra's side, and in her current state she had no hope of evading it. She sank wheezing to the ground.

"Not so strong any longer, are you?" the voice smugly said.

"Water," Catra croaked, her brain not entirely up to speed with current events but not willing to let go of the plan just yet. The bandit looked at her in mock concern.

"What was that? The mighty Catra suddenly has a need for this lowly gang member." She laughed. "Of course you'll have water,

Catra."

She hooked her canteen from the belt. She opened it. With contempt she tossed it to the ground, just out of reach for Catra.

Catra made a strangled little sound as she watched the glittering liquid pour out and disappear into the sand. She tried to get her limbs under control, tried to crawl closer. She managed to roll slightly to the side when the bandit aimed a kick at her, catching the boot on her arm rather than with her stomach.

"Poor kitty," the bandit taunted. "So close, yet so far away."

She aimed another kick. This time Catra couldn't avoid it.

- - -

Rough ropes tied Catra's arms together. Her feet were tied in a similar fashion, leaving her just enough leeway to walk with short steps. She was bruised and hurt and her throat felt like she was still in the quicksand.

But she was alive and she was conscious, if just barely.

The other end of the rope around her wrists was tied to a vehicle, an old Horde service bot if her eyes didn't deceive her, that slowly trudged forward. She looked around.

Ten or fifteen bandits, all armed, all with the hardened demeanours life in the Crimson Waste demanded.

The bots movements forced Catra to keep walking, and she felt a tug in the rope around her waist. She glanced backwards.

Glimmer walked behind her, beaten, barely conscious and tied up in a similar fashion as Catra with the rope from her wrists tied to Catra's waist.

"Glimmer," Catra croaked. Glimmer tried to seek her gaze, but was too tired to speak.

Something started to boil, deep in Catra's chest.

The bandit leader - a serpentile looking woman with sharp teeth who Catra vaguely remembered from Tung Lashor's gang but never had bothered learning the name of - sauntered up to her.

"My, my, my how the tables have turned," she leered. Her grin widened as Catra sourly turned away her gaze.

"Not in the mood for any speeches, Catra? Such a shame. I heard a good speech, once. Just when you took my jacket, in fact."

She winked and gestured to the other bandits to walk closer.

"It said that you can't threaten those with nothing to loose... What do you say, Catra? Do you have something to loose?" She tugged in the rope connecting Catra and Glimmer, causing the princess to stumble to the ground. The bandits laughed.

It felt like Catra's chest could not contain the boiling feeling. It started to move into her limbs and up her throat.

"Ooooh, that touched a nerve," the bandit smirked as she heard Catra's growl. "Don't you worry about a thing. I'm sure the Shadow Queen will take good care of her."

"If you like speeches so much I also heard a good one, once," an unsteady - but still defiant - voice interrupted. It took Catra a moment to realize that it was Glimmer who was speaking, forcing herself up from the ground.

"Last time I was here," Glimmer croaked, "I heard there were two rules to Crimson Waste. The strong makes the rules, and don't disturb Huntara when she eats." She looked the bandit leader in the eyes. "What do you think of the second one?"

"Huntara is not here," the bandit leader growled.

Glimmer got to her feet. She wobbled for a moment, but she stood.

"But I am," she said with venom in her voice.

"Glimmer, No!" Catra gasped as she saw Glimmer's eyes starting to glow.

The bandits had seen it too, and one of them hit her hard in the stomach with her stick. Glimmer stumbled forward, and whatever magic she had assembled poured out of her together with her stomach content as she threw up. The bandit gave her another hard blow, right across her face. Glimmer collapsed with a cry of pain.

"Doesn't look so dangerous," the bandit leader commented.

"Don't let it fool you," another countered and gave Glimmer vicious kick, causing her to roll up to a ball in a feeble attempt to protect herself. Magic still leaked out of her and she sobbed helplessly. "We learnt about princesses and their tricks in the Horde."

"Yeah," another said. "You take your eyes off them for just a moment and they can do all sorts of things."

She unsheeted an efficient looking dagger and pressed it to Glimmer's throat. Glimmer feebly tried to move away, but she had no control over her body.

"The Shadow Queen will pay us for the head of the princess, she didn't say anything about it still being attached to her body. I say we just cut her throat and..."

And then, the bandit died.

The rest of the bandits watched in horror as the body fell forward, eyes empty. Half her throat was ripped off, blood pumped out and disappeared in the dessert sand.

There were, of course, events spanning those two points in time, casually connecting the past with the present.

There were a snarl in animal fury. There were ropes snapping, there were weapons hastily drawn, there were a large number of bandits suddenly realizing just how hard it is to hit someone capable of moving through a battle in such high speed as Catra with so low concern for her own safety as Catra and how hard it is to coordinate with those who - supposedly - are on your own side when everything is chaos and blades and claws and fists are everywhere and how hard it is to motivate yourself to stand between someone as capable in the arts of destruction as Catra and someone she seriously, *insistently* wants dead.

In the end, those inevitable links in the causality chain do perhaps not matter as much as the causality itself, the pairing between cause and effect, action and outcome. The fact of the matter is that someone threatened Glimmer, and then Catra stood over her dead body, claws dripping with blood, throat growling in animal fury, narrow eyes moving from face to face to decide who would be next. The rest of the bandits - several of them bleeding from cuts of their own, one of them holding his palm pressed towards his bleeding face - watched her in frozen fear.

There were moral lessons the be learnt there, and the bandits of Crimson Waste were quick studies.

No one moved. Even Glimmer, who felt sick in her soul watching the carnage, didn't breath.

There were a dozen of them and just one of Catra. She was hurt, dehydrated and unarmed (if you disregarded her claws and fangs, which no one present felt any inclination to do). They could probably take her, right?

As long as someone made the first move.

Someone *else*.

She could only kill one or two of them, before the rest of them could overpower her.

Right?

Catra's demeanour was not of someone trapped, looking for a way out.

It was not of someone deciding whether or not she should kill someone.

It was not even the demeanour of someone who had made up her mind to kill someone, and now tried to decide on who.

It was of someone fully prepared to kill *everyone* hesitating only over who to kill *first*.

And who was happy to take suggestions.

No one moved.

Catra's muscles shifted. Her eyes locked on one of the bandits who had hit Glimmer. Her fangs slowly formed a horrible grin. Glimmer tried to get up on her feet, tried to get in between Catra and her assigned victim.

Then one of the bandits - a survivor of multiple gangs and just, as the gang leader, an alumni of the Tung Lashor fame - very carefully put their knife down. They gave the people next to them a quick glance - silently pleading to them to be smart for once - and slowly, uncertainly started the chant that maybe - just maybe - would save their life.

"Catra... Catra... Catra..."

Catra hesitated.

The other bandits picked up on it. More weapons were thrown on the ground. The gang leader looked around in panic, her closest gang of thugs forming a more and more desperate ring of protection. In the span of a few seconds she saw the mathematics of the situation change to an equation that was way beyond her calculus skill indeed.

She swallowed and added her sword to the pile on the ground. Her thugs quickly followed suit.

"Catra! Catra! Catra!"

Catra, still crouching over the dead body, claws still out, throat still snarling with fury, took in the situation. She slowly stood up and unfolded a hand covered with other people's blood. She pointed at Glimmer, her missing finger only making the gesture more effective.

"*Mine!*" she snarled, fangs putting emphasis on the statement. She glanced pointedly downwards, at the body.

They got the message. Loud and clear.

Catra pointed at the bandit who had been first to drop their weapons. They flinched.

"You. Untie her. You!" she pointed at the former gang leader with her mutilated hand. "Come here."

The former gang leader swallowed. Every eye was on her and she knew had very few options left that wouldn't end with her immediate death. Slowly she walked over to Catra, stopping just one step away. She had seen Catra leap and did not think for a moment that mere distance would save her.

She sunk down on her knee.

"Catra is the strongest in the Crimson Waste," she said with loud, somewhat shrill voice. Catra's stance changed subtly, from fighting to commanding. The former gang leader dared to breath. Trembling, she held up her canteen.

Catra took it.

She drank. Slowly, deliberately. The bandits watched her, transfixed. No one moved. No one dared to break the silence.

Catra lowered the canteen. Her gaze returned to the leader who was still kneeling in front of her. After a thoughtful moment, a wicked smile emerged on Catra's lips. She nodded at the trembling woman at her feet.

The former gang leader - current gang lieutenant - dared a breath. Then she stood up and turned to those who until five minutes ago had sworn her allegiance.

"Who is strongest in Crimson Waste?" she bellowed.

"Catra!" Came the roared answer, all uncertainty gone. Things had been sorted out, good and proper, according to principles and laws well known to everyone present.

"Who do you fight for?"

"Catra!"

"Who do you die for?"

"Catra!"

"Who is the boss?"

"CATRA!"

And just for good measure, and because it in times of transition always pays to stay in the good graces of the new management, the lieutenant added:

"What happens to anyone coming for the princess?"

"THEY DIE!"

Catra smirked, and more than one of the bandits breathed out. They too knew the growth pains sometimes felt during administrative renegotiations.

The hastily untied Glimmer hurried up to her, clutching the canteen she had been given by a bandit with an eye for current

affairs.

"Catra!" she gasped. "What..." Catra gave her a smile full of pride and smug satisfaction.

"We're bandits now, Sparkles."

"Bandits?"

"Sure," Catra drawled. "I thought we could use a hand through the desert, and I know an overachiever like you would want to go the extra mile."

She spoke up to the rest of the assembly.

"All right! You sad lot bring us back to camp and get us something to eat. Then I want *you*," -a nod to the lieutenant- "to bring me the five least worthless scum of these losers. We have lots of planning to do if we are to re-take the Waste from the Horde."

She gave Glimmer a direct look.

"We tried laying low and they still came for us. This time we're doing things *my* way."

"You heard her, folks," the lieutenant bellowed. "The Queen of the Crimson Waste is back!"

Chapter End Notes

> And this concludes the second act. I will start uploading Act 3 - Queens of the Crimson Waste in January 2022.
>
> In the meanwhile, please enjoy this tumblr exclusive interview with the cast: https://baggebythesea.tumblr.com/post/667038794075275264/catra-and-glimmer-queens-of-the-horde-behind

Act Three - Queens of the Crimson Waste

Chapter Notes

With thanks to The_Frank for help and never ending support.

Awesome art commissioned from Lorvikk.

See the end of the chapter for more notes



"Welcome, welcome," Double Trouble drawls from their spot in the middle of the stage.

"I hope you all had something to eat and drink during the act break," they continue, "because we are now getting into the *meat*

of the story."

To illustrate their point they make an exaggerated chewing motion.

"As I'm sure you all recall," they go on, "we were leaving our protagonists just as things were heating up. Glimmer, collapsing under the weight of hardship and metaphoric responsibility, bandits closing in and Catra *losing it*."

Double Trouble's head morph into that of Catra and they stare at the audience in downright hostility.

"Touch *my* princess and *die*," they snarl with Catra's voice.

"See!" Double Trouble happily says and retake their own form. "Protective, possessive, absolutely deadly." They sigh dreamily. "Being in love suits her."

They take a step forward and make a dramatic gesture.

"But all is not lovely-dovey in princess-land. Hordak is still hunting for our happy couple. Shadow Weaver is plotting, and who knows what more dangers the desert will spit out?"

They leer.

"Why, it seems like we will have our plate full in our upcoming installment of this fine tale."

"So please," they say with loud voice, raising their hands towards the heavens, "welcome our heroines for act three: Queens of the Crimson Waste."

They take a quick step to the side of the stage and looks straight at the audience.

"To be updated weekly. Artwork commissioned from Lorvikk (link in notes)."

They slip off the stage as the curtains go up, revealing the inside of a tent, Glimmer sleeping in a bed covered with expensive looking blankets, pillows and comforters.

Chapter End Notes

So excited to be back!

Breakfast with bandits

Chapter Notes

> Warning: This act will contain a prolonged focus on brutality and powerplay. There will be violence, fighting and cruelty. There will also be more problem with Glimmer's magic and some horror elements. This chapter, however, mostly contains some nausea.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Breakfast, Sparkles!"

Glimmer sat up in the bed, fighting back a wave of nausea. She looked in wonder, and just a bit of non-comprehension, at the multitude of plates, bowls, jugs and jars that surrounded her, loaded with dishes and delicacies no one would have thought one would find at any one place in the world outside the royal courts, least of all a bandit camp in the Crimson Waste.

Catra sauntered in, leaned against a trunk, and in the process almost knocked down the bowl of grapes that stood on it. She picked one.

"I didn't know what your highness would fancy, so I had the gals bring you a bit of everything," she said, eyes twinkling.

Glimmer stared at her.

Catra was... stunning. Gone was the desperate, haggard creature she had been on the run with for the last several weeks. In her place stood a well dressed, well equipped and completely awe-inspiring bandit chieftain.

She had a red top with a stylized drawing of her mask on it. Over it she wore a leather jacket with the same symbol on the back. Around her neck was a purple scarf loosely tied (same colour as Glimmer's top, she noticed not without appreciation). She had

several belts, each with a more elaborate buckle than the last. In them hung a whip and a short dagger. The stump of her missing finger was covered with a red piece of leather, protecting the wound while also drawing attention to it. The mask she wore on her face was polished until it gleamed.

"Like my new outfit, do you?" Catra said, clearly enjoying the attention. "Just a little something I picked up. Gotta dress for the job, you know."

"Come over here and I will show you just how much I like it," Glimmer smirked. Catra laughed and walked over to Glimmer. She posed a moment to allow Glimmer to admire her, then she plopped down on her bed.

"My, someone IS feeling better."

"I think I do, actually," Glimmer said, genuine surprise in her voice. "How long have I...?"

"More than a week," Catra promptly answered. "You had quite a bit of sleep to catch up on. You've been up a few times, but I'm not sure how much you remember. You've been pretty out of it."

Glimmer breathed. A long, shivering breath.

She looked at Catra with an expression both thoughtful and grateful.

"You kept me safe for a week?" she asked, voice wavering slightly.

"Oh, I did a great deal more than that," Catra said, and an edge crept into her voice.

"Shadow Weaver put the word out, put quite the bounty on your pretty little head, and the gals were out to collect." She smirked. "They were under the impression that picking a fight with you would be easy money. I put them out of that misconception."

Glimmer stared at her.

"There were others," Catra went on. "Bandits and bounty hunters and opportunists. Some of them have come sniffing and I put them down. Others are still lurking out there. The gals know how to welcome them, should they try something."

"Catra..." Glimmer whispered.

Catra sat down by her side.

She took her hand.

"Glimmer," she said with soft voice. "Back there, with the quicksand... I thought..."

She sighed.

"I can't help you with your magic, Glimmer. I can't give you back what the witch took from you.

Her eyes gleamed.

"But I *can* beat up any asshole that tries to pick a fight with you while you sort that out. And I *will*. And if it takes an army to keep you safe, with both Hordak and Shadow Weaver breathing down your neck, then I will gather that army for you." She held out her hand, indicating the tent. "Believe you me, this is just the beginning."

"Catra..."

Glimmer's eyes were very large, very wet.

Catra squeezed her hand and stood up. She grinned at Glimmer.

"Don't fret, Sparkles," she laughed. "You're cute when you're flustered. I'm just glad you're back in the world of the living."

"Yeah..." Glimmer said, still a bit overwhelmed. "I'm..." She had to take a sharp breath to prevent herself from throwing up. "I'm... still a bit..."

"I can tell," Catra said with compassionate voice. "You look like shit."

"Ever the romantic," Glimmer muttered. She held up a hand. Sparks danced over it. "I've also seem to have quite a bit of magic pent up."

She shuddered as another wave of nausea passed through her.

"Yeah, you should probably do something about that before you have another overflow," Catra agreed. "Don't worry about the beetles. I've given the gals standing order to kill them off if they come sniffing."

"And what if someone picks us up on a detector?" Glimmer remarked as she started to prepare a magical circle.

"Oh, they already know where we are," Catra laughed. "The Queen is back, remember? By now every asshole in the Crimson Waste knows where to find us, should they wish to come knocking. I promise both Hordak and Shadow Weaver have got the memo by now. too."

Glimmer raised an eyebrow.

"And that's not a problem?"

Catra grinned.

"Oh, it will *absolutely* be a problem."

Glimmer took a deep breath.

"Catra..." she begun. "Back out there in the desert..."

Running steps were heard outside the tent. They stopped just outside the opening, and then there was a moment of silence, as if the person outside had to take a moment to compose themselves before entering.

Catra caught Glimmer's eye and grinned.

"Um... boss?" A respectful voice said. "Can I... come in?"

"Why of course," Catra drawled. "The princess is *thrilled* to have company."

"I have a name, you know," Glimmer said.

The serpentile lieutenant entered. She gave glimmer a quick glance, blushing slightly, and then promptly turned to look at Catra.

"Sorry to disturb you and your... um... the princess, boss," she said.

"Name's Glimmer, actually," Glimmer said.

The lieutenant glanced at her again and did a quick nod.

"Sorry ma'am. No disrespect meant."

"I'm sure you had only the *best* of reasons to barge in," Catra said, still with a wide grin. "Didn't you, Slither?"

The lieutenant swallowed.

"Of course boss," she quickly said. "You told me you wanted to know the minute we spotted the Sand Venom gang and... well, we just saw them. They'll be here in a few minutes

"Really?" Catra said, eyes sparkling. "Well, we better go out and great them, then. We wouldn't want to be bad hosts, would we?"

"Um... no, boss?" the lieutenant tried.

Catra laughed.

"That was rhetorical. Why don't you send someone to make sure the princess has what she needs and make sure she stays in the bed. We wouldn't want her to strain herself, the poor thing."

Glimmer made an indignant sound, but before she had time to make a proper rebuttal, Catra turned to her with a wide smirk.

"Sorry, Sparkles. We'll have to pick up our conversation later. Work, work, work. Apparently there's some wanna be tough guy here to cause *trouble*." Her eyes became hard. "I aim to show them that anyone who comes here looking for it will get it. A whole lot of it. Later, princess."

And she left with the lieutenant in tow.

"It's *Glimmer*!" Glimmer protested.

She plopped back in her bed with a grunt. After a few moments she sat up again and finished her magic circle. Magic flowed out of her in a steady stream, lighting up the interior of the tent in a soft, warm glow.

She sat like that for quite awhile, alone with her thoughts, slowly but surely draining herself of excess magic.

Her entire body hurt. She felt dehydrated and nauseas.

Her magic felt sticky as it drained into the circle.

She wondered how long she would have to wait for Catra to come back.

Eventually, as she was beginning to feel the fatigue creep up on her again, a roar of cheering was heard from the outside, and then, as on a given signal, multiple voices began their chant.

"Catra, Catra, Catra..."

Glimmer frowned in thought.

Chapter End Notes

I'm sure it's fine.

Jack

Chapter Notes

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

Warning: Trouble with magic, recovery from hardship, brutality and other "fun" war and gang-stuff.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Horde flag waved over Salineas.

In Brightmoon, shadows boiled from the moonstone.

Desperate refugees fled as well as they could, begging for help that didn't come.

The princesses had abandoned them.

The sun filtered in through the tent canvas.

The air was dry.

Glimmer laid on her back looking up at the tent canvas, feeling nauseas.

She wasn't quite sure where her dreams had stopped and reality had begun, her waking up had been such a slow, gradual process.

It was not that she had much she had to wake up to. Being awake in the tent was only marginally more comfortable than being asleep in the tent.

At least the nightmares kept sleep from being dull.

She shuddered, the last, half-forgotten dream-images of burning cities and screaming citizens faded away. No matter, she would return to it next time she fell asleep.

She didn't know for how long she had slept. She didn't know if it was still the same day as last time she was awake.

It was like if her body, once given the opportunity to rest, had seised on it with a vengeance. That all sorts of healing processes put on hold while she and Catra was on the run now had demanded top priority.

She tried sitting up, but a pang of nausea immediately hit her. She forced her jaw shut and laid down again.

A gasp was heard. Glimmer turned her head and saw one of the bandits, a few years younger than herself, staring at her with large, frightened eyes. They were dressed in the same 'whatever you can steal' fashion as the rest of the bandits and had fine fur covering most of their body and two large rabbit ears tied back in a string. They held a tray.

"Hello," Glimmer tried saying, but her mouth was too dry to form sounds. She got just a croak for her trouble.

The bandit paled and took a quick step backwards. They glanced at the tent flap, but then at the tray in their hands.

Glimmer tried a friendly smile, but halfway through it turned to a grimace of pain. The bandit's eyes grew wider. Finally, having worked up their courage, they dashed forward, placed the tray next to Glimmer with a rattle of cutlery and ran back towards the tent flap.

"Wait!" Glimmer whispered, but by then the bandit had already left her alone again.

Glimmer sighed.

The tray was full of the kind of extravagant dishes she had come to expect by now. She could only imagine how Catra managed to bully the bandits to whip this up in the middle of a desert.

She just hoped she would be able to keep some of it down this time.

She lifted a bowl with some creamy-looking content that smelt a bit sour and tried it on her tongue. She felt a convulsion in her stomach, but nothing worse than that. She braved a tiny spoon and then sank down on her bed as she waited for the nausea to subside enough for her to try another spoon.

Everything had been so frantic these last few weeks. Even the dull parts in the desert had had a sense of urgency over them, had contained the constant need to force herself to perform. Just another step. Just another day.

Now she had time to rest. To relax. To think.

She shuddered.

Not happy with being idle, her brain made pictures out of the spots in the tent canvas.

Pictures of a smiling man, confident and friendly. Of a tall woman, passionate and brave.

Glimmer forced her eyes shut, but the images of Adora and Bow kept dancing in front of her eyes.

She had betrayed them. She had lost them.

She might just as well have killed them.

The bandit that gave her the tray had looked so young.

Glimmer wondered if Frosta was still alive.

Eventually she fell into an uneasy slumber. Turns out, her nightmares were no worse when she was sleeping than when she was awake.

- - -

The next morning, the bandit bringing her tray was a bit more brave, daring to meet Glimmer's gaze as they entered the tent.

"Um, good morning, your highness! I... I bring breakfast."

Glimmer tried a friendly smile, and managed to keep the pain in check.

"Thank you so much," she whispered, maybe a bit more desperation in her voice than she first had intended.

It had been such a long time since she spoke to someone else than Catra.

The bandit hesitated, and Glimmer dared trying to sit up. A wave of nausea hit her, but she fought it down.

She took a deep breath and gave the bandit another smile.

"Please," she whispered. "Stay a little while."

The bandit gave her a scared look, but they didn't move away.

They slowly took a step forward with the tray.

"You don't have to be afraid of me," Glimmer said.

The bandit paled somewhat, but kept walking. They put the tray down and took a few quick steps back.

"See, I didn't bite," Glimmer smiled.

"Sorry..." the bandit blushed.

Unbidden, Glimmer felt a laugh bubbling up at the simply humanity in the bandit's reaction, but she realized too late it was a bad idea. She had to force her mouth and eyes shut to stop her head spinning, and it felt like she was going to puke. Tears emerged from her eyes, sparkling with magic.

The bandit gasped and took several steps backwards, stumbling on a chest as they did. They fell to the ground with a crash.

"Are you...?" Glimmer begun, but as she opened her mouth a wave of magic welled up, lighting up her skin, her eyes, her mouth.

The bandit made a frightened sound and turned and ran out of the tent.

Glimmer took a deep breath, forced the magic under control.

This was getting unbearable.

Something had to be done.

- - -

She had slept again, she didn't know for how long. Presumably it was the next day.

Maybe it had been several days.

She had vague memories of Catra leaning in, for just a moment, kissing her on the cheek, but when she looked up, Catra wasn't there.

Maybe it had just been a dream.

This time Glimmer decided to empty herself of magic before the bandit came with her breakfast tray. She sat up in bed and made a circle and - in what was now a familiar ritual - forced the magic out. She worked in rhythm with her breaths, breathing out, forcing magic out, breathing in, forcing magic out.

When the tent flap opened she had expelled enough magic for the nausea to be more of a nuisance than a constant threat of sickness.

She turned to the flap and smiled.

"It's OK, Glimmer said with calm voice, only slightly hampered by the pain flowing through her together with the magic. "It's just light. Pretty to look at but not dangerous... come in," she added when the teenager seemed hesitant to do so by their own accord.

The bandit took a few, slow steps further into the tent, not taking their eyes off Glimmer. They looked like they were ready to bolt at any moment.

"Catra told you to look after me, did she?" Glimmer asked.

The bandit nodded.

"The Queen sent me to... tend to your needs," they said with frightened voice.

"How generous of her," Glimmer answered.

The teenager fidgeted a bit with the tray.

"She has been really worried for you," they volunteered after a moment, still keeping their distance. "She's really had us do everything we could to make you comfortable as you recovered."

"That's so sweet of her," Glimmer said with a strained smile. "And just where *is* the queen?"

"Oh..." the bandit said with a blush. "Sorry. There was a morning raid. Catra went out to sort it out."

"And no one saw fit to tell me about it?" Glimmer asked.

"She... asked me to make you breakfast?" the bandit said, voice a bit uncertain.

"It was very kind of you," Glimmer said, just the tiniest hints of sarcasm in her voice.

She thought for a moment, then she gave the bandit a direct look.

"Well, it seems like I'm not going anywhere for a little while, and it seems you are stuck with me, so we might as well get to know each other."

The bandit gave her a scared look.

"You don't know me," Glimmer said with soft voice. "You have seen my magic out of control. You have seen people die on my behalf. You have every reason to be afraid of me."

She looked the teenager in the eyes.

"But please believe me when I say that I am scared too. I am weak. I am sick. I know no one here except for Catra and just a few weeks ago I had a knife to my throat."

She tried a smile again.

"Please, stay. Just a little while. I promise I won't hurt you."

The teenager did not look less scared.

But they did step a bit closer.

Glimmer patted her bedroll.

"Come and sit here and tell me of who you might be. What's your name?"

The bandit didn't sit down. They stood in front of her, a bit awkward. Glimmer watched them with interest.

"It's Jack," they muttered when the silence became too much. They put the tray down in front of Glimmer.

"That's a pretty name," Glimmer smiled, a bit more friendly. "I'm Glimmer, but I suppose you already knew that."

Jack nodded.

"Did you pick the name yourself?" Glimmer asked.

"I did, actually," Jack said, a bit defiantly. "It's short for Jackrabbit, because I'm fast like one..." They gave Glimmer a direct look. "In the Waste, all you got is what you take by yourself. I figured a name wouldn't be any different."

Glimmer smiled, and this time she got a quick smile in return from the rabbit-person for her troubles.

"So that means you have another name, then?" Glimmer asked.

"No," Jack replied with level voice. "It means I *had* another name."

Glimmer met her gaze and nodded slightly. Jack relaxed.

"Understood, Jack." Glimmer answered. "Now tell me, how does a girl your age end up in the Crimson Waste."

"Not a girl," Jack said with the same level voice as before, suggesting this was not the first time they had to say those exact words. "I go by 'they'."

"Apologies, Jack," Glimmer answered and lowered her head slightly. "How does a *person* your age end up in the Crimson Waste?"

Jack hesitated a little, but Glimmer's friendly smile seemed to mollify them.

"Someone my age didn't," Jack said eventually. "A much younger kid travelled to one of the surrounding villages with their aunt when their old home was destroyed by the Horde. When the war drew closer, they saw fit to not wait for it this time around." They shrugged a little. "Life in the Waste is hard, but it is a life. I've got a place in the gang, I'm learning, one day I will have a shot with one of the big players."

Glimmer nodded, thoughtfully.

"I see there is a lot I yet have to learn about this place," she said.

"I mean, if you have any questions..." Jack volunteered.

Glimmer grinned.

"I do actually. I want to know how Catra came to take over a bandit camp in just a few weeks."

Jack gave her a surprised look.

"She didn't. She took over the gang in one minute. You were there."

Glimmer mulled over this.

"You're telling me she beat up your former leader, and everyone just rolled over and accepted it?"

"Of course," Jack answered. "Why wouldn't we?"

"What about loyalty?" Glimmer blurted out.

Jack gave her a strange look.

"To Slither? The gang didn't belong to her any more than it belongs to me. The gang belongs to itself. She was the one doing the best job running it - until Queen Catra came along."

"I see..." Glimmer said slowly. "And if anyone were to beat 'Queen Catra'?"

Jack raised an eyebrow.

"You think anyone can?"

Glimmer smirked.

"Not likely, honestly. I think you've got yourself a keeper."

"That's what the rest of us figure too," Jack answered. Their voice grow hard. "And Queen Catra is doing what no one has done since Huntara left the Waste."

"And what is that?" Glimmer asked.

"She's sticking it to the Horde," Jack answered, a gleam in their eyes.

Glimmer nodded thoughtfully.

"How exactly?" she asked.

"She's showing them who's the boss," they proudly said.

Glimmer raised an eyebrow.

"Showing who?"

"*Everyone*!" Jack answered. They chuckled slightly at Glimmer's quizzical look.

"Our little band... we were just small fry," they explained. "Picking up the scraps the larger gangs left behind, running business they felt beneath them. And then, all of sudden, Queen Catra takes over."

Glimmer couldn't help smile as Jack's voice became more animated and they started to gesticulate as they talked.

"We all thought she would just kick us around a few times and then move on, but no - she's sticking with us. She had us seek out one of the other gangs, and then she beat the leader up and told the rest to either join or get out of her sight. Half of them signed up!"

"You're in favour then?" Glimmer asked, slightly surprised. "She just came out of nowhere and took over your gang?"

"She's making it better," Jack said without hesitation. "She's making us stronger. Soon, no one will be able to push us around."

"I didn't see it like that," Glimmer mused. "What about your freedom?"

"Freedom to do what?" Jack scoffed. "Starve? Run away from anyone who looks at us the wrong way? Anyone who wants to live that life is free to do so, all you have to do is walk out in the desert and keep walking."

They sighed.

"Freedom is plentiful in the Crimson Waste. *Power*, now that's rare. And Catra *is* power."

"So she is," Glimmer agreed.

They shared a look. Glimmer couldn't help smirking at what she saw in Jack's expression.

"She's also *really* good looking in that leather jacket," Glimmer casually said. She laughed as Jack started to blush furiously.

"I'm new here, Jack," she said with soft voice. "I don't know the rules. I don't know the land. I need a friend. Do you want to be that friend?"

"Um... of course," Jack answered.

Glimmer smiled.

"Is there anything you want to ask *me*, friend?" she said

Jack hesitated.

"It's OK," Glimmer prompted.

"Is... is it true what they say about you and the queen?" Jack asked.

Glimmer arched an eyebrow.

"And what *is* it they say."

Jack's blush told her everything she needed to know.

"Let's just say, I *really* like that jacket," Glimmer said and blinked at Jack. She was rewarded with another blush.

Catra entered the tent (looking hot in her jacket), steps full of swagger. She had a long gash in the clothes, over her chest, and blood on her claws and fur, but her eyes sparkled.

"Sorry for leaving you to wake up on your own, Sparkles," she drawled. "Some assholes came knocking and you looked so cute when you snored, so I let you sleep in."

"My queen has been victorious, then?" Glimmer said with a hint of a resentment in her voice.

Catra grinned at her.

"As seen from the fact that I'm returning at all," she answered. Voice light but words serious. She stepped up to Glimmer and they exchanged a long kiss, communicating far more than their words.

Jack looked away, a tad embarrassed.

Catra let go of Glimmer and looked at them with a smile.

"I see you met Jack," she said with fond voice. "Aren't they something special."

"They are good company," Glimmer answered.

Catra reached out a hand and fondly scratched Jack behind an ear. Jack leaned in to her touch with a shy smile.

"I think they'll go far. They remind me a bit of me as a kid," she said.

"That's high recommendation, I'm sure," Glimmer said with dry voice.

"Of course it is! Just look how I turned out," Catra laughed. "Now, come with me, Jack, we got some new gang members to introduce, and I want you there. There's a guard outside the tent, Sparkles. Just holler if you need anything."

"See you later, Glimmer," Jack said as they left the tent together with Catra.

"I'll just stay here, then," Glimmer said to the empty tent.

She sat down on her bed with a very unqueenly harrumph.

Flies crawled lazily on the tent canvas.

There were sand everywhere, and despite her being out of the sun, the heat was overwhelming.

She also felt a familiar pressured in her eyes.

With a sigh, Glimmer sat up again and drew a magic circle, continuing to drain herself of magic.

- - -

"Um... hi, your highness," Jack said and entered the tent. They held up a tray. "Lunch?"

"Just Glimmer is OK, Jack," Glimmer said and sat up in bed. "And lunch would be *lovely*.

"Oh, OK, Glimmer," Jack said and carefully put the tray down on a small trunk next to Glimmer's bed. It was not covered in the excess of food that had been on display the first day, but there was still an impressive selection of food under the circumstances.

Glimmer gave Jack a friendly smile and patted at the bed next to her.

"Please, sit down and keep me company. You can even help me eat some of that."

Jack gave her a frightened look.

"I... I couldn't."

"Why not?" Glimmer asked in light tone of voice. "Catra told you to keep me company. Didn't she?"

"I suppose, your high... Glimmer."

Jack sat down on the edge of the bed, back rigid.

"Afraid of the wicked princess?" Glimmer said with light tone but a spark in her eye.

Jack swallowed.

"There are lots of... stories about you, your hi... Glimmer."

Glimmer laughed, a pearly laughter.

"Already? Well, tell me. What do the stories say?"

Jack hesitated.

"It's OK," Glimmer encouraged them. "You can tell me. I won't be angry."

"Well, they say you are... dangerous," Jack carefully said.

"That's true," Glimmer said, her sweet smile gaining a bit of en edge.

"They say you was the one who brought Shadow Weaver to Brightmoon and made her the Shadow Queen."

"That part is... kinda true," Glimmer admitted with a grimace.

"They say you eat naughty children who ask too many questions."

Glimmer laughed.

"Seriously? They do?"

"Not really," Jack admitted, "But the people in my village totally told stories about evil princesses when I was a kid."

"Well, then," Glimmer said. "You are pretty brave then, to be in here, with a real-life princess?"

"I'm used to be around dangerous people," Jack answered carefully. "Just because you *can* do bad things to me doesn't mean you *will*, right?"

They gave glimmer a little glance, gauging her reaction.

"Of course not," Glimmer said with sweet voice.

"We're all used to live like this... We all know the name of the game... Queen Catra most certainly does, that's how she took over so quickly." Jack glanced at Glimmer. "But you... haven't always lived like this, have you?"

"Where I come from, I did not constantly have to watch my back," Glimmer answered, drily.

"Oh, and then why are you here now?" Jack answered.

"Because someone I should have known better than to trust stabbed me in the back," Glimmer mumbled.

Jack didn't say anything.

"Yeah, yeah, I get it," Glimmer muttered.

"You have to watch your back," Jack said with careful voice. "You have to have a way out. You have to be prepared to play rough. You have to chose your friends... and your enemies."

They looked up at Glimmer with a calculating expression.

"Did you really mean it? Am I your friend, Glimmer?"

"Of course you are, Jack," Glimmer answered and put her hand on their shoulder.

Jack almost didn't flinch.

Glimmer looked them in the eyes.

"Now, there's a lot you need to tell me, *friend*, about the local gangs."

- - -

They finished their lunch, and then Glimmer stood up.

"I'm tired of being cooped up here in the tent. Please, show me the camp."

"It's a... camp?" Jack said with slightly bewildered voice as they trailed after Glimmer.

"It's *my* camp," Gimmer corrected, "and I want to see it. Lead the way."

The camp was... well, it was a camp. Dirty tents, storage areas, some temporary guard towers and small groups of people hanging around and talking among themselves, glaring at each other. Glimmer attracted some attention as she walked by. A few of the bandits sniggered openly, only to be quickly silenced by their comrades. Glimmer ignored them.

For some reason, there were lots of holes and people digging more of them. Glimmer commented on it.

"Oh, it's Queen Catra's idea," Jack answered. "Keep people busy, help create the idea of something more permanent than just another temporary camp."

"Oh?" Glimmer asked.

"We're used to sneak around," Jack explained. "Conceal our tracks, move camps every night... Queen Catra is telling us that we don't have to do that any more."

"Do you believe her?" Glimmer asked, voice neutral.

Jack glanced at her.

"Of course I do," they answered, trying as good as they could to mirror Glimmer's neutral tone.

Glimmer laughed.

"Really, Jack?"

"It's a bit scary," Jack admitted. "We've been picking up some of the larger gangs but... well, we're making a name for ourselves now and more will come. And not everyone will be happy to let Catra kill their leader in a duel."

"What will happen then?" Glimmer asked.

"They will ambush us," Jack shrugged, "unless we ambush them first, of course. Catra says we'll be able to handle it when it comes."

"Will you?" Glimmer pressed.

Jack pondered it for a moment.

"Of course we will," they said, then.

Glimmer smiled but didn't comment.

Catra stood talking to some of her bandits. She noticed Glimmer and Jack and sauntered up to them.

"My queen," she said with an obnoxious little bow. "I'm so glad to see you up and about. I trust your beauty sleep was uninterrupted." The bandits sniggered.

"Why, thank you for your concern, my queen," Glimmer answered with a smile that did not reach her eyes. "Can I trust your vigilant watch means that we are safe from those that would mean us harm at the moment?"

"Oh yes, quite safe," Catra leered and winked at her flunkies. "No smelly bandits are coming to steal you away at night, princess."

"And here I was just getting my hopes up," Glimmer said drily.

One of the bandits started to laugh, but quickly turned it into a cough when Catra glared at her.

"So, what's on today's agenda?" Glimmer asked. Catra shrugged.

"I'm sending out some raiding parties today. We have more mouths to feed, but fortunately we have more hands on deck so I reckon it evens out. We're mixing the groups so they have a chance to get to know each other and sort out the pecking order."

"Pecking order?" Glimmer asked. Catra grinned at her.

"Lots of rats dumped in the same sack, Sparkles. Gotta sort out who's the boss."

"I thought you were the boss," Glimmer dryly commented. Catra smirked.

"So I am, because I beat up every other asshole vying for the position." She gave her lieutenant a very direct look. "Can't really deny the rest of them the same opportunity, now can I?"

"The Scarlet Menace are subdued then?" Glimmer asked.

Catra leered at one of the bandits present, a red-haired woman Glimmer had not seen before.

She had fresh claw-marks in her face.

"What do you say, Scarlet? Is the Scarlet Menace properly subdued?"

For a moment, something ugly could be seen in the eyes of the large woman. But then she turned down her gaze.

"Catra is the strongest in the Crimson Waste," she muttered.

"That's what I thought," Catra smirked.

"That should please the Venom-fangs, then," Glimmer said, ignoring the exchange. "Mortal enemies of Scarlet Menace, aren't they?"

Catra looked impressed.

"Looks like someone has done her homework!" she said. "But as for the Venom-fangs, I doubt they have time for celebration. They know I'm coming after them next."

"Bad move," Glimmer said with even voice. "They won't strike out as long as they have the Dark Daggers breathing down their neck. You should go for Five Rocks first. That would secure the path to Skull-eaters' territory. If you put pressure on them, you could bully them to a non-aggression pact. That would leave you free to pick out the smaller gangs to the west at your leisure and forge and alliance with the Worm-killers and the Beaters. Then Venom-fangs would have no choice but beg to join up."

Catra stared at her, admiration in her eyes.

"Sparkles!" she exclaimed. "And here I thought you were going to spend your time recover, not reading up on Crimson Waste gossip."

Glimmer looked pleased.

"Someone should keep an eye on the tactical perspective," she said, just a hint of smugness in her voice.

"But you are totally overthinking this," Catra laughed. "This is not the princess alliance that has to be carefully reforged kingdom by kingdom. This is a bunch of losers in a desert, Sparkles."

She let her gaze play over the assembled bandits.

"No offence meant," she drawled.

They did not meat her gaze.

Catra caught Glimmer's eyes.

"I'll beat them up, one gang leader at the time. Those who have something to prove will come to us, those who don't will stay out of our way. They don't matter."

Glimmer frowned.

"I'd say it matters if we leave a powerful force in our rear as we start the offensive against the Horde outposts," she protested.

Catra laughed.

"You're thinking in terms of armies. That's not how it works in the Waste. These are *gangs*, Sparkles."

"Gangs, armies, what's the difference?" Glimmer grumped.

"Armies follow orders," Catra leered. "Gangs look out for themselves."

She reached out and patted Glimmer on the head with her mutilated hand. Her flunkies sniggered.

"Don't worry your adorable little head about it," Catra said with condescending voice. "Sit in the tent and focus on princess stuff while *I* deal with the gangs." A glint flashed by her eyes. "And don't you worry, there will be a time for tactics, when the Horde starts to realize what we are up to. You can impress us all with your queen-chops then."

"We're just going to *sit* here and ignore the Horde?" Glimmer spluttered.

"For now," Catra repeated. "I'm consolidating power. And in the meantime, you'll be safe." She looked Glimmer in the eyes. "Something I thought you would appreciate."

"Safe?" Glimmer snarled. "With Brightmoon in the hands of an usurper? With the Horde going after the princesses?"

"That's *your* concern," Catra snarled back. "Not these fine people's."

She took a step closer to Glimmer, perhaps without realizing she had unsheeted her claws.

"This is not the princess alliance, Sparkles," she growled. "You are not calling the shots any longer. The people here don't *care* about Brightmoon or the Fright zone, and we can't force them to. I'm going to throw out the Horde from the Crimson Waste. I will build a stronghold for us, carve it from blood and bone and make sure *no one* can hurt you again, and they will follow me, because shitty as this place is, it's *their* shitty place. They haven't signed up to fight your war for you."

"I know *that*," Glimmer spat back, perhaps without realizing that sparks were dancing on her fingertips. "I'm not drafting them in to fight my war. I'm perfectly capable of fighting that myself."

She did perhaps not realize how much emphasis she had put on the word 'myself'.

Catra looked like Glimmer had slapped her.

"I'm doing this for *us*," Catra said, and there might have been just a hint of pleading in her voice.

"Doing *what*?" Glimmer demanded. "Stranding us in a desert while the world burns?"

"I'm keeping us *alive*," Catra snarled. "Something you have not done such a bang up job of lately, *yourself*."

Their faces were just a few hands from each other. Jack and the other bandits looked at them in scared silence. No one dared to intervene.

"Really, Sparkles," Catra said with careful voice after a moment of silence. "We have it pretty swell here. I don't really see the rush."

Glimmer gave her a disdainful look.

"Yes," she said with sarcastic voice. "We're safe here. Behind our high walls. Protected by our guards. Our allies. Our runestone."

She gave Catra a very direct look.

"That's what my mother told me. My entire life she tried to hole up in Brightmoon as the Horde grew ever stronger. The entire princess alliance couldn't keep the threat at bay, and now you want to do the same thing with a handful of thugs in a desert."

"I'm not your mother, Sparkles," Catra shot back.

"I know you're not," Glimmer snarled. "So I'm surprised to hear *you* of all people make her mistakes."

"I dragged you through a desert and took over a pack of bandits for *you*, Sparkles," Catra shouted. "Somehow I thought you would be a bit more grateful."

"I *am* grateful," Glimmer said, voice low.

"Funny," Catra muttered. "That's not what I hear."

They glared at each other.

From one of the groups digging, an angry shout was heard.

"*Now* what?" Catra snarled.

"Just a fight," the lieutenant quickly said. "I'll sort it out."

"No, *I'll* take care of it," Catra said. She shot Glimmer a nasty look. "Come on, princess. I'm sure it will be educational."

As they walked over to the group, a woman dressed in what looked like an old Horde uniform had roughly pushed a man in rags to the ground, aiming a swing at his head. He managed to place a knee in her stomach and roll away. They both got to their feet, glaring daggers at each other.

"You think you're so tough," the man snarled. "You think you can just push me around because you used to be in Scarlet's gang."

"I think I can push you around because you're a wimp," the woman leered, and the fight was on again. The man aimed a blow that the woman avoided. That gave her the opportunity to land a vicious elbow in his chest, but not without her receiving a hard headbutt. A cheer was heard from the rest of the diggers, not so much in support of one of the other of the combatants as in general approval of the violence in itself.

"Well done," Catra drawled. "See, Sparkles. All kind of opportunities for stress release around here. Now let's see how they follow up."

Suddenly weary of the audience, the combatants gave each other a careful glance. Their changed. More alert. More focused. This was not just a little scuffle any longer. The stakes had gone up.

The woman took a small step forward, eyes locked on her opponent. The man took a step to the side, maintaining the distance between them. The crowd started a chant, not so much of specific words as of a specific rhythm, working up the mood for battle. As the man and woman clashed again, the crowed cheered and the chant increased in volume. More people ran over to look. This was promising to be prime entertainment.

Glimmer watched the crowd in unease. The tension in the air was tangible.

"Catra...?" she said with low voice.

"You asked me about the difference between a gang and an army," Catra hissed back. "In an army you could have an officer drag these two apart and throw them in all hole to cool down. Out here - not enough officers, not enough holes. We have to let some tension run its course."

With a vicious growl the woman tackled the man to the ground. He managed to roll away from her and tore a knife from his belt. She attacked again, and before she managed to push his hand away, he had torn a long gash in her arm. Glimmer gasped at the look of the blood that flowed from the wound. They separated, and the woman quickly drew a knife of her own. The hatred was gone from their eyes. Remaining was only fear and cold calculation.

Neither expected to survive this, unless they took out their opponent. Fast.

The crowd sensed the difference as well, and the chant died down. Everyone was watching intently.

Glimmer's eyes were very wide. She trembled slightly. Catra gave her a thoughtful look.

"Alright, loose the knives," she said with contemptuous voice. "Rough each other up as much as you like, but no killing. Save that for the Horde."

The crowd made a disappointed noise. After a brief moment of hesitation, glancing at Catra and each other, the combatants threw the knives to the ground with a quick look of relief that they quickly hid behind scowls of anger. They eyed each other for a moment, then they charged again.

"There," Catra said with happy voice as the combatant traded blows and kicks. "No one dies. I trust everything is to your liking, my princess?"

"Most commendable," Glimmer said with cold voice. She turned to Jack. "Please escort me back to my tent, Jack. I have had *quite* enough of the camp for now."

And without another word she walked away from the group. Catra looked after her with a frown.

- - -

"Wasn't that a pleasurable stroll in the camp, Jack," Glimmer asked as they entered the tent. Her voice was forced cheerful. Jack gave her an uncertain glance but didn't answer.

"I can see there will be no cause to worry about boredom when there is such a rich source of entertainment readily available."

Jack busied themselves with cleaning away Glimmer's lunch.

"I'm sure we are all proud of such an involved queen," Glimmer went on.

"She's just trying to whip the gang in shape," Jack said uncertainly. Glimmer gave them a withering look.

"And a *fine* job she's doing of it, too," she snarled.

Jack recoiled.

The tent flap opened and Catra walked in.

"You OK, Sparkles?" she asked with a frown.

"*Of course*, I'm OK," Glimmer said with barely contained rage. "What cause would I have for feeling otherwise."

"OK, I realize these last few weeks have been a bit... stressful," Catra carefully said, "but come on, Sparkles. I'm doing as good as I can here."

"Did I in any way imply dissatisfaction with your performance, my queen?" Glimmer hissed.

Catra gave a long look, then she did a little annoyed gesture.

"Fine, whatever. If you want to mope about it, be my guest. In the meantime, *I* have things to do."

"I would *hate* to get in your way," Glimmer snarled.

Catra gave her a bewildered look.

"You've been sleeping for weeks. I get if you're feeling restless in here. Come join me. We've more exciting things going on out there than fighting beetles and eating roasted snakes, let me tell you."

"Parade round the camp for your ruffians to laugh at me behind my back? Thank you, I've had quite enough of that."

Catra stared at her.

"So rough them up!"

"I should not have to," Glimmer said with petulant voice.

"Well, what do you want me to do?" Catra exclaimed. "Assign you a body guard? Kill anyone who looks at you funny? I can't walk by your side all the time. I've got a gang to run, and unless you missed it, we're in an expanding phase right now."

Catra gave Glimmer a pleading look.

"Sparkles, I know you. You can take care of yourself. For all that I like to give you shit about you being a little pampered princess, you won't run crying because someone looks at you the wrong way. Bloody their nose, perhaps, which is a perfectly accepted behaviour around here. So what's going on?"

"So you're out there playing queen while I sit around feeling useless?"

"Is *that* what this is all about?" Catra laughed. "You're *bored*?"

"I don't like being sidelined," Glimmer said between gritted teeth.

"So sorry that you're not the centre of attention, Sparkles," Catra shot back. "And I'm sorry if I somehow makes this looking *easy*."

She got a gleam in her eyes.

"I'm not sure you get what I'm doing here, Sparkles. I'm not just running a little gang or pushing around some bandits. I'm consolidating power. I'm taking over the Crimson Waste. I'm building a force not even the Horde will be able to match easily."

She gave Glimmer a very direct look.

"And I'm doing that to keep *you* safe. Sorry for thinking you would be happy."

"Well, what am *I* supposed to do while you have your little project?" Glimmer answered with venom in her voice.

"I thought that maybe it could be *our* little project," Catra snarled, "but if the gang is too smelly for the pretty princess, then at least stay out of my way. You told me you needed time to sort out your magic. Well, I have given you time. So why don't you sort out your magic, *princess*?"

Before Glimmer had time for a furious rebuttal, Catra turned to Jack.

"Come with me, Jack," she snarled. "Let's give the princess some space, least she thinks we're *disrespectful*."

Catra stormed out of the tent. With an apologetic look at Glimmer, Jack followed her.

In a furious scream Glimmer unleashed her pent up magic, and in a storm of glitter, the trays and bowls were flung throughout the tent, spilling it's luxurious food on the dirty ground.

She stalked over to the other side of the tent, and then back again. She felt like an animal, confined to a tiny cage. In the end she went back to the bed, hiding her face in the pillows.

Eventually she sat up.

She made a magic circle.

She forced magic out of her. Not in a gentle stream of sparks but as a furious flood of light.

She felt the magic trickle back in. She forced it out again. Every last spark she could find.

The magic returned. She forced it out.

She heard the dark whispers from Shadow Weaver, but she ignored them.

Sort out your magic, princess

Well, she bloody well would.

It took Glimmer quite some time to calm down. She spent some time looking at herself in a mirror.

A princess in exile looked back at her. Poor thing in her tattered clothes, kept alive at the whim of her former enemy.

That wouldn't do.

A pretty little thing in a pretty little cage, to be brought fort to be admired as needed, and then tucked away and forgotten.

Glimmer had grown up as the heir of the royal throne. She knew how to put on a smile if needed, even if it ate her up. She knew how to make the weight of the crown make itself felt. She had watched her mother command a room without uttering a single word, and she knew how it was done.

Even if she, and every other princess she knew, did their uttermost not to have to play those kind of games, Glimmer knew how to play them, and to play them well.

She opened the tent flap.

The bandit outside gave her the uneasy look of someone charged with guarding a doorway, but without having received clear instructions on which direction to guard it from or what to do if the person they were guarding were to leave.

"Princess?" he ventured.

"Good evening," Glimmer said with cold voice. "Would you please ask Jack to find their way here at their earliest convenience. I have some errands for them."

"Uh... sure!" the bandit said. Glimmer let the flap fall. She looked at herself in the mirror again, at the tattered, pink clothes she had worn throughout the desert.

It wouldn't do at all.

Chapter End Notes

Could we please go back to the kissing part?

Queens of the Crimson Waste

Chapter Notes

Warning: Brutality, cruelty, fighting, manipulation and magic.

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support, not to mention for the cameo of this version of Glimmer and Catra in Best Friend Squad rides again WITH A VENGEANCE!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"...Glimmer?" Jack hesitantly said as they entered the tent.

"Come in, Jack," Glimmer said with friendly voice.

Jack took a step forward. Glimmer sat on her bed. There were no trace in her demeanour of the earlier outburst, and the broken plates were cleaned up, even if Jack could see a few shards on the floor.

"Um... you wanted to see me?"

"Yes, please join me. I need to pick out some new clothes, and you can give me a hand. I figure there is plenty of spoils to pick from, from the raids."

"Um... sure!"

As earlier, Jack sat down on the bed next to Glimmer. Glimmer did a little apologetic gesture.

"I'm sorry for loosing my temper earlier. You shouldn't have to be caught in the middle like that."

"It's OK," Jack said with careful voice. Glimmer smiled at them.

"It can't be easy, to bounce between us like that."

Jack hid a smile.

"The two of you are a bit intense," they said with neutral voice.

Glimmer chucked.

"Have you ever been in love, Jack?" she asked after a little while.

Glimmer smirked as Jack looked away.

"It didn't end all that well," Jack muttered.

"What happened?" Glimmer asked with sympathetic voice.

"She picked someone else," Jack answered with flat voice.

"I've been there," Glimmer sighed. Jack gave her a surprised look which made Glimmer laugh.

"What? You imagined being a princess would make your love life *simple*?"

Jack blushed.

"I... kinda might have had that fantasy," they admitted.

"I'm so sorry for ruining it for you," Glimmer said, just a bit of an edge to her voice. "Let me tell you the one thing being a princess is all about."

"Luxury?" Jack asked. Glimmer made a little nod, conceding the point.

"Fine, that's true," she admitted. "But most of all it's expectations."

"What?" Jack asked. "Keep a straight face, know what fork to eat with, that kind of thing?"

"Sure," Glimmer agreed. "But also rule wise, judge fair and win an impossible war." She sighed. "Which is pretty demoralizing when

the entire current generation of princesses saw their parents killed by the Horde, I'll tell you."

"I wouldn't know what that's like or anything," Jack muttered.

Glimmer gave them a guilty look.

"Anyway," she quickly said. "The point is that there were times when *I* wished I lived in a little cabin in the Whispering Woods or something, having this fantasy of how it would have made my life easier."

They traded a smile.

"The grass is always greener on the other side of the fence, I suppose," Glimmer said. "Or the sand more yellow or whatever you say around here."

"The sand snakes bite less on the other side of the dune," Jack said promptly.

Glimmer eyed them suspiciously.

Jack managed to hold a straight face for a few moments, then they started to chuckle. Glimmer shook her head.

"I'm so out of my depth here," Glimmer sighed.

Jack gave her a hesitant look.

"Is that what bothers you?" they said.

Glimmer gave them a sharp look.

"What?" she said, her voice suddenly hard.

Jack lifted their hands in a pacifying gesture.

"Sorry, I just..."

"No, it's OK," Glimmer said, her voice regaining her friendly composure. "Please go on."

"I just thought... about... earlier. I'd feel pretty out of my comfort zone if I suddenly had to lead the dance on a fancy ball or something. Figure, it might be a bit... stressful for you, if you aren't used to life in the Waste."

Glimmer nodded thoughtfully.

"It's perceptive of you, and you might be right." She frowned. "In which case I should make an effort to learn, shouldn't I?"

"I suppose?" Jack said with uncertain voice.

"But no, that's not the main thing that bothers me."

"Then what is?" Jack asked.

"Catra," Glimmer sighed. "Or more accurately, Catra and me."

"But... don't the two of you like... love each other?" Jack Carefully asked. Glimmer gave them a fond smile.

"Of course we do," she said. "Just between you and me, 'Queen Catra' is hot as shit."

Jack blushed. Glimmer sniggered, but then her face grew serious again.

"She is," she insisted. "But that's not enough to build a relationship."

"Communication?" Jack guessed. Glimmer gave them a sour look.

"That's what one of my friends would have said. But we are not quite at the 'talk it out stage' of our relationship."

Jack looked away so Glimmer didn't see their face. Glimmer made a frustrated sound.

"I'm talking about power balance, Jack."

She sighed and for a moment covered her eyes with her hand in a tired gesture. Then she looked up at the teenager again.

"Who is Catra?" She simply asked.

"She's the Queen of Crimson Waste," Jack answered immediately, not without pride.

"And who am I?" Glimmer asked.

Jack hesitated.

"It's OK," Glimmer said with a comforting smile. Jack gave her an apologetic look.

"Her princess," they muttered. Glimmer nodded.

"*Her* princess," she repeated. She looked Jack in the eyes. "Do you see a problem with that?"

"But... why does that matter?" Jack asked. "She's protecting you, right? Like, when we captured you she tore through the gang like we were *paper*." They shuddered. "She did that to protect *you*. No one out there would dare to even lift a finger to you now."

Glimmer chuckled slightly.

"Catra is quite the romantic, much as she protest otherwise. But that doesn't change the fact that I'm dependent on her. Utterly dependent. That's not the way to set up a working relationship."

"I could stand being pampered and protected by someone I love," Jack muttered. Glimmer nodded thoughtfully.

"I suppose there are worse fates. But it's not only about me. It's about her. It's about us. It's about the gang. Like... what happens when someone finally gets one over her."

"That won't happen," Jack answered with 100% conviction.

All right, 90%.

Glimmer shrugged.

"Why not? Sooner or later someone gets lucky. What's left of my protection then?"

"If they just take over the gang, like Catra did..."

"Then they have no use for me," Glimmer interrupted. "Or... if they *do*..."

She didn't finish the sentence.

Jack didn't meet her gaze.

"I suppose so," Jack admitted after a moment. "But what are you going to do about that. You don't plan on challenging her for leadership, do you, are you?"

"Of course not," Glimmer smiled. "That's her game and I couldn't possible win it."

She looked Jack in the eyes.

"Not without cheating."

- - -

"Boss." One of the bandits stopped on a respectful distance and bowed his head. Catra nodded at him.

"Back from the raid already?" she said with easy-going voice. "What did you get for us?"

"Took out a group heading for the Valley of the Lost," he said with pride in his voice. "Some food, some weapons, and a whole barrel of booze."

Catra raised an eyebrow in appraisal.

"Not bad, not bad at all. Hand it over to the quartermaster, but keep hold of the barrel. We have a party coming up tonight, and I want you to make sure the booze is fairly distributed."

The man's grin widened. He realized perfectly well what position of power and prestige Catra just had given him.

"Where did Jack go?" she said to the bandit that had been appointed as her attaché.

"The princess asked for them some time ago," he answered. "Should I get them?"

Catra made a sour face.

"No, let her highness enjoy some company. Maybe she'll come out of her snit eventually."

The attaché wisely didn't comment.

"How are the preparations going for tonight?" Catra asked.

"Everyone is pretty fired up," the man answered with a grin. "Even those who joined today are falling in line. Everyone is feeling that they are in on something good."

"As they should," Catra drawled.

"As they should," the man quickly agreed.

"Food and drink all lined up? You got some people on security?"

"Everything's taken care of," he answered.

Catra caught his eyes.

"And how about the *entertainment*?"

His grin became more predatory.

"It's right on schedule."

"Good," Catra said. "Keep it up. I want everyone to get a memorable night."

- - -

"Catra! Catra! Catra!"

Catra took another stroll around the fire, waving at the roaring crowd. She tossed a dagger in the air and caught it again. She pumped her fist in the air. She cracked her whip. Whatever she did, the crowd roared in appraisal.

Yes, she could get use to this.

They were seated on a slope just next to the camp. The ground was too steep to peg a tent to, and there was a steep drop to one side that made it better suited as a look-out-point and natural defence than as a camp site.

But this night, it was a perfect natural theatre, with the slope giving even those lowest in the pecking order the chance to see what happened.

Catra held up her hand. At first people roared, but one by one they realized she was asking for silence. It took some while for the most excited or drunk bandits to get the hint, but eventually she had their attention. Only the fire crackled.

"Bandits," she cried. "Scoundrels. Outlaws. *Deserters*."

She grinned at them.

"That's what you're called, isn't it? But do you know what I see when I look over this *fine* assembly."

Everyone hung on her next words.

"I see bad-asses," Catra cried. "I see survivors. I see people who are *done* taking *shit*!"

They roared.

"I took out Tung Lashor!" she cried. "I took out the Scarlet Menace! I took out the Bone-cutters. I took out that looser with a hook-hand who couldn't even think of a name for her gang."

The crowd cheered and laughed, even the members of said gang.

"Because I'm a bad-ass," Catra went on. "I'm a survivor. I'm Catra and I'm *done taking shit*."

The crowd roared.

"WHO AM I?" Catra bellowed.

"CATRA!" they cried in answer.

"Who do you serve?" she roared.

"CATRA!" Came the answer.

"Who will lead you to greatness?"

"CATRA!"

"Who do you fight for?"

"CATRA!"

"Who do you *die* for?"

"CATRA!"

"Who's the boss?"

"CATRA!"

"What happens to anyone crossing the boss?"

"THEY DIE!" the crowd roared happily.

Catra smirked, the fire dancing in her eyes.

"Yeesss," she drawled. "And on that note..."

Suddenly everyone was dead silent.

"Bring them here!" Catra yelled, and from a tent two people were roughly pushed forward. Everyone's attention was on them. They looked around for a moment, perhaps entertaining the possibility of escape, but they quickly realized there was none. They were roughly pushed in front of Catra.

"Thank you for joining us," she hissed, voice clear and sharp as ice. She turned to address the rest of the assembly.

"As you all known, our little merry band have recently gone through some changes in leadership..." she pointedly looked at her lieutenant who visibly paled. Catra held her gaze for a few uncomfortable moments before she grinned and allowed it to move on.

"Most of you have found your place in our new order, but a few of you might still not be entirely *clear* on how we do things around here now..."

"Catra is the strongest in the Crimson Waste!" one of the bandits in front of her piped. The other quickly repeated the phrase.

"Yes," Catra said with calm voice. "I am. I'm so glad that's sorted out. The thing is, though... the two of you seemed to be a bit confused on the subject back when we first met..."

Trembling, the bandits, sank to their knees.

"Otherwise," Catra went on. "You might not have been so eager to hurt *my* princess?"

The already silent crowd silenced even more. Few people even breathed.

"Boss... we're sorry," one of them whispered.

"You will be," Catra snarled back.

"You beat her when she was at her lowest. You said that the Shadow Queen of Brightmoon wouldn't care."

She took a step forward. Everyone's eyes were on her in anticipation.

"But Shadow Weaver isn't here, is she?" she hissed. the bandits shook her head.

"WELL, IS SHE?" Catra roared.

"No, Catra!" the bandit croaked.

"SO WHO'S WORD GOES HERE?" Catra snarled.

"Catra's!" the bandit cried, eyes white from fear.

"Yeees," Catra hissed. She looked out over the rest of the fascinated assembly. "Did everyone get that? Who's word goes in the Crimson Waste?"

"CATRA'S!" they roared.

"That's right!" She screamed. "Not the Shadow Queen in Brightmoon. Not Hordak in the Fright Zone. Not whoever thug or gang-leader might have pushed you around before. CATRA IS THE STRONGEST IN THE CRIMSON WASTE!"

"CATRA IS THE STRONGEST IN THE CRIMSON WASTE!" they dutifully echoed.

"THAT'S RIGHT!" Catra snarled. "And I hope you lot remember that next time someone feels like picking on *my* princess."

They got it, loud and clear.

Catra looked around the roaring crowd in triumph. Then she turned her attention back to the quivering bandits in front of her.

"That leaves us," she hissed, and the crowed fell silent again, "with the little detail of *punishment*."

- - -

It was quite efficient in it's brutal simplicity. The two of them were pushed into a circle by the fire and given a club each, just a heavy stick, really.

And then the fight begun.

Every time one of them landed a hit, the crowd roared. Every time one of them managed to dodge, the crowd roared as well. They had food and drink and a roaring fire and they were part of the greatest gang in the entire waste, under the greatest gang boss in the world and they would go places, do things, *be* things.

Queen Catra of the Crimson Waste would make them a force to reckon with.

Forgotten were past differences. Who had served in what gang, in what army. Who had stolen who's supplies, who had burnt who's village. They were all united now, under Queen Catra. Anyone who crossed them would be shown the error of their ways. They would show them all.

Like, for example, the two poor schmucks who fought in the middle of the circle under the cheers from the crowd and under the careful watch of Catra. Most of the people didn't know what they had done and most didn't care. They had crossed the boss, that was enough.

The people who knew them from before Catra took over the gang did their best to keep silent about that fact.

Another hit landed. A painful bash on the arm. The combatants breathed heavily now. The bandit who landed the hit glanced at

Catra. She grinned back at them, but gave them no sign to stop the fight, no indication of how long they would be forced to do this.

Not that they needed it. Two people fighting. Didn't take a genius to figure out what was expected of them.

Who would - eventually - be allowed to leave the ring.

Hopefully.

Catra kept grinning, and the combatants mustered what energy they had left, desperately tried to keep fighting. Neither of them wanted to find out what would happen when they couldn't fight any longer.

Another hit, another roar. One of the bandits sank down to her knees. The other glanced and Catra, but the queen made no sign of calling off the fight. Not to loose her momentum she aimed a vicious blow. Had it landed, she probably would have won the fight there and then.

But it didn't land.

Because just then, Glimmer walked into the circle with Jack in tow and calmly stepped in right between the combatants.

"That will be quite enough of that," Glimmer said to the shocked assembly.

She looked Catra in the eyes. "The show is over, my queen."

The crowd and the combatants gaped, and not only from her sudden appearance. Most of them had never got a good look at the princess in her brief times outside the tent, and she looked... different.

She was dressed in a flowing multitude of loose fitting fabric in different shades of purple, pink and lilac with a dark, pink rimmed tabard on her chest. Long purple gloves merged with the sleeves,

and the lower part of her face was covered by a a scarf and a purple veil. Only the upper part of her face and her pink hair was visible.

In her hands she had her glowing mage staff.

The two bandits uncertainly lowered their clubs.

Catra stood up from her seat.

"What are you doing, Sparkles?" she protested.

"Putting an end to this whole brutal affair," Glimmer shot back

"And *why* would we put an end to this?" Catra asked, voice angry.

"It's barbaric," Glimmer shot back.

"They hurt you, Glimmer," Catra said, the edge in her voice was clear.

"Yes," Glimmer said. "They did. I was powerless against them, and they used that power to hurt me. They did not have to, they did it anyway. For the sake of their amusement, for the sake of hiding their own fears and insecurities, for the sake of setting an example against anyone who would think to stand against them..." She gave Catra a long look. "Sounds familiar?"

Catra took a step back, too angry to form words. The rest of the camp had fallen completely silent. Jack's eye moved between Catra and Glimmer.

Catra had an almost pleading expression. She sought Glimmer's eyes, and her own eyes darted towards the audience, a clear warning in them.

Glimmer gave her a scornful look.

"Don't want me to show them weakness, is that it?"

"*Yes*" Catra blurted out, trying to keep her voice low. "You are used to loyal lackeys of your mother. This is nothing of the kind. They follow us for one reason and one reason only." She held up her clawed hand for emphasis. "A moment of weakness and they'll be at our throat."

Glimmer rolled her eyes.

"So what're saying is that we are just like them? Just a couple of bullies who happens to have the larger stick at the moment? To be replaced and discarded the time the larger bully emerges?" She looked Catra in the eye. "Then it will be the two of us who have to fight each other to the death for someone's petty amusement."

Catra recoiled as from a physical blow. Her eyes were furious and hurt and frightened at the same time. The bandits saw her humiliation and hardly dared to breath. Someone would die very soon, they knew it in their bones.

"You don't know..." she began but Glimmer cut her off.

"Oh, I'm sure you will be able to scandalize the poor little sheltered princess with tales of grim hardship soon enough. But I know something you don't. I know better than to be just another rat in the sack."

She turned her back to Catra, refusing her the opportunity to answer. She pointed at the two bandits on either side of her in the fighting ring, who still stood with their sticks vaguely pointed at each other, uncertain how to proceed.

"The two of you, come here."

Hesitantly, the obeyed. They stopped a few steps in front of Glimmer, sticks held in unthreatening positions.

"You hurt me when I was your prisoner. Now when our positions have changed, it falls to me to think of your punishment."

Glimmer's voice was soft, but her eyes were hard as steel. The bandits didn't dare to breath. Behind her, Catra snarled but didn't interfere.

"Hit me," Glimmer said to the first bandit. She recoiled as if Glimmer had struck *her*.

"Glimmer..." Catra tried.

"SHUT UP!" Glimmer snarled and spun around. She glared at Catra, eyes full of fury. "You said they should be punished. I'm punishing them. You wanted a show, I'm giving you one. So sit back and enjoy it, 'my queen'."

She turned to the bandits again.

"I said *hit me*. You were able enough to do so when you had me bound and powerless. Now let me see you repeat the feat."

The bandits very carefully approached.

They started to feel that maybe Glimmer wasn't the soft option after all.

The first bandit very carefully, gingerly, reached out her stick and, after a moment of hesitation, poked Glimmer with it.

Glimmer scoffed.

"If you don't hit me," she snarled, "I'll cut both of your throats myself."

"Listen, princess," one of the bandits said. "We are very sorry..."

Glimmer suddenly held a ball of lighting in her hand, as large as her head. They both recoiled.

"I have not given you permission to speak," she hissed. They abruptly fell silent.

"Now, I'm ordering you for the last time, *hit me*!"

One of the bandits, very hesitantly, reached out and gave Glimmer a soft poke with the stick.

Glimmer scoffed.

"Harder."

The other tried a little bit more force. Glimmer nodded approval.

"Harder!"

The first tried a soft blow that landed on her arm. Glimmer grinned.

"*Harder*!"

"Princess..." one of the bandits tried again.

The ball of lighting wooshed past her head and detonated just a step behind her. In pure panic she struck Glimmer again.

The blow caught Glimmer in the stomach. For a moment she wheezed, then she stood up again and took a deep breath.

She grinned.

"Good. Now, whoever of you hit me hardest *might* survive this."

The crowd watched in fascination as the two bandits hesitantly took turns landing blows on Glimmer. They had no idea where this was leading, or where it would end. But they did recognize a good show.

"Glimmer..." Catra said again as a heavy blow landed on Glimmer's leg, forcing her to the ground.

"SILENCE!" Glimmer snarled at her. "We are doing this my way."

She stood up again and removed her veil and threw off the scarf. The moons were bright in the sky. Immediately, her skin started to glow as magic poured out of her.

Jack gasped. The bandits quickly took several steps back.

"I did not say you were finished," Glimmer hissed, and white in their faces from fear the two bandits edged closer, and very hesitantly aimed another blow.

As their sticks struck, light leapt from Glimmer, through the sticks and was within seconds covering both bandits. They screamed and tried to withdraw, but their hands remained stuck to the sticks and the sticks to Glimmer like if they were welded in place by the pulsing magic.

Glimmer glowed brighter. Her face contorted in a mask of pain.

The bandits screamed.

"Glimmer..." Catra cried and rushed forward. Glimmer held up a brightly glowing hand.

"Stand back, Catra," she hissed between gritted teeth.

She stood, proud and with straight back, with the bandits on their knees beside her, screaming in pain and fear. Light poured out of their every orifice, and for every moment it increased in intensity.

Glimmer let her burning gaze sweep over the crowd. Suddenly half remembered bedtime stories of evil princesses didn't sound quite so far fetched.

"Enough," Glimmer said with gentle voice, and abruptly the magic stopped flowing.

The bandits stopped glowing. They fell backwards as they finally could let go of the sticks. Only residual glow remained in Glimmer's eyes as she covered her head and face again.

No one dared say a word.

"I forgive you," Glimmer said softly to the trembling bandits on the ground before her. She reached out her hands and before they

had time to scramble away, she took theirs and helped them to their feet. They stood before her, staring at her in awe and fear.

"I was weak and you took advantage of it," Glimmer went on. "I do not hold it against you. Petty cruelty were the law of the land, the rules of the bandits. But that rule is over. A group of robbers might take their amusement from a helpless prisoner, but that's not who you are any longer. Now you are held to a higher standard."

All the bandits took notice of that. Glimmer lifted her head and addressed the entire camp.

"You are not any little band of bandits any longer. You are an army!" Glimmer turned and pointed straight at Catra who watched her with mouth open. "*Her* army. Queen Catra will lead you to greatness, but you won't get there if you think like two-bits thugs. You said it yourself - the Queen of the Crimson Waste is back, and you are her court, so *act like it*.

Glimmer paused for effect for a moment and then went on in a sweet voice.

"That means, don't hurt prisoners. Now, if you'll excuse me, I will withdraw from the assembly. Ladies in waiting, please attend me."

The bandits before her blinked.

"Yes," she said sweetly. "That means you. You were my captors, and now you are my courtiers. I was in your power, now you are under my protection. So please, attend me."

She turned and walked to her tent with the two newly promoted bandits in tow. She stopped as she walked by the stunned Catra and lifted her veil to give her a peck on the cheek.

"Find them some other amusement tonight, 'my Queen'," she said and walked on.

There was a confused murmur as the bandits tried to work out if they were supposed to cheer or not. After a few moments of hesitation someone started to chant Catra's name, on the general principle that despite the humiliation, Catra was still there, still the boss (allegedly) and might still have aggressions to take out on someone. The rest of the camp joined in. Catra stared after the withdrawing Glimmer.

The 'ladies in waiting' trailed after Glimmer until they reached her tent. Jack made a motion to join them, but Glimmer waved them away. Right now, she had to focus on her victory. Her 'ladies in waiting' was a symbol of it. She stopped and turned to look at them.

"You will keep watch until the festivities are over. Then you will sleep in shifts. No one is to disturb me until tomorrow."

"Um.... not even Catra?" One of the bandits asked, still very unsure of what was going on. Glimmer suppressed a tingle of triumph. Ten minutes prior, no one in the camp would have thought of even asking that question.

"*Obviously* the Queen of the Crimson Waste goes wherever she wishes," she said with condescending voice. When she comes here," ('when', not 'if') "you will show her all due respect. I wish to receive the Queen at whatever time is convenient for her. Until then..."

She let the tent flap fall, leaving the bandits outside to parse her words as well as they could. Then she sunk down on the trunk that was her combined table, storage place and chair and shuddered as anxiety, stress and magic flowed out of her.

Even if she hated it, she knew how to put on a regal face if she had to. Smiles outside, boiling turmoil on the inside. Even when you feel like puking, never let it show. And that was in Brightmoon when the worst she had to fear was the disapproving look of her mother or aunt. This was a different game with different stakes

altogether, and this time she also had to deal with Shadow Weavers magic whispering evil little words of doubt in her mind.

Never mind. Glimmer knew the game well enough to play it, and play it well.

She dried her tears, steadied her breathing and drank water until the taste of gall washed away. Then she composed herself on the trunk and watched the tent flap expectantly until Catra showed up.

She didn't have to wait long.

Glimmer heard her 'ladies in waiting' murmur what they thought of as proper words to greet a queen, but came more across as someone reciting a bad play (she had to do something about that), and Catra walked in. She gave Glimmer a bewildered - and maybe just a smidge scared - look.

"What was THAT?"

Glimmer stood up and removed her vail.

"That was how you become a queen rather than a mob boss," Glimmer calmly answered.

Catra stared at her.

"By utterly confusing them?"

Glimmer smirked and removed her veil.

"Partly, yes. Pulling the rug from them, redefining how they think of themselves, giving them something to aspire to."

"They are a bunch of thugs," Catra exclaimed, "Not a royal court. They have no idea what that means."

"That's right," Glimmer said with a shadow on a smile. "So don't you think they'd want someone to tell them?"

Glimmer stood up, standing just in front of the oil lamp, its warm light embracing her.

"Someone from a world they can hardly fathom, someone who can tell them that they are able to amount to more than anyone ever thought, someone with a vision for a future that is better than today."

She smiled, a confident little smile.

"Look at me, Catra. Tell me what you see."

Catra stared.

"I see an utter maniac."

Glimmer laughed.

"You're one to talk. But go on. Tell me what *they* saw. Who am I to them?"

"You are... I mean, you look like a cream puff pastry in your pretty clothes."

Glimmer gave Catra a saucy look which made Catra look away and quickly shake her head to clear her thoughts.

"I half expect you to pull out parasol for the sun any moment."

"Ooooh! Good one," Glimmer smirked.

"And they have seen you at your lowest. They have seen you beaten, tied up, having to be rescued."

"That was very nice of you."

"And I mean... they get that. I'm the top dog around here... You know what I mean. If I want to keep a pretty little someone for companionship," Glimmer raised an eyebrow and Catra had to clear her throat, "....I... that's not unexpected. That's something they understand. That fits the script. And that thing with me

punishing those two thugs... that was also expected. That how it goes. Those are the rules of this place."

"Those *were* the rules of this place."

Catra gave Glimmer a serious look.

"And you might like it or not, but I *was* going softly on them. You think that fight was just cruelty."

"It was not?"

Catra met Glimmer's gaze.

"It was me giving them a chance. There are a thousand ways to weasel yourself out of a situation like that. Put up a good show, hurt the other non-fatally, humiliate yourself enough to earn forgiveness... heck, they had every opportunity to slip away before it started. But if they are to stay, they have to re-earn their place in the gang. You want to rule people like this, you need a show of force."

"Oh, I get *that*."

Catra made a frustrated gesture.

"Do you, now? You running out there, wringing your hands about the mean cat punishing the prisoners... Honestly, to them you look like a spoiled softie who don't know how the real world works."

"I do, don't I. It's ever so useful."

Catra blinked.

"You want them to think of you as weak?"

Glimmer's smile widened.

"Is that what they still think?"

Catra shrugged.

"After that display out there... They don't know. You come out there, looking like you're about to cry, and then you flip the script on the game with the thugs, and everyone's waiting for the other shoe to drop, and that thing with the sparks... and suddenly the thugs are terrified of you and no one is sure what happened... and after *that* you give this grand speech about how suddenly the old rules are no good any more, and you are the law of the land..."

Catra's voice trailed off.

Glimmer nodded, just a tad smugly.

"Quite the show of force, don't you think."

Catra stared at her.

"You used the two of them as *props*?"

Glimmer raised an eyebrow.

"As did you. You said it yourself, we couldn't let slights against us go without response. You responded with force, I responded with mercy. Now everyone know I have taken a *personal* interest in them. If I play this right, I'll have their loyalty *and* be able to use them as an example."

"And that whole 'queens court' thing?" Catra blurted out.

Glimmer stepped up to Catra and took her hand.

"You belong here, Cara. You know the rules of the land. You can play by them, you can win by them... I don't." Glimmer did a gesture and sparks flowed over her. Catra flinched.

"So I change the script. I change the game. I have them playing by my rules, and in my game *I* win." She let the sparks die down and gave Catra a soft smile.

"Choosing the game, choosing how it's played, picking the rules, writing the scripts for you and for the others... That's true force, Catra. That's how I rebuilt the princess alliance. That's how I tapped into powers even my mother never knew. That's how I almost beat you."

Glimmer chuckled a bit ruefully.

"Adora, bless her heart of gold, never got it. For her it was all about following the rules she was given as well as she could. You know better. You know there will always be cheaters robbing you of a rightful win... Otherwise you would sit on Hordak's throne by now and I would still be the ruler of Brightmoon. You know that you can never beat them by playing fair. Well, I'm not. Not anymore."

Her smile widened.

"This desert is full of bullies and thugs who know intimidation and cruelty as well as anyone. I'll beat them with kindness, mercy and loyalty. Those bandits out there, they will follow you for as long as they fear your whip and your claws. They will follow me for as long as they wish for my approval. I have shown them a new world, Catra. I have made them want to be part of it. I have made it conditional on my say so."

Catra stared at her.

"Wow... and you have the gall to call *me* cruel."

Glimmer had the decency to look ashamed.

"It doesn't *have* to be cruel... not if we deliver what they want."

Catra's eyes narrowed.

"The Crimson Waste."

Glimmer smiled.

"That was the plan anyway, wasn't it?"

Catra smiled in response.

"I have underestimated you, Sparkles."

"Yes. It's very annoying."

"So you really want to do this?" Catra asked. "Not just coming along for the ride, but actually commit to life as a bandit queen?"

Glimmer gave her a very direct look.

"I want do the same thing I've wanted all my life. I want to take down the Horde." An edge of steel entered Glimmer's voice. "And now that includes the witch in Brightmoon."

Her voice grew softer.

"And I thought... perhaps you might want to do it together with me? All of it? All the way?"

She held out her hand. Catra stared at it.

"Do you want to be my Queen, Catra?" Glimmer asked.

"Glimmer..." Catra whispered, her eyes very large.

"Do you want to be my Queen?" Glimmer repeated. "Not just of the Crimson Waste, not just of some bandits, or a scrawny rebellion. Do you want to be my Queen of the Fright Zone? Of Brightmoon?"

"Take down Hordak?" Catra whispered. "And Shadow Weaver? Are you sure that's what you want, Glimmer? Are you sure I..."

"I'm sure," Glimmer said with soft voice. "I know we can do it. Together. I want to. I want *you*, Catra."

She looked Catra in the eyes.

"Do you want me?" she said with low, somewhat vulnerable voice.

"More than anything in the world," Catra heard herself whisper.

"Hordak and Shadow Weaver wronged us, Kitten," Glimmer said. "We'll take the Crimson Waste, alright. We will even do it your way. But we are not stopping here. We're taking them down, both of them. And for that we need an army."

Catra took Glimmer's hand. They shared a knowing smile.

"I'll bring you an army, Sparkles."

"And I will make them march for you," Glimmer said with proud voice. "Not just taking out some Horde outposts in the desert. I will make them march to the Fright Zone, to Brightmoon, to the end of the world if we need them to."

Their faces were very close now. They looked into each other eyes. They saw their own passion and strength reflected in the other.

"Well, then, my Queen," Catra whispered. "For winning."

"For winning, my Queen," Glimmer answered, and her smile was like pure sugar rum - smooth and intoxicating at the same time.

They kissed. A long, eager series of kisses.

Outside the tent, the 'ladies in waiting' kept vigilant watch. They, and the rest of the camp, were not exactly sure of their status right now, but they knew they had been given a position of privilege in something that promised to be great. They did not want to loose that.

Glimmer had made them want her approval. She had given them a position of status and made it conditional on her say so. Thus, those who just a few weeks ago had beaten her now guarded her and attended her. The power dynamic of the Crimson Wasted had shifted.

All hail to the queens.

Chapter End Notes

This was pretty much where the story begun. The rest of it is me extrapolating forward and backwards.

A fun little date in the sun

Chapter Notes

Warning: Fighting.

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

This fic now has a *soundtrack!* The playlist is put together by the awesome Buzzingbee29. Thanks so much! https://open.spotify.com/playlist/3oq3v1tQWwNVb8hSoR98cG?si=FKD26XKMTruomh3zN775qA&utm_source=copy-link

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Kudgel looked over his troops. Ten of his hardest and fiercest warriors, hand-picked for one purpose and one purpose only - to take out the so called 'Queen of the Crimson Waste'.

"Right," he said. "We're getting closer. We'll likely only get one shot at this so let's repeat the plan."

The others groaned. They had heard the plan a thousand times.

"First we..."

"Lay low and send out scouts," one of the others interrupted. Kudgel glared at her.

"Yes. And then, as we spot the cat we..."

"Wait for the opportune moment," another quickly supplanted. Kudgel gritted his teeth.

"*Obviously* we wait for the opportune moment," he said, "at which point we..."

"All gang up on her and take her out," yet another gang member interrupted. "We've been going through this, boss. It's not that complicated."

"Well, I don't want you bulkheads to screw it up. If we take her out quick enough, her gang will fold and then *we* will rule the Waste. But if we alert her gang, than it's over for us. Get that?"

"Yes boss," they said with varying degrees of eye-rolling.

"And that's why I need you all to be alert so we don't miss our opportunity. It's not like she'll just drop in our lap."

As he said that they climbed atop another dune overlooking a little valley. In the bottom of the valley they saw a table, covered with a white cloth and loaded with fruits and snacks. Sitting by it was Catra - queen of the Crimson Waste - by all appearances enjoying a fun date with her princess. They even had a waiter in the form of a young rabbit-person. The princess had a dainty little pink parasol to protect her from the sun.

Catra laughed at something Glimmer said.

Kudgel froze and held up a hand. After some pushing, his gang stopped behind him.

"I can't believe our luck!" he whispered. Spread out. And on my signal, *get them*!"

They spread out. They aimed their weapons. Catra offered Glimmer a snack which she, after some giggling, ate directly from the Queen's hand

"DEATH TO THE QUEEN!" Kudgel cried.

Glimmer looked up and sighed.

"Do you guys *mind*?"

Kudgel hesitated. His gang looked to him for support. He decided to go with condescending.

"My, my, my," he drawled and sauntered down the dune with his gang closing in on the table from all directions. "What do we have

here?"

"Catra, the Queen of the Crimson Waste," Glimmer said proudly and pointed at Catra, who by all appearances was completely engrossed in sipping on her drink, blind and death to everything else.

"Now that's a piece of luck," Kudgel leered. "Isn't it, boys?" The gang dutifully chuckled. "Just the person we came to see." He considered a menacing laughter but thought that perhaps that would be to overdo it. He held up his blaster instead, for emphasis.

Glimmer sighed and turned away from him.

"Catra," she said, "There are some *people* here to see you."

"Well, what do they want, Glimmer?" Catra asked, her entire focus on the drink in her hand.

"I don't know, Catra," Glimmer answered.

"Well, ask them then, Glimmer," Catra answered and took a little sip of the drink.

"Why should I ask them, Catra," Glimmer shot back. "Why can't you ask them?"

"I'm busy, am I not, Glimmer?" Catra countered.

"You don't look busy, Catra," Glimmer answered.

"I'm busy not looking busy, Glimmer."

Glimmer pondered that for a moment. It tracked.

She turned to the baffled gang.

"So sorry, but the Queen of the Crimson Waste is *frightfully* busy at the moment. You know how it is with Queens. Busy, busy, busy. Perhaps you could come back later?"

"I'll *make* her take time for us," Kudgel hissed.

"Catra," Glimmer said with an exasperated sigh. "They *insist*."

"Why do they do that, Glimmer?" Catra asked.

"I don't know, Ca..." Glimmer begun, which was as far as she got before Kudgel decided that enough was enough and aimed his blaster at Catra and pressed the trigger.

Which was the moment when Catra sprung from her seat, jumped on top of the table, her whip lashed out and the blaster was flung from Kudgel's hand, the shot hitting nothing but sand.

Glimmer jumped to her feet as well, and as the gang descended on her, a staff materialized in her hand and she in quick succession threw two of the gang to the ground. Jack quickly ran away from the fray and picked up Kudgel's blaster. They spun around, looking for a target.

"You guys *really* shouldn't have disturbed our date," Catra snarled with a bloodthirsty smile and lashed out with whip at the closest gang member. "I don't know if you guys heard," she drawled, "but there are rules to this place."

"Catra!" Glimmer protested, punching one of the bandits in the face. "You spilled my drink."

"First rule," Catra said, ignoring the indignant princess - "the strong one makes the rules." She caught Kudgel's eyes. "That means me," she leered.

"That means her," Jack echoed.

"I had just refilled my glass and everything," Glimmer whined, ducking under the slash from a sword.

Catra's grin grew wider.

"Care to guess the second rule?"

She jumped straight up in the air, avoiding the shots that were aimed at her. As she landed (scattering more food over the sand) she aimed a vicious roundkick at the bandits closing in. She aimed low, hitting their legs and sending them sprawling to the ground. Then she jumped again, a quick series of leaps in succession that suddenly made Kudgel mindful that it was awfully hard to predict where those razor sharp claws would be next.

Catra slid under the arm of on of the bandits, snagging a glass from the collapsed table. She spun around, aimed a kick at the bandit and used the opportunity to jump over him. She landed on the other side and grabbed a bottle from the basket. She scrambled over the ground to get away from blaster fire and as the next bandit aimed a sword strike at her, she held up the bottle to parry the blow, neatly severing the top.

She aimed the pouring bottle at the face of the bandit and then landed a kick that made them loose their balance and fall to the ground. A quick jump and she was clear of the fracas for a moment, and took the opportunity to pour up the remaining content on the bottle in the glass.

With an exaggerated bow she presented it to Glimmer - who had just struck a bandit's blaster from his hands.

"Another drink for my princess?"

Glimmer giggled.

"*Catra*, you show-off," she said and held her hand to her chest in faux shock. "That's so *cheesy*."

"If you don't want it..." Catra begun and did a show of starting to remove the glass.

"I didn't say that," Glimmer quickly said and took the glass.

For a moment her and Catra's hand touched.

They looked at each other, sharing a soft smile.

Then Catra abruptly spun around, landing a vicious kick on one of the bandits who got to close. She pulled up her whip again and hit another. Glimmer put her staff down and instead sipped on her drink, seemingly enjoying it immensely. Any bandit who hoped to take advantage of her leaving the fight was sadly disappointed as Catra leapt between them like a blood thirsty wrecking ball, all the while Glimmer enjoyed the drink.

"The second rule is, don't mess with her princess," Jack helpfully provided and aimed a blaster shot at one of the bandits who was coming too close.

"Damn straight it is, kid," Catra said and punched Kudgel in the face, sending him flying over the dunes.

"I am *my own* princess, thank you very much," Glimmer interjected pointedly. Catra kicked another of the bandits in the chest and landed in front of Glimmer with an insincere grin. She did a mocking little bow.

"Oh, *excuse me*, princess."

"By all means, *my* queen," Glimmer shot back.

Catra tough a thoughtful step backwards and grabbed the arm of one of the bandits who tried to punch her. She pushed him down into the ground and stomped down on his head long enough for him to eat a faceful of sand.

"'Your queen' she repeated thoughtfully. I *like* that, Sparkles."

"You do?" Glimmer said with genuine, soft voice. Catra laughed, a friendly laughter only slightly dampened by her jumping to avoid a sword trust. She landed some distance away and disarmed the bandit with her whip.

"Of course I do, Sparkles." her voice grew softer. "When it's *you* who's saying it."

"Oh Catra," Glimmer said, voice clearly choking up. She threw her glass backwards, in the face of the bandit who tried to sneak up on her, and followed up with a low kick, sending him to the ground. She walked up towards Catra.

"Glimmer..." Catra said with warm voice and cracked the whip over the head of a bandit who tried to get back up. She walked up to Glimmer and held out her arms. Glimmer melted into them.

"You can call me 'your princess' anytime you wish," Glimmer said with voice full of love.

"I fully intend to, my princess," Catra answered in the same tone of voice.

"Uh, Glimmer? Catra?" Jack cried and fired the blaster towards a bandit coming too close to the lovely-dovey couple. Catra rolled her eyes and let go of Glimmer long enough to land a punch.

"We're having a moment. I'll be with you guys in *just* a minute," she complained.

Suddenly Jack cried out in fear and jumped to the ground. The bandit who was about to attack them gave them a surprised look, but was the moment after hit by a large ball of glitter and fell to the ground. Jack scrambled to their feet.

"Warn me next time!" they cried to Glimmer who lowered her hand after having released the lighting.

"It seems I didn't need it," Glimmer said with thoughtful voice.

"What?" Jack yelled.

"Figure it out later," Catra said. "Time for us to mop it up."

She let go of Glimmer and sauntered up to Kudgel who just got to his feet. He froze in fear.

"Now, this has been fun and all," she said in conversational tone, "but I fear *my princess* is catching to much sun, what with her sensitive skin and all" -Glimmer stuck out her tongue at her- "so it's really time for us to get back to camp."

She gestured at their destroyed table.

"Bring the gear and let's go."

"Go... with you?" Kudgel asked, a bit slow on the uptake.

"Sure!" Catra said with sassy voice. "Or walk the other direction, I suppose. But if you wanna be part of the greatest gang in the Crimson Waste, that's us."

"That's us!" Jack confirmed and earned themselves a grin from Catra.

She offered her arm to Glimmer, and with Jack in tow they sauntered away over a dune. After some hesitation, Kudgel and the rest of the gang gathered the pieces of the wrecked table, chairs and what could be salvaged of the foodstuff and followed them.

Even if they had lost, the couldn't help feeling that they had won something.

- - -

They returned to camp and Catra found someone to yell at the new recruits for a while to break them in. Glimmer headed for the tent.

"Come with me," she said to Jack. "I want to test something."

Jack dutifully strolled after her into the tent, and just as the flap fell they flinched and sharply draw their breath.

Glimmer formed a ball of sparkles in her hand and gave Jack a thoughtful look.

"That's interesting," she said with a somewhat detached voice.

"What is?" Jack asked, eyeing the glittering ball in Glimmer's hand with a nervous expression.

"This," Glimmer said, and held the ball closer. Sparks from the ball seemed to gravitate towards the teenager.

"Why is it doing that?" Jack asked, ill at ease and tried to edge away.

"It's not doing anything," Glimmer said and moved the ball closer to Jack again, watching the behaviour of the sparks with interest. "It's just magic. *You* are attracting it."

"Me?" Jack asked. "How?"

"You're magical," Glimmer simply said, and finally put the ball away. Jack stared at her.

"What?"

Glimmer shrugged.

"It's not that unusual, but most of the time the magic fields is too low for it to make a difference. That's why they spend so much time over at Mystacor learning to ration available magic. Most people never get to learn those tricks."

"I can do *magic*?" Jack said again, completely baffled.

"Sure!" Glimmer smiled. "I can teach you, if you want."

Jack just stared.

"Come here," Glimmer laughed. She took Jack's hand and led them over to the mirror. Jack followed, some slight trepidation in their steps.

"Now, look yourself in the eyes," Glimmer instructed and pointed at the mirror. Jack gave her a guarded look.

"Why?"

"It's just a way of centring yourself," Glimmer explained. "There are many ways to prepare for this. I thought I'd just pick one of the easiest to begin with. This might or might not work. Magic is awfully fickle. But try it and we'll see where it leads us."

She squeezed Jack's hand.

"I'm with you," she said gently. "No matter what happens, you'll be OK."

Jack gave her a nervous look. Then they turned to look at themselves in the mirror.

"Now what?" they asked. Glimmer giggled.

"I was just as impatient my first time," she confessed. "Now, you wait. You steady your breathing. You look at yourself. *Really* look at yourself. Plant your feet firmly, like you'd do nothing today but standing there, looking at yourself. You very well might be."

Jack breathed out and in a few times. They shifted their weight around. They stared at their mirror image. A slight frown suggested they might not fully approve of what they saw.

"Good," Glimmer said with soft voice. "Keep looking. And now I want you to count. Slowly, in rhythm with your breaths. Just keep counting up until I stop you."

Jack complied, and had just got to forty - and starting to feel really foolish - when something brushed against their fingers. They wriggled them as if to get rid of a curious insect, but after a few moment the sensation was back.

"Close your eyes and don't open them," Glimmer murmured. Jack did. The sensation of touching something grew stronger.

"Draw a circle in the air with your finger," Glimmer whispered. "Just a simple circle, and keep your hand in position after you

close it.

Jack did so. It felt like their finger was covered in cobwebs.

"Now what?" they said after a moment.

"Now you open your eyes," Glimmer said softly.

"OK," Jack said and did so. "What happened? Did it..."

And then they saw the glowing trace from their finger hanging in air, just by their hand. It wasn't very fancy - just an irregular circle, but for just a moment it was there.

Then it disappeared in a little puff.

"Congratulations!" Glimmer said. "You did magic."

Jack stared at their finger and the few remaining sparks.

"I... I did that?"

"Sure did!" Glimmer said with a proud smile. She patted Jack on the back. "You haven't seen it before?"

"Never," Jack said.

"Well, you haven't exactly hung out with an elemental princes before," Glimmer said with smug voice. "The magic levels are higher when I'm around. But with some practise, you'll be able to channel enough for a few tricks even when you're not with me."

"What kind of tricks?" Jack asked, intrigued.

"I dare say we will find out," Glimmer answered, slightly more enigmatic than strictly necessary.

"How did you get so good at magic?" Jack asked.

"As much as it pains me to admit it," Glimmer said with dry voice, "I had a good teacher."

- - -

In Brightmoon castle, there were no sounds.

No shouting voices, no running footsteps.

Only silence.

Even the ever present, merry trickling from the waterfalls were replaced by boiling, churning shadows.

There were always shadows.

Silent like a ghost, Shadow Weaver glided through the corridors.

Like obedient dogs, the shadows followed her, waited for her commands.

She stopped by a room, much like any other. The door obediently sprung open at her touch.

She stood in the doorway for a moment, thoughtfully regarding what was inside.

"It's time for you to wake up," she said, with low voice. "I have a little job for you."

The shadows poured into the room.

- - -

"*Glimmer!*"

The urgency of Catra's voice cut through the fog that clouded Glimmer's mind and she abruptly woke up. She looked around the tent, things scattered everywhere, Catra crouching, as if prepared to leap out of the way.

"A... are you OK, Catra?" Glimmer asked, desperately trying to get her still half-sleeping brain in gear."

Catra stared at her.

"Are *you* OK, Sparkles?" she asked.

Glimmer felt a sinking feeling in her stomach.

"What happened?" she whispered.

"Your magic went haywire," Catra exclaimed. "Which kinda made for a rude awakening."

"Did I hurt you?" Glimmer asked, looking at Catra in fear.

"Of course not," Catra scoffed. "You couldn't do it awake, what makes you think you could get a hit in while sleeping? But you did a number of the tent..."

Glimmer looked around. Things had been flung around with considerable force, the way it looked. At least there weren't any burnt marks.

"I... felt something," she slowly said. "In my dreams. Something happened."

"What kind of 'something' Catra asked, standing up from her crouched position and stepping up to the bed.

"A magical something. Something to do with the flow of power. Something to do with the runestones," Glimmer said.

"Vague yet foreboding," Catra remarked with dry voice. "What can we *do* about it?"

"I don't know yet," Glimmer admitted.

"Well, then," Catra said and slip back in the bed next to Glimmer. "Let's chalk it up as yet another case of 'weird magical shit' and go back to sleep."

Glimmer gave her a cautious look.

"Is that wise? What if..."

"You won't hurt me, Sparkles," Catra scoffed. "So cut that out right away."

"You can't be sure of that," Glimmer countered.

"Yeah, I am," Catra said simply. "I'm sleeping here so either you kick my ass and haul me away or you deal with it. Simple enough for you?"

For a moment Glimmer looked like she would argue, but then she breathed out.

"Thanks," she said, suddenly very vulnerable.

"Anytime," Catra answered, and they shared a honest, grateful look.

Catra smirked.

"Of course, if you can't sleep there are other things we might be doing..."

Glimmer laughed.

"I like where this is going. Come here and tell me more."

Catra did.

- - -

"Good morning to you, my fine assembly. I trust you all had your morning porridge and are fresh and alert."

The lieutenant and the other members of Catra's inner council laughed dutifully, as you do when the boss makes a joke. They sat around a table in the mess tent. Glimmer stood behind Catra, face neutral behind the veil. Jack was serving wine.

"We're all ready to kick some ass, boss," one of the bandits said. The others nodded.

Out of the five hand-picked by Slither the first day, three remained. The other two had lost their spots to the tried and true method of succession of being beat up by some of the newcomers. Catra had also expanded the council successively until they were now eleven members, excluding Catra herself - who was the boss, Glimmer - who had decided she was welcome at any and all decision making levels in the gang and who was not going to be contradicted after the example she had made, and Jack - who by now was expected to hang around Catra and Glimmer at most times.

"Good," Catra said. "Because ass-kicking is on the agenda today." She grinned.

"We're stepping up the raids?" one member asked. Catra shook her head.

"Nah, we've picked all the easy nearby targets already. Besides, with the new influx of food from the new members of our little merry band, we're good for a few days."

"Yeah, what we really need is to take out the other gangs," another interjected. "The Hooked Knives are..."

"...are not a problem." Catra interrupted. "If they come sniffing, we beat them up. If they stay out of our way, we can deal with them later."

"What we really need is equipment," another said. "We're getting too large to move around easily, and we don't have enough communication equipment for easy coordination. A smaller gang can do without, but we need vehicles, comm pads. The good stuff."

"Exactly," Catra drawled. "And we need to stop picking off the small fry. It's time to go against the *real* power in the Crimson Waste."

That got their attention.

Catra grinned and leaned forward slightly.

"It's time to take on the Horde."

They grinned at each other. This was the what they were here for.

Slither spread a crude map on the table.

"Right," she said, attempting to sound professional. "The Horde initially had a much larger presence, during their initial power grab..."

"That was my call," Catra said sweetly. "Three fortified battalions and a number of smaller companies at strategic locations, as well as a seizable presence in Valley of the Lost to build up a network of snitches. I figured showing you goons a show of force would make you fold. Worked like a charm."

"Hrmmm. Yes," the lieutenant said, slightly bothered. "But now Hordak has pulled a lot of that out, only leaving a skeleton crew, what with the push against the princesses and all." She remembered herself. "No offence meant, my Queen," she hurriedly said to Glimmer.

"None taken," Glimmer said with a neutral, somewhat eerie voice.

"So anyway, I figure we could start with one of the smaller forts..." she pointed at the map. "This one covers one of the more commonly used roads west, and has decent water supply nearby. We'd have to bring them down quickly, but if we take a small group and sneak in at night..."

"I like what I hear," Catra interrupted. "Keep working on that plan, we'll do than one next. But for our first one I had something slightly different in mind." She pointed at the map. "This."

The lieutenant frowned.

"That one? It's kinda out of the way, isn't it? I'm not sure it's even manned."

"Oh, it's manned," Catra grinned. "And well stocked. Vehicles, weapons, communication. You believe me, we will be in a much better position to pick off the other fortifications after we take that."

"Sure thing, boss," the lieutenant shrugged. "So then, me and the gals could sneak over the wall, and then..."

"Nah, I'll do this one myself," Catra said offhandedly. "You've worked hard whipping the gang in shape. You can sit this one out."

She sniggered at their expressions. "What?"

"...yourself?"

"Catra," Glimmer said with forced patience. "I know you are badass and all, but you can't take down an entire Horde fortress by yourself. That's the whole *point* of having an army in the first place."

Catra pretended to think that over.

"Fine," she amended. "I'll take Jack."

"Jack?" Glimmer asked.

"Me?" Jack asked.

The lieutenant, wisely, stuck to her policy of not questioning the boss.

"You!" Catra grinned. She stood up and patted Jack on the back. "Come on, kiddo! Time to kick some butt."

- - -

"So..." Jack said.

"Yes?" Catra asked.

"On the other side of this ridge is a Horde Fortress."

"Just a small one," Catra said offhandedly.

"And we're walking up to it in broad daylight."

Catra looked down at their feet.

"Sure looks like it."

"They'll see us."

"I sure hope so."

"They have guns and blasters and stuff?"

"That's why we're doing this in the first place."

Jack looked at Catra with narrow eyes.

"All right, I give up. What's the trick."

"Trick?" Catra said innocently.

"We are not just going to walk up there and ask them politely to hand over their stuff, are we?"

"Of course not," Catra said - pretending to be shocked. "That would just be rude. No, we're walking up their asking them to *join* us. Then it will be our stuff too." She tapped her temple with her finger.

"What if they refuse?" Jack asked.

"Why would they do that?" Catra shot back.

Jack sighed.

"You're really not going to tell me?"

"What?" Catra asked. "And deprive myself of the look on your face when you figure it out?"

"Fine," Jack muttered. "But if you get me killed, Glimmer will be super pissed."

"She hasn't been properly pissed with me for a while," Catra mused. "Really makes her riled up, you know."

"*Catra*!" Jack protested.

Catra laughed.

"Just pulling your tail, kiddo. Now let's go score our first victory over the Horde."

And before Jack had time to protest, they crossed the ridge and started to walk down to the fortification below.

'Fortification' was overselling it a bit. It was mostly just a permanent camp site who's inhabitants adhered to the same 'dig and build to keep soldiers busy' philosophy as Catra. A gate of sort - mostly and old metal sheet - blocked the passage. Behind it, two Horde soldiers quickly scrambled to their feet and shouted at their officer.

Weapons were drawn.

Blasters were aimed.

Catra just sauntered up towards the gate as if she owned the place.

"I sure hope you know what you're doing," Jack muttered.

"Where's the fun in that, kid?" Catra leered.

"Halt!" one of the soldiers cried. "Identify yourself."

"Care to introduce me?" Catra asked.

Jack swallowed and took a step forward.

"Queen Catra of the Crimson Waste wishes to speak to you!" they cried, carefully eyeing the blaster in the soldier's hand, prepared to bolt.

Their words caused a stir with the guards.

After a quick, whispered conversation, during which Catra just stood and grinned, the sheet was moved to the side and an officer came forward. She was dressed in Horde Uniform and had a stun baton by her belt. She had horns on her head and was flanked by a lizard woman with four arms.

"Oh, hi boss," she said. "We started to wonder where you got to."

"Madeleine!" Catra cried and happily held out her fist for the goat woman - her former lieutenant - to bump. "And Josephine! Give me ten!" She did two quick high fives with the happily grinning, four armed lizard woman.

Catra gave Jack the most obnoxious grin she was able to muster.

"Told you, Jack. I've got this."

- - -

"You had your own private company?" Glimmer asked as Catra and her convoy of Horde soldier rolled into the camp.

"Half of the Horde was mine," Catra shrugged, "at least as long as Hordak wasn't looking. These gals, they followed me all the way back from my last stint as Queen of Crimson Waste. They never really got into the whole 'live and die for Hordak' thing and preferred to stick with me instead. When things heated up, I sent them away to have as an ace in my sleeve when Hordak did his move. I didn't anticipate it to take this long, but hey - they holed up well and good. We've all the equipment we need now to take the next fortification."

"And Hordak's just let them be?" Glimmer asked as they strolled back towards the tent.

"I doubt he even knew about them. He cracked down on Lonnie hard enough, but these gals," Catra shrugged, "they just slipped away."

She leered.

"Turns out, the last Force Commander wasn't as diligent with the paperwork as perhaps she should."

They laughed.

"Well, good work nevertheless," Glimmer said, earning herself a proud smirk. She lifted the tent flap. "Now we can focus on..."

Her voice trailed off.

Catra, just behind her, stopped dead in her tracks, staring with open mouth. The tent flap fell down after them.

"Hello Kitten. Hello Sparkles. Missed me?"

In the tent Adora lounged on the bed, a sardonic smile on her face.

Chapter End Notes

> After all relationship drama in these last few chapters, that initial scene was such a relief to write.

Cost of doing business

Chapter Notes

Warning: Violence and grief

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer could only stare at the woman in front of her, conflicting emotions welling up inside her like water from a fire hose. Catra, on the other hand, gave Adora one look and grabbed her by the throat, claws on her windpipe.

"Got anything to say to the traitor before I kill them, Sparkles?" Her face was a furious snarl.

Glimmer blinked a few times, then she got it.

"Double Trouble?" she gasped, her stomach still in turmoil from all the feelings seeing Adora's face had awoken.

The changeling laughed as good as they could in Catra's grip and changed into their own form. Catra held them steady and looked at Glimmer, a quizzical eyebrow raised.

"Don't... don't kill them," Glimmer managed. "Not yet anyway. We need to find out what they know about what's going on in Brightmoon."

With a frustrated noise Catra dropped the spy in the middle of the tent. She stalked over to one of the chests and half-sat on it, positioning herself behind the shape-shifter. She very pointedly picked up a knife and started to clean her claws with it.

"I must say I'm impressed, Kitten," Double Trouble said with as much bravado as they could muster with the throat still hurting from Catra's grip. "I got Sparkles here well and good but you - I didn't fool you for even a moment."

Catra growled.

"You did, actually," Glimmer said with low voice, earning herself a death glare from Catra and a careful look from Double Trouble. "For just a moment she thought Adora was here. Then you snatched that away from her. If I were you, I'd keep that in mind as you decide how helpful you are going to be during the next few minutes. You hurt Catra, and right now she has very few reasons not to hurt you."

Double Trouble gave Glimmer a very cautious look and then slowly turned their head nodding to Catra.

"My apologies, Kitten."

Catra barred her teeth and Double Trouble turned back to Glimmer.

"I do hope you forgive me for not being able to resist a flashy entrance, but I actually do intend to be 'helpful', Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon."

Glimmer regarded them with disdain.

"Not a queen any more, Double Trouble."

They broke out in a grin.

"Beg to differ, my Queen. Your castle has been taken from you by an usurper. That does not diminish you claim. A queen in exile is still a queen."

Another set of complex emotions welled up in Glimmer's chest. This was not lost on either of the other two people in the tent.

"Not much of one, I'm afraid," she whispered.

"Not at the moment perhaps," Double Trouble leered, "Meaning no disrespect to 'the Queen of Crimson Waste', of course."

"Is that how you found us?" Glimmer demanded over Catra's angry growl.

Double Trouble laughed.

"Please! The entire Waste is buzzing with news about the Queen's return. The way people are talking she's going to unite the gangs, liberate the Valley of the Lost and send the Horde packing."

"And you don't believe that, do you?" Glimmer asked with narrow eyes.

Double Trouble did a little bow.

"On the contrary! I told you before, darling. I work for the winning side. And right now, with the princesses beaten, with no shining hero in sight, with the Horde gaining ground for every day, with Shadow Weaver entrenched in Brightmoon... that means you."

Glimmer blinked. Catra looked up sharply.

"Us?"

Double Troubles grin widened.

"I have seen what you can do, darlings. Both of you, with you working against each other. With the two of you teaming up... let's just say I know a winning horse when I see it."

Catra and Glimmer shared a long look.

Catra did a little shrugging motion and let her claws slide back in. Double Trouble breathed out.

"You're the most merciful of regents," they said with smarmy voice.

"What's happening out there?" Glimmer demanded.

Double Trouble gave her a smarmy smile.

"Dark bodings, oh my Queen. Tidings such as the pretty pink hair on your head will turn white as you hear the tale of woe I'm about to..."

"Catra, hurt them," Glimmer said with aloof voice.

"OK, OK!" Double Trouble laughed and hurriedly took a step to put the table between them and Catra. "I'll give you the boring version."

"Just stick to the observation and leave the dramatization for the camp fire," Glimmer said. "What is Hordak up to."

"Why, hunting princesses, of course," Double Trouble said with serious voice, "and getting better at it, if what happened yesterday was any indication."

"What happened yesterday?" Glimmer asked, voice suddenly shaking.

"Plumeria fell," Double Trouble simply said.

Glimmer was suddenly white in her face.

"Perfuma...?" she asked, voice barely a whisper.

"I don't know," Double Trouble said with an uncharacteristically sympathetic voice. "Everything I know about the latest developments comes from secondary sources, you understand?" They held up a little comm pad with a crafty wink.

"What happened?" Catra asked. She put a supportive hand on Glimmer's shoulder.

"The Horde had Plumeria under siege," Double Trouble explained. "Perfuma held them at bay with the power of her runestone, but they were winning ground every day. Then, yesterday... something happened. It was like the barriers just disappeared. Miles of thorn hedges withering away. Roots that would grab soldiers just being idle." They shrugged. "Something happened,

either to the princess or the runestone. I don't know what, and I don't know anyone who does. But the Horde took control. No one has seen Perfuma, but Spinnerella was spotted escaping."

"Where?" Glimmer said. Double Trouble shrugged again.

"My guess would be the kingdom of Snow. But you princesses are not exactly predictable, so who knows."

"Frosta is still holding her borders?" Glimmer said, a glimmer of hope in her chest.

"That she does," Double Trouble leered, but 'holding her borders' doesn't entirely do her justice." Their smirk widened. "The roads to Snow by land or sea are blocked by pack ice, the like of it has not been seen in our life time. Grinding. Churning. Not a single Horde vehicle has made it through. But Hordak is persistent and he's trying to establish a beachhead."

"What about the others?" Glimmer demanded. "Mermista? Netossa?" her voice grew weaker. "Scorpia? Adora? Bo..."

Her voice cracked.

"I don't know," Double Trouble gently said. "She-Ra has not been seen since before the fall of Brightmoon. Most people thinks Shadow Weaver killed her or... something like it. No one has seen Scorpia or your little boy-toy either for that matter."

Glimmer closed her eyes. She forced her breathing to become steady. Catra gently squeezed her shoulder.

"I understand," she said after a moment.

"Netossa was in Plumeria until recently," Double Trouble went on, "and gave the Horde soldiers hell wherever she showed up. It's anyone's guess if she's still there or if she got out with her wife. Mermista..." their mouth split up in a big grin. "Well, no one has *seen* her since the day Brightmoon fell, but there are... signs."

"What kind of signs?" Glimmer asked,

"As you know, she ambushed Hordak on his way to Brightmoon," Double Trouble explained, "and she apparently caused quite a bit of damage until she was driven off."

Glimmer shuddered.

"No one has seen her since, but there have been a string of pirate raids against Horde ships and coastal fortifications that seemed to be almost supernaturally lucky with wind and waves. Also, there was a break-in in Salineas. The thief got away with a number of valuable artefacts connected to the royal court. They also put the entire Horde fleet garrisoned there to the match."

"What?" Catra said, impressed despite herself.

"Thirty ships up in flame in one afternoon," Double Trouble chuckled. "So even if I can't tell for sure that Mermista was paying the old homestead a visit, her hotshot boy-toy at least seems to have been around."

Glimmer managed a little chuckle.

"I'm glad to hear that," she said. She blinked hard a few times. Then she caught Double Trouble's eyes.

"What about Brightmoon?"

"It belongs to Shadow Weaver," Double Trouble said, for once not a trac e of sarcasm in their voice. "No one goes there. No one leaves. The whole city is shrouded in shadows."

"Sounds like what she always wanted," Catra muttered.

They pondered that for a moment.

They shuddered.

"But on a happier note," Double Trouble quickly said, "there is unrest all over the place. Pirate and bandits and home-brew rebellions are having field days and the Horde is too thinly positioned to do anything about it."

"Hordak was so sure he wouldn't have to bother much about the fortification phase," Catra mused. "Not if big bad Horde Prime was here to lend a hand."

"Yes, I did mean to ask you about that," Double Trouble said. "What's holding him up?"

Catra shrugged.

"No clue, but all I ever knew of it came from Hordak."

"Perhaps he doesn't even exist," Double Trouble speculated. "Quite the con if Hordak pulled it off."

"Yeah, a flair for the dramatic, that's our Hordak," Catra said drily.

"Don't knock that dark and brooding evil overlord aesthetic," Double Trouble drawled. "In fact, I might help you with some designs for when you take the Fright Zone. This whole 'pirate queen and creepy sorceress' vibe is a good enough fit for the desert - oh it's just so romantic, two thorny roses blooming together - but once you take the Horde you'll have some big shoes to fill. Gotta dress for the job, Kitten."

Catra blinked.

For a moment, something rare and soft could be seen in her expression.

"Take the Horde?" she whispered.

"That's your plan, isn't it?" Double Trouble said with eyes intently focused on her. "You don't plan to sit idle in the desert, and Hordak won't allow you to carve out a kingdom of your own. The

two of you will comes to blow eventually, and I already told you where my money is."

"You really think we can do it?" Catra asked.

Double Trouble laughed.

"The two of you? Working together? Of course you can do it. If I were Hordak I'd be working full time on getting space daddy to take me away from all this, because there is nowhere on Etheria he'll be able to hide once you get rolling."

"I start to see why we'd want to keep them," Catra said to Glimmer.

"They are good for entertainment," Glimmer said drily.

"I'm good for much more than that, as both of you know very well, my queens," Double Trouble drawled, and something dangerous flashed in their eyes.

"Yes," Catra said with measured voice. "I have not forgotten that. Very well, consider yourself part of our court, for whatever it's worth. If you want to make yourself useful, see if you can root out the Horde spies."

"Horde spies?" Glimmer asked.

Catra rolled her eyes.

"Don't go naive on me now, Sparkles. Of course the Horde has sent spies by now. Me and the gals keep an eye out, but Double Trouble can take a sneakier approach."

"Much sneakier," Double Trouble confirmed.

"Great! I'll show you your tent. Later, my Queen."

"Later, my queen."

They kissed. Double Trouble grinned.

They walked out of the tent and strolled through the camp together.

"I must say, Kitten," Double Trouble begun. "It feels good to... URGH!"

Catra held them by the throat. They could feel the prick of her claws against their skin. Not piercing, but definitely leaving the possibility on the table.

"If you hurt her, I'll kill you," Catra said in conversational tone of voice. Double Trouble tried to reply, or nod, or anything, but her vice-like grip didn't let them. "I just thought I'd make that clear from the outset this time," Catra went on. "I know how much you love your little games, but when it comes to her, we're *not* playing. Do we understand one another?"

Double Trouble managed to blink in what they hoped was a placating way.

"Good," Catra said in the same tone of voice. She seemed lost in thought for a moment, then she let go. Double Trouble slumped to the ground and stared at her, wide-eyed. "You can sleep wherever," she said. "Welcome to *my* court. Try not to fuck it up this time."

She sauntered back towards the tent with Double Trouble staring after her.

"Being in love suits her," they commented, rubbing at their throat.

- - -

"Why are you so insistent on teaching me magic anyway?" Jack asked.

"Might come in handy, don't you think?" Glimmer said loftily and moved Jack's hand slightly to the left, correcting their hand movement.

"Sure, but what's in it for you?" Jack answered and tried the spell again. A few spark fizzed and died.

"Always an angle, always a price, is that right?" Glimmer sighed.

"In the Crimson Waste, sure!" Jack answered.

"I'm trying to introduce another way of doing things," Glimmer said.

"So you are saying you don't get anything out of teaching me?" Jack pressed.

Glimmer laughed.

"I didn't say that," she said.

"What, then?"

Glimmer held up her fingers, sparks dancing between them.

"I need to learn a new way of doing this as well. How to use magic without overloading." She chuckled a bit remorsefully. "I've always been the weak princess. Always had to strain myself to use every single spark I could scrounge up. Now the magic of the world and the moon is always threatening to overwhelm me. I have to hold back."

Jack gave her a hesitant look. "When you did that thing with the light, when you took down those two people... you held back?"

"Oh yes," Glimmer said, her smile showing more teeth than before. "Otherwise I'd have put a crater in the sand as large as the camp... of course, I would collapse in a pile of rainbows if I did."

She sighed.

"Which, impressive as it might be, is not very useful. So I need to relearn the basics, need to figure out how to limit the magic flow

and still get enough to power my spells. That's where you come in."

She smiled at Jack.

"There is nothing that beats teaching when you need to learn."

"Oh, so you wanted a sparring partner," Jack said and made a move to draw the circle again. "Why didn't you just say so?"

"That would have been easier," Glimmer laughed. She took a deep breath. "Now, attempt the spell again. This time we'll add some more power."

She took Jack's hand. After a moment, it started to glow.

Jack finished their spell, and this time the construct held. Magic poured in from Glimmer's and travelled through Jack's arm and out through their other hand into the magic circle.

"Hold the spell firmly in your mind," Glimmer instructed. Your pattern is right, but it only exists for as long as you force the magic in place. If you relax it will earth itself into the path of least resistance, not in your circle."

"OK," Jack said, brows furrowed in concentration. "Now what?"

"Now you slowly increase the power," Glimmer said, the excitement in her voice clear.

Jack did so, and the glow of the circle grew steadily brighter.

"Now what?" they said through gritted teeth

"Now you close your eyes," Glimmer said softly.

Jack glanced at her.

"Why? What's going to..."

Glimmer squeezed their hand.

A surge of power flowed from Glimmer, through Jack and into the construct.

Jack yelped as the circle exploded in a light, bright as the sun.

"Not bad," Glimmer said happily, completely unperturbed by the mayhem.

Jack stared at her in shock.

"A bit of warning next time?"

"When you deal with magic, things will go boom now and then," she smirked and gave them her hand. "Be thankful it was only light."

"Flashy," Jack agreed and climbed back on their feet. "I'm just not sure how much use a lightshow will be in a fight."

"You'd be surprised," Glimmer laughed. "I made less glitter than that count for a lot when I first set out. If nothing else it might serve as an excellent distraction."

"Heh, I suppose," Jack said as they got their breathing under control. "Is it OK if we try it again, with a bit less power this time."

"Sure," Glimmer said. "Just draw the circle again and..."

Suddenly a commotion was heard outside. Glimmer quickly fastened her veil just as the tent flap opened and one of her ladies in waiting stuck in her head.

"Um... my queen?" she said. "We're under attack."

- - -

Everyone was running, shouting or running and shouting. Catra stood in the middle of the chaos, barking out orders. Next to her, the goat woman - Madeleine - did the same to her gang of ex

Horde soldiers. Catra grinned at Glimmer and Jack as they ran up to her.

"What's happening?" Glimmer cried.

"Finally the Horde's attacking," Catra said happily. "I was starting to think they would ignore us for ever."

"That's a good thing?" Glimmer asked.

"Sure it is," Catra answered. "The raids are fun and all, but this will be a victory for the whole gang to share - not to mention we could use some of the gear the Horde soldier's are kind enough to lug all the way here."

"How many are they?"

"We don't know, yet. The scouts saw a couple of vehicles, but there's plenty of dust kicked up behind them."

Glimmer gave Catra a careful look.

"We can take them, can't we?"

Catra laughed.

"Of course we can, Sparkles. They've put themselves in the worst possible spot. They're attacking us on our home turf with enough warning for us to prepare whatever ambush we like."

Glimmer's eyes narrowed.

"Sounds like a trap."

Catra laughed again.

"You're adorable, my Queen, but you're not fighting *me* any longer. This is not a scheme. The reason this sounds stupid is because it *is* stupid. This is just some hothead backwater force captain who want to impress Hordak and think I'm just another

upstart gang leader." She leered. "They still don't get it. They think of us as a nuisance, not a threat."

"Quite right," a bandit who had walked up to them said with a grin and morphed into Double Trouble's familiar shape. "Although I suspect they will soon learn their mistake."

"Do you have anything for me?" Catra demanded.

"Indeed I do, my Queen" Double Trouble said with a flourished bow. "There are some names I can tell you, people who should perhaps not be left to their own devices in camp during the attack..."

"Good," Catra said with a grim smile. She turned to Glimmer again.

"Do you have enough sparks for some action without starting to vomit rainbows?"

"I might manage a poof or two," Glimmer said carefully.

"Good," Catra smirked. "Then I want you to stay out of the action to begin with. Take the long way around and find a position in their rear. Once they get the bright idea to get out of the fray, blast their vehicles."

She smiled.

"They put themselves right where we want them. I see no reason for them to leave anytime soon."

Glimmer gave Catra a suspicious look.

"And you're not only saying that to keep me out of danger?" she asked.

Catra gave her an insulted look.

"Who do I look like? Adora? You can take care of yourself, Sparklepants. But unless you have another princess stashed away somewhere, blocking their retreat is where you'll be of the most use to us. Just try to not trash the vehicles completely. We want to be able to repair them afterwards."

"Fine, I'll do it," Glimmer agreed. "Jack, you can..."

"Jack will come with me," Catra interrupted. "You can take your mooks if you want company. I know you have recruited more. This could be a chance to break them in."

"Ladies in waiting," Glimmer corrected with an annoyed frown. She turned around and waved the aforementioned ladies closer.

"Sure, sure," Catra agreed. "Take them. Now, give me those names, Double Trouble, and then we will be off... hey, Sparkles?"

"Yeah?" Glimmer said.

"Have fun," Catra grinned.

"And you, my queen," Glimmer answered. "Take care of Jack."

They grinned.

Their eyes conveyed another, more worried, meaning.

Catra turned around to talk to the goat woman while Jack waited uncertainly behind her. Glimmer and her ladies in waiting walked back to the tent to make preparations.

She had to admit, preparing for battle felt less scary now when Catra wasn't on the other side.

- - -

The moons shone bright over the Brightmoon Castle.

Over the shadow-tainted Moonstone.

Shadow Weaver watched it in silence from the throne.

Her throne.

She sent a spiteful thought at Angella, hoping that the queen could see her from whatever otherworldly prison she was trapped in.

The high and mighty Queen of Brightmoon, with her throne and her runestone, the one everyone flocked to, begging for help against the Horde, the one Micah chose...

"I took your throne from you, Angella," Shadow Weaver hissed to no one but herself. "I took your husband. I took your castle. I took your *runestone*."

She silenced for a long moment, feeling the tug of the powers from the Moonstone.

"And I will have your child," she finished, voice dripping of spite.

By the feet of the throne, her shadows lifted their heads, in eager anticipation of what was to come.

- - -

The moons shone bright over the camp, fighting with the numerous bonfires for attention. Drunken songs and cheers were heard everywhere.

Why shouldn't they celebrate? They had just won an overwhelming victory over the Horde.

Catra moved between gangs of bandits and freshly recruited Horde soldiers, trading grins, handing out nods of recognition and in a few rare and treasured cases, fist bumps. Everywhere she went she was met with cheers and drunken admirations of how great their boss - the greatest boss - was.

She wished she could join in their celebration, but her head was too full of worried thoughts. Strategic concerns mingled with worries about gang moral and the ever present risk for mutiny.

Heavy is the crown on the head of the Queen.

Come to think of it, Hordak never took part of post victory celebrations back in the Horde days.

Neither did Shadow Weaver.

Catra couldn't help chuckle at the thought.

Jack was by one of the smaller fires, boozing with their pals and reaping their well earned recognition. They had done well in today's battle, and Catra had made sure she had recognized that in public.

Double Trouble had slunk away somewhere, no doubt playing their own little games. Catra didn't mind. People like them were inevitable in an army of their size, and at least she liked this one and was even willing to extend a measure of trust (no matter how stupid that was).

Glimmer...

Catra sighed and walked up to the Queen's tent. Her hand ached. The ladies in waiting stood guard outside, not taking part of the celebrations. In some sort of confused recognition of their station, they seemed to have decided that lady-waiting required abstinence. Catra supposed she should talk to Glimmer about that. She didn't like how they started to isolate themselves from the rest of the gang.

But it could wait. There were more urgent things on her mind.

"The Princess wishes not to be disturbed..." one of the ladies in waiting had the audacity to try. Catra ignored her and lifted the tent flap.

"Hi, Sparkles," she said softly as she entered the tent.

She saw Glimmer quickly contort her face, trying to hide her tears.

"It's OK, Glimmer," she softly said. "It's me."

For a moment it looked like Glimmer would scream at her. Then she sunk back into the bed.

She looked so small.

Catra sat down next to her.

Neither sad anything for awhile.

Catra thought of burning houses. A woman with a sword running towards her.

Blood on her claws.

"Your first?" Catra said eventually with low voice.

Glimmer just nodded. She was still very pale.

"What happened?" Catra gently asked.

For a long moment Glimmer didn't answer.

Catra didn't press.

"She just came towards me..." she whispered.

"It's OK," Catra said with low voice.

"I... I didn't dare to teleport and I didn't think there was time for running. I had a blaster and I..."

Her voice trailed off.

"There is always a first," Catra slowly said. "And you never quite forget it."

Glimmer looked up at her.

"You too?" she whispered. Catra shrugged.

"It's when we took one of the villages north of the Whispering Woods. Nothing special. Just... they came at me with a sword. I tried to scramble away but they were faster and I..."

She took a deep breath.

"Well, I couldn't get away so I went for them instead. Ripped their throat."

She glanced at her hands, as if to check if the blood was still there.

"I... I've been fighting for so long," Glimmer whispered. "Against soldiers, bandits, bots... you." She gave Catra a shy look. Catra gave her a little smile in return.

"I just never had to... kill anyone before," Glimmer whispered. "I could subdue them, teleport them away, blind them, trap them..."

Catra hugged her.

"Yeah," she agreed. "That's how it usually goes. That's how it's *meant* to go. I mean, most people feel like shit when they kill someone. It's only the real creeps like Octavia who gets a kick out of it. Even the Horde knows that. For all our 'tough guy' talk, forcing people to kill when they're not up to it would be shit for the morale. That's why we have so many bots. In the ideal scenario, they stomp in and do all the killing, with the people doing all the tedious and sticky stuff, like maintenance and mopping up, not to mention holding the territory afterwards."

"You didn't seem to bother that much about holding territory towards the end," Glimmer commented, even managing a bit of a bite to her voice. Catra made a little smile that didn't reach her eyes.

"That's what happens when you stop thinking of 'winning' in terms of 'reach your objectives' and think of it in terms of 'beating the other guys'."

They didn't look each other in the eyes.

"Profound," Glimmer muttered.

"I have my moments," Catra answered with low voice.

She sighed.

"Besides, most people who died in the war didn't die in our little scuffles," she went on. "It's disease or starvation or accidents that get them. Like in the village of Toadbridge. More than fifty people dead, and only three in direct hostilities. The rest..."

"Fuel factory exploded," Glimmer glumly interrupted. Catra gave her a surprised look.

Glimmer shrugged.

"I also got the reports from that. Damaged by one of your bots..."

"...because one of your troop transports stood just next to it," Catra filled in.

They exchanged a look of pure anguish.

"Fuck war," Glimmer mumbled.

"You said it," Catra answered. "And yet, here we are, gearing up for another one."

"No," Glimmer answered, a hint of steel in her voice. "We're gearing up for the next round of the *same* war. The same war that's been raging since Hordak first came to Etheria."

"Get rid of Hordak, get rid of the problem, eh?" Catra asked.

"Get rid of the *Horde*, get rid of the problem," Glimmer answered.

Catra shrugged.

"Sure, why not."

Glimmer gave her a surprised look.

"You really think so?"

Catra laughed, a bitter laugh.

"Of course not, Sparkles." I think war is shit and will go on for as long as there are people. Doesn't stop us from getting caught up in whatever war is going on at the moment.

"There have been hundreds of years without war," Glimmer countered. She sounded a bit more like her usual self now, Catra noted with relief. "Long before Hordak showed up. Sure, occasional scuffles, bandit raids, really *spirited* arguments..."

"I love it when you talk dirty to me," Catra growled. Glimmer smirked at her, both feeling a bit better.

"But for most of the time, the princesses kept the peace."

"What? No war between princesses?" Catra asked, curious despite herself.

Glimmer gave her a suspicious look.

"You're leading me on," she accused.

Catra gave her a surprised look.

"No? I'm honestly just curious. Why?"

"Because there have been some quite famous wars between princesses, actually," Glimmer carefully answered.

Catra raised an eyebrow.

"It has? I haven't exactly had a bias free history education, Sparkles."

"Still, that doesn't sound like something Horde propaganda would skirt over," Glimmer mused.

"Well, tell me, Sparkles," Catra said and sat up more straight. "Impress me with your knowledge."

"Sure, why not," Glimmer laughed. "If you're hanging out with a princess you should know what you're in for."

She collected her thoughts for a moment.

"I suppose we could as well start with Salineas."

"We're always coming back there, aren't we," Catra muttered. Glimmer gave her an apologetic look.

"This was before mom became queen, so, you know, a long time ago. Salineas has always been a bit... entrepreneurial about that whole 'Salineas rules the sea' thing. Mostly they use it as an excuse for tolls and privateering. But there was one queen - Atlanta - who decided to make it a full fledged empire. She took over some of the big independent port cities, forced the free merchant fleets to sail under her flag, conscripted the pirates to her fleet..."

"Sounds like fun times."

"It was, until the princess of Plumeria got worried they were going to go after her coastal towns next. So she amassed an army, which got Arachnida anxious..."

"Arachnida?"

"The Fright Zone before Hordak took over. Didn't Scorpia talk about it? It was her family's kingdom, after all."

"I doubt Scorpia was told much of her true history either," Catra said with dry voice.

"Figures. Anyway, the whole thing started to look really ugly, which got everyone else worried. The king of Snow issued an ultimatum, basically told Atlanta to back off, which she refused to do."

"Then what?"

"Then they united, all the rest of the elemental princesses. They threw her out back into the the sea, sank her fleet, took back the trade routs. That's when Salineas first built the Seagate. In the end, the others laid siege to Salineas until they grew bored. They made a big treaty about leaving the independent cities independent. It lasted well into my mom's reign."

"So the moral is, don't piss off the ruler of Snow?"

Glimmer smirked, an fond smirk.

"Honestly not a bad moral. I'm pretty sure Hordak underestimates Frosta. But it's more like, don't scare the other princesses enough for them to band together."

"Oh, now I get it," Catra said loftily. "This is about how good you were to rebuild the princess alliance."

"I was," Glimmer said modestly. "Because the true moral of the story is that the princesses don't usually band together. We usually stick to our own kingdoms, doing our own thing, but when there is a big enough threat we band together. That's why Mystacor and the independent cities were so slow so react to the Horde - they just figured the princesses would take care of it. Earlier we have. But up until Hordak, that 'big enough' threat has always been another princess."

Catra gave her a surprised look.

"It happened more than once?"

"Sure! Snow tried it once. And Brightmoon - again, before my mom's time - and even some of the non-elemental princesses. There was some sort of monster-tamer operating out of the Whispering Woods for a while that made everyone shit their pants. Most recently, Arachnida got into a border dispute with Plumeria that had everyone worried. Maybe..." Glimmer looked down. "Maybe it influenced how slow everyone was to respond to Hordak when he showed up from nowhere and threatened the Scorpion king."

"Scorpia always said the other princesses would hate her," Catra mused.

Glimmer looked guilty.

"Well, I'm glad at least that Perfuma and Frosta could disprove that idea."

"What?" Catra asked sharply.

Glimmer smiled at her.

"Frosta was all, 'new best friend!' and Perfuma..." she gave Catra a cautious look.

"Oh!" Catra said after a moment. Then she started to snigger.

"Way to go Scorpia!" she said.

Glimmer breathed out.

"They didn't really have time to go anywhere with it, but they sure seemed intent on trying."

She made a sour expression.

"If either of them is alive, hopefully they can try again, after the war."

Catra laughed, a bitter laugh.

"You think there is an 'after' the war, Sparkles?"

"Sure it is," Glimmer said sharply. "After we've won."

Catra gave her a long look but didn't say anything.

"We can do it, Catra," Glimmer said, voice steady.

Catra nodded, a bit hesitantly.

"Glimmer..." she said slowly. "There will be more moments like today."

"You don't think I know that?" Glimmer asked, voice sharp.

Catra did a little acquiescing gesture.

"You of all people really don't need to tell me about the cost of war," Glimmer went on.

Catra could feel the princess' body grow stiff. She held up her hands.

"OK, OK. All I'm saying is... there are alternatives."

"Catra," Glimmer said with level voice. "If I even for a moment suspect you try to shield or coddle me, I will kick you furry butt all the way to the Fright Zone myself."

Catra chuckled.

"Now there's an image."

"Just as long as we understand each other," Glimmer said, still holding Catra with a very direct look.

Catra looked away.

"Anyway," Glimmer went on. "The point is that the first princess alliance was the first time we all ganged up against an external threat, for all the good it did us. The usual state of affairs have

been that the independent states and cities are kept in check by the princesses, and the princesses are kept in check by each other. That's why there are elemental princesses in the first place," she concluded. "Not to rule but to balance."

Catra pondered that.

"Does there really need to be princesses, though?" she asked.

Glimmer gave her a suspicious frown.

"What?"

"Just thinking, if the planet is run by gangs, and as soon as one gang gets to big the other gangs mobs it... what do we need princesses for? Seems to me like the same thing would happen even without princesses. Like, if our lot here went out to grab stuff, there would still be other gangs to stop it."

"Didn't quite work that way with the Horde," Glimmer commented drily.

Catra shrugged.

"Well, neither did the princesses."

Glimmer looked like she was going to argue, but then she released the tension with a little laughter - if yet strained.

"Which rather neatly brings us back to my initial point - that the Horde is the problem. We get rid of it, we get back to a balanced world."

"With OR without princesses," Catra added. Glimmer rolled her eyes.

"Sure, why not. At the best of times the princesses are the least important anyway. There have been decades at the time when the princesses mostly are a single woman in a tower doing weird shit and some staff waiting on her, while the surrounding area governs

itself. Pretty much like Dryl. Not that the two of us have ever experienced 'best of times'."

"I wonder if they mentioned any of this stuff in Force Captain Orientation," Catra mused. "If I ever catch up with Scorpia again I'll have so many questions for her."

"If she's alive," Glimmer muttered.

"Yeah," Catra answered.

They sat in silence for a little while.

It was nice.

"Thanks for talking to me," Glimmer said. "I... it feels a bit better now."

"Anytime, Sparkles," Catra said and failed to make it flippant.

"I.. I think I will drain myself now," Glimmer said. "Then I'll get some sleep. You coming?"

"Sure, I'll just check on the gang," Catra said. "See if there's a fight that needs breakin' up or needs help to break out properly."

"Well, don't take to long," Glimmer said. "I want cat-cuddles."

She laughed at Catra's suddenly bashful expression.

"You're so easy to put out of balance it's funny," she smiled.

"Well, hanging out with you is one big roller-coaster," Catra muttered.

"Don't want you to think I'm boring," Glimmer said, her smile becoming more challenging.

"Believe you me, princess" Catra replied. "I've called you many things. 'Boring' has never been one of them."

"How about 'cute'?" Glimmer asked and lifted an eyebrow.

Catra laughed.

"Someone's fishing for compliments."

"Yes," Glimmer said, voice suddenly sincere. "Tell me I'm beautiful."

Catra looked at her.

Their eyes met.

There were all sorts of sarcastic or flippant comments Catra could have made.

But for whatever reason, none of them came out of her mouth.

"You are the most beautiful woman I've ever known, Glimmer," Catra said, voice sincere.

Glimmer did a whimpering little sound, suddenly looking very unsure.

Slowly Catra bent forward, and their lips met.

A long, gentle kiss.

They separated, looking at each other with wide eyes.

"You really mean that, don't you?" Glimmer asked, eyes very wide.

Catra could only nod.

"I love you, Catra," Glimmer whispered, a tone of amazement in her voice, like the words surprised her.

Catra suddenly looked very vulnerable. Very small.

"You do?" she whispered.

"I do," Glimmer answered. Their lips brushed against each other again.

"You promise?" Catra asked.

"I do," Glimmer said, voice steady.

Catra shuddered.

"I never thought... this... we..."

Glimmer held her harder.

"Neither did I, Kitten," she said with gentle voice. "But here we are."

"Fancy that..." Catra muttered.

The moment stretched.

Catra burrowed her face against Glimmer's neck.

They held each other like that in silence.

Then Catra started to cry.

Soft, gentle tears.

"So... sorry," she mumbled. "I..."

"Ssssssh, it's OK," Glimmer whispered. "Just stay here with me. Cry as much as you want."

"I never... I just didn't..." Catra tried.

Glimmer gently stroked her over her shoulder.

"I know," she whispered.

In the end, Catra never did check on the gang that night.

- - -

The fires were still burning, even if most of the soldiers were winding down. A few drunken songs were heard, a few drunken fights were fought, there were quite a bit of drunken physical activity that was not *fights* per se, even if there was some wrestling involved. Even the guards who had drawn the short straw - or simply were low enough in the pecking order - and had to stay awake and sober felt good. They were part of the best gang with the best boss and no one could shove them around any longer. What more could you ask for in life?

"Hey, did you see something?" one of them asked.

"No," said the other. "Some of the lads getting frisky, perhaps?"

"Maybe..." the other said without conviction... "hey, there it is again!"

A shadow moved over the dunes. Slowly, without any rush, the person casting it walked closer.

"Hey, who's there?" the guard shouted, but did not get any answers.

The stranger got closer. An imposing figure, carrying a staff. The guards took a better grip of their blasters.

"Who's the strongest in the Crimson Waste," the stranger asked with gruff voice. The guard stood tall. She knew the answer to that one.

"Queen Catra is!" she said, and then she said nothing on account of the blood flowing out from the wound in her chest.

"No," the stranger said. "Not any longer." She turned to the other guard who watched her in frozen fear. "Tell the so called 'Queen of the Crimson Waste' that her reign is at an end. Tell her that Huntara is here to kill her."

Chapter End Notes

I really enjoy how every single one of you immediately spotted Double Trouble last chapter.

The strongest in the Crimson Waste

Chapter Notes

Warning: Fighting and violence

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The moons shone cold over the desert.

The fires burnt.

The drums thundered.

The crowd watched in fascination mingled with fear. Many of them were still drunk, few of them had got more than a few moments of sleep.

It didn't matter.

The future of their gang hang in the balance. The bold dreams of Queen Catra clashing with the old ways that was once personified by the woman now here to challenge the queen.

If Catra won, they would go on to take back the Crimson Waste from the Horde, conquer the Fright Zone, Brightmoon, the Word (they were a bit hazy on Queen Catra's end game). If Huntara won they would...

They didn't know actually.

Who is the strongest in the Crimson Waste?

There was not complete silence, but it was also not the adrenaline filled roars normally associated with these affairs. The stakes were too high.

Catra lashed out with her whip again. Huntara easily avoided it.

Again.

The fight showed no sign of slowing down.

Catra was strong, but Huntara was stronger. Catra was fast, but Huntara was tireless. Catra was cunning, but Huntara had years and years of experience fighting the strong and the fast and the smart and the cunning. Catra could leap and feint and strike from any direction. Huntara always seemed to know were Catra would strike from next. She knew how to trick and misdirect and lure her opponents in little traps - just a moment of lost footing or overreached aim - where Catra would be vulnerable to Huntara's staff.

Catra changed her tactic. She tried to keep her distance, look for an opening. But Huntara had danced this dance for years, and she would not be the one to tire first.

"Why are you here?" Catra snarled at her opponent, low enough for the audience not to hear.

"To kill you," Huntara answered and struck. Catra just barely avoided the tip of the staff.

"Why?" Catra hissed. "Don't tell me you care about this pit."

"It's not for you to take," Huntara answered.

"What?" Catra spat. "You'd rather have the Horde hold it?"

"The Horde has its uses," Huntara calmly said. "From a distance, obviously."

Catra smiled, a mock compassionate smile.

"That's why you ran away, wasn't it? You got fed up with being bullied in the Horde so you found yourself a desert where you could be top bully instead. Not bad. I get it. I did the same thing, once. But then I got bigger ambitions."

For a moment something ugly could be seen in Huntara's face, like a cloud passing her eyes.

"I am well aware of your ambitions, Catra," she said, voice dark and smooth.

"Well, yeah, you better stand aside, then," Catra snarled, "because I'm just getting started."

She lashed out with the whip and managed a glancing blow on Huntara's shoulder.

"I'm gonna take these fine people here and make them *all* top bullies when we take over the Horde. Too bad if you think I stole your thunder, tough gal, but just face it - I'm better at this than you ever were. You never offered them more than a gang. I offer them a place in an army. You made loosing a bearable alternative - I offer them a chance to *win*."

Huntara took a step back and Catra gladly took the opportunity to get a few precious moments of rest. A rumbling sound was heard.

It took Catra a few moments to realize that Huntara was laughing.

"You think that's what you are doing? Winning?"

"That's what we're here to figure out, aren't we?" Catra cried and lashed out.

Huntara easily avoided her and landed a painful counterblow in Catra's chest.

"Yes," Huntara said calmly. "We are."

And the dance was on again.

- - -

Jack watched from the crowd, a worried frown in their face.

They knew Catra was the best. The strongest. The fastest.

They knew Catra could beat any asshole out there.

But still... this was Huntara.

Everyone in the Waste knew about Huntara.

"Quite the entertainment, wouldn't you say?" A smarmy voice said. Jack looked up and saw... themselves! A person who was their exact copy, down to the clothes and smudge on her skin, slid down next to them with an irreverent smile.

It took them a moment to parse what they saw.

"Double Trouble?" they asked.

The changeling laughed and took their own form.

"Jack," they said with a small nod. "The Queens' little protégé. Care to make a wager?"

"Catra will win, of course," Jack said and tried to sound convincing. Double Trouble studied them carefully.

"Do you believe that, or do you wish that?" they asked with deceptively soft voice.

"Both, I suppose," Jack answered.

Double Trouble laughed.

"Good answer. Incidently, I'm not taking your bet."

"You think Catra will win?"

"I've learnt not to underestimate the kitten," Double Trouble leered. "There's only one person who ever convinced me to bet against Catra, and she isn't here right now." They gave Jack a very direct look.

"Speaking of - where *is* Queen Glimmer?"

"Still in her tent," Jack answered, trying to parse Double Trouble's words for hidden meanings. "She claimed she had no interest in

seeing Queen Catra dispose of yet another upstart."

"Truly you don't think that's a fair description of Huntara?" Double Trouble leered.

"She was once the ruler of the Crimson Waste..." Jack said, face neutral.

"And might be again, depending on what happens in that ring," Double Trouble finished the thought. They leered and put a hand on Jack's shoulder. "This is a pivotal moment, Jack. The tipping point for this whole drama."

"Meaning what?" Jack said and shook the hand off.

"Meaning at least one of them has an ace in their sleeve. I can't wait to figure out what it is."

"Catra will win," Jack said again.

Double Trouble looked at her intently.

"And why is that?"

"Because she has offered us something Huntara never did."

"And *what* is that?"

"Hope."

Double Trouble nodded thoughtfully.

"You do have a point, kid. Still, it remains to be seen how much that hope is worth for Queen Catra right here, right now."

- - -

Catra was screwed and she knew it.

Whatever she threw at Huntara, she could counter it.

Whenever Huntara went on offensive, Catra barely got away.

And the whole time, there was the feeling that Huntara held back, that she had a reserve of energy she had yet to tap into.

She would not be the one to tire first.

So far, Catra had managed to hold her own, but she knew she couldn't keep it up forever. Her main advantage came from her agility and speed, and that drained her quickly.

And as soon she slowed down, Huntara could pick her off easily.

She landed from her last jump and lurched slightly. A quick expression - as if from pain - flittered over her face. She crouch and braced herself for Huntara's inevitable attack.

It didn't come. Huntara stood in defensive position, eyebrow raised.

Catra barred her fangs and got to her feet. Her feint hadn't worked.

She couldn't outsmart her opponent. Couldn't outfight her. Couldn't outrun her for much longer.

What remained?

Out-annoy her?

Catra could do that.

"This brings back memories, doesn't it?" she leered and ducked from what turned out to be a feint. "What happened last time again?" She allowed her claws to pop out for emphasis. "Oh yeah, I took your gang, took your weapon, took Adora and you ran away to Brightmoon with your tail between your legs."

"Yes, you did," Huntara said with calm voice. "You had your precious Adora at your disposal, the key to Hordak's portal device.

Your triumphant return to the Fright Zone secured... and yet you managed to waste your spoils completely. Entrapta banished, your little 'gang' scattered, you on the run from the very princess who now shares your bed. All you managed was to smash the fabric of reality like the petulant child you are, and even that victory was snatched away from you when Adora freed herself, despite your best effort to the contrary."

Say what?

Huntara smiled, a cold smile.

"You are pathetic, Catra. Even your victories amount to nothing, just like you yourself amount to nothing."

Catra suddenly got a sinking feeling in her stomach. Something was very wrong. And not only in the sense that she was about to be beaten to death.

"Now, that's uncalled for," she replied in a tone of voice she forced to be casual, if yet a bit annoyed.

She tried another whiplash, but Huntara caught it on her staff, and before Catra knew it, the whip was snatched from her hand.

"You have lost, Catra," Huntara said loftily. "You have lost your gang, lost your weapon, lost your princess and you will not be given the opportunity to run away anywhere, tails between your legs or not."

Seemingly from out of nowhere, a strike from Huntara's staff caught Catra in the stomach. She sank to her knees, wheezing.

Huntara walked up to her and bent down. She looked Catra deep into her eyes.

"It's finally time for you to die," she hissed. "You have stood in the way of my plans for the last time, you insolent creature."

Catra looked at the shadows that danced in Huntara's eyes.

She felt an all too familiar cold move down her spine.

"Shadow Weaver?!" she gasped.

"Farewell, Catra," the entity before her sneered. She aimed a blow with her staff.

Before Catra had time to move, shout, anything, it struck her head.

Jack cried out loud. The crowd gasped. Catra, already on her knees, fell to the ground.

Huntara stood up. She looked around at the crowd with a triumphant growl.

"Who is the strongest in the Crimson Waste?" she bellowed.

Who is the strongest in the Crimson Waste?

There was a moment of hesitation, a moment when everyone waited to see what everyone else would do, waiting for someone else to make the first move.

It was a moment of uncertainty, a moment when - despite the fact that everyone could see Catra lying broken by Huntara's feet - the victory was not yet certain, when the crown had not yet passed, when there was still an opening to change destiny.

A moment was all she needed.

Out of nowhere, there was a flash of light, a blinding super nova in the dark desert night. It was over in an eye-blink, but in its stead she stood, just as radiant, just as eye-stinging, dressed all in purple and pink and holding a staff, pointing straight at Huntara.

"Princess Glimmer is the strongest in the Crimson Waste," she said with clear, deadly voice.

- - -

Huntara was fast, but Glimmer could disappear and reappear in a puff of sparks. Huntara was strong, but Glimmer commanded magic powerful enough to melt the flesh from her bones. Huntara fought with years and years of experience. Glimmer fought with the grim determination of someone standing between her unconscious lover and her would-be killer.

Even so, Glimmer would have hardly been a match for Huntara in a fair fight.

But this was not a fair fight, and it was not exactly Huntara she fought. The entity that fought Glimmer was in two minds, literately, and those minds were at odds with each other.

"I know who you are," Glimmer said with low voice between blows. "I know what you have done. I can undo it."

"Bold words, little Queen," the thing that hid behind Huntara's eyes hissed.

"Merely observations," Glimmer countered and landed a blow with her staff. She teleported out before 'Huntara' could retaliate. Light was pouring from her every orifice and her skin glowed bright, but her voice was steady.

"Observations?" 'Huntara' scoffed. She struck out with her staff and forced Glimmer on the retreat. "Like the observations that you are exiled from your kingdom, from your throne and from your runestone. Like the observation that your precious princess alliance has fallen to pieces, your friends have abandoned you and all you have left is a handful of bandits in a desert and the most unworthy of creatures for someone with your talents."

"You always did underestimate Catra," Glimmer calmly said and ducked under 'Huntara's' blow, stepping closer to the cliff edge. "Just as you underestimate me. That's why you will loose, in the end."

"I will, will I?" the creature behind Huntara's eyes snarled. She forced Glimmer backwards, towards the edge. "And what makes you think that, princess?"

"Because you are a coward," Glimmer answered. "And Huntara isn't. Also, you allowed yourself to be distracted by gloating. You never could resist making a speech, could you?"

And just as the shadow entity tried to make sense of Glimmer's words, Huntara's eyes cleared - for just a moment - and with a furious snarl she hurled herself over the cliff edge.

The crowd cried out. Huntara screamed in rage as she fell. Glimmer poofed out of existence and - reappearing by Huntara's side in the air - grabbed her and teleported them back to the fighting ground.

Huntara sank down to her knees. Glimmer bent down in front of her.

She looked her in her eyes. For a moment they were clear from the shadows.

"You scared her off by jumping, but she'll be back in a heartbeat," Glimmer urgently whispered. "I can help you. I can get her out of your head, but you have to do something for me."

"What do you need?" Huntara said between gritted teeth.

"I need you to bleed," Glimmer said, her eyes full of light.

"Do it, Pinkie," Huntara hissed, her eyes already filling with smoke again.

Glimmer struck.

The crowd gasped as the sharp crescent of Glimmer's staff sliced through Huntara's chest. Blood flowed from the wound. Glimmer held her staff pressed against the wound for a moment, then she

carefully used it to paint a circle on the ground, centred on the still kneeling Huntara.

As she closed the circle, the staff flared up and the blood on the ground began to glow, dimly at first, but then brighter and brighter. The light pulsed, matching that of the bright glowing princess.

The crowd watched in dead silence. A fight to the death for dominance was one thing. This was something else.

This was princess business.

Without any warning, the light flared up, brighter than the sun, and for several, terrible heartbeats everyone had to look away.

Then the light died down.

Huntara laid slumped to the ground, next to the unconscious Catra. For a moment, wriggling shadows moved around her, and then they dispersed.

Only Queen Glimmer still emitted light, her skin and eyes and hair glowing dimly. She leaned heavily against her staff, face locked in an expression of pain and nausea.

She took a few heavy breaths. Then she stood tall. She let her glowing gaze sweep over the crowd.

"Catra is the strongest in the Crimson Waste," she whispered, voice unsteady.

The crowd hesitated. This was not how it was supposed to go.

"Catra is the strongest in the Crimson Waste!" A voice boomed in replay, strong and confident. One of the bandits stood up and held a fist up in the air. None of the others recognized her straight away, but that didn't matter to the crowd. One of them had spoken up, put her hat in the ring so to say. All uncertainty melted

away. The Queen had been challenged. The Queen had won. Who cared if it was just by proxy?

"CATRA IS THE STRONGEST IN THE CRIMSON WASTE!" the crowd roared, and all the tension, all the uncertainty, all the fear of the last hour exploded in a cheer that must have been heard all the way to Brightmoon.

"Catra! Catra! Catra!" the crowed cried.

"Good timing," Jack commented.

"Think nothing of it, kid," Double trouble said with a grin and regained their usual form. "They needed a stage prompt and I was happy to provide. Now, I think your Queen might need some help."

Jack was already pushing their way through the crowd to Glimmer who was rocking back and forth, unsteadily leaning on her staff. Her ladies in waiting had the same idea and quickly walked up to her. Glimmer nodded at the mighty form of the fallen Huntara.

"Bring her to your tent," she whispered. "Tend her wounds. Keep watch. No one else is to see her until I say otherwise. Don't allow her to leave, but be respectful." She had to take some deep, gulping breaths of air before she managed to go on. She looked at the lieutenants who had bent down by Catra's side.

"Bring your queen to my tent," Glimmer said. "I'll tend to her wounds myself. Allow the crowd to celebrate, but keep alert. I don't want any further disruptions tonight."

For a moment she looked like she was about to fall, but Jack hurried up and put Glimmer's arm around their shoulder.

Supported by Jack and by her staff, and followed by the soldiers carrying the unconscious Catra, Queen Glimmer returned to her tent, leaving behind her the ladies in waiting trying to figure out how to carry the unconscious Huntara, as well as a camp full of bandits fully prepared to start their celebrations all over again.

They were the best gang, they had the best boss and Catra was the strongest in the Crimson Waste. They even had their own princess, which - scary as it was - also was genuinely *cool*.

Nothing could stop them. The Horde was as good as kicked out already.

- - -

In the empty throne-room of Brightmoon, the lone figure of Shadow Weaver thoughtfully watched her shadows squirm and coil.

It seemed like the young Queen might be a challenge for her, after all.

Chapter End Notes

> I should just have named this fic 'the strongest in the Crimson Waste' while I was at it.

The Shining Princess

Chapter Notes

> Warning: Use and abuse of political and magical power. Entomophobia (insects)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There were many defectors from the Horde living in the Crimson Waste. Around camp fires and by bedrolls, half remembered horror stories were whispered in the night. The headless princess. The mad princess. The bloodied princess. Now they got another one to add to the list.

The Shining Princess had killed the mighty Huntara. She had brought the stars of legend from the sky and boiled twenty armed soldiers alive. She had stolen the magic from the legendary She-Ra.

She could hear every word said in moonlight, or possibly in shadow. She could see you from within the mirrors. She could read your thoughts. She collected the hearts of her enemies in a jar.

She was the puppeteer behind or the slave of or the lover of the Queen of the Crimson Waste.

If you don't eat your porridge, the Shining Princess will take you.

Every time the legend of the Shining Princess was passed on, it grew.

"I swear!" A woman with a scar across her face said. "She drinks blood and gnaws bones."

"It's true, I was there!" A man who sweated profoundly said. "She uttered a single word, and thirty Horde soldiers were burnt to crisp."

"I'm scared of Shining Princess," a child whined, one who none of the adults recognized, but assumed belonged to one of the other families. None of them saw the child sneak away some time later with a decidedly unchildlike grin.

Double Trouble took their own shape and strolled towards the next encampment to tell the next story, building the legend of the Shining Princess, one piece at the time. They sure hoped Glimmer appreciated all the hard work they put it. They had a good feeling of where this was going.

- - -

"I trust my reputation is in good hands," Glimmer commented with dry voice.

Double Trouble leered at her.

"People whisper your name in fear throughout the Waste, my Queen."

"As they should," Glimmer said with a hard glint in her eyes.

"Apart from giving Sparkles an ego boost, what have you accomplished," Catra cut in.

Double Trouble did an obnoxious little bow.

"I have put my finger on the proverbial pulse, my Queen."

Catra rolled her eyes.

"Yes?"

"And from here to the Whispering Woods, Catra is hailed as Queen of the Crimson Waste, no matter how valiant the Horde commanders protest the notion."

Catra smiled.

"Good," she said. "It would seem we are ready, then."

"Ready to throw out the Horde?" Jack asked, full of excitement.

"Oh yes," Catra said. "Throw them out all the way to the Fright Zone."

"Since my 'kingdom' is in such good hands, I'll get going," Huntara gruffed.

"You are not staying?" Jack asked.

"No," Huntara simply answered.

Jack frowned.

"But why?"

"Because Catra is Queen of Crimson Waste," Double Trouble drawled.

Huntara gave them an annoyed look which they met with an irreverent smile.

"You don't expect the ex-queen to stick around, do you?" the changeling went on. "Bad form altogether."

"We could use your talents when we take on the Horde in earnest..." Glimmer said, voice trailing off.

"I don't doubt it," Huntara agreed. "I, however, have little use for you and your court, 'my queen'."

"I DID save you from Shadow Weaver," Glimmer pointed out.

"So you did," Huntara agreed. "I'll make sure it won't be necessary again."

Glimmer nodded, a quiet acquiescence in her body language.

"Where are you going now?" Jack asked.

"Valley of the lost," Huntara said and checked the straps on her backpack. "I have some scores to settle, some debts to pay."

Double Trouble chuckled.

"And then?" Glimmer pressed.

Huntara gave her a direct look.

"Anywhere. I don't have to stay in the Waste any longer to find those on the run - from the Horde or from the Shadow Queen of Brightmoon. I'm needed *everywhere*."

"I remember setting up the fortifications in Valley of the Lost," Catra said voice neutral. "I remember there being a little chasm just outside the main vehicle bay. I remember thinking, 'if something were to happen to the bridge... why, the majority of the Horde vehicle would be trapped.'"

Huntara looked at her with an eyebrow raised.

"Wouldn't that be a shame," she commented with dry voice.

"Shame." Catra echoed. "Anyway, me and the gals will probably pay the city a visit in about... two weeks. You know, just take in the sights. You know what I mean."

"I know what you mean," Huntara said.

"I *love* this," Double Trouble chuckled. "It's so *clandestine*."

"Glad to amuse you, lizard," Huntara said and rolled her eyes. Double Trouble smirked at her.

Huntara turned to Glimmer.

"There is one more thing you should know, 'your majesty'."

"And what is that?" Glimmer asked.

"Shadow Weaver trapped and snared my mind when she took over Brightmoon. I've been captive there ever since, until she found it within her to make use of me.

"Yes, I gathered that much," Glimmer said.

"Then you should also know that I was not the only one," Huntara said, eyes not leaving Glimmer.

Glimmer nodded, slightly paler.

"Do you know who?" she asked, voice almost not trembling.

Huntara shook her head.

"I only saw the cocoons. But this won't be the last time you see a face you once knew, with Shadow Weaver hiding behind their eyes."

"Understood," Glimmer said.

And Huntara went.

Catra was the strongest in the Crimson Waste.

- - -

Slither looked over the camp with a content grunt. Things were going well. Everyone were still giddy with excitement over their Queens' defeat of Huntara, New members showed up every day. The smaller gangs came to them now, not to fight but to sign up. The other bosses kept in line...

"Everyone's in shape, I take it?" Catra hissed from behind her. The lieutenant did her best not to jump. Damned, her queen could move silently when she wanted to.

"Everyone's in shape, boss," she said and stood up a bit straighter. "I'm having them expand the camp again, and putting some of the new gals in outposts to cover our area... don't worry, I have

old hands watching them. The rest are drilling. You say the word, we're ready to move."

"Excellent!" Catra said, genuine appreciation in her voice. She nodded towards a group of people in the outskirts of the camp. "What about those?"

"Refugees," the lieutenant shrugged. "Just the latest of the group to show up hoping to mooch some food. I'll get rid of them."

"Please," a woman pleaded. "There is nowhere else for us..."

She was about to continue to plead their case, but she silenced in fear as the lieutenant took a threatening step towards her. Catra put a hand on her shoulder and she stopped. She gave Catra a quizzical look that Catra ignored.

Instead, her attention was focused on a small child, hiding behind the adults.

"You," she said with not unfriendly voice. "Step forward."

After some hesitation, the adults parted and the frightened cat child gave Catra a quick look.

"I have seen you before," Catra stated. The child nodded, afraid to speak.

"I gave you a toy last time we met," Catra went on. The child nodded again, and then, with a quick look at the adults to confirm it was OK, slowly opened the bundle they carried and took out a Horde standard issue stun baton.

Catra smirked and bent down.

"Found any use for it?"

The child nodded, and then finding a bit more of bravery answered in whispering voice.

"One of your... friends tried to grab me. I... zapped them."

Catra laughed.

"Glad to hear it kid. Don't you take shit from these guys." She stood up and caught the eye of one of her underlings.

"Make sure to give this fine fellow a spare charge pack. Can't have him run out of zaps, eh?"

"Does that mean we can stay?" one of the adults dared to ask. Catra frowned.

"You will be fed," a calm voice answered from behind Catra, before she had time to answer. Despite the low, conversational tone, the voice carried well and everyone gathered took notice. Catra glanced behind her and saw Glimmer walk up to them, flanked by two of her ladies in waiting. She stopped just in front of the child who looked up at her veiled face in apprehension.

"You will be fed," she repeated in the same calm voice. "You will be clothed. You will be given tools and weapons, as needed to carry out the work you will be assigned. You came here as refugees, and you will be given a place in the court of the Queen of the Crimson Waste."

"Oh..." the refugee said, paling slightly. "There will be no need to..."

Glimmer ignored her. With assertive movements, not for a second signalling that her actions could be perceived as unwelcome, lifted up the child. She looked around.

"Everyone is welcome here," she said with loud voice. "Everyone cast aside by the Horde and the usurper in Brightmoon have a place in the liberated Crimson Waste. She stepped forward and handed over the frightened child to the refugees he travelled with.

"You are under the protection of the Queen now," she said and nodded at Catra who watched her in silence, a quizzical eyebrow

raised.

"Tha... thank you," the refugee who had accepted the child stammered. "But all we need is some food and we will be on our..."

"Nonsense," Glimmer said and gracefully took a step back. "You are part of the court of the Crimson Waste now."

And accompanied by her ladies in waiting, she walked back towards her tent.

Slither stepped up to Catra.

"We're... letting them stay?" she asked, voice neutral. "All of them?"

Catra made a frustrated grimace.

"Seems like it," she muttered. "Get it sorted out. I'll talk to her."

The lieutenant nodded, still maintaining a carefully neutral expression. Catra sighed and walked after Glimmer.

She seriously started to wish the princess would give her a heads up on these things.

- - -

"Well, care to fill me in," she grumbled as she stepped into the tent. Glimmer had just pored up a cup of water. She handed it to Catra.

"What's there left to say, darling?" Double Trouble drawled from the trunk they had picked as their lounge spot.

"I wasn't aware we were running a refugee camp," Catra said with grumpy voice.

"We are running a court, my queen," Glimmer said, eyes glittering.

Double Trouble giggled.

Catra shot them a sour look.

"Since the two of you have such a grand time of it, could you *please* tell me what Queen Sparklebutts here is up to now?"

"She's feeding the hungry," Double Trouble said, eyes intense. "She's taking in the desperate. She's promising those who have nothing a *something*." They laughed. "I told you she is dangerous."

"You can build a bandit gang or an army from those who fight," Glimmer explained. "But if you aim to build a kingdom, there is one thing above all else you have to offer to *everyone*, regardless of if you can provide it or not."

"And what is that?" Catra sighed.

"A future," Double Trouble drawled. "A shared dream. A place by the fire." Their smile widened. "A *story* about *them*."

"To think I once thought I was clear of politics," Catra grumbled.

"No such thing, darling," Double Trouble sniggered. "Only thing to chose is if you're the one pulling the strings or the once stuck in them."

Glimmer coquettishly lowered her gaze, suddenly seemingly engrossed with her nails.

"Well, what do I do with a camp full of starving people?" Catra grumped. Glimmer put a soft hand on her arm.

"*You'll* do nothing. *I'll* feed them. *You'll* keep leading your army. *I'll* take care of the civilians for you. I dare say there's a lot of work that needs to be done."

Catra gave her a long look.

She turned to Double Trouble.

"What just happened?" she asked.

"Depends, on your martial harmony," Double Trouble sniggered. "As long as the two of you pull in the same direction, your queen here just handed you the Crimson Waste."

Catra blinked.

"I thought the Horde had the Crimson Waste."

"Nope, they have the largest army in the Waste. Not the same thing. Up until now you have had a band of thugs, an army if I'm generous. Now you have a population. A *people*."

"A kingdom," Glimmer said sweetly.

Catra narrowed her eyes.

"You mentioned another prospect," she said.

"Ah, nothing I foresee," Double Trouble drawled. "I just mentioned the technical possibility out of a sense of completionism. But if there ever were to be a little... hiccup in your martial bliss, my guess is you would experience the usual fate of a kingdom with divided rulers."

"Civil war," Glimmer said calmly. She met Catra's gaze. "I'm glad that's not something we will have to worry about."

Catra gave her a long look.

"Any chance of giving me a little notice next time you pull a stunt like that?"

Glimmer sniggered.

"What, and deny myself you looking at me like that?"

After a moment, Catra started to snigger as well.

"Never a dull moment with you, is there, Sparkles?"

"I should hope not," Glimmer said, just a touch of challenge in her voice.

"Well, that's all fine and good," Catra replied with just a hint of a blush, "but how are we supposed to find food enough for everyone in the dessert?"

"There is plenty of food in the desert," Glimmer said with serene - and maybe just a tad smug - voice. "Plants and animals hidden, waiting for the rare raindrops that will bring it to the surface."

"What? And you can just make it rain in the desert?" Catra asked.

"Yes," Glimmer said simply.

- - -

"Like this?" Jack asked.

"Exactly like that," Glimmer answered from the other side of the large area they have picked for the ritual. "Now hold the construct."

The ladies in waiting had taken position around the large, crude circle drawn in the sand by Glimmer and Jack some distance from the camp, shooing away the curious (but not *too* far away - they still got to be able to catch a glimpse of their princess in action).

Jack stood in the middle of the circle, holding a glowing construct of light like if they held a barrel hoop in front of them. Glimmer walked along the larger circle, just inside the line they had drawn in the sand. Glitter dropped from her hands and formed a glowing curve behind her.

"Um... are you sure about this?" Jack asked nervously.

"Don't you worry, they will come," Glimmer said, a touch of viciousness in her voice.

"That's... actually the part that worries me," Jack confessed. "You made them sound pretty bad."

"They caught me on a bad day," Glimmer said loftily. "This time it's their turn."

"What if..." Jack begun, but then the sentence disappeared in a scream as Glimmer poured magic into them.

"Hold the construct," Glimmer said with urgent voice as the figure in Jack's hands started to shine like a search light. The light spread from the construct, along the trails Glimmer had placed and out through the entire area. Within moments a magical sigil large as a dance floor lit up the desert.

"What do I do?" Jack screamed.

"Just let the magic flow," Glimmer said and stepped up to them. She had thrown back her hood and taken off her veil, and her eyes and skin glowed with power.

"I... I think it's flowing over!" Jack cried, as sparks flowed from their hands on all sides of the circle.

"That's the whole point, remember," Glimmer said. "The light is neat for a show, but what we're after here is the raw magic. Just focus on channelling magic to the construct, and don't worry about the spillover." She squeezed Jack's shoulder, and the intensity of light and sparks increased.

"I'm not sure how long I can keep it up," Jack cried, light starting to pour from their own eyes as well.

"Oh, you can," Glimmer said. "For as long as it takes. Because we have just begun."

She already heard the excited chitter of beetles as she and Jack poured out a feast for them.

"Listen, Sparkles," Catra said with low voice as she walked up to her. "I know you're working through some stuff, but..."

"I'm doing my duty, my Queen," Glimmer said and turned her burning eyes towards her girlfriend.

"Yeah, yeah," Catra muttered and took an uneasy step back. "And just happen to get some sweet payback in the process. I get it it. Nothing wrong with a good show-'em-all. Just wanted to make sure you're all right?"

"I'm more than 'all right', my Queen," Glimmer said with a vicious smile.

"And the kid can take it?" Catra asked with a nod towards the straining Jack.

"They are, strong," Glimmer said with a shrug. "They can take it."

Catra and Glimmer looked each other in the eyes in silence for a long moment.

"Well, I sure hope you know what you're doing," Catra muttered, "because the beetles are coming. The gals are letting them through, just like you ordered."

"Good," Glimmer said. "Then perhaps my Queen could see fit to leave me and Jack to our business."

Catra gave the struggling teenager a last, long look. She shook her head and walked back to disperse the crowd.

They needed to leave room for the beetles.

Glimmer lifted her hands and sparks poured as from a fountain. She threw off her cloak. She was not *completely* naked underneath it - in fact, she was actually rather modestly dressed by Mystacor standards - but Glimmer knew the value of a good show, and while the loose sheets of cloth she wore covered quite

a bit of her glowing skin, they were also very good at suggesting just what bits were covered.

The onlookers gasped. Those in the back tried to push themselves forward, and those in the front tried to push back in case Glimmer would suddenly do something princessy.

Glimmer knew that by morning, human nature (and quite possibly a few little nudges from Double Trouble) would have spun the tale of the princess dancing naked in the moonlight, flinging deadly magic, better than anything she could ever stage.

Moonlight poured into Glimmer, and she poured the magic into the empty desert soil around her. Jack soaked up the excess magic like a sponge and poured it out in their own construct. Glimmer smiled, a satisfied smile. What was it Bow had said once - for any problem there was always a technical solution.

She fought off the pang of guilt at thinking of Bow. He, of course, also always said that for any problem there was a *friendship* solution.

"Not this time, there isn't," Glimmer muttered.

The beetles flocked from near and far. Glimmer could *feel* the web of magic flowing through the desert, through sand and plants and the bodies of those who fed on them. The beetles - magivores as they were - stood out as nodes of concentrated magic in the barren landscape.

They could no more resist the lure Glimmer and Jack offered them than could starving dogs resist a pile of meat in the forest - no matter how suspicious.

Glimmer watched in satisfaction as the first insects came sniffing. Most of them stuck to the magic she had poured in the outer edge of the circle, but a few of them crawled further, towards Glimmer and Jack in the middle of the circle.

Glimmer held out a hand, dripping with magic, and - with a pang of nausea she quickly forced down - allowed the beetles to stroke antenna and mandibles over them.

For a moment she stood frozen rigid, but then she felt the initial revulsion die down as she realized the beetles were not hurting her. She held out her other hand and more magic pored out. More beetles came.

Glimmer screamed when a couple of antenna touch her neck, but but she bit it down and turned around, inviting even that beetle for the feast. She walked among the insects, getting more numerous by the minute, forcing herself to look and touch and feel, to normalize the experience.

She felt a triumphant laughter bubble up, and she did nothing to stop it.

No insects were the boss of her!

"Glimmer!" Jack cried as the beetles nudge closer to them and their shining construct of light.

"They won't hurt you," Glimmer said loftily. "But if they get too close, just activate the barrier."

Jack took a deep breath and slammed their foot down on a crude pedal rigged up by one of the camp makers. Immediately the beetle closest to them jumped back as electric sparks hit them. The barrier was made from the same principles as the stun batons, but consisted of a circle -that protected the person within it.

Quite a neat technological emulation of standard magical practise, Glimmer mused.

"How long will the charge hold?" Jack asked, focusing on holding their construct intact.

"Long enough," Glimmer said and pushed back a beetle that tried to get in her face to lick the sparks from her eyes.

"I sure hope so," Jack shuddered and eyed the squirming mass of beetles with distaste.

They waited for almost an hour, all the time seeing how more and more beetles scrambled in. The circle was a boiling inferno of large, chitin clad bodies. Glimmer had retreated to inside the stun circle as well, but she kept poring out magic.

Jack was starting to show serious signs of fatigue, and Glimmer decided enough was enough.

"Ready for the next part?" she whispered to the exhausted teenager next to her.

"What *is* the next part?" Jack panted.

"The part where we make use of all this magic," Glimmer said, and her eyes were hard like steel. "The part where these scavengers learn it's not their place to mess with an elemental princess of Etheria."

And she weaved the spell.

The last spell Shadow Weaver had taught her.

She felt the connections build, one by one like the fibres of a rope, tethering her to the magic of the huge sigil she had made, the feast she had poured for the beetles.

She finished the spell, and just like opening a dam, the flow of magic changed direction and flowed into Glimmer.

From the sigil.

From the beetles that fed on it.

The intensity of the light Glimmer emitted increased hundredfold. Jack screamed. The onlookers gasped as what suddenly looked like a miniature sun emerged in the midsts of the sigil. Glimmer felt the nausea well up in her. She knew she wouldn't be able to hold this sort of power for more than a heartbeat, even with Jack to feed off the excess to.

But a heartbeat was all she needed.

She teleported - up.

Far above the desert she lit up the sky as if it had been day.

And in one enormous wave she expunged all the magic she had absorbed. All the excess power from the moons and the earth and the beetles that concentrated it.

She let it all out in the Etherian sky.

It wasn't so much a spell as it was a tsunami of force. A bowling ball on the rubber sheet that was the sensitive Etherian climate system. The same shift in power that once had caused the Whispering Woods to freeze over now caused the winds to shift, waterlogged air to rush in from the ocean and clouds to form.

"The purpose of the elemental princesses is to balance Etheria," Glimmer recited to herself.

She smirked, amidst the rolling clouds.

How is this for balancing?

In front of the eyes of the terrified onlookers, the light Glimmer emitted winked out, and as the first drops of rain fell, she teleported down to the burnt out sigil again, to the unconscious Jack and to the lifeless husks of more than a hundred dead beetles.

Before Catra or the ladies in waiting had time to reach her, she fell face-first in the sand and was quickly lost to the onlookers behind

the heavy rain the rolled in.

- - -

"Don't *scare* me like that, Sparkles!" Catra said with exasperated voice.

"What?" Glimmer giggled. "It totally worked."

She sat up in the bed and massaged her throbbing head.

"How is Jack," she asked.

"Alive," Catra answered, voice somewhat cold.

"Good," Glimmer said.

She caught Catra's eyes.

"Anything the matter, Catra?"

"You could have *killed* them," Catra said, voice sharp.

"No, it was perfectly safe," Glimmer answered loftily. "They will have a headache and be a bit dehydrated, but they will be fine." Her voice grew colder "but I'm sure we could find someone to fight them to the death instead, should you find my care inadequate."

"Low blow," Catra muttered.

"Was it?" Glimmer said with the same cold voice. "You might not be in favour of my way of doing things. Do I have to remind you that I'm not necessarily the biggest fan of your way of running this band of thugs either."

"Hey, I already told you," Catra said hotly. "I do what has to be done."

"So do I," Glimmer said, and for a moment shadows danced in her eyes.

"Ladies, ladies," Double Trouble interjected and stepped between them. "Don't fight in front of the spy, I'm *so* sensitive to strife. Let's celebrate our victories instead."

"Sparkles' victories, you mean," Catra muttered.

"When you are partners in crime, you split the profit," Double Trouble leered.

"I take it it worked, then?" Glimmer asked.

"It did indeed," Double Trouble answered, a hint of admiration in their voice. "The whole area is blooming. Every available hand is out tending crops and no one will go hungry or thirsty for months, even if this was a one time miracle."

"And what do people think of me?" Glimmer asked.

Double Trouble winked at her.

"Never be shy to listen for applauds, my queen. Very good."

"They are terrified of you," Catra said.

"But also a bit proud of you," Double Trouble said. "Some say you are a monster, but then some say you are *their* monster."

"Like the princesses of old," Glimmer mused. She sighed.

"Not what your dear mama would have wanted?" Double Trouble grinned.

"My dear mama is dead," Glimmer said with flat voice. "I'm the queen now."

Catra looked away.

"And you aim for a different leadership style, I take it?" Double Trouble asked, all attention.

"My mother intended to sit out the war," Glimmer said, voice sharp. "I will win it."

"Of that I have no doubt, my Queen," Double Trouble said with a glint in their eyes.

"*We* will win the war, you mean," Catra said with sharp voice.

Glimmer gave her a placating smile.

"Of course I do, Kitten," Glimmer said. She put a soft hand on Catra's.

"It's you and me against the world, Catra," she said with warm voice. "That has not changed. That will never change."

Glimmer sought her eyes. After a moment, Catra met Glimmer's gaze. She looked at least somewhat mollified.

Suddenly there was a commotion outside of the tent. Catra sharply looked up.

"Who seeks to see the Shining Princess?" they heard one of the ladies in waiting ask (they were getting pretty good at it).

"Oh my, how serious we are," a friendly, somewhat motherly voice said. "You can tell the princess of the moon, if she still answers to that title, that the princess of winds request a *formal* meeting."

"*And* the princess of webs," another voice cut in.

"Of course, dear," the first voice acquiesced. "Tell Glimmer that Spinnerella and Netossa are here to see her."

Chapter End Notes

About time they showed up.

The princesses of winds and webs

Chapter Notes

> Warning: While war is constantly part of the backdrop in this story, in this chapter sieges and army moments is brought to the foreground together with descriptions of killing and death.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Hello Glimmer," Spinnerella said happily as she swept into the tent with Netossa in tow.

Glimmer looked up at them from the table, face white from shock. Catra and Double Trouble stood up from their own lounging places, looking like they were prepared to fight or bolt, respectively.

"Spi...Spi....Spinnerella?" Glimmer whispered.

"*And* Netossa," Netossa added.

"Oh, Glimmer," Spinnerella said, and before anyone knew what was happening she was hugging the young queen, hard. "I'm so glad you are alive. It's such a horrible mess we are in. No one knew where you went after Shadow Weaver took over and the princesses have been hounded nonstop by the Horde and we were all starting to suspect the worst - except young Frosta, naturally - and now look at you, alive and well in the Crimson Waste of all places."

"A *bandit leader* in the Crimson Waste," Netossa filled in, not entirely without admiration.

"Actually, *I'm* the bandit leader," Catra cut in. "Glimmer is in charge of the scary princess magic... you might have noticed that yesterday."

"We did indeed," Netossa said with a sharp look at Catra.

"'Noticed?'," Spinnerella said. "We felt it all the way to the Whispering Woods. You really did a number of the magical balance, Glimmer."

"And you did it with Shadow Weaver having her dirty paw's all over the Moonstone," Netossa said with clear respect in her voice. "I haven't seen anything like that since..." she hesitated, "Well, since Entrapta hacked the Black Garnet, I suppose. But I was going to say I haven't seen anything like that since Micah was alive."

"But how have you been?" Spinnerella asked. "How did you get out of Brightmoon? What did Shadow Weaver even do? We knew nothing, we just tried to hold the Horde at bay in Plumeria, and now poor Perfuma is helping young Frosta over in Snow."

"Glimmer," Netossa said, voice serious. "Where *is* Adora and Bow. What happened to them?"

"And Scorpia?" Spinnerella asked. "Perfuma and Frosta are just so sure she wouldn't go back to Hordak but then no one has seen her."

"And what about Mermista?" Netossa asked.

"Is she out camping with a bunch of Horde deserters as well?" Spinnerella said with a blink at Catra

"Mermista is not with you?" Glimmer whispered, still white in the face and seemingly overwhelmed by the onslaught.

Spinnerella and Netossa shared a look.

"We don't know where she is," Spinnerella said kindly. "She set out with her pirate to reclaim the Pearl from Salineas, and no one has heard from her since. We hoped you had..."

"I... I haven't heard anything," Glimmer said with low voice.

Netossa gave her a look full of concern.

"Of course you haven't. Poor thing, all the things you've been through."

"The company you kept..." Netossa muttered with another long look at Catra.

"We'll have plenty of time to catch up, once we are back in Snow," Spinnerella said.

"...Snow?" Glimmer asked, and her voice sounded very small.

"...Glimmer?" Catra asked with a twang of anxiety in her voice.

"Of course," Spinnerella laughed. "You didn't think we would leave you in a smelly old desert for the rest of your life, did you? Now, Frosta's castle is not as comfortable as Brightmoon, but you can at least get a decent bath."

"*And* better company," Netossa added.

"Perfuma and Frosta are worried sick about you," Spinnerella said, "and we have so much work to do."

She sighed.

"The princess alliance is in shambles, Glimmer. Hordak is pushing the borders even of Snow and most of the independent cities and villages... well, they have more or less given up on us. Even Mystacor keeps to themselves. We need the queen of Brightmoon."

"The *real* queen of Brightmoon," Netossa said pointedly.

"Yes, of course," Spinnerella said. "Shadow Weaver holding Brightmoon and having declared herself some sort of Dark Princess... well, it does nothing for the morale."

"You really made a mess, dear," Netossa sighed. "Good thing we found you."

"I'm not coming," Glimmer blurted out. Spinnerella and Netossa stared at her.

"What?" Spinnerella asked.

"Why?" Netossa added.

"I'm not coming," Glimmer said, voice more self assured now. "*We*" -she took Catra's hand- "didn't go to all this trouble just to hide away in yet another castle at first opportunity."

"You can't be serious," Spinnerella exclaimed.

"What do you even think you'll achieve out here," Netossa frowned.

"I *think* I'll get on with what *you* should have been doing all along," Glimmer said with cold voice. "I'll defeat the Horde."

"You can't defeat the Horde," Netossa scoffed. "You couldn't even hold Brightmoon."

Glimmer stared at her, unable to find words.

"Glimmer," Spinnerella said with soothing voice. "We have fought the Horde for longer than you have been alive. The entire princess alliance, your parents. What do you think you and that mangy cat can achieve with a handful of thugs that we couldn't."

"This 'mangy cat' was Force Commander of the Horde, in case you have forgotten," Glimmer said, voice shaking with rage.

"I have not forgotten her handiwork in Salineas," Netossa said, voice sharp as a knife.

Catra did not say anything, but she took a step forward, claws out.

"Glimmer," Spinnerella said with patient voice. What do you think your mother would say if she were..."

"She *isn't*," Glimmer snarled.

Netossa took a small step forward, the first tendrils of a magical net at her fingertips. Catra shifted her body weight. Their eyes locked.

"Glimmer...?" Spinnerella said. Glimmer said nothing.

The silence hung like a bomb with lit fuse in the air.

It was Double Trouble who broke it.

"Ladies, princesses, queens," they said and jumped to their feet. "Why don't we take a little break. I simply *must* show our esteemed guests around. There are such sights to be seen in our camp."

They walked up to Spinnerella - very purposefully placing themselves between her and Glimmer - and did a little obnoxious bow. They gesticulated towards the opening of the tent.

"Wait, we're not..." Spinnerella begun.

"Yes, we're leaving," Netossa interrupted, not taking her eyes of Catra.

"I think that's an *excellent* idea," Catra said, not taking her eyes of Netossa.

"Glimmer..." Spinnerella tried again as Netossa took her hand and dragged her towards the exit.

Glimmer crossed her arms and turned her back to them, refused to look at the two older princesses as they left the tent with Double Trouble in tow.

Catra took a deep breath. She waited a moment for the bickering voices of Spinnerella and Netossa to fade out, then she turned to Glimmer.

The 'Shining Princess' stared into nothing, her eyes were large and blank and her breathing was shallow. She hugged herself hard.

"You OK?" Catra asked. Glimmer closed her eyes and clearly bit down a snappish reply.

"Of course," she said with shaking voice. "Why wouldn't I be?"

"Can I..."

"I do feel a bit tired, however," Glimmer said, voice a horrible forced cheer. "I do request for my queen to get rid of our unwanted guests and allow me some time to withdraw from my duties to catch up on lost sleep."

"Glimmer..." Catra begun and took a step forward. Glimmer spun around, eyes wild.

"Leave me the fuck alone, Catra!" she screamed. Catra recoiled.

"Sparkles!" she tried again.

"Get OUT!" Glimmer shouted, and Catra saw light gather around her hands.

"OK, OK," she hurriedly said, and with one last, worried look at her, Catra did get out.

She was barely out of the tent before she heard the explosion from the inside, the shattering of pottery and Glimmer's enraged screams.

- - -

It was some time later when, hesitantly, Jack opened the flap of the tent and peered inside.

The inside was gloomy, the floor was full of shards of plates and jars mingled with splinters and ripped fabric. Glimmer stood in the

middle of the tent, body tense and holding a large sphere of pink magic in her hands.

"Um... hello?" Jack said.

"I said, *GET OUT!*," Glimmer snarled and spun around ready to hurl the sphere at Jack.

"Glimmer!" they cried in desperation and flinched back.

"Jack?" Glimmer said, and suddenly her voice was full of concern instead of anger.

She closed her fist, and the ball of lighting disappeared.

"Sorry!" Jack squeaked, "I didn't mean to..."

"No, I'm sorry," Glimmer said with tired voice. "Um... come in."

Hesitantly, Jack entered the tent.

Glimmer sighed and sat down on a still mostly not broken chest.

"Sorry about that," she said with low voice. "I was... angry."

"I could tell," Jack said carefully and sat down next to her.

Glimmer took a deep breath and buried her face in her hands. Suddenly the fierce, scary princess looked so small.

"Who were they?" Jack asked.

"Friends of me and my mother for my whole life," Glimmer muttered.

"Oh..." Jack said.

"They love me," Glimmer muttered. "They stood by me at my darkest hour and I... abandoned them."

She let up a little sob.

"I... I tried so hard to make everything right and I... I screwed up."

"...Oh?" Jack said again.

"They... trusted me," Glimmer whispered.

Jack carefully put an arm around her.

Then they didn't say anything, for a while, while Glimmer cried in Jack's arms.

"Are they still here?" Glimmer asked eventually.

"No," Jack said. "Double Trouble made them leave."

"Good," Glimmer muttered.

Jack dared a glance at her.

"What did they want?" they asked.

Glimmer laughed, a humour-less laugh.

"The same thing everyone wants, of course," Glimmer said, a bit more of venom in her voice. "They want to lock me up. They want to *protect* me. Because they don't trust me. They don't think I can do this."

"Catra doesn't think of you like that," Jack said.

"Of course not," Glimmer said, after just a heart-beat of hesitation. "Catra believes in me."

"Well, for what it's worth, so do I," Jack said.

Glimmer stared at them, eyes suddenly very large.

"You do?" she whispered.

"Of course I do," Jack said. "You are great, Glimmer. You are one of the strongest people I ever met - and I've lived in the Waste my whole life where *everyone* has to be strong to make it. You don't take shit from anyone and you are just a little bit scary."

Glimmer looked down at her hands.

"And..." Jack went on, a bit more confident now. "The rest of the gang *love* you. You scare the living shit out of them, but you are *our* princess. We know that if anyone... scary, tries to give us shit, you'll be in their way. And you believe me, if anyone tries to give *you* shit, the gang has your back."

Glimmer shivered.

"Really?" she asked.

"Yeah, really," Jack answered, earnestly. "People are *fighting* to join up with your ladies in waiting. You say the word, and you'll have twenty new gals before morning."

They took Glimmer's hands and looked her in the eyes.

"Out here, knowing who to chip in with is the difference between life and death, and we all know a winning card when we see it. That's what we saw in Catra, and that's what we see in you."

Glimmer breathed out, a long, shivering breath.

"Thank you," she whispered.

"Any time," Jack smiled.

Glimmer sat up more straight.

"I will talk to the ladies in waiting," Glimmer mused. "We could do with expanding. And I need to talk to Catra and Double Trouble. I have some tricks up my sleeve that will be useful against the Horde."

"I look forward to it," Jack grinned.

Glimmer took a deep breath and stood up.

She looked around.

"I suppose I should clean up a bit," she said, a bit bashful.

"If you want help..." Jack begun.

"No, I think it'd be good for me to have some time to cool down," Glimmer said.

Jack hid a smile.

"...but thank you," Glimmer went on.

"Anytime," Jack said.

They squeezed Glimmer's hand and walked to the tent opening.

"Jack..." Glimmer said with low voice.

Jack turned around.

"Are you... feeling OK?" Glimmer asked, suddenly a bit hesitant.

"I'm fine," Jack said and managed a smile. "I had a bit of a headache when I woke up after the ritual, but it wore out."

"I do not want to put too much strain on you so..."

Jack gave her a suspicious look.

"You think I'm week?" they accused.

"Of course not," Glimmer quickly answered, "but..."

"But what?" Jack shot back. "We did a thing and I took a beating. We still won, didn't we? I got up the next day, didn't I?"

"I suppose..." Glimmer said hesitantly.

"I want to learn magic, Glimmer," Jack said with earnest voice. "With you. Please don't hold back on me."

"I'm not sure I'm a very good teacher," Glimmer sighed.

"I wouldn't say that, jack answered with a cheeky smile. I'm learning a lot."

Even Glimmer had to smile at that.

- - -

The campaign against the Horde had started simple enough, with ambushes and raids, but as bandits, luck-seekers and deserters flocked to the banner of the Queen of the Crimson Waste, Catra soon deemed it time to take the fight to their encampments.

The first encampment feel with almost trivia ease. As the Horde soldiers sounded the alarm, that the Queens raiders had been spotted, they got no response from their leaders. In the few vital minutes it took them to force themselves into their captains quarters, only to be met by the grizzly sight of the captain's dead body still lying on the bed, throat slit, Catra had already got her chosen strike team in position to control the main defences and open the gate. Five minutes later, the raiders were inside and the soldiers subdued.

Turns out, the attackers having a leader who knew the camp layout, routine and even some codes they had neglected to change made everything much easier.

The leaders in the second encampment were more alert, and the strike team had to fight themselves in. The defenders were valiant, but the main forces of the Queen were sure of their victory and eventually managed to breach the wall. The Queen herself killed the commander in front of them all, and they cheered her name.

The night before the third encampment fell, the Shining Princess was seen. She soared in the dark desert sky looking down at the terrified soldiers, seemingly unaffected by their gun fire. Nearly one third of the soldiers deserted that night, apparently egged on by a soldier no one knew the name of, but who could tell them a safe way away from the Shining Princess.

"And scene," Double Trouble said to themselves with a grin as they took their own shape. From a dune they saw Catra's forces make short work of the now hopelessly understaffed encampment. Glimmer walked up to them.

"Fear is a powerful weapon," she noted.

Double Trouble did a mocking little bow.

"Did you ever doubt me? I told you I could make you a monster."

"I tried so hard not to be one. Who knew I had this in me."

"I knew," Double Trouble said with a smug smile. "That's why I came here."

Back in the Fright Zone, Hordak raged at the reports provided by terrified subordinates. He ordered more troops, more guns, he ordered for Catra to be brought to him in chains.

The Court of the Queen of the Crimson waste celebrated. Their rank swelled every day and they became bolder. Catra and her lieutenants gathered around the maps. Every move the Horde made, Catra anticipated. Every reinforcement were ambushed. They followed routines Catra had written, carried equipment Catra had ordered the design of. They were easy prey for the Queen of the Crimson Waste.

- - -

"You *dare* show yourself here!" Hordak cried in fury at the masked face that suddenly had appeared in his mirror.

Shadow Weaver smiled, a cold smile.

"Hordak," she said as way of greeting. "Despite what you might wish, we do still have unfinished business together. Your old force commander to be exact."

"*Your* old student," he retorted.

"Yes," she agreed. "My old student. Elevated to a position of power far exceeding her abilities or your capability to keep her contained, in direct contradiction of my advice. I'm not surprised how badly it all turned out."

"Do you have anything to offer me except mockery?" he snarled.

She smirked.

"Hordak... all that technological might, not a lick of strategical sense. You don't assault your enemy from from the front, where they see you coming. You go straight for their heart." She made a slashing motion.

Hordak narrowed his eyes.

"And you know the way to Catra's heart, then?"

She laughed.

"Please, Catra wears her heart on her sleeves, much as she tries to protest otherwise. I can bring down the so called Queen of the Crimson Waste for you... but there is a prize."

"I have already given you everything you have," he said coldly.

"You have given me *nothing*," she snarled, shadows flickering over the mirror surface. "What I have, I have taken for myself, as I will earn the prize I'm asking or now. You will stay away from Brightmoon. You will stay out of the Whispering Woods. The rest of this pitiful world, it's yours to play with as you like. But that's the kingdom I claim."

He lifted an eyebrow

"Queen Shadow Weaver? The wicked witch of the woods? Those are your ambitions?"

"Why not?" she answered with cold voice. "Everything else has been denied me. Do we have an agreement?"

"We do."

"Then prepare your troops. The Crimson Waste will soon be yours to take."

- - -

They sat around the table in the largest tent. The atmosphere was victorious.

"Catra is the strongest in the Crimson Waste!" Slither bellowed, giddy from their recent string of victories.

"I think we might all be happy to save that for the public affairs," Glimmer said with dry voice from her usual place, a step behind Catra.

"I don't know, I could stand to hear you say it, Sparkles," Catra drawled. She looked up at Glimmer with a cheeky smile. "Come one, say the line," she prompted. "Catra is the..."

"I think we'll save that for when we are in private, don't you, *my Queen*," Glimmer said with a look at Catra from behind her veil that made Jack blush.

Catra laughed.

"Work before pleasure, got it 'my Queen'. And get yourself a chair, Glimmer. That whole 'evil princess' shtick is getting old."

"I am perfectly comfortable right here, 'my Queen'," Glimmer answer, just a touch of smugness in her voice.

"Ladies, queens, please," Double Trouble said from their favourite lounging chair. "Normally I'd hate to be the one to interrupt your flirting, but we *do* have a war to plan."

"We have a *victory* to plan, you mean," the goat horned woman Madeleine said, unable to contain her excitement. "Every major Horde encampment in the Waste has fallen to Queen Catra. A full third of the soldiers have joined us. The people adore us and more are flooding in from the surrounding areas. People actually come TO the Crimson Waste to get food now."

"Only the Valley of the Lost remains," Slither filled in, and that should be a picknick. You say the word, boss, and you can have your triumphant entry into the city the day after tomorrow.

"Yes," Catra said thoughtfully and studied the map that was outstretched on the table between them. "That *would* be the expected next move, wouldn't it."

"She's getting sneaky," Double Trouble said with glee. "I love it when she's getting sneaky." They elbowed Madeleine in the side "Don't you love it when she's getting sneaky?"

"What are you thinking, boss?" the Madeleine asked, following her usual policy of ignoring Double Trouble.

"Hordak," Catra simply asked. "He's bound to make a move soon."

"He already did those," Slither objected. "We stopped his troops as quickly as they got here. We can take whatever he throws at us."

"Those were just whatever small fry he happened to have lying around in the general area," Catra said dismissively. "I'm talking about actually getting his attention. I'm talking about the full might of the Horde. Can we take that?"

That sobered their mood.

"He's currently tied up with Snow," The goat woman said thoughtfully. "And recent reports" - she eyed Double Trouble who leered back - "indicates he's preparing a push to re-assert dominance over the pirates. They're mostly operating out of Seaworthy, but a few of them even have reconnected to Salineas after the fire that weakened the Horde presence."

"Does Hordak really care about the Crimson Waste enough to open up a third front when he has all that going on?" Jack mused. Usually this is where we could run from the Horde because they *didn't* care enough to chase us. At least until..." their voice trailed off and they gave Catra cautious side-glance.

"At least until *I* figured out the rebels had found a honest to life First Ones *space-ship* in the middle of the desert," Catra smirked. Glimmer gave her a sharp look, but didn't say anything.

"Astute observation, my lovely lagomorph," Double Trouble drawled with a nod to Jack. "But there is, in fact, one thing in the Crimson Waste Hordak wants bad enough to divert the full might of the Horde here if need be."

"Me," Catra said modestly.

"Or more to the point, your head on a pike," Double Trouble said, for once sincere. "You challenge his leadership, Kitten. You are one of very few people on the planet who can reasonably make claim to leadership over the Horde. You shared command with him. A large part of your force consist of defectors. You have crowned yourself queen. He can't let that pass."

"I certainly hope not," Catra said. "I'd hate to go to all this trouble of pissing him off without him taking the bait."

Double Trouble looked at her sharply. After a moment they started to chuckle.

"I told you - I love it when she's getting sneaky."

"Care to fill us in?" Glimmer said drily.

"It's very simply, really," Catra said with false modesty. "We make a big show of taking the Valley of the Lost. We make sure to draw his troops in. Then we pull back. While they are busy figuring up what we are up to, we take a strike team to the Fright Zone."

She let her gaze move between the faces of the others.

"We don't need to fight the Horde one soldier at the time. We take out Hordak and we have won. One single strike to end the war."

It was dead silent in the tent. Everyone stared at Catra, except for Double Trouble who studied the faces of the others.

"The Fright Zone?" Madeleine said eventually. "The most heavily fortified place on the planet."

"You know as well as I do that those fortifications leak like a badly plunge sieve," Catra snorted. "A small enough force can easily gain access. Just ask the princess here."

"It took the entire princess alliance *and* the help of Shadow Weaver to get in last time," Glimmer said drily. "And the before that they had Adora who led the way. I wouldn't exactly call it easy."

"And this time you have *me*," Catra said - not without force to her voice. "And we have the 'Shining Princess'. We can do it."

"Wait a minute," Slither blurted out. "Wouldn't that mean we leave the Valley of the Lost to the Horde forces?"

"If we can take Hordak quick enough, they will be *our* forces," Catra shot back.

"Unless the commander decides that would be a good opportunity to strike out on their own," Double Trouble casually said, studying their nails.

Catra gave them an annoyed look.

"Sure, in which case The Valley of the Lost will still be occupied. Some difference. We can come back and sort it out later."

Slither and Madeleine shared a long look.

"Hey," Madeleine said. "Just an idea - we are not in any rush here, are we? Hordak's armies are currently tied up in Snow. Let the princesses grind him down for a while, increase your chances."

Glimmer met her eyes.

"We do not wait," she said with cold voice.

The goat woman looked like she might have wanted to protest, but as the moment stretched and Glimmer held her eyes, she said nothing.

"There is also one other who could challenge Hordak for leadership," Glimmer said silently. "One other with a history of seniority in the Horde and with a power base of her own."

"Shadow Weaver," Catra said grimly. Glimmer nodded.

"Will she try to interfere?" Jack asked.

"She will make a move at some point," Glimmer said ominously. "It's anyone's guess what, and when."

"No," Catra said pointedly. "It's *your* guess. That's why we keep a princess around, isn't it? To deal with that kind of 'Shadow Queen' bullshit."

She met Glimmer's eyes with a cheeky smirk. Glimmer rolled her eyes.

"She doesn't care about the Horde any more than she cared about the princess alliance," she said, eyeing Jack. "For her, it's all about personal power."

"She already has the full power of a runestone and the entire royal castle of Brightmoon," Jack protested. "Isn't that enough for her?"

Glimmer and Catra glanced at each other, and then they both started to laugh.

"Cute, kid," Catra smirked.

"The ocean might yearn for the heat of the flame, but that does not mean it will be satisfied once it snuffs out a candle," Glimmer said enigmatically.

Catra gave her an annoyed look.

"Knock it off with the 'creepy princess' vibes, Sparkles," she grumbled. "Just tell me what her next move will be."

Glimmer pondered that.

"One out of three," she said, voice eerie.

Catra rolled her eyes, but Jack stared at her in awe.

"You're talking about the runestones," they said, and earned themselves an approving nod. "The pearl, the heart-blossom and the fractal flake."

"Very good," Glimmer said. "With the princesses not guarding two of the rune-stones, Shadow Weaver is free to complete the whole set."

"The Horde is guarding them," Madeleine objected. "They're not just going to hand over the most precious spoils of war to a wanna be princess, no matter how scary."

"The Horde will not be an obstacle to Shadow Weaver," Glimmer said with a sincerity that made the Goat Woman shut her mouth and look away.

"You know there is one more runestone," Catra said silently.

Glimmer nodded.

"The Black Garnet," Jack whispered.

"Can Shadow Weaver assault Hordak in his own stronghold?" Slither asked.

"Why not?" Catra shrugged. "That's what we're attempting to do."

"Far be it from me to spoil the potential drama," Double Trouble drawled, "But there is another potential venue for power for the self appointed Shadow Queen,"

"The Heart," Glimmer said quietly.

"The what?" Jack asked, eyes wide.

"Sorry, kid," Double Trouble said with a wink. "There are arcane secrets that would turn your hair white, were you to learn about it."

Jack frowned and glanced at Glimmer who gave them an enigmatic look in return.

"So which one will she go for?" Catra demanded.

Glimmer sighed.

"I don't know."

They were silent for a moment.

"Well, whatever dirty trick she has up her sleeve, it sounds like her first move will be against Hordak," Catra concluded, "not against us."

"It looks that way," Glimmer admitted.

"So we press ahead," Catra decided. "At best, she'll keep Hordak distracted. At worst, we run into her in the Fright Zone."

"What if we do?" Jack answered, a shiver to their voice.

"Then we move her up the agenda," Glimmer said, an edge to her voice.

"There we go," Catra said, determination in her voice. She turned to her lieutenants. "The two of you, come with me. We have some planning to do for the move on the Valley of the lost. Sparkles, you do princess stuff."

And with Madeleine, Slither and Double Trouble in tow, she left the tent.

Jack gave Glimmer a warm smile.

- - -

And so another day had turned to night. Had she eaten? Catra couldn't remember. These days, everyone wanted a piece of her time. Almost like the bad old days in the Fright Zone.

She smirked.

No, not quite like that. Because back then, she was constantly feeling an all encompassing emptiness that threatened to swallow her whole.

This time, she had Glimmer.

Catra walked towards the tent. The ladies in waiting gave her a careful look, but did not object. Strange how much of an outsider they made her feel. She was the boss. The Queen. Her words were the law. But in this tent, Sparkles played by her own rules.

If felt oddly familiar, somehow.

"Sparkles, are you..." she began, but silenced as she saw the sleeping form of the queen. Jack sat by her side and had by all appearance just tucked her in. They looked up at Catra with a finger to their lips. Catra nodded and slipped inside the tent without a sound.

She gave the sleeping queen a fond look. Her princess looked so peaceful when she slept. Free from the strain of responsibility and magic for at least a few hours.

Jack caught her eyes. They traded a soft smile.

Then Jack picked up a knife from the food tray and plunged it into Glimmer's heart.

Chapter End Notes

Uh, oh

Night Terrors

Chapter Notes

> Warning: Horror, violence, maiming, grief, oh and Glimmer gets stabbed.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Jack plunged the dagger in Glimmer's heart. The sleeping princess didn't even have time to scream before the sound got stuck in her throat.

Catra didn't think, didn't allow herself take in the horror of what had just happened. She just allowed her body to react. With a desperate snarl she hurled herself at the teenager and ripped their throat to shreds with her claws. She roughly threw Jack's body to the side and sank down next to Glimmer.

"*Glimmer!*" she whispered.

Blood was flowing from the wound in her chest. Catra could see that there was nothing to be done. As she stared in desperation, Glimmer sought her eyes.

"Catra," Glimmer whispered, the light in her eyes fading.

"Glimmer!" Catra cried, repeating the name as if by saying it she could hold the her lover back from the dark abyss she was about to fall down.

"I just want you to know," Glimmer whispered with her final breaths, "that if... you had done more to protect me... I'd still be alive."

And her eyes went dark.

Catra felt her heart crumple up and fall apart in her chest. She felt the all too familiar pain again. Adora... Scorpia... they at least

were still alive. There still was some hope, no matter how slim. Some vestige of future to cling to. But Glimmer was gone.

Gone.

Catra fell down to her knees. She felt like she was drowning. She'd always thought 'dying of a broken heart' was some sort of soppy exaggeration for the characters in Scorpia's romance books, but the way her chest felt like she had swallowed a grenade she wouldn't be surprised if her heart was physically broken.

Then she saw it.

The smile lurking in the edge of Glimmer's mouth.

"Glimmer?" she whispered, white in her face.

Glimmer smirked at her.

"You have to admit, Kitten. I got you good."

Jack sat up from the floor and, with a laughter, morphed into the shape of Double Trouble.

"You were right, Sparkles," they drawled. "She's just as pathetic as you said."

"Right," Glimmer laughed. She held out her hands and helped Double Trouble from the floor. They sat down next to Glimmer and they gave each other a deep kiss. "She truly believed I'd want to be with the woman who killed my mother."

"Well, she *is* a bad friend, after all," Double Trouble smirked. "It would be foolish to think she could ever be anything else."

"Don't I know it," Glimmer said and shook her head. "Best thing Adora ever did was to leave this looser behind."

Catra stared at them, barely registering their words. She wanted to run, to scream, to hit and hurt - but she could barely even find

the energy to turn around, leaving the enthusiastically kissing Glimmer and Double Trouble behind her. Tears trickled down her cheeks as she somehow managed to get out of the tent.

Away. That was the ticket. She had to get away from here.

"Help me," she whispered to the lady in waiting who guarded the tent.

"There is no helping you, Wild Cat," the guard said with sad voice. "You are and have always been a bad friend. Glimmer is better off without you."

Catra stared.

"Sco... Sco... Scorpia?" she stammered.

The scorpion princess nodded solemnly.

"Faaaaaaaashinating," another voice cut in, and Entrapta dragged herself out of a vent - in the desert? - with her hair. "She still thinks she gets to just walk away from everything she has done?"

"She never was good at empathising with others," Scorpia answered.

"You are on Beast Island," Catra whispered, head spinning.

"We *were* on Beast Island because *you* sent Entrapta there to die," an all too familiar voice said. "But I always have to clean up your messes, don't I?"

And that final straw finally became too much. Catra sank down to the ground, tears flowing from her eyes as the blonde, muscular woman walked up to her.

"Please forgive me, Adora," she wept.

"Forgive you?" Adora scoffed. "I tried that, so many times. But you'd rather see me hurt than try to make things better."

"I'm trying now," Catra wept. "I'm trying to help Glimmer. I know how much she means to you."

"Help me?" Glimmer said from behind her. "You can't even help yourself. Did it ever occur to you that your help is not needed? That it's not wanted."

"This is your idea of helping?" Adora laughed, a mean spirited laugh. "Drag her out in a desert? Make her the queen of a bunch of bandits. Pathetic."

"You and me, we could have made it work, Wild-Cat," Scorpia sadly said. "But you wouldn't. And now you try to recreate what could have been us with Glimmer. Sorry, Wild-cat, but it's just pathetic."

"Pathetic," Glimmer echoed.

"Pathetic."

"Pathetic."

"NO!" Catra cried. "I'm trying my best."

"Well," Glimmer said, voice full of barbs. "Maybe your best is just not good enough."

"Face it, Catra," Adora said. "You've made your choice. Now live with it."

She roughly shoved the kneeling Catra, causing her to fall over.

"Stop it," Catra snarled, but before she could get up, Glimmer kicked her in the side. Hard.

"Why don't you just die?" Glimmer hissed at her.

"We're better off without you," Entrapta said and pushed her head down in the sand with her hair.

"We always were," Scorpia said and plunged her stinger towards Catra's face. Catra just barely managed to avoid it.

"You are a burden for those around you," Adora said and lifted her sword over her head. "You always have been. You always will be."

"NO!" Catra cried. She swiped around her in wild panic to get away and she felt her claws tear through flesh.

A gasp was heard. Suddenly, it was only her and Glimmer, the others melting away like bad dreams.

Glimmer stood on her knees, a hand to her throat. Blood, shimmering with glitter, flowed between her fingers.

"You... killed me?" Glimmer gasped.

Her eyes were so large and beautiful. Catra felt her throat contract. She couldn't get any air.

Glittery blood dripped from her claws in impossibly large quantities.

"No..." she protested feebly. "I didn't. I... It was Jack... or Double Trouble or..."

"You *killed* me," Glimmer repeated, indignation mingling with the pain and fear.

"I tried to keep you *safe*," Catra cried.

"You failed," Glimmer whispered. "The way you fail at everything."

And the light in her eyes went out.

Catra watched her in despair.

"STEP AWAY FROM HER!"

Filled with dread, Catra turned around.

Glimmer walked up to her with angry steps, radiating of light.

"Glimmer," Catra pleaded. "Please believe me..."

"Step behind me, Catra," Glimmer demanded.

"Glimmer...."

"BEHIND ME! NOW!"

Glimmer firmly pushed Catra to the side and stepped up to... herself, eyes burning of fury.

The Glimmer on the ground stood up with a laugh. The blood behind her fingers turned black. Slimy. *Shadowy*. Her eyes were full of roiling shadows.

"So, the little queen is here to defend her pathetic lover," she hissed. "How touching."

"You truly only know one trick, don't you Shadow Weaver?" Glimmer snarled. She roughly lifted her shadow lookalike and pinned her to a wall behind her. "You couldn't get to me, so you went for the woman I love instead. Didn't you grow tired of that game with Adora?"

"You don't know what you're talking about," Shadow-Glimmer hissed. And if you truly knew the power hidden away in Adora's blood, behind that pathetic, deluded mind of hers, you would not be so fast to dismiss her."

"*Shadow Weaver*," Catra gasped.

"Or her influence, at least," Glimmer confirmed. "The witch herself is still hiding in Brightmoon."

"You are alive?" Catra gasped, still grasping to get to grips with what was going on.

"Of course I am," Glimmer smiled at her, and a wave of relief surged through Catra. "How could I be otherwise, with you keeping me safe. The full might of the Horde couldn't get to me. A washed up old sorceress surely has no chance."

"You're arrogant," Shadow Glimmer mocked. "But you will learn, before you die, just how far beneath me you truly are."

With a furious snarl, Glimmer slammed her counterpart against the wall again, which - despite everything else that was going on - Catra couldn't deny was totally hot.

"Big words from a thief sitting in a stolen castle threatening me with stolen power from a stolen runestone."

"You never deserved that power," Shadow Glimmer hissed. "A spoiled, petulant child of a weak, recreant mother; born with the key to Etheria but too craven to properly wield it."

"Yes, I know that tune," Glimmer hissed. "The only tune you ever sang. Well, then tell me, Shadow Weaver, of your grand designs. You tricked my father to help you gain your forbidden powers, and all you did with it was to hide out in the Fright Zone and bully children. You stole Scorpia's birthright and you used it for petty parlour tricks. Now you have stolen my runestone. So tell me what you are using that power for that makes you so much more *deserving*."

Shadow Glimmer smirked.

"Nice try, little princess. You'll just have to wait and see, won't you?"

Glimmer's eyes narrowed.

"Wait for what? You have turned my kingdom to your own little shadow realm. What else is there?"

"As always, we are more alike than you care to admit," Shadow Glimmer stated. "That includes our goals."

"The Horde?" Glimmer asked with suspicious voice.

"Since Hordak came to this planet, many have stated the need to stop him. No one, but me, has ever had the courage to do what's needed to accomplish it."

"You betrayed us to him," Glimmer protested. "You sabotaged my attempt to stop him." .

"Please," Shadow Glimmer laughed. "Your pathetic attempt would never have succeeded, but it served its purpose for me to acquire the power necessary to take the next step."

"What step?" Glimmer pressed.

"Power enough to take down the Horde for good," Shadow Glimmer gloated. "And I'm not talking about Hordak and his pathetic little splinter fraction. *I* aim to destroy Horde Prime. Not that I expect you to thank me."

"You're going after the Heart of Etheria," Glimmer said with flat voice.

Shadow Glimmer smirked.

"You said it yourself, to the other princesses. It's the only way to save Etheria."

"Yes, yes," Glimmer said dismissively. "Save me the speech. I got my answers, and *you* have outstayed your welcome."

"And how do you intend to keep me out of Catra's mind now that I gained entry?" Shadow Glimmer hissed. How sure will you be, the next time you look into her eyes, that it won't be me you see?"

"Shadow and nightmares, that's all you are good for," Glimmer snarled. "But Shadows are nothing - just the absence of light. And whatever you think you might have taken from me I'm still..." -

strong, white light radiated from her hands- "The Princess of Light!"

"Lovely sentiment," Shadow Glimmer snarled, "but..."

And that was as far she got, before Glimmer hit her straight in the chest with a beam of light, bright as the sun.

Shadow Glimmer's form was flung backwards and ripped apart by the strong light, but not the way flesh and blood gets blown to pieces by a strong enough blast (something Catra, sadly, knew exactly how it looked). Rather, slithering shadows scattered, revealing the entire body to be a construct of the slimy, black tendrils.

As Catra stared, they condensed together again, forming into Shadow Glimmer, crouching and ready for battle.

She still looked like Glimmer, but different.

Her hair was pink as usual, but dripping of inky black liquid, like it had been dipped in oil. Her eyes were hollow. Shadows danced at her finger tips.

"So be it," she snarled, and a stream of darkness boiled from her hands, straight towards Glimmer.

With a snort of disdain, Glimmer teleported out of the way. She rematerialized straight above Shadow Glimmer's head and kicked downwards with all her might, causing the shadows to scatter again, only to rematerialize just as Glimmer landed, forming two slippery hands around her throat. Glimmer lashed out with a strong beam of light and teleported again with the shadows in hot pursuit.

Catra stared as transfixed at the rapid fight, neither Glimmer nor her shadow counter part being in the same place for more than a moment at the time. She tried to get up from the ground, with a vague thought of helping her girlfriend, but her legs felt like gelatine.

"I thought I had made myself clear," Glimmer snarled, holding Shadow Glimmer's wrists to keep her claw-like hands out of her face. "You have used Catra as your own private punching ball her entire life, but that's *over*. I took you in, I gave you a modicum of freedom, I even extended trust to you, and you took that trust and stabbed me in the back. This time..." -bright light started to radiate from her entire being, while she held Shadow Glimmer in an iron grip, denying her to flee- "this time you are not welcome. And I'll see you *burn* before I let you hurt Catra again."

Light flared up like a super nova.

Catra had to close her eyes.

When she opened them again she was in the tent with her head in Glimmer's lap. Jack and Double Trouble looked at her in concern.

There was no trace of Shadow Glimmer in the tent.

"She's waking up!" Jack cried.

Catra looked around in confusion.

"Jack? Glimmer?" she sobbed. "Are you OK?"

"Are *you* OK, Catra?" Glimmer cried.

"I... yeah, sure. But what about you. I saw you..." Catra's voice trailed off as she watched the worried-looking and perfectly alive Jack in confusion.

"It wasn't real," Glimmer said gently. "It was just her."

Catra stared at her for a few moments, and then she breathed out.

"Fucking witch," she said eventually.

"You said it," Glimmer answered. Her voice was shaky.

"I don't get it," Jack frowned. "How did she gain entry? There must have been a connection."

Glimmer actually blushed at that. Catra stared at her, then she started to chuckle.

"Well, it seems to me everyone is alive and well and witch-free for the moment," Double Trouble drawled. "Come on, kid. Let's leave the lovebirds to cry in peace."

Jack started to protest, but Double Trouble firmly led them out of the tent.

"You... were in my mind?" Catra asked, looking at Glimmer with large eyes.

"Yeah..." she looked slightly ashamed. "I mean, kinda. Technically *she* was in your mind. I just came along for the ride."

"Oh..." Catra said. She closed her eyes.

"I didn't peak," Glimmer said gently. "I only saw what she put there, and honestly, it was just the same old crap."

"Yeah..." Catra murmured. Her mind felt like she was still slogging through the desert. Nothing made sense and she hurt in ways she had done her very best to deny was even possible.

But Glimmer was here. Glimmer held her. Glimmer would stand between her and the shadows.

Honestly, that was a pretty good deal.

"So, me and Double Trouble, huh?" Glimmer said, voice carefully teasing.

Catra managed a smirk.

"Shut up, Sparkles."

"No, no," Glimmer said. "It has potential."

She caught Catra's eyes. They smiled at each other.

"Please don't take this the wrong way," Glimmer said, voice gentle, "But you and Adora are pretty alike."

"I dress better than her," Catra muttered, bracing herself for what was to come.

Glimmer laughed.

"So does Sea Hawk, so that's not much of a distinction. No, what I meant to say was that you are both so very protective of me. It's adorable, but honestly it can get a bit much. I'm a big girl, I can take care of myself."

"Looks who's talking," Catra answered. "You just saved me from the wicked witch." She put a hand to her forehead, palm out, and faked a girly voice. "Oooooh, save me, brave princess. I'm totally in distress."

"Stop it," Glimmer giggled and playfully swatted at Catra's hand. "I owed you one for dragging me through the desert." Her face grew serious. "But I mean it, Catra. We've got each other's back and that's fine and good. But Adora has a hero complex larger than the moon. You don't need to take after that."

"Then you better stop being so adorable every time I save you," Catra smirked.

"Look who's talking," Glimmer shot back and pecked a little kiss on Catra's forehead. "All it took for you to curl up with me was an evil sorceress trying to destroy your mind from within."

"Nah," Catra deadpanned. "It was the shiny hero that saved me from her that did it for me."

They smiled.

Glimmer's face grew serious.

"But for real, Catra," she said with insistent voice. "You are my lover. My partner in crime. My Queen. But you are not my knight. Please don't go down that road. It didn't end well last time."

Catra met her eyes.

"Got it, Sparkles."

Glimmer put a hand on Catra's cheek in response, and Catra felt herself go all tingly.

Catra didn't care what Glimmer said. She could get used to this whole 'damsel in distress' thing.

She managed to hide her shudder as Glimmer leaned in close for a kiss. She could still vividly remember the swirling shadows in the eye sockets of the Glimmer in her dreams.

- - -

"Reports from the Waste, boss," Octavia said with the usual dry voice she used when she talked to her master. He took the pad with a grunt.

"Catra is still holding a firm grip over her forces," she went on, "and they're still moving in on the Valley of the Lost."

He skimmed through the content on the pad without comment.

"So, they witch failed, I take it," Octavia went on.

"It would seem that way," he said with menacing voice. If it affected her, she didn't show it.

"So, what do you say, boss? Is it time for me to move in and bag the cat once and for all."

"I have already sent you on that assignment once," he said, barely containing his rage. "You failed."

"Yeah, because Catra failed to take out the glitter princess," Octavia shot back. "Unless you count *eating* her out."

She chuckled and Hordak gave her a disapproving look.

"Your excuses are of little relevance," he growled. "Your assignment remains the pirates that somehow still seem to make a mockery out of the flag you fly."

Octavia gritted her teeth.

"I would be able to hold the sea just fine if *someone* hadn't let Salineas out of our grasp."

She gave Hordak a direct look.

"Salineas rule the sea, boss."

"*I* rule the sea," he growled.

Octavia stood her ground.

"Sure, because you took Salineas. But you didn't *keep* it. You didn't leave enough troops to hold it. And now it's all pirates and smugglers and rebels and a token Horde presence that's bribed to the gills."

"Watch your tongue," he shouted.

She looked at him with defiant eyes for a moment, then she looked away.

"Sure, you're the boss," she muttered.

"Yes, I am," he retorted. "An alarming number of my trusted officers seem to have forgotten that fact. I trust I won't see your name among them."

"I'm not running away to pretty princess-land if that's what you are worried about," Octavia growled. "But you sending me to the hunt for pyromaniacs and pirates is just us stopping leaks, and

you know it. We've taken the world. We won, boss. Now we need to figure out how to hold it."

"We are not done with our conquest," he said. "We yet have to take Snow. We apparently have to re-affirm our grip on the Crimson Waste."

"And Brightmoon?" Octavia asked.

He met her gaze.

"Do not concern yourself with Brightmoon," he said.

"Got it, boss," she answered, after a just slightly too long moment of silence.

"Snow will fall, eventually," he went on. "As soon as we have established enough of a beachhead to properly set up the factories. And as for the Crimson Waste, I will send reinforcement. The fourteenth and sixteenth command should be able to get there in a few days. Cravlor could use the leadership training."

Octavia didn't bother to hide the scepticism in her voice.

"Cravlor is just a rookie, boss, and you're sending them against *Catra*. If they pissed you off recently, there are easier ways to handle it."

"They won't have to worry about Catra," Hordak answered. "Just the rabble she has gathered. Catra herself won't be in the Valley of the Lost."

"Oh? And where will she be?" Octavia asked with grumpy voice.

"She's coming here," Hordak answered, absolute conviction in his voice. "She doesn't care about the Crimson Waste any more than we do. It's all a play for legitimacy as she goes after the commander of the Horde. Me."

Octavia raised an eyebrow.

"Think she's that stupid, do you?"

"Yes," Hordak answered.

Octavia shrugged.

"Well then, I'll take it you will be ready for her when she comes knocking."

For answer, Hordak powered up his arm canon. He smiled, a grim smile. Octavia chuckled.

"Right," she said, not willing to let her earlier point slip away. "So I keep the lid on the pirates, and you take out the cat, and the main force eventually brings down Snow. What then?"

"What is your question?" Hordak said loftily.

She gave him a direct look.

"What happens when we conquered the word?" she asked. "You know we can't keep a hold on it for long, not with the rate we're going."

"What happens next is that you and everyone else in this pathetic world will see the *true* might of the Horde," he said with a voice that made chills move up her spine.

"Horde Prime has yet to show himself," she said with as much bravado as she could muster with the arm canon pointed at her.

"Then we will have to *make* him pay attention, won't we?" he said, voice deadly calm.

- - -

Shadow Weaver walked in her garden. Pruning a stem here, removing a weed there, adding a drop of nutrients to a struggling plant, removing another for it's neighbour to bloom.

Not for the first time she wished children could be more like flowers.

Perhaps she would even find them cheerful, were they less of a hassle.

Still, they had their use, something she couldn't deny.

She removed a small silver box from her robes - she had found it in Angella's sleeping chamber. She opened it and regarded the pink lock of hair with an almost tender expression for a moment. The she put the strands of hair in a silver bowl full of clear water. Silver for the moon.

There were flowers growing in her garden no one in Mystacor knew the name of. Shadow Weaver picked an ugly, parasitic plant with blue veins.

She crushed the petals over the bowl. She weaved a magical construct.

Then she waited. She had to wait a long time before an image took form.

The image of a ill-looking man with a bushy beard, eating a beetle. He looked at the image of her, forming in a puddle in front of him, as if he wouldn't believe his eyes.

"Micah" she said in conversational tone.

"Li-light Spinner?" he whispered.

"I don't go by that name any longer," Shadow Weaver said coldly.

"You are real?" the man gasped. "You are not just a trick."

She smiled at that.

"I'm very real, as you of all people should know. But as for trick... everything is a trick. You should know that as well."

"How..."

"How I contacted you? Trivial." She snorted. "People who make assumptions of my limitations are usually frustratingly wrong. It's useful, but frustrating never the less."

"You could have contacted me any time?" he gasped. "Why didn't..."

She sneered at him.

"I did not have cause to contact you before now."

The look he gave her contained such layers of pain, loss, anger and betrayal that it could have melted a rock. Shadow Weaver ignored it.

"I regret to inform you," she said with lofty voice, "that your daughter, Glimmer, is in peril. She will surely die - and quite horribly at that - at the claws of the Horde."

Micah made big eyes.

"Glimmer...?"

Shadow Weaver smiled.

"She's such a beautiful child. Strong willed and full of life and light... for the time being, that is."

As she talked, a shimmering picture of a happily laughing Glimmer (just a few years younger than her actual age) took form. Micah reached for it, a longing in his heart.

Shadow Weaver did a quick jabbing gesture and the picture disappeared.

"Of course, these last months have been hard on her, poor child. The war on her doorstep, the crown weighing on her head, no mother to guide her..."

Micha stared at her.

"Angella?" he whispered in horror.

"Yes, Angella," she replied. "Such a loss. Such a tragedy, should poor Glimmer have to share her mother's fate so soon..."

She turned her eyes to the crying castaway.

"There is a way for her life to be saved, however, but that rather hinges on you."

Micah swallowed and nodded wordlessly.

"Three people have landed on your island," Shadow Weaver went on. "A Horde traitor named Adora, a maker of no heritage of note named Bow and the failed princess Scorpia of Archnidia. You might also encounter princess Entrapta of Dryl. Neither of these people are to leave Beast Island until such a time that I say otherwise."

He gave her a surprised look.

"What? Why?" he blurted out. She sniffed.

"That's none of your concerns."

"But how am I supposed to stop them from leaving?"

She smiled again.

"You are resourceful, Micah. I trust a loving father will be able to do this small thing to save his daughter... unless I'm wrong about you, of course, in which case her life is forfeit."

He gave her a pleading look.

"Light Spi... Shadow Weaver. Whatever plots you are up to, please, let us talk about th..."

She sniffed.

"There is nothing to discuss. Just the simple question of what a loving father is prepared to do to save his daughter... or perhaps what he's *not* willing to do. Either way, we will know soon enough."

He gave her a helpless look which she ignored.

"Oh, and one more thing," she said with aloof voice. "Adora must be kept alive."

"What?" he blurted out. "I'm not killing anyone."

Shadow Weaver shrugged.

"You are not killing Adora," she corrected him. "Only she matters. Everyone else is expendable. Including you, Micah, and including your pretty little daughter. Remember that."

He sagged.

"There was a time I thought you loved me," he said with bitter voice.

"There was a time I thought you were worthy of love," Shadow Weaver answered, and then her reflection in the puddle dispersed.

Micah was alone again, with his thoughts and his fears and the endless droning signal of Beast Island.

Chapter End Notes

Bad Shadow Weaver, bad.

Towards the Fright Zone

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Horde transport putted up the road, Double Trouble by the wheel, whistling a jaunty tune. They stopped in a little hidden nook of the road.

"You're late," Catra said, stepping out from her hiding place.

"I'm *devastated* to have caused you discomfort, my Queen," Double Trouble said in a tone of voice that suggested they were anything but. "Errands to run, people to meet. You know how it is."

"Was there any trouble stealing the transport," Glimmer interrupted.

"Not at all. The commander was seen giving the order to send the transport back to the Fright Zone well and proper. No one will suspect nefarious business... at least not with everything else going on?"

Catra raised an eyebrow.

"Oh?"

"Seems like some reckless individual went and destroyed the bridge connecting the main vehicle depot with the city."

"Such a shame."

"Shame."

"Also, several high ranking Horde officials were seen by reliable witnesses plotting against the commander." Double Trouble put on

a tragic expression. "It's *so* hard to find trustworthy people these days."

"I'm glad you've been enjoying yourself."

"I always do, dear Kitten. You should know that by now."

"I suppose I should. Very well!" Catra turned to her lieutenants. "Madeleine, Slither, you're in charge of my army now. Don't break it."

"Sure you don't want us to come with you?" Madeleine protested.

"Nah," Catra said offhandedly. "With me gone, I need you to watch these mooks so no one gets any bright ideas."

The 'and each other' went unsaid.

"Anyway," she continued. "We'll be in the Fright Zone in just a few days and after that... well, whatever happens, it should be quick. Just keep a presence around the city and play hide and seek with whatever the commander throws at you. "

"What about me?" Jack said.

"You're staying with them," Catra said gently but firmly.

"But I wanted to come with you," Jack said.

"Of course you can come," Glimmer smiled with a direct look at Catra. "I couldn't hope to do my part without a trusty assistant by my side."

Jack hurried up to Glimmer's side. Catra gave Glimmer a long look, but didn't comment.

"I trust *I'm* coming with you?" Double Trouble said.

"You most certainly are," Catra sternly said. "I want you where I can keep an eye on you."

The rest of their chosen troops filtered into the transport. Nine of Catra's hand-picked soldiers, three of Glimmer's 'Ladies in Waiting'.

The mode was exciting. They were going places, they were kicking ass. Their boss was going to go up against Hordak himself!

They realized there was a very good chance none of them would come back.

"Will you miss it?" Glimmer said softly as they drove north, Double Trouble by the wheels.

"What? The desert?" Catra scoffed. "I like the sun just fine, but the sand gets everywhere."

"I was thinking more of the simple life as a bandit chieftain," Glimmer said.

"I'm still the boss, sparkles," Catra said with just a little bit of an edge to her voice. "I'll be even more so when I take out Hordak."

"Yes, you will," Glimmer said with sincere voice. But then it won't be just the two of us and our little world. Things will be complicated again."

Catra laughed.

"Do you figure any part of this has been *easy*, Sparkles?"

"Oh, I'm not saying it was without complications," Glimmer admitted. She shuddered. "I could really have done without those beetles, for example."

"What, and miss out on all the beautiful memories," Catra leered.

Glimmer laughed.

"I'm just saying, things will be different," she said and squeezed Catra's hand.

"I sure hope so," she shot back. "That's the whole point, remember? We take him out. We take Shadow Weaver out. We take out anyone who dares mess with us. Then no one will mess with us again."

Double trouble quickly hid a smirk behind their hand.

Catra glared at Glimmer.

"What's all this anyway, Sparkles? You're not getting cold feet on me, are you?"

"No," Glimmer said with absolute conviction. "We're going to stop the Horde."

"And here I thought you were going to *become* the Horde," Double Trouble said with a wink.

"Shut up, Double Trouble," Glimmer said without force.

"And then what?" Catra asked.

"Then we will live happily ever after," Glimmer said with mock sincere voice.

They smirked at each other, smirks that soon became more sincere - and complex - smiles.

The transport steadily took them away from the Crimson Waste, towards the Fright Zone.

"Home sweet home," Catra muttered.

Glimmer took her hand.

- - -

A match was struck. A lamp was lit.

Two faces were illuminated by the flickering flames.

"Glimmer is alive, you say," a man's voice said. "And with Catra of all people? Love truly finds the strangest of passages."

"As lovely dovey as anyone could ask for," the gruff woman confirmed.

"And they are gunning for Hordak. Now, that's fortuitous news for the rebellion indeed."

Huntara laughed.

"Rebellion? You still cling to that delusion. The rebellion died with the princess alliance, and you know it."

"On the contrary, my prickly desert rose," Sea Hawk answered. "Without Brightmoon as a base of operation we were forced underground. Without queen Glimmer we were left leaderless. A loss, true, but also an opportunity. The different cells work independently now. With the old order gone, with the Horde biting over more than they can chew, there is tinder everywhere, just waiting for a *match*."

Huntara smirked.

"I heard about the fleet you torched in Salineas. Good work."

"Why thank you," Sea Hawk said modestly. "And you believe me - that was just the beginning." Something hard flittered past his normally so carefree eyes. "There is many a fire yet to be lit."

Huntara smirked.

"Now, what do you want with me?" Sea Hawk asked. "If you want to join the rebellion you are in the right place.

Huntara shook her head.

"I need a ship. I need help to get through the blockade."

Sea Hawk gave her an inquiring look.

"And say I were to provide you with what you seek, oh mighty huntress, what would be our destination?"

"Beast Island," Huntara said, voice hard. "It's high time to get Adora back. She's needed."

Chapter End Notes

> Aaaaand that's all for act three. Now we will have a break as I prepare the fourth act: Siege of the Fright Zone. The story will continue in May.
>
> In the meanwhile, please enjoy this tumblr exclusive interview: https://baggebythesea.tumblr.com/post/679231650382675968/queens-of-the-horde-tumblr-exclusive-interview

Act Four - Siege of the Fright Zone

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Welcome back, welcome back," Double Trouble drawls from the stage as the theatre fills up. Emily walks along the rows with Imp on her back, selling popcorn.

"The next act is just about to start," Double Trouble go on, "and this one is a doozy."

Their grins widen.

"When we last saw our girls, they had threatened, manipulated and in general bullied all of the Crimson Waste into doing their biddings. They had fought. They had loved. They had shown the world that the fucking Queens of the Crimson Waste are *done* taking any shit."

"Fun times," they happily sigh. Then their expression becomes serious.

"But now, the vacation is over and it's time to once and for all cement their bid for power. Because now our queens is gunning for the big man himself."

Double Trouble take the guise of Hordak, tall and imposing, cape flapping in the wind, glaring at the audience with barely contained rage.

"In one corner," Double Trouble drawls through Hordak's mouth, "we have the technology dictator of the Fright Zone, the architect of the Horde and the catalyst for the devastating war that has raged Etheria for generations. In the other we have a pissed off cat and her princess."

The return to their own shape and leers at the audience.

"Place your bets, my good people. Place your bets. Because while this act is short, it will be *intense*."

The light dims, and Double Trouble slinks off the stage as the curtain opens to the silhouette of the fortified bunkers of the Fright Zone.

Chapter End Notes

We're back! This one is short but intense.

You can never go home again

Chapter Notes

> Warning: Vicious fighting, maiming and death. Fire and crushing and electrocution and shooting and your little cat too.
>
> I want to be quite clear - I have not tagged the 'major character death' warning. That means that the protagonist of *this* story will survive to the end, meaning Glimmer and Catra. Everyone else is fair game, regardless of their canon status. (Oh, and Jack will survive too, because I'm a softie at heart).
>
> This act is pretty much non-stop fighting, marinated in angst, with some horror elements thrown into the mix just to make it interesting, so braze yourself.
>
> Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Everything was silent.

The night was dark.

The Fright Zone was on high alert. The enemy drew closer and no one wanted to be caught unaware.

But even in these trying times, people will be people, and who can really be surprised if two soldiers find an opportunity for a little moonlight stroll, away from the prying eyes of their officers.

Hand in hand they walked through the ruins that surrounded the building complex they had been charged with guarding. They took their time, talked with low voices.

Eventually they found a hidden nook in a corner of a destroyed building, only the walls remaining, and slipped in for some kissing.

They took their time.

When they eventually separated, the shorter of them made a little worried sigh and sat down, back against the wall. The taller one followed suit.

"You think she's attacking tonight?" Kyle asked with low voice.

Rogelio grunted and shrugged.

"Yeah," Kyle agreed. "She can afford to keep us guessing. Bet she won't wait long, though."

Rogelio said something in reply.

"I'm not to worried about the princess," Kyle answered. "Not with these new pylons Lord Hordak has us building. He will be able to interfere with her magic in time if she tries anything."

Rogelio grunted.

"Sure, sure, unless they take out the generators," Kyle admitted. "But they are guarded. It's not like they will think of going through the sewers this time. Not without the water princess."

Rogelio bent forward a bit and grunted something. He leered as Kyle blushed.

"Well, if the wicked princess comes for me again, you'll protect me - won't you, big guy."

Rogelio grinned.

They kissed again.

"We'll better get back to Lonnie," Kyle said with regret. "It's not like she can guard the entire block 3B by herself."

Rogelio nodded and they stood up.

For a moment, Rogelio stared, unblinking into the night.

Then they walked back.

Catra stayed in her hiding place atop the wall for a little while. Then she slipped back towards the rest of her command. She had been given a lot to think of.

- - -

"Right," Catra said to her little task force. "Three of you, cause a distraction in their outer perimeter. Nothing big, but loud enough that they can't ignore it. Three of you, go through the sewers and take down the generators. Once that's done, send a signal and then move on block 2. The first group keep making noise. Move around, keep them guessing how many we really are."

"You don't want us to move on block 3B?" one of the soldiers interjected. "It's closer from the generators."

"Don't bother them and they won't bother you," Catra said with a direct look. The soldier hesitated, but didn't say anything more.

Catra moved her gaze to Glimmer.

"The moment the generators are down, you teleport the rest of us inside, Sparkles. "Aim for as close to the sanctum you can."

"I remember the way," Glimmer said drily.

"Once inside," Catra said, turned to her remaining soldiers, "the three of you engage whatever resistance is there. Play it safe. You don't have to take them down, just keep them distracted while me and Sparkles go for Hordak."

Glimmer turned to her ladies in waiting.

"And I want the three of you to prepare the ritual the moment we get inside. Draw the constructs, get the items in position."

Catra gave her a level look.

"Ritual, Sparkles?"

Glimmer calmly met her eyes.

"A disruption of any magic detector that might have its own power source, as well as a shield for some more esoteric attacks that might come our way."

"Think such an attack is likely, do you?" Catra asked, not loosing eye-contact.

"I think I'd better be safe than sorry, in this case," Glimmer answered.

They regarded each other in silence for a moment.

"Very well," Catra said. She turned to Jack.

"And you keep close to Sparkles. Keep her out of trouble, if at all possible."

"Trust me, boss," Jack grinned, trying to hide their fear behind bravado. Glimmer put a protective hand on their shoulder.

"As for you, Double Trouble, I want you to..." Catra interrupted herself and glared at the empty space where Double Trouble had stood.

"What are they up to now?" Glimmer asked.

"It better not be anything nefarious or I will feed them their own tail," Catra snarled.

"If they betray us, there won't be enough left of their tail to feed anyone," Glimmer said, voice menacing.

She took Catra's hand.

"Are you ready to do this, Catra?" she asked, voice serious.

"Sure," Catra growled. "I left unfinished business behind. Time to deal with it."

Just a short while later, an explosion was heard. One of Glimmer's ladies in waiting sharply looked up from her comm pad.

"The pylons are down, my lady," she reported.

Glimmer took a deep breath.

"Then let's do this."

"Take us away, Sparkles," Catra hissed.

And with a poof of pink glitter, Glimmer teleported them to the heart of the Fright Zone.

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"Block the east door," Catra hissed, as her soldiers scrambled to do just that.

"The sigil is in place, my Queen," one of the ladies in waiting reported as she looked up from a chalk circle she had drawn on the wall. She placed a small, bottle of a glowing liquid in front of it.

"Good," Glimmer gasped as she steadied herself after the teleportation. Jack's hands glowed like flash-lights as Glimmer poured excess magic into them.

"Right, Catra hissed. Then let's..." she froze as a door opened.

Force Captain Cobalt stared at her from the door opening.

For a moment neither of the parties moved.

Then he smirked.

"Welcome home, Catra," the old training officer growled, and as Catra lunged herself forward, Cobalt threw the mug of coffee he

carried at her and retreated, slamming the door behind him.

Catra swatted the mug away and spat out a curse. She tore the door open and lashed out with her whip. She managed to snare the fleeing Cobalt's legs and he fell. Catra rushed forward, but before she reached him he had pulled out his telescopic battle staff and used it to push a button on the wall.

He caught her eyes.

"You always did well with the surprise scenarios in training," he growled. "Let's see how you deal with this."

And from both ends of the corridor, bots sprung to life. Catra gave Cobalt an annoyed look as he freed himself from the whip and stood up in a defensive position. There was no way she would get to him quick enough.

"Get Cobalt," she snarled at her soldiers. "Me and Sparkles will take the bots."

"Find the Black Garnet chamber," Glimmer cried to her ladies in waiting. "Hold it until I catch up with you."

Catra got an uneasy feeling in her stomach.

"The Black Garnet, Sparkles?" she asked as she slashed the plating of a robot open and tore it's circuitry to shreds.

"I don't know what connection Shadow Weaver still has to it," Glimmer explained as she ducked under the leg of a bot a released a handful of sparkles in its sensors. "I'd prefer not be be caught blind-sided by her for once."

"Very prudent," Catra said with dry voice and despatched another bot.

Glimmer gave her an even look.

"Um... guys?" Jack said, cornered by two bots.

Glimmer smashed her staff into one of them, causing both of the bots to turn around. Quick as a shadow, Catra slipped under them and tore their sensors out.

"Thanks," ´Jack gasped and cut the cables of the now blinded bots with their knife.

"Don't mention it, kid," Catra said and got to her feet. The running steps of her soldiers still trying to catch up to Cobalt could be heard further down the corridor.

"Well, seems like we're on our own. Come." She tore open a vent cover.

Glimmer frowned.

"What's in there?"

"A shortcut to the inner sanctum," Catra explained. She smirked. "Entrapta showed it to me. Time to put it to good use. Coming, Glimmer?"

And together they crawled into the vent.

- - -

"She's in the facility," Grizzlor warned his soldiers. "Stay alert."

"Yes sir," a soldier grunted and peered down the hallway along the length of her rifle.

There were twenty of them by the door to Hordak's sanctum, hand picked by Grizzlor, one of the most senior officers of the Horde, who had been with Hordak almost from the start. They had the best equipment, the latest bots, they had time to prepare.

And they were going up against Catra and her mad princess.

Grizzlor knew in his bones this was going to be the fight of his life.

"Sir...?" one of the soldiers said.

Grizzlor stood unmoving for another moment, and then shook his head wearily.

"I thought I heard..." he begun, and then he swore as a bright, pink light suddenly filled the corridor.

"Fire!" he cried and dodged to the side as a barrage of small lighting balls hurled towards them. He smashed the button that put the bots in attack mode, and then he quickly fell to a knee and scanned the corridor. It was empty.

"Stay in formation," Grizzlor spat to the soldiers. "Someone, toss a grenade down the corridor. The princess is there *somewhere*. And don't forget to..."

He swore again and yanked blaster upwards. He managed to catch a fleeting glimpse of Catra, scuttling along the ceiling. The moment the cone of light from the blaster's search-light fell on her, she dropped and jumped straight towards the soldiers, claws out.

"HOLD YOUR FIRE!" Grizzlor bellowed, but the bots had detected the attacker and spewed death towards their own, with Catra quickly disengaging and disappearing in the shadows.

"YOU FIVE, ON CATRA!" Grizzlor cried to one of the groups of soldiers, and left another to get the bots under control. He quickly pulled a blaster grenade from his belt and tossed it down the corridor. It had hardly left his hand until suddenly another poof was heard, and in a cloud of glitter, the Shining Princess stood behind him.

He reacted immediately, mashing the stun baton towards her face. She blocked it seemingly without any effort with a swipe from her staff and threw a fistful of sparks in his face. It felt like his eyeballs were on fire. He couldn't see anything. Quickly he dropped and fell back to a defensive position. He heard one of the soldiers scream, a quick, cut off scream, immediately replaced by

a thud as the unlucky bastard fell from the ceiling where the princess had teleported her, landing on another solider.

"CATRA'S COMING BACK!" someone cried, and a moment later a whip cracked, and the bot just next to Grizzlor toppled over, firing wildly, as the whip tangled its leg.

"STUN BATONS!" Grizzlor bellowed and pushed forwards, towards the group surrounding Catra. He blinked furiously and just got a good look at his former pupil, snarling as she fought with a knife in each hand, when the air was suddenly full of pink sparks again, and a moment later - when he could see - Catra was gone.

But she left a stun grenade behind.

"DOWN!" Grizzlor cried and hit the floor as the blast went off. His ears were ringing, but he managed to tear up his magic detector, and the moment he saw the indicator light up, he gave the bots order to fire at the highlighted coordinates.

The princess, however, immediately teleported away again, and Grizzlor had to cancel the fire-order least the bots would start chasing sparks and fire in random directions. He blasted a few shots himself for good measure in the direction the magic detector indicated and then...

"SHIELD!" he yelled as the detector went wild and a magic lighting ball as big as his head hurled towards them through the corridor. Luckily the shield generator was still operational, but that meant the soldiers manning it had their focus on the controls and not their immediate surroundings.

Catra made short work of them

Grizzlor pushed himself forward, towards his former student, former leader.

He grinned.

"Welcome back, Catra," Grizzlor said, voice deceptively calm.

"Glad to see me, are you?" Catra shot back, voice barely hiding her rage. "Missed me, did you?"

"Of course I didn't," Grizzlor spat. "You were a horrible second in command. We were better off without you."

For a moment Catra looked like he had struck her, then she lounged forward with a snarl. Grizzlor, however, had expected the outburst and calmly took a step back, raising his staff into a defensive position.

"What did you expect me to say?" he growled, voice raspy. "That we all finally learnt to respect you once we got to see what you truly what capable of? That we *liked* you?"

He leaned closer to the furious feline and smirked, his fangs flinting in the flickering light. He ignored the continued fighting around them.

"Did you truly think we didn't know what Shadow Weaver did to you?"

For a moment Catra froze, not a muscle moving. She stared at Grizzlor with clenched fists.

He laughed at her discomfort.

"Did you think you were special, Catra? The only kid we were hard on? The truth is, you were such a little shit the rest of us were *glad* the witch took it upon herself to discipline you." He raised his staff slightly in a mocking salute. "In fact, the only thing with you that was special was that you never got it."

"Got what?" Catra spat, voice furious. She pressed her claws into her palms so hard that she drew blood.

Grizzlor took a short step forward.

"To fit in. There's a place for everyone in the Horde, Catra, even for people like you. But you were too stubborn to accept it."

"We will see about that, won't we," Catra snarled. "When I take over, we'll see who doesn't 'fit in'."

"I'm sure we will," Grizzlor leered, taking another step forward. "But there's one more thing you should know..."

"Oh yeah?" Catra asked, despite herself holding her breath.

Her whole attention was focused on his words, which was why she reacted a moment too late when he pulled a small, sharp crystal rod from a pouch and stabbed it at Catra's breast. As it broke her skin, purple light immediately flowed over her body.

Catra screamed, a high pitched cry that begun in fury but as the light engulfed her, it shifted to pain and fear. Her eyes stared at something unseen and her entire body shivered.

"Let it be said for the old witch," Grizzlor muttered as he drew his phaser and pointed it straight at Catra's head. "She knew her tricks."

He pulled the trigger.

A beam of pure magic hit Grizzlor in the torso, hot enough to burn straight through him, straight through the massive door behind him.

For a moment, the force of the magic held his spasming body upright, a surprised look on his face, then it abruptly stopped and the body fell to the floor.

The crystal rod fell from Grizzlor's still trembling hand. It fell to the floor with a small plink, rolled a few moments and then unceremoniously was crushed under Glimmer's foot as she stepped out of the smoke, her skin glowing like a miniature furnace, up to the still screaming Catra.

The purple light immediately disappeared and Catra gasped for air. She looked up in Glimmer's furious face.

"Gli-glimmer..." she whispered.

"He's *wrong*," Glimmer snarled. She stomped down on the crystal rod again. "This whole *place* is wrong."

She leaned down and took Catra's feet, helping her to her feet.

"When Adora first came to Brightmoon," she said with softer voice, even if the anger was still simmering under the surface, "when me and Bow first realized just how much damage had been done to such a sweet girl, I was so furious with the Horde. And when she talked about the rest of you... Lonnie, Rogelio, Kyle... you... it was so clear it wasn't just her. ALL of you were abused, lied to, manipulated... told that if you just worked a little harder, was just a little better to follow just another order, you would finally get what you had been denied. Respect, love, a place to belong."

She turned around and let another beam of light scorch the walls.

"But it was all a *lie*. You were just cannon fodder. *Your* big crime was that you never accepted that."

"Yeah, I got it myself, Sparkles," Catra gulped. "I was raised by Shadow Weaver, you know. It didn't take me THAT long to realize she'd never be happy with me, whatever I did."

She sighed.

"But it's easy to lapse, I suppose."

"You OK?" Glimmer said with a gentleness that contrasted vividly with her fury just a moment ago.

"Yeah, I think I am," Catra said. "Can't believe the old coot got one over me, but I'll live." She looked at the body on the floor, at the fallen bots and soldiers, and glanced at Glimmer. "Are *you* OK, Glimmer?"

"More than OK," Glimmer growled. She picked up one of the shards from the crystal rods and gave it a disdainful look. "And I will be even more so once I take care of this nuisance."

"What WAS that?" Catra asked, still carefully eyeing Glimmer. "It felt like one of Shadow Weaver's love taps."

"It was the Black Garnet," Glimmer said between gritted teeth, the anger that simmered under the surface on it's way up again. "It has been activated. How, I don't know. But the rod serves as a connection."

Catra was silent for a long moment.

"Is *she* here?" she asked eventually, not quite daring to meet Glimmer's eyes.

"I don't know," Glimmer confessed. "As far as I know there are only two people who have accessed that rock since the old Scorpion Queen died, and I doubt this is Entrapta's doing."

"So then what do we do, Glimmer?" Catra said with low voice.

Glimmer looked at the hole she had blasted through the doors, into Hordak's inner sanctum.

"We move on," she said. "I have a few tricks to keep the Black Garnet at bay, and once we have dealt with Hordak we can take care of whatever is going on at our leisure."

"'Tricks'?" Catra asked with level voice.

"Tricks," Glimmer repeated.

"Care to elaborate on that?" Catra said, raising an eyebrow.

"Not in particular, no," Glimmer said.

She looked Catra in the eyes.

"Whatever happens," she said with soft voice, "I've got your back. Shadow Weaver will never get to you again."

"You know," Catra said slowly, "you are the second person in this world who ever gave me that promise."

For a moment, Glimmer's face was an absolute expressionless mask.

"I'm not Adora," she said then, just a hint of frost in her voice.

"I know you're not," Catra said with low voice.

For a moment they just looked at each other.

Then Catra broke the tension with a smirk.

"It's funny," she said. "This used to be our dream, mine and Adora's. Take down Hordak, take over the Fright Zone, do it *right*."

"Do I even want to know what you meant with 'right'?" Glimmer said, matching Catra's smirk.

The tension between them dissipated somewhat.

But it wasn't forgotten.

"Fair, I suppose," Catra said with a shrug. "We were kids. More ration bars, more play time, no bullying, no targeting poor innocent catgirls just because a wicked witch was in a bad mood that day." She showed her teeth. "And we would totally have kicked the ass of any pink princess that got in our way."

"I'd liked to have seen you try," Glimmer growled.

"I can kick your ass right here, right now if you want," Catra said and took a step closer to Glimmer, a hungry glint in her eyes.

"Can you *please* stop flirting while we are in the middle of an attack?" Jack piped up with scared voice, staring down the empty

corridors, the floor filled with bodies and wrecked bots.

"No such time as the present, kid," Catra said loftily.

"No, no, they've got a point," Glimmer said teasingly. "Work first, pleasure later. But don't think I'll forget about the 'pleasure' part."

She grabbed the sides of Catra's head and held her gaze.

"Once you take down Hordak, I'll fuck you like you've never been fucked before."

"*Glimmer!*" Jack cried, cheeks burning. Even Catra looked flustered as Glimmer kept her head in a steady grip for another moment or two, and then let go with a smirk.

"If you're up for it, of course, Kitty-Cat," she purred.

"I have dreamt of this moment my entire life," Catra growled. "You really don't have to sweeten the deal for me."

"Either way, I think we're due some 'us-time' once the job is done," Glimmer said loftily. "So you better come back from this in one piece."

"Same goes for you, Sparkles," Catra said with sincere voice.

"Don't you worr..." Glimmer began, but then she yelped and scrambled backwards as a laser blast hit the floor, just next to her feet.

"GLIMMER!" Catra cried.

A bot stepped into view, from the hole Glimmer had blasted in the door. It had a different design than the bots they previously had encountered. It was sleeker, more spindly. A ghostly light played over it.

Glimmer gave it a disdainful look and opened her fists. A beam of light shot from her hands, cleaving the bot in two.

"Glimmer! No!" Catra cried.

"WHAT?" Glimmer snarled, her anger flaring up again.

"That's one of Entrapta's designs..." Catra begun, but before she had time to finish, before their eyes each half of the bot regenerated, and within moments two bots moved towards them.

With an enraged cry Glimmer shot another beam, slicing both bots into pieces.

"Stop!" Catra cried. "You will only make it double again."

"Then I hit it again first," Glimmer snarled. She teleported into the middle of the regenerating bots, and before they had time to reform, light shot from every direction. Catra and Jack quickly scrambled into cover not to be hit.

When they could see again, Glimmer stood in the middle of veritable crater of debris and burnt metal. Her skin was glowing and she panted hard. All around her were the sound of tiny little pieces of metal, dragging itself together, regenerating lost limbs.

As they looked, a particularly large piece sprouted legs and a camera lens, forming a miniature version of the bot Glimmer had destroyed.

"Oh, come on!" she panted.

"How do we destroy it?" Jack cried.

"Power source," Catra answered, looking around frantically. "A piece of first one's tech. It can't duplicate itself indefinitely."

"We better get to it quick, then!" Jack cried, desperately looking at the pieces of debris that skittered around them, assembling into miniature robots that became more complete - and deadly - by the minute.

Catra stared intently at the scene, completely unmovable for a few moments.

"There!" she cried, pointing at a spot close to the door. "The moment is centred on that spot. The first one's tech must be there."

"On it!" Jack cried and ran, ducking blasts from the bots that already had assembled their laser guns.

They snatched up the crystal, severing several thin cables that connected it to the surrounding debris. Proudly they turned to Catra.

"I got it!" they said, and then gasped in pain as a light flickered over the crystal. It fell to the ground and new cables immediately sprouted. All around them, the half-finished bot started moving again.

"Entrapta was so proud of her little tricks," Catra said between gritted teeth.

"Well, I know a few of my own," Glimmer snarled. She teleported just next to Jack and formed a pink bubble, trapping the crystal shard inside it, snapping the cables once again.

Glimmer held up the bubble and watched in grim satisfaction as tendrils of light uselessly tried to penetrate the pink surface. All around them, the bot fragment fell silent again.

She took a deep breath, and as she breathed out the light intensity of the bubble increased. Jack and Catra had to look away as the pink light played over the room.

When they looked again there was no bubble in Glimmer's hands. Nor was there a crystal.

The bots remained dead.

Glimmer looked around in grim satisfaction.

"*Now* perhaps we can..."

Her voice trailed off as a low humming was heard, rapidly growing louder.

"NOW what?" Glimmer snarled. Catra's hand flew to her whip and they all rapidly looked around.

One by one, crystal rods - much like the one Grizzlor had - attached to the ceiling lit up along the corridor. Purple light jumped between them.

"Oh shit," Catra said with low voice.

Glimmer quickly spun around. She held out booth hands, fingers spread wide and a dome of light emerged around her and Jack. For a moment, she just held the force, shielding them against the purple lighting from the crystals. Then she made a jabbing motion and it exploded outwards, shattering crystals along the corridor.

Glimmer's skin glowed bright and she visibly had to force had mouth shut not to throw up. With fumbling hands she grabbed Jack. The teenager screamed as magic flowed into them. They quickly forced a crude construct in shape and lit up the corridor with sparks as they tried to ground the excess magic.

The humming sound only grew louder. Purple light still jumped between the shards of the smashed rods.

Catra stared at Glimmer.

"What's happening?" she cried.

"Magic!" Glimmer spat. "Get moving, I'll cover your rear."

Catra nodded, took a quick breath and - with one last look at Glimmer and the trembling Jack - went through the hole in the door.

"All right," she whispered. "I think we're in the clear."

When she didn't get an answer, she glanced behind her.

Glimmer and Jack was no longer standing behind her in the corridor.

- - -

"Where are we going?" Jack hissed as they hurried after Glimmer, hand held in a vice-like grip.

"The Black Garnet chamber," Glimmer hissed in answer.

Jack gave her a frightened look.

"The Black Garnet? I thought we were going to follow Catra."

"Oh, we are," Glimmer answered with level voice. "We are just taking care of a little errand first."

Jack stared at her.

"I'm going to connect to the Black Garnet," Glimmer explained.

"Wha-at?" Jack blurted. "Connect? You told Catra you would help her with Hordak."

"Taking down those rods would be very helpful, don't you think?" Glimmer hissed and rounded a corner.

"But Catra will be in the sanctum! Alone!" Jack cried in fear.

"Catra is a big girl, she can take care of herself for a little while," Glimmer said between gritted teeth. She peered through a doorway and quickly ducked back.

"Bots," she said as an explanation and hunched down by the side of the door.

"I don't understand!" Jack gasped. "If you're planning to go after the Black Garnet, why didn't you tell her?"

"Because Catra, just like everyone else, don't think I'm strong enough," Glimmer snarled. She gave Jack a look hostile enough for the teenager to shrink back and press themselves against the wall.

"Catra thinks," Glimmer said with even voice, quivering with rage, "that I need to be protected. Held back. *Controlled*." She spat out the last word.

"I'm not sure..." Jack begun, but flinched when Glimmer produced a ball of lighting.

"*Catra* wants me to wait like a good girl for *her* say so before I take the Black Garnet," Glimmer went on. "But I'm done waiting."

She turned straight to Jack, the sparkling light making her features seemingly boil. Jack tried to press backwards against the wall.

"Shadow Weaver took my runestone, Jack," Glimmer snarled. "She took my throne. She took my magic. She left me this wretched shadow of what should have been *mine*. It only seems fair I take something from her, don't you agree."

Jack, too afraid to speak, just nodded. Glimmer held their gaze for a moment.

Then she flung the ball of lighting into the next room, detonating the bots in an explosion that rocked the entire building.

"Shadow Weaver spent decades trying to wrestle the secrets from the runestone of the Scorpion family, with very limited success," Glimmer said as she strode into the next chamber, past the wrecked bots. "But she is no elemental princess. I am. The Black Garnet will answer to me."

She blew a bolted door from its hinges.

"And if Hordak tries to stand in my way it will be worst for him," she said.

- - -

Catra carefully moved forward, keeping to the shadows.

"Glimmer?" she whispered.

- - -

Jack trailed after her as Glimmer walked past the doors and into a corridor. Glimmer hesitated, looking both ways.

"Are you sure we shouldn't stay with Catra..." Jack tried again.

Glimmer snorted.

"I told her I'm going to neutralize whatever this is," -she pointed at the rods in the ceiling- "and that's exactly what I'm going to do."

She chose a direction and started half-sprinting down the corridor with Jack in tow.

"I just think..." Jack begun.

Glimmer stopped abruptly.

"That I can't do it? That I'm weak?" she said with deceptively soft voice.

Jack flinched back.

"I... I didn't say that," they whispered.

"Good," Glimmer said with cold voice and started down the corridor again.

In the ceiling, the rods shimmered and hummed.

They got to another crossing. Glimmer closed her eyes and took a deep breath. She summoned a handful of sparks, and a after a moment she opened her eyes and watched them carefully.

"That way," she concluded and pointed down a corridor.

"Are you sure?" Jack frowned. "I didn't see anything."

"The rods make it hard to get a clear signal to the runestone," Glimmer admitted. "But I'm confident that..."

"Glimmer!" Catra's voice cried out, down one of the other corridors.

Jack and Glimmer stared at each other.

"She should be in the sanctum," Glimmer muttered in confusion. "What is..."

"GLIMMER!" Catra cried again, voice more urgent.

Jack gave Glimmer a scared look.

"What will...?" they begun, then they gasped as Glimmer grabbed them.

"What is she up to?" she hissed, staring Jack in the eyes.

"What? I don't know!" Jack yelled. "I thought we had a plan."

"Apparently we had more than one," Glimmer said grimly. She let go of Jack and stared at the corridors, trying to make up her mind.

"Glimmer...?" Catra cried again, voice fainter now, sounding more scared than urgent.

"Glimmer...?" Jack whispered, full of misgivings.

"FINE!" Glimmer snarled. "Let's find her, let's kick ass and then I can connect to the rock in peace.

She slammed her fist into the palm of her hand, unleashing a pink shock wave that travelled down the corridor, smashing every crystal as it went along.

The air was still full of shards as they ran down the corridor. Jack kept their ears close to the body and their eyes almost entirely closed, relaying more on sense than anything else to stay close to Glimmer.

"Glimmer!" Catra cried from somewhere in front of them. Glimmer ran faster, trying to see as far forward as she could, but dust and debris and crystal shards were everywhere.

"Catra!" she cried in answer.

"Glimmer!" Catra cried again, further away, and with more urgency in her voice.

"*Catra!*" Glimmer cried, more scared now.

"Glimmer!" Jack cried as a warning, and barley managed to jump to the side as bots lumbered towards them through the dust and darkness.

Glimmer snarled in frustration and blasted a bot to shreds. She ran forward through the smoke, scanning the narrow corridor for anything that moved.

"Wait!" Jack gasped as they tried to keep up with the glowing princess, excess magic spilling in every direction.

"Fast as a jackrabbit, are you?" Glimmer snapped at them. She rounded a corner and quickly teleported as a bot opened fire on her. Jack flung themselves to the floor, but a moment later Glimmer had rematerialized above the bot and made short work of it.

She gave Jack an impatient look.

"Where's Catra?" she cried.

"I don't know," Jack confessed and hurried up to her. "She should have been right in front of..."

"GLIMMER!" Catra's voice cried out further down the corridor.

Jack and Glimmer stared in frustration.

"Get to the Black Garnet chamber," Glimmer shouted to Jack. "I'll find her."

"Wait!" Jack cried. "What are..."

And then they were alone in the corridor, as Glimmer teleported out.

"Catra!" Glimmer snarled, emerging as close as possible to what she estimated to be the source of the voice. "Where *are* you?"

"Glimmer!" Catra said with low voice, from just inside a door.

Glimmer eyed it suspiciously, but she kicked it open and jumped inside.

"This better be..." she begun.

She abruptly silenced.

The room was lined with crystal rods, connected by thick cables to a central drum. The air between them was thick with purple magic.

In the middle of the room sat Imp. The little creature smirked at Glimmer, then he opened his mouth and from the smooth baby face came Catra's voice, fear and urgency mixed.

"*Glimmer, Glimmer, Glimmer!*" it cried.

Chapter End Notes

Uh oh!

When titans fight

Chapter Notes

> Warning: Vicious fighting, shooting, maiming and death. Crushing and burning. Imagery of drowning and suffocation.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The throne.

The throne.

The symbol of the Horde.

Tall, dark, imposing.

Power and will made manifest.

A reminder for everyone in its presence, of the terrible might of technology and willpower that had held Etheria in an iron grip since the day Hordak first arrived.

With measured steps Catra walked up to it, stopping by the foot.

She let her eyes play over the steps, all the way up to the tall, dark, imposing man sitting in it.

"Catra," he said, voice barely containing a growl.

"Hordak," she answered, voice quivering with rage.

For a moment they just regarded each other in silence.

Maybe, just maybe, pondering if there was still something left unsaid between them.

Then Catra tore out her whip, just as Hordak stood up, and in the same precise - almost mechanical - moment his arm canon turned towards Catra and fired.

- - -

The explosion shook the corridor, causing bricks to fall and pipes to burst.

With heart beating, Jack crept through the corridors of the Fright Zone. Their ears twitched as they took in every sound, searching for familiar voice, but all they heard were the clangs of bots, distant explosions and the shouts of Horde soldiers.

"Halt!" a voice suddenly commanded.

Jack spun around and looked right into the barrel of a blaster, held by a Horde soldier.

"I caught an intruder!" the soldier shouted, and out of the steam an officer stomped. She gave Jack an unpleasant grin.

"Great," the commander gruffed. "String her up and put her in a cell. We'll sort her out when Lord Hordak is done with Catra."

The solider made a smart salute.

"Actually, they go by 'they'," the solider said with smooth voice.

The commander gave them a confused look.

"What?" she said, and then didn't say much of anything as the soldier cut her throat.

Jack stared with enormous eyes.

"Bit of a pickle, isn't it," Double Trouble said and took their normal guise. "No fear. Between the two of us I'm sure we can sort out any wrinkle."

"Gli... Glimmer's went on her own!" Jack gasped, still staring at the dying commander at their feet.

"Did she now?" Double Trouble said as they went through the officer's pockets. They handed Jack the stun baton. "And left you

all by yourself in the middle of the Fright Zone. She must think highly of your capabilities."

"She told me to get to the Black Garnet chamber," Jack went on.

Double Trouble gave them a long look.

"Did she now?" they repeated.

"Where's Catra?" Jack asked.

As if for an answer, another explosion shook the building.

"In Hordak's sanctum," Double Trouble said - for once completely sincere. "Fighting for her life and for his throne."

"We have to help her!" Jack said with determination.

Double Trouble smiled and put a patronizing hand on their shoulder.

"No one can fault you for your loyalty, kid, and Catra is lucky to have you. But when titans fight, regular folks like you and me do better to step aside."

"You can't seriously mean we are to do nothing," Jack complained.

"I didn't say that," Double Trouble smirked. "There is plenty of work to be found for the smart and sneaky such as ourselves."

"Like what?" Jack asked.

Double Trouble gave them a serious look.

"Hordak expected us. He prepared a trap and we fell right into it like good little goslings. Now it's up to us to cut the net before it chokes us."

Jack gave them a confused look.

"And by that you mean...?"

"The Black Garnet," Double Trouble answered. "Your Queen gave you a command. I suggest you abide by it."

- - -

"I should have done this a long time ago," Hordak growled as he narrowly missed Catra with yet another beam from his arm canon.

"Yeah, because back then you might actually have had a chance," Catra snarled and fired her blaster, hitting the wall just behind him.

She had to jump aside as another shot melted a beam just next to her. She scrambled backwards when a section of the roof fell down between them, giving them both time for a few, ragged breaths.

Then the dust cleared and they locked eyes again, and with a roar they ran towards each other.

- - -

"Me and Glimmer already tried to get to the Black Garnet."

"I hate to tell you, kid, but you're in the completely wrong part of the complex."

"Hordak mislead us?"

"It's not much of a trap if the prey gets to pick their own path, is it."

Jack nodded.

"And the two of us are going to find our way there?"

Double Trouble grinned.

"Unless you have any pressing plans..."

Jack gave them a bleak smile.

"It must be guarded."

"Undoubtedly," Double Trouble repeated.

"The two of us, against the full might of the Horde," Jack mused.

"Hardly fair," Double Trouble drawled. "With just one of us it might have been something of a challenge, but we are on the clock."

Jack looked slightly more happy at that.

"You really think we can do it?"

Double Trouble chuckled.

"I think that the two of us make hell of a team, kid."

"Right..." Jack said, more to themselves than to Double Trouble. "I suppose I can just as well be killed trying to do something stupid as trying to find a hole to hide away in."

They gave Double Trouble a brave smile.

"What do I do?"

Their grin widened.

"You bleed."

- - -

Glimmer struggled against a flood of power. She gritted her teeth and fought back. Purple light flashed in every direction and it felt like swimming against a water fall. She closed her eyes and forced herself to keep struggling.

- - -

"You have a lousy aim," Catra taunted from the rafters. "But then again, Entrapta could have told us that much, couldn't she?"

"You DARE?" Hordak roared.

"What are you going to do about it?" Catra shot back. "Send me away to die? Sorry to tell you but it didn't take."

"One of many oversights concerning you that I now aim to correct," Hordak hissed, and Catra had to flee again as the metal ceiling she had hid underneath melted under the onslaught of Hordak's arm beam.

- - -

"I'm not a princess," Jack protested. "You *know* my blood isn't magical."

"I meant metaphorically, kid. Where's your sense of drama?"

Despite everything, Jack found it in themselves to roll their eyes at the grinning Double Trouble.

"What? This isn't dramatic enough for you as it is."

"First rule, kid. There's room for improvement in any story."

"Well, how do you plan to improve this one?"

"Just do some magic by the next corner. It doesn't have to be much, just enough to trip the sensors."

"Without Glimmer, that's probably all I will be able to do anyway."

Double Trouble smiled.

"Good. That should cause enough of a distraction."

"Enough of a distraction for what?"

"For you to reach the control panel by the guard post."

"And what will I do once I reach the control panel by the guard post?"

"You will enter the activation code for the bots, of course.

"I don't have the activation code for the bots," Jack protested.

Double Trouble grinned in the satisfied manner of someone who just got the exact line delivered to them they had been angling for.

"Ah, that's true, you don't. It's a piece of luck then that you have a friend who just so *happens* to have overheard a *criminally* reckless officer share the code with a soldier."

Jack rolled their eyes.

"Fine, I cause a distraction, I slip past them and then I activate the bots. Won't they shoot at me?"

Double Trouble looked shocked.

"Shoot at a fellow Horde Solider? I've never!"

Jack narrowed their eyes.

"And how do I..."

With a wink, Double Trouble handed them a horde badge and uniform.

"Pays to be prepared, kid."

"I wish you would stop call me that," Jack grumbled.

"Savour the thought," Double Trouble leered. "If you keep it up, you might be promoted to 'sport' before this is over."

"Happy thought," Jack snarked. "And what are *you* doing while I pretend to be a horde soldier running from a wicked princess?"

Double Trouble's grin grew wider.

"I give you something to run from, naturally."

- - -

The light filled her lungs. Glimmer fought furiously for air, but the light stretched in every direction, like she had been transported to the middle of an ocean made of magic. She recognized the power signature. The Black Garnet. She had felt in in the crystals. She remembered vividly the time Shadow Weaver had trapped her in its light. But the structure of the power was nothing she had ever encountered before. It wasn't the structured layers of a spell, the way Castaspella or even Shadow Weaver would have weaved. It wasn't the raw torrent of emotions and power intermingled, like an elemental princess like herself could unleash - Glimmer couldn't help smiling as she remembered some sparring sessions with Frosta.

This power was structured but incoherent. It repeated and it looped and it spiralled out in a fractal pattern, were every time she thought she could grasp it's overall structure, find a node to grasp on to or a thread to pull, it turned out to be just a small part of a larger structure, blooming out in all directions.

Glimmer wondered what kind of mind could ever shape - or even make sense of - something like this. Unbidden, her thoughts went to a happy face, a shrieking laughter, hair moving on its own accord in all directions.

She shivered. Fighting down the panic, she forced herself to keep fighting, keep searching for a way out.

- - -

"Die, die, die!" Catra shouted, rapidly firing her blaster towards Hordak.

With a snort of disdain he ripped a metal sheet from the wall and held it up as a shield, walking steadily towards her.

- - -

"Help, help!" Jack cried as they rounded the corner. The magic detectors blared like crazy and in the ceiling the violet crystal rods lit up. "The princess is coming!"

Perhaps, if they had had one more moment of reflection, the soldiers would have seen through Jacks flimsy disguise and opened fire.

But they didn't have a moment, because just behind Jack followed the Shining Princess.

Smoke billowed ('smoke grenade - never leave home without it, kid') and lighting flashed ('You'd be amazed how much flash you can get from a standard issue blaster if you put your mind to it'), and in the middle of it all walked Glimmer... or rather, Glimmer as the stories would have her.

Her hair was dark purple with streaks of blood. Her eyes were sunken and surrounded by shadows. her mouth were slightly too wide with too many teeth.

"You have angered the Shining Princess," she hissed with a voice that carried well, despite the clamour.

The soldiers desperately scrambled to open fire, but Double Trouble quickly darted back and forth through the smoke, making it near impossible to get a good aim.

Jack ran up to the control panel and hammered on the keys putting in the code Double Trouble had given them.

All around them bots sprung to life, adding to the chaos as they opened fire on soldiers and foes alike.

"I will eat your souuuuuuls," Double Trouble boomed in a suitably demonic version of Glimmer's voice.

Jack decided that they had done well enough for their part, and ran on through the corridor, only narrowly avoiding the bots that

scrambled in the opposite direction to unleash hell on a generous basis.

- - -

Glimmer felt her powers ebb. She was struggling against the torrent of magic that surrounded her, struggling to find a way out of the endless, fractal maze, but every move seemed to suck the magic out of her. The light filled her entire world, it was like she could hear it, taste it, feel it - like fine sand over her skin, wearing her down. Glimmer wondered if - if she ever got out of this - there would be anything left of her.

- - -

"Well, that was fun," Double Trouble said when they caught up with Jack.

"It was terrifying!" Jack gasped.

"And fun," Double Trouble insisted.

"How much further to the Black Garnet chamber?" Jack asked.

"A bit," Double Trouble answered loftily, but we are making a detour.

"We are?" Jack asked with the slightly tired voice of people who have to deal with Double Trouble for any length of time.

"Indeed," Double Trouble drawled. "The prison complex is right in front of us. I figured we could do with some backup."

"Halt," a soldier cried from the end of the corridor.

Jack, stopped, trying their very best to look like they belonged.

"What's happening back there!" the soldier asked.

"Um..." Jack begun, but was interrupted by a gruff voice from behind.

"Catra is happening," Grizzlor said, striding purposefully towards the soldier.

"Lord Hordak is taking care of her, right?" the soldier said.

Double Trouble only hesitated for a moment.

"Obviously Lord Hordak is taking care of her. But we need to secure the prisoners even so."

The soldier gave them a suspicious look.

"You never gave me the password," they said, voice hostile.

"Password?" Double Trouble roared. "I have never heard of such insolence from..."

Which is as far as they got before Jack pressed their stun baton to the soldier's chest.

Double Trouble gave the spasming soldier a hurt look.

"Personally I found my impersonation impeccable." They turned to Jack. "Be honest with me? How would you rate my performance?"

"Now?" Jack gasped as more soldiers came running down the corridor.

"I want to dispel any notion that I did a subpar performance," Double Trouble sniffed and took Grizzlor's shape again.

"That soldier is a spy!" they shouted and pointed at Jack.

Jack gave Double Trouble a hurt look, but when the soldiers surrounded them, they didn't pay attention to Double Trouble, and the next moment the shape-shifter had taken they guise of one of the soldiers and smashed the heads of two of the others together.

One of the remaining soldiers stared in confusion into her own face while the other hesitated, waving their blaster back and forth.

"Shoot her, she's the imposter," Double Trouble gasped and pointed at the real soldier.

"What? No, *she* is," the soldier objected and pointed at Double Trouble, who immediately matched her expression.

"Could you be serious for maybe one second?" Jack shouted as they zapped the hesitant soldier with one of his fallen comrade's freshly charged stun batons."

The remaining solider roared in frustration and lounged at Double Trouble, who took Jack's shape.

"Shoot them, they're the imposter," they said and pointed at Jack.

"That doesn't even make sense," Jack yelled and slunk behind the soldier, who was still coming for Double Trouble. With two against one the fight was short.

"It was the punchline," Double Trouble explained and took their own guise again. "Repeated for humorous effect."

Jack groaned in frustration and struggled to regain their breath. To their surprise they suddenly felt Double Trouble's hands on their temples. Double Trouble caught their gaze.

"Deep breaths, kid. In" -they demonstrated- "and out."

They repeated the pattern a few times, and to Jack's great surprise they felt calmer.

"Remember, kid, life's too short not to joke about," Double Trouble said loftily as they entered the prison.

"All that, and I'm still not ranking as 'sport'? Jack asked, mock petulance in their voice.

Double Trouble looked up from the control panel they fiddled with and grinned at them.

"Find a way to get your queen's ladies in waiting out of here and you'll be 'sport' to me any day of the week."

Jack looked around the gigantic room, floor after floor lined with cells.

"Oh, I think I can do one better than that," they said and pushed Double Trouble away from the terminal.

- - -

Where the hell was Sparkles?

Catra had done her part. Engaged Hordak, strung him along. Kept the banter going. But Hordak had been prepared. The Fright Zone was a fortress. And that shit Grizzlor had pulled, with the crystal, that had spoked her.

The feeling of being helpless to stop those purple tendrils of magic had etched themself into her brain far more efficiently than as a mere memory. Catra could practically *taste* her old childhood fear.

Well, this time Catra wasn't just a little kitten, helpless as the wicked witch came for her.

This time, Catra had her very own princess.

If she just could show up!

Catra wasn't stupid. She knew Glimmer had her own agenda. Her own power bid.

She knew, much as Glimmer tried to downplay it, that Hordak was only a stepping stone for her.

That her real adversary waited back in Brightmoon.

Catra got it.

It was OK.

She still hoped Glimmer would hurry up doing whatever she was doing with the Black Garnet so they could get on with taking down Hordak.

She heard the steps behind her in the corridor.

It was OK.

She could keep this up.

She knew Glimmer would come.

She knew her princess wouldn't abandon her the moment she had what she needed.

Like all the others had.

- - -

"You mean to tell you that you had access to the master code, and didn't even know it?" Jack asked incredulously as their fingers danced over the terminal.

"I just knew it would control the bots," Double Trouble said defensively. "I never bother understanding how machines work. People are much more interesting."

"Well, you'll have a whole lot of interesting people to deal with right... now," Jack said and pressed the final button.

The cell doors swung open. A whole lot of prisoner carefully peaked out.

Double Trouble put a hand on Jack's shoulder.

"Well done, Sport," they said with genuine warmth in their voice.

Jack blushed.

"Now, get your queens ladies-in-waiting and get to the Black Garnet chamber. I have a feeling you will be needed there."

"You are not coming with me?" Jack asked.

Double Trouble shook their head.

"Someone need to give these poor lost souls directions... and create a veritable nightmare for the Horde while we're at it. Just give your queen whatever help she needs and I'll make sure she has the time she needs to finish what she came for."

They made a grimace.

"And then maybe, just maybe she won't kill me for what I'm about to do."

With one last blink to Jack, Double Trouble shifted into well known hero of the rebellion, Bow the Archer.

"Huzza!" they proclaimed with loud voice to the escaped prisoners. "By the power of friendship you are saved. But our predicament is not yet over. Hug your brother and your sister next to you, and with teamwork we will get ourselves out of this pickle! FOLLOW ME!"

Purposefully they strode towards the exit, with the majority of the prisoners in tow.

Jack stared after them for a moment, chuckling slightly for themselves.

Then they walked up to the ladies in waiting who had gathered in their own clique.

"Come with me," Jack said with serious voice. "Our princess needs us."

- - -

Glimmer slowly sank downwards - as so far directions had any meaning in here. She had stopped struggling. Now all she could do was try to keep her breathing steady, despite the light that for

every breath seemed to suck more and more air from her lungs. Her very being ached. The light hammered at her brain, from the outside and from within. The fractal pattern roared in her brain, making thought nearly impossible.

Glimmer thought of Catra. The guilt churned in her breast. She wished she had followed the plan. Wished she had let her partner - girlfriend - in on her true motive. She knew in her heart Catra would not have stopped her, had Glimmer only trusted her.

Glimmer had her reasons. Good reasons. At least they had seemed like that at the time.

Glimmer wished she had trusted Catra.

- - -

Metal groaned against metal as a load bearing wall - damaged in the latest explosion - slowly gave in to the demands of the heavy load it carried.

"Come *on*," Jack shouted to the slowest of the three ladies in waiting, who grimly trudged on, despite a rather nasty looking wound in the thigh.

"Where's the Queen?" one of them panted.

"Black Garnet Chamber," Jack shouted in response.

They entered a hallway just to see the ceiling give in and collapse. Jack yelped and flung themselves backwards. The ladies in waiting swore and quickly retreated.

"Right..." Jack said as they got back on their feet. "We're not going that way."

"We'll have to double back and find another way to the central corridor," one of the ladies in waiting - a Horde deserter and somewhat familiar with the layout of the Fright Zone - gruffed.

"Easier said than done," another objected. "The whole place is crawling with soldiers."

"The Queen counts on us," the first answered with the kind of voice that won't allow contradictions

The others grunted in affirmation.

They peered down the corridor they had come from.

"For Queen Glimmer," One of them said.

"Queen Glimmer," the others repeated. Jack, too, chimed in and felt oddly better for it.

Then walked down the corridor with uneasy steps.

They hadn't come more than a few steps until a bot staggered out of the gloom on crab-like legs. It froze as it saw them, and with a buzz of servos moving, it focused its camera lenses on them.

Without hesitation one of the ladies in waiting stepped up in front of it.

"For Queen Glimmer," she said, calmly staring at the weapons that were aimed at her.

The other ladies in waiting quickly fanned out. One of them had managed to find a metal pipe and quickly smashed a sensor, causing the bot to spin her way. That left its back exposed and soon it was dismantled.

"It almost got you," Jack said with low voice to the lady in waiting who had offered herself up as a distraction.

"But it didn't," she calmly answered.

She picked up a leg from the destroyed bot and swung it in her hand a few times, adjusting her grip to the weight and balance.

"Let's go," she said, and they kept walking down the corridor.

They reach the intersection without further incident and peered down the main corridor. Explosions could be heard in irregular intervals.

"Seems like Double Trouble is keeping them busy," Jack observed.

"Either that or poking the hornets' nest either more," one of the ladies-in-waiting darkly remarked. "But we have no choice. It's either this way or a longer detour."

"...which the Queen might not have time for," another finished.

They came upon a group of fallen Horde soldiers and quickly armed themselves with their gear. With blasters and stun batons they felt their confidence returning, and their earlier, nervous crawl along the corridor walls were replaced with a quick paced march. The corridor was large enough to allow vehicles to pass, and there were tracks in the floor and chains hung from the ceiling. In even intervals along the ceiling, the crystal rods they had seen earlier were placed, pulsating with a purple light.

The corridor forked, and Jack and the Horde deserter stopped to peer at the signs.

"We should go left here?" Jack asked. The lady-in-waiting grunted.

"Says so on the sign. The way I remembered it, it was right. But that was several years ago."

"So what do..." Jack begun, and then the entire corridor shook by an enormous explosion. A beam of energy, bright as the sun, sliced through the thick metal of the wall like it had been a hot knife through butter.

"LEFT!" Jack cried, and they ran like rats as debris started to fall behind them. They managed to get into the next section of corridor. They sank down to the floor, wheezing for air, their lungs full of dust and ashes, and Jack slammed the button to the fire-door. Slowly - painfully so - it started closing behind them.

"What *was* that?" One of the ladies-in-waiting asked between coughs.

"I don't... another begun, but then she abruptly stopped talking, staring at the fire door.

It was thick as an arm, made by solid metal. It was designed to keep sections of the Fright Zone completely separated in case of fire, dangerous gasses or enemy combatants. But as they looked at it, the black metal became red hot in a matter of seconds, and just as sudden it crumpled and fell to pieces.

Heavy boot-steps was heard, approaching in even pace. Jack and the ladies-in-waiting slowly withdrew down the corridor.

Through the destroyed gate stepped Hordak, ruler of the Fright Zone. His clothes were torn, his armour dented. A first one's crystal shone like a star of ancient legends on his breast. He let his gaze sweep over the corridor and stopped on the little group.

A cruel smile grazed his lips and he aimed his arm canon right at them.

- - -

I'm sorry, Glimmer thought as her last grasp of consciousness slipped away.

- - -

"For the Queen!" the Horde deserter cried, rushing towards the approaching Hordak, and was instantly shot.

Jag stared in horror at the hole, large as a dinner plate, in her chest, and only remembered to jump to the side in the very last moment, just before Hordak fired again and hit the wall, just where they had stood.

Shrapnel and molten metal flew in every direction and Jack cried out in pain and fear. The ladies in waiting ran as fast as they could

down the corridor, with Hordak stalking after them. Jack pressed against the corridor wall.

As unmoving as they could, Jack slowly produced the blaster from their pocket, and with beating heart aimed it at the back of the Lord of the Fright Zone.

Hordak didn't even glance their way. With a derisive snort he tore off a metal rack from the wall with one hand and flung it full force towards Jack. Jack barely had time to duck and scramble to the side, their blaster clanging useless to the floor.

The arm canon boomed again, and another lady-in-waiting fell to the the floor, trapped under debris from the ceiling. The one remaining tried running behind the approaching warlord. Hordak's thin smile grew more blood thirsty, and suddenly the light emitting from the crystal on his chest increased in intensity.

A continuous stream of death poured from the arm canon, a beam as bright as a furnace and as thick as his wrist sliced through the metal and stone of the walls, floor and ceiling, just as easily as the flesh and bone of the poor soul caught by it. Screams full of pain and horror echoed through the corridor before they were all too soon cut off.

Jack scrambled backwards, no other thought in their head than to get away from the carnage. They felt their feet tripping over some of the debris, and as they struggled to get up, they heard Hordak's footsteps coming closer.

With a frightened yelp they pressed against the wall. Hordak towered over them with the arm canon pointed straight at their head.

"Wa-ait!" Jack gasped, but Hordak's expression didn't change.

Jack saw the arm canon light up.

They never even saw her coming. One moment, it was just Jack and their impending doom.

The next moment Catra was there.

With a snarl of rage the Queen of the Crimson Waste slashed her claws towards Hordak's face. He barely had time to block the blow before she darted off into the shadows again. He hissed and spun around, his arm canon trailing death and destruction. Jack could only stare as Catra darted from spot to spot, landing on the walls just as often as the floor.

She lashed out with her whip and hit his arm, throwing off his aim. The beam from the arm cannon hit the wall, causing the entire corridor to shake. Jack scrambled to the side as a huge beam fell from the ceiling.

Hordak grabbed a piece of concrete, large as Jack's head, and threw it towards Catra with force enough to dent the corridor wall. Catra jumped to the side and fired a shot from her blaster which singed the wall behind Hordak. He fired his arm canon again, creating a large hole to the soldiers' sleeping quarters on the other side of the wall.

Catra lashed out with her whip, and then slipped through the hole in the wall. Hordak trailed the arm canon after her, causing another explosion as he hit something volatile on the other side. With an angry growl he stalked after her.

Jack stared, still pressed against the wall. The entire encounter, that had left the entire corridor devastated and the other ladies-in-waiting dead or trapped, had only taken a few seconds.

An ominous sound from the ceiling reminded them they had to keep moving. Jack stared wildly around and found another survivor.

"We're almost there," they gasped, hoping it was true. They managed to lift their fallen comrade who had their leg crushed by some debris, and together they hobbled out of the damaged section, just as the roof gave in and collapsed.

They hobbled the last few steps, past a couple of crushed bots, caught in one of Hordak's blast, and through a deserted guard post.

They entered the Black Garnet chamber. The ceiling was lined with purple rods, pulsating with glowing light, all mirroring the light that streamed from the garnet itself, fixtures in a cradle of cables, instrument and devises Jack could only guess at the purpose of, with cables snaking out in all directions.

In a stable cone of light, emitting from the runestone, Princess Glimmer floated, eyes closed, trapped in a prison of magic.

Chapter End Notes

I've wanted to write this side of Hordak for SO LONG!

The Ruler of the Horde

Chapter Notes

> Warning: Vicious fighting, maiming and death. Fire and crushing. Depiction of depression, self destruction and destruction in general. Mentions of suicide... Let's just say that neither Catra nor Hordak are in a good place right now and they make it absolutely everyone's problem.
>
> Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Tell me, Catra, what did you hope to gain by coming here?"

Hordak walked in even pace along the corridor, making no haste as he followed his former second in command.

"To kill you," Catra snarled back from her temporary hiding place behind a corner.

Almost leisurely Hordak evaporated a large section of the wall.

"Given that you could, what would that achieve?" he asked.

"It would make you dead," Catra quipped back as she scrambled along the ceiling.

"More formidable opponents than you have tried and failed," Hordak noted as he trailed his arm canon after her. "Their bleached bones adorn the shore of Beast Island."

"Too chicken to off them yourself, were you?" Catra taunted.

She jumped from the ceiling, avoiding the beam from the arm canon, and managed to land a kick at his thigh before she scampered off in the shadows again.

Hordak winced with pain but kept going.

"We both know this is not about me," he went on in the same, cold voice. "It's about the throne."

"You'd have us believe there is no difference between you and your throne," Catra shot back, aiming her blaster.

"There isn't," Hordak said, smoothly stepping to the side so Catra's shot missed.

"The hell there isn't," she snarled in replay, aiming another shot. "I ran the Horde for more than a year with you sulking in your lab. All you were was a figurehead."

"All you were was an administrator with delusions of grandeur," Hordak replied, one-handed throwing a dislodged piece of metal towards Catra, forcing her back.

"The Horde is just another gang," Catra snarled. "You call the shots because you have the biggest canon. That changes today."

"And that short-sighted belief is why you'll never be able to rule," Hordak shot back. The beam from his arm canon scorched the corridor. "The Horde is will made manifest. *My* will. A single, broken clone in a single, broken ship with nothing but a bunch of barbarians and paltry parlour tricks who created something truly grand."

"Oh yeah?" Catra said with deceptively soft voice. "And what about Horde Prime?"

Hordak stopped in his tracks.

"*What* did you say?"

"You heard me," Catra hissed. "This was all to get on big brother's good side, wasn't it? You wanted it to be perfect when he showed up to award marks. Well, where is he? Do you think *he* will look at this crumbling heap and see something 'truly grand'?"

"You dare?" Hordak whispered. "You insignificant creature dare invoke the name of Horde Prime?"

"Why not?" Catra taunted. "Why shouldn't we talk about the glorious leader of the Horde. The *real* leader of the Horde."

She was silent for a few moments as she crept to a new hiding place.

"That's why you didn't tell us, wasn't it?" she said. "You didn't want us to know about Horde Prime because that would have told us that you were nothing special. You were not a leader of the Horde, just the local branch."

She chuckled.

"And still you made yourself a throne and had us praise you. 'Oh, the big Hordak, leader of the Horde'. Now who's having delusions of grandeur?"

"Be silent!" Hordak bellowed.

"That touched a nerve, didn't it," Catra leered. "You don't want Big Brother to see what you have done, because you know he won't approve. Hah, and you tell me the Horde isn't a gang. Looks like you pissed off the *real* big man by pretending to fit his shoes."

"SILENCE!" Hordak snarled, and his arm canon spewed death in all directions. Catra barely had time to flee into the vents, leaving only a taunting laughter behind.

She emerged in the next room and quickly looked around. Old storage facility that she had some fond memories of. Good place for a nap. Only someone should have fixed...

She grinned.

"You went to a lot of trouble to come find me," Hordak gruffed as he without effort broke down the door. "I would have thought that you..."

He stopped in his track, taking in the room. The floor was covered in dirty water from a busted pipe.

"Someone *really* should have fixed these cables ages ago," Catra said from the ceiling.

A slash with her claws, and a large chunk of cables that had been inadequately held up by one rusting rivet fell down into the water.

"...it's just an accident waiting to happen," Catra finished as she fired at the cables with her blaster, severing them and electrifying the water.

With a derisive snort, Hordak fired a beam from his arm canon, which severed the cable in the ceiling in both sides of the room. This also had the side effect of cutting loose the scaffold Catra clung to. With an angry yelp she fell into the water, next to the now inert cable.

"You would know all about accident, wouldn't you, Catra?" he said with calm voice as the beam from his arm canon boiled the water as it trailed closer to her.

Catra managed to get up from the floor in the last second and scrambled out of the door, too out of breath for a comeback. Chuckling without humour, Hordak followed her.

He caught up with her in the corridor and fired a few almost lazy shots from his arm canon. She gave him a suspicious look.

"You're not even trying," she accused.

"Why? Do you have other engagements?" he drawled, steadily walking closer.

"Nah, I cleared my calender for you, big boy," Catra muttered and hastily retreated further down the corridor.

She took the corner in exactly the right speed, jumped to grab the lamp fixture, swung to the ceiling and landed on a small ledge

that permitted her entry to the crawlspace that brought her past a locked door to the next corridor.

Hordak's stomping feet followed her.

Heh, she could have done this in her sleep. Running through the corridors of the Fright Zone, under hot pursuit by some old bore.

There would be a guard post in the upcoming crossing she knew. Back in the old days, it would most likely only be whoever had annoyed ol' Grizzlor enough to get the night shift, but today it was prudent to assume there would be armed guards there.

Catra grinned.

Good thing she knew a trick or two.

She slid to a halt, looked up and down the corridor and slipped through a little hatch that led to a long broken conveyor belt to the kitchen. Great way to steal a snack, great way to avoid a patrol. She emerged at another hatch, quickly slipped on in the corridor and...

"THERE SHE IS!"

...and remembered why she always had Adora stand guard in this corridor.

Dodging blasters as she ran down the corridor, Catra felt her mood sour. Trips down memory lane really never were worth it, she reflected. Not if all they did was to remind her what she had lost.

How she, every time she thought someone had her back, had been horribly wrong.

Not this time, though.

Glimmer had her back, she was sure of it.

Even if she sure took her sweet time.

- - -

"We need to get her out of there *now*," Jack whispered, voice full of fear, staring at the unconscious princess, trapped in the light of the Black Garnet.

"She told us how to prepare the ritual that would help her connect to the runestone," the surviving lady-in-waiting said with week voice, sitting propped against the wall and trying with little success to cut open her pants to access her wounded legs. "I have no idea how... shit."

Jack gave her a desperate look as the lady-in-waiting gritted her teeth at the freshly exposed, copiously bleeding wound.

"Here," Jack said, fumbling with the first aid kit they had stolen from an unconscious horde soldier. I'll...

"*You* will save our queen," the lady in waiting said sharply and grabbed the kit from Jack.

- - -

"Don't run, Catra," Hordak rumbled. "You came all this way to see me. Surely there are things we have to talk about."

Catra didn't bother with a comeback. She kept her pace in front of him in the corridor. He fired a shot now and then, but saved the charge until it was needed. They were getting closer to the workshops, he knew. Perhaps she would make her stand there.

He knew Catra well enough that she wouldn't have come here without something in her sleeve.

He also knew her well enough to predict what that something would have been.

He grinned and fired another blast.

Today he felt alive in a way he had not felt for a long time. He supposed he should thank Catra. After all, he could never have taken this step without her 'help'.

"I do have to congratulate you, Catra," he said with even voice. "Your consolidation of the thugs and bandits of the Crimson Waste were not entirely incompetent work.

"You're making me blush," she snarked from the shadows.

"Sadly you lack the endurance to solidify your position," he went on. "Just a brightly burning flame, soon spent. Unless you can find new fuel to sustain it."

"I'm here, aren't I?" Catra shot back.

"Yes, you are here." Hordak repeated. He carefully scanned the large foundry he had entered. The echo made it hard to pinpoint Catra's location. "You are here because that's the corner you have backed yourself in. You have the keep providing victories in an accelerating rate or your power base will crumble like a house of cards."

"Speaking from experience, I hear," Catra taunted. She was somewhere in the ceiling...

"What I built has lasted for generations" he calmly said. "What you built will last no longer than a drop of dew in the desert."

"Wow, a warlord *and* a poet," Catra taunted from somewhere among the many scaffolds. "One has to wonder how this place turned out as shitty as it did."

"Incompetent underlings, mostly," Hordak calmly answered and fired a shot towards the ceiling.

"Yeah, because you were doing *so* hot without me," Catra said, more of an edge to her voice.

"Whatever you might have been led to believe, burning through resources in a mad rush to take territory is not exactly the the act of a tactical genius," Hordak replied with dry voice. "Your reliance on the true talent and strength of those willing to humour you have left you with an inflated sense of your own worth."

"Shut up," Catra snarled.

Hordak smirked.

"Adora... Scorpia... Shadow Weaver... Even Entrapta, and just look how you paid her back. Now it's that failed princess of yours. One has to wonder how long she will put up with you, Catra."

"*SHUT UP*," Catra hissed.

"You do realize it's only a matter of time, right?" Hordak went on with the same conversational tone.

"You were happy enough with my performance when I brought you Salineas," Catra snarled.

There...

He fired his arm canon full force at the spot where he had seen Catra move. He missed with a hair's width, and he trailed the beam after her until she managed to loose him among the many chains, drums and rails that hung from he ceiling.

"I don't deny you had your use," he said, as if the outburst hadn't happen. "But you outlived that usefulness the day you assumed to be my equal."

"Oh?" Catra said from her new hiding spot. "Is that how it went between you and Horde Prime?"

"Silence!" he snarled and fired several shots, that did nothing to stop her taunting laughter.

"No, I guess it wasn't," she leered. "You were never 'too good' or whatever. You never threatened him. You were just a failure.

"SILENCE!" he bellowed.

"Hit a nerve?" Catra taunted him. She was perched on a crane over the foundry. "It should. After all, you are a nothing by a defect, a mistake. It's OK. I'll take out Horde Prime's trash for him, like he should have done himself a long time ago."

With a snarl of fury, Hordak unleashed the arm canon with full force. Catra only got away in the last second. The thick support for the crane was cut through, which left it hanging with just a tiny chain holding it.

Before Hordak had time to get his bearing she came for him. A blow to his jaw, and then a powerful kick shattered his arm canon.

Pain trailed along his arm, it felt like she had broken internal bones as well as external.

Hordak forced his teeth shut. He had once again underestimated just how strong the infernal cat was.

He brought up his other arm in defence, but Catra had already landed on the floor, ducked and gave him a vicious kick.

Hordak stumbled forward, wincing in pain as he was forced to support himself with his broken arm.

"Now we can finally end this, like we should have done a long time ago" Catra snarled. "I didn't need Entrapta. I didn't need Scorpia or Adora. I most certainly didn't need Shadow Weaver. I don't need Glimmer to finish this, and I don't need *you*!"

Catra leapt at him, claws first.

It would probably have been the end of him, had he not anticipated it.

Quickly scrambling backwards, Hordak brought up a hand, protecting the first one's crystal in his breast. He managed to deflect Catra's blow by an inch, leaving her open to his counter blow as he brought up his broken arm canon and bludgeoned her with it.

He managed to get to his feet as Catra was still laying stunned on the ground.

"You were right about one thing, Catra," Hordak panted. "Horde Prime does not care about a *defect* like me. Nor will he care about you, your precious princess or anyone else in your pathetic world."

Catra looked up at him, the rage in her eyes tinted with fear.

"What?" she asked.

Instead of answering, Hordak just smiled at her, as the heavy crane crashed down between them.

- - -

"I think I can access the main interface," Jack reported from the terminal. "But I have no idea of what I'm supposed to..."

"Cut the power?" the lady-in-waiting suggested. She sat with half-closed eyes, breathing heavily. She had managed to dress the wound, at least stopping the blood flow, but she had lost a lot of blood.

"It generates its own power," Jack protested.

"Then what does the cables feed it?" The lady-in-waiting asked, struggling to stay awake.

"Data, as far as I can tell," Jack said, staring at the screen, and then slowly moving their gaze to the thick cables that connected the cables to the glowing runestone. "It feeds commands to the stone, just like we tried to do with a magical circle... only much faster."

They blinked as slowly an idea took form.

"So that means... each command takes the form of a micro enchantment... There is no way Hordak could sustain a complex magical construct through a computer interface. These commands are all repeating. If we can just figure out the feed process we could disconnect the right cables, and then..."

Jack glanced at the lady-in-waiting, hoping for feedback. But her eyes were closed and she didn't answer.

- - -

Catra darted between shadows with Hordak following her. She had slowed him down, she had broken his arm canon, but that burning will and a common blaster made him deadly enough.

Her thoughts were churning.

She thought she knew all Hordak's moods by now. The rage. The iron clad integrity. The endless, burning passion that kept him on course year after year. But also the fear, the self loathing. The hope for validation from big brother from the other side the empty night sky.

She even knew those sides he desperately hoped would stay hidden. The tentative comradery the two of them had shared as they took over the world. The yearning for such simple things as the touch of another being, or the comfort of a shared smile. She knew about him and Entrapta.

But she didn't recognize his mood today.

Hordak was burning not only with fury, but with... glee? With a cruel humour. He was fighting not only for revenge or for the sake of his grand goal or to avenge his hurt pride but out of enjoyment, out of sadistic pleasure.

He had waited for her.

Because he wanted an audience.

Catra turned a corner and fired a shot with her blaster. It missed, but she got another good look at his face.

Cruel, triumphant, spiteful. Almost like...

...Oh no!

Catra felt like a bucket of cold water had been thrown over her.

Almost like herself.

- - -

Jack stared at the terminal, their heart sinking in their chest. They had spent some time around mechanics. They knew their way around the standard layout of the Horde interface - dumbed down enough for every soldier to understand it in the field if need be.

But this... this was something else. Commands and subcommands nested. The data infrastructure was layered in more directions than Jack could readily fathom. and all the time, more information popped up on the screen.

This was work for the guild makers, for the wise people from Mystacor, for the princesses. Not for a bandit kid from the Crimson Waste.

But there was no one else here to do the job.

- - -

"Hordak," Catra shouted around the corner, suddenly full of misgivings, "what *is* the deal with Horde Prime."

"Whatever do you mean, Catra?" he said with deceptively calm voice.

"You know what I mean," she said, slowly backing away, scanning the corridor for the next hideout. "We were pushing like mad to

finish the takeover before he arrived. He just didn't show, or what?"

"Oh, he will be here, don't you worry," Hordak said with the same calm tone of voice, perhaps with a bit of an edge to it. He rounded the corner and quickly looked up and down the corridor. He fired a shot towards the ledge where Catra was perching and she quickly withdrew.

"But you don't think he'll be happy with what he sees, is that it?" she persisted.

"I think what I'm about to show him will make him reconsider," Hordak snarled.

Catra did a little gesture taking in the crumbling architecture around them. She raised an eyebrow.

"You think of Horde Prime like a larger version of me," Hordak snorted. "You think of the Horde as a gang and Horde Prime as a thug. A misconception I have to admit guilt in fuelling. For simplicity and for my vanity's sake. But I can assure you he is *nothing* like me."

"Then what *is* he like?" Catra asked, creeping along a beam.

"Horde Prime is what you primitives would describe as 'God'," Hordak calmly said. "And this place, this... Despondos... was a place where God could not reach. Not until *I* showed him the way."

"That... that was the plan, wasn't it?" Catra whispered.

"A limited plan sat in motion by a defect clone with no imagination, no sense of priority and not enough courage to see what was in front of him."

"And what was in front of him?" Catra asked, dreading the answer.

"That *imperfect* as this world was," Hordak shouted, his fury boiling to the surface again, "it was *beautiful*."

Catra fled as his blaster - apparently modified beyond the capability of a standard issue weapon - melted the metal all around her.

She didn't realize where her latest turn had taken her until she saw the broken vats around her.

They were back in the sanctum.

- - -

"Come on," Jack muttered to themselves, furiously typing at the terminal, adapting what little they knew about the interface from Horde war machines into what Glimmer had told them of how magic worked. They had managed to identify the outgoing connections. Now all they had to do was to...

They flinched as a nearby explosion caused the room to shake.

"I... I never really told you," Jack whispered, glancing at the unconscious princess, floating in her prison of light, "but in case we don't make it, I just wanted you to know it... meant a lot for me, you and Catra taking a chance on a Crimson Waste nobody like me." They stared at the screen in frustration as another error message popped up.

"I just hope I won't disappoint you," they added and tried another command.

Suddenly the sound of metal scraping against metal was heard as a small panel opened. Jack spun around, quickly aiming their blaster at the newcomer, a blonde, short man wearing horde uniform.

"Stand back or I'll..." they gasped but the man quickly held up his hands in a pacifying gesture.

"Sssssh," he said and nodded at Glimmer. "I'll help you get her out."

Jack gave him a suspicious look.

"Oh yeah? Just who are you?"

"I'm Kyle," he said and - glancing at Jack to make sure they wouldn't stop him - opened up his own terminal, and with used fingers started to type commands. "Catra gave a finger to save me last time we met. This is the least I can do to repay her."

- - -

"OK, so no longer so eager for big brother to show up, I see," Catra said, quickly glancing around the room for something to use. "Welcome to the club. I'm not sure if you've heard, but most people who knows about it are not so hot on the idea of a Space Horde."

"I have been made aware," Hordak said grimly, aiming another shot.

"So, yay for you having a change of heart!" Catra exclaimed. "Call off the whole thing."

"The portal has opened," Hordak snarled. "The signal got out. Horde Prime knows where to find us. He's coming."

"Bummer," Catra said, firing her own blaster and then scrambling to hide behind a vat. "Sucks to be you, I suppose."

"I do not need your pity," Hordak said coldly, dodging Catra's shot with the barest of movements of his head. "I did not need your support and I do not need your sympathy. You think we are equals, but we are nothing of the sort. I was made in the image of *God* and you are nothing but an *insect*."

"Well, why do you spend your precious time ripping wings of flies?" Catra snarled back. "Do you think *that* will win Horde Prime

over when he finally asses his way here?"

She took in Hordak's expression.

"You don't think you will win him over?"

"I have harboured under that delusion for too long," Hordak said with heavy voice. "You have helped me see how truly naive that mindset was."

"Me...?" Catra asked.

"Me winning the favour of Horde Prime by this pathetic cargo cult" - he gestured at the broken vats around him- "is no more likely than you winning my favour with your clumsy coup attempt. Horde Prime will come. He will look upon my work and he will see me as the *failure* I am."

"What? Because Shadow Weaver snatched Brightmoon before you?" Catra asked. "You can take her. Kinda surprised you haven't already."

"NO!" Hordak shouted. "I'm not a failure because I have yet to bring my emulation of Horde Prime's empire on this pitiful planet to it's fullness."

He met Catra's eyes.

"I'm a failure because I *made the attempt to begin with.*"

She recoiled from the venom in his voice.

"My entire existence I thought that Horde Prime was the highest goal in the universe. *She* showed me that I was wrong."

Catra suddenly felt a very quickly sinking feeling in her stomach.

"Entrapta?" she asked.

"Yes," Hordak answered, a terrible calm in his voice. "And you took her from me."

"Yeah," Catra said with low voice. "I did."

They looked at each other in silence for a moment, both holding their blasters not exactly pointed at the others, but so they very quickly could be brought up.

"Why?" he said with low voice.

Catra arched an eyebrow.

"...you're kidding me?"

"You have deprived me of the one meaning this life holds," he said without changing his tone of voice. "Could you please humour me to let me know what purpose was served by my misfortune."

It took Catra a moment to get control over her breathing before she could answer.

"You of all people don't get to ask me that."

"Oh?" he said? "And why is that."

"Because you fucking *know* the answer," she snarled, voice suddenly filled with venom. "You and this pile of shit you have built has *told* me the answer my entire life."

"Indulge me," he said, showing no reaction to her vitriol.

"YOU TOLD ME, YOU TOLD EVERYONE STUCK IN THIS HELL-HOLE THAT WE DON'T MATTER!" Catra screamed. "PEOPLE DON'T MATTER. ALL THAT MATTER IS PURPOSE. THE HORDE'S PURPOSE. *YOUR* PURPOSE." Her eyes narrowed and she barred her teeth. "And now you're telling me that it was all a *lie*?" she hissed.

"If it's any consolidation, I was as fooled by you, even if the lie was of my own design," Hordak said, still with the same, matter-of-fact tone of voice, still with the rage lurking under the surface.

"Well, there you have it," Catra spat. "Entrapta would have stopped you from opening the portal. I stopped her. All in the name of the grand purpose of the Horde. Hey, how about a medal?"

"You never cared about the Horde," Hordak said. "You only cared about yourself and your own vicious ambition."

"What else did you give us to care about?" Catra snarled. "The 'glory of the Horde'? Don't make me laugh. You? You who gave *children* to a monster like Shadow Weaver. Horde Prime? You never even told us about him."

"I gave you everything," Hordak said with cold voice. "I gave you food and shelter and purpose and even a vicious creature like you the opportunity to find your place."

Catra opened the mouth to protest, but Hordak interrupted her.

"Everything you have you have got from me," he snarled. "Everything you have, I can take away from you."

He pushed a button

A screen flickered to life.

Catra stared at the Black Garnet chamber. Glimmer was floating, seemingly unconscious in the light from the gem with Jack in the background working furiously by a terminal together with... Kyle?

"How..." Catra begun.

Hordak laughed

"All these princesses and sorceresses, so self assured. So certain in their absolute dominion over these *trinkets*."

He scoffed.

"I allowed Shadow Weaver to play her little games with the Black Garnet because she was useful to me. But in the end of the day, all she wrestled from it were parlour tricks. Entrapta achieved more in *a day* than Shadow Weaver did in *decades*. With reasoning. With science. With technology. And I paid closer attention than I might have led you to believe. Your princess thought she could just take over where Shadow Weaver left. I taught her otherwise."

Hordak leered.

"The Black Garnet is an instrument, that is all. A powerful instrument, yes, but ultimately just a tool to analyse and to use. *My* tool."

Catra barred her teeth, fear fighting with anger in her voice.

"You let her go at once or I'll..."

"You took my princess from me," Hordak interrupted, voice filled with cruel satisfaction. "It only seems fair that I take yours."

He pulled a lever.

- - -

Jack blinked in confusion as new commands suddenly popped up on the screen. A new program loading, the interface activating...

The right connections forming.

They had it!

"There! Take note of the ports!" Kyle shouted.

Suddenly, purple lighting surged through Glimmer's body. Her eyes snapped open and she screamed in agony.

"*Glimmer!*" Jack cried in horror and started to tear at one of the many cables connecting the Black Garnet to the surrounding

machinery.

- - -

"Stop!" Catra cried. She tensed to jump.

"I told you, Catra," Hordak said with grim satisfaction. "Everything you have, I can take. Prepare to watch your princess die."

And he pulled another lever.

Catra felt in horror how the air *changed*, remembering the suffocating atmosphere Hordak had exposed her to once before only too well. She took a quick, deep breath. She looked at Hordak with eyes full of hatred.

"Not. Her."

And having spent valuable gulps on air on those two words, Catra charged.

He was prepared for her. His blaster on her the moment she jumped.

But he was not quick enough.

Catra jumped from a vat, over a work bench and fired a volley from her blaster, absolute murder in her expression. She landed on the other side and lashed out with her whip. Snagging Hordak's damaged arm, she caused him to stumble, away from the controls he fiddled with.

On the screen, Glimmer trashed around in agony in the purple light. Catra could see Jack fumble with cables, ignoring the tendrils of purple that snaked towards them.

Catra slid along the floor, catching Hordak with a kick, and than a vicious swipe with her claws over his face. But his fist caught her, strong as a piston, and she flew across the room, dropping her blaster as she did. Her lungs were burning, and despite her best

effort, she couldn't help to draw a shallow breath. She forced her mouth shut as the toxic atmosphere entered her lungs. Her entire body screamed for oxygen. She knew she only had moments left.

Glimmer kept screaming.

With painful movements, Hordak stood up. He turned to Catra with a scowl.

"A pitiful..." he began, then he fell to the floor with Catra's foot in his chest. She lashed out with her whip again, managing to snag the lever that controlled the Black Garnet. With her vision turning black, Catra tugged for all she was worth and managed to pull the lever towards her, breaking it as she did.

On the screen, the lighting stopped and Glimmer fell down to the bottom of the force field with a little whimper. Jack scrambled to their feet and resumed furiously tugging at the cables together with Kyle.

Catra sank down to the floor, unable to hold her breath any longer she inhaled the toxic atmosphere that surrounded her. Her lungs burned. She felt she was going to throw up.

But she still found it in her to give Hordak a little smirk.

"Not... her..." she repeated and sank down to the floor.

"A pitiful attempt..." Hordak said again, but then a third voice interrupted them.

"But Hooordak," it said. "How can Catra have killed me if I'm not dead? That's not very scientific, is it?"

Hordak and Catra both turned the head to the person speaking.

It was Entrapta.

They stared in shock at the purple-haired princess who walked towards them with bounce in her steps. She was dressed in her

usual overall, one strap hanging loose, with her long hair trailing after her.

"Entrapta?" Hordak whispered, mouth open, clearly not believing his eyes.

"There is so much I have to tell you!" the princess said happily.

She stood up on her toes on pecked Hordak on the cheek, then she seemingly for the first time noticed the control panel in front of him, one of the levers still snared in Catra's whip.

"Now, thiiiis is a sturdy lever," she breathed, and - bending forward so her loose overall just 'happened' to display quite a bit of breasts - she put a hand on the lever. With a very suggestive little motion indeed she pulled it, and Catra realized she could breath again.

She threw up as her body fought to get the toxic air out, fighting for valuable gulps of oxygen.

"Entrapta..." Hordak whispered, eyes large and wet.

Forcing herself to stop vomiting, Catra managed to unsteadily get to her feet. With fumbling fingers she withdrew a knife from her ankle sheet.

"Hordak!" Entrapta piped and affectionately stroked his cheek. She gave Catra a quick look.

Hordak stared at her in wonder, a terrible longing in his eyes.

Catra stood crouched behind him, knife in hand.

She hesitated.

Her eyes were large.

Hordak's stare gradually became darker. 'Entrapta' gave Catra a quick, desperate look.

"You are not her," Hordak said, voice flat.

"DO IT, KITTEN!" Double Trouble cried and jumped free from Hordak's lap.

"YOU'RE NOT HER!" Hordak roared, and at the same time as Catra struck, he slammed a fist on the First One's crystal in his chest. Lighting shot out. Catra dropped her knife and quickly jumped to the side, feeling the sting of electricity against her skin.

Hordak grabbed a heavy chair and tossed it after Double Trouble who scampered away, now in their own guise.

"You picked the *worst* time to develop a consciousness, Kitten," Double Trouble complained.

"Shut up, I got it," Catra muttered between heavy breaths and ducked another piece of debris, thrown by the enraged Hordak.

She looked Double Trouble in the eyes.

"Thanks," she said with reluctant voice. "You saved me."

"Don't you worry, my queen," they smirked. "Impromptu princess impersonation comes with a hefty price. I'll be sure to add that to my bill."

"You do that," Catra said, gratitude still in her voice. They ducked under a low table and ran together towards the other end in the room. Hordak had got his hands on the blaster and spewed death after them.

"You need to get to Glimmer," Catra said urgently. "Get her out of that thing, and then..."

"Jack's there," Double Trouble interrupted. "They'll figure it out. My efforts are better spent keeping Hordak away from that control panel."

"It will be dangerous," Catra warned as they took temporary shelter behind a large pillar. "Your cover is blown."

"Hah, I'm not out of tricks yet," Double Trouble drawled, and with a wink they took Catra's own guise, complete with recent damages.

Catra chuckled.

"Not bad."

"Glad to keep you on your toes, Kitten," Double Trouble drawled. "Now let's do this."

And together they charged out form their hiding place, running from obstacle to obstacle and circling Hordak from two different sides.

"You mock me with my loss," Hordak growled and eyed the approaching Catras with narrow eyes. "You mock me with my grief." He fired the blaster towards the ceiling, causing a rain of molten metal and debris to fall down all around them. "It matters not. *You* matter not. This whole insignificant *world* matters not."

Catra dodged pieces of metal falling all around her. She caught Double Trouble's eyes and held up three fingers. The changeling nodded, and then both of them ducked behind lab benches, quickly moving towards the still firing Hordak.

Slowly counting to three under her breath, Catra carefully sneaked closer. She took a deep breath, and with a cry she jumped up from her hiding place. She bounced off a pillar, swung in a fixture in the roof - she felt it coming loose under her grip - and then she dove straight for Hordak, claws out. From the opposite side of the warlord, she saw Double Trouble mimic her acrobatics.

She had to hand it to the imposter - they were good.

Hordak snorted dismissively and grabbed a metal object from a pocket. Just as the two Catras reached him, he threw it to the

ground. Blue flames immediately erupted, burning with an intensity far beyond normal fire.

Catra made a quick side step and jumped to the side while Double Trouble yelped and fell back. Catra had to take a moment to get her balance and scan the room. The fire spread like... well, wild-fire and from the inferno, Hordak calmly walked. With one hand he grabbed the still dazed Double Trouble by the throat and tossed them into the wall. They slumped down unconscious to the floor and retook their own guise.

"Double Trouble!" Catra cried. She took a step towards her fallen comrade, but a shot from the blaster forced her away.

"Do not mourn them," Hordak said loftily. "You will join them soon enough."

Without sparing the shape-shifter another glance, flesh blistering, his armour red hot, Hordak kept walking with steady pace, right towards Catra. She barely had time to duck to the side as he tore a lab bench from its attachments to the floor and with both hands threw it at her.

She scampered to the side just as another heavy piece of equipment crashed into a pillar, right in front of her. It folded, and with a groan the heavy metal beam it had supported started to give way above her.

Catra jumped up the pillar, over the head of the still approaching Hordak and landed on a bench where the fire had yet not reached.

"Listen..." she cried as she prepared her next jump. "I'm sorry, OK? About Entrapta. That was shitty of me. The rest... not so much."

And she jumped to the damaged ceiling. She scrambled atop the folding beam and jumped, as hard as she could up and down.

The ceiling crashed down over Hordak. Catra jumped free in the last second, landing a good twenty steps away. The beam had torn down several other sections of the ceiling. Debris was everywhere, and the remaining pillars and beams seemed dangerously unstable. The fire was still spreading.

Catra ducked, preparing for another attack, but nothing came.

Carefully she peaked up.

Hordak was trapped under the pillar, his arm - the one that used to host the arm canon - was crushed under it. Catra winched as she imagined the state it would be in. Hordak tugged at it a few times, then he relaxed and sought Catra's eyes.

"If it's absolution you are after, you will not get it from me," he rumbled.

Catra fiddled a bit uncertain with her claws. The fire was still everywhere and the smoke was getting in her eyes. She blinked away tears.

"It's over," she said with pleading voice. "Just give up."

"I do not share your tactical analysis, *ex-force-commander*, Hordak said with derisive voice." He stared at his stuck arm for a moment. And then, with grim determination, turned his blasters towards his elbow.

"NO!" Catra cried, but Hordak had already sliced off his limb with one, neat cut, cauterizing the wound with the heat from the blaster.

With a grimace of pain he stood up and turned his blaster towards the staring Catra.

"I was most impressed by how you evaded the patrols sent after you," he grumbled. "Sacrificing part of the whole for victory takes resolve. But here, as in all aspects, you are second to me, Catra."

He fired.

Head swimming, Catra ducked to the side, only saving herself by the fraction of a second. The fur on her head singed. She felt nauseous. She could *smell* the burnt flesh of Hordak's arm, remaining trapped under the pillar where the fire was completing the work the blaster started.

She crawled along the floor, away. Just... away. Hordak kept walking towards her, seemingly unstoppable, but he was unsteady. The smoke or the loss of the arm affecting even him. He fired a few shot after her, but without much of an aim.

"You told me once that when I sent you to the Crimson Waste, you had nothing left to loose." Hordak said in conversional tone. "Please let me assure you nothing could have been further from the truth." He fired another shot, Catra kept scrambling backwards. "You felt you suffered under Shadow Weaver. Let me assure you, the care she offered you was an unheard luxury compared to what I had to endure under Horde Prime."

He fired his blaster again, a continuous beam, melting the metal debris all around Catra. She felt her fur singe away as droplets hit her. She screamed and scampered to the side.

"When I first came to this world," Hordak went on in conversational tone, "I had no name, no knowledge of the taste of food, no word for companionship and not even a sense of how profoundly these things had been denied me."

"Sucks to be you," Catra panted.

"Do not pity me," Hordak growled. "You will all get to share my fate, once Horde Prime gets here."

"You have *lost*," Catra panted. She slipped under a table, darted between piles of debris and emerged just by Hordak's side. She made a quick swipe towards his face and darted away again.

"How long do you think you can keep this up?" she asked as she fled his fire. "Not nearly long enough, let me tell you. I can evade you for as long as it takes. Glimmer will be free at any moment. Just *give up*."

"I will not," he said between gritted teeth, wiping the blood from his face and taking aim again. Catra darted out from the smoke and gave his leg a kick, forcing him down on his knees.

"It's *over*," she repeated, tears in her eyes. "*Please*."

"Then finish me, if you have it in you," he growled as he laboriously got on his feet again.

"Hordak!" Catra cried. "I don't want to kill you."

"How generous," Hordak drawled. "Sadly you have no alternative."

"No, seriously," Catra persisted. "You've lost and you know it. I can't keep you around, but I *can* give you an out."

"Really?" Hordak snorted. "And what kind of 'out' would that be."

"Beast Island," Catra said, voice urgent. "I know, I know," she quickly followed up as she saw Hordak hesitate, "it's a slim hope. But if she's alive she's there, and you'll have a chance to find her."

"Why would you do such a thing?" Hordak asked, voice heavy with suspicion.

"Because..." Catra faltered for words. "Because I know... what it's like, to have someone like her."

Hordak watched her in silence for a moment.

He nodded.

"You do, don't you," he said with low voice. "And this is... what? You trying to live happy ever after?"

"This is my bid for power," Catra snarled. "My bid for me and Glimmer to *have* an 'ever after' to be have a chance to be happy in."

That actually made Hordak chuckle, despite everything.

"Not dishearten by my example, are you?"

"I know it's shitty," Catra said with pleading voice, "but it's all I can offer you. Please, take your chances on Beast Island. I don't want to kill you."

They looked at each other through the smoke.

"You should have stayed in the desert, Catra," Hordak said eventually, voice almost gentle. "You should have spent what time you had left with your princess. Instead you came here."

"Yes," Catra said. "I did."

"Generous as your offer is, I must decline," Hordak said again. He started to limp towards a yet undamaged area of the lab. "Because no matter what kindness you imagine you'd do me, no one returns from Beast Island."

He looked Catra in the eyes.

"Entrapta is dead - killed by your hand. My life's work is forfeit and the chance I might have had for happiness was snuffed out, by you."

He grinned, a horrible grin.

"The only thing that remains is her *legacy*. I can still complete her masterpiece."

He stepped up to a panel. A large lever in his hand.

Behind him was a metal frame holding up wires and crystals, all centred around a circular gaping hole.

Catra stared.

"That's the portal," she whispered. "You rebuilt the portal machine."

"Yes." Hordak said in grim satisfaction. "Eventually. I had to painstakingly reverse-engineer Entrapta's work, but at long last I have finished it."

"I thought it needed Adora's sword to work properly."

"The sword is the single most potent piece of first one's technology I have yet encountered," Hordak answered. "There are other, *lesser* sources of power that can be utilized as substitutes."

He lifted his hand and tore the crystal Entrapta had embedded into his armour from its fittings. He immediately sank down on his knees. But he managed to fit the crystal in a socket that was prepared for it.

"Did you solve the flaws then?" Catra asked in dread.

"There were no flaws," Hordak answered in the same deadly, triumphant voice. He smirked. "Only imperfections. Haven't you heard, Catra? Imperfections are beautiful."

"But... the portal nearly destroyed the universe," Catra said. She took a small step towards him.

"Nearly." Hordak answered, following her with his eyes. "The lack of success was not in the design, it was in the feeble execution. Without the sword, the reality sustained by the portal will be less expansive and be able to support fewer fractal iterations. The final collapse should be as impressive, though."

"Entrapta didn't want for that to happen!" Catra cried. "She tried to *stop* me from opening the portal. "*That's* why I sent her to Beast Island."

Hordak snarled at the reminder.

"And because of that, she is no longer here to prevent this fate." He moved the lever, just a few millimetres. "I hope you are proud of your handiwork, Catra. I spent my life in pursuit of an unworthy goal. I saw the mere shadow of a worthy one, and that was stolen from me. By *you*. Now, nothing remains but destruction. For me, for you and for this world. And when Horde Prime comes looking for his missing brother, he will see that I chose *oblivion* over *him*. *That* is the legacy I offer Entrapta. *Defiance* in the face of Prime."

"Catra!" Glimmer cried, poofing into existence, Jack in hand. "Are you..."

Catra hurled herself forward.

With a spiteful, triumphant, smirk, Hordak pulled the lever.

Chapter End Notes

> As I set out to write this chapter, I promised myself even larger amount of property damage than in canon. I'm not disappointed with the result.

Playing house

Chapter Notes

> Warning: Parental angst, surreal horror, existential horror, religious horror and some light body horror.
>
> Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Breakfast, Kitten!"

Catra opened her eyes and gave Glimmer a confused look. She was sleeping in their usual bunk bed. The blanket next to her was not the usual warm pile of sleepy wife, but rather a disorganized, empty mess. It was rare that Glimmer woke up before Catra, but this time she was apparently making an effort.

Glimmer plopped down by her side, dressed in her usual Horde uniform - which looked quite fetching on her, if anyone were to ask for Catra's opinion on the subject - with a tray from the canteen. Grey and blue ration bars, cut in little pieces the way Glimmer knew she liked it.

"You're up early," Catra said.

Glimmer giggled.

"No, you are the one's who up late. It's OK, I don't mind making my favourite wife breakfast in bed now and then."

She bent down and gave Catra a warm kiss on her cheek. Catra squirmed pleasantly.

"I usually don't sleep in," she mused and took a little grey piece of ration bar. She made a happy sigh as Glimmer squeezed in next to her in the bed.

"Well, I glad you got to rest," Glimmer said and gave her another kiss on the cheek. With a happy little sigh she put her head on Catra's shoulder. "You know, we are in no particular hurry to get up..." she suggested.

"Let me finish my breakfast first, Sparkles!" Catra protested, blushing slightly.

"No promises," Glimmer smirked and nibbled a bit on Catra's neck.

Not much.

Just to show that she could.

Catra grew redder and busied herself with the food.

"Who did you talk to?" she asked as Glimmer reluctantly withdrew her mouth.

"When?" Glimmer asked, placing a last little peck on Glimmer's forehead.

"Just when I woke up," Catra explained. "I heard you talk to someone."

"Must have been a dream," Glimmer said with lofty voice. "There's only me here."

"Yeah, I suppose," Catra agreed. "I dreamt a lot of things."

"Oh?" Glimmer asked, slipping a hand under the blanket with a mischievous smile. "Was I in it?"

"I... I think so," Catra said, blinking a few times. The dream had been so clear in her mind just a moment ago, but no when she talked about it, it was like catching mist.

"We were.... fighting, I think? Not with each other," she quickly clarified. "We were... attacking someone?"

"About time, too," Glimmer grumbled. "As far as I'm concerned, we've played defence for too long."

"I know, I know," Catra said, not really feeling up to the the next round in the same old row. "But you know what Father..."

"Yeah, yeah, I know," Glimmer said dismissively. "What else happened in your dream?"

"Someone was... looking for me, I think?" Catra said uncertainly. "At least... someone was calling my name."

"Oh, there you go then," Glimmer said with care-free voice. "That's why you remembered me talking to someone, when all I wanted was for my perfect wife to wake up so I could give her breakfast."

"Wife..." Catra said dreamingly.

Glimmer laughed.

"Don't you go soft on me, Kitten. We've been married for a long time, you know."

"Yeah..." Catra said with a frown. "I suppose we have."

"Don't tell me you forgot it, silly?" Glimmer laughed and playfully slapped Catra on the arm.

"I'd forget my own name before I ever forgot you," Catra said, voice full of warmth.

To her great delight, she saw little blush light up Glimmer's cheeks.

"Come now, 'wife'," she said, finishing the last piece of the blue bar (and pushing a grey piece to Glimmer's side of the plate). "Let's visit Father before we gets any later."

"Fiiiine," Glimmer said and plopped the grey piece in her mouth. She waited until Catra was halfway up from the bed before she dragged her down again. "...*after* I get another kiss."

Catra happily obliged.

"You go ahead," Catra said after they finally emerged. "I'll just put on my uniform."

"I like you juuuuust as much without it," Glimmer smirked, causing Catra to blush again. With a happy laughter she jumped out of reach for Catra's playful swipe, and then she skipped away towards the other end of the room, where the large throne stood.

Catra smiled after her and put on her uniform. She nodded at their friend who was also getting ready and she was just about to go when...

"Catra!"

Catra looked around. Their friend didn't seem to have said anything, and no one else was nearby. Perhaps she...

"Catra?"

She head the voice again. It was close. It sounded eager. Enthusiastic.

"Yes?" she ventured.

"Catra," a different voice said. Cold. Malevolent.

Just behind her.

Catra spun around. Behind her stood a tall figure, hidden in black cloth and shadows. Catra felt the cold gaze on her.

"Ever the disappointment," the figure said with even voice from behind a veil.

"Mother!" Catra hissed. "I told you to get away from me."

"And I did," the figure said. "But clearly I am still needed."

"And just what's that supposed to mean?" Catra spat, hands in her sides.

"You don't know?" the figure said, clearly amused. "You don't know where you are."

"I'm Home," Catra snarled. "I'm Safe. I'm with Glimmer. That's all I need to know."

She turned her back to the figure and with purposeful strides walked over to the throne in the other end of the room.

She heard scuffling just above her, in the ceiling, but when she glanced up there was nothing there.

They assembled by the throne, Glimmer, Catra and their friend. Hordak sat on top of it, glaring at them with stern but loving eyes, petting Imp who sat in his knees.

"Daughter," he greeted Catra.

"Father." She nodded her head. "Am I worthy of praise?"

"You are, Daughter," he answered. "Am I worthy of love?"

"You are, Father."

"Love! Love!" Imp echoed.

Catra took a deep breath.

"Mother made me uncomfortable, Father."

"Mother is not welcome here, Daughter," Hordak said. "You have made sure of that."

"No one messes with my cat," Glimmer growled, holding Catra tighter.

Friend nodded eagerly.

"Guys...." Catra said, slightly embarrassed.

Friend, a bit shy, pulled her sleeve.

"You are a good friend," they whispered, and Catra gave Friend at thankful smile.

"Give me the report, Force Captains," Hordak interrupted.

Glimmer took a step forward.

"We are down to ten beds, which is fine because there are only four of us. The vortex has consumed most of the eastern corridor and will probably reach the door in a day or two."

"What about the sounds?" Catra interrupted.

"What sounds?" Hordak asked.

"You know, from the wall?" Catra said. "The scrapes? The thuds?"

"There is nothing moving in the wall," Glimmer quickly said.

"But..." Catra's ear perked up. "There it is? Can't you hear it?"

From the wall behind the throne, something could quite clearly be heard scuffle about.

Hordak frowned.

"It's time for sparring!" Glimmer brightly said.

She tapped Friend's shoulder and summoned her staff. Friend eagerly brought forth a staff her their own, and soon Glimmer and Friend moved back and forth, staffs clacking at each other.

Catra frowned and stepped up to the wall. It vibrated slightly as she touched it.

"What do you hope to find?" Hordak said from just behind her.

Catra jumped slightly. She had not heard him leave his throne.

"I... I don't know," she confessed.

Hordak put a hand on her shoulder. Catra flinched slightly, but then she looked up at him with large eyes.

"Remember, Catra," he rumbled. "God is searching for us. God will find us. But we will not let God take us alive."

"We will not let God take us alive," Catra repeated with sing-song-voice, the way you do with childhood prayers.

"Very good, Catra," Hordak said.

For a moment they listened to the shuffling from the wall, then he steered her back to the throne. Catra helped him ascend it, his damaged joints giving him trouble, and with a little grunt he sat down again.

Catra gave him a worried look.

"You are unwell, Father."

"I will remain functional until the great deed is finished," he hissed, doing his best to mask the pain.

"Functional is not the same as well, Father," Catra protested. She hesitated for a moment, and then took his hands.

"If we could only find your heart..."

"Don't start that old argument again," Hordak muttered, glancing at the necrotic tissue that surrounded the hole in his chest. "That old thing only held me back. I'm better off without it."

He gave Catra a fatherly smile.

"Your concern gives me comfort, Daughter. But it is misguided. I will prevail."

Catra shook her head slightly, but she descended the throne, leaving the old man to his rest.

Glimmer stood by the door, talking with low, earnest voice to someone outside. Catra walked up to her.

"Hello princess," she smirked. "Who are you talking to?"

"Hi Catra," Glimmer said with a bright smile. "I'm talking to our child, of course."

With a quick motion, she leaned outside the room and dragged Child into view. Catra smiled at them.

"What's the little rascal up to now?" she asked and bent down in front of the frowning Child.

"Just some fun adventures," Glimmer assured her and ruffled Child's hair. "The high spirit of youth and all that."

"Are they safe?" Catra asked in slight trepidation.

"Of course they are," Glimmer laughed. She took Catra's hand. "Nothing will ever hurt them. They will never be abused or unloved or go hungry because food or love or care is denied them."

"I'm hungry," Child interrupted.

"Then let's get you something to eat, you little rascal," Glimmer laughed and pulled Child with her to the mess hall (in another corner of the room, next to the throne), where Friend had prepared ration bars. "You will have as many grey ration bars as you want."

Catra looked after them with a smile. Then, quickly checking so no one was watching her, she risked a quick peak outside the door.

The vortex twirled and swirled, the way it always did. It had consumed most of the corridor by now, and it was steadily coming closer.

"Catra!"

Catra quickly spun around. The voice had come from just behind her, but no one was there.

"Yes!?" she snarled. "If you want to talk to me, just talk. No more of these stupid games."

"Games?" Mother chuckled from the corridor behind her, causing Catra to spin around again. "You know better than that, Catra. Games are for fun. Are you having fun, Catra?"

"Games are fun for those who make the rules," Catra spat.

"Not necessarily," Mother said with aloof voice. "Still, some rules are necessary. Like the rule that forbids you to know what's in the wall."

Catra's ears perked up.

"Why? Why can't I know what's in the wall?"

"Because Glimmer doesn't trust you," Mother said with cruel glee in her voice.

Catra staggered backwards as if she had received a physical blow.

"She... Of course she trusts me."

Mother chuckled.

"She thinks that if you learn what she's hiding, you'll leave her."

"I'd never do that!" Catra cried hotly.

"Then I assume there is no danger in you finding it," Mother sneered.

"Finding what?" Catra asked.

"Hordak's heart, of course," Mother said.

"Catra!" Glimmer cried from the table. "Come, join us. Child want to tell you that they love you."

With a last, thoughtful look at Mother, Catra hurried over to Glimmer and Child.

"I love you, mother," Child said with grumpy voice.

Glimmer beamed at Catra.

"See!" she said.

At the same time, a large thump was heard above them, and a ceiling panel came loose. Purple cables spilled out of the hole.

"I'll get it," Glimmer quickly said and stood up on a chair, ineffectively trying to push the cables back.

"Glimmer..." Catra begun.

"Catra!" a voice said, just next to her ear. Catra spun around.

Two red eyes stared at her from a hole in the wall where a loose panel had finally fallen off. The eyes were surrounded by purple cables, intermingled with what looked more like plant tendrils, dotted with blue light.

An eerie sound could be heard. For some reason the sound made Catra's teeth itch.

"Who are you?" Catra gasped and took a step away from the threatening eyes.

"You can hear me, Catra? Great!" The voice said happily. "Listen, you're trapped in a spatiotemporary anomaly again... you really make a habit of these things, don't you? No judgement!" the voice quickly added.

"How..." Catra begun.

"I don't know how long I can maintain the connection, so just listen," the voice said. "In case you don't remember, you need to find the anomaly focus point. The artefact used to fuel the portal machine. Someone need to grab it to collapse the fractal reality. Only, that person will be trapped."

"Collapse... reality?" Catra gasped.

"Only your pocket-dimension," the voice said dismissively. "Otherwise, it will take all of Despondos with it when it eventually falls apart."

Catra stared at the red eyes. From deep inside her brain, a memory slowly emerged.

"Entrapta?" she gasped.

"You remember!" the voice said happily. The purple-haired woman flipped up her welding mask to reveal a friendly, if yet bruised face. Tendrils travelled over it and intermingled with her hair.

"Entrapta..." Catra repeated. "I'm... I'm so so..."

"CATRA!" Glimmer cried. Catra spun around.

Glimmer's face radiated fear and concern. She quickly stepped between Catra and the loose panel.

"There," she said. "I fixed the ceiling. Let's prepare Child for the afternoon exercise."

"Glimmer!" Catra gasped. "I talked to Entrapta. I think she might still be ali..."

"Entrapta is dead," Glimmer quickly interrupted.

"No, listen Glimmer," Catra tried. "She said..."

Her voice trailed off as she saw she shadowy figure of Mother sitting by the table, watching Child eat.

"How long as she been there," she angrily blurted out.

"Who?" Glimmer said brightly, moving slightly to stand between Catra and the table.

"Mother!" Catra snarled. "How long has she been talking to Child?"

"Oh, not long," Glimmer said dismissively. "Hey, let's go on a picknick!"

She quickly gathered up the remaining ration bars in a little basket and gave Child a nudge. Child stood up from the table with a scowl.

There was no longer a loose panel in the wall.

"There we go," Glimmer said happily. Let's climb the roof.

"Father says we're not to leave the room," Catra objected.

"Pish posh, what he doesn't know won't harm him," Glimmer answered.

She held out her hand to Catra.

"Listen, Glimmer..." Catra begun as she took Glimmer's hand. Then she drew a sharp breath as they suddenly stood on the roof, looking down at the churning vortex below.

"How did we get here?" she exclaimed.

"We climbed of course," Glimmer said with forced cheer in her voice. "Child is getting really good at it. Soon even you will have a hard time keeping up."

"Glimmer!" Catra pleaded. "Something very strange is going on here."

Glimmer gave her a concerned look.

"Whatever do you mean, my beloved?" she asked, stomping hard at a purple plant tendril that snaked itself upwards.

"I... I don't know," Catra confessed. "But Entrapta said..."

"Entrapta is dead," Glimmer said with hard voice, pushing her veil aside. "You should know. You killed her, after all."

Catra blinked. Glimmer's uniform was gone. Instead she was dressed in the shadowy robes she previously had seen Mother wear.

"Glimmer...?" she said with cautious voice.

"Don't you worry, Catra," Glimmer said with an edge to her voice. "Everything will be all right."

She took a step closer.

Catra took a step back, acutely aware that only a rickety old metal fence stood between her and the steep drop to the churning vortex below.

"Glimmer..." she tried again. "Reality is collapsing. Entrapta said we had to..."

"*Sssssh*," Glimmer said, suddenly very close.

She put her hand on Catra's cheek, and Catra did her best not to flinch at the sight of a robed arm so similar to Mother's so close to her face.

"I know," Glimmer said, voice low. She stared Catra intently in the eyes. "I know, but we mustn't let Father know that we know."

"Father...?" Catra begun, but caught the warning in Glimmer's eyes and lowered her voice.

"Why can't we let Father...?"

"Father's design is to destroy the world," Glimmer whispered.

"'We will not let God take us alive'," Catra recited, for the first time reflecting on the meaning of those familiar old words.

"Father is right," Glimmer urgently whispered. "God *is* searching for us, aimed to destroy us or worse. But Father is wrong. There is another way than to destroy ourselves before *he* gets here."

"Another...?" Catra begun.

"We must kill God," Glimmer said. "It's dangerous but it can be done. But for that we need power. Lots of power."

"How do you know all this?" Catra blurted, her head spinning.

Glimmer lowered her gaze.

"Catra..." she begun with uncertain voice. "You know that I love you, right?"

"Glimmer...?" Catra begun, voice full of dread.

"...and I'd never do anything to hurt you?" Glimmer went on.

"How do you know all this?" Catra insisted, despite already knowing the answer.

Glimmer looked down.

"Sorry," she said with small voice.

"Mother told you?" Catra cried.

"Please, keep your voice down!" Glimmer pleaded with a scared look around them.

"I can't believe you trust *her* over *me*!" Catra cried. She felt anger boiling up in her.

"I don't *trust* her," Glimmer blurted out. "But there is no one else to talk to about these things..."

"You could have talked to *me*," Catra screamed. She took a step back, body language poised for a fight. "We could have figured it out *together*."

"What's there to figure out? Sparkles doesn't trust you," a third voice added.

Catra turned her head and stared at... herself, but at a version of herself unlike anything she had ever seen. Half her body was pitch black, with a jagged line of white light marking the border. An empty eye stared at her with malevolence.

"Glimmer doesn't trust you," the corrupted Catra snarled at her. "Glimmer doesn't *love* you."

"I... I do love you," Glimmer feebly protested, looking with scared expression between the two Catra's.

"And you express it by leaving Catra on her own in the Fright Zone, to fight Hordak by herself while you cosied up with the Black Garnet. And now you're going behind our back, to *Shadow Weaver* of all people," the corrupted Catra leered.

"She said it was necessary," Catra protested, trying to position herself between the corrupted Catra and Glimmer.

"She's just the same as the others," the corrupted Catra snarled. "She wants something from us, and the minute she gets it she'll leave us all alone."

"No..." Glimmer protested. "No... I won't leave you?"

"Won't you?" the corrupted Catra leered. "And what about *Adora*?"

Glimmer recoiled as from a physical blow.

"... Adora is not here," she muttered.

"But when she comes back?" the corrupted Catra persisted. "What then?"

"What then?" Glimmer shot back, angry blotches of red on her cheek.

"Then who do you chose?" the corrupted Catra leered with a terrible grin. "You've had fun slumming it with us, haven't you? The pretty princess and the ruffian. No wonder Double Trouble loves that tale. But when Adora comes back, when you find all your pretty princess friends again... what then?"

"Yeah!" Glimmer snarled. "*What* then? Adora never *once* stopped hoping for you to crawl back to her. *You* have never once stopped hoping to follow her. You'd go to *Beast Island* of all hell holes just to have a chance to find her."

She turned to Catra and looked her straight in the eyes.

"So, what *about* Adora?" Glimmer snarled. "You'll creep back to her the moment we find her won't you?" Her voice cracked and died down to a whisper. "You will leave me..."

"No!" Catra wanted to protest, but the word was stuck in her throat.

The corrupted Catra gave her a smug look.

"I'll tell you what, 'Sparkles'," she said to Glimmer with sarcastic voice. "We'll not wait around for you to dump us."

Glimmer looked like she had a bucket of cold water dumped on her.

"Catra... please," she begun.

"In fact... the corrupted Catra said, voice suddenly smooth. "I see no reason to wait that long at all..."

She took a step forward, claws out.

"Catra...?" Glimmer carefully said.

"Hey!" Catra cried.

"So sorry, 'Princess'!" the corrupted Catra snarled. "Seems like I didn't trust you either, after all."

She lunged.

Glimmer gasped and brought her arms up in a defensive pose. But the corrupted Catra's claws never connected. She crashed down on the metal floor, Catra holding her down, her claws digging into the shadowy flesh.

"Not. Her." she growled.

"She'll leave us," corrupted Catra spat.

"We won't hurt her," Catra cried, anger boiling up. "We'll *never* hurt her."

"*She'll* hurt *us*," other Catra snarled, struggling to be free.

"I'll take my chances!" Catra hissed. She dug her claws deeper in the other Catra's shoulders.

"She'll leave us," the other Catra taunted, her claws scratched at Catra's face leaving deep gashes.

"I won't leave you," Glimmer said softly.

Ignoring the corrupted Catra, she bent down and put her hands on Catra's cheeks, her black gloves becoming wet with blood.

"I... I don't know what will happen," Glimmer confessed. "If Adora is alive... If there ever is an 'after the war'. If we ever win... Our lives will be quite different."

She looked Catra in the eyes.

"But whatever happens, I want you in my life. I want to be in yours."

She leaned forward. Her face filled Catra's entire world.

"I don't know what will happen. I don't know what promise I can give you. But, please, let me be in your life."

Catra felt tears welling up.

"That's all I want," she whispered.

Glimmer leaned forward and gave her a deep, long kiss.

When Glimmer withdrew, there was no corrupted Catra on the roof.

- - -

They sat on the roof together, look a bit bashful at each other.

"Do you really think there is a way out of here?" Catra said with low voice.

"Yeah," Glimmer said. "If we can find Hordak's heart. Only..."

Catra suddenly got cold.

"Only... someone must take it," she whispered.

Glimmer nodded, unhappily.

"Someone must be left behind," she sighed.

"You were planning to be the one to take it, weren't you?" she accused.

Glimmer made an apologetic smile.

"I... I don't know what else to do," she said with small voice. "We can't return to the normal universe... there won't *be* a normal

universe unless someone stays behind."

"I can do it," Catra said hotly. "I can get you out."

"No!" Glimmer whispered, suddenly white in her face.

"Well, I'm not letting you sacrifice yourself for me," Catra snarled. "You're too important. You have to..."

"Don't you think *you're* important?" Glimmer cried. "To *me*?"

Tears were streaming down her face.

"I can't do this. She whispered. "Not again."

She took Catra's hand and held it so hard it hurt.

"Adora..." she cried. "And mom... You are a survivor, Catra. You're a badass cut-throat villain. You always have a way out. You don't sacrifice yourself. Don't leave me alone, not again."

Catra stared at her.

"That's why," she said with low voice. "That's why you wouldn't tell me."

"I tried to find another way," Glimmer sobbed. "Tried so hard."

"...That's why you didn't tell me your real plan in the Fright Zone either..." Catra said, the memories coming back to her in bits and pieces.

Glimmer cried harder. She didn't meet Catra's eyes.

"...I needed power," she sobbed. "Power to stop you from sacrificing yourself for me if you felt it was needed."

She stared in Catra's eyes.

"Swear to me that you won't do it," she hissed. "Swear to me that you won't close the portal and leave me alone on the other side."

"I promise," Catra said bewildered. "But I just don't know..."

"We'll find a way," Glimmer said with desperate voice. "Will find a way *together*."

"Together," Catra echoed.

Glimmer closed her eyes for a moment, a shiver moving through her body.

She stood up and held out her hand. Catra took it, and Glimmer helped her to the feet.

"Right," Catra said with more bravado than she felt. "None of us sacrifice ourselves. Both of us make it. So what do we need? A mysterious heart and some other rube to take it. How hard could it be?"

Glimmer grinned at her, relief radiating from her.

"Piece of cake, for the two of us."

They looked around. The vortex was coming closer. There was no way down.

"Well, piece of cake, as long as the heart is hidden somewhere up here," Catra tried.

"I kinda think it is," Glimmer said with low voice.

She pointed above them.

On a large pole, the first one's crystal that had been embedded in Hordak's armour was crudely fitted to the metal. It was shining with a cold, blue light.

"Well..." Catra said. "That wasn't very hard."

"So... for step two?" Glimmer said with low voice.

They looked around.

There were only the two of them on the roof.

"Might be a bit more of a hassle," Catra said.

They looked at each other.

"Don't you dare," Glimmer said, trying to keep the fear from her voice.

"I won't," Catra promised. "You too?"

"Yeah, I do," Glimmer said.

They looked at the crystal.

"I suppose we can just as well..." Catra begun, and then the roof exploded under them. One moment they stood hand in hand, the next they fell, surrounded by debris.

They landed with a hard crash on the floor in front of the throne. Hordak stood by it's foot, fully dressed in the armour Entrapta had built him. His face and body was divided, just the way the Corrupted Catra had been. A jagged white line separated his normal flesh from ink blackness. His arm canon was on the corrupted side, still pointed upwards.

"YOU DARE?" he bellowed.

"Yeah," Catra snarled and took a step in front of Glimmer. "We've been through this. I dare."

"I offer you oblivion, you ungrateful creature," he scowled. "There is no greater gift in front of Prime."

"*You* brought Prime here," Catra snarled.

"Did I?" Hordak said, voice like poison. "As far as I recall, you were the one who pulled the lever."

"Of *your* machine," Catra cried.

"Yes. My machine," Hordak said. "Mine to do with as I see fit. As I have."

"You can't try to destroy the world and then be grumpy when people try to stop you," Catra said. She edged a bit closer.

Hordak grinned, a humourless grin.

"People of your world have always registered complaints at my doings. Never in a way that mattered."

"Then allow me to clarify our position," Glimmer said, a deadly edge to her voice.

She took a step forward, matching Catra's steps. The two of them slowly moving to opposite sides of Hordak.

"You?" he scoffed. "A little queen without kingdom. A band of ruffians in a desert and a wayward cat. Those are your claims?"

"They are," she said, tone deadly. "And you will find my claims more than adequate to speak for our world. To defend our world - against Horde Prime and against *you*.

Hordak had tracked her with the arm canon, but at her final words he sighed and sat down on the steps leading up to the throne.

"What's the use?" he muttered. "I'm doing you a favour, even if you can't see it."

"You said the same thing when you wanted to open the way for Horde Prime," Catra said.

She sat down next to him.

"I get it, you know," she said with low voice.

That got a chuckle out of Hordak.

"Do you, now?"

"I get what it is to have nothing left," she shrugged. "I get what it's like just wanting to... lash out. Make an impression."

"A final bid for power," Glimmer sighed. She sat down on the other side of him. "A final bid for relevance."

"And yet, here you are," Hordak muttered.

"And yet, here *we* are," Catra corrected him.

"Not for much longer now," Hordak said. He eyed the approaching vortex.

The first one's crystal was still attached to the pole, laying among the other debris.

"I lost my bid," Glimmer said slowly. "I lost my castle. I lost my runestone. I lost my friends."

"My condolences," Hordak said.

"But I gained other things," Glimmer said. I found Catra... we made a new beginning together, found new hope. Another throne to take."

"It's severely over-rated," Hordak drily remarked, glancing at the throne behind him.

Catra chuckled.

"Nevertheless," Glimmer said. "It's our bid, mine and Catra's. It's our fight. We have not given up. Just because you don't see alternatives... It's not your place to rob us of them."

"There are no alternatives against Horde Prime," Hordak said with heavy voice. "He finds you, he *takes* you. You and your entire world. Your one hope, your only hope was to remain hidden, but that is no longer an option."

"What about Entrapta?" Glimmer asked.

"Entrapta is dead," Hordak said with heavy voice.

"Actually..." Catra said, and Hordak turned his head to give her a scrutinizing look.

"Actually what?" he asked, voice full of suspicion.

"Actually, I... talked to her. Here." She gesticulated to the room around them, slowly being swallowed by the vortex. "I'm not sure how it works... but... it wasn't like a dream or something like that. It really felt like her."

Hordak gave her an intense stare.

"What did she say?" he demanded.

"Only that whoever took the crystal would end up inside the dimension when it closed," Catra said. "And... well, she looked... not well. I think she's still on Beast Island."

She looked down at her hands.

"Sorry," she muttered.

Hordak kept staring mouth open.

"The pseudo-lateral framework cannot support non-actualized forms," he said, more or less to himself.

"What does that mean?" Catra frowned.

"It means that she's alive..." Hordak breathed.

Suddenly he stood up, full of energy and purpose again.

"She's *alive*!" he bellowed.

He spun around and looked Glimmer in the eyes.

"Do you truly mean it, little queen? Are you ready to make your bid, make your stand, against *him*?"

"I am," Glimmer answered, slightly bewildered at Hordak's change in demeanour.

He turned to Catra.

"And you will support her in this?"

"I didn't drag her through a desert to abandon her now," Catra said and took a step closer to Glimmer, taking her hand.

"Then you'll have your chance," he said, eyes shining.

"What will you do?" Catra asked, fear in her voice.

"Entrapta is alive," Hordak repeated. "She can pull me out of this pocket dimension. I will wait for her, no matter how long it takes."

And taking two long strides forward, Hordak grabbed the crystal.

All around them, the vortex started howling.

"Make no mistake," he growled. "Horde Prime *is* coming. When he does, it will be up to you to stop him. Because this is a world he *can't have*."

Light erupted from the crystal, forcing Catra and Glimmer to look away. When they could see again, Hordak was no longer in the room.

Catra and Glimmer stared at each other.

"Well, I suppose that worked for step two," Glimmer said.

"Right," Catra agreed. "So what do we...?"

In front of them, the floor broke up, individual pieces falling into the vortex.

"RUN!" Glimmer cried. She scrambled up the throne, now impossibly tall. At the very top they could see a swirling portal forming.

Glimmer scrambled like a monkey, with Catra just after her. They had to duck stones that fell from the roof, and the wind grew stronger for every second.

"Hurry!" Catra said, and then she had to kick at some debris that had snagged her foot. She tried to get it loose, but it stuck to her again.

Catra looked down and saw the claw-like hand of Mother holding her, as the tall figure flapped like a rug in the wind.

"Catra!" she pleaded.

"Let me go!" Catra cried and aimed a kick. Mother made a grimace of pain, but didn't let go. Instead she clung harder to Catra, grabbing hold of her tail as well.

"Catra!" she cried again, voice urgent.

"Catra!" Glimmer cried from the top of the stair, next to the flickering portal. "*Come*!"

Catra turned around and, in desperation, sunk her teeth into Mother's arm. Mother cried and let go of her leg and tail, and Catra quickly turned to scramble towards the portal again.

"Wa-wait!" Mother whispered, and despite herself Catra glanced over her shoulder.

Mother sat hunched on the steps, no longer reaching for Catra. She moved her hand to her face and, with fumbling fingers she unfastened her veil.

The face behind it was regal. It was furrowed and tired, but the kindness and compassion shone through. She gave Catra a warm smile, full of tears.

"Catra..." she whispered. "You and Glimmer... please... take care of each other."

"COME!" Glimmer cried, and dragging the stunned Catra with her she managed to bring them the last few steps, and together they tumbled through the portal.

Chapter End Notes

> And with that delightful image we leave the Siege of the Fright Zone. Now we will take a break until July until we move on with Queens of the Horde act five - Queens of the Horde.
>
> In the meanwhile, please enjoy this Tumblr exclusive interview with the cast: https://www.tumblr.com/blog/view/baggebythesea/686066096409870336

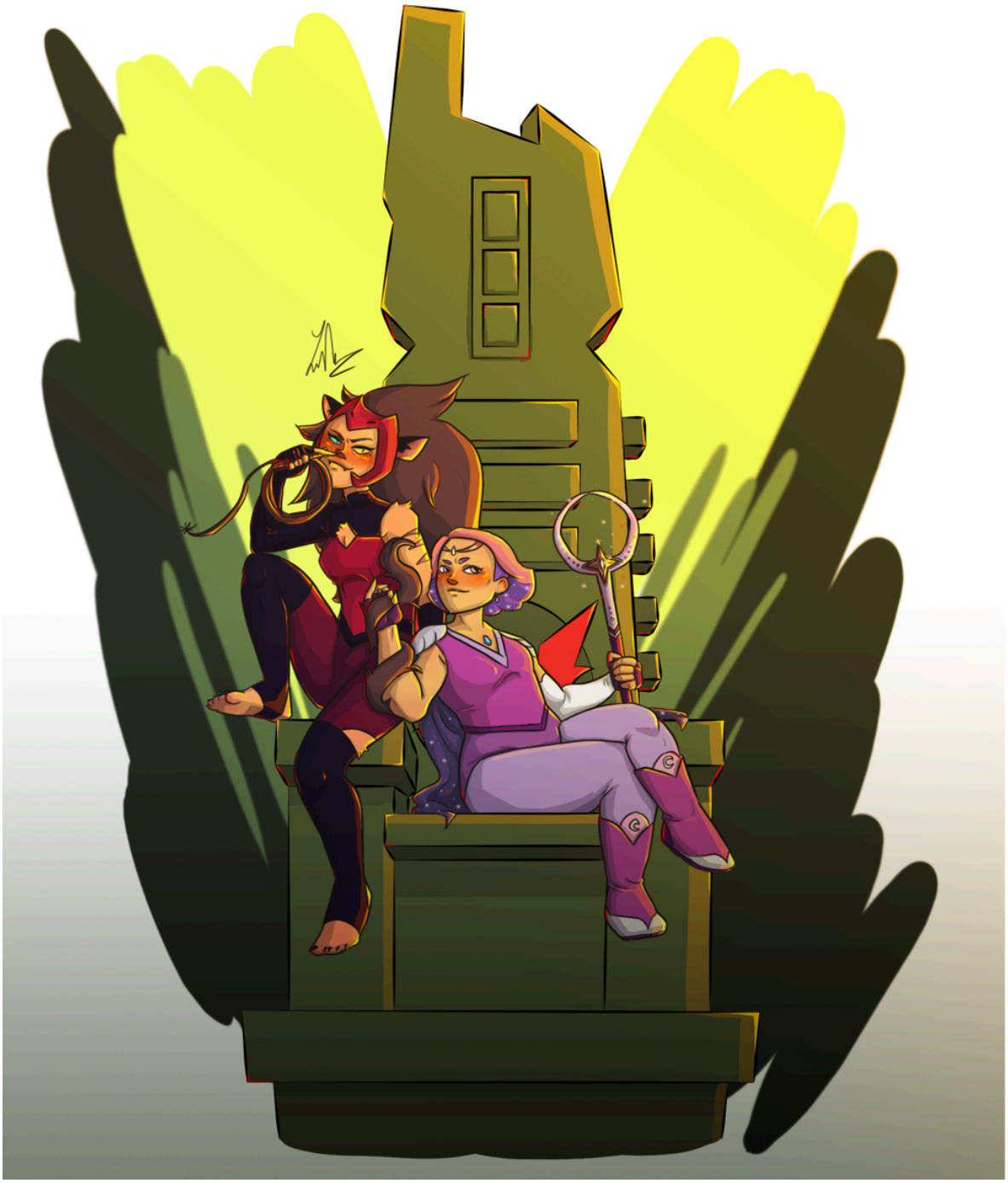
Act Five - Queens of the Horde

Chapter Notes

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

Art commissioned from Lorvikk.

See the end of the chapter for more notes



"Would you like more tea?" Angella politely said.

"You are most accommodating," Hordak rumbled.

Angella held up a prop tea pot made of cardboard and a bit sheepishly mimed pouring up tea in an prop mug. She hesitated a moment, and then handed it over to Hordak. He glared at it and put it down on the table.

They sat alone on the stage with the curtain drawn behind them. A single spot lit up their table with the prop tea set.

"So..." Angella said after an uncomfortable pause. "I trust you are feeling well...?"

"Agreeable," Hordak muttered.

"I'm glad to hear..." Angella said.

They fell silent again.

"The weather?" Angella desperately said.

"Give how we are trapped in a pocket dimension completely void of atmospheric fluctuation, I have no opinion on the subject," Hordak said with a voice that almost passed as polite.

"Of course, of course," Angella quickly agreed.

She fidgeted with her prop cup.

Hordak, obviously feeling he should contribute, cleared his throat twice.

"Your daughter..." he rumbled.

Angella glanced at him.

"She seems very... *passionate*," he said, obviously choosing his words carefully.

Angella couldn't help but chuckle.

"That she is," she said. "Sometimes I feel there is no cause to small for her to form a burning opinion about."

She smiled, a bit shyly.

"Your own ward also seem to have a bit of a *drive*," she ventured.

"Catra's relationship to the word 'no' is a personal insult as well as a challenge. She has never yet refused it."

"And now they're together," Angella said, not quite able to contain her glee.

"I feel confident Etheria will not experience a prolonged period of boredom," Hordak grinned.

They smiled at each other.

"I suppose we will have to find out," Angella said. She turned directly to the audience. "And so will you, in this next act of 'Queens of the Horde' - titled..." - she glanced at a note taped to the back of the tea-pot- "...um, 'Queens of the Horde'."

"To be updated every week," Hordak muttered.

"With artwork of the delightful Lorvikk," Angella went on.

"From tumblr," Hordak gruffed.

"With content warnings about violence," Angella read on from the note, "...depression, codependence, mutilation, self harm.... um..." -she turned to curtain- "Glimah? You said this was a perfectly family friendly production?"

"Sheeeesh, mom! It will be fine," Glimmer's annoyed voice was heard.

"Queens of the Horde!" Hordak rumbled and gesticulated at the curtain. It opened to reveal a beautifully painted set full of crystals and strange corridors.

Chapter End Notes

I got this idea from Crack_Fic_Casey and it was too good to pass up on. :-)

Anyway, welcome back! This is probably the longest act, so let's get started!

Light Hope

Chapter Notes

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Nothing stirred.

Nothing lived.

There were no noise in the empty, crystal hallways.

Silence.

But then, all of sudden, a sound.

A presence where there before had been none.

A voice cried out.

"Unauthorized presence detected!"

Red light flowed over the temple of the first one's. Spiders emerged.

Spiders were slain.

A brief pause. A brief exchange.

More spiders, same result.

"I know what you want, Light Hope," a smooth voice said. "You want to balance Etheria. You won't succeed." A brief pause for effect. "Not without me."

Silence.

"Princesses has come and gone," the voice continued. "Royal lineages have snuffed out, and the lone runestones have attached themselves to new hosts. Etheria's magic keep flowing. I could threaten either one of them, and they would be a poor hostage... unlike Adora."

Fury.

"Yes. Adora," the voice said. "The key to your genetic lock. The child from beyond the veil. The *First One* you brought here. You see, I figured out your little puzzle, and I have taken her to a place where you can't reach her. One word from me, she's dead and your grand purpose is forfeit."

Silence. Then:

"Your terms?"

"Power."

Silence. Then:

"Welcome, administrator Queen Shadow Weaver of Brightmoon."

Chapter End Notes

I'm sure that's fine

Spoils of Victory

Chapter Notes

Warning: Medium levels of violence and power play

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Well..." Lonnie looked around at the wrecked throne room and scribbled something on her clipboard. "I can see we have some repair work to do."

Catra and Glimmer just nodded at her, too tired to answer. They sat by the foot of the broken throne, holding each other.

"We actually won!" Jack said with wonder in their voice. "We actually took over the Horde?"

"Not quite, Sport," Double Trouble chuckled and put their undamaged hand on their shoulder, the other arm being held in a temporary sling.

Jack frowned.

"What do you mean? Catra took down Hordak, didn't she?"

"She sure did," Lonnie said. "And for a few of us that settles it." She did a gesture to indicate herself, Kyle and Rogelio - who were trying to do some emergency repair on the electrical cables Hordak had severed. Jack smiled at Kyle, who smiled back.

"But many of the others might take this as the opportunity to take their leave," Lonnie finished.

"We can't afford that," Glimmer said with tired voice. "We need the Horde to go after Shadow Weaver, and we can't stop to put

out fires everywhere a horde alumni get the bright idea to take over a village of their own."

"My thoughts exactly," Double Trouble said. "We have a small window of opportunity while everyone is still trying to figure out what's going on."

"A show of force," Catra said with determined voice.

"Another one?" Jack groaned. "Didn't we just do one?"

"We did show that we could *take* the throne," Double Trouble confirmed. "Now we need to prove we can *hold* it. As your queens well know, there is *quite* a difference between a conqueror and a ruler."

"Yeah," Lonnie said, eyeing Catra carefully. "About that..."

"Yeah, Lonnie?" Catra said, meeting her eyes.

"You were a shit boss, back before Hordak turned on you," Lonnie said without changing her tone of voice.

"Were I now...?" Catra said, letting go of Glimmer and standing up.

Not quite in a fighting stance.

Not quite in a non-fighting stance.

Jack opened their mouth to say something but Double Trouble squeezed their shoulder, signalling to them to be silent. Kyle and Rogelio stopped their work to look at Lonnie and Catra, their hands gripping their tools a bit harder than before.

Glimmer watched the two women without blinking.

"Yeah, you were," Lonnie confirmed, not backing, not blinking. Her hand, as by coincidence, hovering close to her blaster.

"I seem to recall that I gave you a promotion..." Catra went on with the same faux-friendly tone of voice.

"About bloody time someone did," Lonnie gruffed. "Do you happen to remember *why*?"

"Yeah, I do," Catra said. "You gave me a whole grand speech about the Horde running on soldiers and machines, not magic and fancy princess-tricks. You told me you needed downtime."

"And now?" Lonnie said, not even trying to be coy about looking at Glimmer.

"And now, *what*," Catra asked, voice sharp.

"That's what I'm asking you," Lonnie said, giving Catra a hard look. "You beat the big man, you got the big chair. Good for you."

"Good for me," Catra echoed.

Her claws where out.

"You want to run this place, you need us," Lonnie said, "and you know it."

"Do I?" Catra said, voice deceptively calm.

"Yeah," Lonnie said with a snort.

Catra relaxed her stance and nodded.

"Yeah, I do," she said.

"...and?" Lonnie prompted.

"And now I'll try to do better," Catra said with low voice.

Lonnie held her gaze for a few moments, then she nodded.

The atmosphere in the room immediately became less tense.

Jack realized they had held their breath.

"Do you know why I took a chance on you?" Lonnie said to Catra, moving her hand away from the blaster, back to the clipboard. "Why the three of us decided to stay out of the fight?"

"I figure you had an inkling what Hordak was up to," Catra said, slumping down next to Glimmer again.

"Yeah," Lonnie confirmed, not quite suppressing a shudder as she looked at the throne. "But there were no lack of candidates for kicking his ass. I took a chance on you because you threw me a bone back in the Waste."

She glanced meaningfully at Catra's mutilated, left hand. Catra looked away, suddenly somewhat bashful.

"I took a chance on you," Lonnie went on, "because I remember a little kitten who sometimes, when she was not feeling backed into a corner, looked out for the rest of us."

"Can't have been very often," Catra muttered, not meeting her gaze.

Lonnie shrugged.

"Wasn't very often you weren't backed into a corner. Shadow Weaver saw to that." She met Catra's eyes. "You have it in you to be a good boss, Catra. I can't see anyone except you uniting the Horde after Hordak. If you say you want to be better, then I'm willing to take our chances."

Rogelio and Kyle nodded agree.

"Also, being in love suits you, *boss*," Lonnie smirked and glanced at Glimmer. "Can't wait to see what your princess will bring to the table."

"So glad to be included in the conversation," Glimmer said with dry voice.

"No offence, 'your majesty'," Lonnie shrugged. "Just want to make sure you know what you're up against."

"What *am* I up against?" Glimmer said.

She remained seated, but her back was straight.

Catra took a step backwards, not wanting to interfere in this new confrontation.

"The Horde is not the princess alliance," Lonnie said. "The Fright Zone is not princess la-la-land."

"Meaning?" Glimmer said, voice sharp.

"Meaning that this place won't care how sparkly your mommie's tiara was," Lonnie gruffed. "Nor does it run on loyalty. Not any more. I've heard what you been up to in the Waste. I fought you often enough to know that you can be tough when you have to be."

"I do think I can be tough, yes," Glimmer said, hands in her sides.

"Good," Lonnie nodded. "I just wanted to be the first to give you the heads up. In the Horde, you have to be tough to rule. If that's your ambition, of course. You can sit in your lab and tinker with your pet projects if you want, but then you're not a ruler, just the queen's tame princess."

"I like the sound of that," Catra drawled.

Glimmer gave her a faux-disgruntled look and swatted her hand.

"I do intend to take a more active hand at current affairs than Entrapta did, if that's what you're asking me," she said to Lonnie. "And I do think I can bring something to the table not even Hordak managed."

"And what is that?" Lonnie asked.

"Diplomacy," Glimmer said simply. "Negotiations. Alliances based on common goals rather than who will stab who in the back first."

"And what common goals would that be?" Lonnie asked

"To end the war," Glimmer answered. "This world has been fighting longer than most of us have been alive. I can offer an end to that."

"After Shadow Weaver is defeated, I take it," Lonnie said.

"Naturally," Glimmer answered.

"What about Horde Prime?" Jack asked silently.

"One thing at the time," Glimmer sighed. "Most people have never heard about him, and they most certainly wouldn't believe us if we told them."

"And right now we have more immediate concerns," Catra filled in.

She eyed Lonnie.

"Like, where we should direct that 'show of force'?"

"Octavia," Lonnie said simply.

Catra raised an eyebrow.

"Oh?"

"The armada changed course an hour ago," Lonnie explained, glancing at her comm pad to make sure. "Every Horde communication channel is abuzz with gossip about what happened. Octavia is coming here, and she'll bring enough firepower and soldiers to take over the whole place."

"Which means that the others will look to her to see how we will react," Catra mused.

Glimmer stood up.

"Thus, the perfect show of force."

She held out her hand.

"My queen," she said.

"My queen," Catra answered and took her hand.

They disappeared in a shower of pink sparkles.

- - -

"Let me know the minute we are in range of the communication relays," Octavia ordered. "We should be able to bypass them, but in case the cat has changed the codes, I want to know the moment you find out. Be prepared to open fire. Even if she's taken control of the defence system, we can shoot our way through."

"Got it, captain," her second in command answered.

"And prepare the landing teams," Octavia gruffed. "I'll prepare orders for them. I want a main theme to take the inner sanctum, but I have several secondary objectives I want secured before we get there."

"You've thought this through, captain," the second in command said with dry voice.

"Everyone needs a hobby," Octavia shrugged. "It's been clear for a while now that Hordak is loosing it. *Someone* is bound to take over."

"Can just as well be you, eh, captain," the second in command said with a smirk."

"You said it," Octavia leered.

With a grunt she walked into her cabin, bopping on her comm pad. Right. She would need one team in the eastern block as soon as they made land-fall. If she could cut off the main corridor the canons would be...

"Hello, Octavia," Catra drawled. She sat in Octavia's chair, cleaning her claws with Octavia's pen-knife.

Octavia's hand flew to her blaster. She fired without aiming and jumped to the side immediately as Catra flung the knife at the spot where Octavia's head had been a moment before and leapt to the table, whip in hand.

"Fucking cat!" Octavia snarled and managed to fire several more blasts before Catra's whip tore the blaster away from her hand. She fumbled with her belt to get hold of her stun baton and rush her opponent, but before she had time to reach it, out of nowhere a pink light filled the cabin.

Without being able to see, Octavia spun around, swiping wildly with her fists. Then she felt a sharp pain in her back and was tackled to the ground, a small, strong body pressing her towards the metal deck. She struggled to get free, but then she felt the all to familiar sensation of sharp steel against her windpipe.

Octavia froze.

"Yes, hello Octavia," the princess hissed just by her ear. "Tell me, just how much would you miss your remaining eye?"

Just in the edge of Octavia's clearing field of vision, a slender hand could be seen moving a thin, efficient looking dagger from her throat, instead pointing straight at her eye.

Octavia forced herself to relax.

"Hello, Catra," she gruffed. "Hello, princess."

Catra smirked at her and took her seat by the desk again, making a show of tidying up the upended chair. The princess let go of

Octavia and took a step back, out of her field of vision.

"We are *so* happy to see you," Catra said.

"So happy," the princess echoed behind Octavia.

"I'm sure you are," Octavia said and carefully got to her feet. She had a blaster grenade in her top drawer for situations like this. Maybe if she...

"We just thought we would pop in and say hi," Catra said. She opened the top drawer and picked up the grenade. She eyed it with interest for a moment, then she put it back in the drawer and closed it carefully with a little click.

"After all, this is new ground for all of us..." the princess filled in behind her.

"We're at sea now, Glimmer," Catra said. "Perhaps a more nautical metaphor?"

"New winds? Uncharted waters? Unburnt sails?" the princess tried. Octavia dared a small step to the side so she had both of them in her field of vision.

"Maybe not the last one," Catra objected. "The others are good."

"Fine," the princess said. She turned to Octavia again.

"As we are in *uncharted waters*, we thought it would be best to pop by in person to have a little 'chat'."

"A little 'chat'," Catra echoed.

"...to clear up any misunderstandings."

"...misunderstandings."

"After all," the princess went on, we wouldn't want our *working relationship* to get off to a bad start."

"...bad start," Catra leered.

"So please, have a seat," the princess said, indicating the chair normally reserved for underlings Octavia wanted to bully in person. The symbolism was not lost on her.

She sat down with a grunt.

She stared at Catra for a moment. The princess had taken position in a corner.

"You really took out Hordak?" Octavia asked after a little while.

"Sure did," Catra leered.

"And now you intend to hold the throne?" Octavia went on.

"Sure do," the princess said behind her.

"The two of you? Queens of the Horde?" Octavia went on. She managed to keep most of the scorn out of her voice.

"Sure are," Catra said with an intense look at Octavia.

"Everyone won't follow you," Octavia observed.

"Yeah, we figure," Catra said.

"Transitions of leadership is always messy," the princess filled in, looking with pretend interest at her dagger.

"A time of uncertainty," Catra said.

"Much easier if expectations are clearly communicated," the princess hissed.

"Listen," Octavia said with heavy voice. "Just kill me. You don't have to keep me around to listen to your jabbering."

"Oh, but we intend to," the princess laughed.

"Not the jabbering part, necessarily," Catra said with a slight blush.

"But we do intend to keep you around," the princess said.

Octavia turned and gave her a long, speculating look.

"Yeah?" she said eventually.

"Yeah," Glimmer confirmed. "We need *someone* to lead *our* fleet, and you're our top candidate for the job."

"I kinda thought you would give the job to the Salinean princess, or that insane pirate boytoy of hers," Octavia said with an eyebrow raised.

"I'm not giving Sea Hawk command of anything I want not to burn to the ground anytime soon," Glimmer said with a snort.

"And I'm not just handing over vital parts of the Horde to princesses, no matter how cute this one might be," Catra filled in.

The princess did a little soppy sound, and Octavia found it within herself to roll her eyes.

"I tried to kill you," Octavia pointed out. "Both of you."

"Well, Catra tried to kill me too, and I like her just fine," the princess said with flippant tone.

She caught Catra's eyes.

"In fact, I like her *very* much."

Catra cleared her throat and looked away. The princess smiled smugly and Catra rolled her eyes harder.

"Our point is," Catra said, "we don't let little things like who tried to kill who stand in our way as we do business."

"...business," the princess echoed.

"Yeah? Well, I'm not exactly great in the bootlicker department either," Octavia gruffed, "in case you hadn't noticed."

"And here I really wanted me a good bootlicker," the princess sighed.

"We know you're not a bootlicker. We know you don't like us and we know you're not more loyal to us than you were to Hordak, or will be to anyone else who hold the throne," Catra said, focus suddenly entirely on Octavia. "You're a vicious old pirate, and that's what we want. We want you to stay on as an admiral, because you know how the ships work, because you can bully the rest of the fleet in line and because when we tell you to fight, you won't hesitater."

"Oh yeah," Octavia said. "And who are we fighting?"

"The enemies of the Horde," Catra said with an edge to her voice.

Octavia laughed.

"Just like that, huh?"

"Just like that," the princess confirmed.

"And suppose I were to decline your fine offer?"

"We'd kill you," the princess said with calm voice. "Here and now."

"We will show your head to the rest of the Horde, as an example," Catra said. "We would prefer it to be attached to the rest of your body, but if not we are sure there are lessons to be learned anyway."

"...lessons to be learned," the princess leered.

Octavia grunted.

She glanced at the knife Catra had placed on the desk.

She looked between Catra and the princess.

She weighed her options.

"I want an apology," she gruffed eventually.

Catra raised an eyebrow.

"An apology, Admiral Octavia?"

"For my eye," she clarified.

Catra stared at her for a moment, then she started to laugh.

"By all means, of course. We can't have a little thing like that hanging over us."

She got up from her chair and made the most obnoxious little bow in front of the chuckling Octavia.

"I *do* beg you pardon for scratching out your eye *and* for calling you a dumb-face. I *promise* that it won't happen again."

Her face suddenly grew serious, and in the blink of an eye, she was in Octavia's face, a claw to her throat.

"...because if I ever see you pull that kind of shit on a kid again, I will fucking *kill* you. Are we clear?"

"Apology accepted and message received," Octavia said with calm voice. "Also, there's one other thing."

"And what might that be?" Catra said and retreated half a step. "Pay rise? More purple ration bars? Better stuffed chair?"

Octavia smirked.

"I won't do the 'my queen' shit," she rumbled. "I can do 'boss'. That's what you get. Take it or leave it." She was silent a moment, forcing her mouth to form the correct syllable, "...boss, and boss," she said to Catra and Glimmer, in turn.

Catra and Glimmer exchanged a triumphant smirk.

"That will do nicely, *Admiral* Octavia," Glimmer said with smug voice. "Welcome on board the New Horde. I look forward to our collaboration."

"Yeah, 'boss'," Octavia rumbled. "It will be barrels of laughter, I'm sure."

A knock was heard on the door.

"Hey, captain," the second in command cried. "We just hailed the command relays, and the codes have changed. Should I blast them?"

"Nah," Octavia sighed. "I'll give you the new codes." She glanced at a piece of paper Catra slipped her. "Also, there's a slight change of plans."

"Oh," the second in command said as she entered the small cabin. She took in the scene with a sharp intake of breath.

"I've talked over our situation with our *queens* here," Octavia rumbled with a gesture to Catra and Glimmer. "I think we have cleared up any *misunderstandings*."

"...misunderstandings..." Glimmer and Catra echoed with obnoxious smirks. Octavia gave them an annoyed look.

"Yeah?" the second in command frowned, hand on her cutlass.

"We whip the rest of the fleet in shape for them, they'll keep us on," Octavia clarified.

"Got it," the second in command said after a long pause. "Shall I belay the order of landing in the Fright Zone?"

"No, you will land as planned," Glimmer said, causing the second in command to jump slightly. "Nice and ordered, and that way no one manning the canons on shore will get nervous as they see you coming. We wouldn't want you to miss the coronation after all."

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Lonnie consulted her clipboard.

"...and the rest of the officers are staying behind with their units to keep an eye on things. I've got some feelers out. If anyone tries something, I'll know it."

"...and I've got a whole lot more feelers out," Double Trouble smirked. "Those most likely to 'try' something won't be in a position to do so."

Lonnie gave them an annoyed look, but nodded.

"The boys are almost done with the throne room, but we'll need some more time to get the reception area ready. Long time since we had this many officers in the Fright Zone at the same time, and well, you and Hordak kinda did a number on the place, boss."

"You should have seen the other guy," Catra mumbled, fighting desperately to keep her eyes open. She and Glimmer leaned on each other, sitting by the foot of the throne.

"...so right now, all we have to do is to keep them busy. I'll have Rogelio run some sparring while Kyle work on the ceremony."

"'ts good," Glimmer muttered. "I should..."

"*You* should get some sleep, 'your majesty'," Lonnie said with sharp voice. "And drag Catra with you. You have a big day ahead of you, and you won't be able to bully anyone to accept you as their leader if you're falling asleep on the spot."

"Need to keep an eye on things..." Catra said, desperately trying and failing to keep her eyes open.

Lonnie sighed.

Without rush, she drew her blaster and pointed it straight at Catra.

For a moment no one moved, and then, just as Catra and Glimmer scrambled to their feet and Jack and Double Trouble started to move forward, Lonnie put the blaster away again.

"Or you trust me," she said calmly to the heavily breathing Catra. "You need to turn your back at me at some point. Can just as well get it over with."

Catra stared at Lonnie, the other people in the room glanced at Catra, waited for her to react. Lonnie calmly waited.

"Don't push your luck, Lonnie," Catra said after a few moments, forcing herself to sit down again.

The atmosphere in the room immediately became more relaxed.

"Why not?" Lonnie shot back. "You say you want to be a better boss than last time. I can just as well find out early on if you truly mean it."

Catra gave Lonnie a little respectful nod..

"If this is you angling for a better office, you have it. You can grab the one on the corner with the window. You've earned it."

She stood up again and dragged Glimmer with her to her feet.

"Me and Sparkles will tell our gals to stand down, then we'll hit they hay. Jack, get some sleep as well. Double Trouble, keep an eye on things. You can sleep when you're dead."

Double Trouble did an obnoxious little salute, while Jack followed Catra and Glimmer out of the chamber.

Glimmer gave Lonnie a long look, but didn't say anything.

They left the room with Jack in tow.

"You trust Lonnie?" Glimmer asked with low voice as they walked hand in hand down the corridor.

"Might as well," Catra shrugged. "We need her and she knows it."

"I trust you," Glimmer said, voice tired. "So if you says so, I'll trust her. One person less to bully in place."

"Yeah..." Catra sighed. "We'll have enough of that, once it truly sinks in for people that Hordak is gone."

Jack had been given their own room with a mattress that must have been pillaged from one of the conquered villages, all feathers and frills and as alien to a Crimson Waste bandit as anything they'd ever seen.

"For me?" Jack gasped eyeing the excess in softness with enormous eyes.

"For you," Catra confirmed, satisfied with Jack's reaction. "I thought you'd earned yourself something better than just an ol' dorm bed."

"Just drag the blanket to the floor if you have trouble sleeping," Glimmer smirked. "It takes some time getting used to."

They left Jack to explore to wonders of their own bed and entered their own quarters, set up to in an old storage room. Neither of them were eager to sleep in the tiny room where Hordak had holed up all these years. Their bed was serviceable and high quality, but nothing as fancy as the one given to the teenager.

"Softie," Glimmer smiled.

"What?" Catra grunted.

"Only the best for our apprentice, eh?" Glimmer teased.

"If they're hanging out with a princess all the time they should sleep like one," Catra gruffed.

"How thoughtful," Glimmer laughed. "And it's just a coincidence they get the luxury you were denied as a kid, right?"

"Shut up..." Catra muttered.

Glimmer smirked at her and gave her a quick peck on the cheek.

They sat down on the bed.

"Glimmer..." Catra begun. "Are you OK?"

Glimmer actually laughed a bit at that.

"What an odd question," she smirked.

"You know what I mean," Catra sighed. "After the... portal?"

Glimmer hid her face in her hands.

"I truly hate that place," she muttered. "Too many ghosts."

"Yeah..." Catra agreed. She glanced at Glimmer. "Um... How much do you remember?"

"Bits and pieces," Glimmer answered. "More like a dream than anything else." She managed a tired little smile. "I remember the two of us playing house in your old dorm. You're quite the romantic, you know."

Catra blushed.

"Fine, so not all parts were bad," she admitted. She hesitated a moment before she went on. "Do you think Entrapta actually is alive?" she asked with low voice.

"Who knows?" Glimmer answered with a shrug.

"Hordak sure seemed to believe it," Catra persisted.

"Hordak was just as sure she was dead a moment before," Glimmer said with tired voice as she bent down to take off her shoes. "I'm not sure he's the best judge."

"Yeah..." Catra said.

"Just ghosts," Glimmer said. "They can't hurt us. Not in the here-and-now."

Catra sighed and removed her mask.

"You don't truly believe that, do you Sparkles?"

"Living, dead, I don't care," Glimmer said. "I'm not letting anyone hurt you."

Catra gave her a quick, thankful smile.

They sat in silence for a little while.

"Catra... "Glimmer said with low voice, without looking at her girlfriend. "I'm sorry."

Catra glanced at her, but didn't say anything.

"I should have told you about me going for the Black Garnet," Glimmer went on, still looking at her hands.

"Yeah," Catra said without heat.

"Sorry..." Glimmer sighed.

"You remember back in the desert," Catra said with gentle voice. "How I told you you won't have to pussyfoot around me?"

"Yeah," Glimmer said.

"I mean it, Sparkles," Catra said with a direct look at Glimmer. "I'm not Adora. I'm not your mom."

"Yeah, so what if I *had* told you I was going to connect to the Black Garnet?" Glimmer said, voice a bit sharper.

"I'd told you that Hordak probably had booby trapped it and told you to sort it out after we kicked his ass," Catra said with just a hint of a smirk.

"Fine, you get one 'I told you so'," Glimmer muttered.

"Hey, you made the wrong call, but you still kicked ass," Catra sat and put an arm around Glimmer's shoulder. "Around here, that counts as a win."

"*You* kicked ass," Glimmer muttered. "I was just in the way."

Catra regarded her in silence for a moment.

"You don't get it, do you," she said, just a tiny bit of hurt in her voice.

"Get what?" Glimmer said, suddenly slightly apprehensive.

"I couldn't do this without you," Catra simply said. "I couldn't do any of it without you."

"Catra...." Glimmer whispered, her eyes suddenly full of tears.

"This is *our* victory, Glimmer," Catra said and - slightly shy - took Glimmer's hand.

"And it's not the last one," Glimmer assured her.

Then she wriggled out of her clothes. Catra watched as she let the last of her clothes - burnt and damaged from the fight - fall to the floor.

She gave Catra a direct look.

"Now come to bed. Hold me, Catra. We have won, and things are about to get very hectic once more people realize that. Right now, I want things to be un-hectic for once. With you."

"Now who's the romantic," Catra chuckled as she took off the last of her clothes and slipped down under the blanket together with Glimmer.

For an answer, Glimmer kissed her, a slow series of kisses, ending with her pressing her face at the little spot under Catra's chin.

Catra could feel the smell of smoke in Glimmer's hair.

"I love you," she muttered, voice slightly muffled from Glimmer's hair.

"I love you," Glimmer answered, almost but not quite stifling a yawn.

Not even ten heartbeats later, they were both fast asleep.

Chapter End Notes

Lonnie takes no shit.

Queens of the Horde

Chapter Notes

> Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support. And thanks to jid123 for helping me think out and describe outfits for the girls.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The throne room was abuzz with whispers. The most senior officer of the Horde was all there, together with selected, elevated underlings. Kyle, Lonnie and Rogelio stood by the door. Jack watched nervously from a dark corner by the side of the throne. Double Trouble stood by themselves in a corner, meeting every glance in their direction with a cheeky grin. Even Madeleine and a few others of Catra's lieutenants and Glimmer's ladies-in-waiting from the Crimson Waste were there.

In front of them the Throne, empty, illuminated by a single spotlight.

By its foot, Hordak's discarded, broken arm canon just 'happened' to be left lying around.

The rumour mill had been ablaze these last few days. Catra had killed Hordak. She had lead an army of thugs from the Crimson Waste. Her mad princess had shattered the Black Garnet. She had brainwashed Octavia. It was all a puppet show orchestrated by Shadow Weaver. The Scorpion King was back!

What everyone knew, what everyone agreed on, was that Hordak was gone.

The one, unifying will of the Horde was gone.

Most of them had experience of Catra's leadership from before Hordak had thrown her out. It was with some trepidation they looked forward to her taking full control of the reins.

A side door opened, and without any fanfare, Catra sauntered into the room, dressed in her 'bandit queen' gear, polished and repaired, but otherwise no different from when her 'kingdom' was a camp in the desert. She stopped by the foot of the throne. She looked around with a grin.

"Hi, did you miss me?" she said.

No one breathed.

"I missed you," Catra leered.

She let her gaze play over the assembly.

"I missed *some* of you," she clarified, her eyes dancing with mirth at her own little joke.

"Aren't we all *glad* we are all back together?" she drawled.

"CATRA IS THE..." Madeleine begun, but Catra held up her hand, silencing her.

"There will be plenty of time for that later," she drawled, a glint in her eyes. "We will have a proper coronation with speeches and ceremony and all that crap. I just thought it would be useful to meet up a bit before that."

She looked around again.

"Clear the air."

She took a step into the middle of the room.

"Sort out any lingering... issues."

"After all," she went on, "These are times of transition. There must be so many questions. On policy... on organisation... on who will be the first to try anything..."

She held up her hand, her claws shooting out.

"What do you say?" she hissed. "Anyone want to take a swing at me?"

No one said a word. Catra slowly moved through the ranks of the most powerful people in the Horde, one by one looking them in the eyes.

"What do you say, Octavia?" she leered. "Want a chance to get even for that thing with the eye?"

"Pass," the octopus faced admiral rumbled, staring impassionately at the air in front of her.

"Oh?" Catra said. She stopped in front of an officer not much older than herself. "How about you, Cravlor? Up until a few days ago, you were trying your best to take down my forces in the Crimson Waste. Why don't you get the job done, here and now?"

"I wouldn't call it 'their best'," Slither sniggered and got a guffaw from Madeleine.

Catra raised an eyebrow.

"Held back, were you?" she asked with pleasant voice.

"Ye-eah?!" Cravlor said with palatable fear.

"*Sure* you did," Catra laughed.

She took another few steps and stopped before Cobolt, who looked back at her without any sign of being stressed. Half his face was hidden behind a bandage.

"What about you, Cobolt?" she hissed. "You always beat me in training. Care to try the real thing?"

"I did, a few days ago," he calmly answered. "You won."

"Yeah, I did, didn't I?" she hissed.

She stepped back, to the foot of the throne.

"Did you all get that," she said, voice hostile. "I *won*."

No one said anything.

"Shadow Weaver, Hordak, the princesses... everyone who tried to keep me down... it didn't end so hot for them, did it?"

There was no single sound, except Catra's footsteps as she paced back and forth along the ranks of Horde officers.

"In fact," she said, "*all* of you had your chance, *all* of you took your swing at me, but none of you ever came close to get me. None of you could even hurt a *finger* of my body..."

She silenced, a grin slowly spreading on her lips. She held up her mutilated left hand.

"...now that is not entirely true, is it?"

The whole room was dead silence. No one blinked, no one breathed. Only Kyle made a silent whimper and was quickly silenced by Rogelio who put a hand on his arm. Lonnie clenched her fists, but didn't move.

"Why don't you make me company, Lonnie?" Catra drawled, voice dripping of faux friendliness. Lonnie took a deep breath and walked up to the throne.

"You see," Catra said, addressing the entire room. "While you all were taking your best shots at me, *Lonnie* here was crafty. She tracked me. She tricked me. She cornered me. She damned nearly got me. She took my *finger*."

"Isn't that right, Lonnie," she hissed.

She looked Lonnie in the eyes, her grin less friendly now. Lonnie met her eyes without blinking.

"Tell me Lonnie," Catra purred. "Why did you do it?"

"Because the leader of the Horde ordered me to," Lonnie answered without hesitation.

"Reaaally," Catra drawled. "And what will you do now, I wonder, with the orders you get from the leader of the Horde."

"I will follow them," Lonnie shot back. Catra nodded, almost undetectable, and Lonnie breathed out.

"I expect nothing less, *Force Commander* Lonnie," she said with loud voice.

She addressed the larger room.

"You all answer to her now. Anyone thinking of giving her or her boys shit... well, I'm not stopping you. Take your best shot." Her grin widened. "But know that it won't be enough."

Lonnie turned around. Staff in hand. A proud grin on her lips. She let her eyes slowly travel between the assembled Force Captains.

No one met her gaze.

"Go Lonnie!" Kyle cried, unable to stop himself any longer. Rogelio started to clap, and one by one, more or less reluctantly, the other force captains followed suit. Some of them looked disappointed or disgruntled, but a few also looked happy with this turn of events.

"That's all, for the moment," Catra said once the applauds were dying out. "You're all tired from the latest push and from the uncertainty these last few days. My new *Force Commander* here is big on down-time, so that's what we are going to do. Stand down on all fronts, hold your positions and keep your soldiers busy with repair and maintenance. You will all get your specific orders from Lonnie. The coronation will be tomorrow. Make sure to get some sleep. I promise you it will be a party to remember."

She silenced and let her gaze play over the assembly one last time, daring anyone to speak up.

No one did.

"Well then," Catra drawled. "Later."

And with Jack in tow, she left the room. Lonnie waited until she was gone until she started to shout orders.

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"Nervous, Sparkles?" Catra asked.

Catra wore a black top that clutched tight around her neck, with a diamond of cleavage visible. The Horde logo glowed blood red across her chest. A matching cape hung over her shoulders, and in her ears were large, golden rings brightly polished. On her right arm was a black brace and her mask had been reforged so that it framed her face, eerily similar in design to the Horde logo on her chest.

Glimmer raised an eyebrow as she put her new clothes in place. She was dressed in a regal, dark pink dress over purple tights. A black v-shaped belt held it together and on her chest a black Horde logo matched the one on Catra's top. She wore a high, white collar, held in place by a long, purple mantle with a blue gem glowing over her heart. Her pink hair was adorned by an elaborate crown with wicked spikes, in which a white, glowing gem was fastened, etched with the Horde logo.

"This is not my first coronation, you know, Catra," she said with dry voice.

"But it's not your usual crowd either," Catra smirked.

Glimmer smiled.

"Believe you me. If you are used to herding princesses, a room full of Horde soldiers are easy."

"I'll take your word for it, my queen," Catra laughed.

"What about you, Catra?" Glimmer asked.

"Eh, I've done this gig before," Catra shrugged.

"Yes, and a large portion of the people out there would kill you if they thought they could get away with it," Glimmer said frankly.

"Ooooh, well *that's* such a novel experience for me," Catra said with sarcastic voice. "The trick is, make sure they know they *won't* get away with it."

"They absolutely won't get away with it as long as I'm here," Glimmer said with a dangerous smile, and to her great delight she saw a little blush creep up Catra's face.

"What's that?" she teased. "Big bad cat not totally minding the princess having her back."

Catra blushed more and muttered something Glimmer couldn't hear.

"Cat got your tongue?" Glimmer asked.

"It's nothing," Catra quickly said. "Hey, let's go in. We have kept those schmucks waiting long enough."

To Glimmer's surprise, Jack stepped in front of Catra.

"Oh no, you don't," Jack said with a stern look.

Catra gave them a frustrated look, but the teenager held their own and crossed their arms in silent defiance.

"What are the two of you cooking up?" Glimmer said with a bemused smile.

For a moment, Catra looked like she would argue with Jack. Then she took a deep breath and turned to Glimmer, her cape flowing around her. She looked Glimmer in the eyes.

"Glimmer..." she begun.

Her voice trailed off.

"Catra," Glimmer answered in a clear 'I'm waiting' voice. Then her eyes popped wide open as Catra - after a last, pleading look at Jack which was met with a little encouraging gesture - sank down on one knee.

"Glimmer," Catra said, looking into her eyes. "You kick ass. Us kicking ass together is the best thing that ever happened to me. It brought us this far. I want to kick ass with you all the way. All the time."

She made a face and took another deep breath.

"OK, this is stupid..." she muttered. "I... I asked Double Trouble how you princesses do this and everything and..."

To a little whispered 'yeeeees' from Jack she took a big, golden ring from her ear and held it up to the speechless Glimmer.

"Do you want to be not only my partner-in-crime, but my *queen*, Glimmer? Do you want to marry me?"

"Catra..." Glimmer whispered eyes perfectly round.

"What's the matter," Catra said with a flippant voice that almost - but not entirely - managed to hide the nervousness underneath. "Cat got your tongue?"

"You know you did," Glimmer said and couldn't stop herself from smiling. "But why this? Why *now*."

Catra nodded at the door.

"For the longest time, I thought I wanted the big chair in there. I thought that was all there *was* for me to want." Her face formed a tender smile. "Then I met you."

"Catra..." Glimmer whispered, tears in her eyes.

"I just want you to know..." Catra said, struggling to keep her voice even. "I'm with you for the long run. This thing is not my endgame. You are. I'll go with wherever you go. I'll kick whatever ass you need kicking. I'll be with you for as long as you'll have me... if you'll have me."

Her voice died down to a whisper.

"Of course!" Glimmer blurted out. "Always, Catra. I want you, always.... I... I love you."

With trembling fingers she took the ear ring and fastened it in her ear, and then - breathing heavily - she took the large gem from her top. She fastened it on Catra's breast.

They stared at each other.

"You... do?" Catra whispered, like if she couldn't believe it.

"Of course I do," Glimmer answered, voice gaining in confidence. "I love you Catra. I want nothing more than to marry you."

She took Catra's hand.

"Let's kick ass together, now and always, *my queen*," she said, "starting with those schmucks in there."

Catra quickly got to her feet and then - slightly hesitant, if she was not sure how it would be received, leaned in for a kiss.

It was very well received, indeed.

"YES!" Jack cried and pumped a fist in the air as Glimmer and Catra separated. With a huge grin, they put a hand on the door.

"Are you ready?"

"Just one more thing," Glimmer said. She took a step closer, gently put her hands on the sides of Catra's face and removed her

mask. Catra stared at her, eyes large as Glimmer leaned forward and gave Catra a little peck on the cheek.

"I'll have your back, Kitten," she whispered. "Now and always."

"That's all I want," Catra whispered, furiously blinking to keep tears from her eyes.

"Now and always," Glimmer repeated, helping Catra put the mask back.

"Well then," Catra said after a few moments of composing herself. She took Glimmer's hand. "Shall we, my queen?"

"My queen," Glimmer answered, almost unconsciously touching her ear ring with her free hand, as if she wanted to reassure herself it was still there.

Hand in hand, they entered through the large doors to the throne room. They were met with a roar of a hundred throats.

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Horde soldiers lined the room. All of the big units were represented, including the senior officers (worst bandits) from Crimson Waste with Slither and Madeleine in the lead.

Glimmer's ladies-in-waiting had recruited again, and now fifteen of them stood as a unit of their own, dressed in purple robes and veils, clearly inspired by 'their' princess, lead by the one survivor from the assault of the Fright Zone who sat in a wheelchair.

Double Trouble and Lonnie stood on the stairs, very carefully positioned in a manner that wouldn't suggest either had the senior rank.

As they saw them, the crowd started chanting Catra's name.

'Catra! Catra! Catra!'

"Wasn't hard to win them over for you?" Glimmer asked as they regally walked along their ranks, Jack in tow.

"Eh, they were used to follow my orders anyway," Catra shrugged. "Half of them have never even seen Hordak, being stuck in his stupid old lab all the time."

"I'm happy for you, Kitten."

Double Trouble took in Glimmer's mismatched earrings and the gem on Catra's chest. Their smile grew wider.

"Catra and Glimmer!" They cried. "Queens of the Horde, *wives*, our glorious leaders!"

"I couldn't have done this without you, Sparkles," Catra said with low voice as the crowd cheered.

"Stop being all mushy and go sit on your throne already."

"Oh, I will..."

Catra let go of Glimmer and leaped up the stairs. She stood by the throne and held out her hand to Glimmer.

"...together with you."

Behind her, the Horde soldiers changed their chant.

'Glimmer! Glimmer! Glimmer!'

- - -

Her entire life, Glimmer had fretted about the throne that was her birth right. Was she good enough? Was she magical enough? Was she worthy enough? Was she ready?

Could she truly step into the shoes of her mother?

There had always been a part of her that strongly suspected the answer to those questions to be 'no'.

This was something else altogether.

This was a throne no one had expected her to have. This was a throne no one had wanted her to take. This was a throne that belonged to her by virtue of her deeds, not her linage.

The very fact that she had the throne was more proof than anyone could wish for that she was good enough for it.

The feeling was quite intoxicating. Catra smiled at her, a proud smile. She still held her hand towards Glimmer, and after another heartbeat of hesitation, Glimmer took it.

The soldiers roared in appreciation.

Catra and Glimmer sat down on the throne with the Horde soldiers cheering them on.

"Who rules the Horde?" Lonnie cried from the first step.

"Catra and Glimmer!" they cried in answer.

"Who do you obey?" Lonnie went on.

"Catra and Glimmer!" The soldiers roared.

"Who do you fight for?"

"Who do you die for?"

"Who do you win for?"

"*Catra and Glimmer!*"

The Horde soldiers roared on like people do when they have one line and have learnt it by heart. Glimmer squeezed Catra's hand and stood up. The crowd silenced. She held their silence with her gaze for a few moments, then she spoke. Her voice was soft but carried throughout the vast hall.

"Where do we go now?" she asked. There were some mumbles and a few enthusiastic "Catra and Glimmer" from the soldiers in the back who didn't really pay attention to stage prompts. The rest looked at Glimmer in hesitation.

"I will tell you where we go now," she said, her voice growing stronger. "We do the one thing the Horde has intended all along. The one thing the Horde has always failed. The one thing THE HORDE WILL NOT FAIL any longer."

She materialized her staff in her hand. It glowed bright with magic.

"THE HORDE WILL TAKE BRIGHTMOON!"

The cheers exploded throughout the room. Catra gave her a look full of admiration.

Chapter End Notes

Sweet, sweet taste of victory.

The diplomatic solution

Chapter Summary

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Um.... thanks for... receiving me, princess..."

"It's Queen, now, I think you will find," Glimmer said with sweet voice. Rogelio growled slightly from the side of the throne room.

The Plumerian envoy visibly shrunk back.

"Sorry, sorry, my Queen," he hastily said. "We... that is, Plumeria, want to congratulate you and your..." -he hesitated a moment as he glanced at Catra, clearly searching for words- "...queen," he ended up with.

Glimmer smiled, a pleased little smile.

Catra barred her fangs.

"Um, we want to congratulate you on your... ascension to the throne."

"The Queens of the Horde recognize Plumeria's gesture of goodwill," Glimmer said loftily.

"Yes, um..." the envoy continued. "We... we also wonder... um... what *policy* we might be expecting on... um... Horde *protected* areas."

"Why?" Glimmer said sweetly. "Are there any details in the current arrangement that need our attention?"

The envoy stared at her, eyes full of fears. Glimmer remembered the first time she had seen him. Seneschal had been one of the citizens of Plumeria that greeted her, Bow and Adora on their fist official 'Best Friend Squad' mission, and one of the ones who had most enthusiastically attacked the Horde Soldiers later when he, together with Perfuma, discovered the joy of hitting people with flowers.

He still had a flower wreath. Glimmer had come to realize the Plumerians regarded them as ceremonial, as important to his office as the crown was to her.

"The... Horde is... um... kinda occupying us," Seneschal said with frightened voice, staring at Glimmer's face.

"Occupying?" Glimmer said with mock scandalized voice. "Catra, are we *occupying* people?"

"Oh yes," Catra drawled. "The last boss was pretty big on it."

"Well then, have we received any complaints on this policy?" Glimmer asked with sweet voice.

"None that I have heard of," Catra leered.

"There we go, then," Glimmer said happily to Seneschal who watched them with weary eyes. "No reason to break established practise just because we have a new management..." she suddenly got a surprised expression, as if hit by a sudden thought. "...unless you are here to *register* a complaint?"

Catra's grin grew wider.

"We are our own kingdom. You know that, Queen Glimmer," Seneschal whispered, not daring to quite meet Glimmer's eyes. "Will the Horde soldiers leave?"

"Oh, of course," Glimmer said nonchalantly. "If the presence of the Horde soldiers are not welcome in the sovereign kingdom of Plumeria, we will withdraw immediately." She turned to Lonnie.

"See to it, Force Commander,"

"Yes, my Queen," Lonnie nodded.

Seneschal looked between Glimmer and Catra, clearly waiting for the other shoe.

"But Sparkles," Catra drawled. "What about the bandit raiders?"

"Bandit raiders?" Seneschal asked.

"Oh yes," Glimmer drawled. "It seems like there are bandits *everywhere* these days. And with Brightmoon unwilling and Snow unable to do anything about it... why, it seems it's up the Horde to keep law and order these days. Still, if Plumeria feel they can defend themselves without the Horde, that's your sake."

"We... we will manage," Seneschal swallowed.

"I know you will," Glimmer said with that kind of smile a fox gives a rabbit. "There is, however, another matter of security for us to discuss."

"Security?" Seneschal asked in trepidation

"I'm not talking as the leader of the Horde now, you understand I'm talking as a member of the princess alliance."

"The princess alliance couldn't defend Plumeria," Seneschal said, a trace of bitterness evident in his voice.

"I was not there," Glimmer sharply said. "I am, however here now. And I have obligations."

"Obligations?" Seneschal echoed.

"The Heart Blossom," Glimmer said with voice like a knife. "The runestone of plants. With Perfuma not present, it falls to me as the closest neighbour to defend it from Shadow Weaver."

She caught Seneschal's eyes.

"It must not fall in her hands."

"We can defend it," Seneschal protested.

"With all due respect," Glimmer said with a voice making clear how much respect she felt was due, "you can't. I, however, can."

"The Heart Blossom has dwelled in Plumeria since the time of the First Ones," Seneschal protested.

"So it has," Glimmer said, and for a moment something dark was seen in her eyes. Then she relaxed and gave Seneschal a soothing smile. "And so it will remain. I'm naturally not suggesting anything else. However, without a Horde presence in Plumeria, we will need to have contingencies."

"Such as?" Seneschal said with suspicious voice.

"The Horde will set up a fortification in the Whispering Woods, on the far side of Plumeria," Glimmer said matter-of-factly. We will need access to transport through Plumeria... communication... the occasional patrol staying the night... and in return we will be available for defence against raiders, should the need arise.... should you request it."

Catra smiled.

"We are also open to trade," Glimmer went on. "We are in great need of provisions and will buy any and all food Plumeria can provide - *without* any obligations. We will pay handsomely, naturally, in gear, in weapons, in soldiers, in *protection*."

"Protection," Catra repeated with a little smirk.

Glimmer looked the frightened man before the throne in the eyes.

"The Horde will leave Plumeria, as requested. Plumeria's sovereignty will not be called in dispute. But I will still be able to protect the Heart Blossom, the Horde will still be able to offer Plumeria protection. This is a good arrangement for all of us, and

far more generous than you had any right to bargain for. I trust there will be no objections."

Seneschal was fully aware of the attention of everyone in the room.

He swallowed.

"I remember when you first came to Plumeria, Queen Glimmer" he said with slow voice, as if talking to himself. "How some of us were... hesitant. How we feared the princess alliance threatened our way of life. Still, you did help us defend against the Horde."

"And now?" Glimmer asked, her voice sharp as a whip.

"Now the Horde is defending us against Brightmoon," he sighed. "Strange, how the wheel turn."

"If there is nothing more..." Glimmer begun, but Seneschal looked her in the eyes.

"Plumeria accepts your offer, Queen Glimmer. Both your withdrawal and your... protection, and we do so with all gratitude you are due. I do however have two more things to discuss, if you will indulge me for yet a few moments. A piece of information, freely given, and a question, with no prize offered for the answer other than our goodwill."

"Let's hear it," Glimmer spat, still somewhat off balance.

"Something happened to the Heart Blossom, just a few days ago," he said. "It went completely dull, like it had been cut off from the magic of the world completely. It lasted for well over an hour, then it went back to normal. We don't know what it means, but I think the 'princess alliance' should know.

"I see," Glimmer said, getting her voice under control. "And the question?"

Seneschal looked her in the eyes.

"Do you know where Perfuma is, Glimmer?"

- - -

"That went well," Lonnie commented after he left. "Fortification, transport and provision. We lost the land itself, but we got everything we need from it for only a fraction of the cost in manpower."

She gave Glimmer an appreciating smile

"If you forgive me for saying so, my Queen, I start to realize how the Princess alliance managed to hold us at bay all this time."

"The Horde has never been in the right mindset for building alliances," Glimmer sighed.

"Until now," Double Trouble drawled.

"Until now," Glimmer agreed.

"You know to be quite the mean girl, Sparkles," Catra said with just a hint of apprehension in her voice. "Somehow I thought you would want to dial it back with your old buddies."

"Yes, a lot of people will expect that," Glimmer sighed. "So I have to make an example of poor Seneschal and the others like him."

She took Catra's hand.

"The princess alliance in the last day was... it was a mess. Everyone bickering, no one daring to make any decision. Thanks to outside 'help', certainly" -she gave the grinning Double Trouble a stern look- "but it nevertheless formed an impression I can't afford to carry with me to the Horde." Her eyes became hard. "Last time Seneschal saw me, he saw a poor little girl wringing her hands about her friends not listening to her. This time he - *everyone* - need to know that I'm in *control*, or we will have our hands full with everyone's petty little problems. And that we can't afford. Not until we have dealt with Shadow Weaver."

"Well, I'm impressed," Catra said with a little squeeze of Glimmer's hand. "And I can help bully these goons for you just fine. You might have to give me a few pointers on the 'listen to their petty problems' part later on, though."

Lonnie didn't roll her eyes, which probably took some work.

"All I need you to be is yourself," Glimmer said with a fond smile that grew wider as a faint red spot could be seen on Catra's cheek.

Lonnie loudly cleared her throat to put a stop to further flirting.

"You're no fun," Catra muttered.

"You promoted me to be efficient, not fun," Lonnie said with a pointed look at her clip-board.

"I can be both!" Double Trouble contributed.

Glimmer - ignoring Double Trouble - gave Lonnie an almost pleading look. "We haven't heard...?"

"No, my queen," the Force Commander, answered, voice neutral. "We have halted the offensive against Snow, as ordered, and we are preparing to bring home our forces. Frosta's forces have taken the opportunity to consolidate their positions rather than mount a counter attack. But we have not had any formal contact."

"And we don't know...?" Glimmer begun.

Lonnie shook her head.

"No words on Perfuma, my Queen," she answered. "We know for a fact that the wind princess was in Snow just a few days before your takeover, unless Snow has another way of summoning storms we don't know about. But the flower princess haven't been spotted in the field for several weeks."

"If you want to send an official envoy to Frosta," Double Trouble began, "I'd be more than happy to tell the little brat that..."

"No," Glimmer said quickly. "I will talk to my fellow princesses myself when the time is due. Right now, we have to focus on stabilizing our positions until we are ready to move against Brightmoon."

"Not to mention put all the people who think we will be the soft option now that Hordak is gone out of their delusions," Catra growled. She turned to Lonnie. "Who's next?"

Lonnie looked at the list in her hands.

"We got some force captains that desperately want to discuss how their standing orders change with Hordak gone, a couple of representatives from the free cities. A gathering of 'concerned citizens' from Salineas..."

"They want to know if the old bribes are still good or if the rate has gone up," Double Trouble happily supplanted.

"And there is an envoy from Mystacor," Lonnie finished.

Glimmer gave her a frightened look.

"...Mystacor?" she whispered.

"The head sorceress," Lonnie said. She gave Glimmer a direct look. "Your aunt. Should I send her in or..."

"Yes," Glimmer said quickly. "Yes, do that."

"Sparkles..." Catra said with careful voice. "Are you..."

"I can handle it," Glimmer said quickly.

She took a deep breath.

"We are going after the most skilled sorceress this world has seen in a millennium. We will need the support of Mystacor." Her voice

grew harder. "And they need us. And if Castaspella thinks I'm still a little girl she can bribe with candy, it's better to put her out of that notion sooner rather than later."

"Could *I* bribe you with candy, my queen?" Double Trouble leered.

"Sorry, you're not sweet enough for my taste," Glimmer said loftily, earning herself a wink from Double Trouble and a growl from Catra, who looked slightly less worried, if not entirely mollified.

In the meanwhile, Lonnie had walked over to the huge doors and walked outside. She returned just a few moments later with Castaspella in tow.

"Queen Catra, Queen Glimmer," she bellowed with formal voice. "I announce the Head Sorceress of Mystacor, Castaspella."

The short woman walked with quick but even steps to the foot of the throne. She was dressed in her formal regalia, but still looked as comfortable as if this had been a tea party in Brightmoon. She bent her head slightly and then she looked up.

She didn't say anything, she just looked in silence at Glimmer.

The silence stretched. Catra glanced at Glimmer. Her co-queen stared at the woman in front of them. Castaspella looked back, a smile mixing concern and pride on her lips.

"Hello, auntie," Glimmer finally whispered.

"Glimmer," Castaspella said with warm voice. "On a different throne than last time I saw you. You have done well for yourself."

"I..." Glimmer begun, but the word got stuck in her throat.

"And the infamous Force Commander Catra," Castaspella said and moved her gaze to the feline. "Sorry, I mean *Queen* Catra. Quite the catch for my niece, if you don't mind me saying. I'm glad to see the two of you together. Thanks for taking care of her."

"I... I do as good as I can," Catra said, taken back by the compliment.

"You have, however, done things very difficult for me, I'm afraid," Castaspella tutted. "A royal wedding on the fly, not a moment of warning. How is a poor aunt supposed to find a suitable gift in time."

"Oh..." Glimmer said, taken aback. "You really don't have to..."

"Don't underestimate me, Glimmer," Castaspella said with a gleam in her eyes and handed a lasciviously wrapped box to Lonnie who clearly had no idea what to do with it. "Allow me, with this little token of auntly love, to welcome Catra to the family." She smiled, a warm smile at the flustered feline. "We're glad to have you, Catra."

"Casta..." Glimmer whispered, eyes large and wet.

"So many formidable people I have seen in my days," Castaspella mused, "wowing to do what the two of you have done. Light Spinner, my brother, your mother... even She-Ra herself. All of them promised to take down Hordak. But it was the two of you who did it in the end, with nothing but your own strength and wits and what allies you could scrounge up in a desert. My congratulations."

"I ..." Glimmer begun, but Castaspella's face got harder.

"Hordak is out, yet the flag of the Horde still fly from the shores of Snow to Salineas, in Elberon and all the way to the Crimson Waste. Yet, the armies march and yet tyrants and usurpers sit on the Throne of Archnidia..." she sighed. "Don't get me wrong, Glimmer. I *am* both impressed by your successes and grateful for your deeds, but you must understand that a lot of people are scared."

She looked Glimmer in the eyes.

"A lot of people want answers. Their questions are not unreasonable."

"And that's why you are here?" Glimmer asked, some angry red colouring her otherwise pale face. "For answers?"

"I might be here for a lot of things," Castaspella enigmatically answered, "depending on what answers you give me, *your majesties*."

"Very well, ask your questions," Glimmer said, perhaps unconsciously sitting up as tall as she could, suddenly very self conscious about how tiny she looked in the enormous throne.

"What will happen now, Glimmer?" Castaspella asked with gentle voice. "Will the Horde withdraw their forces?"

"The Horde will defeat Shadow Weaver," Glimmer said coldly. "I'm not here for Scorpia's thrones. I'm here for the means to take back my own."

"And then?" Castaspella asked gently.

"And then *what*?" Glimmer spat.

"What will you do when you rule the world?" Castaspella asked, making a little nod to Catra to make sure it was understood that 'you' was in plural.

"We will rule fairly and wisely, auntie," Glimmer said with sarcastic voice. "That's what you want me to answer, right?"

"What I want is less important than what you intend," Castaspella said with unperturbed voice. "And being good queens is one of your options."

"Did you have any other in mind," Glimmer asked, desperately trying to force herself to calm down.

"There are many kinds of rulers..." Castaspella said with a pointed look at the Horde emblem. "There are even those who allow their subjects to rule themselves."

"You'd have us withdraw?" Glimmer asked. "Leave the entire world as a free-for-all between every robber and pirate? I saw quite enough of that in the Crimson Waste."

"You emerged victorious in the Crimson Waste," Castaspella commented.

"Yes," Glimmer said, her angers rising. "We *did* emerge victorious. We *did* beat every other asshole in Crimson Waste. We *did* defeat Hordak - the one thing no one else in this world could do as you so rightly said yourself. And we *will* defeat Shadow Weaver, whatever you or anyone else have to say about it."

Castaspella did not react to Glimmer's outburst. She regarded her in silence for a moment, her head slightly cocked to the side.

"You know," she said after a moment, "Me and your father, we often spent our summers with some relatives, not far from Elberon. The two of you are so much alike that sometimes, when I think of me and my brother as little tykes, playing around by the brooks at the edge of the forest, I can so easily see you in his stead."

"I don't see..." Glimmer begun between gritted teeth.

"What would you have me say if it really *was* you, a you free from obligations of crowns and gems, growing up in that place, when the Horde flag suddenly waved over Elberon. What would you do, were it you who saw armies marching into the free cities where you grew up?"

"I have not..." Glimmer spat, but Castaspella interrupted her.

"We both know the answer. The headstrong girl I saw grow up, who knew right from wrong and who defended the weak with a passion even when her mother was afraid to move, she would be

a *nightmare* for the Horde invaders." Castaspella looked Glimmer in the eyes. "Let me give you a friendly reminder, Glimmer, that you are not the only headstrong little girl in Etheria. I *strongly* suggest you conduct your business with Shadow Weaver quickly, or you will find that holding the world is not as easy as it was for you and your lovely wife to conquer it in the first place."

"Do not speak to me like I'm just your niece," Glimmer snarled. "I'm the queen of the Horde now. I hope I finally have proven to you that I'm not just a little girl."

"Very well," Castaspella said. "Mystacor wishes to apologise to the leader of the Horde. This is neither the time nor the place for personal issues and I do beg you pardon for my presumptions."

"Casta..." Glimmer begun, but Castaspella shook her head.

"You wish to focus on our official business, Queen Glimmer, very well. We have much to discuss."

"Yes, we do," Glimmer said, quickly regaining her composure. "Starting with Shadow Weaver. She single-handedly took Brightmoon, yet no one is posing any serious threat against her, no one except me and Catra. What help can we expect from Mystacor when we move against her?"

"What help would you want?" Castaspella immediately shot back.

"The support of the head sorceress and the most skilled of the teaching staff, for one," Glimmer immediately said. "Detection spells and counter spells and protection. Maybe even some offence if that wouldn't tax you too much. Three teams of sorcerers, prepared to work in shift."

"Nothing more?" Castaspella asked with sarcastic voice. "Only the near total draft of the Mystacor senior staff to the Horde? Hordak himself couldn't have asked for more."

"I am not Hordak," Glimmer said with cold voice.

"You are most decidedly not," Castaspella said. "*He* was a conqueror, and a failed one at that. *You* are a ruler. How you plan to rule will affect a great many people."

"I asked for aid and I got platitudes," Glimmer said with cold voice. "If that is all that Mystacor has to offer..."

"Mystacor has plenty to offer, as you well know," Castaspella said with soothing voice. "Only, it's not the thing you are asking for."

"Then by all means, illuminate me," Glimmer snarled.

"Neutrality," Castaspella said with even voice. "A meeting ground. A facilitator, a diplomat. A place where different sides can meet to sort out their differences."

"You *must* be kidding me," Glimmer snorted.

"I'm not talking about Shadow Weaver," Castaspella calmly said. "I'm talking about you. The two of you and the rest of the world."

"Convenient," Glimmer said, voice dry. "You offer me help with the last thing I need. You propose to set the dinner table for my victory celebration - incidently gaining a place by it for yourself - but no support for winning the victory that you propose to help me celebrate."

"You are a child of war," Castaspella said with sad voice. "You have never experienced peace. I promise you it can be just as daunting as war. Do not dismiss Mystacor's offer so easily."

"Still see me as a child, do you?" Glimmer said, and it was evident that her anger started to flare up.

"I see you as a queen," Castaspella said calmly.

"Then treat me like one," Glimmer demanded.

"I do," Castaspella answered. "I give the same answer Mystacor has given every queen, king, princess, captain or general for the

last thousand years who asked for our involvement in their disputes."

"And how many of those involved the end of the world?" Glimmer asked with sarcastic voice.

"Before the arrival of Hordak? None, as far as I know," Castaspella answered.

"Then perhaps this would be the time for Mystacor to get off their high horse and sacrifice their oh-so-important principles," Glimmer snarled. "Perhaps if you had done so earlier, things would not have come to this."

"Yes, that is an opinion that has been aired before," Castaspella said with dry voice. "Interestingly, by the only other person who has shared both your thrones."

"Shadow Weaver never sat on the this throne," Glimmer said with cold voice. "And she's an usurper to the throne of Brightmoon. The most powerful sorceress Mystacor has trained in any of our life times has *stolen* my throne. Don't you *dare* sit this one out."

"Some would say she has the same claim to your throne that you have to the throne of Hordak," Castaspella said, quick as a viper.

Double Trouble took a small step forward, as if preparing to intervene.

"It's not the same thing," Glimmer shouted, clenching her fists so hard her knuckles turned white.

"No, it isn't," Castaspella said calmly. "Brightmoon is not a bandit camp. The throne is not the price in a bout of jostling. Shadow Weaver is no more Queen of Brightmoon than Hordak was Queen of Archnidia." She sighed. "Angella was Queen of Brightmoon, by count of established order of succession, by count of the people accepting - adoring - her and by count of her connection to the runestone of the moon." She looked Glimmer in the eyes. "By all those counts, the rightful ruler of Brightmoon is not that usurper

that claims the title. It's the very woman who I now stand before. Isn't that right, Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon?"

"Of course..." Glimmer, suddenly loosing the trail of her indignation.

"And as such," Castaspella went on, "Brightmoon and the moonstone are your responsibilities. The lengths you have gone to speak for how serious you take that responsibility. I know you will do your utmost to rid Brightmoon of the witch *you* invited, the one who grew in strength in the kingdom *you* now have taken over - including its obligations."

"It's all my fault, is it?" Glimmer growled. "...WELL, IS IT?" she shouted when Castaspella didn't answer.

"Is that really what you think I'm saying?" Castaspella said with said voice.

"What *are* you saying?" Glimmer snarled.

"I'm saying that I - just as many other - are offering you help, only it's not the help you hope for or the help you think you need," Castaspella said soothingly.

Her eyes might have flickered to Catra.

"Mystacor is not offering you military aid, neither would we be of much use to you if we were. Surely the leader of the princess alliance and the rightful Queen of the moon have more power to her disposal than us mere peddler of tricks can muster. In addition, the help we actually *do* provide is far more important than any change we could hope to offer on the battle field."

"And what help is that?" Glimmer sighed, sinking back on the throne. "And if you say 'diplomatic help' I will..."

"There are still arcane secrets hidden from Shadow Weaver's prying eyes - secrets that are hidden for good reasons. We keep

them away from her, as well as we can. To a great cost in life and power, I might add. You are welcome."

"That's the help you offer me then, as I attempt to do the impossible a gain," Glimmer said with bitter voice. "Unspecified and unverified secrets kept away from our enemy, and diplomatic meddling once the victory is secured?"

"Don't dismiss either," Castaspella said and gave Glimmer a compassionate look. "And we do have one more thing to offer."

"Do I even want to ask what?" Glimmer sighed.

"Advice," Castaspella simply said. "If you care to hear it."

"I could have used your advice after my mother died," Glimmer muttered, causing Catra to shift uneasily in the seat next to her.

"Why?" Castaspella asked. "There were no lack of voices telling you to steer clear of Shadow Weaver. Would my addition to the chorus really have made a difference?"

For a moment Glimmer glared at her with eyes full of hate, but she gained control over herself.

"Fine, point taken and blame accepted," she muttered. "Let's hear what pearls of wisdom the high and mighty scholars of Mystacor have for us poor queens this time."

"You are one of only two people I've ever known that Shadow Weaver does not underestimate," Castaspella said with serious voice. "The other being your father."

"That's a statement of fact, not an advice," Glimmer said with rather whiny voice.

"Yes," Castaspella answered. "Another statement of fact is that Shadow Weaver thrive on the lonely and the isolated. She does not relate to other people without using them." She smiled fondly at Catra by Glimmer's side. "The two of you being together... the

two of you forming a relationship out of love rather than utility... that's one of the worst possible things that could happen to her, one of the last things she could possibly plan for."

She bowed.

"My advice is, take care of each other, Glimmer and Catra. What you have is good, what you have is worth having, and what you have will allow you win in the end."

"...thank you, auntie," Glimmer said weakly.

"Think nothing of it, Castaspella said. "And let Mystacor know when our diplomatic services are welcome."

She bowed again.

"Until then, my queens."

And Castaspella left the room, flanked by Rogelio.

No one said anything, all the rest of them taking turns to glance more or less surreptitiously at Glimmer, who stared at nothing.

"So, that was your aunt," Catra said eventually.

"Yeah," Glimmer sighed. "Family dinners were bundles of fun, let me tell you."

"She sure used a lot of words to tell us she's sitting this one out," Lonnie grumped.

"She said a lot more than that," Double Trouble said with admiration in their voice. "What a remarkable woman. Is she single?"

"I hereby expressively forbid you to make a move on my aunt," Glimmer said, not entirely able to keep her amusement from her voice.

"No promises, my queen," Double Trouble drawled.

"What do you want me to do with this?" Lonnie asked, holding up the gift like she had no idea what it was.

"Open it," Glimmer said with absent voice. "She could just as well get the last word."

"Huh, oil?" Lonnie said, holding up a dainty little bottle. "I didn't take her for much of a mechanic."

"In a manner of speaking she is," Double Trouble said, eyes glowing as they glanced over Lonnie's shoulder at the multitude of bottles and jars in the box. A wonderful air of perfume moved through the throne room.

"She won't help us with Shadow Weaver, but at least we can give each other a relaxing massage," Glimmer sighed.

"You OK, Sparkles?" Catra asked with worried voice.

"Sure," Glimmer muttered and rubbed her temples.

"Perhaps my Queens should retreat to focus on higher matters," Double Trouble suggested and nodded meaningfully at the package Lonnie still peered into with suspicious expression. "Leave the trivial riff-raff to me and commander Grumpy-pants here."

"I should be seen," Glimmer muttered. "Should let them know that I'm a Queen too, not just Catra's hang-around."

"Ah," Double Trouble said happily. "Now there's a problem with an easy solution."

And with a little twirl they took Glimmer's visage.

"You think you can handle it?" Glimmer asked, the challenging edge to her voice not quite managing to hide the gratitude..

"I know how you like to play the political game, my Queen," Double Trouble leered with their own voice coming from Glimmer's

mouth (which made Catra feel conflicted and complicated feelings). "I'll give the free cities the Plumeria treatment and grant them freedom for dependency. I'll grab the pouch of the penny-pinchers from Salineas. I will let Lonnie here bully the force captains at her own leisure, and if need be, I will threaten with the Kitty-Cat."

Catra gave Double Trouble a direct look.

"And you won't play your own little games by the side?"

They gave her a faux wounded look.

"Please, my Queen. Would I ever abuse your trust?"

Catra held their gaze in silence for a moment, then she turned to Lonnie.

"Don't hesitate to stab them if they need it."

"Yes my Queen," Lonnie said with a little smirk. She put her hand on the dagger at her side and gave Double Trouble a calculating look.

"Your skill in encouraging loyalty is legendary," Double Trouble laughed. They skipped up the throne.

"Don't worry, my Queens. I'll take good care of your kingdom." Their voice softened. "Now go and take care of each other."

"Yes, my Queen, let's." Glimmer held out her hand to Catra. After a moment of hesitation, Catra took it.

Together they left the room through one of the side doors.

"Send in the mayor of Thaymor," Double Trouble said to Lonnie with Glimmer's voice. "We have *so* much we're *dying* to discuss with them."

Chapter End Notes

I kinda wish I had written the scene where they made use of Castaspella's gift. Oh well.

A truly magical moment

Chapter Notes

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra stalked the corridors in fury, angry cadets and force captains slipping away as they saw her. She heard them laughing behind her back.

The Horde flag flew over Salineas, over Elberon, over Thaymor. It was not enough. It would never be enough.

Not until she had taken Brightmoon.

Then she would have shown them.

She snarled at her badge.

Why the hell didn't Scorpia pick up?

Thump, thump, thump, came the scrapings and crawlings from the vents, but Catra ignored them. Just keep running, that was the ticket. Never look back, never show fear, otherwise the shadows would take you.

She ran through the corridors. Someone was staying ahead of her. Just around the next corner, but however she tried, she couldn't catch up. They knew, *they knew*, they were going to tell Hordak about Entrapta unless she silenced them.

Adora had abandoned her. She chose the princess over her.

Catra would make her sorry. She would make *everyone* sorry.

The woman she tried to reach was just one step ahead. She saw the tip of her claws, her blonde hair, her sparkly cape, but always too late, too late.

'Wait,' Catra tried to call, tears streaming down her face. 'Don't leave me!', but no sounds left her lips.

A purple light, just ahead, pulsing and throbbing. With her heart full of misgivings, Catra entered the Black Garnet chamber.

A short figure, draped in cloth and shadows and sparks and stars stood by the runestone. Catra wanted to run, but her feet was as glued to the floor. Shadows tugged at her, tried to drag her down.

"I told you to keep out, Catra," the voice of her childhood nightmares hissed. "If you did, you could have been happy, but no, here you are. Now, what shall I do with you."

Shadow Weaver turned around and stared impassionately at Catra.

Catra tried to scream, but no sounds left her lips.

Catra opened her eyes. She was in the bed Kyle had rigged up for her and Glimmer - rather luxurious by Horde standard.

She breathed sharply, in and out.

Then she relaxed.

A dream.

Of course the old witch would find a way to worm back into her dreams.

She glanced beside her, but the spot Glimmer had occupied - a warm little ball of glitter, even if she probably wouldn't appreciate hearing Catra call her that - was empty and cold. The smell of the perfumed oils Castaspella had given them still lingered.

Catra sighed and got up. She dressed and splashed some water in her face.

"What's the status?" She gruffed to the guard outside her door, a soldier named Crustatia who Lonnie had hand picked as potential officer material.

"Everything's calm, my queen!" Crustatia said and scrambled to her feet. Force Commander Lonnie has a report for you as soon as it suits you, Force Captain Kyle says the repairs of the foundry is going faster than anticipated and... eh... Communication Liaison Double Trouble...?"

She trailed off and gave Catra an apologetic look.

"They haven't got a title, it would just go to their head," Catra muttered. "What do they have to say?"

"Er... that 'all the little kids are playing nice - for now'.

"That means there's no mutiny brewing today, which is about as good as it gets," Catra said. "Where is Glimmer," she added with low voice.

"Um, Queen Glimmer left together with her apprentice about an hour ago," Crustatia answered, fiddling nervously with her claws. "I didn't inquire as to where..."

"Don't bother, I know where she is," Catra sighed. "Thank you, that will be all."

With a last nod to the soldier, she walked out to the corridor and made her way to the Black Garnet chamber.

- - -

Purple light flowed out of the room when Catra opened the door. She glanced at the two silhouettes before the Black Garnet in slight apprehension, but she steeled herself and walked in.

Fucking witch wouldn't affect her.

Glimmer looked... adorable. She had not her Queen outfit on, but a simpler romper Double Trouble had conjured up for her. She had thrown on an oversized jacket - probably stolen from a force captain's uniform - which made her look almost like a child, playing around with the grown-ups clothes.

Catra glanced at the Black Garnet and shuddered.

Jack was next to her, staring intently at a terminal connected to the runestone. Glimmer held a magical construct in her hands, modifying it slightly as Jack quickly muttered a stream of numbers that apparently meant something for the two of them.

"Hi Sparkles," Catra said and walked in. "Hi Jack. Up early today?"

"Early bird, you know," Glimmer smiled and tucked a strand of hair behind her ear, causing the construct to wobble as she did. "Hordak did a number on Scorpia's runestone, so it will take some work to figure out."

"I'm glad we have our best and brightest on it," Catra said with just a hint of sarcasm in her voice. "In the meantime, have you had any thoughts to spare on our *other* little project?

"I haven't forgotten Shadow Weaver if that's what you're asking," Glimmer said with dry voice.

"Glad to hear it," Catra answered. "So, what will our play be?"

"We need to cut her off from the Moonstone," Glimmer answered with serious voice. "My mother could hold the castle alone if she had to, and Shadow Weaver has access to tricks my mother would never imagine."

"How are we doing that?" Catra asked, slightly apprehensive.

"There is a cave," Glimmer said with low voice, "under the castle. If I can get there, get past the guardian... I could re-align to the moonstone. I should be able to cut her out."

"Should?" Catra asked.

"Should," Glimmer confirmed

They watched each other in silence for a moment.

"What do you need?" Catra asked, showing her teeth.

"Distraction," Glimmer answered smirking back at her. "I need Shadow Weaver to look elsewhere."

Catra grinned.

"Well, we *do* have an army."

Glimmer matched her grin.

"Exactly my thought."

"Would be a shame if were never got to use it."

"I hear you."

Their grins were bloodthirsty in the flickering light from the Black Garnet.

"Two routs to the Fright Zone," Catra mused. "By sea or through the Whispering Woods."

"We go by sea," Glimmer said firmly.

"Very well," Catra answered. "I'll tell Lonnie and Octavia to prepare. We'll be ready in three days."

"Thanks, Catra," Glimmer said and gave her a quick peck on the cheek.

Catra left the Black Garnet chamber, and as she did she saw the purple light start pulsate from the old runestone again.

She shuddered.

- - -

Catra strolled down the corridors of the Fright Zone, taking the long way towards the throne room. Her feet walked automatically, following twists and turn in the corridors hard coded into them.

"Home sweet home," Catra muttered to herself.

There were voices coming from around the next corner, so she sneaked closer.

"So what, we're just going to wait?" one of the soldiers gruffed.

"Not for long," Force Captain Cobolt answered. "Catra is not one to let the grass grow under her feet."

"Indeed not," Catra hissed behind them and had the great satisfaction of seeing Cobolt jump. He spun around and stood to attention.

"My Queen!" he quickly said.

"Force Captain," she said with a little smirk. "I trust you're not growing bored?"

"Of course not, my Queen," Cobolt said with a hard look at the solider.

"Don't worry," Catra drawled. "You'll have all the action you can ask for once we get to Brightmoon. Queen Glimmer assures me it'll be truly *magical*."

"Ye-es, my Queen," Cobolt answered, clearly not sure what to read into the statement.

"In the meanwhile I'll suggest you keep up the maintenance. Don't want Force Commander Lonnie to catch you slacking, eh?"

"No, my Queen," Cobolt answered.

"Don't worry, it'll be our little secret," Catra said and winked at him. She held his gaze for another moment, and then - chuckling to herself - she walked on down the corridor. Cobolt waited until she was almost out of earshot before he started urgently whisper something to the solider.

Catra smirked - after all these years he still hadn't caught on to just how sharp her hearing was.

It was such a strange feeling, being back. How she had hated this place. How she had felt it suffocate her. In hindsight, it felt like she hadn't been able to breath properly for years. Not until she found herself a fugitive together with a malfunctioning princess on the back roads.

And now she was back.

Back to echoing corridors and stinking machines and people fearing her and hating her whispering behind every corner.

Still, it was different this time around. This time she had Glimmer.

Catra glanced at the gem Glimmer had put on her breast.

This time she had Glimmer.

This time it would all be different.

Her feet stopped, and it took her brain a moment to realize that they had followed whatever route they decided on to the end. She looked up, and realized that she stood by the door to Scorpia's old quarters.

With a sour frown she went to find Lonnie instead.

- - -

"There you are," Glimmer said happily as she with Jack in tow entered the throne room some time later. Catra was sitting on one

of the lower footsteps, munching on a ration bar and looking at a map.

Glimmer leaned forward to peck Catra on the cheek, and when the feline looked up at her she pinched a crumb from her ration bar.

Catra growled and Glimmer gave her a smug smile.

"How's the princessing going?" she asked and tossed Jack half of the remaining bar and handed the other half to Glimmer.

"Good thanks," Glimmer said and raised the crumbling bar in a salute. "We have disabled most of the connections Hordak added to the stone. We're keeping a few monitoring programs though. They might be useful."

Catra arched an eyebrow.

"Really?"

"It would be naive to assume that Shadow Weaver won't attempt something with the Black Garnet eventually." She gave Catra a direct look. "I for one am done being naive."

"That's good," Catra said, "because we have an invasion to plan, and since it's your castle I thought you might have some input."

"I have looked at some of your old plans to reach Brightmoon together with Lonnie," Glimmer said.

She shuddered.

"They were... good," she said.

"There were some blind spots," Catra commented.

"I noticed," Glimmer said. "I filled them in. There are some shortcuts... some easier routes, oh, and a few of those towers have not been manned for years."

"I knew *that*, Sparkles," Catra grinned. "You don't think Double Trouble's only mission was to stir up trouble for you and Adora, do you?"

"I suppose not," Glimmer said, voice slightly melancholic. "Still, with Shadow Weaver in charge, there are other plans we have to make."

"Such as?" Catra said.

"Such as what new surprises she has in store for us," Glimmer said. She looked at the map.

"Magic?" Catra asked.

"What else," Glimmer said with an eye-roll. "For Shadow Weaver everything is a nail."

"Well, what do we expect?" Catra asked.

Glimmer took a pen and started to draw thin lines over the map.

"Magic will flow most easily along these routes," she explained, glancing at Jack. "That means that everywhere there are lines crossing, there will be a convergence point where she most easily can set traps or other surprises."

"So we avoid them?" Jack asked.

"*We* avoid them," Glimmer agreed, "But they are certain to have monitoring spells as well so she'll know when one trap is triggered. If we set them off at once, she'll have a much harder time picking up our *real* advanced from the noise."

"Bots!" Catra promptly said. "We'll send a bunch of them to each focus point, and a first wave avoiding them to go for the main defences. While she's figuring that out we open fire with long range artillery." She grinned at Glimmer. "Sorry, we might put a dent in that fancy castle of yours."

"You seem to have this figured out," Glimmer said with dry voice.

"We *have* been fighting princesses before, Sparkles," Catra said drily. "The trick is to keep you occupied so you don't see the sucker punch coming."

"The sucker punch in this case being me," Glimmer said.

"Yeah," Catra said, suddenly sincere. "As long as Shadow Weaver clings to that runestone, we'll have no other choice but to wear her down, and slippery as she is I don't like our chances. Lonnie won't like it, but this is *exactly* the time for a princess trick."

"Glad to be contributing," Glimmer said drily.

"You think your cave will be it?" Catra asked.

Glimmer nodded.

"That's my best bid to get back control of the Moonstone. And even if I don't, I'll at least be able to keep her at bay for a little while."

"For how long?" Catra asked.

"For long enough, I'd say," Glimmer said with a pointed look at Catra's claws. "I assume it will be over fairly quick."

"And if you *do* gain control of the runestone yourself?" Catra asked.

Glimmer looked her in the eyes.

"Then it will be over *very* quick."

"Just wanted to make sure we are on the same page on that," Catra muttered.

"I made the mistake of letting her live once," Glimmer said with low voice. "I'm not doing that again."

"I hear you," Catra said.

"And you?" Glimmer pressed.

"I so desperately wanted her to be proud of me. Just once I wanted her to say it..." Catra sighed.

"...and?" Glimmer asked, slight trepidation in her voice.

"And she used it to escape," Catra sighed. "To you. Yeah, I'm done making that mistake as well."

Glimmer took her hands.

"She blind-sided us. Shame on us. This time we have each other's back. If she wants to hurt you again, she'll have to go through me." She looked Catra in the eyes. "And you better believe me when I say that I am *very* proud of you.

"You protecting me against bullies will never not be hot," Catra smirked, and she bent her head upwards and caught Glimmer in a kiss.

They kissed for a long time before Lonnie loudly cleared her throat over by the door.

"Work, work, work," Catra sighed as she and Glimmer separated. "What do you have for us, Lonnie?"

"The force captains are here to discus the push against Brightmoon," Lonnie said. She gave Glimmer a pointed look. "...as soon as your current debriefing is over."

"It's OK," Glimmer said and stood up, putting her clothes in order." Me and Jack have our own preparations to make together with my Ladies-in-waiting. We'll leave you to it?"

"You're not wanna stay and listen to me bullying the minions, Sparkles?" Catra smirked.

"You are perfectly capable of doing that on your own," Glimmer said with dry voice. "Talk to you later, my queen."

She bent forward and gave Catra another quick kiss. Then she left the chamber

Catra looked after her for a moment. Then she stood up straight and kicked away the remaining crumbs of the ration bar. She ascended the throne and made sure her mask was on right.

"Very well, let them in," The Queen of the Horde said with hard voice.

Lonnie nodded to Rogelio who opened the door wide. About twenty officers entered the room - more or less apprehensive, more or less eager - to get their first assignments.

Catra didn't say anything. She just let her gaze linger on each face, as if she committed their features to memory.

"Where is Force Captain Fang?" she demanded.

"They had an accident," Lonnie replied with even voice. Catra raised an eyebrow.

"Really? What kind of an 'accident'?"

"The kind of accident you have when you try to pick on Kyle," Lonnie answered.

A small growl was heard. It wasn't very loud, but for those who had come to recognize it, Force Captain Rogelio's laughter made an impression.

Catra smirked.

"Very well. Force Captain Kyle?"

"Ye-yes Queen Catra?" Kyle said.

"When *cadet* Fang is ready to return to service in your unit, I trust you will keep them in line. We don't want to see any more... accidents, do we?"

"No Queen Catra," he answered with a rare, smug smile. Catra held his gaze for a moment and answered with a toothy grin of her own.

She leaned back in the throne.

"Right! What's our situation?"

- - -

Catra felt jittery as she left the throne room. An old anxiety from the last time she commanded the Horde. That feeling of always expecting another shoe to drop, always looking for the dagger before it hit your back.

Octavia stood leaning against the wall in the hallway outside the throne room, clearly waiting for her.

"Octavia," Catra said with even voice.

"Boss," Octavia answered with jovial voice. "So, we're finally doing it?"

"Yup," Catra confirmed. "We're taking Brightmoon."

Octavia watched her in silence for a moment.

"You know," she said with what for her counted as a soft voice. "There is not a man, woman or otherwise in the Fright Zone who has not at one point or another itched to take a swing at Shadow Weaver."

Catra arched an eyebrow.

"Really?"

"Really," Octavia confirmed. "Don't get me wrong, the old witch could get things done if she wanted to. Most of the time she didn't want to. Also, she was a creep."

"Still is," Catra said matter-of-factly.

"I expect nothing less," Octavia shrugged.

She looked Catra in the eyes.

"Can you take her, boss?"

"I've done it before, haven't I," Catra growled.

"Yeah, and she wormed herself out of that one," Octavia gruffed. "I hear she's tougher this time around, too."

"Yeah, well so am I," Catra hissed, a deadly edge to her voice.

"You better be," Octavia said with low voice.

Catra glared at her.

"Not really afraid of loosing that other eye, are you?"

"Told you I'm not much use as a boot-licker," Octavia shrugged. "I just wanted to make sure you know what you're getting us into."

Her words were nonchalant, but there was a seriousness to her voice that registered through the flippant demeanour.

Catra watched her carefully.

"What are you trying to tell me, Octavia?"

"We've been fighting princesses for ages," Octavia said, for once sincere. "Even your crazy ex... all right - sorry, boss! What I mean is, even after *She-Ra* joined the field, we kinda knew what to expect. Shadow Weaver now... she's something else."

Octavia leaned forward, her voice reduced to a whisper.

"I'd kinda appreciate if you kept this one from her majesty Glimmer, boss, but I was there when we brought down the king of Brightmoon, all those years ago... you know he was Shadow Weaver's student over in that fancy magic school of their, right?"

Octavia leaned even closer. Catra could feel her stinking breath close to her face.

"He fought like a devil. There were thirty of us that day, and he flung us around like rag dolls. In the end we had to use artillery to bring him down... and he was just a kid when Shadow Weaver taught him, and *he* didn't have a runestone. Shadow Weaver will be magnitudes worse, boss, especially on home ground."

"I know Shadow Weaver," Catra said, voice hard. "You believe me, I won't underestimate her."

Octavia looked at Catra, head to toe. For a long time her eye rested on the scars on her arms. Finally she said "I'm sure you won't, boss. Only, there is one other thing you should know, about your wife's old man..."

Catra glared at her.

"Yeah? What?"

Octavia told her.

- - -

Catra found Glimmer in their sleeping chamber, sitting on the bed with a comm pad in a her lap.

"Hi there, Sparkles," she said and plopped down on the bed next to her. "Done with the creepy princess stuff."

"For now," Glimmer said. "I sent Jack to get some food together with their unit. We can't isolate them completely."

"Good thinking," Catra agreed. "So you retreated here?"

"I couldn't just pop into the soldier mess hall, asking if I could sit by someone's table, could I now?" Glimmer said with a slightly embarrassed laugh.

"Hordak never did, that's for sure," Catra answered. "Never Shadow Weaver either."

"Mom did, sometimes," Glimmer mused. "But things got really awkward when she did. Mostly she kept to the top tier courtiers."

"We should get some of those," Catra smirked.

"We already have them," Glimmer shrugged. "Lonnie, Double Trouble, Jack..."

"Oh, flunkies," Catra shrugged.

"Yeah, those," Glimmer sighed. "But you and Lonnie were busy and Double Trouble is away snooping somewhere."

"So you're back here, all by your lonesome self," Catra said with what had been intended as a taunt, but just came across as tender. She gave Glimmer a side hug.

"Not lonely anymore," Glimmer smile back and returned the hug.

"Come," Catra said and stood up. She helped Glimmer to her feet.

"We're we going?" Glimmer asked.

"Just for a walk, if you're up for it. I thought you might want to see some more of the place. You fought hard for it, after all."

"I thought you'd never ask," Glimmer laughed and put her arm on Catra's - which for whatever reason made Catra seriously flustered. "Lead the way, My Queen."

Catra held the door open and bowed slightly as Glimmer passed.

Then they went outside to see the Fright Zone.

- - -

It had rained during the night and the many exercise yards, vehicle storage lots and simply empty, forgotten spaces between the garages, factories and barracks were full of puddles. Insects buzzed and birds chirped and - by Fright Zone standard - it was all pretty cheerful.

"Me and Adora used to sneak back here whenever," Catra explained and helped Glimmer climb up the side of a building (she could easily had teleported, but perhaps she didn't quite mind Catra helping her).

"Hearing about happy childhood memories from either of you is always a roller coaster," Glimmer remarked. "Want to tell me now what horrible thing Shadow Weaver did to you as punishment, or will you let it slip into casual conversion?"

"Eh, just the usual," Catra shrugged. "It was totally worth it, anyway."

"I'd totally had sneaked out with you if we were cadets together," Glimmer smirked.

"Oh, I know you would," Catra leered back. "Adora was a goody-two-shoe at the best of times. You're a *bad* girl."

"I'm the bad girl you married," Glimmer proudly reminded her.

"You totally are," Catra laughed. Her face grew serious. "I can't believe you said yes."

"What?" Glimmer protested. "You still don't think you're fancy enough for me?"

"You *are* used to that kind of people that hang around at princess prom..." Catra said with a glance at Glimmer which wasn't as subtle as she had hoped.

"Yeah, and how many of them have clawed their way to the top, *twice*?" Glimmer shot back. "No one, except you..." she hesitated. "Well, actually, I think that warlord who ruled the West Towers might have done it, but she's a looser. Besides, you were at princess prom too."

They heaved themselves up to a flat roof. All around them the rusty, degrading industrial landscape of the Fright Zone sprawled.

"Wow," Glimmer said.

"And it's all ours," Catra said with ironic voice.

"One step up from the desert," Glimmer said loftily.

"Arguably," Catra grumped.

"Oh, don't you fret. If my queen doesn't like her current surroundings, I promise Brightmoon will be more to your liking."

"Bringing me home, are you," Catra smiled and failed to make it a leer.

"I'm bringing you home," Glimmer confirmed. She held out her arms. "All the way home."

Catra leaned into the hug. They held each other for a long, long time.

"Princess prom..." Catra mused. "That was the first time we kidnapped each other."

"Happy memories," Glimmer smirked, even if her eyes were hard.

"Hey," Catra said, remember our dance?"

"How could I forget," Glimmer sighed. "We just got a few beats together, but - wow did you rile me up."

"I had it all the way back then!" Catra commented with an evil grin.

"You absolutely did," Glimmer laughed.

"Hey..." she said on a sudden impulse. "Do you want to..." she fiddled with her comm pads. "Do you want to finish the dance?"

And she put down the pad as it started to play ballroom music. The acoustics was not terrible good and the loudspeakers were atrocious, but the beats could clearly been heard.

Glimmer held out her hand.

"Can I have this dance with my wife?"

Catra stared at her.

"Wife..." she said, voice soft.

"Wife," Glimmer confirmed with a content smirk that made Catra's spine feel all tingly. "Come, lets dance."

Catra took her hand.

Together they danced, in the puddles that had formed on the roof, to the tunes that blared from the comm pad. They started slow, savouring each other's grace, to move in synch, but as they grew more confident they sped up the dance. Making more advanced moves sure that the other would follow, that the other would catch them.

"Not bad, my queen," Catra smiled as Glimmer held her high.

"Thank you, my queen," Glimmer said as Catra slid to her feet and held Glimmer in a deep dip.

They looked each other in the eyes, then Glimmer leaned forward and gave Catra a soft kiss on the lips. Catra let Glimmer up to her feet with a blush, and as the dance twirled on, they found many more little opportunity for kisses.

It truly was a magical moment.

So it was a shame when the music abruptly stopped and an urgent beep was heard from the comm pad.

Catra hissed and picked it up.

"What?" she snarled. "For your sake I really hope it's worth interrupting us."

"Sorry, Ca... my Queen..." Kyle said with scared voice. "It's the battalion in Thaymor... it's under attack."

"*What*!?" Catra snarled. "*Who's* attacking?"

Kyle gave Glimmer a downright scared look through the camera.

"The rebellion, my Queens."

Chapter End Notes

Oh dear.

My description of Catra and Glimmer dancing at Princess Prom can be found here: https://archiveofourown.org/works/29181504/chapters/80167780

The rebellion

Chapter Notes

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"How could this happen?" Glimmer snarled.

The force captain in charge of the Horde presence of Thaymor didn't meet her gaze.

"As per the agreement with the mayor, we were preparing to move..."

"I'm aware of the agreement," Glimmer spat. "An ordered retreat to an outpost just outside town."

"The preparations were taking longer than anticipated, and the townspeople were... eager to see us go. There were some kind of celebration... someone must have slipped past our guard."

"Twenty vehicles destroyed!" Glimmer snarled. "The majority of your supplies. Your gear. Should I count us lucky you still have your *clothes*?"

"Your majesty," the mayor begun, "I trust our agreement..."

"Oh, you do, do you?" Glimmer spat with teeth barred. He took a quick step back.

"You threw a party, did you?" Glimmer hissed. "Can't wait to be free from the Horde, can you?"

He stared at her, obviously weighing his next words very carefully.

"Don't bother," she snarled. "How you let a saboteur through tells us everything we need to know."

"Your majesty!" he protested. "We had nothing to do with..."

"Oh, don't worry," she spat. "If we are not wanted, the Horde won't bother you with our presence any more."

"My queen?" the Force Commander said.

"Pack up what remains of your gear," Glimmer snarled to the force captain. "Get your soldiers marching. We're withdrawing to the Fright Zone."

"Sparkles?" Catra said carefully.

"If the good people of Thaymor don't need our protection, who are we to insist?" Glimmer spat. She gave the mayor a nasty look. "After all, I'm *sure* that once we are gone, Shadow Weaver will be content to stay behind her walls, not even three days from here."

The mayor paled.

"Glimmer..." Catra tried again.

"Double Trouble!" Glimmer snarled, ignoring Catra. "Get your green ass back here, we are *leaving*."

The changeling hurried up to her from the crowd, where they had been making their rounds. They did a little bow and held out their hand.

"Ready, my queen," they said, for once without a trace of irreverence.

Glimmer took their hand and held out her other hand to Catra.

"Are you coming, or are you walking together with the troops, *my queen*?"

"I'm coming," Catra muttered. She caught the eyes of the force commander and shrugged slightly.

Then she took Glimmer's hand, and in a cloud of pink sparkles, they were gone.

The mayor gave the Force Commander an uneasy look.

- - -

"Listen, Sparkles, I get that you are mad, but..."

"We were betrayed, Catra. I think feeling mad about it is perfectly reasonable under the circumstances."

"I get that this is new to you, but the Horde has never exactly been welcomed anywhere we went."

"That's different," Glimmer spat. "This time it's..."

"You?" Catra said.

Glimmer glared at her, but Catra held her ground.

"I *know* it isn't news for you that if you put yourself as head of an army, people will kinda associate you with it."

"Your point?" Glimmer spat.

"My point is, that your old princess friends might not be as friendly as you remember them, not from this side," Catra spat.

Glimmer glared daggers at her, then she pointedly turned around and looked at Double Trouble.

"What did you learn?" she demanded.

"Three people," they answered. "Apparently two of them had integrated themselves in the village for some time."

"And the third?" Glimmer demanded.

Double Trouble actually looked genuinely sorry.

"The villagers didn't learn his name, and only a few saw him, but..."

"Double Trouble!" she said, voice sharp.

They sighed.

"Tall, nautical clothes, terrible moustache, enjoyed singing."

Glimmer stood as paralysed.

"Sorry," Double Trouble said.

"...Sparkles?" Catra tried.

"Catra," Glimmer said with forced cheer. "Could you be a *dear* and talk to Octavia for me. I'm not in a mood the easily lends itself for a constructive discussion."

"And just what do you want me to tell Octavia?" Catra said, full of misgivings.

"That by the time the tides turn this evening, the fleet will be ready to set sail," Glimmer said between gritted teeth.

"Where are we going?" Catra asked. Glimmer gave her a hard look.

"To Brightmoon. We will settle the score with Shadow Weaver once and for all."

"Tonight?" Catra protested. "We gave Lonnie three days to prepare."

"And now she has one," Glimmer shot back.

Catra looked at her in silence.

"*What*?" Glimmer snarled.

"So that is what it looked like, from the other side," Catra mused. "Man, I used to be such a bitch."

"Did you just call me a bitch?" Glimmer snarled.

"Yeah," Catra said, hands in her side.

"I think thaaaaaat's the cue for us to be elsewhere," Double Trouble hurriedly said and steered Jack by the shoulders towards the closest door.

"Do you think this is *funny*," Glimmer said to Catra, completely ignoring them.

"I'm not laughing, am I?" Catra retorted.

She held out her hands in a non-threatening manner.

"I get it," she said with pleading voice. "I really do."

"Really?" Glimmer answered with scorn in her voice.

"*Yeah*, really," Catra snarled. "I get how it feels to be betrayed. I get how it is to want to rush in. I get how it feels when people hate you." She gave Glimmer a direct look. "And I trust you believe me when I say that I get what it feels like when self appointed 'good guys' wreck your shit."

"There is a difference," Glimmer said between gritted teeth.

"Yeah, I know," Catra spat back. "Because this time we target the *right* evil queen of Brightmoon."

Glimmer looked like Catra had slapped her.

"*YES*!" she shouted - perhaps unaware, perhaps not, of the magic forming around her hands. "Did you somehow think that it *didn't* matter who you fight against?"

"So what does that make the rebellion, now that they target us?" Catra shot back. "The bad guys?"

"It makes them a nuisance," Glimmer snarled. "It makes them yet another road block to pass as *we* take down the *real* threat."

"And if they should get in our way, what then?" Catra asked, voice more concerned than angry.

"Then we..." Glimmer begun, but her voice faltered. "Then I..."

"Point of advice?" Catra said.

For a moment it looked like Glimmer would storm off, but she managed to keep hold of herself.

"Fine," she hissed. "What?"

"Hurting them won't make it feel better," Catra said matter-of-factly.

"I'm not going to *hurt* them," Glimmer begun.

"Good," Catra cut her off, "because I mean it, Sparkles. It *really* won't make you feel better, no matter how much you want it to."

"You don't..." Glimmer begun.

"Yeah I *do*," Catra snarled with sudden venom. "And you believe me, Sparkles. I love you *way* too much to stand by and see you make *my* mistakes all over again."

She took a step closer, into Glimmer's personal space. She grabbed her wrists, forced her arms apart and looked her into the eyes.

"Three days, Sparkles," she said with gentle voice. "We have a plan, we will follow it. We'll go to Brightmoon. We'll take down Shadow Weaver. We'll get your castle back. After that you and your friends can patch things up at your own pace."

"And if the 'rebellion' has other ideas?" Glimmer snarled.

"Then *we* deal with them," Catra said with determined voice.

"Fine," Glimmer spat after a moment. "We'll do this your way. "

"Thank you," Catra said, relaxing slightly.

"Now, if you'll excuse me..." Glimmer said.

"Yeah, yeah," Catra muttered. "Go and blow off steam."

Glimmer gave her an withering look, but didn't say anything as she teleported out.

Catra slowly counted on her fingers and reached twelve before she heard the first explosion.

The door behind her opened.

"You handled that well," Double Trouble said with low voice.

"Did I?" Catra muttered. "It didn't feel like that."

"Nevertheless," Double Trouble said. "You told her what she needed to hear, even if it perhaps wasn't exactly what she *wanted* to hear."

Catra glanced at them.

"You make it sound easy."

They laughed.

"Matters of the heart are never easy, Kitty-Cat. Those who tell you otherwise are liars or fools."

Catra sighed.

"And here I had hope winning would make things easier for us."

"Since you are not a fool, I take it you were lying to yourself," Double Trouble loftily said, earning a glare from Catra.

"You'll keep an eye out, won't you," she said. "I would prefer if there are no other little surprises before we get to Brightmoon."

"I'll see what I can do," Double Trouble said with serious voice, "but I give no guarantees. The rebellion can be very cunning once they put their mind to it, as you well know."

"Don't I know it," Catra muttered. "But keep an eye out nevertheless..." she sighed. "And thanks."

Double Trouble gave her a surprised look.

"Whatever for?"

"...for being here," she muttered. "For believing in... us."

Double Trouble put a sympathetic hand on her shoulder.

"Of course I do, Kitten. Don't worry, this time your princess won't run away on you."

Catra shot them an angry look, but it soon melted in the face of their cheeky grin.

"Let's hope you are right," she sighed.

"I am," they said with an annoying degree of confidence. "Now, go check on the preparations with Lonnie. She has a clipboard a mile long she'll need your input on. I'll keep an ear to the ground, in case that hotshot pirate has any other surprises in store for us."

"And Glimmer?" Catra asked silently.

"The kid has it covered," Double Trouble assured her.

- - -

"Glimmer?" Jack asked, voice shivering slightly as they pushed the door to the Black Garnet chamber open.

"Come in, Jack," Glimmer said, voice stable.

"I'm sorry," Jack said.

Glimmer sighed.

"Thank you, but it was to be expected." She sadly looked at the horde emblem on a poster on the wall. "Small minded people have a problem seeing past the colours of a flag. I counted on that, for me to get in this position. I should have expected it to cut both ways."

"Sorry..." Jack said, not knowing what else to say.

"I've meant to talk to you. I want to give you something," Glimmer said with serious voice.

"Oh?" Jack said, somewhat cautious. "What is it?"

Glimmer held out her hand, and in a flash of light her mage-staff manifested in it.

"This," she simply said and held out the staff towards Jack.

"What?" Jack said, taken aback. "You can't give me your *staff*."

"Of course I can," Glimmer said with a complicated smile. She held the staff closer, and Jack hesitantly took it. It felt smooth in their hands, balanced despite the top heavy look.

"But why?" Jack asked.

"Because once we get to Brightmoon, you might very well need it," Glimmer said. "We will fight magic, and you - like it or not - are one of the best magicians in the Horde. You need to be prepared."

Jack stared at her with huge eyes.

"Magician? Me? Glimmer, I just know a few tricks, and those won't..."

"You know more than a few tricks," Glimmer said calmly. "You know what magic is. You know how it works. You have practise, experience. Much as I try to drill my ladies-in-waiting, there is only so much I can teach them in this short time. You are smart, you are adaptable, and most importantly..." she looked Jack in the eyes. "I believe in you."

"Wow.... um, thank you," Jack said, blushing brightly. Glimmer grinned at them.

"Now, make a defence glyph," she said. Jack obediently signed the pattern in the air, leaving a glowing trail after the finger from the residue magic emitting from Glimmer.

"Very good," Glimmer said approvingly and quickly made a glyph of her own. "Now, if I were to attack..."

She send her glyph hurling forward. Jack opened their eyes wide, but managed to expand her glyph enough to block the energies. Glimmer gave them a nod.

"Well done. Now..." -she made a new glyph- "Try using the staff to direct the energies."

"Um... how do I...?" Jack begun, but then quickly scrambled to get their defence in order as Glimmer raised her hand.

Again, the energies splashed harmlessly against Jack's defence glyph.

"The staff made it really easy," Jack said. "It's like... um," they fumbled for a metaphor.

"Like steering a sailboat with a rudder," Glimmer said, suddenly something wistful in her voice. "All this force at your command with a little stick."

She sighed.

"At least that's what my father liked to say."

"I've never been in a boat and I've never had a dad, but I'll take your word for it," Jack drily commented.

"Well, at least you have a magician's staff now, which might serve you better than either in the long run," Glimmer answered. "Keep your guard up, because now the attacks will come faster."

They kept sparring for a while, Glimmer's attacks getting faster and faster, Jack's blocks getting more and more confident.

"Good," Glimmer said after awhile, holding up her hand to signal they were stopping. "Take a breather, and then we will try something new..."

"Something new, how?" Jack asked and grabbed a field canteen for a drink of water.

"Now I will attack you with raw energy," Glimmer said and held up a fist with sparkles dancing over it.

"Raw energy?" Jack frowned. "Isn't that just a waste of power?"

"That's what they would teach you in Mystacor," Glimmer agreed and stepped back to the middle of the room, waiting for Jack to prepare their defences. "And most of the time it's true. There are places however, where magic is more readily available, and speed of the attack might make up for diminished return of the magic used."

"Places like Brightmoon?" Jack asked and grimaced as they only partly managed to block Glimmer's attack.

"You learn quick," Glimmer said and prepared a new fistful of sparks. "Also, there are opponents who will more often resort to raw power, and defending against that will take a special technique."

"Opponents like princesses?" Jack asked silently as they altered their defence glyph slightly to better capture the scattered energy of Glimmer's attack.

"Let's focus on Shadow Weaver for now, shall we?" Glimmer said with forced cheer. "I promise you there will be enough fight waiting for us in Brightmoon, without us having to look for it elsewhere."

- - -

Catra stood by the dock. Everywhere people were busy shouting or being shouted at. Ships were prepared, last minute supplies were loaded, bots were deployed, vehicles secured, soldiers marched on board.

The Horde was going to war.

Catra regarded Lonnie's hand picked strike team.

"Think these goons will be up to the task, do you?" she asked Lonnie with low voice.

"These 'goons' are the best we have to offer, 'my queen'," Lonnie gruffed. "They can get you in position, all right."

"Our mission is more than 'getting in position'," Catra said with a raised eyebrow.

"*Their* mission is exactly that," Lonnie shot back. "After that, it's up to you and your princess to find something to throw at Shadow Weaver that sticks."

"Having doubts, do you?" Catra said, voice just a tad more sharp than it had to.

"You know my feeling about princess tricks," Lonnie sighed. "But no, Catra. I don't doubt you and I don't doubt her." Her face split up in a grin. "Hey, when you 'talk' to Shadow Weaver, say hi from little ol' overlooked Lonnie. Tell her that if she wants to bully Kyle again, he's by one of the canons, poking holes in her castle walls."

"I will," Catra grinned. "And thanks. Not a bad job putting this together in just three days."

"Glad to be appreciated," Lonnie said, not quite managing to sound as flippant as she tried to.

Catra grinned at her and turned to the troops.

"All right, gang," she cried with loud voice. "This is it. The final push. We take Brightmoon, we end the war. We. Win." She leered. "You've heard me say that once before, haven't you?"

She let her gaze play over the ranks.

"That time it didn't turn out quite the way I said it would, did it?" she said, an edge to her voice.

No one met her gaze.

"That time, Hordak stabbed me in the back," she said forcefully. "He is not around to do that this time. That time, Queen Glimmer stood on the castle wall, facing us. This time, she's with us."

"We are going up against Shadow Weaver," Catra went on. "Last time I went up against her, I beat her up with my own two hands and landed her in a prison cell." Her eyes narrowed. "She wormed her way out of that one. She ran away the tail between her legs. She found a new throne to usurp, like she tried with Hordak's all those years..."

She silenced a moment to let her gaze travel over the rows of soldiers, in case anyone had anything to say on the subject of just who sat on just who's throne.

"This time there won't be a hole deep enough for her to crawl away to," Catra shouted. "This time we're finishing the job *I* started. This time we kill the witch. This time we take Brightmoon. This time we end the war. This time..."

On cue, Glimmer appeared next to her, glowing with power. She held out her hand and a staff emerged in it. It was huge and clumsy compared to the slender staff she had given away, but it crackled with power. It was black, full of sharp edges, seemingly

forged from the same crystalline material as the rods Hordak had used the channel the power of the Black Garnet.

"This time we win," the Shining Princess said in low, deadly voice.

- - -

"You sure you can get the bots to the castle wall in time?" Catra asked, glaring at the map, doing her best to keep it steady as the ship tossed back and forth in the rocky sea.

Rogelio growled.

"I *know* you've done it before," Catra hissed at him. "I was there, remember?"

"That time my mother and She-Ra were there to help with the defence," Gimmer reminded them. "Shadow Weaver will be magnitudes harder to beat."

"That time we didn't have you," Catra shot back.

They sat in the rather roomy officer's cabin of the ship, holding last minute council, going over the details in the plans and - secretly - worrying like crazy.

"She knows we're coming, right?" Jack said nervously.

"Obviously," Double Trouble said in obnoxiously relaxed voice, leaning against the wall and gently shifting with each wave to keep the balance.

"So, what will her counter strike be?" Jack went on.

Everyone's eye went to Glimmer.

She sighed.

"The usual, I'd presume. She preys on fears. You all have to prepare for the risk of having hidden monsters dragged up from your nightmares."

"How do one possibly prepare for that?" Lonnie frowned.

"By focusing on the task at hand," Catra said with hard voice. "By reminding yourself that at the end of the day you might still live, and the witch will be dead."

"I'll drink to that," Lonnie said with heartfelt voice.

At that moment the ship lurched, causing them all to fly in all directions, except Catra who kept her balance.

"What the fuck was that?" she snarled and ran to the door.

They emerged on a deck covered in snow. Heavy waves hurled the ship back and forth, and the sea were covered in small patches of ice.

Octavia stood by the stern, staring grimly over the dark waters where the waves were growing larger by the second.

"What's going on?" Catra cried, struggling to keep her balance as she walked over the slippery deck, the others in tow.

"This, my queen, is what us humble sea folks know as a 'storm'," Octavia gruffed, not taking her eyes off the gloom.

"You never mentioned fucking ice bergs when we sat up our plans," Catra snarled.

"I did not do that, that's correct My Queen," Octavia said with heavy voice, "the reason being that I thought it such a distant risk that it was hardly worth mentioning."

"Oh well? It seems to be worth mentioning *now*," Catra said between gritted teeth. "So please elaborate on your 'humble sea folk ways'. What can we expect?"

Octavia turned to her, her face grim.

"Thirty years I have sailed these waters, girl and woman," she gruffed. "One cause one and one cause only for this weather, at this time of the year."

"What?" Catra snarled, in a bad mood from the cold.

"Magic," Octavia answered with level voice, looking directly at Glimmer.

At the same time, a loud crash resonated through the ship as something landed on deck. Glimmer and Catra ran up to the small shape in tattered clothes lying on the deck, surrounded by sharp shards of ice.

"Help me, Glimmer," princess Frosta whispered and fell unconscious.

"*What*?" Catra yelled. "What's *she* doing here."

"I don't know," Glimmer cried, voice rising in panic, "but we have to get out of here, right now!"

"*Why?*" Catra snarled. "What are we running from? The Horde controls the sea, remember?"

"No, Catra," a sardonic voice said - clearly heard despite the storm. "Salineas controls the sea."

They rushed to the rail and stared at the source of the voice. In the sea, swimming next to the ship and having no trouble keeping even pace with it swam princess Mermista, her strong fish tail propelling her forward. On her lips was a cruel smile and her eye sockets were full of swirling, billowing shadows.

Chapter End Notes

Oh shit!

Salineas rules the sea

Chapter Notes

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

Warning: This chapter features a fight with Mermista. At sea. Expect all sort of danger related to water, drowning and sinking ships.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Mermista?" Glimmer whispered, white in her face.

"What's the matter, little queen?" the shadow-tainted Mermista taunted. "You of all people should know that the princess alliance will do whatever it takes to stop the Horde."

"Full power to the engines," Octavia roared to her second in command. Sharp port. Prepare the torpedoes."

"Are we running or are we fighting?" Catra snarled.

"Both," Octavia spat, "and we hope like fuck that either of it will be enough."

She turned to the second in command again.

"Order the fleet to scatter," she bellowed. "Get them as far away as they can while the Salinean bitch is busy with us. Set course on the crab islands. We'll set her aground if we have to."

"Set the ship aground?" Catra protested.

"You haven't been to sea much," Octavia said between gritted teeth. "And since you skipped Force Captain Orientation, please let me give you the cliff notes: a direct confrontation with the princess of Salineas in open water is the nightmare scenario. So

unless your wife has a trick in her sleeve, we're running with the tails between our legs."

"We're not running," Catra snarled. She turned to the second in command. "Belay that order."

Octavia gritted her teeth, but didn't protest when the second in command - after a long look at her - passed Catra's order on.

Mermista stood up in the water, like a dolphin, staring at Glimmer who grasped the railing with white knuckles.

"You are not the princess alliance," Glimmer hissed.

"Oh, but I will be," the thing behind Mermista's eyes said, voice deadly calm. "One by one I will have you, starting with the brat from Snow."

"No." Glimmer said, teeth barred into a snarl.

"You think you can stop me?" Mermista said, a mighty wave of water rising under her.

"Yes," Glimmer said, voice cracking from anger. She held up her hand, and in a flash of pink light, the crystal staff emerged.

"Glimmer?" Catra said carefully.

"Get them out of here," Glimmer said between gritted teeth. Catra looked like she was going to protest, but before she had the time Glimmer teleported away - just as the wave crashed into the ship.

"Fuck you," Catra snarled to the ocean in general. She grabbed a blaster and tried to get an aim at Mermista, but before she had time to fire, Glimmer had teleported into close combat and tackled Mermista into the water, her staff crackling with energy. Then she teleported out again before the mermaid had time to grab her.

"Torpedoes ready," Octavia said with tight voice.

Catra stared at the water princess, who was whipping up huge sprout of water, aiming for Glimmer, who hurled towards her from the sky like a shooting star.

"Fire," Catra snarled.

"FIRE!" Octavia bellowed, and two sleek missiles shot through the water towards the mermaid.

"NO!" Glimmer cried, and beams of light shot from her staff, diverting the torpedoes. Mermista spun around in the water with a shout and a mighty current swept them away.

The next moment Glimmer landed like a meteor in the water, pushing Mermista downwards, both of them surrounded by a pink bubble of magic. The force of Glimmer's attack pressed them downwards several meters, and then the bubble shot up like a cork.

"Ungrateful children!" the thing behind Mermista's eyes spat.

"Let. Her. Go!" Glimmer snarled, her staff vibrating with power.

The bubble popped at its highest point of the arc, and - letting go of the staff - Glimmer grabbed Mermista, forcing her downwards with all her might. But before they reached the surface, another wave hit them, and Glimmer teleported away.

"Now," Catra snarled, and the canons of the ship thundered. Mermista barely had time to get in safety under the surface before the ocean erupted in an inferno of projectiles.

"Do you think we..." Catra begun, but her voice trailed off as she saw the waves changing direction around the ship. While she watched, large waves formed on both side of the ship, crashing into it with dangerous speed.

"Catra," Octavia said, voice scared. "We need to get out of here right *now*."

"Not without Glimmer," Catra snarled.

"She can teleport," Octavia pointed out, staring at the higher and higher waves forming around the ship. "All we can do is fucking *drown*."

"Or we take out the water bitch," Catra growled.

"We *can't*!" Octavia cried, voice crackling.

"You can't," Catra hissed. "Glimmer can."

"*Captain?*"" the second in command yelled, hands on a tiller.

"Full speed ahead," Octavia bellowed, ignoring Catra's death glare.

"Fuck you," Catra snarled. She rushed up to one of the huge cannons and roughly pushed the solider manning it out of the way. swung it around, trying to get a shot at the mermaid who resurfaced again.

For a moment her eyes locked with Mermista's, then Mermista made a contemptuous little flick of her wrist, and the ship rocked, causing the shot to miss wildly.

"TURN AROUND!" Catra snarled to Octavia.

"And do *what*?" Octavia yelled back. "We are sitting ducks out here."

"I said *turn around*," Catra snarled and glared at Octavia. Behind her a few members of the crew had gathered, looking at her with a body language Catra well recognized.

Everyone looked at each other in silence for a moment, while behind them the sound of explosions suggested Glimmer and Mermista were still fighting.

"Do you really want to do this, Octavia?" Catra said with treacherously soft voice, the entire ocean around them seemingly calming down to match her tone. She slipped down from the canon, body language alert, not taking her eyes of the admiral.

"If we don't get out of here, she'll kill us," Octavia said, voice pleading. Around the ship, waves started to rise.

"Oh no, she won't," Catra answered in the same soft tone of voice. "Not you. Because if the next word out of your mouth is *anything* other than 'yes my queen', I'll.."

"*Catra*!" Jack cried in fear, still struggling to get the unconscious Frosta into the cabins. Catra and Octavia both looked up and saw titanic walls of water forming around the ship.

"Can we evade it?" Catra whispered, despite already knowing the answer.

Octavia just shook her head numbly, not taking her eyes off the mountain of water towering above them.

Catra sank to the deck, head spinning. She should get the crew working. She should take another shot at Mermista. She should get to Jack. She should...

She didn't know what she should.

"...fuck..." she whispered.

As the tower of water crashed down towards them, she closed her eyes.

The expected crash never came. Instead, a sound like a bell chimed. Catra opened her eyes.

The ship was surrounded by a pink dome of energy, the water breaking against its surface and flooding down on every side of the ship. In front of the ship, hovering in the air, glowing staff held over her head, was the Shining Princess.

"No," Glimmer said, voice quivering with fury, her body radiating like a tiny star. "They are *mine*."

"...OK," Catra said to no one, "that's pretty hot."

"Really," Mermista drawled, rising on a pillar of water just next to the ship. "You really think you can protect them from *me*?"

"Yes!" Glimmer snarled, and then, in a cloud of sparks, she teleported to Mermista staff first, held like a spear. The mermaid laughed a spiteful little laugh and slipped down in the sea again.

"Boss..." Octavia said with low voice. "We're just slowing your wife down."

Catra stared at her for a moment, then she closed her eyes.

"Get us out of here," she whispered. "Glimmer can catch up once she's skinned that fish."

"Yes, my queen," Octavia said, radiating of relief.

- - -

"Let. Her. Go!" Glimmer cried again, light pouring from her every orifice as she punched Mermista, then quickly teleported out before the mermaid could grab her.

"The little queen, so protective of those she regards as her friends," The thing that spoked through Mermista's mouth mocked. "What will she do, I wonder, if I do this...?"

She spun her hands in a circle. around the struggling ship, a vortex started to form.

"Stop it!" Glimmer cried.

"Come with me, and I will," Mermista hissed. "The life of your friends in exchange for your freedom, is that a fair trade?"

"Never," Glimmer shouted.

"Very well," Mermista said, and the vortex grew bigger in size.

"You won't hurt them," Glimmer said between gritted teeth.

"And what makes you so sure?" Mermista mocked.

"You won't risk to kill Frosta," Glimmer answered.

"She is an elemental princess of Etheria," the thing behind Mermista's eyes gloated. "She will live even as the rest of them perish."

"Even so, there is still one princess unaccounted for," Glimmer said, voice full of barely contained rage.

"And who would that be," Mermista answered.

Glimmer didn't answer. She just held Mermista's eyes for a moment.

Then she teleported.

Downwards.

As far as she could.

The water pressure hit Glimmer like a hammer. Her lungs felt like they would explode and the only light she saw was a faint red hue filtered from far, far above. She closed her eyes and forced her mouth closed. She pressed her fingers against her nose and held her breath, doing her best to avoid the throbbing pain in her ears.

One second... two second... three seconds...

She wondered how long she would be able to hold her breath.

She opened her eyes as she felt the change in water pressure, so she could see how an agitated Mermista swam into her field of vision. The next moment the pressure around her disappeared, and she took a tentative breath.

It was still dark, but she could breathe just fine and her ears had stopped hurting. They were in a bubble, barely large enough for the two of them, the water pushed away by the ocean princess's powers. Glimmer held up her hand and summoned a little ball of sparks. Then she gasped as she realised that Mermista's face was just a hand's with from her own, staring at her with eyes filled of shadows.

Glimmer stared in fear at her skin, covered with letters of the kind the first ones used. They glowed in the gloom.

"Why do you insist on making everything so difficult," Shadow Weaver whined through Mermista's mouth with a petulant voice.

"You mean, by not letting you kill me friends and enslave me and my fellow princesses?" Glimmer asked, slightly dizzy.

"Obviously," Shadow Weaver said. "I will win in the end, you know. You are just making this harder for no reason."

"You are so assured of your victory?" Glimmer asked with a raised eyebrow.

"Why wouldn't I be?" Shadow Weaver shrugged with Mermista's body. "I have won and you have lost, as simple as that."

"Hordak said the same thing," Glimmer snarled. "We beat him and we will beat you."

"I'm sure you will," Mermista said with dry voice. "Just tell me one thing. Which direction is the surface?"

Glimmer sat silent in the bubble, a sinking feeling ln her stomach.

"Is it that way?" Mermista said and pointed upwards, a cruel little smile lurking in the edge of her mouth. She made a little gesture and the bubble turned in the water, almost without affecting Glimmer's sense of gravity. "Or is it that way?" Mermista went on, still pointing at the subjective direction of 'up'.

"Tell me, Glimmer," she went on, a rare smile on her lips. "How far have we drifted since you entered this bubble, and in which direction?" she stared Glimmer in the eyes. "How far is it to the surface, my Queen?"

Glimmer stared at the Shadow possessed princess, the air of the bubble suddenly feeling very hard to breathe.

"That is not fair," she whispered.

"Perhaps then," Shadow Weaver gloated, "children should have stayed out of games for adults."

"This is a game for you?" Glimmer asked, anger returning to her voice.

"You know perfectly well what this is to me," Shadow Weaver said, voice sharp. "I have sacrificed more than you ever could imagine, for one reason and one reason only."

"To win," Glimmer sighed.

"To save our world," Shadow Weaver said, voice sharp as a whip.

"Yes," Glimmer sighed. "For *you* to save our world. Not for our world to be saved by someone else."

"As if someone else *could*," Shadow Weaver scoffed. "As if anyone else would ever have what it takes."

"You know, I learnt something from you," Glimmer said, "during your stay in Brightmoon."

"I'm glad to hear my efforts as a teacher were not entirely wasted," Shadow Weaver scoffed.

"I learn that there are some people who are simply not worth saving," Glimmer spat.

She teleported out of the bubble. The pressure threatened to crush her, but she forced her eyes open. She released a cloud of sparkly bubbles and took notice of what direction they moved. Then she teleported in that direction, as far as she could.

It took her three teleports, each more claustrophobic than the last, but finally she breached the surface. She took an enormous gulp of air and looked around in panic.

Waves were everywhere around her. Seagulls cried. She had no idea where the ship was. She had no idea where she could find land. She also had no idea how many more teleports she would manage before she passed out.

"Well done, princess," Mermista said, emerging from the water like a seal. "But you do realize you're only postponing the..."

She glanced towards the sky with an annoyed frown.

"Shut up," she snarled, for a moment looking much more like her old self.

"What?" Glimmer gasped as she treated water and tried to regain her breath.

"Not you," Mermista growled. "Those infernal birds."

"What?" Glimmer asked, bewildered about this new turn. "The seagulls?"

"Little busybodies are what they are," Mermista grumbled.

Then, with no warning whatsoever, a ship emerged from the waves, heading straight towards them. It was a small ship, by ship standards, probably manoeuvrable by a single person, but from Glimmer's perspective in the water it looked enormous. She cried out in fear and teleported up in the air. Mermista shouted in frustration and dove under surface.

Glimmer stared at the ship as she fell. It turned against the wind at breakneck speed, the boom swinging like the branches of a tree in storm. The ship leaned so much towards the surface that the mast almost scraped the water. Glimmer noticed a liquid pouring from barrels by the scuppers. Mermista emerged by the side of the ship, shouting in anger. Glimmer teleported again, down to the surface behind the ship. The water felt... strange. It had a new texture and smelled sharp.

Glimmer yelped as a vortex formed around her, starting to suck her down.

"We are doing this the hard way, then!" Mermista snarled, just next to her in the water. "I'll be happy to oblige."

Glimmer desperately tried to teleport away, but the water squeezed the air out of her lunges, making it awfully hard to concentrate.

"I'm afraid I can't allow that, my beloved," a voice said, confident and melodic. Glimmer and Mermista both looked up, at the ship that loomed over them. At the man by the stern, and at the torch he tossed in the water.

"Uuuuuuuugh!" Mermista said - for a moment entirely herself.

Then the ocean caught fire. The oily liquid that poured from barrels floated atop the water and burnt like gasoline. Glimmer and Mermista both cried in fear as the flames surrounded them, but before she caught on fire herself, Glimmer felt a sharp tug in her clothes, and before she knew it she had been dragged from the water with a boat hook and floundered like a fish on the decks of the ship.

"Salutations, Glimmer," Sea Hawk said with a grin as he stepped back to the wheel and loosened the rope keeping it in place. "Good winds, indeed, that brings us together again. "Now, I suggest you hold on."

"What..." Glimmer begun in indignant tone, but then she gasped and desperately managed to get a grip on a rope as Sea Hawk turned the wheel and the main sail caught the wind.

The entire ship lurched, and then shot forward as from a canon. Glimmer screamed as the waves tossed the ship between them like it had been a toy.

"The fire will keep my lovely dove busy for a little while," Sea Hawk said in conversational tone of voice, "but outrunning the mistress of the sea is not for the faint of heart. "Luckily we are not far from shore. We might even survive this."

Glimmer forced herself to keep hold of the rope as she was flung back and forth. The waves seemed to increase in size for every moment and the sails were strung like bowstrings in the wind. Securing the wheel with one foot, Sea Hawk pulled a rope with both hands, causing the already dangerously leaning ship to dip even closer to the waves.

"Why can't you keep it steady?" Glimmer managed to scream, fighting to keep her stomach content down.

"The ship is as steady as they come," Sea Hawk answered with an uncharacteristically concerned tone of voice. "Sadly, the same can't be said for the wind and the waves themselves."

"Is that normal?" Glimmer cried.

She risked opening her eyes slightly. Sea Hawk was watching the water just in front of them with a frown.

"Usually I would have said no," he answered and fastened a rope to the wheel again. "But when you find yourself in a little tussle with the Queen of the Oceans, things like these are only to be expected."

In front of the ship, a gigantic wave rose, easily twice as high as the mast. Mermista road it, her entire being covered in shadows.

"Incidently," Sea Hawk said, stepping up to Glimmer - seemingly immune to the ship's frantic lurching. "Would you mind transporting us to shore? It would be about twenty degrees port." He took in Glimmer's nonplussed stare and then helpfully pointed. "That direction."

Glimmer grabbed him, and just as the wave crashed down on the ship, she teleported them in the indicated direction. It took her two jumps but then she saw land, and with a final teleportation they sank down in the sand, Glimmer burning like a small star and throwing up bile mixed with glitter.

"Well, that was a refreshing little adventure," Sea Hawk said with unconcerned voice as he stepped up to the retching queen. She looked up his boots and trouser legs with absolute murder in her gaze.

"She almost *killed* us," she spat, wiping her mouth on her sleeve.

"Almost," Sea Hawk admitted cheerfully. "The sea is a harsh mistress, but that only makes her the more exciting. You're welcome for saving you, by the way. No extra charge for heroics."

"Heroics," Glimmer hissed and scrambled to her feet. "Was that what you called it when you burnt down the garrison in Thaymor too?"

"Of course it was," Sea Hawk said without changing tone of voice. "The plucky rebellion standing up to the evil Horde. Why, it's a saga worthy of song."

"If I hear even a single tone out of you, I *will* kill you," Glimmer hissed you, only for Sea Hawk to give her an even more annoying grin than usual. "And the Horde is not evil any more. It's *mine*."

"Ah, yes," Sea Hawk said with condescending voice. "Many a captain I've sailed with who think of themselves as the ship rather than just part of the crew. No matter. On this leg of our journey we yet again find ourselves with aligned interests."

"And what would those be?" Glimmer hissed, trying without much success to get the sand off her wet clothes.

"Mermista," Sea Hawk said. "You saw what the witch in Brightmoon did to her. I want her back, and you can help her."

"Of course I can," Glimmer spat. "What do you think I'm trying to do."

"I think we could benefit from each other's help," Sea Hawk answered and started to walk inland. "But first there is something you should know. Follow me, my sparkly sovereign."

"Follow you *where*?" Glimmer asked, bewildered as she hurried after him, forced to take two or three steps for every single one of his.

"To Plumeria," he answered. "Everything might not be as well in the Kingdom of Flowers as you have been led to believe."

Chapter End Notes

> There is no single character in this story that has been as hard to write as Sea Hawk. I knew what the story demanded of him, but to force him into that role took some work.

The Princess and the Bandit

Chapter Summary

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Um.... breakfast, your highness?"

Frosta opened her eyes.

She gasped when she saw the Horde logo on the the jacket of the teen that hovered over her, holding a tray. Ice formed around her fists and the teen quickly scrambled backwards. The tray dropped to the ground.

"I'm with Glimmer!" the teenager yelled. "You're OK! We're not on the ship any more!"

Frosta hesitated for a moment, then she conjured away the ice with an embarrassed little cough.

"Sorry about that..." she chuckled slightly. "I... I kinda forgot for a moment that the Horde is the good guys now."

The horde soldier stared at her for a moment, and then started to chuckle as well.

"I... I suppose we are."

"Sure you are, Glimmer is the boss now, isn't she?" Frosta said flippantly.

"Yeah, and Catra," the teenager pointed out.

Frosta did a little 'yeah, yeah'-gesture and glanced at the tray on the floor.

"Um... Sorry about that."

She started to pick up the spilled food (not very hard since most of it consisted of ration bars). The teenager bent down and helped her.

"It's OK," they said. "I'm Jack."

"And I'm Frosta," Frosta answered.

The looked at each other and smiled.

"Are... are you OK, your majesty?" Jack asked. "You have slept for three days."

Frosta blinked at them.

"Three days? Wow." She looked down at herself and nodded contently. "I'm fine. Elemental princesses heal fast," she said, slightly smugly.

"What happened?" Jack said. "You just crashed down on our ship from nowhere, with that mermaid princess hot on your heels."

Frosta gave them a guarded look.

"I think I'd better tell Glimmer directly," she said. "Not to be rude, but..."

Her eyes might have darted to the horde logo at Jack's jacket again.

"Oh... of course," Jack answered, blushing slightly. "No offence meant, your majesty."

"It's OK," Frosta assured them. "And you don't have to call me 'majesty'. Frosta is enough."

"OK, Frosta," Jack said and carefully sat down by Frosta's bed. "Glimmer is not back yet so we might have to wait a little while. Breakfast?"

Frosta gave the ration bar a dubious look, then she shrugged.

"Sure, I'm hungry enough for Horde food. Here!"

She broke the ration bar in two and handed one of the pieces to Jack.

"What?" Jack said, slightly taken aback.

"Eating by yourself is boring," Frosta shrugged.

"Heh, Glimmer said pretty much the same thing when we first met," Jack smiled.

"I've missed her so much," Frosta confessed.

Jack gave her a sympathetic little smile. They got it.

They munched on their ration bars. Frosta looked around curiously.

"I feels so weird to be here for real," she commented, and then did a little chuckle. "Without punching stuff, that is."

"I know, right," Jack said. "I've been on the run from the Horde all of my life, and now I get a uniform and, 'hey, congratulations, I'm the scary Horde now!'"

"You don't look *that* scary," Frosta giggled.

"I totally startled you as you woke up," Jack snickered.

"Fine, you totally did," Frosta admitted.

"To be fair," Jack said, "I was pretty nervous as well... princesses can be scary."

"Me? Scary?" Frosta snorted. "Everyone's treating me like a kid all the time. I have no idea of what I'm doing and even when I do, I mostly punch stuff."

"The way Lonnie talks about you, half of the Horde shits their pants, just thinking of the pack ice you put between them and Snow," Jack said, admiration in their voice.

Frosta gave them a surprised look.

"They do? I mean, I knew the ice thing I cooked up was cool, but..."

"'I'd rather ride a unicycle all the way through the Crimson Waste than make another attempt at Snow with that ice bitch holding the fort'," Jack said with a passable imitation of Lonnie's gruff voice.

Frosta looked at them with large eyes

"She said that?" she whispered.

"Yup!" Jack confirmed.

"That's right!" Frosta cried. "Look out, world. The ice bitch is out of her castle now."

"Oh mighty ice bitch, spare me," Jack laughed, causing Frosta to giggle even more.

"I might be so inclined," she said with a faux-haughty voice... "*if* you give me another ration bar."

"I live to serve," Jack grinned. "Only we seem to be fresh out at the moment."

Frosta glanced at the empty tray.

"Oh well," she said with normal voice. "I'll just have to..."

"Buuuuut I do know where the kitchen is," Jack said with a little wink. "If 'your highness' is up for some sneaking.

Frosta was up for some sneaking.

- - -

"I can't believe a princess can be so good at sneaking past guards," Jack said with admiration in their voice as they, munching on a ration bar each, walked through the rusty corridors of the Fright Zone.

"Are you kidding me?" Frosta laughed. "That's the only way to get some freedom in a castle full of people with nothing better to do than to keep tabs on you. I knew like five secret paths to the kitchen when i was ten."

"When I was ten, my gang was overrun by the Rat Gobblers," Jack mused. "Me and some buddies tried to go solo in the Valley of the Lost. We made it a few months before we had to scram. We joined up with Tung Lashur after that... that was before Catra took him out, obviously," they added with pride.

"Wooooooooow," Frosta said, staring at them without any attempt to hide the admiration in her voice. "You're so cool."

Jack blushed.

"That's just how it was in the Waste..."

"Hey," Frosta said. "I bet you've got some sick moves when you fight."

"Well..." Jack said.

"Care to show me?" Frosta asked.

Jack gave her a hesitant look.

"OK... but you have to promise not to use any scary princess powers."

"I promise!" Frosta said solemnly.

Jack steered them down a corridor, towards one of the many gyms and training rooms used to keep soldiers busy when there was nothing better to do.

They spent the better part of an hour sparring.

- - -

"Everything hurts," Frosta complained.

"I'm so sorry," Jack said, voice concerned.

"Don't worry," Frosta laughed. "I heal quickly. And that was so fun. That thing you did with the feint and then the overhand blow..."

"I learnt that from Catra," Jack said with pride in their voice.

"Well, it was cool," Frosta said.

"I liked your duck-and-punch move," Jack said and rubbed their chin.

"Normally I'd have followed it up with an ice-fist," Frosta grinned, "but hey" -she held up her hands- "no scary princess powers."

"Good for me," Jack agreed.

In the corridor in front of them, shouting voices could be heard. Jack and Frosta glanced at each other, and then - without a word - they pressed themselves against the wall.

"What's going on?" Frosta whispered.

"No idea," Jack whispered back. "It's the throne room up there. Must be something important."

"Might be interesting to listen in..." Frosta said, glancing at Jack.

Jack only hesitated for the tiniest moment.

"Wait," they said. "I'll just..." and face scrounged up in concentration, they put together a spell. Normally, they'd have to fight with their entire being to get enough magic for it, but with Frosta just next to them it was remarkably easy.

"There!" they said as the circle they had spun expanded and covered them like spider web. "It's kinda an invisibility spell. It's not very good, but it will at least make it harder for people to notice us."

Frosta stared at them.

"You can do *magic*!" she whispered.

"A bit..." Jack admitted. "Glimmer taught me."

"You are so cool!" Frosta breathed in a tone of voice that made Jack feel funny inside.

"It's nothing..." they said.

"Of course it's not nothing!" Frosta cried. "You are an outlaw, rebel *magician*. I bet you have a pet snake or something too, haven't you"

"She's called Miss Hissyfits and she drinks the blood of my enemies," Jack said with deadpan voice.

Frosta glared at them suspiciously for a few moments, until Jack's composure failed them and they started to giggle.

"Shame," Frosta said over giggles of her own. "I wanted to introduce her to my pet polar bear Mrs Mightyroar."

"Mrs Mightyroar?" Jack guffawed.

"That's all I could think of," Frosta tittered.

"Well, for what it's worth, Miss Hissyfits would be *charmed* to meet Mrs Mightyroar," Jack said with a smile.

"Then let it hereby be known," Frosta said, perhaps without noticing it slipping into her 'royal' voice, "that Miss Hissyfits enjoy a standing invitation to the kingdom of Snow. Mrs Mightyroar would be *delighted* to make her acquaintance." She gave Jack a somewhat shy look. "...and you can come too, I suppose."

"Oh..." Jack said, suddenly at a loss for words. "Um... thanks."

"Um... don't mention it," Frosta said, not meeting Jack's eyes.

It suddenly dawned on both of them just how close to each other the spell demanded them to stand.

"Um... should we...?" Jack began with a slight nod at the corridor in front of them.

"YES!" Frosta quickly said.

With some false starts, where they bumped into each other and had to take a brief blushing pause, they started to sneak down the corridor.

"...then why can't...?" Catra's voice cried for a moment, until the clang of big doors were heard, and her voice was reduce to a mumble.

Jack and Frosta sneaked up along the corridor wall. In front of them were the mighty doors leading into the throne room (the hole Glimmer had made hastily patched). Two worried looking guards stood outside with the the kind of expression guards have when they want to make it very clear that they have not heard a single word of the argument taking place inside the door they are guarding, and have absolutely no opinion on whatever subject might be at hand or any sides that might be forming.

Frosta glanced at Jack, who looked around with a thoughtful look. After a moment, their eyes fell on the door to a little room, not much more than a storage closet, by the side of the entrance. They silently pointed it out to Frosta, and then glanced at the guards.

Frosta nodded thoughtfully and held up her hand. She caught Jack's eyes and mouthed a silent 'one' followed by a 'two'.

The guards sharply looked up as a sounds was heard from down the corridor, as of fresh winter ice breaking. As they looked, they didn't notice the still partly cloaked Jack and Frosta who sneaked behind their backs and into the tiny room and closed the door.

"*YES*," Frosta whispered and pumped her fist in the air. Jack grinned at her and pointed at weirdly large ventilation shaft. After some pushing, they managed to squeeze up into it enough for them to be able to look out over the throne room.

"....to grab a bolt gun yourself to make it go faster, be my guest, *boss*," they heard Octavia say with hard voice. She stood in front of the throne, arms crossed.

"I'll tell you what..." Catra begun hotly, standing a few steps up. Lonnie quickly stepped in between them and held up her hands.

"Listen," she said with tired voice. "It doesn't matter how long it will take to repair the ship. We have plenty of ships ready to embark right now."

"Then why aren't they doing so?" Catra snarled.

"Embark *where*?" Octavia snarled back. "Care to point that out on the map for me?"

"I don't KNOW," Catra shouted with the voice of someone who has said the same thing ten times already, and didn't liked the answers she got any better after the first time. "She could have teleported *anywhere*."

"So what do you want me to do?" Octavia said, voice full of ice. "Pick a random spot in the ocean and start dredging? Sail around haphazardly and shout her name through the megaphone? With the Salinean princess out there waiting to make cat food out of us?"

"Interesting turn of phrase," Catra hissed.

"My Queen, if I may," Double Trouble said with their smarmiest voice. "We all know from ample, personal experience that Glimmer is one of the most dangerous people in this world. If she is... delayed, may I suggest it might not be because *she's* in danger but because she is busy kicking ass and taking names."

"And that's supposed to make me happier?" Catra snarled.

"It's not like she'd go to Brightmoon to fight Shadow Weaver on her own..." Lonnie begun, but silenced as Double Trouble quickly shook their head.

Catra glared at them.

"We can't just sit her and hope she'll poof back," she said, voice almost pleading. "We have to do something."

"We have every Horde command looking for her," Lonnie said with patient voice. "The moment she's spotted, we'll know. If she's... in need of help, they'll help her."

"Yeah? Because Glimmer is *so* beloved by the rank and file?" Catra spat.

Octavia looked like someone who works very hard to remain silent.

"They are scared shitless of her," Lonnie said and looked Catra in the eyes. "And they are scared shitless of you. Believe me - no one will try anything."

"You better be right," Catra said, something very ugly in her eyes.

"She is," Double Trouble said with a soothing grin. "Believe me, Kitten. If someone - if *anyone* - tries something with Sparkles, we will know. We can just follow the sound of explosions."

"We ran as fast as we could *from* the explosions," Catra pointed out. "We left her with yet another of Shadow Weaver's fucking puppets."

"Your princess bought us time precisely to get away," Octavia pointed out. "And for what it's worth, that's the only reason any of us are alive to complain about it."

"How noble of her," Catra snarled. "But now that we are alive, what are we supposed to *do*?"

Lonnie took a deep breath.

"We really should continue the push, Catra."

Catra glared at her, and Lonnie steeled herself.

"I know, I know," she hurriedly said. "But we just can't put the entire Horde on standby. Either we push towards Brightmoon, or we stand down. And if we do, we won't be able to get back in gear quickly."

"Glimmer could poof back any moment," Double Trouble helpfully added. "You know she won't be happy for more delays."

"And if she makes contact with any of the outposts, we will know about it," Lonnie added, holding up her comm pad.

"Fine," Catra growled. "We'll continue the push. In the meanwhile..."

"Not by sea," Octavia said with hard voice and the expression of someone prepared to speak uncomfortable truth all day long if needed.

"What?" Catra snarled.

"I said, we're not doing the push by sea," Octavia said. "Not without a way to neutralize the Salinean princess. Not unless you

want to drown half the fleet before we even get close to Brightmoon."

"You mean to tell me one single princess can stand in the way of the entire Horde fleet?" Lonnie snorted.

"You're welcome to try it yourself," Octavia said, a vicious glint in her eyes.

"Fine, then we go by the Whispering Woods," Catra spat.

Lonnie gave her a sceptical look, but just then her comm pad started beeping and she took a few steps away from the group.

"The troops can be ready to start whacking weeds first thing tomorrow," Octavia shrugged.

"Hey," Lonnie said, looking up from the pad. "I just got a message from the force captain in the unit outside of Plumeria. It seems Queen Glimmer..."

A sudden cloud of sparkles interrupted her, and Glimmer stepped out of empty air, clothes torn and burnt, skin glowing. Her black, crystalline staff crackled with purple power. Her expression was furious.

"Glimmer!" Catra cried and rushed up to her, face full of worry. "Are you...?"

"Where is Frosta?" Glimmer demanded. Her skin burned with excess power.

Frosta and Jack exchanged a quick glance.

"What?" Catra said, bewildered.

"Frosta," Glimmer repeated through gritted teeth. "The Princess of Winter and the Queen of Snow. Don't tell me you lost her on the way back."

"Of course not," Catra said. "Jack's keeping an eye on her. Last time I heard, they were raiding the kitchen. But where have...?"

"I'll get Frosta," Double Trouble quickly said as Glimmer opened her mouth to spit out an answer.

They hurried towards the large doors. Jack and Frosta looked at each other, but before they had time to decide if they should scramble for the door or stay put, Double Trouble turned to look right at their vent.

They winked.

"Did they see us?" Frosta whispered.

"Seems like it," Jack said.

A moment after a quick little knock was heard, and Double Trouble slunk through the door to their closet and closed it behind them.

"How did you know that we were here?" Jack demanded.

"Don't take it as a slight of your stealthy abilities," Double Trouble said with low voice. "You were quite competent. But I *am* a master of the trade."

"What happens now?" Frosta asked.

"Now we listen to what they have to say when they don't think you can hear them," Double Trouble said. "A most useful habit."

Jack looked doubtful, but they didn't protest. They turned their attention back to the people in the room.

"Where have you *been*?" Catra exclaimed. "I was..." she glanced at Octavia. "...concerned," she finished.

Glimmer snorted.

"I was in Plumeria," she said between gritted teeth. "In the most aggravating company. But it was an illuminating trip."

With a visible effort to stay calm, she dematerialized her staff.

"Oh yeah?" Catra said. "So what happened. What's with Plumeria that's so important."

"More what *isn't* in Plumeria," Glimmer snarled. "The Heart Blossom. The runestone of plants has been *stolen*." She turned to stare at Lonnie. "Apparently without anyone in the Horde unit stationed there being the wiser."

Lonnie paled and took a quick step back from the furious princess.

"We... we did evacuate Plumeria," she said, knowing very well what was to come.

"So this is *my* fault, is it?" Glimmer snarled.

Lonnie said nothing. Catra stepped in between them.

"Don't mind who's fault it is," she said "The Plumerians turned out to be as shitty treasure keepers as they were fighters. So what?"

"So *what*?" Glimmer spat. "Who do you think might take an interest in collecting runestones?"

"We've had one of those forever," Lonnie protested, "and no one except Entrapta ever got anything useful from it."

"Well, it wasn't Entrapta, who stole it," Glimmer snarled. "And it wasn't Entrapta who controlled Mermista. Shadow Weaver is collecting princesses and she want the full set." She spun around and glared at the door. "*Where the hell is Frosta?*"

"Thaaaaaat's our cue," Double Trouble said and quickly shooed the teenager out of the room. They nodded to the guards, and together they walked into the throne room.

"Your majesties," they said with loud voice. "Allow me to formally introduce Queen Frosta of Snow."

Frosta waved, a bit shy.

"Um... hi Glimmer!" she said, and then she took a step back and - almost unconsciously - took Jack's hand as Glimmer stepped up to her, radiating of fury.

"Frosta," Glimmer demanded. "Where is Perfuma."

"Um... what?" Frosta asked, taken aback by the hostility.

"You heard me," Glimmer snarled. "Where is Perfuma."

"I... I don't know," Frosta confessed, edging a bit closer to Jack. "Spinnerella and Netossa said she left Plumeria before it fell - that's *why* it fell. Without her in Plumeria, Netossa and Spinnerella could only hold the fort in Plumeria for so long."

"That explains why the final push got so easy," Lonnie mused.

"Why would she leave," Glimmer asked and managed to keep her voice at least somewhat even.

"She wanted to look for the other princesses... for Mermista, Adora, Scorpia... and you," Frosta said. "She... she managed to sneak into Brightmoon, but what she saw spook her real bad. Apparently, Shadow Weaver has possessed a lot of people. Perfuma tried to free some of them, but she failed. She came to me after that... um... she and Spinnerella and Netossa argued a lot. They blamed each other for what happened to Plumeria..."

Her voice trailed off. Jack squeezed her hand.

"Then what happened?" Glimmer said, voice less hostile. She bent down slightly and touched Frosta's shoulder.

"Then... then she left again," Frosta mumbled. "It was a little while after Netossa and Spinnerella went to see you. Um... I

wanted to go to the Crimson Waste, but they said no and the Horde kept attacking..."

Lonnie and Octavia very carefully said nothing.

"Do you know where she went?" Glimmer asked kindly, even if the rage was still simmering under the surface.

"She... she said she had a lead on Mermista," Frosta said with a worried look at Glimmer. "She thought Shadow Weaver nabbed her all the way back when we tried to ambush the Horde... I think Perfuma went to Seaworthy first, and was trying to find a way to get to Salineas."

Something dark passed Glimmer's eyes.

"Salineas," she said, voice heavy.

"Y-yeah," Frosta said. "At least that's what Spinnerella said. Perfuma never told me where she was going when she left."

"I see," Glimmer said after a short pause. "And after that you didn't hear from her?"

"No..." Frosta admitted. "This was just before you took over here." She did a sweeping gesture at the throne and then made a shy little smile. "Um... that was really cool, by the way."

"Thanks," Glimmer said, a genuine smile flittering past her lips.

She took a deep breath and looked Frosta in the eyes.

"Then what happened," she asked with low voice. "Why did Mermista chase you? How did you end up on our ship."

Frosta took another little step towards Jack.

"She... she attacked us," she mumbled. "In Snow. She just came from nowhere and her eyes..." she shuddered. "Spinnerella got me out, but then Mermista chased after us. She's more powerful

than I've ever seen her before. I got separated from the others and tried to flee, but Mermista followed. I thought if I could get to the Fright Zone, maybe you could help me, but before I got here, she managed to force me out to sea..."

She shuddered.

"I saw your ships and... yeah."

"You did very well," Glimmer said with low, somewhat numb voice. "I fought her myself and... well, I barely got out alive."

"*How* did you get out alive?" Catra exclaimed. What *happened*, Glimmer?"

"There will be plenty of time for that story later," Glimmer said with dismissive voice. She looked Frosta in the eyes.

"Frosta," she said, voice serious. "Where is your runestone? Is the Fractal Flake safe?"

"It's..." Frosta glanced around, seemingly uncomfortable with the discussing the topic around so many people. "Um... there are safety measures... there is a guardian..."

Glimmer breathed out.

"It should be safe enough for now, then," she said. "Until we can get it. Where are Netossa and Spinnerella."

"I have no idea," Frosta said after just a moment of hesitation. "I'm pretty sure Mermista didn't get them. She followed me the entire time."

"We'll deal with them once they deign to make contact, then," Glimmer said, just a hint of frost in her voice. "Until then, you'll be safe here."

She smiled, and Frosta released a breath she hadn't realised she had held.

Glimmer stood up and turned to Catra.

"How has the tactical situation unfolded?" she said.

"We're preparing to continue the push through the Whispering Woods," Catra begun, "but what..."

"We will not do that," Glimmer countered. "The soldiers will stand down and we will delay the push until the path is clear."

"What?" Catra shouted, bewildered. "Do you have any idea how much..."

"I do have some experience of military logistics, yes, my queen," Glimmer said with cold voice. "And I have been paying attention to Lonnie's reports. I know perfectly well what it will demand in terms of wasted preparations and re-organisation."

"But why?" Catra demanded. "We've pushed through the Whispering Woods before. Hell, I was almost by Brightmoon by the time Hordak decided it was time to pull the rug under me."

Octavia grinned, but she didn't say anything.

"You have not done so facing the Princess of Plants boosted by the Heart of Etheria," Glimmer said, the rage breaking through her voice again. "You think Mermista was scary? Perfuma would *devour* whatever forces we send her way."

Double Trouble sharply looked up.

"'The Heart of Etheria', my Queen?'" they asked, voice carefully neutral.

"Shadow Weaver has cracked the vault open," Glimmer snarled, her rage evident. "I don't know how, but she's feeding that power to Mermista. And if she has captured Perfuma, she'll be sure to do the same thing with her."

"We don't even know that she has captured Perfuma," Catra protested.

"She has Perfuma's runestone," Glimmer said, power radiating off her. "How long do you think it will take her?"

"Dunno," Catra spat back. "Shadow Weaver has your runestone too, and any attempt she made to grab you, you kicked her in the crotch and sent her packing. Granted, you are ten times more awesome than the flower princess, but cut her *some* slack."

"The whole fucking *reason* Shadow Weaver has taken Perfuma and Mermista is because *I* failed to protect them," Glimmer screamed, taking a threatening step towards Catra. "So if you think any of this is fucking *funny*..."

"I'll order the soldiers to stand down," Lonnie quickly interrupted.

"Do that," Glimmer said, turning away from Catra with a snarl. "But be prepared for them to board the ships the moment I've found a way to deal with Mermista.

"I'm on it, my Queen," Lonnie quickly said and walked towards the door, obviously happy for an excuse to leave the room. Octavia looked like she was about to follow her, but Glimmer stopped her with a look.

"Octavia," she said, voice deceptively calm again. "Tell me, is the Horde in control of Salineas."

"That's what all the flags say, boss," the admiral muttered.

"Then could you put our flag ship in order to take me there in a manner that suits the Queen of the Horde?" Glimmer went on in the same voice.

"I wouldn't recommend it, no, boss," Octavia answered. "Not with the ocean princess out there."

"So then we are not really in charge, are we?" Glimmer said through gritted teeth.

"If I may, my Queen," Double Trouble smoothly interjected, "the illusion of Salineas under Horde control still holds, even if it's weak. There are... competing factions, each with their own agenda, who have carved a substantial amount of influence from the Horde. But as of this moment, none of them are prepared to seize power for themselves."

"That's something, at least," Glimmer muttered. "Keep an ear to the ground, the two of you. If the situation changes in Salineas, I want to know about it immediately."

Double Trouble bowed and Octavia gave her a curt nod, and together they left the throne room.

Glimmer took a deep breath and sat down on the lowest step of the throne. She did a little gesture to Catra, who immediately sat down by her side.

"I'm sorry I had you spooked, Catra," Glimmer said with tired voice. "I can only imagine what it must have been like for you."

"I knew you could take her," Catra said with voice shaking. "I just didn't know... what took you so long."

"Shadow Weaver won't get me," Glimmer said. "I promise."

She held out her arms, and Catra gladly sank down in them. They hugged each other for a long, long time, with Jack and Frosta not really knowing where to look.

Glimmer stood up, with Catra reluctantly letting go of her.

"Frosta," Glimmer said, with slightly detached voice. "I'm glad to see you again. In time we will be able to catch up, but right now there are urgent work for me."

"It's OK," Frosta said quickly. "Jack's looking after me."

Glimmer looked at her and Jack - still holding hands - and the shadow of a smile passed her lips.

"I'm glad," she said, and started to walk towards the door.

"What work?" Catra demanded. "What are you going to *do*, Sparkles?"

"I'm going to do what I should have done from the beginning," Glimmer said, fatigue giving way to determination. "I'll find a way to take out Shadow Weaver."

"That's what we're working on, unless you missed it," Catra cried.

"Yes," Glimmer said. "And we failed. Now we will do things *my* way. And for that I need a runestone."

"Glimmer!" Catra protested, but before she could add anything else, Glimmer disappeared in a cloud of pink glitter. With a groan of frustration, Catra walked to the door and with quick steps stomped down the corridor, towards the Black Garnet chamber.

Jack and Frosta stared after her.

"They... get like that sometimes," Jack said with apologetic voice. "Mostly when they are scared."

"It was the same with Perfuma, Netossa and Spinnerella," Frosta reported.

They looked at each other.

"Grown-ups, huh?" Frosta said, rolling their eyes.

"They're all so *stupid*," Jack agreed, grinning in return.

They laughed. After the tense conversation, it felt so good to laugh together.

"Come," Jack said. "Let's see what's for dinner."

"Please don't say 'ration bars'," Frosta groaned.

"You know it!" Jack laughed.

Together they left the throne room.

- - -

Frosta and Jack spent most of the day after that exploring. The Fright Zone was full of nooks and crannies where two adventurous teenagers can get in all sorts of trouble, and they took full advantage of it. Then there was the question of living quarters...

"Um... it's really the only bed we have that's fit for a princess so... um.... maybe if you wanted to you could... share it? With... me?"

Frosta wanted to share the bed with Jack.

After a while they settled down on a roof to talk.

They had a lot to talk about. A lonely princess growing up in a frozen castle with the weight of generations on her shoulder, a Crimson Waste thug with nothing to their name except what they could steal, their worlds had been as different as could be. But still as they sat there, together, and listened and laughed and asked questions, they felt that they might be pretty similar, after all.

They talked about Glimmer, about what she had told them. They lowered their voices and glanced with worried eyes at the shadows that grew longer as the sun set.

"Shadow Weaver is really trying to catch you?" Jack asked, voice trembling slightly.

"Yeah," Frosta sighed. "Bundles of fun, sometimes, being a princess."

"It must be scary," Jack whispered.

"Nah," Frosta said, trying to be brave. "If she tries something, I'll punch the daylight out of her" - she formed an ice fist as means of illustration. "Also, I'm with Glimmer now. No way that washed up old witch can get one past Glimmer."

"You're right, Jack said with heartfelt voice. I saw how she dragged Shadow Weaver right out of Huntara's head when they fought back in the Waste."

"...wow," Frosta said. "I wish I could have been there instead of being locked up in my stupid castle."

"It was scary, sometimes," Jack admitted.

"You were with Glimmer, weren't you," Frosta countered. "Of course you made it out in one piece."

"Yeah," Jack admitted.

Frosta glanced at Jack.

"...and even if that mean ol' witch manages to slip past Glimmer, you'll protect me, won't you, Jack?"

Jack blushed.

"You're an elemental princess, and I'm just a Crimson Waste thug who learnt some tricks. I'm not sure I'd be able to..."

"Of course you could," Frosta said with admiration in her voice. "You actually know magic. All I know is how to freeze and punch stuff. And hey, if you ever run out of sparks or whatever, you could borrow some from me."

She held out her hand with a little blush - blue energy playing over it - and after just a moment of hesitation Jack took it.

They looked each other in the eyes and Jack felt the magic energy move into them from Frosta. Despite what one might have

expected, it didn't feel cold. It rather felt... warm, and slightly tingly.

Frosta laughed happily as Jack weaved a circle with their free hand, and bright light flowed over their little balcony, like glowing honey.

"See," Frosta said. "No wicked witch will get one over us."

They looked at each other in the glowing light, and even if they couldn't quite articulate why, they both felt that they didn't want to let go of the other's hand just yet.

Chapter End Notes

> Turns out, this entire story is just a framing device for a Young Adult adventure/romance with Jack and Frosta as protagonists.

A Little Lovers' Spat

Chapter Notes

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The purple light pulsed from the Black Garnet chamber. Catra felt the familiar dread in the pit of her stomach as she walked up to the door. She had to stand tip-toes to reach the handle, but she managed to push it open.

The chamber was full of shadows, slithering around in the corners, brushing against her tail and legs. In the middle stood the Black Garnet, towering monolithically over her.

Catra trudged up to the two people by the glowing runestone. It felt like she had to walk for several minutes to cover the short distance, and all the time the shadow tugged at her.

"Hi Catra," the blonde girl happily whispered as Catra finally reached them.

"Hey, Adora," Catra muttered without enthusiasm.

"Glimmer is showing me what she can do with the Black Garnet," Adora went on. "Isn't she great?"

"Sure is," Catra muttered unhappily. She glanced at the tall figure towering over them, covered in black cloth. Despite everything, Catra couldn't stop a little shiver along her spine as the pink-haired woman turned to look at her, eyes expressionless under the mask.

"Catra," the smooth, cold voice chided. "I thought I had ordered you to remain outside this chamber."

"Yet here I am," Catra muttered.

"Yet here you are," Glimmer agreed. "What is to be done with an disobedient child, such as yourself?"

"I'm sure you will think of something," Catra sighed.

"Please, don't punish her," Adora pleaded. "She can't help that she's a bad friend."

"Got that in too, did you," Catra said and rolled her eyes. "Bravo."

"You are insolent," Glimmer said, eyes hard. "But that doesn't matter. *You* don't matter."

"It's true, you don't," Adora agreed. "Glimmer chose me, after all."

"And I will do so again," Glimmer said. "First chance I get."

"I don't blame her," Adora said with a little chuckle. "She'd have to be pretty desperate to pick you, after all."

"Very funny," Catra muttered. "Can I wake up now?"

"Not yet," Glimmer said, a sadistic smirk on her lips. "Because I just thought of a suitable punishment."

"No thanks, I'm good," Catra tried to say, but the purple light that lashed out from Glimmer's hands paralysed her, and prevented her from getting a single sound out.

"Please don't hurt her," Adora pleaded, stepping in front of Catra, who was now lifted up in the air by the magic power.

"Oh, but I will," Glimmer said. She stepped closer, her mask filling Catra's entire world. "And she knows it. That why she doesn't trust me."

Catra opened her eyes.

She took a deep breath.

Friggin' nightmares.

She idly wondered if they truly were the fruits of some dark seed Shadow Weaver had planted last time she messed with her mind, or if it was just her subconscious getting creative.

Some difference.

Catra sat up in bed and glanced to the side.

No Glimmer.

She wish that would have surprised her.

Still not entirely awake, she sat up and put on her mask. She left the chamber and nodded at the guard.

"Your majesty!" the guard dared to say. "Force commander Lonnie..."

"Yeah, yeah. You can consider the message delivered," Catra muttered and walked up to the breakfast tray some thoughtful underling had left, following the logic that you don't want the boss to be hungry. She ignored the more fancy dishes and picked a grey ration bar. Munching on a corner she walked to the door, then upon reflection doubled back and picked up the tray itself.

She walked down the corridor, not taking notice of the underlings who scurried out of her way. She walked sharp left at the intersection where the right path would bring her to the throne room, and then up a staircase.

Rogelio stood nonchalantly leaned against a wall, bopping on a comm pad. Catra gave him a sour look.

"Lonnie is placing spotters now?"

Rogelio growled and gave her a little shrug.

Catra sighed.

"Tell her I'll be in the throne room in half an hour, OK? Just a few things to take care of."

Rogelio nodded. Then he made a sympathetic little sound Catra hadn't heard in a long time.

Not directed at her.

"Yeah... thanks," she mumbled, quickly looking away.

Rogelio followed her with worried eyes as she kept walking.

Catra walked slowly along the corridor. This was a section of the Fright Zone that had fallen in disrepair over the years, and it wasn't used much. Catra's ears twitched this way and that. After a little while she started to grin.

She stopped just by a rickety old door, leading to a balcony that threatened to fall at any moment, and put down the tray. She then stepped back and leaned against the opposite wall, and waited.

She didn't have to wait long.

"Um... hi," Jack said, opening the door and blushing slightly. "How did you know we were here?"

"I know all the best spots," Catra said with a grin, ignoring the little pang of pain at the memory of exactly *why* she knew the best spots. "I figured you kids might want some breakfast."

"Thanks, Catra," Frosta said from behind Jack. Catra nodded at her.

"Have you seen Gimmer," she said with low voice.

"Oh, she's... working," Jack said, concern radiating from them.

"She didn't want to talk to us," Frosta added. "I don't think she's slept tonight."

They looked at each other in silence for a few moments, sharing concern without verbalizing it.

"I'll talk to her," Catra said eventually. "You kids enjoy the breakfast."

And she kept walking to the Black Garnet chamber.

Catra ignored the cold feeling in the pit of her stomach and pushed the door open. Glimmer stood by the black garnet, looking almost like a child next to the towering runestone. Purple light snaked around her.

Catra picked up the tray left inside the door and walked up to her.

"Hey, Sparkles," she said with low voice.

She waited while Glimmer took a deep breath and compose herself before turning around.

"Hey, fussybutt," Glimmer said with forced cheer. "Finally awake, huh?"

"I felt like sleeping in," Catra lied. "How's the work coming along?"

"Fine, just fine," Glimmer lied. "There's a lot of complexity in the interface, and the underlying energy infrastructure is of course attuned to the Scorpion royal family."

"Of course," Catra echoed.

"But I'm getting there," Glimmer said with an edge to her voice.

"Don't doubt it," Catra said.

She held up a grey ration bar.

"Breakfast?"

For a moment, Glimmer looked like she would argue, but then she shrugged and took the bar.

They sat down on a crate by the wall, containing some forgotten tech equipment.

"How're the soldiers doing?" she asked eventually.

"Fine," Catra shrugged. "Lonnie worries about morale, which is fine because that's her job to worry about. But there's no immediate crisis."

"Good," Glimmer said.

Catra nodded and grabbed a bar of her own.

"I've no idea how Entrapta made it look so easy," Glimmer confessed after a little while, nodding at the Black Garnet.

"That's Entrapta for you," Catra sighed. "Leave her alone for an afternoon and she'd whip up a total game changer. Of course, with the rock she didn't as much take control of it as push it out of balance. I figure that must be easier."

"Yeah..." Glimmer said.

They sat in silence, each nursing their bad conscience concerning Entrapta.

"Has it ever been done before, what you're trying to do?" Catra asked casually.

"No," Glimmer admitted through gritted teeth. "No elemental princess has ever connected to someone else's runestone. I don't even know of anyone who tried it. Shadow Weaver came closest, and she spent decades figuring it out."

"Well, she wasn't an elemental princess," Catra said with light voice. "She wasn't *you*."

Glimmer gave her a thankful look.

"I can do it," she muttered.

"You can do it," Catra said with low voice.

She took a deep breath.

This was as good as it was going to get.

"Only... I'm not so sure it's the best course of action right now."

Glimmer's body language stiffened. She glared at Catra.

"Oh?" she said with a voice that could keep Frosta's entire castle frozen for a full day.

"Seems to me... she's forcing our hand," Catra went on, forcing her voice to remain casual. "I think we might want to... explore alternatives."

"We have tried your way," Glimmer said with cold eyes. "Shadow Weaver stopped us. We need to meet her on her arena. We need to fight magic with magic."

"So it's all up to you, huh?" Catra said, just a little edge to her voice.

"Unless you happen to have another princess stashed somewhere..." Glimmer said coldly.

Catra took a breath.

She didn't foresee this conversation to be anything but bad, but she had to try.

"Yeah... about that," she muttered.

Glimmer turned and gave her a hard look.

"*What*."

"You think She-Ra is magical enough to pave us a way to Brightmoon?" Catra quickly said before she had second thoughts.

"*Now* you bring her up?" Glimmer hissed. "You haven't said a word about her for forever."

"Yeah..." Catra muttered, guiltily rubbing her hands. "We don't really talk about her, do we?"

"And for good reasons," Glimmer snarled. "Adora isn't here in case you haven't noticed."

"I know," Catra said with level voice. "She's on Beast Island."

"Not much help to us then, is she?" Glimmer said, voice like ice.

"We have boats now, Sparkles," Catra said, voice slightly pleading. "The Horde used to send prisoners there regularly. We could go and... get her."

"What?" Glimmer snarled. "You think they would just come with us? 'So great to see you again. Ooooh I hear you are evil now, so interesting. Of course we'll help you!'"

"You don't think they would help us take down Shadow Weaver?" Catra asked, bewildered.

"Why should they?" Glimmer snarled. "When they can just go back to rebellion and keep fighting the evil Horde. Fun with a breather, back to business."

Catra regarded her in silence for a moment, composing her thoughts.

"Glimmer," she said as gently as she could. "I realize this is a first for you, but some of us are old hats at being targeted by Adora. She might not agree with what we're doing, but she won't hate us." she chuckle ruefully. "She's really annoying like that."

"So glad to hear you find it amusing," Glimmer said between gritted teeth. "But in case you didn't notice, we *can't* go to Beast Island. It's an *island*. There's an *ocean* between us and it. And

Mermista would *drown* us if we try. Remember? It was a whole thing."

"Yeah, we can't take the armada to Brightmoon," Catra agreed. "Sneaking one ship to Beast Island is another matter. Especially if we run some distractions."

"You truly think so little of princesses, do you?" Glimmer accused.

"What?" Catra asked, bewildered. "I know Shadow Weaver has you spooked, Glimmer, but even with her upgrades, the mermaid princess is not unstoppable. I took her entire city behind her back, remember?"

"Thanks for that delightful reminder of how easily duped I am," Glimmer shouted. "You and Double Trouble must have laughed until you got the hiccups from that one."

"I didn't mean..." Catra tried.

"Well, seeing how useless I am, I should really focus on trying to pull my weight around her, so if you excuse me, *my queen*..."

Glimmer turned her back to Catra and faced the Black Garnet again. With a furious growl, she released a stream of magic, causing the light from the runestone to flair up.

"Glimmer..." Catra tried.

"Thank you, Catra, that will be all," Glimmer hissed without turning her back.

Catra clenched her fists in frustration and stared at the pink head of her wife.

"Just like that?" she spat. "You're throwing me out like I'm a flunkie?"

"I won't take more of your precious time," Glimmer snarled. "I'm sure it's better spent elsewhere."

"Dammit, Sparkles!" Catra cried. "It wasn't supposed to *be* like this. Not this time."

"Sorry, to disappoint," Glimmer said between gritted teeth, still without turning around.

"This time around it was supposed to be you and me against the world," Catra cried, her voice rising. "Not me wringing my hands with you shut in here like..."

"Like *who?*" Glimmer snarled and spun around, tendrils of purple light oozing from her hands.

Catra flinched and took two step backwards. Her body was crouched, as if she was ready to flee.

For a moment, she and Glimmer stared at each other.

Then Glimmer forced herself to relax. The purple light abruptly died down.

"Catra..." she whispered. "I'm sorry."

Catra slowly relaxed her stance.

"I... I'm just tired," Glimmer lied. "I... I will go and lie down a little while. We'll talk later, OK?"

"It's OK," Catra said, trying to get her breathing under control. "I'll... I'll just keep an eye on things until then. OK?"

"OK," Glimmer said.

"OK," Catra answered.

They stared at each other.

Then Catra slowly turned around and left the chamber, leaving Glimmer to stare at the closed door.

The light from the Black Garnet pulsed, almost like heartbeats.

- - -

Lonnie stood by the foot of the throne, swiping at a comm pad. She looked up as Catra entered the room. Her fur was still slightly damp, like if she had just washed her face.

"Glad to see you boss," she said with a tone of voice that not entirely managed to hide the implied 'finally'.

"Glad to see you too, Lonnie," Catra muttered, which earned her a concerned glance. "What fresh crises to you have for me today?"

"The pirates are getting bolder," Lonnie said, consulting her comm pad. "So far they're just testing the waters" -she frowned at the unintended pun- "but as soon as they realize Octavia is hiding in port rather than out there hunting them, we will see a free-for-all for the oceans."

"And they don't have any trouble with Mermista?" Catra asked.

Lonnie shrugged.

"There have been a few sightings of her, but she mostly leave smaller ships alone. Some of the bigger independent 'merchants' have been chased back into port, though."

"I'm sure they're having a field day over in Salineas," Catra remarked.

Lonnie pinched the bridge of her nose.

"So far, the Horde command still holds, even if that doesn't mean much considering how bribed everyone on that fucking island is. But your pet lizard's prediction hold true this far - no single faction has dared to move against the others yet. But I'm giving it a week or less for someone to get bold."

"And the soldiers?" Catra asked and sat down on a step.

"Morale holds so far," Lonnie carefully said. "But everyone is waiting for the other shoe to drop."

"And with the other shoe you mean..." Catra prompted.

"Queen Glimmer," Lonnie said and looked her in the eyes. "Some of the old hands grumble, but the new recruits that were with you in the Waste all swear she can juggle stars and fart fire."

"Well, that's something," Catra sighed. She flashed Lonnie a quick grin. "Looks like we are down to princess tricks, eh, Lonnie?"

"It would seem that way," Lonnie said with carefully neutral expression.

"...unless you have other suggestions?" Catra prompted.

"It isn't for me to question my queen..." Lonnie begun.

"Bullcrap," Catra interrupted. "I've had your job, remember, and even if I made a mess off it, I know what's it means. It means, you figure shit out while the boss sulks. So tell me, Lonnie. We've got two overpowered princesses standing between us and Brightmoon. How would *you* deal with it?"

Lonnie gave Catra a quick, genuine smile and handed her the comm pad.

"I might have one or two little ideas..." she admitted.

"Multiple commando teams..." Catra read. "...funnel her into a narrow bay - oh, you have included maps - nets... mines... yes, you have done your homework... any thoughts to the members of the teams?"

"I might have a few names in mind," Lonnie carefully said. "We could even use you, if you could spare the time."

"So glad to be included," Catra said with dry voice.

"That's how you took out Hordak, after all," Lonnie said with what almost sounded like admiration in her voice.

"I see no mention of teleportation in the tactical assessment..." Catra said in a voice that was almost but not really a question."

"I felt it presumptuous to include Queen Glimmer in our plans," Lonnie said, face a mask. "After all, she has important princess business to attend to."

"Also, we are setting out to kill one of her bests friends," Catra said with low voice.

Lonnie said nothing.

"Put the teams together, but keep it quiet," Catra said without changing her tone of voice. "I don't feel we need to bother Glimmer or Double Trouble with this little project."

Lonnie gave her a thankful smile.

"Yes, your majesty," she said.

She took the comm pad and left the room.

- - -

"Ooooh, look at this!" Jack said and held up what appeared to be a metal statue of a centipede, and then hastily dropped it as a leg twisted.

"Hah, classic Entrapta," Frosta grinned. "I've fought so many of her bots. There's always a quirk."

They were poking around in an old workshop, abandoned since the tech princess' banishment. They had quickly realized what a treasure trove anything Entrapta-related were to youngsters of an inquiring mind and a sense for the macabre. So far they had been nearly electrocuted, immolated and stabbed by a particularly grumpy robot. They considered it an excellent use of their time.

"I don't know much about her," Jack admitted and poked the centipede again in the hope of it doing something weird. "Glimmer and Catra don't like talking about her."

"I only met her once," Frosta said. "When I hosted Princess Prom." She laughed, a bit ruefully. "I was just a kid back then, and I wanted to impress the other princesses so bad. And Entrapta was a riot. She didn't care what anyone thought. I wish I had had more time to get to know her."

"I can't imagine what it's like, being you," Jack sighed. "Hosting fancy balls, hanging around with princesses, being magical..."

"Hey, you hang out with princesses," Frosta protested. "And you are totally magical."

"I *can do* magic," Jack said. "You *are* magical. Totally different."

"Oh, I don't know," Frosta muttered, beeping randomly on an old data pad. "You are magical to me..."

She blushed slightly as she whispered the last words.

"What was that?" Jack said, still busy with the centipede.

They hopefully waited for Frosta to elaborate, but didn't get any answers. They looked up and saw Frosta stare at the pad, white in her face.

"Frosta?" Jack asked.

"Jack..." Frosta said slowly, "you who know magic, can you look at this?"

"I'm not sure I know that much ma..." Jack begun, but their voice trailed off as they looked at the data pad over Frosta's shoulder."

"Does this mean what I think it does?" Frosta asked, voice frightened.

"I... um... I don't know," Jack confessed. They stood up. "But I think Glimmer needs to see this right away."

Frosta put a hand on their arm.

"I think we need to talk to Netossa and Spinnerella first," she said with low, cautious voice.

- - -

The throne.

The Throne.

The symbol of power and authority. Even now, even after Hordak, the symbol of the terrifying, unifying purpose of the Horde.

Alone on the throne, Catra sat.

A lone figure slowly, hesitantly walked up to it.

"Get out!" Catra growled. for a moment, a casual observer might have thought Hordak never left.

"Sorry!" A voice close to panic said. "I just... sorry, Catra. I just thought... maybe you could use... someone to talk to?"

Catra stared at the figure by the foot of the throne.

"Kyle?"

"Sorry..." the force captain said. "Um... I know you... are busy, but..."

For a moment it looked like Catra would growl at him again. Scream and threaten and ensure no one got close enough to threaten the shield she carefully had built up.

But... what was the point?

She sagged down in the throne, and suddenly the Queen of the Horde looked very small.

"...Catra? Kyle asked, carefully taking a step up the throne, and then another one - knowing perfectly well that how much hurt she was capable of inflicting, should she so chose.

Catra didn't answer. She buried her face in her hands, and to his great shock, Kyle realized she was crying.

It had been a long, long time since Catra had let him see her cry.

Walking the final distance he sat down on the top step of the throne and slowly, awkwardly, put a hand on her arm. Catra tensed at first, but then she relaxed. Allowed the hand and the comfort that came with it.

They sat like that, in silence, for what must have been at least a few minutes, Catra crying silently in her hands, Kyle patiently sitting next to her.

"What are you doing here, Kyle?" Catra asked eventually, not looking at him.

"I... I never really talked to you when Scorpia... left," he said after some hesitation. "And later I thought that.. maybe if I someone *had* talked to you after Scorpia left, maybe things would have been better, so this time I thought... maybe this is also one of those times when... when you might not mind someone to talk to?"

Catra didn't answer for a little while.

Then she sighed. A shivering sigh.

"I'm loosing her," she said, almost too low for Kyle to hear.

"Glimmer?" he asked, bewildered.

"This place... this fucking place... it destroys us," Catra said a bit forcefully. "Adora and Scorpia did the smart thing. You should to," she said and looked up at him with a glare.

"We're not leaving you," Kyle quickly said.

"Then you're more stupid than I thought," Catra muttered.

"I don't think Glimmer wants to leave you either," Kyle tried.

Catra snorted.

"Me and Rogelio... sometimes when we have a little spat... we take it to the gym," Kyle tried. "Just punching sand bags or sparring together. Feels good to... you know, just move, together."

Catra sighed.

"Thanks Kyle, but this isn't the kind of thing you just sweat out. I just don't know how to reach her," Catra cried in frustration. "Whatever I do she gets angry or dismiss me. I don't want to push her too far, don't want to scare her away... I just don't know what to do."

Kyle watched her in sympathy.

"I wonder..." he said slowly... "when Adora asked you to come with her to the rebellion... what could she have said to actually make you join her?"

Catra stared at him in slowly dawning comprehension.

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"Glimmer..." Catra said with low voice. "Are you in there? Can I talk to you?"

There was no answer from within the Black Garnet chamber. Catra sighed. She hesitated for a moment, then she sat down in the corridor with her back towards the door.

"I'm scared," she said in a voice that she hoped was loud enough to be heard inside the chamber. She perked her ears. Did she hear a sound?

"I'm scared of loosing you," she went on. "Scared of... doing the wrong thing. Don't get me wrong. I know Shadow Weaver hurt you, hurt you in ways I can't imagine..." She grimaced. "And you believe me - I can imagine *a lot* of ways she can hurt people."

She sighed.

"She took something from you. Something that's you. I know shit of what it means to be an elemental princess, but I don't have to know that to understand that she..."

Catra felt tears forming in her eyes.

"...hurt the woman I love," she whispered.

Still no sound were heard from inside the chamber.

"If I..." Catra had to swallow a few times before she could continue. "If I could give that back to you, the thing she took, I would in a heartbeat." She snarled. "If killing the witch will do that, I'm more than willing. You know that, Glimmer. It's only..." Catra took a deep breath. "It's only that I'm not so sure that killing her will be worth it." She had to interrupt herself for another sob.

"Don't get me wrong," she quickly added. "We'll get around to it, eventually. Your castle and your rock... those are important. We will get them back... but you are more important."

There, she had said it.

"We can get help, Glimmer," she whispered. "I think we need help. I'm not talking about all this scary magic stuff... I'm talking about you. Me... Us. About being us.... Glimmer, I think... I think we're having another portal moment here. I beg you Glimmer, do not pull the lever."

Silence.

Tears still flowing, Catra got to her feet.

"I'm coming in, Glimmer, OK?" she said. "I'm coming in, and we talk and... and I won't force you. If you still want to do this, I'm behind you. I just... please, just talk to me first."

She pressed open the door and stepped in.

The room was empty. Only the Black Garnet stood proud and tall, seemingly radiating of menacing power.

Chapter End Notes

> There is no contractual rule saying I can only use the force field scene ONCE in a fic, is there?

Staff meeting

Chapter Notes

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

Warning: Some pretty nasty bullying in this one

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"We got the new orders?" Stripe asked.

"Sure," Slug answered. "Got them from Lonnie this morning."

"So, we're finally moving towards Brightmoon?" Stripe pressed.

Slug made a sour face.

"'Equipment maintenance'," she sighed.

"*Again?*" Striped groaned. "How much can a blaster be polished anyway?"

"It's just busywork," Slug shrugged. "You know, keeping us occupied."

"That's such bullshit," Stripe snarled. "Remember when Catra called the shots alone? She wouldn't let us just sit on our asses."

"On the other hand, shit broke down a lot more," Slug mused.

"She got shit done," Stripe snarled. "Her fucking princess would just have us..."

"*SHUT UP*," Slug hissed, face suddenly full of fear.

"Excuse me," a new voice said, full of venom. "I couldn't help to hear you mention Queen Glimmer."

Stripe scrambled to her feet. Behind her stood one of Glimmer's ladies-in-waiting, dressed in their easily recognizable robes and veil. Two others were walking their way.

"I just..." Stripe begun, but they lady-in-waiting interrupted her.

"I heard you mention Queen Glimmer in a less than respectful tone..."

"I'm leaving, OK," Stripe said, taking a step to the side, but the lady-in-waiting took a quick step to the side, blocking her path. Stripe gave Slug a pleading look, but Slug just stared at her, white in the face.

"What's going on, sister?" One of the newly arrived ladies-in-waiting asked.

"This soldier is disrespectful of our Queen," the first lady-in-waiting hissed.

"I didn't mean..." Stripe protested.

"Disrespectful?" the other lady-in-waiting echoed.

"Disrespectful of our Queen?" the third filled in.

"I did not..." Stripe begun, but was the roughly knocked to the floor.

"What should we do, sister?" one of the ladies-in-waiting asked the others with calm, conversational voice.

"What should we do we the one who is disrespectful of our Queen," the other filled in.

"How should we teach her *proper* respect," the third asked rhetorically as Stripe scrambled to her feet.

"Fuck you," she cried in a futile attempt to hide her fear. She tried throwing a punch, but the lady-in-waiting easily evaded it, and

before she knew it, the other two had grabbed her arms, holding her in a vice-like grip.

"Let me go," she cried. She gave Slug a pleading look, but Slug just stared, too afraid to do anything.

"We will let you go," the lady-in-waiting said, voice condescending. "We will let you go just as soon as we have taught you a *lesson*."

With her finger she drew a circle in the air, just a few centimetres from Stripe's face, and light trailed after her finger.

"Please..." Stripe pleaded. "I didn't intend any disrespect... I love our queen..."

"You will," the lady-in-waiting said with menacing voice. She finished her glyph and it glowed in the air. The lady-in-waiting gritted her teeth in obvious concentration, and the glyph started to shine brighter.

Any first-year Mystacor student would have recognized the obvious flaws in the spell. The linework was sloppy, the framework shaky and in order to maintain it the lady-in-waiting had to constantly feed it power from herself and her surrounding, most of which just dissipated as heat anyway.

Lots of heat.

Stripe desperately tried to move away from the rapidly heating glyph, so close to their face, but the other ladies-in-waiting held her in place.

"For Queen Glimmer," the lady-in-waiting said, sweat running down her face. She looked the screaming Stripe in the eyes, and with a wave of her hand, the glyph moved forward.

"What's going on here?"

Glimmer stood behind them, carrying several folders marked with the spindly hand writing some of the older hands recognized as Shadow Weaver's.

Immediately the glyph was dismissed and the three ladies-in-waiting sank to their knees, their heads bowed. Stripe took three quick steps backwards.

"My Queen," the first one said.

"My Queen," the others echoed.

Glimmer slowly looked between her ladies-in-waiting and Stripe, who stood pressed against the wall.

"Do we have a problem?" she asked, slight suspicion in her voice.

"N...no," Stripe quickly answered with high pitched voice.

"This soldier was disrespectful to you, my queen," one of the ladies-in-waiting answered without hesitated. "We aimed to teach her proper respect."

"I see," Glimmer said after a moment of thought. "Please raise."

The ladies in waiting did so, bowing their heads.

"You," Glimmer said to Stripe. "Please come here."

"My... my queen," Stripe piped and took a frightened step forward, with the ladies-in-waiting silently fanning out behind her. She was easily two heads taller than the tiny queen in front of her, with the kind of muscles you get from a life as a soldier in the Horde, but the way the princess held herself there was no doubt in anyone's mind that Glimmer could defeat her or worse with a stray thought.

"You were disrespectful..." Glimmer mused and let her words trail off.

"My Queen!" Stripe piped. "I spoke out of line. I'm so sorry. I never..."

"No, no, it's fine," Glimmer said with a little smile, as if the two of them shared a private joke. "I get it. It must be pretty strange, fighting princesses all these years and suddenly having one trying to order you around..."

"My Queen..." Stripe said, not knowing what else to say.

Glimmer sighed and shifted the folders to one arm. With the other, she idly drew with her fingers in the air. Stripe stared as a glyph took form. It was nothing like the crude construct the lady-in-waiting had weaved. It was elegant and intricate - much like the woman in front of her. And just like her, it was absolutely clear to Stripe how deadly the delicate construct in the air in front of her was.

"I did not deliver, did I?" Glimmer said, voice like velvet. "I promised you we would have taken Brightmoon by now, didn't I? Instead we ran with the tails behind our legs... I can understand your disappointment."

"No, no, not at all!" Stripe squeaked, staring like transfixed at the glyph.

"What's your name?" Glimmer abruptly asked.

"S... Stripe, My Queen!" Stripe whispered,

"Stripe, eh," Glimmer said with a slightly bemused smile, looking at the stripes in Stripe's sleek fur. "And who is your commanding officer, Stripe?"

"Tha... that's me, my Queen," Slug said and took a step forward. "I'll be happy to discipline Stripe. We don't need to take more of your valuable time..."

"Force Captain Slug," Glimmer said thoughtfully and looked at Slug. "Has Stripe, in your opinion, made herself guilty of a

transgression that warrants discipline?"

"No one gets to disrespect the Queens of the Horde," Slug immediately answered.

"Is that so..." Glimmer said. She did a little gesture, and the glyph disappeared. "So you don't share your soldier's disappointment, then?"

"I know you will lead us to victory, my Queen!" Slug said in desperation.

Glimmer regarded her in silence for a few, very tense moments.

"Tell me, Force Captain Slug," she said thoughtfully, "did you serve under Queen Catra when she held the title of Force Commander?"

"Ye-yes, my Queen?" Slug squeaked.

"Under Force Commander Catra you did not just sit idle, I take it?" Glimmer asked with the same gentle voice.

"...My Queen?" Slug asked.

Glimmer's fingers traced another glyph in the air.

"Where were you stationed, during the last big push, Force Commander Slug?" she asked.

Slug hesitated for a moment, obviously scanning her answer for problematic passages.

"Salineas, my Queen," she said eventually, voice weak.

"Salineas..." Glimmer repeated, voice less gentle now. "And Stripe here served under you?"

"Ye-yes, my Queen," Slug answered, giving Stripe a quick, apologetic glance.

"It must have been pretty exiting," Glimmer said, her glyph glowing brighter. "Sneaking behind the backs of the princess alliance, laying waste to the city defences before we had time to react, driving the civilians away from their homes..."

Slug said nothing, she just stared at Glimmer with terror in her eyes.

"I can see how you miss that excitement..." Glimmer said, voice growing sharper. "I can see how you must find me *weak* in comparison..."

"No, my Queen!" Slug protested with shaking voice.

"I wouldn't want you to sit idle," Glimmer said, voice full of venom. "I'll make *sure* there are proper activities for you to engage with..."

"My Queen?" Slug whispered.

"Please join me in the throne room in half an hour," Glimmer said and dismissed the glyph, "and I will discuss the next mission for you and your unit." She turned to the leering ladies-in-waiting. "Please alert the head of your order. I want her present as well."

"We obey your orders, my Queen," the first lady-in-waiting said with a gleeful look at Slug.

"Thank you, that will be all," Glimmer said and, with a little nod to Stripe, walked down the corridor.

Slug and Striped stared after her with beating hearts.

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Catra's comm pad beeped.

"Yeah?" she sighed as Lonnie's face showed up, expression carefully neutral.

"My Queen," she said. "I just wanted to let you know I'll be in time for the meeting."

"What meeting?" Catra snarled.

"The one called by Queen Glimmer with me and several of the Force Captains in the throne room in just a few minutes," Lonnie answered. "I'm sorry if I were not supposed to bother you with it. I simply assumed the invitation was supposed to be read as coming from *both* my queens."

Catra stared at her for a few moments, parsing the words Lonnie didn't say. She took a deep breath.

"Thank you, Force Commander," she said, voice professional. "You're not bothering me. I'll see you at the meeting."

"Thanks, my Queen," Lonnie said, radiating of relief.

Catra closed her eyes and resisted the urge to massage her temples.

Then she steeled herself and walked to the throne room.

- - -

"Catra," Glimmer said with cold voice as her wife entered the large room. She stood two steps up the stairs to the throne, ten of the force commanders - including the one leading her ladies-in-waiting - as well as a worried looking Lonnie standing around her in a semi-circle. Double Trouble lounged the shadows next to the throne, very much not part of the group, very much an active listener to everything that went on.

"Glimmer," Catra said with a little nod and walked up to Double Trouble. "Don't mind me, I'm just hanging around."

"I'm so glad, my Queen," Glimmer said with a snarl. She resolutely turned her back to Catra and faced the Force Captains again.

"As I said before the *interruption*," -she shot Catra an evil look- "I want you to start pushing through the Whispering Woods."

The Force Captains gave each other uneasy looks, and more than one of them glanced at Catra, who pointedly ignored them.

"My Queen," Lonnie said after a long moment. "Our forces were prepared to board the ships. We would need several days to..."

"Your ladies-in-waiting will move as soon as you give the word, my queen," the leader of said group said and gave Lonnie a hard look.

"I expect nothing less," Glimmer said. She let her gaze play over the assembled force captains. "I expect nothing less from *any* of you," she said, voice not quite - but note quite *not* - turning to a snarl.

"We have tried pushing through the Whispering Woods for years..." Lonnie begun.

"I'm well aware," Glimmer said with cold voice. "Least you have forgot, I had a first hand view. I even recall you reaching my castle walls, a few years back."

Lonnie gave Catra a quick, helpless look. Catra still didn't answer.

"That was... um... Catra and Entrapta..."

"Entrapta is not here," Glimmer snarled. "*I am*."

"What about the flower princess," Lonnie pleaded. "You said she would..."

"I said she would *devour* whoever entered the Whispering Woods," Glimmer hissed. "She will. You can count on it."

The Force Captains looked more uneasy, except the leader for the ladies-in-waiting who sat up straighter in her wheelchair.

"But... um... you still want us to...?" Lonnie begun.

"I'm not ordering you in there defenceless," Glimmer said with an unpleasant smile. "*Some* of you," -she glared at Catra- "might think I have wasted my time, these last few weeks. I have not. I have a new toy for you..."

She opened the bag by her feet and held up crystal rods, the same rods Hordak had used to channel the power of the Black Garnet. They were glowing with sickly, purple energy.

"Some of you might not remember," Glimmer said with deceptively calm voice, "but Perfuma was at first rather hesitant to join the princess alliance. I had the Horde to thank for her coming around in the end."

She held up one of the rods, and the Force Captains flinched as energy dripped from it and fell to the floor, where it oozed down the cracks.

"There was a rather ingenious plan, actually," she went on with the same smooth voice, not quite hiding the rage that simmered underneath. "The strength of Plumeria lies in their plants. Kill the plants, kill the opposition. I assume we had Shadow Weaver to thank for that little spark of creativity?

"Yeah," Catra confirmed, voice neutral.

"I know how she did it," Glimmer said, voice smooth as glass. "I have replicated it. I have made it *portable*." She glared at Slug and the Force Captains. "You will each take ten rods. You will each venture into the Whispering Woods from different points. As you go you will make use of these. You will each clear a path, and while you do, *Lonnie* here will prepare the rest of our forces."

"Yes, my Queen!" the lady-in-waiting said with clear, unwavering voice. She held out her hand and Glimmer placed the rod in it.

"It's... an ambitious plan, my Queen," Lonnie begun.

"I did not ask for your assessment," Glimmer said with cold voice. "I gave you an order. I wait for you to obey it."

"Yes my Queen," Lonnie quickly said and made a quick gesture to the Force Captains. They hurriedly repeated the words. They glanced at the bag, but no one approached it. Slug looked like she was ready to bolt.

"Anything the matter?" Glimmer asked, voice full of poison.

For a long, terrible moment no one spoke. Then Lonnie took a deep breath.

"My Queen, if I may..."

"Yes, Force Commander?" Glimmer asked, the rage that simmered underneath coming closer to the surface.

"I just wonder if I may ask for a few *clarifications* on the plan," Lonnie braved forward.

"I was not aware I left room for interpretation," Glimmer said, voice hard.

"Only... um... these teams... their activities will attract monsters, I assume?"

"*I* assume the Horde has trained and equipped the soldiers enough to deal with some beetles, *Force Commander*," Glimmer shot back.

"Sure, a large team could take them," Lonnie said, her voice slipping out of the cold, professional tone she normally used. "Or a small, mobile team. You're proposing small, slowly moving teams stuck to their own little corridor while the Woods snack away at them at its leisure."

"I'm not *proposing* anything," Glimmer shouted. "I'm *ordering*."

"You're ordering us to *die*?" a Force Captain grumbled, and several of the other's muttered similar things under their breath.

"Your ladies-in-waiting will follow your word, my Queen," the leader of the ladies-in-waiting said with loud voice.

"I'm glad *someone* does not immediately jump to treason," Glimmer snarled. Her fists were clenched and sparks started to form around them.

"No one is talking about treason, my Queen," Lonnie pleaded giving the Force Captains a quick 'shut up' look. "We simply ask for the full picture to better be able to follow your orders, my Queen."

"The full picture?" Glimmer said suspiciously.

"You told us about the flower princess," Lonnie quickly went on. "Obviously you have a plan for when she approaches our teams?"

Glimmer hesitated a moment.

"Of course I do..." she begun.

"NO ONE GETS TO QUESTION OUR QUEEN!" the lady-in-waiting shouted with loud voice.

"No one is questioning the queen," Double Trouble quickly said with forced calm voice, taking a step forward. Their eyes were narrowed as they studied Glimmer's expression.

"All we're asking is for a heads-up," Lonnie pleaded. "Once we encounter the Plumerian princess we need to act quick, and we wouldn't want your plan to be ruined by miscommunication, my Queen."

"My plan..." Glimmer repeated.

"I assume the team that first encounters the princess falls back?" Lonnie guessed. "Reports her position so you can...?"

"So I can take her down," Glimmer filled in with renewed confidence. "Of course. Once I know where she is, once I have lured her into the corridors I can..."

She hesitated. Everyone in the room hung on her next word.

"...I can..." Glimmer went on.

"You will *crush* her, my queen," the lady-in-waiting said with a voice that dared anyone to disagree.

"Of course I will," Glimmer said quickly. Her eyes landed on the crystal rod in the lady-in-waiting's hand, still oozing with power. "Once I have connected to the Black Garnet I will take Perfuma down... and Mermista too!"

Double Trouble took another careful step forward.

"My queen," they said with soothing voice. "I think perhaps the finer points of your plan can wait until..."

"You asked," Glimmer snarled, eyeing Lonnie with angry expression. "And there you have the answer. I will connect to the Black Garnet. I will use it to get my *own* channel to the Heart of Etheria. Then me and Perfuma will meet on equal footing. Is that good enough for you, *Force Commander*?"

"My Queen," Lonnie said with frightened voice, "I did not intend to..."

"You didn't did you?" the lady-in-waiting asked, not trying to hide the scorn in her voice. One of the Force Captains whispered something to another who just shook his head. Double Trouble tried to catch Glimmer's eyes, even as her hands started to glow.

"Do you think I can't do it?" Glimmer said, voice brittle, like it could break into a thousand cutting shards at any moment.

"I..." Lonnie whispered.

A sardonic laughter interrupted them. Everyone's eyes turned to Catra who leaned against the wall.

"Something funny, *My Queen*?" Glimmer snarled, her entire body emitting light.

"Yeah, big time," Catra laughed with forced cheer and turned to Lonnie.

"Seems you owe me a purple ration bar, Force Commander," she drawled.

"What?" Lonnie said, slightly bewildered.

"What?" Glimmer asked with suspicious voice.

"Sorry, Glimmer," Catra shrugged, managing to keep her body language casual. "I know Lonnie is a stickler for details, but this time it's partly on me." She shook her heads. "She was so sure we could do this one without 'princess tricks'." She turned to Lonnie again. "'Machines and soldiers', eh, Lonnie? Didn't turn out quite like that, did it?"

"No, my Queen," Lonnie said, looking back and forth between Glimmer and Catra.

"Turns out," Catra leered, "that this is *exactly* the time for princess tricks."

Glimmer watched her through narrow eyes, but the light around her hands died down.

Catra took a step forward and addressed the assembly.

"I don't think you schumcks understand the extent to which Glimmer is saving our asses here. Some of you old hands have fought the princesses for decades, fighting for every fucking inch of land we took. Turns out, they were holding back all this time."

She let her eyes travel over the Force Captains as her words sunk in.

"The Heart of Etheria is open," she said, voice serious. "A stash of magic large enough to wipe the entire Fright Zone from the map, should it take their fancy. You think the princesses were hard to beat before. Now they are fucking *nightmares*. I know most of you didn't quite get what happened during our little pleasure cruise to Brightmoon, what with you being busy puking your guts out in the cargo holds, but that bitch from Salineas had us dead to rights. She would have *drowned* us all like *rats*. The only reason she didn't, the only reason *any* of us is alive right now..." Catra pointedly looked at Glimmer.

"So when *Queen* Glimmer says she can take the flower princess - in the Whispering Woods no less - I want you all to realize that it's not an empty boost. Because if the princesses are nightmares, The fucking Shining Princess is what sends *them* screaming. And she's with *you*."

The Force Captains visibly trembled. The lady-in-waiting grinned a blood thirsty grin. Glimmer stared at Catra with open mouth.

"So instead of quibbling about the details of *her* plan," Catra snarled, "I *strongly* suggest you start weed whacking, because if Queen Glimmers says we can go through the Whispering Woods, that's where we're going."

Catra winked at Glimmer.

"But cut Lonnie some slack, Glimmer. If she says she needs another day to get everyone out of their swim trunks or whatever, in my experience that time is well spent. Surely Perfuma can wait a day?"

"Ye-eah," Glimmer muttered.

"There you have it," Lonnie, "Catra leered. "You have a day, make the most of it. She turned to the Force Captains, who looked

around uncertainly. "What are you fuckers still here for? I want you ready to move the moment you get the call. Now scram!"

The Force Captains fled the room. The lady-in-waiting was last through the door, glaring at Catra with narrow eyes.

There was a terrible moment of silence as Lonnie, Double Trouble and Catra pretended not to notice as Glimmer slowly regained control.

"Catra," she said eventually, voice shaking. "I did not need to be rescued."

"Of course you didn't," Catra protested. "I just..."

Suddenly, in a cloud of sparkles, Glimmer stood immediately in front of her, a ball of lighting in her hand.

"Just *what*?" she hissed.

Catra stared at her face a frozen mask of fear, seemingly unable to produce a single sound.

It was Double Trouble who broke the silence.

"Bravo my queen," they laughed and clapped their hands at Catra. They turned to wink at Glimmer.

"Sly as a fox, that one. You have good taste, Glimmer, if you don't mind me saying so."

Glimmer looked like she minded them saying, but before she could answer Double Trouble turned to the still stunned Catra with a broad grin.

"Afraid wifie will steal your thunder, are you?" they leered, shooting Catra a quick, warning glance, completely at odds with their nonchalant tone of voice. "You shouldn't be. I keep telling you, you're *both* Queens of the Horde. Her victories are your victories." They turned to Glimmer again. "Don't worry, Glimmer.

Catra might want to make a grand speech now and then, insert herself into your plans, but we all know who makes it possible."

Glimmer hesitated, staring first at Double Trouble, and then glancing at Catra who quickly held up her hands in a pacifying gesture.

"Sorry, Glimmer," she said. "I know it's your show. I just felt the need to dumb it down for the bozos on the floor..." she caught Double Trouble giving her a quick, sharp look, and she sighed and looked down at her hands. "...also, I suppose I'm a bit insecure," she said with bashful voice. "I'm used to do this job on my own, you know. Sorry."

"It's OK," Glimmer said after a few moments of hesitation, voice much gentler than previous. She took a deep breath. "Just give me a heads-up first next time, OK?"

"Of course, Glimmer," Catra said, not quite managing to hide the relief in her voice.

"I'll keep an eye on the teams," Lonnie quickly said.

"Yeah..." Glimmer mumbled, not meeting Catra's eyes. "I'll do the... final adjustments on the Black Garnet..."

"Before you do, my queen," Double Trouble leered, "I have a few trivial little issues that I might need to trouble you with..."

"Yeah, sure..." Glimmer said, the previous fury melting away. "Seems like I have some time on my hands..."

"My thoughts exactly," Double Trouble drawled. "And seeing how I'm fed up with ration bars, and how I have 'liberated' a crate or two of foodstuff from the acquisition teams, perhaps we should move the debriefing to dinner...?"

Glimmer shot Catra a quick, guilty look.

"The two of you go ahead," Catra quickly said. "I need to go over the logistics reports anyway."

"I'll save a plate for you," Glimmer promised.

"Yeah, yeah," Catra smiled. "I'll see you tonight."

"Sure," Glimmer said.

"Sure," Catra answered.

They hesitated for a moment, then Glimmer nodded to Double Trouble, and together they walked towards the door. As they did, Double Trouble traded a long, worried look with Catra.

"I'll make sure there are no... problems, with the teams," Lonnie said with low voice and walked towards the opposite door.

Catra nodded. She sank down on the lowest step of the throne, legs shaking. Lonnie stopped by the door and glanced at her.

"Catra...?" she said hesitantly. "Do you want me to...?"

Catra didn't look at Lonnie, she just shook her head.

Lonnie hesitated for another moment, then she quietly opened the door and walked out.

Catra waited until the door closed, then she took off her mask and put it next to her on the step. She buried her face in her hands and cried.

Chapter End Notes

:-(

Sweat it out

Chapter Notes

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Please... tell me... tell me what I should do?"

The blonde woman gave Glimmer a warm smile.

"You're asking me, Glim. You already know what the answer is." Adora bent forward and took Glimmer's hand. For a moment Glimmer looked like she would snatch it back, but she allowed the other woman to take it and look into her eyes.

"Your friends are in danger. *Of course* you go. Drop everything, rush in, blow anything that stops you up with your terrifying magical might. Hug. Cry. Sort it all out afterwards when everyone is safe."

Glimmer looked at her with big eyes, tears threatening to emerge at any moment. Her lips parted and she let out a soft, whining sound. But then the moment passed and she angrily snatched her hand back.

"NO!" she cried. "I can't just drop everything and run away on a fools errand."

Adora sighed and did a little frustrated gesture.

"I know that, darling. But you *did* ask me for hair-poof's advice. You know that's what she would want you to do." 'Her' features shimmered, and Double Trouble took their own form again. They strolled over to the overturned crate they had used for table and picked up the wine bottle they had shared.

"Maybe Arrow Boy would be a better fit..." they said with a sly glance at Glimmer.

Their hair started to morph, but before they managed to fully take Bow's form, Glimmer shouted out a single "NO!", and Double Trouble's ordinary hair colour flowed back.

"...no," Glimmer said, calmer this time. "I know what Bow would say. What I need is a *new* perspective."

Double Trouble gave her a careful look.

"Might I suggest that perhaps it's not a new *perspective* you need."

Glimmer gave them a suspicious look.

"What do you mean."

"Here, let's try this..." Double Trouble morphed into Adora again. They sat up straight and took a few moments to get their body language right, then they looked at the queen with a serious expression.

"Glimmer," 'she' said with soft voice. "Is there anything you wish to say to Adora?"

Glimmer recoiled. She stared at the changeling like she expected them to turn into a snake at any moment. But Double Trouble just looked at Glimmer with a patient expression on Adora's face.

"Wha-at?" Glimmer whispered.

"I can put words in Adora's mouth all day if you like," Double Trouble said. "But maybe it would be more constructive if *you* were to talk to *her*. What would you say to Adora if she were here?"

"Well, she isn't," Glimmer snarled, "which sort of is the issue at hand if you hadn't noticed."

"I have noticed," 'Adora' said calmly. "And you know me, Glim. I would just rush head first into whatever nest of vipers stood between me and whoever I tried to save."

"I can't *do* that," Glimmer snarled.

"I know," 'Adora' said patiently. "You're the queen. You have to think of the bigger picture."

"*YES*," Glimmer cried. "I can't just blindly follow whatever lure Shadow Weaver dangles in front of me. I have to keep people *safe*, and to do that I have to be powerful enough to take on Shadow Weaver." Her voice turned pleading. "She took my runestone, Adora. She took my elemental connection to Etheria. I have to get that back. If I can just... borrow the Black Garnet that would allow me to... to..." her voice trailed off.

"Glimmer..." 'Adora' said softly.

"YOU DON'T KNOW!" Glimmer shouted in fury. "You don't know what it is to be the week princess. The one who will never be enough, but still the one who has to be strong enough for *everyone*."

A shadow of a grin could be seen in the corner of 'Adora's' mouth, but 'she' maintained her concerned expression.

"I KNOW I should go to Beast Island to get you," Glimmer shouted, and sobs started to break through. "I KNOW I should have done so when you first asked me, followed you to save Entrapta. But I didn't, OK? I couldn't! I... wouldn't. I... thought I could fix everything by myself but I couldn't and now I made everything worse and I have done so many horrible things and now I'm even hurting Catra and I... took her from you and I'm SORRY FOR NOT BEING PERFECT LIKE YOU! I'm... I'm... sorry."

The words had been shouted at first, an angry snarl, but the last 'sorry' was whispered.

Glimmer sank down to her knees and she started to cry.

"I'm sorry, Adora," she whispered. "I'm so, so sorry. I should have listened to you. I should have done what you said. I..." the rest of the sentence was lost in sobs, and Double Trouble sat down next to her. Still in Adora's guise they held the crying queen for a long, long time.

"Glimmer," they said eventually with soft voice. "You know I'm not her, but you also know that if I *were*, if it really was Adora sitting here, she would forgive you in a heartbeat."

"Yes," Glimmer whispered. "Yes, I know."

She rubbed her eyes and sat up a bit more straight. She took a deep breath.

"Thanks, Double Trouble," she said with low voice. "I know what I have to do."

She left the chamber.

Double Trouble watched her walk away, listened to her footsteps fade. Then they changed their appearance into that of the queen that just left.

"I hurt," they said to themselves with Glimmer's voice. "I hurt because I want to do the right thing, but tell myself that I can't. I hurt those who love me and try to help me, because lashing out is easier than admitting fault."

They sighed, a bit melodramatically, and did a little helpless gesture.

"How do you help those who don't want to help themselves? Who don't think they deserve help? If only there was a cute catgirl who could show me love and help me overcome the error of my ways..."

"Knock it off," Catra muttered and climbed out from the air vent where she'd been lurking for the better part of the conversation.

Double Trouble smirked and returned to their own guise. They held out their finely manicured hand and Catra helped them to their feet.

"How long have you known I was there?" Catra demanded. Double Trouble shrugged.

"A few minutes," they said in their usual voice. "I must admit most of my attention was on poor little Mrs Sparkles, though. Do you think I made an impression?"

"I think that if you had tried that stunt on me, I would have killed you," Catra replied.

"Occupational hazard," the changeling commented with dry voice.

Catra sighed.

"I'm worried about her," she confessed. Double Trouble nodded.

"That much is evident, Kittycat, and for good reasons."

"What should I do?" Catra wailed.

They leered.

"You know that thing with your tongue where you..."

"I can always default to murder," Catra hissed.

"Sorry," Double Trouble laughed. They sighed and put a hand on Catra's.

"Talk to her. Keep trying to get through. Eventually you will."

Catra gave them a sceptical look.

"Just like that? Keep nagging?"

Double Trouble shrugged.

"I mean, there's finesse to it. The two of you are always at your happiest when you're riled up, so maybe pick a fight with her?"

"I'm not sure the Fright Zone could stand another fight of that magnitude," Catra muttered.

Double Trouble sniggered.

"Do you know what your problem is, Kitten?"

"You want the entire list or just the highlights?" Catra said with dry voice.

"Your problem is that you keep falling for girls who put their job first," they said with kind voice. "Glimmer loves you, she really does, but she will never not feel the need to be the queen she thinks her mommy expects her to."

Catra closed her eyes and took a long, shivering breath.

"I don't want to drive her off like I did with Adora," she whispered, voice pleading. "What do I *do*."

"She won't run away from you," Double Trouble said with reassuring voice.

"Yeah, right," Catra muttered.

"She *might* run away on a stupid mission on her own if she talks herself into it being the only way," Double Trouble went on, but she won't leave you."

Catra sighed.

"Can I give you a piece of advice, Kitten?" Double Trouble asked. "You know, without you clawing my eyes out?"

"No promises," Catra muttered.

Double Trouble gave her a compassionate smile.

"You know that thing where you tell yourself you were not good enough for Adora, and she was right to leave you?"

Catra gave them a suspicious glare.

"Glimmer tells herself the same thing," Double Trouble went on. "Anyway, it's all horse shit. You're both worthy of love - you're worthy of *each other's* love."

"You're full of shit," Catra muttered.

"I am," Double Trouble admitted, "but that part happens to be true."

"Fine, what's your advice then," she said.

"I already gave it to you," they smirked. "You and Glimmer *are* worthy of each other. She *does* love you, she *won't* leave you and you *can* patch it up - if you try."

"And the advice is..." Catra pressed on.

"That you keep trying, Kitten," Double Trouble smiled. "Because she's worth it."

"Well, we can agree on that at least," Catra sighed. "I still think you're full of shit, but thanks."

"No problem," Double Trouble said with casual voice. "Also, I *strongly* recommend against a commando raid against Mermista,"

Catra gave them a long look.

"You know about that one, do you?"

"Please," Double Trouble said with hurt voice. "I'm a spy at trade. *Of course* I know about it. But more importantly, as your advisor, I recommend against it."

"Oh, Catra said and pressed her hand against her forehead in a tired fashion. "And why is that?"

"Because you and Glimmer complement each other," Double Trouble said with sincere voice and looked her in the eyes. "As long as you work together, no one - including Shadow Weaver - can beat you. If you start going behind each other's back..."

Catra sighed.

"I know," she muttered. She tried a wry little smile.

"To be perfectly honest with you, I don't care all that much about winning any longer. I have won. It's totally overrated."

"Then what *do* you care about?" Double Trouble asked, all attention.

Catra met their gaze without blinking.

"Her," she said, and as she did she felt something move deep in her chest.

Double Trouble nodded approval.

"Then go tell her," they said with gentle voice.

Catra gave them a downright scared look.

"Do you think she'll listen?" she whispered.

"One way to find out," Double Trouble said encouragingly.

"Thanks," Catra whispered. She rubbed her eyes and left the room.

Double Trouble watched the retreating queen.

"I should add Royal Couple's Therapist to my card," they commented to themselves.

- - -

Catra found Glimmer outside the closed doors to their own shared quarters, nervously changing feet.

"Hey, Sparkles," Catra said as she walked up to her.

"Oh, hi Catra," Glimmer said, quickly turning around and trying to hide her nervousness. "I... um, I asked Lonnie to delay the Whispering Woods expedition a few days..."

"Good call," Catra said lightly. "She's really annoying with all that down-time, but usually it pays to give her the time she needs."

"Yeah..." Glimmer said, not meeting Catra's eyes.

Catra held up two training staffs.

"Wanna spar?"

"Absolutely," Glimmer said, relief radiating of her.

They walked to one of the small gyms, stealing glances of each other.

"I'm... not all that sure I can connect to the Black Garnet as quickly as I'd like..." Glimmer said silently.

"You'll get there," Catra said with false confidence. Glimmer glanced at her through the corner of the eye but didn't answer.

They started with a simple routine to warm up.

"I talked to Double Trouble..." Glimmer begun.

Catra made an affirming sound.

Glimmer jabbed at the air in front of her and glanced apologetically at Catra.

"I've been a bitch. I'm sorry."

"You were a bitch back when I first fell in love with you," Catra countered. "That's just you playing to my taste."

"Fine," Glimmer laughed, feeling better despite herself. "But you know what I mean."

"Yeah," Catra said and tried a kick. "It's OK."

"Thanks," Glimmer said. "It isn't, but I appreciate the sentiment."

"Eh, I'm a bitch too," Catra said. "But really, Sparkles, I'm... a bit worried."

"Yeah, I know," Glimmer said silently.

They moved a bit closer to each other, their staffs making contact.

"What exactly is it that worries you," Glimmer said after they had exchange a few blows.

"It's not that I don't trust you..." Catra quickly said.

"I know," Glimmer sighed and initiated a slow series of blows, not so much to try to get a hit in but just for her and Catra to get into a rhythm. "But you are also clearly about to crawl out of your skin every time I go close to that rock so... what's the matter."

"It can't come as a surprise to you that me and that rock have a bit of a history..." Catra said, fumbling for the right words.

"The Black Garnet was one of many tools Shadow Weaver used to hurt you, yes I get it," Glimmer said, moving her staff in rhythm, matching Catra's speed. "But Shadow Weaver isn't here. The rock doesn't belong to her any more. So how is that any different from all the other things around here that used to hurt?"

"I'm not saying I'm exactly jumping with joy to be back," Catra countered, increasing the pace. "But the rest of this fucking place... it's just about who's at the top of the heap."

"Like Octavia?" Glimmer asked. She broke the pattern, attempting a strike towards Catra's legs that she easily blocked.

"Sure," Catra agreed and feinted left and jabbed right, only to be blocked by Glimmer who anticipated the move. "She was a constant threat my entire childhood. An adult who likes to pick on kids is someone you learn to be really careful around. Now I'm the top bully and she's in line. She doesn't scare me."

"But magic does," Glimmer said with low voice, reducing the tempo somewhat.

Catra nodded without saying anything.

"...you aren't worried for me," Glimmer said slowly. "You are *afraid* of me."

"You are freaking terrifying, Sparkles," Catra said with as light voice as she could manage. "That can't be news to you."

"I shouldn't be terrifying to you," Glimmer said.

"Hey, I can be pretty scary myself," Catra protested.

"You know I won't hurt you, right?" Glimmer said, searching Catra's eyes.

"Of course I do," Catra quickly said.

Their staffs moved automatically in the routine.

Neither said anything for a little while.

"I'm sorry," Glimmer sighed. "I should be more mindful of these things. For you to be back here... for me, that's... I'm sorry."

"It's OK," Catra said.

"Do you know why I first fell in love with you?" Glimmer asked after a few beats with the staff.

"Because of my amazing ass," Catra immediately answered and drew a little smile from Glimmer.

"Well, duh," she said with a long, pointed look at said ass. "But also because you could take it. Whatever I dished out. There were no pussyfooting around you. You wouldn't break if I raised my voice. You wouldn't run off."

"...I wouldn't call you a 'bad friend'," Catra interjected. "Yeah, I get it. Sorry to disappoint, Sparkles."

"Did I say I was disappointed?" Glimmer said, an eyebrow raised.

"Me falling to pieces anytime you light a spark is not exactly me 'taking whatever you dish out', is it," Catra countered.

"No, it's you showing vulnerability, dropping the mask, trusting me enough to show the real Catra."

Glimmer sighed.

"Trust. You trust me. I know how hard that is for you. That's why I stayed in love with you, even after the first rush died down and we had to deal with all the nitty-gritty of running a bandit camp and an army and the friggin' Horde."

"I'm not doing so hot in that department either, am I?" Catra ruefully said over the beats of the staffs. "Not with me wringing my hands every time you come within ten meters of that runestone."

"I just told you twice that I love you," Glimmer said with some heat, whacking at Catra's head with the staff, giving Catra ample of time to parry. "Why must you be so difficult."

"I... I kinda think I should be," Catra said with low voice. "I kinda think we have to talk about these things. Even the difficult parts."

Glimmer chuckled slightly to hide her worried frown.

"You talked to Double Trouble too, huh?"

"They are extremely annoying," Catra confirmed.

"Well, says something about how much of a disaster we are," Glimmer chuckled, "it they are the person we go to for relationship advice."

"We are the biggest disaster this side of Etheria," Catra agreed with heartfelt voice.

"We are still worth it," Glimmer said. She looked Catra in the eyes. "Whatever happens, you and me are worth fighting for."

"I will never stop fighting for you, Glimmer," Catra said, voice full of emotions. "Never."

"Then let's fight," Glimmer said, picking up the pace somewhat. "Let's have the difficult conversation. Talk. I'm listening."

Catra automatically followed in her routine, her muscles easily moving her staff in position while her brain razed.

There were so many thoughts she wanted to put in words. So many things she wanted to say just right. So many nuances of what she felt that she didn't want to be lost or glossed over.

But in the end, her mouth just unbidden blurted out the simplest, most fundamental part.

"Don't leave me," she said, words stumbling on each other before she could stop her mouth from saying them. "Please, don't leave me."

Glimmer gave her a surprised look.

"I'm not leaving you," Catra.

"Fuck you!" Catra cried, suddenly furious, and gave Glimmer a hard whack, forcing the queen to quickly move the staff to defend

herself. "*She* told me the same thing, and look how fucking well that turned out."

"I'm not Adora," Glimmer said, calmly moving her staff to keep defending, without doing any counter-moves.

"Well, neither was Scorpia and that didn't exactly turn out so great either." Catra snarled, increasing the pace.

"I'm not Scorpia either," Glimmer said. "You know who I am." She gave Catra's staff a hard whack and caught her gaze. "I am the one who can take it. I'm the one you don't have to pussyfoot around. I'm the one you can trust." She twirled her staff, making two quick jabs to force Catra on the retreat, and then she made a quick break and gave her rear a pointed look. "*And* I have an amazing ass."

Catra had to chuckle at that.

They traded a few blows back and forth. Glimmer didn't say anything, she kept the rhythm and waited for Catra.

Catra allowed herself time to fall into the pattern again, let her muscles do the work, let her breathing become steady.

Whack, whack, whack went the staffs.

"You won't leave me," Catra said with low voice after a little while.

"I won't leave you," Glimmer said.

Whack, whack, whack.

"What about all your fancy princess friends?"

"Fuck those bitches," Glimmer said without hesitation.

"Well, what about the people of your kingdom?" Catra pressed on. "Once we kick Shadow Weaver in the pussy, they won't be too

happy with you slumming around with a stray cat on the royal throne, will they?"

"Unless they want Shadow Weaver's pussy to remain unkicked, they *better* be happy with you. You're the one that's making it happen, after all. And if they complain about it, I'll build another statue of you."

Catra raised an eyebrow.

"'Another' statue?"

Glimmer smiled sweetly at her.

"First thing after we win, I'm putting up a statue of you in the main courtyard."

"Fuck you," Catra laughed.

"Oh, that's just the beginning," Glimmer smirked. "I'm thinking of a stained glass window."

"I suppose there is no chance of talking you out of it," Catra asked with level voice.

"None whatsoever," Glimmer confirmed, then her voice grew serious. "The point I'm trying to make is that I love you, I want to spend my life with you and I'm going to show off my awesome wife to *everyone*."

"Sweet-talker," Catra muttered as she failed to hide a blush.

Glimmer winked at her, which only caused Catra to blush more.

"You have it all figure out, haven't you, Sparkles?" she muttered.

"The trick is to make people think you do," Glimmer drily commented, which made Catra nod in agreement.

Whack, whack, whack.

"OK," Glimmer said. "You can just as well say it."

"Say what?" Catra asked.

"The thing you're trying to figure out the right words for," Glimmer said with kind voice. "It's OK, the words don't have to be right. No pussyfooting, remember?"

Catra looked at her a long moment, moving her staff without any input from her brain.

"What about Adora?" she said with low voice.

Glimmer stiffened, but managed to hold the routine.

"We always come back to her, don't we?" she said. Catra nodded, but didn't say anything.

Whack, whack, whack.

"It could have been something, the two of us," Glimmer said eventually. "It could have been good."

"Yeah, she gets that a lot," Catra growled, not quite manage to keep the hurt out of her voice.

"I won't lie to you, Catra," Glimmer said with slightly detached voice. "That little naive princess who found her very own Horde soldier out in the woods... yeah, she wouldn't have minded a happily ever after with her. Not minded it at all."

"I get you," Catra said, keeping her voice in check.

"But it didn't really turn out that way, did it?" Glimmer sighed.

"Sorry to ruin your happily ever after, princess," Catra muttered.

Glimmer gave her a scornful look.

"Don't think you'll get to take the credit for that one," she snorted. "The girl who drooled over Adora was a little princess. I'm a

queen."

"What difference does that make," Catra asked sourly, making a mean spirited feint which Glimmer easily blocked.

"You of all people don't have to ask me that," Glimmer shot back. "You know perfectly well what it's like on the throne."

"Lonely?" Catra guessed. Glimmer nodded.

"Yeah," Glimmer sighed. "Not really much room for company."

"We make it work just fine..." Catra said, almost without adding a question mark in the end.

Glimmer gave her a fond smile.

"Yeah, we do. Because we have worked for it, we have literately been through hell together and we are both too stubborn bitches to allow each other to be anything but equals."

"But Adora...?" Catra asked, already knowing what would come next.

"Adora had it in her to be a good ruler," Glimmer sighed. "Or a great knight. But sharing the throne... I'm not so sure."

"For all of my life, there was nothing I wanted more than to be *her* knight," Catra said. "She'd rule the Horde, I'd keep her safe."

"And now you keep me safe while we both rule the Horde," Glimmer said, some edge to her words.

"Trust me, Sparkles," Catra said with admiration in her voice. "I've never dared dreaming of someone like you."

"Glad to exceed your expectations," Glimmer said loftily. "But you get what I'm saying, right? You are not my 'second best' when I couldn't have Adora. What I have with you, I could never have had with her. Who I *am* with you, I could never be with her."

"You say that like it's a good thing," Catra mumbled.

"Fuck you," Glimmer laughed and made a quick jab with her staff that Catra blocked.

They kept sparring in slow tempo, both lost in their own thoughts.

It was Catra who broke the silence.

"This has all been me talking," she said, just a bit hesitantly. "What about you."

"Me...?" Glimmer said, taking a step back and holding her staff in defensive position.

Catra took a step forward, aiming a slow blow at the staff.

"I can't be the only one in this relationship who's an insecure mess," Catra said and moved her own staff to defensive position, inviting Glimmer to strike the next blow. "And since we're already ripping off the bandages... spill it. What is it that you're afraid of?"

Whack, whack, whack went the staffs.

"To disappoint you, I suppose," Glimmer muttered. "You know, like I disappoint everyone eventually."

"What?" Catra cried. "That's crazy."

"Fine, I suppose I'm crazy, then," Glimmer smirked.

"Low blow," Catra said and aimed a low blow at Glimmer's leg, which she jumped to avoid. "You know what I mean."

"Yeah," Glimmer sighed. She gave Catra an almost shy look. "I know you're all gaga about me, Catra, and it's very endearing, but I'm not all what you make me out to be."

"Sure you are," Catra said dismissively. "You've got a *spectacular* ass."

Glimmer smirked.

"Fine, I'll give you that one," she said. Then her voice grew more serious. "I've also got self esteem issues enough to drown a mountain and hubris enough to blow up a small city."

"Theatrical," Catra commented.

"I'm trying to be serious," Glimmer said with a frown. She made another few whacks with the staff while Catra parried, waiting for her to continue.

"I think... part of me still thinks that my mom will show up at any minute and tell me I can't do this and... lock me up in my room, or something."

"Well, if she does I'll totally sneak in through your window," Catra smirked, and to her enormous gratification saw a little blush light up Glimmer's cheeks.

"That's... you know what, let's save that thought for later," Glimmer said, and blushed again as Catra grinned at her.

"By all means, my princess," Catra said, took a step back and did an obnoxious little bow with her staff held like a sword. "Let's talk more about it *tonight*." She hissed the last word without letting go of Glimmer's eyes, and even licked her lips for good measure.

"Stop it," Glimmer giggled and whacked Catra's staff to the side. Catra stood up again and - with a last wink - continued the routine, waiting for Glimmer to gather her thoughts.

"I don't know what scares me more," Glimmer silently said. "The thought that someone will still try stop me... or that there is no one left who can."

"I think I get it," Catra slowly said. "Last time I did this..." she gesticulated vaguely around her, indicating the entirety of the Fright Zone, "after Scorpia left... well, there kinda wasn't anyone left to stop me, even when I really needed it."

"Good thing Hordak backstabbed you when he did, huh?" Glimmer said, voice slightly sarcastic.

"Honestly, yeah," Catra said with sincere voice. "I truly think he did me a favour, and not only because that pushed the two of us together."

"Well, I for one do not want to thank Shadow Weaver just yet for backstabbing me," Glimmer muttered.

"That goes without saying," Catra said.

They whacked their staffs together in silence a few times.

"I'm scared," Glimmer admitted with small voice.

"Of failing?" Catra asked. "Or of... going too far?"

"Yes," Glimmer said sincerely. "Or.. going too far *and* failing." She sighed. "Again."

"I hear you," Catra muttered.

"What if I can't do it?" Glimmer asked, voice shivering slightly.

"What if *we* can't do it you mean?" Catra corrected her. "I'm with you, you know that."

"Sure, fine, what if *we* can't do it," Glimmer said with a thankful look at her."

"Then we grab the kids and run," Catra said with confident voice. "We couldn't stay hidden with both the Horde and Shadow Weaver looking for us, but without the Horde doing her dirty work for her I figure we could stay a step ahead of that stupid old witch. Especially with the rest of Etheria in chaos. Then we'll figure out how to take our next shot from there."

"'The kids'," Glimmer said with a little smile.

"Well, yeah," Catra shrugged. "You've seen how Jack act around Frosta. You hardly think they would want to leave her behind, do you?"

"I just didn't expect you to get so... domestic all of sudden," Glimmer grinned.

"Whaaaat?" Catra said. "I'd be a great mum."

"You *are* a great mum, Catra," Glimmer said with a voice that made Catra feel warm inside.

"Jack could do better than disasters like us," she said instead, trying for flippant but mostly sounding sheepish.

"Well, we're the ones who got the job," Glimmer said with carefree voice, "and we're gonna *ace* it."

"That's how you think of your princess gig too, huh?" Catra asked, suddenly more serious.

"Yes," Glimmer said, suddenly sincere. "My job is to balance Etheria, just as it's always been. That means getting Shadow Weaver's dirty paws off the moonstone, and that's what I'm going to do."

"Yes you are," Catra said with heartfelt voice. Glimmer gave her a thankful look. "But be smart about it."

"Meaning?" Glimmer said with sharp voice.

"Speaking as someone who has done my fair share of manipulating you in the past," Catra said with forced calm voice, "nothing does the trick as well as dangling something before your nose and telling you that it's your only option."

Glimmer bit down on an angry retort and glared at Catra.

"The Black Garnet?"

"You said it yourself," Catra said. "Shadow Weaver is collecting princesses. Princesses *and* your runestones. Do you really think she couldn't have grabbed this rock from Hordak during all this time if she really wanted?"

"You think she left it here for me?" Glimmer asked.

"The thought has crossed my mind," Catra said carefully.

Glimmer made a series of quick beats which Catra easily parried.

"Fine," Glimmer spat. "It's worth considering. And I'm sure you have a great alternative for me?"

"Nope," Catra said. "This is where you impress me with your princess smarts."

"So much for that cunning Catra who always were two steps ahead," Glimmer muttered.

Catra gave her a careful look.

"Although... there IS one piece that's still has to hit the table..."

Glimmer narrowed her eyes.

"Shadow Weaver is nearly as hung up on Adora as we are," Catra said. "If She-Ra shows up it's bound to catch her attention."

Whack, whack, whack.

"Sneaky," Glimmer commented after a while. "Think we can pull it off?"

"Double Trouble has been itching to play that role forever," Catra shrugged. "As long as we pull off the follow up-punch, we should be good."

"Worth considering," Glimmer thoughtfully said. "We'd need to get the timing just right."

"Of course..." Catra said, "When you peddle a fake, nothing beats having the original in our sleeve."

"No," Glimmer said with flat voice.

"I heard you last time," Catra said. "Still, if we go to Beast Island..."

"*No*," Glimmer said, more forcefully.

Catra sighed.

"Listen, Glimmer. There's one thing I have to tell you. About... your dad."

Glimmer froze.

"What about him?" she said, voice slightly shaky.

"He... Octavia says he wasn't killed, back during the first offensive. He was sent to Beast Island."

Glimmer stood rigid, holding her staff in front of her. Catra had lifted her own staff in a non-threatening gesture.

"That's awfully convenient," Glimmer said eventually, forcing herself to keep her voice steady. She slowly started to move again. Catra moved with her, blocking Glimmer's blows as they came.

"I'm not trying to manipulate you, Sparkles," Catra protested.

"Really?" Glimmer said. "To dangle that false hope in front of my nose sure sounds like manipulation to me."

"It might not be..." Catra begun, but Glimmer knocked her staff to the side and held jabbed viciously towards Catra's face, giving Catra only the tiniest fraction of a second to move to the side.

"My father is dead," Catra, "she said with even voice. Killed by the person sitting on the throne that now is my own. If he was killed

in battle, or executed, or sent to a nightmare monster island doesn't matter. He is still dead."

"But what if..." Catra begun, but she had to defend herself against another onslaught.

"You get that, right?" Glimmer said, teeth barred. "Beast Island is where you send people to *die*. My father is dead. Entrapta is dead. Scorpia is dead and -" she viciously stabbed her staff towards Catra's face "- Adora is dead. They are dead because *we* sent them to Beast Island to *die*."

"Hey," Catra tried. "The only one sent there to die by either of us was Entrapta, and that one is on me."

"I could have rescued her. I didn't," Glimmer shouted and made another attack Catra barely got away from. "How does that make me any better."

"Yeah, I get that you feel like shit, but speaking as the one who *actually* sent her to die, that makes *quite a bit* of difference," Catra snarled.

"Fine," Glimmer hissed, blocking a blow from Catra. "I'm not getting into a pissing contest about who's the worst piece of shit. The point still remains."

She unexpectedly moved her staff out of the way, and Catra had to quickly interrupt a blow to prevent herself from hitting Glimmer's face.

Glimmer took a step forward and, dropping her staff to the ground with a loud 'thunk', she took Catra's hands and looked her in the eyes.

"The point is," Glimmer said with gentle voice, "that there is nothing for us on Beast Island. Going there would be a fools errand chasing a fools hope. Our friends are dead, Catra. It's our fault and we have to live with that." Her eyes grew harder. "For one thing, by making sure their deaths were not in vain."

"Glimmer..." Catra whispered, eyes wet.

"I know," Glimmer whispered, her voice cracking. "I... I want her back too. Even if she would hate us, even if she would stop us from doing what's necessary to take down Shadow Weaver... I want her back. But I have to live with the fact that it won't happen."

"We could at least go and check," Catra pleaded.

"And we will," Glimmer said with warm voice. "I promise. After we are done with the business at hand."

She looked Catra in the eyes.

"I'm done sparring. Why don't you join me in the *shower?*"

"Um...?" Catra said, suddenly loosing her thread of thoughts.

"I thought you could help me scrub my back," Glimmer purred.

There was quite a bit of splashing after that.

- - -

"I don't know about you," Glimmer said a little while later as they walked hand in hand down the corridor, but I could absolutely *murder* a ration bar.

"I honestly never thought I'd miss the Fright Zone cooking," Catra mused.

"Let's see if our two lovebirds wants to..."

Glimmer's voice trailed off as she opened the door.

Jack's little chamber - that Frosta had moved into after just the barest prompt - was clean. Much cleaner than any room harbouring two teenagers had any right to be. The storage lockers were empty, the huge bed was made. On the pillow was a note.

Catra and Glimmer stared at each others, hearts racing.

Glimmer opened her mouth and closed it again, white in her face. She stared at the note, as unmovable as if she had turned into a statute.

Without thinking, Catra caught her as Glimmer slumped down towards the floor. They sat down together.

Catra felt her own gaze being drawn back to the note. She didn't want to read it. Didn't *need* to read it.

She already knew what it would say.

She felt Glimmer shake in her arms.

"I'm so sorry, Glimmer," she whispered. "I'm so sorry."

She turned to look at Glimmer's face and saw how Glimmer was shaking with laughter.

"...Glimmer?" she asked.

"Fucking kids," Glimmer managed to get out between spasms of laughter.

Catra stared at her like she was crazy, but after a moment she felt how laughter started to bubble up in her own stomach as well.

"Fucking *kids*," she managed before she started to laugh, which set off Glimmer again. They held each other and laughed like crazy for a solid minute, tears running, sides aching. Every time one of them thought they started to get the laughter under control, the other would try to say something or point at eh note, which set off the other.

That was how Double Trouble found them, a little while later as they came strolling down the corridor.

"My queens seem to be in a good mood," they loftily commented.

"You fucking knew," Catra said, pointing accusingly at them.

Double trouble made a perfectly executed innocent gesture.

"I don't have the faintest idea what..."

"Don't bother," Glimmer chuckled. She stood up with the help of Catra and stepped into Double Trouble's personal space, looking into their eyes.

"Just tell me one thing. Are they OK?"

Double Trouble held her gaze and nodded slightly. Glimmer relaxed and took a step back.

"They brought supplies," Double Trouble said with a soothing voice. "They stole a small vehicle. And more to the point, they are resourceful and they have each other." Double Trouble pointedly let their gaze travel between Glimmer and Catra. "If any ruffian out there aim to give them trouble, your worry would be more aptly directed at the ruffian in question."

"I suppose we don't have a leg standing on, bitchin' about the young ones not doing as they are told," Catra mused.

"Well, just for mother's information, if she can hear me, I for one refuse to learn any lessons from this," Glimmer loftily said.

She turned to Catra and took her hands.

"You are right, Catra. You are completely right. I'm done moping. We will beat that fucking witch *our* way, not by playing her games."

Catra didn't say anything, she just squeezed her hands, her eyes full of love.

"I like what I hear," Double Trouble chuckled.

"You fucking manipulative bastard," Glimmer laughed. "Well, since you are so invested in our relationship, you can just as well help out."

That took even Double Trouble back.

"*My Queens!*" they said.

"Not like that," Glimmer laughed. She gave Double Trouble a coy look. "At least... not right now. For now I have something else in mind. I rather think me and Catra are due for a date."

"What are you up to, Sparkles," Catra asked, a raised eyebrow.

"Double Trouble," Glimmer said with a grin. "Didn't you tell me once about a club where the pirate captains like to gather?"

"Ah, you must be thinking of the Enchanted Grotto," Double Trouble drawled. "An oasis for forbidden delights for those guile enough to decipherer the clues to it's hidden location."

"You can get us there, I take it," Glimmer said.

Double Trouble's grin widened.

"Naturally, my queen."

"What are you plotting now, Sparkles?" Catra asked with slight apprehension.

Glimmer gave her a radiant smile.

"Don your finest suit, my Queen. We are going dancing."

Chapter End Notes

Diiiiid someone say jazz club episode?

The Enchanted Grotto

Chapter Notes

Warning: Mentions of suicide.

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"You, my queen, look absolutely smashing."

"Thank you, my queen. Would it be forward of me to point out that you are hot as shit?"

"Much appreciated, my queen."

"Think nothing of it, my queen."

Glimmer was dressed in a black and pink formhugging dress, covered with frills and sequins that made her sparkle for every step she took (and not only from magic this time). Black feathers with pink frosted tips covered her shoulders and neck. Her hair was adorned by a circlet of black and pink gems and feathers. Catra was dressed in her old suit all the way back from princess prom, sleek and dangerous. She still hadn't tied her tie.

They gave each other a long, admiring look.

"I have only one question, my queen," Catra said.

"Yes, my queen?" Glimmer asked.

"What is *he* doing here?" Catra asked and pointed at Sea Hawk with her thumb.

"Fear not, my most stylish evil overlords," Sea Hawk said with a flourished bow. "I'm here to make sure there are no dangers lurking."

"Can I maim him just a little if I promise not to kill him?" Catra wined.

"No maiming," Glimmer drily said. "And he is here because he is useful to us." She looked Sea Hawk right into the eyes. "A usefulness that is greatly dependent on him being able to not sing for the next three hours."

"No promises, my Queen," Sea Hawk said with a little bow that was so obnoxious that Double Trouble was visibly impressed. They held out their hand.

"Perhaps I can find a way to keep your mouth occupied, hot stuff," they drawled.

"A bold claim, my thrilling thespian, which many have attempted but no one as of yet succeeded," Sea Hawk said and took their hand. He quickly bent down to place a kiss on it and then held Double Trouble's gaze with a raised eyebrow.

"Oh I *like* this one," Double Trouble laughed. "Can I keep him, my queen?"

"You might, *if* you behave," Glimmer said. "But right now, I want him to properly introduce us."

"Of course, my Queen," Sea Hawk said and - with a last wink at Double Trouble - stood up and walked up to the door.

"What's the password?" the fish person on guard sneered.

"'The dolphins roll in the tide at dawn'," Sea Hawk whispered with a little wink that made Double Trouble titter.

"Piss off," the guard said.

"Your intelligence does not seem to hold up," Glimmer said with a raised eyebrow.

"My intelligence is good," Double Trouble shot back with offended voice. "The reception isn't. If I were to venture a guess, there are certain elements behind that door who perhaps would like to conduct their business away from the watching eyes of the Queens of the Horde."

"Well, I'm going to..." Catra begun and took a step forward, but before she had time to do anything violent, Sea Hawk stepped closer to the guard.

"Please," he said with reasonable voice. "I'm not sure you properly appreciate the intricacies of the situation."

Without waiting for an answer, he punched the guard in the chest with a move straight from the 'Gentleman's manual to the noble art of fisticuffs'. The guard flew backwards, through the door, into the rickety elevator on the other side, and hit the wall with a loud crash.

Before the guard managed to get his breath back, Sea Hawk had dragged him to his feet.

"The lovely ladies in my company have expressed the wish to visit your establishment incognito," Sea Hawk said with a voice that in no manner betrayed that he was talking about anything more exciting than the weather. "But since you carry the important burden of ensuring the security, I felt you should be let into a little secret."

He lifted the still half-dazed guard to get a better view of Glimmer - who looked bored, and Catra - who studied her claws.

"Despite their delicate appearance, my exquisite company here are no others than the Queens of the Horde - supreme rulers of the largest armed force of this world, scourges of the Crimson Waste, vanquishers of Hordak and - least you happen to fraternize with the Shadow Queen of Brightmoon herself - without any doubt the single most dangerous individuals you will ever meet:

Catra, also known as the Strongest of the Crimson Waste; and Glimmer, also known as the Shining Princess."

Sea Hawk's moustached face moved closer to the guards face, and his voice died down to a whisper.

"If you and me were to continue our little tussle, I want you to be in no illusion that it would most certainly result in me kicking your ass into such a variety of geometric figures that the noble scholars of Mystacor would put together an expedition for the sole reason of studying it in all its intricacies. However, I want it to be perfectly clear that such a fight would be without contest the safest possible fate the future has in store for you. You see, my lovely companions have at the moment accepted to leave the nitty gritty of administrative burdens to yours truly, but if entry is denied them much longer, they might wish to inquire just *why*."

"I *do* like him," Double Trouble chuckled as the guard scampered to give them entry to the elevator. "Just *look* at that delivery."

Catra kept concentrating on her claws.

- - -

"Do you by any chance have experience of the theatrical arts?" Double Trouble asked, tail rapidly shifting between different colours as they - hand on Sea Hawk's arm - left the elevator and entered the Enchanted Grotto.

"The ocean is my music hall and the stern of my ship is my stage," Sea Hawk answered and puffed up his chest slightly.

"I would take it as a personal favour if the two of you could cease your flirting for the time being," Glimmer said with an eyeroll as she, hand on Catra's arm, left the elevator behind them. "Take a round to prepare for the necessary introductions instead. Me and Catra will wait in the bar."

"I for one never saw the reason for separating work and pleasure," Double Trouble drawled and reached up to press a little

peck on Sea Hawk's cheek. "But have no fear, my magnificent monarchs. By the time you have finished your drink, we will have set the scene."

With Sea Hawk in tow they walked into the crowd and was soon swallowed by it.

"I still don't see what he is useful for," Catra grumbled.

"A common reaction to Sea Hawk," Glimmer noted, "which is one of many properties that make him *very* useful despite how extremely annoying he is."

"If he can keep Double Trouble busy for a while it might very well be worth it," Catra mused.

"We should be so fortunate," Glimmer sighed. With gentle pressure she signalled to Catra to get moving, and they walked over to the bar placed close to the entrance but a bit out of the way, for people such as them who preferred to lurk before they entered the main room.

"Could you please give my lovely wife something strong but surprisingly sweet," Glimmer asked the bartender.

"And then for *my* lovely wife something pink and ridiculous, but that can burn you up from the inside if you aren't careful," Catra said.

They smirked as each other. The bartender - wisely - prepared their drinks and took their coin without comment. They sat on bar stools next to each other, just so close that their arms made occasional content, and sipped their drinks as they watched the crowd.

"This, right here is pretty much what I thought it would be," Catra said as two large women - covered with tattoos and between them carrying enough weapons to sink a medium sized Horde ship - tackled each other into the opposite wall and enthusiastically started to make out.

"Hmmmm?" Glimmer said, seemingly lost in thought as the two kissing women started to cause structural damage to the surrounding architecture.

"The world..." Catra said. "Outside of the Horde. Me and Adora used to sit up in bed and fantasize of what it would be like."

"And your idea was a room full of ruffians finding creative ways to debase each other?" Glimmer said with dry voice.

"No boss," Catra simply said. "No Hordak. No Shadow Weaver... she gave Glimmer a cheeky grin. "No princesses."

"One out of three is not so bad," Glimmer remarked.

"I haven't' exactly left the Horde," Catra shrugged. "Still, it's fun visiting this kind of place now and then. It must be old hat for you!"

"Are you kidding me?" Glimmer laughed. "You went to princess prom. You know what my social circles looked like - only more boring."

"I'm so glad we got this little opportunity to let our hair down," Catra growled and in one fluid movement stepped up to Glimmer's chair and leaned closer - much closer - to the suddenly flustered Glimmer. Catra quickly nibbled at her chin, and then moved her mouth downwards, towards Glimmer's neck.

"Please forgive me for interrupting," Sea Hawk said with unperturbed voice, but we are ready to make introductions, your majesties."

"*Now* can I maim them?" Catra growled, still pinning Glimmer to the chair.

"Not... yet..." Glimmer gasped, cheeks red. "Sea Hawk, it would be *most* considerate if you gave us a moment to compose ourselves."

"I'm ready to chaperone you as soon as you find it suitable," Sea Hawk grinned and moved over a few steps. At the same time, a man with an impressive sword at his belt left the elevator. He and Sea Hawk stared at each other.

"Oh dear..." Sea Hawk said. "Um, hi, Falcon. Long time, no seen."

"YOU!" The man bellowed and draw his sword.

"Catra...?" Glimmer sighed.

"Fine, but you owe me one," Catra hissed and, reluctantly, stood up from Glimmer's lap and, without any preamble whatsoever, stuck out a leg and tripped the approaching pirate. She sauntered over to him and pressed a claw against his throat, silencing whatever curse he was about to unleash.

"I don't care who you are," she hissed. "I don't care what history you have with the idiot over there. I don't care about anything you might be about to say or do. I just want you to know that the seconds I have to spend talking to you could be spent doing something much more enjoyable, and that all things considered, clubbing was not in the cards for you today."

She pressed her claw further against his throat and leaned closer, showing her teeth. "Stand up, walk into that elevator and leave before I decide that spending more time on you will be worth my while."

The man glance in the direction of Sea Hawk with pure, burning hatred in his eyes, but then he relaxed and gave Catra a short nod. She released him and he walked into the elevator without a word.

"I owe you many thanks, my fabulous feline," Sea Hawk said with bombastic voice. "My ex is not as forgiving as perhaps could be..."

"YOU!" a woman cried, coming from the bar. She immediately drew a knife and rushed towards Sea Hawk.

"Oh... um, hi!" Sea Hawk said.

"Oh for crying out loud..." Glimmer said, and teleported to the woman's side, and then away. A moment later she was back by Catra's side.

"I am ever in your debt..." Sea Hawk begun.

"Let's get to the introductions *before* we have another interruption," Glimmer said pointedly.

"By all means," Sea Hawk said and set off towards the main room. "Follow me, my Merciful Monarchs."

With a perfectly synchronized eye-roll, Catra and Glimmer followed him through the crowd, to a table in a somewhat secluded part of the room. It was not exactly a private section, but the way it was placed in a corner and the way heavily armed thugs blocked the way for everyone not invited helped create privacy of sorts.

The thugs glared at Sea Hawk but let them through, to a table occupied by Double Trouble and a man with a short beard and a shirt that left a generous amount of muscles visible.

There were two empty chair, which Sea Hawk made a show of holding out for Glimmer and Catra. Then he walked over to the wall, where extra chairs stood stacked, lifted one to the table and happily plopped down.

"My Queens," Double Trouble drawled while the others rolled their eyes at Sea hawk's antics. "Please allow me to introduce admiral Scurvy of Seaworthy. Admiral Scurvy, these are..."

"I'm aware who they are," Scurvy answered with a long look at the two queens.

"I am glad to hear that," Glimmer said with sweet voice. "That saves us any tedious introductions."

"Your reputation precedes you, your majesties," Scurvy said.

"And what does that 'reputation' say?" Glimmer casually asked.

"It says you are not people to be trifled with," Scurvy replied.

"That is true," Glimmer said, and for just a moment sparks glittered over her hands.

"It also says you as rulers might be open to... new ways of doing things."

"That is also true," Glimmer said, smiling a smile that showed off pearly white teeth.

Scurvy leaned back and thoughtfully regarded the two women for a moment, then he abruptly shouted at one of his goons: "Don't just stand there! Give our guests something to drink!"

"See, as a man of marine enterprise," Scurvy said, "I might also be open to... new ways of doing things."

"Really?" Glimmer said, eyebrow lifted. "The current winds not to your liking?"

"There is an old saying among us simple sea-folk," Scurvy said, taking a swig from a bottle that his thug placed before him. "The saying goes that Salineas rules the sea... heard of it?"

"I have been made aware of it, yes," Glimmer said, face neutral. She took her time choosing from the assortment of bottles and glasses placed in front of her, picking a dainty little glass with sugar frosting and something pink and sparkly inside.

"Lots of old superstition, really," Scurvy mused. "But it makes an impression. We *are* a superstitious lot, I'm afraid."

"It might have something to do with Salineas being the residence of the Sea Gate and the princess of the ocean," Glimmer suggested.

"Like I said," Scurvy said without breaking eye-contact, "lots of old superstition."

Catra didn't say anything, but a low growl could be heard in her throat. Her claws scratched gorges in the table.

"An interesting perspective, I'm sure," Glimmer said and put a soothing hand on Catra's. "However, the current little... spat between the Horde and the princess of Salineas, is more than mere superstition. To be perfectly frank it's becoming a bit of a problem."

"You *did* invade her home," Scurvy pointed out and made a mock toast to Catra. Catra glared at him, but took a swig from a bottle with clear content in response.

"We can't have little things like that hanging over us while we do business," Glimmer said with a shrug.

"Ah, business," Scurvy echoed.

"Yes, business," Glimmer said, voice suddenly sharp. "Like the business that is now flowing through Seaworthy rather than Salineas. The business that is lining your pockets while our coffers echo empty. *That* business."

Scurvy might have shifted his weight slightly, just by chance positioning himself for easier access to his weapons.

"Free entrepreneur can't really be faulted for finding the safest port for their wares," Scurvy said, voice carefully neutral.

"Nor can't competing ports be faulted for finding ways to increase their attraction."

Scurvy raised an eyebrow.

"Is that what you call the Horde's blockade? Since you took Salineas, the customs have doubled and you've hunted everyone trying to avoid them without mercy."

"I don't see the problem," Glimmer primly said and sipped her drink, body language relaxed.

After a moment, Scurvy relaxed as well and tog another swig from his bottle.

"Neither do I, to tell you the truth," he grinned. "The blockade keeps us on our toes, but it weeds out the competition. To be perfectly blunt, your majesties, you have made me rich."

"We are aware," Glimmer said.

They sipped their drinks.

"All this is well and good," admiral Scurvy said. "But you have still not told us what interested the Horde has with the, ah, free merchant enterprises of Seaworthy."

"You can say 'pirates'," Glimmer said with prim voice. "We are all adults here."

Double Trouble smirked.

"It's very easy," Glimmer said. "The Horde is consolidating our efforts. We are no longer attempting to invade Snow. The Crimson Waste is ours. The sea... well, there are those who say it belong to Salineas, like you noted, but Salineas is *ours*, and still the trade flow by Seaworthy."

"The sea belongs to *Mermista*," Scurvy said pointedly. "Mermista belongs to Brightmoon."

"The *imposter* in Brightmoon might have some temporary hold on the princess of the sea," Glimmer spat, "but rest assured that the Horde will deal with the witch, and soon."

"What business is that of Seaworthy?" Scurvy shot back.

"You mean, 'what business is that of Admiral Scurvy'?" Glimmer said with a little smile. "The answer is that we have a business

proposal for you."

Scurvy smiled. Now they were talking.

"You want to close another front? You want me to play nice with your ships and your coastal towns even if you call off your pet octopus."

"I want a great deal more than that," Glimmer said. "I want to get my fellow princess back from the clutches of the imposter in Brightmoon. I want to end Shadow Weavers hold on the oceans.

"And how am I supposed to do all that?" Scurvy scoffed.

"*You* are not supposed to anything," Glimmer said coldly, "except for a little piracy."

"Actually, when you work for the crown it's called 'privateering'," Double Trouble drawled. Glimmer and Scurvy shot them a synchronous, annoyed look.

"What do you want us to steal?" Scurvy asked, all attention.

Glimmer sipped on her drink with perhaps just a slightly bit more melodrama than strictly necessary (hanging out with Double Trouble does that to people).

"Nothing much, just the runestone of the ocean, the lynchpin of the Sea Gate and the most heavily guarded treasure of Salineas. I want you to bring me the Pearl" She smiled at Scurvy's shocked look. "What? Too hot for you to handle? I thought it would be right in the wheelhouse of an, ah, free enterprising merchant of Seaworthy."

"You own Salineas," Scurvy shot back. "Why don't you just order your men to pry it loose for you if you want a table decoration back in the Fright Zone?"

"Hah!" Sea Hawk guffawed to everyone's irritation. "I'd like to see them try."

"Turns out, being an absolute monarch - let alone an invading usurper to the throne - does not convey the absolute power one might wish," Glimmer said with dry voice. "We would much more prefer for this matter the be handled in a more... discrete fashion."

"Ah," Scurvy said.

"Ah," Double Trouble echoed.

They knew about discrete.

"And what do I get in return," Scurvy said, leaning forward.

Glimmer looked him in the eyes.

"Salineas," she simply answered. "The Horde will withdraw our presence and flag and name *you* the ruler - all official and proper. Admiral Scurvy rules the sea. Nice ring to it, don't you think?"

"Sparkles..." Catra carefully aid. "I didn't go to all the effort to take Salineas just for you to give it away."

"Glimmer..." Sea Hawk said. "My beautiful Sea Tulip is the very epitome of forgiving, but I don't think she would approve of..."

"Too bad," Glimmer shot them down. "Sharing the throne means sharing your stuff, and I'm giving this thing away. As for Mermista, she already lost her kingdom to the Horde once. She should be used to it by now. If Shadow Weaver isn't stopped, none of us will have a kingdom to return to."

"You have yourself a deal," Scurvy said with a wide grin.

"Thank you, and the best of luck on your enterprise." Glimmer said. "Oh, and one more thing. Sea Hawk and his crew are coming with you."

"He is?" Scurvy cried.

"I am?" Sea Hawk cried in exactly the same tone of voice.

"He is," Glimmer said coldly. "He is the Horde's liaison on this venture and his presence is non-negotiable."

Without taking any notice of their outraged looks she turned to Catra.

"I feel no need to prolong this conversation, my queen," she said with aloof voice. "Please see that these merry buccaneers remove themselves from our table, and then perhaps you'd see fit to join me on the dance floor.

She held up her hand to Double Trouble.

"Would it please you to keep us company until then, Double Trouble?"

"It would, my queen," they leered and took her hand. With a suave little movement they helped her to her feet and led her to the middle of the room, where a band was playing.

"Masterfully played, my queen," Double Trouble whispered as they led the dance.

"Why, thank you," she answered. "You will be undercover as a member of Sea Hawk's crew, naturally. I want you to keep an eye on the transaction so everything goes smoothly and no one gets creative. With Sea Hawk in the lead, you should have all distractions you could ever need."

"Naturally," they said. They relaxed their grip slightly, signalling to Glimmer to take the lead of the dance as the music picked up speed.

"There is one thing I wondered," they said as Glimmer dipped them (they might have cheated and made themself shorter to facilitate it).

"Only one thing?" Glimmer asked with dry voice.

"For the moment," Double Trouble amended. "Do you really intend to hand a second rate pirate they keys to Salineas?" they asked as Glimmer whirled them back up to their feet.

"Sure, why not?" she shrugged. "It's not like Mermista did much ruling even before the Horde took over. In fact, the princesses have not been in a position to rule *anything* lately."

"Present company excluded, naturally," Double Trouble commented.

Glimmer gave them a short nod, her face the queenly mask they had come to recognize as her way to shield complicated feelings.

"And you think Scurvy will do a better job?" they commented with dry voice.

"Of course not," Glimmer laughed. "And it's not like he will keep it. Someone else will take it from him within a month."

"You're opening up a free-for-all for control of the oceans?"

"Yes," she simply said, slowing down the tempo. "Mermista might even make her own bid once we've freed her from Shadow Weaver, should she so wish."

"And then what?" Double Trouble asked, leaning slightly forward.

"Then *what*?" she shot back as they circled each other, not breaking eye contact. "I'll negotiate with whoever holds the sea at any given point. For the moment, I have just united the pirates and the Horde. Once I have the Pearl I can neutralize Mermista, and then I will have all the access I need to the sea without having to position a single Horde soldier. And if Scurvy, or whoever holds Salineas at the moment, should come to be more hindrance than help... Well, Catra has taken the city once before. She can do it again."

"Very pragmatic, my Queen," Double Trouble said as they let go of Glimmer's hands and twirled. As they spun back, Catra had moved

in between them.

"I'm cutting in, if you don't mind," she said, putting more emphasis on the word 'cutting' than strictly necessary.

"By all means, my queens," Double Trouble laughed and spun away in the dance, heading for the stage.

Catra took Glimmer's hands. Glimmer squeezed them slightly, signalling for her to lead.

"Enjoying yourself, Sparkles?" Catra said as she led her sparkly girlfriend to the centre of the floor.

"Immensely, Kitty-cat," Glimmer smiled at her.

"So, you get the Pearl, you can take care of Mermista?" Catra asked and lifted Glimmer on her strong arms.

"I should," Glimmer said with low voice. "Even if I can't break Shadow Weaver's control outright, I should be able to keep her down while our fleet slips past."

"And then... Brightmoon?" Catra asked and let Glimmer slide back to the floor.

"That's the plan," Glimmer said. "Strike fast, strike hard before Shadow Weaver has time for whatever her next trick would be."

"I sure hope you know what you're doing," Catra said. Glimmer smiled at her.

"Don't I always," she said sweetly.

Catra just shook her head.

They moved through over the floor, a slow, close dance, their feet in perfect synch.

"Do you ever wonder..." Glimmer said silently "If we had met at another time... in another place... if we could have done things

like... this without having to fight a war."

Catra was uncharacteristically silent as she led Glimmer another few steps of the dance.

"It was a long time ago I stopped wonder if I could have nice things, Sparkles," she said with low voice.

"This is nice, isn't it," Glimmer answered, the same low, somewhat dejected voice.

"Yeah," Catra said. "It is. And all we had to do was to wade through an ocean of blood to get here."

She sighed.

"Don't get me wrong," she said with tired voice. "I'd totally do it again.... I'll probably *have* to do it again, if we're going to survive whatever nefariousness Shadow Weaver has in the pipeline. I just... sometimes... wish I didn't have to."

Glimmer moved in and gave her a quick hug before the beats of the dance separated them again.

"We could have a little house together," she said with soft voice and allowed Catra bring down the pace. "By the sea. And we would go dancing every weekend."

"Would there be a garden?" Catra asked and pulled Glimmer slightly closer.

"Of course there would be a garden," Glimmer answered, taking the opportunity to hide her face in Catra's fur, just for a moment. "We would grow carrots, potatoes and leek"

"What's that?"

"Tastes good with fish."

"Oh, OK! That's good then."

They took a few steps more.

"And... we wouldn't have to fight anyone," Glimmer said a longing in her voice.

"You'd grew bored in a week," Catra smirked.

"I could take up a hobby," Glimmer protested. "I'd take up... dunno, mountaineering or something."

"What?" Catra asked. "Climb up a mountain."

"And down again," Glimmer said.

Catra pondered that.

"Can I come?" she asked. "Up the mountain?"

"Of course you can," Glimmer said. "And down again."

"Yeah," Catra said after a few moments. "It would have been nice."

"It would have been nice," Glimmer echoed.

They danced in silence.

"Did you ever think we would get this far?" Glimmer asked silently.

"Honestly," Catra answered. "I didn't think we'd ever get out of that desert."

"We wouldn't, if it weren't for you," Glimmer reminded. "You physically carried me out of there."

"Yeah, because there was someone for me to carry," Catra answered quietly.

"Catra..." Glimmer said. Catra shook her head.

"I... honestly thought there wasn't anything for me, after Hordak kicked me out. I thought... I thought I would..."

She sighed.

"I'm so glad I have you, Glimmer," she whispered. There were tears in her eyes.

"You do have me," Glimmer whispered, her own voice shaking. "I'm not going anywhere."

"Sure you won't," Catra said and managed a little smirk. "We both know you have fancy plans for the future."

Glimmer answered with a bleak smirk of her own.

"Taking over the Horde was not enough?"

"For you? No. That was my goal, never yours."

"And me?" Glimmer asked silently.

Catra watched her intently.

"You told me once that your goal was to take down the Horde."

"I honestly didn't expect to take over it instead," Glimmer admitted.

"Well, you did. So now what?"

"You know the answer to that," Glimmer said with somewhat sharp voice.

Catra made a dismissive little gesture.

"Yeah, yeah. But I'm not talking about Shadow Weaver. I'm talking about afterwards."

Glimmer smiled, a somewhat guarded smile.

"Now look who's believes in happily ever afters."

"Is that what taking over the world is?" Catra asked. "Is that what you want?"

Glimmer didn't answer.

"What about guys like Scurvy?" Catra asked. Glimmer gave her a sharp look.

"What about them?"

"We'll have to keep dealing with guys like that, won't we?" Catra shot back. "And what about the princesses? Will they have objections?"

"They will hardly be in a position to," Glimmer said sharply. Then her expression suddenly grew pained.

Catra sighed.

"Yeah, that's what I mean. Winning the war the way we do is one thing... but ruling the world...?"

Glimmer sighed, a tired sigh.

"Is it to late for that cottage-thing?"

"I honestly don't know," Catra answered. She dipped Glimmer and held her.

"I just want you to know..." she bent down. "Wherever you go, Glimmer, I'll be with you. You don't have to win alone."

She lifted Glimmer to her feet again. Glimmer looked at her with eyes full of tears.

"Catra..." she begun, but then her voice faltered. She burred her face against Catra's shoulder.

They danced in silence for a few moments.

"Did... did you ever think of doing something else...?" Catra asked with low voice. "About not being a princess? Not fighting a war?"

A shiver went through Glimmer's body.

"This is not exactly what you were thinking, were it?" Catra sighed. "It's OK, I get it."

"I love you," Glimmer muttered, voice muffled.

"I know," Catra said with slightly tired voice. "And I love you, you know that."

They moved another few steps in synch with the music.

"I... I mostly didn't," Glimmer said eventually. "Dream about not being a princess, that is. I dreamt about being *more* of a princess. Stronger. More powerful. I dreamt of kicking the Horde's ass."

"Well, there're a few dots you can cross from the list," Catra said flippantly. Glimmer snorted.

"But we would... I mean, it was just an idle fantasy. We talked about having a cottage. Just the two of us, out in the whispering woods. He would hunt for us and I would bake, and then he'd tease me about being shit at baking. We could... have a workshop and make little contraptions to sell in the town square... it would only be us. No meetings. No parents. No war..."

Glimmer blinked away fresh tears.

"It was never serious, of course. We both knew I wouldn't step away from my responsibilities... but..."

Her voice trailed off.

"I get it," Catra said with tone-less voice. "Sometimes the 'to' is not as important as the 'from'."

"Yeah..." Glimmer sighed.

"You know..." Catra carefully said after a few more steps. "You never talk about him."

Glimmer gave her a downright scared look.

"Wha-at?"

"We talk about Adora," Catra mused with the same careful voice. "We've talked about your mom. Obviously we talk about the Shadow Bitch. We even talk about Scorpia and Entrapta, but not Arrow Boy."

Glimmer held her breath, staring at Catra with large eyes.

"Want to tell me about Bow?" Catra gently asked, and then she held Glimmer hard as a tears emerged in her eyes.

Catra gently steered the rigid Glimmer to a little alcove (where the two kissing pirates who occupied it wisely evacuated as they saw the Queens approaching). They sat down on a sofa, and Catra held Glimmer as she silently wept.

"He wouldn't... approve of us, is that it?" Catra said.

Glimmer didn't answer.

"Hey, I get it," Catra said. "I'm used to be the bad friend." She held Glimmer harder. "But you aren't, are you?"

Glimmer did a little feeble, protesting sound.

"This... happily ever after we'll have, whatever it'll be," Catra said, voice reduced to a whisper. "It's... not exactly compatible with the one you were dreaming of, is it?"

Glimmer shook her head, but Catra ploughed on before Glimmer could speak.

"It's not really fair, is it? I got it all. I got to beat the shit out of Hordak, I snagged myself a princess with a great ass... I'll even

get a shot to sort out my mommie issues before this is all over... but you, you're stuck with me."

"No!" Glimmer protested. "I'm not 'stuck with you'. I *love* you, Catra. I won't just throw you away for something better once the war is over."

"I know. I believe you," Catra quickly lied. "But it's not like your little princess friends will want anything to do with me."

"Frosta thinks you're cool as shit," Glimmer protested.

"Frosta ran away," Catra pointedly said.

"That doesn't count," Glimmer protested. "She and Jack are out on adventure. Can't have us old folks getting in the way of them getting into a proper mess together."

"Speaking from experience?" Catra smirked.

"As do you," Glimmer shot back.

Her smirk died down and she took a deep breath.

"I get it, Catra. You worry about me. It's sweet, but..."

"No, you listen to me," Catra interrupted her. "I get you. You feel that you have to move on, that what's done is done, that you have done your damage. And that now you have to justify it. Thing is... That's bullshit." She looked Glimmer in the eyes. "You tell me you won't give up on me. Fine, I appreciate it. What about him? What about *her*? Are you giving up on them?"

Glimmer trembled visibly. Her mouth moved but she couldn't produce a single sound.

"Tell me," Glimmer, Catra said with gentle voice. "What would he think of us?"

"He would support us, obviously," Glimmer whispered, fighting hard to hold her tears back. "That's what he does, whatever happens, he is the supportive guy, the friendship guy. He believed in me... always... whatever I..."

She blinked furiously.

"Wouldn't exactly believe in what you are doing now, is that it?"

"I turned Netossa and Spinnerella down," Glimmer whispered. "I'm haggling with Mermista's kingdom like I have any right to it. I didn't even send a messenger to Snow after we took the Fright Zone because I was so ashamed, but then Frosta showed up and... *adored* me."

Glimmer's voice became barely audible.

"She should have hated me," she whispered.

Catra held her harder.

"So, Bow...?" she asked.

"He won't hate me either," Glimmer vailed. "None of them will. Not even Adora. But someone *should*."

"Feel you deserve to be hated, do you?" Catra said with even voice. "For being with me?"

"No!" Glimmer protested. "Not that. Not you. The rest of it. The shortcuts. The bullying. Salineas, Thaymore... The thing I did to poor Seneschal when he asked us to move out of Plumeria... it shouldn't be like this."

"Hey, Glimmer," Catra said gently. "I fought the princess alliance, and you guys were loosing pretty badly - and that was with Adora doing heavy lifting for you. If you - *this* you - had been on the throne, Hordak would have been pushed back to the Fright Zone in a month."

"Just because it's working doesn't mean it's right," Glimmer muttered.

"Says who?" Catra shot back. "People like Netossa and Spinnerella? They weren't the one's winning the war."

"Well, neither have I, yet," Glimmer sighed.

"You will," Catra said with determined voice. "*We* will. Together."

"Together..." Glimmer echoed, her voice very vulnerable.

"I get it, Sparkles," Catra said voice full of compassion. "You feel like shit. You want other people to hate you because you feel you *deserve* to be hated. I've been there...." she sighed. "Stupid Scorpia never hated me the way she should. Even *Adora* was busy trying to forgive me or save me or whatever..."

She blinked, keeping her eyes closed for a few moments while collecting her thoughts.

"Thing is... the stupid thing is... the really *unfair* thing is... that even if people were hating you like you feel they should, it wouldn't make things better. Not for them, not for you. It only makes you miserable, which is part of the goal, I suppose, but things are still shit. Not only for you, but for everyone else."

She gave Glimmer an almost shy smile.

"Do you want to know the weirdest part of it? The one thing that *actually* made things better?"

Glimmer wordlessly nodded.

"It was someone who loved me," Catra said and squeezed Glimmer's hand. She barred her teeth. "I *know* how soppy that sounds. Shut up."

Glimmer looked at her with eyes full of tears. Catra met her eyes with a serious expression.

"Let's not beat around the bush, Sparkles. You saved me. You were there for me when I most needed it. I wouldn't have made it, without you. Octavia would have got to me. Or Hordak. Or..." -her voice died to a whisper- "...I would."

She sighed.

"You saved me, Glimmer. And now I see you hurting the way I did. I see you doing the same mistakes i did. I see you beating yourself up, and the thing is..." -she barred her teeth. "*No one* gets to drag the woman I love. Not even you. So if you need hugs and kisses, I'm there for you. If this is the time when you need someone to kick your ass and tell you to get your shit together, I'm more than willing. The thing is - I'm not giving up on you, Sparkles. Ever."

"Catra..." Glimmer begun.

"So look me in the eyes, Glimmer," Catra growled, "and give me one fucking reason why we shouldn't go and get your fucking friends when you so clearly need them?"

"Catra..." Glimmer whispered again, white in her face.

"I'm glad to see how much we're all enjoying ourselves," a rich and smooth voice said from the stage. "This next song is dedicated to two *special* ladies gracing us with our presence tonight."

"Is that...?" Glimmer said instead.

The man on stage smiled, a deeply irreverent leer.

"It is," Catra confirmed. "What are they up to now?"

"Singing, by the look of it," Glimmer said as Double Trouble - in the guise of a fish-person dressed in an expensive looking suit - slid down by the piano and started to sing, a smooth song, with a rhythm that made them want to swing and twirl. Glimmer took a deep breath and stood up. She held out her hand to Catra.

"...mommie's little princess,
was a little brat..."

"I'll kill them," Catra said between gritted teeth.

"...she found an alley cat..."

"Not yet!" Glimmer said and dragged Catra to her feet. "It's catchy."

They're bad, bad girls,
The badest girl in the whole wide word...

"Feel like dancing with a bad girl, do you?" Catra smirked.

"You know it, kitty cat," Glimmer laughed and they threw themselves back in the dance.

There was this ne'erdowell
Who thought 'I'll bag myself a cat'
'You gotta go through me,' the princess said
And threw him to the mat

Cause they are bad, bad girls,
The badest girls in the whole wide world
You think you got one of them in the sack
You'd better watch your back.

"You'd stop any ne'erdowell coming do hurt me, would you?" Catra smirked.

"I'd *crush* them," Glimmer said with a conviction that made Catra feel quite wobbly.

"You say the most romantic things," she smiled

Glimmer smiled back. There was a sincerity in their expressions that matched badly with the cheesy song.

"You know it's true," Glimmer whispered. "I'd do anything to keep you safe, Kitten."

"I'd do the same for you, Glimmer," Catra said with gentle voice. "That's what I'm trying to do now."

They had themselves a grand ol' time
They danced the night away
But as the music faded and the moonlight dimmed
They had to face another day

They are bad, bad girls,
The badest girls in the whole wide world...

"...Sparkles?" Catra said carefully. She felt a shudder go through Glimmer's body.

"We will get her back," Glimmer whispered, chin pressed against Catra's, tears flowing. "I don't care what the witch is doing, I don't care who stands in our way. We are getting Bow and Adora and Entrapta and Scorpia off that island. And my dad too, sure, why not! And if they hate us, then the least we can do is to allow them to say it to our faces."

"I love you," Catra said, relief flooding through her.

On the stage, Double Trouble grinned.

"They are bad, bad girls,
The badest girls in the whole wide world...

Chapter End Notes

They are bad, bad girls... (inspired by Sinatra's Leroy Brown)

One more chapter in this act.

Beast Island

Chapter Notes

> Warning: Themes of hardship, depression, grief, guilt and suicide.
>
> Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Beast Island," Octavia said, voice heavy.

Glimmer and Catra looked at the ill boding blue light blinking from the distant landmass.

"So this is where you take prisoners," Glimmer said. "I'd have expected a dock or a pier or something."

"We are not stupid enough to set foot on the island ourselves," Octavia shrugged. "We just toss the prisoners in a row-boat and let them take it from there. Those who are stupid go for the shore."

"And no one ever returns?" Glimmer asked with a shudder.

"Never," Octavia answered.

"It strikes me," Catra said with an edge to her voice, "that once me and Sparkles are ashore, you'll have some decisions to do..."

"Yeah," Octavia answered gruffly, keeping her voice even.

"Three days," Catra said. "If we are not back in that time, the throne is up for grabs and you'll have the first shot."

"Awfully kind of you, boss," Octavia grumbled.

"But if you should get the bright idea to depart before that time has passed..." Catra went on, "well, you'd better be *really* sure

we're not coming back."

"Got it," Octavia answered in the same voice.

She and Catra looked each other in the eyes (just one of them, in Octavia's case) for a long, uncomfortable moment.

"Very well, Sparkles," Catra said. "Take us to the shore."

"Just the two of us?" Glimmer asked. "Isn't the point of having underlings to sometimes have them do stuff for you."

"They'd only be a liability on that Island," Catra explained. "Besides, whatever the two of us can't handle we should probably run from anyway. We're faster on our own."

"Well, I suppose we are due a honeymoon," Glimmer mused. She held out her hand. "My Queen?"

"My Queen."

And together they teleported to shore.

Octavia watched the pink flash in her spyglass that heralded her queens' arrival to Beast Island. She stood in silence for a while, impassionately watching the blue lights.

Her first mate walked up to her.

"Captain?"

"We could always become pirates." Octavia muttered.

The first mate watched the island together with her for a moment.

"Aye," she said after a while.

It really did seem like a logical career choice.

- - -

Glimmer and Catra looked around. They stood on a beach, littered with first ones' trash.

"Well, they are not here," Glimmer concluded.

"Perceptive as always, Sparkles," Catra commented and got a grin for her troubles.

"With both Bow and Entrapta stuck here, I figure they have probably rigged some kind of signal, but I don't receive anything," Glimmer reported, fiddling with her comm pad.

"Let's head inline," Catra decided. "Once we get a sense of the terrain we'll have a better idea of where they might have gone, and with some luck you'll pick something up."

"Lots of static," Glimmer frowned. "There's *something* sending a signal. I just haven't seen anything like it before."

"Might be that annoying buzzing," Catra growled. "The faster we find them, the faster we can get off this rock."

They started walking, into the trees and the blue-glowing vines that lined them.

"You're really giving Octavia first dibs on the Horde?" Glimmer asked, an eyebrow raised.

"Sure, why not?" Catra said with a shrug.

"I'd have thought someone like Lonnie would have been a better fit," Glimmer said.

"Yeah..." Catra muttered.

"So...? Glimmer prompted.

Catra sighed.

"Octavia is a thug. She'd run the thing like her own personal gang and it would fall apart in a month. Lonnie... Lonnie could actually

make it work."

"And we don't want that?" Glimmer asked.

"I don't know about you," Catra said. "But I'm not overly keen on a well functioning Horde without us calling the shots."

They walked in silence for a few steps.

"I see your point," Glimmer said, eventually.

"Also," Catra went on, "if we don't make it off this rock in three days, but still manage to stay alive, somehow, I don't really want anyone to get the idea that it will be smooth sailing in the Horde without us. It's not like Lonnie will hand over the throne without a fight, and that would buy us time. She'll even have a decent shot at winning, eventually."

"Good thinking," Glimmer agreed.

They walked in silence for awhile, taking in the strange sounds and sounds. Often they would hear the sound of something moving, without seeing anything.

Suddenly, without any warning, a large, millipede-looking creature came crashing out of the forest, straight towards them.

"Huh," Glimmer said. "I guess there really are monsters here."

"Seems like it," Catra said and jumped up in the air. She landed on top of the creature and fired her blaster straight between two segments. Meanwhile, Glimmer waited until it was almost upon her, unleashed a beam of light into its eyes and then teleported out. She emerged on the other side, only to see the creature wriggle back and forth on the ground, dying. Catra joined her a moment later.

"I've never seen anything like that in the whispering woods," Glimmer commented.

"Really? Plenty of weird bugs there," Catra said as they walked on.

"This was different. It was... slimier?"

"'Slimier'," Catra laughed. "Truly a fundamental difference."

"Shut up," Glimmer grinned.

They followed a small brook upstream.

"Looks like there's fish," Glimmer mused. "One could live here."

"Careful with those," Catra warned. "The razor-fins can have your arm off in the blink of an eye."

"You had way too much fun with ghost stories in the Horde," Glimmer commented.

"Kept us sharp," Catra grinned, and without further ado, she jumped into the brook, and a moment later had emerged with a fish speared on her claws.

"Would my queen fancy a bite?" she said with a little bow. "It's not sand snake, but perhaps it might be sufficient for a light lunch?"

"I would fancy that very much," Glimmer giggled. "Let's find a path up the ridge and I will build a fire."

It took them another hour to find a good enough clearing. They had walked uphill and now had a glorious view of parts of the island, with the dark canopies of the trees lit up by the blue glow of the vines.

There were no trace of people.

"Not bad," Glimmer commented as they ate the fish. "I didn't think I would miss the desert, but I could do with a camping trip with you now and then."

"Plenty of time for that once we rule the world, I'm sure," Catra leered.

Glimmer fiddled with her food a little while.

"Do... do you think that's what it's like for the others... a camping trip?"

Catra gave her a level look, but didn't say anything.

"Entrapta would like it here, right?" Glimmer went on, voice shaky despite her attempts to keep it bright. "All this tech lying around. Bow could explore it with her. He was such a fan of her when we were younger... Adora could fish for them. She'd like that... Swift Wind and Scorpia... I dunno..." her voice trailed off.

"You know we don't get to imagine happy endings for the people we banish, right?" Catra said with level voice.

"I know," Glimmer sighed. "I just... do you think there is any chance of them being alive? Any chance at all?"

"That's why we are here, isn't it?" Catra reminded her.

Glimmer did a little helpless gesture. "Either that or to properly bury them so we can move on."

"Yeah, I don't know if you noticed, but I don' have a perfect track record moving on from Adora," Catra said with an attempt to sound flippant, but what only came across as bitter.

"This time you have me," Glimmer said with a bit of a challenge in her voice.

"Yeah, I do," Catra hurriedly said.

They ate in silence for a little while.

"We keep going inland?" Catra asked eventually.

"I suppose..." Glimmer said and fiddled with her comm pad. "Either that or set a signal of our own. Let them come to us."

"I'd rather wait a little while with that, if that's OK with you," Catra said and glanced into the forest with a shudder. "I'm not sure we would like who'd come knocking."

"Prudent," Glimmer agreed. She glanced at a gathering of one-eyed, monkey-like creatures that had melted out of the forest edge, regarding them with interest. "What are those?"

"Probably pookas," Catra shuddered. "The way Shadow Weaver told it, they are among the more dangerous creatures here. Smarter than they look and hunt in pack."

"Well, if they're so smart, we better give them a reason to keep their distance," Glimmer said and held up a sparkly fist. Catra nodded and readied her blaster.

After a quick and bloody attack, the pookas held their distance.

They finished their meal and continued to walk uphill. A few times the rocky path was too steep even for Catra to climb, and Glimmer teleported them to the next ridge.

"You think they have a camp or something we could find?" Glimmer wondered.

"They probably move around to make it harder for the monsters to find them," Catra mused. "Adora always aced survival training. She knows how to stay hidden."

"Still, their main priority would be to get off the island, right?" Glimmer thought out loud. "They are not here enjoying nature. They want back."

"...and they do have a space ship," Catra followed her logic. "Why don't just they fly home?"

"Maybe it crashed?" Glimmer suggested.

"Like if Entrapta couldn't repair it," Catra said dismissively. "With all this junk, I assume she could build an entirely new space ship if she wanted to."

"Then why hasn't she?" Glimmer demanded. "In fact, between Bow and Entrapta, why haven't they just built a boat if the space ship is damaged beyond repair. It's not like they lack parts."

"I don't know," Catra sighed. "We're missing something."

They walked in silence a little while, thinking of potential scenarios for what they were missing, each more gruesome and guilt-inducing than the next.

"If they crashed we should be able to find the crash site, once we get high enough," Glimmer said. "That would give us a starting point."

"Fine by me," Catra growled and gave a vine a vicious slash with her claws. "This place is starting to get on my nerves."

They emerged a bit later in a clearing, high up on a hill. A quick teleport brought them to the top of a tree, giving them a splendid view of this segment of the island.

"What the fuck are these ugly, blue vines?" Catra snarled, slashing at one of the vines. They could see the blue dots all over the landscape.

"No idea," Glimmer said, "but it sure seems ingrained in the ecosystem."

"Well, I have no intention to be 'ingrained in the ecosystem'," Catra snarled, "so if we could find a lead..."

"There," Glimmer said, suddenly all focus. Catra abruptly closed her mouth.

Far away, on another ridge, they saw a burnt patch of forest, saw a long line of trees uprooted and rocks flung around. The line

ended with a large, burnt area.

"Think that's the crash site?" Catra asked with low voice.

"I think that's *a* crash site," Glimmer said with pedantic voice. "It remains to see if it's the one we're looking for."

She closed her eyes and took a deep breath.

She held out her hand.

"Let's go say hello," she said with forced cheer.

Catra gave her a concerned glance, but then she took her hand.

Glimmer transported them to Mara's crashed space ship.

- - -

"Not a trace?" Glimmer asked, some time later.

"Plenty of traces, but nothing fresh," Catra corrected her. "They've been here. Moved about."

"You sure it's them?" Glimmer asked.

Catra snorted.

"Like I wouldn't recognize Adora's foot prints. Scorpia's too for that matter. And unless they brought another horse, I'm sure those hoof prints come from that stupid sidekick of hers."

Glimmer gave her an almost scared look.

"...and?" she whispered.

"And another set of print," Catra said with comforting voice. Has to be Arrow Boy."

Glimmer breathed out.

"Then they survived the crash.

"Seems like it," Catra agreed.

They sat by the fire. Turned out, some of the bugs were not all that bad if you roasted them.

"But they are not here," Glimmer said, more or less to herself.

"You searched the wreck yourself," Catra said. "They haven't been here for at least a month."

"And the ship was pretty thoroughly wrecked," Glimmer mused. "That didn't just happen from the crash. It was sabotaged."

Catra raised an eyebrow.

"A traitor?"

"Or a goodbye gift from Shadow Weaver," Glimmer sighed. "Impossible to know unless we talk to them."

"Yeah..." Catra muttered.

"There were traces of other energies than the fire," Glimmer said with low voice. "Magic," she clarified when Catra raised an eyebrow."

"Adora brought the sword with her, right?" Catra said.

"Obviously," Glimmer said, "but I don't think it was She-Ra. Too many different energy sources woven together. To me it looks like formal spells rather than wild princess magic."

They looked into the fire for a while.

"Catra..." Glimmer said with low voice. "My father can't be alive, not after all this time... right?"

"I don't know," Catra gently said. "No one returns from Beast Island, that's the line we were fed... I always assumed no one

would stay alive more than a few days... but if your old man is anything like his daughter, he would have pulled it off."

"Great," Glimmer sighed. "More ghosts."

Catra said nothing, she just stared into the fire.

"We'll continue to search in the morning, right?" Glimmer said.

Catra didn't answer.

"What do you think we will find?" Glimmer said with low voice.

"Not much," Catra answered, somewhat detached. "A jungle like this would eat through a corpse in no time. We might find some gear, if we are lucky, before it's swallowed by the moss."

Glimmer shuddered.

"You really think they are dead?" she whispered.

"That was the point, wasn't it," Catra mutters. "Entrapta was in my way so I... got rid of her."

"Bow and Adora wanted to save her," Glimmer answered. "I forbid it."

"Yeah, I didn't give you much choice, did I?" Catra asked.

"I had a choice, Glimmer whispered. "I chose wrong."

Catra gave her a look.

"You chose me," she said, not without edge.

Glimmer gave her a guilty look.

"No... I mean, yes, I did, in the end, but that came later. At the time, when Scorpia told us about Entrapta I..."

Tears started to roll down her cheeks.

"I was so angry," she whispered. "So very angry."

"At Entrapta?" Catra said with low voice.

Glimmer nodded. She glanced at Catra.

"Because she left you," Catra said.

It wasn't a question.

"She left the princess alliance," Glimmer sobbed. "*My* alliance. *Me*."

"I read you," Catra muttered.

"What kind of monster leaves someone to die in a hole like this because she feels rejected," Glimmer wailed.

"The same kind of monster who sent her here in the first place, I'd imagine," Catra shot back.

Glimmer glanced at her.

"Sorry," she muttered after awhile.

Catra shrugged.

"What the fuck are *those* doing here?" Glimmer snarled, watching the eyes that lit up in the edge of the clearing.

"Looking for an easy meal," Catra growled.

They stood up.

"Seems like they need to learn we are not it," Glimmer said as her eyes started to glow.

She teleported out, and soon yelps and screams of pain were heard throughout the woods. Abruptly, the eyes went away.

When Glimmer teleported back she had blood on her hands.

"Got them?" Catra asked.

"Some of them," Glimmer shrugged. "I think the others got the message."

Catra looked at the closest tree with a calculating look.

"We better sleep up there tonight. Come join me, princess."

Without waiting for answers, she climbed up the tree trunk. Glimmer watched her for a moment, then she teleported up to join her.

It took them some time to fall asleep, curled into each other's arms like a ball of comfort in the midst of a hostile environment, listening to the other's breath, to the rustles of unseen horrors in the wood just beneath them and the never ending, droning signal of Beast Island.

- - -

They woke up next morning with blistering headaches and in foul mood. They munched a ration bar for breakfast as they kept walking inland. They walked slowly, often making detours to increase the area they covered, looking for tracks.

The entire time the signal droned louder and louder.

"They're watching us," Catra commented after awhile.

"Who?" Glimmer asked, her thoughts far away.

"Those stupid pookas," Catra answered. "They are careful, but they keep circling us.

"Should we make another example of them?" Glimmer asked, teeth showing.

Catra shrugged.

"So far they're keeping their distance. I'd rather we just find Adora and the others so we can get off this dump."

"What if they won't follow us?" Glimmer asked.

"What, you think they'd rather stay here?" Catra asked.

"Can't see why they'd want to follow a bunch of bad friends back home," Glimmer said in what was probably meant as sarcastic tone of voice.

"Not funny," Catra muttered.

"I suppose not," Glimmer sighed.

"I kinda hoped you'd do the talking once we find them," Catra said after a few moments.

"Me? why?" Glimmer scoffed.

"Because you're the one they ran away to," Catra reminded her.

"Not Entrapta," Glimmer shot back.

"Yeah, I don't think she wants to talk to me either," Catra sighed.

Glimmer giggled slightly.

"Something funny, Sparkles?" Catra said, voice somewhat sharper then perhaps intended.

"Just thinking, this is what it felt like when I rebuilt the princess alliance," Glimmer said. "The anxiety about whether they would follow me, the fear they wouldn't..."

"Well, they did so hooray for you," Catra muttered with sour voice.

"Eventually, thanks to you," Glimmer shrugged.

Catra gave her a level look without commenting.

"After we lost Entrapta the whole thing fell apart," Glimmer explained. "Everyone back to their own kingdom to sulk. If you hadn't attacked Brightmoon I doubt we'd have ever gotten back on track."

"Well, hooray for me," Catra muttered.

From the ground before them, a crab like monster more than a meter in diameter erupted and burst forth with pincers large as shovels aimed straight at their faces. Catra gave it an annoyed look, ducked to avoid the pincer and placed a throwing knife right in the soft spot by its eyes. A quick swipe with her claws severed the eye-stalks and the crab fell to the ground and started to trash around.

Glimmer just teleported to the opposite side of the monster and kept walking in even pace. After a moment Catra joined her, wiping the ichor of her claws on a leaf.

"Is that what we are doing now?" Catra wondered. "Rebuilding the princess alliance?"

Gimmer gave her a careful look.

"Does it seem like that?"

"A little, yeah," Catra said. "We got the ice brat (even if we lost her) and once you get the Pearl you'll free Mermista, and here we hope to pick up Scorpia, Entrapta and Adora..."

Glimmer sighed.

"Yeah, I thought so too, once. Lets bygones be bygones. Sorry for the whoopsidoodle, let's gather the old gang again for a rematch."

"But you don't think so any longer?"

Glimmer made a sour expression.

"Netossa and Spinnerella kinda put me out of that mindset."

"Bummer," Catra commented.

"Yeah..." Glimmer sighed. "I figured, once we beat Shadow Weaver we'd have time to patch things up, but..."

"But now we need the princesses to beat her," Catra finished the sentence for her. "Well, don't look at me. I don't have the best track record in recruiting princesses."

"I wouldn't say that," Glimmer smirked. "You totally snagged Entrapta and me."

"Didn't work out that hot," Catra muttered.

"You and me will work out, Catra," Glimmer said with low voice.

"Of course, Glimmer," Catra hurriedly said.

"And as for Adora and the others," Glimmer went on, "they can hate us as much as they want. All we need is for Mermista to stand down long enough for us to... hey, what's happened here?"

They had just crossed another ridge, and now stared down at an utterly devastated area in front of them. Trees were uprooted, rocks flung around, the undergrowth were gone and the soil black, as if it had been washed in acid.

"What the fuck?" Catra slowly asked.

They walked through the ruined landscape. It seemed completely devoid of life. Even the otherwise so ubiquitous stinging insects were nowhere to be seen.

In the centre was a huge crater, centred around a gauge in the rock, the covering soil completely gone.

"Glimmer," Catra said with low voice. "I've been in the receiving end of Adora being pissed with me enough to recognize what it looks like when She-Ra has let loose."

"Yes..." Glimmer said slowly. "But there's more than that." She held up a handful of the dead, black moss that covered a lot of the ground, outside the crater itself.

"Magic?" Catra said with low voice.

Glimmer nodded.

"Magic," she confirmed. "But not the sort they teach in Mystacor."

They looked over the desolate landscape. Nothing stirred. Nothing lived. The only sound was the signal.

"Shadow Weaver was here?" Catra silently asked.

"I don't know," Glimmer admitted. "I suppose nothing would have stopped her from going if she wanted to - she knows where the island is, and she has Mermista in her pocket. My dad would also fit the bill, I suppose, if he is alive. Casta says he was a really good sorcerer."

"That's what I heard too," Catra agreed.

"So what are we looking at here?" Glimmer thought out loud. "A little misunderstanding? An abduction? A full out fight?"

"Maybe your dad wanted the island for himself?" Catra mused.

"Well, too bad," Glimmer muttered. "And then what happened? Did they all just wander away?"

"Probably," Catra agreed. "After a showdown like that, you'd have put yourself on the map for every monster on the island. The smart thing would be to get away."

"There should be tracks, then," Glimmer decided. "See if you can find any, and I will see what I can do with the magic signature."

"Sure," Catra said. "Just keep an eye open. If someone had any thought of people like us coming, this would make an excellent

place for an ambush."

"We'd be so lucky," Glimmer muttered. "We'll have to find them ourselves."

Catra gave her a bleak smile, and they sat to work.

"Any luck?" Catra asked some time later to Glimmer, who sat crossed-legged in a magic circle, pink energy slowly pulsing outwards.

"Nope," Glimmer said and stood up, "but all the junk here messes up magic too, not only the communication signals. What about you?"

"Clear tracks going east," Catra promptly said.

"Great," Glimmer said and dismissed her circle. "So are we...?"

"...and really well hidden tracks going south," Catra finished.

Glimmer raised an eyebrow.

"Someone who really knows what they are doing," Catra clarified.

"Bow's pretty good in the outdoors," Glimmer suggested.

"I've tracked you three disasters for years," Catra snorted. "Unless he's been holding out on me all this time, this is someone way better than both him and Adora."

"Scorpia doesn't strike me as the type," Glimmer commented as she followed Catra's lead south.

"She's competent enough," Catra said, just a tad defensive, "but stealth isn't her best subject."

"More riddles," Glimmer sighed and massaged her temples.

"Hordak has sent people here to die for years," Catra mused. "Perhaps someone should have checked that they are really

dead."

"Seems like a bit of an oversight," Glimmer agreed.

They walked south. It was slow work. Catra often had to stop and double check the tracks, and more than once they had to double back when it turned out they had followed a false trail for the last half an hour. The air was hot and stifling. Insects were everywhere and the signal just didn't shut up.

"Fuck it," Catra snarled and kicked viciously at a tree.

"Lost it again?" Glimmer asked in a tone of voice that was way more snippy than it should be.

"Either that or they fooled us again," Catra said between gritted teeth.

"You know," Glimmer commented without looking at Catra, "all we know is that someone tried to hide this trail. We have no idea if they really walked this way. Maybe the east trail was the right one, after all."

"You're welcome to try it, princess," Catra snarled.

"Pass," Glimmer growled. "Just tell me where we go."

"Let's move on," Catra decided. "Let's see if we can pick up the trail further uphill. Otherwise we walk back to that place with the quicksand and see if they split off there."

"Oh goodie," Glimmer said with sarcastic voice. "My favourite place."

"I don't hear you having any better ideas," Catra hissed.

"Now who wants a princess trick?" Glimmer said with deceptively calm voice.

They looked at each other for a moment, body language tense.

"...fuck," Catra sighed and started walking. After a moment of hesitation, Glimmer followed.

"*Now* what?" Glimmer snarled as Catra held up a hand a short while later.

"Don't like the smell of those flowers," Catra said, pointing at dark, slimy tendrils hanging from the trees over the path ahead.

"Is there *anything* on this fucking island that isn't poisonousness," Glimmer snarled.

"Sure, the old trash just want to electrocute you," Catra shot back.

"So fucking glad to hear it," Glimmer said, and without further ado she released a ball of light that burnt a hole straight through the forest in front of her, completely annihilating the ugly flowers.

"Well, are we going?" she snarled.

"And how the fuck am I supposed to find any tracks now?" Catra shouted at the sight of the destroyed forest.

"It's not like you were finding them anyway," Glimmer snarled.

Catra stared at her for a moment, fangs barred. Then, with visible effort, she took a deep breath.

"OK, I've head enough of this shit." She sat down. "Let's camp here for the night."

"Fine by me," Glimmer growled.

They made a fire in sullen silence and sat down on opposite sides of it with a ration bar each, listening to their own thoughts and the signal that droned, louder than ever.

"She had the right idea," Catra muttered after awhile.

"Who?" Glimmer said with absent voice.

"Scorpia," Catra said. "I was such a shit to her. Good thing she got out."

"Yeah, for all good it did her, coming to me," Glimmer sighed.

"The way you tell it, she was better off there, even for a short while," Catra said, staring into the fire. "So was Adora... even Shadow Weaver for awhile."

"Thanks for reminding me," Glimmer growled.

"You get that, right?" Catra said, "they had to get away from *me*. Because I was *destroying* them. You should take the hint."

"Fuck you," Glimmer said. "If you even for one moment think of starting to push me away..."

Catra glared at her, and for moment it looked like she would argue, but then she just shrugged and returned her gaze to the fire.

"Whatever..." she muttered.

"Fuck you," Glimmer snarled. "You think you're dragging me down? *You* were the one doing better. *I'm* the one who dragged you back to the Fright Zone."

"I had unfinished business..." Catra muttered.

"The fuck you did," Glimmer snarled. "Shadow Weaver and Hordak had you trapped there all these years because *they* told you all you were good for was fighting *their* war. And the moment you finally got wise to their bullshit *I* repeated the lie. You *never* needed them. You never needed *me*."

"You're wrong about the last one," Catra said with low voice, not looking Glimmer in the eyes.

Glimmer was about to unleash another angry retort, but she hesitated at that.

"Catra..." she said.

"I'm a big girl, Sparkles," Catra said, voice somewhat detached. "I knew what I was in for. You're not the first girl with a mission I've fallen for, you know."

Glimmer watched in her silence for a moment, eyes full of tears.

"Well, maybe it would have been better if you hadn't," she whispered. "Fallen for me that is. Without me you could've..."

"Without you, I'd had killed myself," Catra said bluntly.

Glimmer blinked furiously a few times, but she said nothing.

"You think you're bad for me," Catra said, a shadow of a smirk on her lips, despite the overall gloom in her expression. "That's rich. I'm the one who sent Double Trouble to tear up your alliance. Nearly worked, too."

"I'm the one who turned your spy back against you," Glimmer answered, voice low. "Pretty much your last friend, and I had them lure you into a trap."

"Yeah," Catra sighed. "Well, I'm the one who kept targeting *your* friends. I knew how much it would hurt you."

"Well," Glimmer muttered. "I was the one who almost killed you, back when we met in the warehouse."

"I sure as hell did my best to kill you back," Catra hissed. "Together with half of the fucking woods."

"I flaunted Shadow Weaver like a trophy because I *knew* how it would make you feel," Glimmer hissed, teeth barred.

"I took your *mother*," Catra snarled.

"I stole *Adora* from you," Glimmer shouted.

They glared at each other, through the flames.

"...fuck," Catra muttered.

Her body language slumped. So did Glimmer's.

"It's not like I didn't deserve it," Catra went on. "All of it."

"So did I," Glimmer sighed. "Guess we're truly made for each other."

"I sure hope so," Catra sighed. "Not much else for us."

"Yeah..." Glimmer muttered.

They stared into the fire.

"What would you do different?" Glimmer asked after a little while.

"What, if I could chose again?" Catra asked.

"Yeah, like... pick one choice, make another one."

"Kill Shadow Weaver the moment I got picked up by the Horde," Catra said immediately. "I was just a little shit, but I'd probably managed it if I put my heart to it. I knew where they hid the knives."

"Yeah, that's a good one," Glimmer said, looking at her hands. "I should have done the same thing, the moment she got to Brightmoon."

"Thing is..." Catra sighed, "We like to think of it like that, like had we just made one thing right, been a bit smarter, a bit stronger, a bit better, it all would have worked out."

"Adora used to think like that all the time," Glimmer said with low voice.

"Yeah," Catra said. "Thing is though... there never is just one moment, is there? I could have killed Shadow Weaver plenty of times. I had her in a cell. I was set to send her *here*. I was *begging* for the chance of saving her life."

"I know," Glimmer sighed. "There were so many times I could have turned back, but I just kept leaning on her, kept giving her a bit more freedom, a bit more power."

"I could have followed Adora," Catra said, voice bitter. "I could have stood by Entrapta. I could have been less horrible to Scorpia..."

"I could have listened to Adora and Bow," Glimmer mumbled to herself, eyes blank. "I could have been there for Mermista when Salineas fell. I could have said a proper goodbye to mom..."

Catra gave her a guilty look.

"It never was 'just one thing'" she sighed. "It was us. Always us."

"Yeah," Glimmer agreed.

They looked into the fire.

"Should have been me being sent here," Catra said with a voice that was barely a whisper. "Not them."

"We're here now..." Glimmer said.

"Yeah," Catra muttered.

"No one leaves Beast Island..." Glimmer mumbled.

They sat in silence.

They listened to the signal.

Glimmer felt so tired.

What was even the point?

If they don't trust me, I don't trust them.

Some parting words.

"You know..." she said with low voice. "Maybe it wouldn't have been so bad... if we'd just stayed in the desert..."

Catra didn't answer.

"Catra?" Glimmer whispered.

Catra's eyes were closed and vines crawled over her still body.

Glimmer knew she should do something, clear the vines away, teleport them out of there, drown the signal with the sound of her rage, blow up anything threatening them.

But at the same time... it was so tempting to just let go.

Close her eyes.

Let the vines take her.

Never hurt anyone ever again.

She crawled over to Catra and took her hand.

"Sorry..." she whispered, not only to the unconscious woman next to her.

This was for the best.

At least she got to be with Catra.

She should have done this a long time ago, really. That would have saved so many people so much suffering.

The signal droned on and on.

Glimmer felt her eyelids getting heavy.

Catra's hand was so soft and warm.

Glimmer closed her eyes.

She only wished she had got to say a proper goodbye.

Chapter End Notes

Whatever I write, sooner or later I return to Beast Island.

This chapter contains quite a few callbacks to my earlier story "We won't die here", that in hindsight is the more idealistic of my main universe Glitra stories.

Rescue

Chapter Notes

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

But just as Glimmer closed her eyes, a vine just next to her was hit by an arrow.

Chapter End Notes

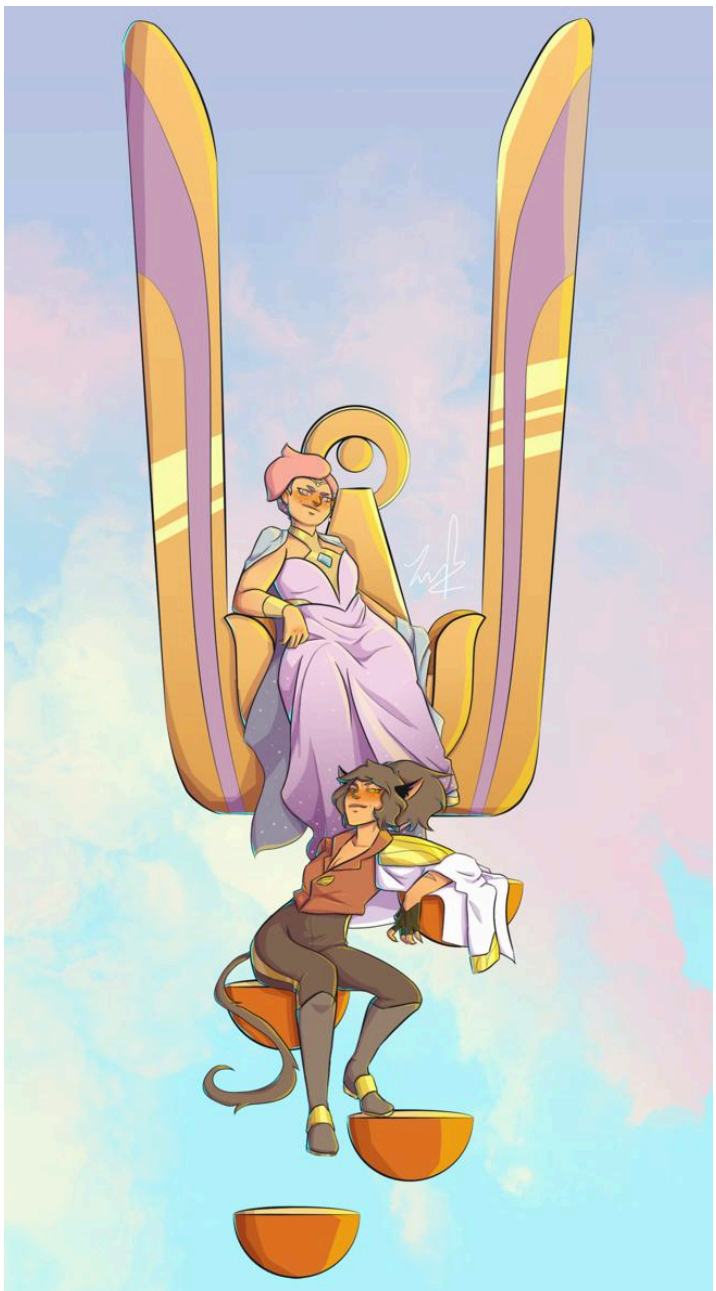
Aaaaaaand that wraps it up for this act. The next and final act - Queens of Brightmoon - will start updating in December. In the meanwhile, please enjoy this tumblr exclusive interview https://www.tumblr.com/baggebythesea/698788474075152384/tumblr-exclusive-interview-with-the-cast-of-queens

Act six - Queens of Brightmoon

Chapter Notes

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

Awesome art commissioned from Lorvikk.



They have crushed every barrier

They have defeated every enemy

They have taken every throne

Except one

A single spotlight light up the stage, focusing on two figures, laying motionless, holding each other, ensnared in vines. A second spotlight lit up, illuminating Double Trouble who stands by the side, with a rare serious expression on their face.

"How the mighty have fallen," they say with sombre voice. "Catra and Glimmer together did what neither of them could do on their own. They did what no one thought was possible."

Their expression hardens.

"They went from bitter enemies to the closest of lovers. From outcasts to taking over the largest army of Etheria. From bandits in a desert to Queens of the Horde."

They wink at the audience. "Title drop drop intended."

"But see now where all their power and all their conquest have brought them," they say, holding out a hand to the unmoving women. "Consumed by grief, guilt and the weight of their actions. Brought down by the very same fate they were willing to accept for those who trusted them, but who they cast aside."

They sigh theatrically.

"There are no more victories to be had for our queens. No more power. No more thumb on the scales of the world. Their final conquest, unfinished. Their final victory, denied. Their final opportunity, squandered. There is nothing left for them now, except guilt and grief and an unmarked grave..."

They smile.

"...unless, of course, they get some help from their friends."

The circle of light widens to show Bow and Scorpia standing next to Glimmer and Catra, watching them with concerned expressions.

No princess left behind

Chapter Notes

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"So..." Bow said with a little smile, containing quite a range of emotions. "You and Catra, huh?"

Queen Glimmer, the Shining Princess - conqueror of the Fright Zone, tyrant of the Horde and regular resident in the nightmares of three quarters of the power-holders of Etheria - blushed crimson red.

"It's not like we planned..." she begun, not meeting Bow's gaze (but not letting go of Catra's hand).

"No, no," Bow said quickly. "I totally see it. I'm just glad you found each other." He sighed. "It was a bad time for you to be alone"

They sat by a camp fire. Around them, the blue light of the vines played, but right here the fire was warm and friendly.

Turns out, cuddles from Bow and Scorpia was a pretty good antidote to the signal, at least for the time being.

Bow sighed.

"I'm glad you found *someone*. I just wished we could have..."

"Don't you *dare* blame yourself for this," Glimmer blurted out. "*I'm* the one you should blame."

"Glimmer..." Bow begun.

"Don't you *dare*," she repeated. She resolutely buried her face against his chest. Bow didn't press the issue. He just held her as

she cried.

"I can't believe you defeated Hordak," Scorpia said with wonder in her voice.

"Defeated is a bit too strong of a word," Catra muttered. "He was all set on blowing up the world, but then he decided to trap himself in that portal thingie instead and wait for Entrapta to drag him out again."

"That's so romantic," Entrapta said with enthusiastic voice.

Catra gave her an uncertain, almost scared look.

"Entrapta..." she begun.

"Hmmmm?" Entrapta said, looking up from a diagram she was drawing in the sand with a stick. Catra recognized a few of the symbols from her analysis of the portal.

"I... um..." Catra sighed, sometimes there really isn't an easy way to say something. "I'm sorry I sent you to die," she said, forcing the words out before she had second thoughts.

Entrapta looked at her in confusion for a few moment, clearly searching her memory.

She lit up.

"Oooooh, yeah. I remember. I didn't die, so it's OK," she said, maybe just a fraction of a second too fast.

She patted Catra on her hair with her hair.

Catra blinked at her.

"It... is?"

"Sure!" Entrapta said happily.

Catra gave her a look full of doubt.

"Glimmer," Bow said gently. "There is something we need to tell you."

Glimmer tensed.

"About Adora?" she whispered, dreading the answer. "Why she isn't here, with the rest of you."

"Yes, that too," Bow said. "But there is more." He hesitated. "I... don't really know how to tell you this..."

"Your dad's alive," Entrapta helpfully interjected. "He's been here on Beast Island all this time and he's really grumpy about a little friendly borrowing, for some reason. Other than that he's super nice, but he got evil and kidnapped Adora, so that's a a bit rude."

Glimmer stared at her, white in the face.

"That's one way to tell it, I suppose," Bow muttered.

"Daddy...?" Glimmer whispered.

"He..." Bow begun, obviously choosing his words with care. "He... it really was him, Glimmer. He just showed up from the woods, he helped us against the monsters. He knew the island and told us he would help us get Entrapta. But then... well, we started to suspect he lead us in circles, and then Entrapta found *us*"

"You had a spaaaaaace-ship," Entrapta helpfully added.

"Yeah, and when we started to repair it, Micah attacked us," Bow said with heavy voice. "Sorry, Glimmer. I don't know what came over him... well, after Huntara told us how Shadow Weaver possessed her, we kinda think that's what happened to him too."

He squeezed the trembling queen harder.

"He was... quite scary. I've seen you let loose, Glimmer, and he... yeah, it was like that. Adora and Swift Wind fought him to give the rest of us time to get away, and by the time we tried to circle

back they were gone. Huntara has been looking ever since, but there is no trace. As far as we can tell, they are not on the island anymore."

"Shadow Weaver took them," Glimmer said with flat voice. "And it's *my* fault."

"Sparkles..." Catra begun.

"You wanted to go here *months* ago," Glimmer snarled. "Instead I led us against the Horde just so I didn't have to face my fucking insecurities and now I've given Shadow Weaver exactly what she wants, *again*."

"Um, guys...?" Bow said.

"Fuck you, Sparkles," Catra interrupted him. "You think you get to sit there an wallow in self-pity? Adora was here in the first place because *I* sent Entrapta here to *die*."

"Still not dead!" Entrapta said cheerfully and raised her hand.

"Fuck *you*, Catra," Glimmer shouted back. "*I* was the one who..."

"*Guys*!" Scorpia said with so much urgency that both Glimmer and Catra lost their thread. They followed her claw as she pointed towards the edge of the clearing. From the undergrowth, vines crawled purposefully towards Catra and Glimmer."

"Oh..." Glimmer muttered.

"Yeah," Scorpia confirmed. "Those things are a bit pesky." She gently put Catra down and cut the vines with her claws. "A positive attitude helps though," she added with a sly little smile at Catra.

"Yeah, yeah," Catra muttered and held out her arms. With a little 'squee' Scorpia scoped her up again.

"What happened to the space ship?" Glimmer asked Bow. ('Spaaaaaace ship,' Entrapta mumbled happily for herself.)

"Don't know," he sighed. The moment we got close to Beast Island, everything went wrong at the same time. Cables burnt, crystals broke. There were even some hull damage."

"Shadow Weaver," Glimmer said, not as a question.

"Yeah, we figured pretty much the same thing," Bow said. Apparently she wanted us out of the way while you...?"

Glimmer sighed.

"I tried to open the Heart of Etheria," she said with tired, bitter voice. "I failed."

"Good thing too," Entrapta piped up. Catra tensed as Glimmer gave Entrapta an angry look.

"*What?*" she snarled.

"If you'd had succeed, the world would have exploded," Entrapta explained.

Glimmer blinked.

"...what?" she said, in a completely different tone of voice.

"I found a terminal," Entrapta enthusiastically explained. "It's amazing! The elemental princesses and the runestones are all control nodes for the Heart of Etheria, with She-Ra as the master key."

"...controlled?" Glimmer asked, voice weak.

"By Light Hope," Entrapta happily filled in. "And she wants to blow up the world! Kabooom." She thought a moment and then felt more emphasis was needed. "Kaboooooom!"

"You told me..." Glimmer whispered staring at Bow, completely white in her face. "You and Adora told me, and I didn't believe you."

He looked at her, expression somewhat distanced.

"I've had a lot of time to think," he said with low voice. "A lot of time to be angry..."

She stared at him, eyes wide.

"...and?" she whispered.

"And I'm glad you're alive," he said, voice full of compassion, but not entirely without a cold edge.

Huntara walked out of the gloom and unceremoniously sat down by the fire.

"The monsters keep the distance for now," she reported. "We shouldn't stick around too long, though."

"I still don't get what you're doing here," Catra said. "Didn't we last see you when we took over your shit-hole in the desert?"

"I came here to get Adora to slap some sense in the two of you," Huntara said and barred her teeth. "Turns out, though, getting off the island is a lot harder that getting on it."

"She had a ship," Bow explained, "but it got smashed by the rocks."

"I hoped that idiot pyromaniac pirate would get the hint and come pick us up, but apparently he had different priorities," Huntara growled.

"The love of his life is possessed by an evil witch," Glimmer said with dry voice. "That's the sort of thing that can keep you occupied."

"We wouldn't have made it without you," Scorpia said with heartfelt voice. "the pookas would have got us by now... or the king..."

"I would have been fine!" Entrapta piped. "I built me some *new* friends."

Scorpia and Catra gave her a guilty look, then glanced at each other.

"...hug?" Scorpia asked.

"Fine," Catra muttered.

"Squeee!" Entrapta said as Scorpia scoped her up as well, and all three of them hugged.

Emily beeped in a decidedly smug manner.

"Yeah, we should get going," Huntara said with no attempt to hide the scorn in her voice.

As they walked, Bow stepped up to Glimmer. It was such a well known movement, the two of them stepping in stride with each other as they had done countless of times before, that it took her a moment to realize just how momentous it was to finally be with Bow again.

And how much she missed it.

She gave him a scared look.

"Hi Glimmer," he said with low voice. "I missed you."

"Hi!" she squeaked, white in her face.

They walked in silence for a few moments.

"I..." Glimmer began at the same moment as Bow said "We..."

They gave each other an embarrassed look.

"Um..." Bow said, at the same moment as Glimmer said "Er..."

They stared helplessly at each other.

"No, no," Glimmer quickly said. "You say first."

Bow gave her a warm smile that didn't quite mask the pain underneath.

"I worried about you," he said with low voice.

"...me?" Glimmer whispered.

He gave her a rueful look.

"I just slipped away in the middle of the night. I left you with an impossible situation... with *Shadow Weaver* of all people... I'm so glad you're OK."

Glimmer closed her eyes and forced down a sob, her entire being tremble.

"I'm not OK, Bow," she whispered, not quite able to keep the tears from her eyes. With a face full of compassion he took a short step closer, arms slightly outstretched, completely instinctively preparing for a hug - just one of the millions of hugs they had shared before.

Glimmer crossed her arms tighter and took a small step to the side, eyes fixed on the path in front of her.

"Sorry..." Bow mumbled.

"Don't say that," she hissed. "Never say that."

They walked in uncomfortable silence for a few moments. A bit in front of them, Catra snarled and barred her teeth at Scorpia, who by the look of her body language tried to coax Catra into letting Scorpia carry her.

"The... signal?" Glimmer whispered without looking at Bow. "You hear it to?"

"Yeah..." he sighed and made a pained grimace. "Sometimes it's more manageable... sometimes its louder."

"It almost killed me and Catra," Glimmer mumbled, tears running down her cheeks. "And that was in just two days. How did you stand it? How did you survive all this time."

"It wasn't easy," he chuckled. "But there are tricks... ways to distract yourself or to clean your mind. Your dad and Entrapta helped a lot. They've been here for longer so they had more time to figure it out. Also..." he gave her a sly look. "...it helps to have something to keep you going."

"Don't..." she whispered, unable to keep the tears from keep flowing.

"That's how Adora did it," he sighed. "She never stopped thinking of you, of how we left you... of getting back so we could help you..."

"*Stop*..." Glimmer cried.

"I know why you..." Bow began and made that little hugging motion again.

"I *told* you why," Glimmer shouted at him, suddenly furious. "I told you, when you wanted me to get Entrapta." She nodded at the happily humming woman who walked in front of them, fiddling with an antenna as she did. Glimmer took a step closer to Bow, perhaps unaware of the light that formed around her hands. "I told you that my war, my kingdom, my queenhood were more important than *saving my friends*. That's why I never came for you. You get that right? I *abandoned you* to *die* in the worst hell hole on the planet because I chose my fucking war and my fucking ego over *you*."

The others had turned around to see what the commotion was about. Huntara had casually put her hand on her whip and looked at Bow with a raised eyebrow. He ignored her and looked Glimmer in the eyes.

"You know..." he said with calm voice, "Huntara told me a bit of how you took over the Crimson Waste... not only the violence but the diplomacy, how you played different factions... She said the Shining Princess was quite the accomplished liar."

"Wha...?" Glimmer begun, slightly derailed from Bow's lack of reaction to her outburst.

"You know you can't lie to me, don't you," Bow said and stepped forward with arms outstretched.

Glimmer stared at him like he had been made of fire, but then her body took over and by it's own accord and it flung her into his arms and hugged him like a life raft, crying, crying, crying like her heart would break.

"Let's take a break," Huntara said with dry voice.

Catra looked at Glimmer and Bow for a moment, then she looked up at Scorpia and rolled her eyes. With crossed arms she leaned against the Scorpian girl who, with a happy squee, picked her up and hugged her like a rag doll.

- - -

"You should hate me," Glimmer muttered, sitting in Bow's lap. "Why cant you just fucking hate me like a normal person."

"Seems to me there's quite enough Glimmer-hate going on already," he said - hands busy playing with her hair - and gently bopped his fingers against the side of her head.

"Not nearly enough," she muttered.

"Glimmer..." he chided. "I could never hate you." She opened her mouth to protest, but before she did, he went on. "I *am*, however just a tiny bit disappointed."

She tensed and looked up at him with the expression on someone facing her rightful execution by firing squad.

"You thought I wouldn't approve of you and Catra," he explained. "Shame on you, Glimmer. Of course I approve. I have seen the two of you together, I've always known there is chemistry... and more to the point, you both really, really needed someone. I'm so glad you found each other."

"But she's the enemy..." Glimmer weakly said.

"Not anymore," he happily said. "The best way to loose an enemy is to gain a friend.... or a wife in your case. But then again, you never do things by half, do you, Glim?"

"I suppose I don't..." she said, managing a shy chuckle.

"Besides," he went on. "She's not the first Horde soldier you found in the woods and chose to keep, is she?"

Glimmer paled at the mention of Adora.

"Adora should hate me," she mumbled.

"But she doesn't," Bow cheerfully said. "You know what she said when Huntara told us about you and Catra gunning for Hordak?"

"That she hated me?" Glimmer tried.

"That she knew you would win. The she was so proud of you for finally taking down Hordak. That she wanted to high five you for fulfilling her childhood dream and be with Catra on that throne."

"Well..." Glimmer mumbled, blushing slightly. "What can I say? Adora has good taste."

They laughed, and parts of Glimmer that had been frozen since forever melted as she could laugh together with Bow.

"This place..." Bow mused. "It has a knack to drag your fears out. You know what Adora always feared, more than anything else?"

"Of course I know," Glimmer muttered. "Just because I'm a bad friend" -Bow frowned to register a complaint about that characterisation- "doesn't mean there's anything wrong with my memory. Her greatest fear is to fail in her duties. And I pushed her into a situation when she couldn't avoid it."

"Light Hope did that," Bow sighed. "And Shadow Weaver before her. No, when it comes down to it, Adora always chooses what's right over her duty."

"Hurray for her," Glimmer muttered

"Her biggest fear on the other hand," Bow said with a glance at Catra, who was currently crying with her face hidden against Scorpia's breast, "was that either you or Catra would kill the other. She loves both of you so much, and the thought of you meeting in battle without her being there to step in between..." He chuckled. "When Huntara told us about the two of you being... an item... I've never seen her so relieved. She nagged Huntara for details for ever. She cheered so much about the two of you taking over that bandit camp. She was totally dreaming of joining up with you to become your knight."

"...and I left her here, where Shadow Weaver could get her..." Glimmer whispered, full of remorse.

Bow hugged her a little harder. On a sudden impulse, he opened the bag he had slung over his shoulder. He brought up a faded, blue blanket and gave to Glimmer.

"What's that?" she asked.

"Adora brought it from Brightmoon," he explained. "She said it brought her comfort."

"What? A random blanket?" she frowned. "She mostly kicked those away anyway."

"Not just any old blanket..." he hinted with a smile. Glimmer glanced quizzically and looked closer. The colour drained from her face.

"No..." she whispered.

"It totally is!" he said with a dorky smile that made it ache in her breast of longing.

"That's that blanket we got in Thaymor," she whispered. "When we wanted to disguise her just after we met."

"Her first party!" Bow proudly said.

"And she kept it, all these years...?" Glimmer went on, barely getting the sounds out.

"She sure did," Bow said. He gently took Glimmer's hand. "She said it reminded her that the moment she lost everything... everything she had believed in, everyone she had ever known..." - he glanced at Catra- "there were two people who believed in her."

"She brought it *here*," Glimmer said, completely aghast. "Even after I betrayed that friendship, after I tried to stop you from going?"

Bow caught her eyes.

"She never hated you Glimmer. Never ever. She was worried sick about you - we both were - and she blamed herself so hard for what happened, but..."

"It wasn't her *fault* Glimmer wailed, almost not daring to touch the blanket. "It was *mine*."

Bow squeezed her hand.

"What you actually *did* tell me when Scorpia told us about Entrapta," Bow said, suddenly serious, "was that you carried everyone's load. That you stood between the Horde and everyone else, and you wouldn't let them slip past you. Whatever it took."

"Well, fat lot of good that did," Glimmer muttered.

"You took down Hordak," Bow repeated. "And you kept control over the Horde. An army of that size suddenly leaderless..." he shuddered. "It wouldn't have been pretty."

"We *are* the Horde now," Glimmer wailed. "Me and Catra. I swore I would stop them and now..."

"And now you're in the perfect position to do just that," Bow firmly said.

"*You don't know,*" Glimmer cried. "You don't know what I'm doing. I'm a bully to the people who should be able to trust me and I enable scums and bandits and I play people and cities like game pieces and trade them like a fish monger and..." -her voice broke down and she started blubbering- "Casta was right... not to trust me... Seneschal... Perfuma... ...Mermista"

Bow's face hardened for a moment, but he didn't say anything. He just patiently held Glimmer as she cried.

"I trust you," he finally said when her tirade died down. "I know you're doing bad things, but I also know you will make it right in the end."

She looked up at him through the tears.

"You are an incurable idiot," she smiled at him.

"I'm the incurable idiot that trusts in you," he corrected her. "And I know you, and I've seen enough of Catra to know that there is *nothing* you can't do..." -he let his gaze sweep around the little glade- "...with the help from your friends. We're with you all the way, Glimmer. You don't have to do this alone."

And then Glimmer had to cry again.

- - -

"Well," Huntara said some time later. "Sun will be setting soon. Are we staying here for the night or what?"

Glimmer took a deep breath, and with slight regret let go of Bow enough to stand up.

"We are not staying another night on this island," she said. "We should have got here way sooner" -she gave a guilty look- "but we are here now and this time we're not leaving anyone behind."

"Actually," Entrapta piped. "I'm making progress on the space ship, so if you just go ahead I can stay behind to fix it."

Bow and Scorpia exchanged a worried look. Glimmer saw Catra tense. She motioned her wife to come closer, and together they sat down next to the princess of Dryl.

"Entrapta," Glimmer said gently. "We have both abandoned you..."

"Banished you..." Catra muttered.

"We're so sorry," Glimmer said.

"I'm sorry, Entrapta," Catra whispered.

"We've both thought you lost. We don't want to loose you again."

"I'm not..." Entrapta begun, but Glimmer interrupted her.

"Now we beg you to come back with us to the Fright Zone. We need your help."

"...help?" Entrapta asked, trying to keep up.

"So many bots that need repair..." Glimmer said, sitting down next to Entrapta.

"So many upgrades to be done..." Catra filled in, fiddling with Entrapta's hair. "We could really use that data communication node you always wanted to build."

"Hordak installed a crystal network around the Black Garnet," Glimmer said with a guilty glance at Scorpia. "I haven't even begun to understand how it works."

"He rebuilt the portal machine," Catra said with a shudder. "We need you to safely... contain it."

"And there is also another little project we could use your help on..." Glimmer said enigmatically, a glint in her eyes.

Entrapta looked at them temptation and wariness written all over her face in large letters.

"We're sorry, Entrapta," Glimmer sighed. "We... you deserved better."

"You deserved better than *bad friends*," Catra mumbled.

"We have not been the friends you deserve," Glimmer said. "But we will try to do better."

"...if you let us," Catra whispered.

Entrapta looked between them, uncertainly. Her hair fiddled absent-mindedly with a stick.

"...I can just stay here..." she mumbled.

"Entrapta," Glimmer asked, voice kind. "Do you remember what I asked you when we first met?"

"You asked me to turn off the murder bots," Entrapta promptly answered.

"I did," Glimmer admitted, not loosing a beat. "That was a bad call. This time I want you to build *more* murder bots for when we

take on Shadow Weaver."

Entrapta perked up.

"But more importantly, I asked you to join the princess alliance." She stood up and held out her hands. "Now I ask you again - please, Entrapta, we need you. Please join us in the *new* new princess alliance. The princess alliance 3.0. The princesses *and* the Horde. We are taking down Shadow Weaver and we need your help. She has stolen Mermista. She has stolen Perfuma. She has stolen Adora. We are getting them back. Because if there is one thing the princess alliance is all about..." -she took a deep breath- "...it's that no princess gets left behind. Including you. So please, come with us."

Entrapta looked at her with mouth open, mouth trembling.

"Also," Catra said, "Glimmer will totally use the Pearl to wrestle control of Mermista from Shadow Weaver and could use some help. So if you want to hack a princess, now's your time."

"Hack an elemental *princess*?" Entrapta breathed, stars in her eyes.

"Oh yes!" Glimmer smirked. "And that is just the start."

Entrapta took Glimmer's hand and allowed her to help her to her feet under Catra's relieved sigh and Bow's and Scorpia's jubilation.

"All right then," Glimmer said, becoming them to come closer. "Time for Shadow Weaver to learn that when we say no princess left behind *we mean it*. The princess alliance is back in business."

And she teleported them to the ship, almost giving Octavia a heart attack in the process.

Chapter End Notes

> I'm so glad to be back. It was about time we caught up with the Beast Island crew. Ten more chapters to go!

The princess of the sea

Chapter Notes

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

Warning: You remember last time there was a fight against Mermista? I'm doing my best to one-up it. Drowning, grievous wounds, mutilation... basically anything bad that can happen at sea. Be warned.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"So, what's the plan?" Bow asked. "We're going straight to Brightmoon?"

They all sat around the small table in the officer's meeting room aboard the ship, Glimmer and Catra in the captain's chair.

"No, at first we go to the Fright Zone to regroup," Glimmer said. We need to get our army in shape, and there are another little thing or two we need to sort out."

She glanced at Entrapta who had borrowed a welder's mask from the ship workshop and was now sitting in the corner with her hair wrapped around her.

"Fright Zone..." Scorpia mused, a slight shiver to her voice. "I thought I'd never see that place again."

"Same shithole," Catra muttered, and then glanced at Glimmer. "The new boss is cute, though."

"Yeah..." Scorpia agreed, looking at Catra with forlorn eyes.

"But if we're going to the Fright Zone, why are we moving South East?" Huntara objected.

"We have to believe that Shadow Weaver knows by now that we rescued you," Glimmer explained. "And if that's the case..."

"Mermista," Bow finished her sentence in sudden understanding.

"She almost got us last time," Glimmer said. "I'm not all that eager for a rematch. Not before we hold the cards."

"So were are we going?" Scorpia wondered.

"We're meeting up with some friends," Glimmer said with a sharp little smile.

At that moment, the engines stopped and Octavia's voice came from a loudspeaker.

"We're at the meeting place, boss. A small ship is anchored. It's not too late for me to torpedo them. Just say the word."

"No torpedoes," Glimmer said in the same tone of voice a parent says 'no snacks before dinner'. Prepare a dinghy for us instead.

"Can't you just teleport us?" Catra objected.

"I could," Glimmer said with serious voice, "but at this point I'd rather not announce where I am. Better keep Shadow Weaver guessing."

They assembled on deck, and Octavia rowed them to the other ship, a small, slender vessel of the kind favoured by smugglers.

"Well, who are we meeting... Oh, fuck you!" Huntara cried as Sea Hawk walked towards them on the deck.

"Thousands of apologies for the delay, my beautiful desert rose," he said with an obnoxious bow. "If it's any condolence, I had assumed you had perished on Beast Island."

"No thanks to you that I didn't," she spat, but the pirate ignored her as he spotted Bow boarding the ship.

"Bow, my boy," Sea Hawk thundered and slapped Bow on the back. "I knew you would survive Beast Island. Takes more than a demon possessed murder island to put a frown on that face. In fact, it reminds me of a rousing shanty..."

"No singing," Glimmer drily remarked.

"Go... good to see you again," Bow coughed, trying not to stare a the muscular pirate's bare torso.

"Whatever!" Mermista muttered and rolled her eyes as she strolled after Sea Hawk.

"Mermista?" Bow gasped.

"Double Trouble," Glimmer corrected with dry voice, and the grinning changeling took their own shape. "That disguise is in bad taste, even for you."

"Do not judge us so harshly my quarrelsome Queen," Sea Hawk cheerfully said and put a hand on Double Trouble's tail. "It's been many a night I've longed for my jewel of the ocean."

"...moving right along," Glimmer said and pretended not to see Double Trouble's smug smirk. "And more to the point. Do you have what I sent you for."

"Of course we do, my queen," Double Trouble drawled, and with a flourish presented what looked more like a bag for a bowling ball than anything else. "When have I *ever* allowed pleasure to interfere with my duty."

"Can I maim them?" Catra asked with annoyed voice.

"No maiming," Glimmer said absent-mindedly. She took the bag and glanced inside.

She took a deep breath and smiled in smug satisfaction.

"Come on, Entrapta," she said and nodded to the tech princess (who was currently in the process of taking a sonar detection array apart). "Time for us to get hacking."

"While you enjoy yourself, I'll continue to the Fright Zone," Octavia gruffed. "I'll make some noise as I go so the Salinean bitch finds me. Then I can properly 'entertain' her until you catch up."

Glimmer nodded solemnly and looked her in the eyes.

"Good luck, Octavia," Glimmer said with sincere voice. "And thanks. With Mermista following you, we should be able to blind-side her."

"Thanks, 'my queen'," Octavia leered.

"You're so brave," Bow said.

She turned and gave him a scornful look.

"If it helps to tell yourself that, sure."

"What did she mean with that?" Bow said with a frown as Octavia entered the dinghy and started to row back.

Glimmer stood with her back turned to him. She took two deep breaths before she answered.

"She means that she will try her very best to kill Mermista, and I'm giving her permission to," she said with flat voice.

Bow gave her a horrified look.

"Kill Mermista? But..."

"She won't succeed," Glimmer snarled. "But I can hardly use her as bait without giving her a chance to defend herself, can I?"

Bow stared at her, mouth moving in silence as he tried to work out a suitable answer.

"Welcome to her world," Double Trouble leered as they slid up next to Bow. "It's like this all the time."

"Still think I'm worthy of friendship, do you?" Glimmer said with only the flimsiest layer of sarcasm over the bitterness in her voice.

"I think you need more hugs," Bow answered, voice brimming with emotions.

"That's what she has the kitten for," Double Trouble leered.

"Catra needs more hugs too," Bow said with determined voice, which really was all the prompt Scorpia needed.

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"How is the spooky stuff coming along?" Catra gruffed some time later.

"We're getting there," Glimmer said, staring with a frown at a terminal hooked up to one of the many bundles of cables that emerged more or less spontaneously from the middle of the room, where Entrapta and Bow had set up an impromptu workshop. "We won't hook up the Pearl until we have to, not to tip off Shadow Weaver, but Entrapta has built a solid framework."

"Did you know that elemental princesses have their neural pathways rewritten in order to set up an interface to their runestone?" Entrapta happily said.

"Creepy, yet not surprising," Catra muttered and glanced at Glimmer.

"Mom always made a big point of me bonding with the Moonstone as early as I could," Glimmer mused.

"My moms always forbade me to go close to the Black Garnet," Scorpia mumbled.

"My mom let me do whatever I wanted," Entrapta contributed. "I programmed her that way."

Bow stared at them with tears in his eyes, but before he had time to say anything soppy, a little light next to the loudspeaker in the wall lit up.

"My apologises for interrupting, my productive princesses," Sea Hawk's voice sounded, but it would seem our cephalopodian co-worker has attracted the attention of my lovely coral blossom."

"Oh, and what makes you think that?" Catra asked.

"The sky just exploded," Sea Hawk said unperturbed, and the moment later the sound hit them - a long, continuous boom rolling like thunder over the ocean. They saw red flashes of light through the windows.

"Oh yeah," Entrapta said. "The sky-mines I designed. I thought they would be a great way of keeping flyers away."

"Turns out, they work great as a weapon of terror as well," Catra muttered without looking Entrapta in the eyes. "Did a number on the morale of the defenders in Salineas."

"But why does she use them now?" Entrapta frowned. "The splashy princess can't fly, right?"

"Octavia wants to give us our best chance to get close to Mermista without her detecting us," Glimmer said with determined voice. "So let's make good use of it." She moved closer to the loudspeaker. "Sea Hawk, sail in the direction of the mines, as silently as you can. Lights out."

"As you wish," Sea Hawk answered, and they felt the ship lurch as they changed direction.

Glimmer looked to Bow, who had set up a temporary workbench next to Entrapta.

"Not much time now until we have to engage. How is the lure coming along, Bow?"

"Here!" he said, handing Glimmer a hastily cobbled together contraption, a box surrounded by wires leading to an antenna.

"Thanks!" Glimmer answered and, as she took the box from him, momentarily brushed her fingers against his. She closed her eyes for a moment and took a deep breath.

"...thanks," she repeated with low voice. "for..."

She abruptly turned her back to him and looked at Entrapta.

"We will get as close as we can before you attempt to access the Pearl," she said with almost steady voice. "I'll hold her off you as long as I can, but you won't have much time, once Shadow Weaver realise what we are up to."

"Don't worry," Entrapta happily said. "The setup I used for the Black Garnet should be good for the initial iteration, and once I access the primary interface I can..."

"Good," Glimmer interrupted her. She turned to Catra.

"Once we engage... can you keep them safe?"

"I'll do my best, Sparkles," Catra said with low voice. "Can you keep *yourself* safe?"

"I beat her once before, remember?" Glimmer grinned with a confidence that didn't match her wavering voice.

"I remember how she almost killed you," Catra said with serious voice. "Don't be a hero, Glimmer."

"I won't," Glimmer promised. She slowly leaned forward and gave Catra a tender kiss.

"Shadow Weaver has had us fooled at every turn," she said, her voice growing sharper. "It's about time we take we strike a blow that truly hurts her."

"You know I'm all for that," Catra grinned back.

Glimmer took a deep breath and looked Catra in the eyes.

"I'll keep her off you until you can land the first punch. Make it count."

"You bet, Sparkles," Catra said.

They held each other's gaze for a moment, expressions tender beneath the worry. Then Glimmer climbed up the hatch.

"Just out of curiosity, Kitten," Double Trouble said with low voice to Catra, "what is plan B?"

"Plan A is not enough for you?" Catra drawled as she climbed up the ladder.

"Plan A is a mess of moving pieces and power crazy princesses," Double Trouble said with low voice. "I'm normally all for that, but given that we're in the middle of the ocean in a little toy boat, I would be much happier if I knew..."

Catra steered them a few steps away from the rest of the people who climbed up from the little cabin Entrapta used as a workshop.

"If Glimmer and Octavia can keep Mermista busy long enough to let Entrapta do her shit, we go with that," she said with low voice. "Otherwise, we high-tail it out of here."

"And if we can't?" Double Trouble asked, voice serious.

Catra looked them in the eyes.

"Then we kill her."

"The hot shot pirate might not be up for that plan," Double Trouble warned with a little nod at Sea Hawk who stood by the wheel, gazing forlornly into the darkness.

"Yeah, so I want you to stay close to him," Catra said with low voice. "Be prepared to take him out if we need to."

Double Trouble grinned at her.

"Glad you haven't lost your edge, Kitten."

"Same, Lizard," she said.

They looked each other in the eyes for another moment, then they walked separate directions. Catra walked up to Scorpia and the rest of the group, while Double Trouble joined Sea Hawk by the wheel.

Bow had placed himself in the stern, fiddling with his magic detector. Glimmer sat next to him, looking at the waves.

"That thing you said..." she begun with a tentative glance at him.

"Yeah?" he said, frowning as he tried adjusting the settings. His mannerisms were so familiar Glimmer could predict the exact moment when he scratched his head. She took a shivering breath.

"About me and Catra...."

He looked up and smirked at her.

"I told you I get it." He raised an eyebrow. "'Miaow'," he said with a suggestive little wink.

"Shut up...." Glimmer blushed. He gave her a good natured laugh and returned to his work.

They sat in silence for a few moments, Glimmer figeting with her hands while Bow concentrated on the detector.

"Do you think it ever could have been... us?" she blurted out before she would chicken out.

Bow closed his detector and look up at her. His smile was friendly as always, but there was something hard in his eyes she hadn't seen before.

He said nothing, he just looked at her.

"Like... if we... If I..." she tried, not really daring to meet his gaze and not really daring not to. "Could we have...?" her voice trailed off.

"What do *you* think?" he said, not unfriendly, but not without a certain challenge in his voice.

"I think that being without you for this long is the worst that's ever happened to me," Glimmer muttered.

"Yeah, being trapped on Beast Island this long wasn't a picknick either," he said with even voice, making the guilt churn in her breast.

"Bow..." she said, tears threatening to emerge at any time.

He sighed and took her hands.

"Glimmer... You're my best friend. You've always been, you'll always be."

She waited, steeling herself for the 'but'.

"When I first came to Brightmoon, when we first met..." he gently went on. "I couldn't believe it. I couldn't believe *you*. You were everything I ever dreamt of... *more* than everything I dreamt of. You were funny and brave and absolutely radiant."

"...but?" she asked, voice no more than a whisper.

He squeezed her hand a little.

"I loved princess Glimmer so much," he simply said.

"And Queen Glimmer?" she asked.

"I love her too," he said with a complicated smile. "I have missed her so much and I want nothing more than to be her friend."

"Nothing more?" she asked, voice trembling.

"What does Queen Glimmer want?" he asked, catching her gaze.

She looked into his big, brown, friendly eyes, for a moment, staring right into a whole world of whatifs and couldhavebeens.

"...to win," she muttered eventually and lowered her gaze. "To be the person who *can* win. To be the person who can do what needs to be done."

"To be the person you are with Catra," he finished for her.

"...yeah," she muttered.

"Then you will need friends by your side," he firmly said and opened his magic detector again.

She sighed.

Eventually they were joined by the others.

"Are you sure you can't see her?" Scorpia asked, voice trembling.

"Nothing," Bow frowned, staring at the magic detector. "I'm getting some background..." he glanced a bit sheepishly at Glimmer - "but even so, we should see her."

"If she's deep enough, the water will shield her," Glimmer said absent-mindedly.

"So when how do we know when its time to..." Scorpia begun, but was interrupted by Huntara who stood by the side of the ship, staring out into the darkness.

"*PORT*!" she hissed with strong voice. Sea Hawk immediately turned the wheel, and the people on the deck scrambled to stay upright as the ship leaned heavily in the wind.

Out of nowhere, an enormous wave rushed past, narrowly missing them.

"Has she spotted us?" Catra whispered.

"I don't think so," Bow frowned. "There seems to be magic waves emerging and dispersing at a wide area. I think she's looking for us."

"Then she knows we are not with Octavia," Glimmer said. She took a deep breath. "That means it's time to let her find what she's looking for." With a last, long look at the assembled people, Glimmer teleported away.

A moment later they saw a pink flash far away at starboard.

"The magic detectors are going wild!" Bow reported, eyes glued to his instrument. "The emulator seem to be working, as far as I can tell the Pearl's signature resonance is part of the signal."

"Think Shadow Weaver will fall for it?" Scorpia asked, voice trembling slightly.

"One way to find out," Catra said, voice hard. She turned to Sea Hawk.

"All right, main sails down. We go with the current until we can sneak up on the bitch. Keep the course steady. Glimmer will lead her to us."

"Right you are," Sea Hawk said, for once entirely without bravado.

They sat in silence, listening to the waves against the hull, the gentle creaking of the rig. From the distance they heard the thunder of Octavia's canons, and the occasional explosion they all had come to associate with Glimmer.

Everyone's eyes were glued to Bow's magic detector. Scattered burst of light lit up the screen occasionally to immediately disappear - just part of Etheria's usual background magic.

"How comes we can't see Glimmer on there?" Scorpia asked after a little while.

"She's probably out of range," Bow whispered with low voice. "Either that or she's too high up in the air for the detector to catch her."

"Or too deep," Catra shuddered. "Don't ask," she muttered as Bow gave her a quizzical look.

The sky was dark, just a few of the smaller moons out. The water was darker. The little ship felt like a tiny bubble of shelter in an endless, hostile universe.

Catra shivered. She really wished Glimmer was there.

Scorpia inched a bit closer to her.

"Catra..." she said with low voice. Catra tensed.

"Scorpia..." she said, dreading whatever would come best.

"After I left..." Scorpia went on, scanning Catra's expression for reactions. "Hordak cast you out?"

"Nothing so formal this time around," Catra muttered, not meeting Scorpia's gaze. "He found out about what I did to Entrapta, so he sent Octavia to kill me. When she fucked it up, he waited for me in the Fright Zone to finish the job himself. Can't really blame him," she sighed. "I'd have done the same."

"I left you..." Scorpia said, voice sad.

"I gave you no choice," Catra hissed. "You fucking know that. I'd only have dragged you down with me, or worse."

"I wish I could have brought you with me," Scorpia said, tears in her eyes. "Out of there."

"Story of my fucking life," Catra muttered. "Turns out, if you're a big enough bitch you make it really hard for people to save you."

"But you and Glimmer...?" Scorpia said, just a tiny sliver of hurt feelings in her voice."

"We make it work," Catra muttered. She looked up at Scorpia's compassionate face, her ears flat against her head. "Sorry," she sighed.

"You and me... we could have been something," Scorpia said, voice wistful.

"You can do better," Catra blurted out.

"I'm so glad to see you again," Scorpia said, voice cracking.

"You can be *better*, I said!" Catra snarled loud enough for Huntara to give her a hard look. Scorpia looked away with a hurt expression.

"I'm ready!" Entrapta happily said as she emerged from the cabin and immediately got hushed by Bow, Catra and Scorpia. She clamped a strand of hair over her mouth and nodded. She held up the pearl - still in it's bowling ball bag - connected to a veritable snake's nest of cables. "Just let me know when it's time to PRESS THE BUTTON!"

"Hssssh!" Catra hissed. "Not yet. Not until..." her voice trailed off as Bow's comm pad suddenly emitted a series of loud beeps.

"...wow," Entrapta said, eyes wide as she stared on the screen.

"...oh dear," Bow said.

"What?" Catra snarled.

"I think we just picked up Mermista on the magic detector," Bow said. "And it's... a lot of magic."

"IT'S OFF THE CHART!" Entrapta shrieked with exhilarated voice.

"What does that mean?" Scorpia asked.

"It means we don't hold back," Catra said with grim voice. "Prepare the bombs."

"Ay," Double Trouble grinned and opened a crate. Bow looked at them with large eyes.

Suddenly and without any warning, the gloom was replaced by a bright, pink light as Glimmer emerged out of nothing just in front of the ship.

"SHE'S COMING!" she yelled and disappeared again.

"STARBOARD!" Huntara yelled, and Sea Hawk frantically turned the wheel, forcing everyone to throw themselves to the deck as the boom to shoot over their heads. A huge pillar of water emerged from just before the ship and rained down over them.

"HOIST THE SAILS!" Sea Hawk bellowed, and Bow and Scorpia ran to the rigging and begun to franticly pull at the ropes.

"NOW, ENTRAPTA!" Catra yelled to the giggling tech princess who clung like a spider to the rigging with her hair at the same time as she tinkered with the devices connected to the Pearl.

At the same time, Glimmer emerged in the air a few meters behind the ship. She fell towards the water for a few moments, and then teleported again just before she hit the surface. Another pillar of water hurled itself upwards the moment after Glimmer disappeared.

"PORT!" Huntara yelled, and Sea Hawk turned the wheel again, causing Scorpia and Bow to drop their rope as they crashed to the deck.

"EMILY!" Scorpia yelled in panic. The bot rolled back and forth like a steel ball on deck - uncomfortably close to falling off. She blipped a few times, and then grabbed the rope the Scorpion princess had dropped.

"You're the best!" Scorpia breathed in relief as she and the bot started to pull in unison. Bow, meanwhile, had released a rope grappling hook arrow into the rigging and was now climbing upwards, trying his best to avoid to swing down into the water as the ship caught the wind and leaned in a dangerous angle against the surface."

Another pillar of water emerged, this time just where the ship would have been had Sea Hawk not changed course. They felt the little craft lurch heavily and water rained down.

"Sails... hoisted?" Scorpia cried as she and Emily fasted the rope.

"Excellent, my muscular mate," Sea Hawk bellowed. "Then we can cease the pleasure cruising and do some *sailing*."

"Wait, didn't we already...?" Scorpia frowned, and then she shrieked and grabbed on to the mast as the deck suddenly became nearly horizontal as Sea Hawk steered right into the wind.

"Well done, my love," Sea Hawk laughed with a maniac grin as another pillar of water emerged just behind the ship. "But you'll have to be a lot faster to catch... well *done*!" He abruptly turned. The boom shot out as the sail caught the wind and the ship hurled forward like a torpedo, just narrowly getting out of the whirlpool that formed around it.

"Where is she?" Huntara yelled, staring unblinkingly at the water surface.

"Um.... just behind us, I think," Bow yelled, frantically making adjustments to his comm pad. "It's hard to get a ping, but..."

"Bombs away!" Catra snarled and, together with Huntara, dropped several of the sinking bombs off the side of the ship.

"Are you sure..." Scorpia begun with worried voice, and then shrieked in fear as the ship was lifted by a gigantic wave.

"Sails down!" Sea Hawk bellowed and abruptly turned again, trying to navigate a safe path down from the wave.

"EMILY!" Scorpia yelled and managed to catch the rolling bot the moment before she went over the railing.

"SAILS!" Sea Hawk cried again, fear in his voice as the boom shot back and forth, threatening to crush the mast.

"Got it," Catra cried and threw a knife, neatly severing the rope that held the sails.

"Hey!" Entrapta cried indignantly as the sails collapsed over her, still stuck clinging to the rigging with her hair like a spider.

Behind them, the sea boiled as the sinking bombs reached the appropriate depth and detonated.

"Elegantly done, my ferocious feline," Sea Hawk congratulated. "But I fear we now need to get the sails up again. Bow, my boy. Take the wheel, hold her steady!" and with a nod to Bow who scrambled to take the wheel, Sea Hawk walked across the deck and jumped up the mast as easily as if he had navigated a staircase rather than a little boat being tossed around by the waves.

As Sea Hawk quickly begun splicing two ends of rope, Glimmer blinked into existence, glowing like a little star.

"I try to lure her out, but she stays in deep water," she panted. "How is the Pearl coming along, Entrapta?"

"Doing great," Entrapta said from her spot in the rigging. "Five more minutes!"

"I'm not sure we have that many minutes," Huntara said with a grim look at the boiling ocean.

"Right..." Glimmer said and took a deep breath. "Right..." She walked over to the crate and scooped up a handful of bombs.

"Sparkles...?" Catra said.

"Don't worry, I'll be fine," Glimmer hurriedly said. "Um... just know that I loved you."

"GLIMMER!" Catra protested, as Glimmer winked out of existence. A moment later a pink flash of light was seen under the ship, followed by a muffled explosion.

"Is she...?" Bow begun, white in the face as he struggled to keep the ship steady. The moment after, however, Glimmer - emerged in a pink force field shot up like a rubber ball from below the surface just next to the ship. After her, Mermista hurled, carried by an enormous pillar of water.

Mermista snarled in fury. Her eyes were completely black and shadows painted her veins dark. She had lost a lot of weight since they last saw her. First one's writing covered her skin.

"Come back you insufferable brat," she shouted with Shadow Weaver's voice.

"Catch me if you can," Glimmer mocked and let herself fall towards the surface.

"My lovely ocean flower!" Sea Hawk cried. He tossed the spliced rope to Scorpia. "There, that should hold. Hoist the sails!"

"Almost..." Entrapta muttered, typing at a terminal with both hands and hair.

Glimmer had almost reached the ocean surface when she prepared to teleport again. But this time Mermista was ready for her, and a strong water jet knocked the wind of her. Before anyone had time to react, Mermista had grabbed her and held her hard.

"Give. Me. My. *Runestone*." Mermista shrieked.

"Sure," Glimmer smirked between desperate gulps for air. "Here."

She tossed Mermista the little contraption Bow had put together.

"What is the meaning of...?" Mermista begun.

"SHOWTIME!" Entrapta shrieked.

With her hair she tore up the Pearl - surrounded by a snake's nest of cables - from the bag and pressed a final button on her comm pad. A thick beam of light emerged and latched on to Mermista.

Mermista screamed in agony. Light and shadows tore through her body, battling for dominance.

"Don't let her get away!" Glimmer panted. She tried to teleport again, but the shadows that tore from Mermista disrupted her magic field. She cried in fear as they plunged towards the ocean surface when the water pillar that carried them dissolved.

"I've got you!" Bow cried and hit Mermista with a net arrow.

"Pull her in!" Catra snarled and helped Bow tug in the rope. Glimmer teleported back to the ship, sinking down on all fours as she - shining like a star - retched out bile, glitter and sea water.

"Hehehehehehe!" Entrapta laughed and scrambled down the rigging, heads down like a monkey.

"You're not getting away this time, princess," Catra snarled as Scorpia rushed forward to help hold the wildly trashing Mermista down.

"You spoiled *brat*," Shadow Weaver hissed through Mermista's mouth with utter hatred in her voice.

"Yeah, yeah," Catra muttered. "Work quicker!" she cried at Entrapta who leaned over Mermista with the shining Pearl in both

hands.

Mermista struggled in vain as the light from the runestone washed over her. They saw how the shadows were pushed further and further back. Suddenly, Mermista gave Entrapta a sly look, and abruptly her eyes turned brown again.

"The Horde took your kingdom," Shadow Weaver's voice echoed from out of nowhere. "The traitor princess tries to take your runestone."

"Get off me, traitor!" Mermista cried, voice full of hatred and fear, and headbutted Entrapta with a force enough to make her fall backwards with a little 'eeek'. Abruptly, the light from the Pearl died out.

"Glimmer!" Mermista frantically cried, her eyes landing on the still brightly glowing princess on the deck. "I'll..."

The the Shadows returned to her eyes.

"...kill every last one of you!" Shadow Weaver finished the sentence.

"GRAB SOMETHING!" Sea Hawk bellowed, too late as an enormous wave washed over the deck, carrying several of them overboard.

"Catra!" Glimmer cried, and quickly teleported to where her wife and Scorpia were still struggling with the net. She teleported them back to the ship, only to groan in disappointment as she saw that the net was empty.

A grappling hook arrow hit the mast, and a moment later, Bow swung on board, carrying Entrapta who was still clutching the Pearl.

"We're OK," he panted.

"Where's Double Trouble!" Glimmer gasped, quickly looking around.

"Right here, my queen," Double Trouble said with strained voice from the cabin, where they firmly had shut the door.

"What now?" Huntara asked grimly, staring into the storm.

"Now you drown," Mermista said, entirely shrouded in Shadows as she rose in front of the ship, carried by an enormous wave.

"Glimmer?" Catra said, carefully eyeing the mermaid princess that towered over them.

"Just... give me a minute..." Glimmer gasped, desperately trying to breath as magic poured out of her.

"*Glimmer*!" Catra cried as the wave crashed down towards them.

Suddenly, the sound of canons tore through the air. From the darkness, the Horde Destroyer forced itself, full speed ahead, right into the wave. Mermista abruptly spun around.

"First time in my life I'm happy to see Octavia," Catra muttered as Sea Hawk managed to slip past the bulk of the wave and manoeuvrer to get the Horde Destroyer between themselves and the enraged mermaid.

"It's leaking!" Double Trouble said as they bolted up from the cabin, the door smashed. "Is it supposed to be leaking?"

"Don't mind the leak," Sea Hawk cried with panic in the voice. "The mast is breaking! Reef the sails!"

"Wait, is 'reef' up or down?" Scorpia asked. "Only, when we went through that lesson of Force Captain orient..."

"Leave the sails up or we'll be dead in the waters!" Catra snarled.

"And then just dead," Glimmer grimly filled in. "How fast can you get the Pearl up and running again?" she asked Entrapta who was rubbing her bleeding nose with her hair at the same time as she tried to replace the cables around the Pearl.

"Just a few minutes," Entrapta muttered, glaring at a destroyed cable.

"TURN HER AROUND!" Huntara cried from the stern. She had grabbed a harpoon and had her eyes were firmly fixed on Mermista.

"What!" Bow cried. "You can't..."

"The tech princess had her shot," Huntara growled as Sea Hawk turned the wheel around.

"Do as she says!" Glimmer snarled between gritted teeth, forcing herself to stop throwing up.

"I'd love to, most radiant princess," Sea Hawk cried, fighting with the wheel with all his might, "but the mast can't take the strain."

"I've got it," Scorpia cried and - feet firmly planted in the deck - held the mast with both arms.

"She can't hold against the wind," Sea Hawk objected.

"The fucking princess of Arachnida will hold until the rest of this piece of shit is turned to *matches*," Glimmer snarled.

"Did I mention the leak?" Double Trouble babbled. "Because it actually is a rather *substantial* leak..."

Octavia's canons boomed again, but it was clear that the Destroyer was fighting a loosing battle against the maelstrom Mermista had formed around it.

"Glimmer!" Bow cried. "The magic detector is going wild. I think she's..."

"Shadow Weaver is forcing her to take in more magic from the Heart than a princess can bear," Glimmer snarled. "We end this *now*."

Grabbing the wheel herself, she fought with all her might to turn the ship around. After a moment of hesitation, Sea Hawk helped her.

The boom shot over their head as the sails suddenly caught the wind from the other direction. Scorpia screamed from pain and effort as the mast bulged, but she held it. The little ship shot forward the way they had come, the deck almost vertical.

"NOW!" Glimmer cried as they were upon the surprised mermaid, and Huntara - standing in the stern - hurled a harpoon straight at Mermista. It caught her in the flank and she cried in pain and surprise, the Shadows in her eyes momentarily lapsing.

"CIRCLE THE SHIP! DRAG HER IN!" Glimmer snarled as Huntara heaved in the rope attached to the harpoon. Mermista screamed in pain as the barbs of the harpoon dug into her scales and the flesh underneath it.

For a moment it almost looked like they got her.

But then something dark and slimy emerged from the depth, and with a lash like from a whip tore the rope from Huntara's hands. Mermista, once again free, formed another wave as the little ship rushed forth over the ocean.

"You should have seen the one that got away," Double Trouble tittered with a voice that bordered on hysteria. "Also, the cabin is half full of water. I think I should mention that since normally the *inside* of the ship is where water *isn't* supposed to be."

"Shut up!" Catra snapped at them. "Keep her steady," she snarled at Sea Hawk. "We need to keep the distance until we're ready to take the next shot."

"Glimmer?" Bow gently asked, sliding down by her side. "Are you OK?"

"...oh no," Glimmer whispered, white in her face, still staring at Huntara who was grimly preparing another harpoon.

"Glimmer, what's going on?" Bow asked, fear written all over his face.

As for an answer, thick wines of sea-weed boiled from the dark water and started to engulf the ship.

"...not one princess..." Glimmer said, eyes large with horror.

"Hello, Glimmer," Perfuma said as she emerged from the ocean, carried by an enormous lily-pad, hair clinging around her - wet and slimy. "Did you miss me?"

Shadows boiled and churned around her. Her her veins almost entirely black against her too pale skin.

"...two princesses," Glimmer finished.

"Perfuma?" Bow whispered, staring in horror.

"Perfuma?" Scorpia gasped, struggling with all her might to keep the mast together.

"But you have a plan, right?" Bow said hopefully.

Glimmer stared at nothing, fear and fatigue written in her face.

"*Right*?" Bow croaked as the seaweed reached them and attempted to snare their legs. The entire hull was engulfed now and the boards started to creek dangerously loud.

"...right..." Glimmer whispered, tearing her eyes away from the shadows in Perfuma's eyes.

"Right," she repeated with a deep breath. "Sea Hawk?"

"On it, my lovely lamprey," He cheerfully said and whacked at a barrel with the axe he carried. Two mighty blows and it spilled open, a light, oily liquid spreading over deck.

"No, no, fucking *no*!" Catra cried, but Sea Hawk had already lit a torch and tossed it at the barrel.

"Scorpia! Let go!" Glimmer shouted. "Everyone, to Entrapta!"

As everyone scrambled to get away from the flames and huddled together by the tech princess, Glimmer teleported up in the mast. Without Scorpia stabilizing it, it creaked dangerously. Glimmer emerged by the top and heaved with all her might.

"Don't think you can..." Perfuma begun, but then Glimmer managed to break the mast, and in a cloud of splinters and loose rigging, it crashed down towards the bewitched Flower Princess.

"We'll get you later," Glimmer muttered and teleported down to her friends and - in the last second before the ship turned into a huge fireball - teleported them out to the Horde destroyer.

They all landed on the deck of the Horde destroyer. Bow and Scorpia hugged each other in fear. Huntara jumped to her feet, harpoon ready. Sea Hawk patted at his burning moustache, an enormous grin on his face. Double Trouble rapidly shifted colours, eyes turning in every direction. Emily beeped frantically, while Entrapta just gave her surroundings a quick look and then went back to trying to reconnect cables to the Pearl.

"Did Perfuma...?" Bow asked with trembling voice, staring at the burning wreck of their ship.

"She's fine," Glimmer whispered with the kind of voice where you really, really want to believe what you're saying. "The Heart protects her." She sank down to the deck, utterly spent.

"Two princesses," Catra said with flat voice.

"Seems like it," Glimmer answered with voice almost inaudible.

"And we're down one ship," Catra pressed on.

"'was sinking anyway," Glimmer mumbled, fighting to stay awake.

"We're taking a beating here, Sparkles," Catra said urgently. "We need to get the hell out of here."

"Can't outrun them," Glimmer said, voice barely more than a whisper. "Can't take them both at once... need to... separate them... take on Mermista on her own."

"How do we do that," Catra cried.

"You always ran rings around us," Glimmer mumbled. "You figure it out."

And with that, she closed her eyes.

"Thanks a ton, Glimmer!" Catra hissed.

"Is she OK?" Bow asked, white in his face.

"She's not dead," Catra countered. "And as long as we manage to get away from the princesses she'll probably stay that way."

"What do we do, Boss?" Octavia asked with strained voice, having joined the group.

Catra looked around and realized that every pair of eyes were on her.

Shit.

What *would* they do?

"We need to delay the flower princess," she said. "If Entrapta gets five minutes with the mermaid, she should be able to kick out Shadow Weaver. But as long as we dodge seaweed we won't have five minutes."

"I'm currently staying ahead of them, but it won't last," Octavia reported.

"Catra?" Scorpia asked with low voice. "What *do* we do?"

"Turn around," Catra said with determined voice.

"Boss...?" Octavia said.

"We've going about this the wrong way," Catra said, gaining more confidence as she spoke. "We've tried to figure out ways to take out Mermista. Princesses are annoyingly stubborn. Trust me, I know. But Mermista is not calling the shots. Shadow Weaver is."

"So how does that help us?" Huntara grumbled.

"We give her what she wants," Catra smirked.

- - -

Back in her throne room in Brightmoon, Shadow Weaver stared intently into her mirrors. As expected, Micah's brat had found the most vexing way of defying her, but at least it had taken a toll on her own resources. She had burnt one of her ships, she was still far from land and Shadow Weaver knew that Glimmer's magical reserves must be almost depleted by now.

She briefly allowed her consciousness to touch that of the Plumerian princess, currently resting in an air bubble deep under the surface. She had suffered some damage from the fire, but not more than that she could remain functional after some time of recuperation. Shadow Weaver instead shifted her consciousness to the oh so useful Salinean princess. She followed the Horde Destroyer, preparing for the next attack. She had entertained the notion of keeping some of the Beast Island prisoners alive for potential use, but with that infernal Dryl princess tinkering with the Pearl she was not inclined to prolong this farce longer than she had to.

Better just drown them all, grab Micah's daughter and the Salinean runestone and be done with it.

Just as she was about to have Mermista form another whirlpool, the ship turned around. Shadow Weaver's eyes narrowed as she saw the annoying archer stand in the stern, frantically waving a white flag.

Oh, to be young and naive again.

A moment later, the ship's engines stopped. They rolled with the waves, waiting for Mermista to catch up.

Shadow Weaver had the princess circle the ship, but she couldn't find an obvious trap. She carefully swam closer and couldn't help but smile at what she saw.

"Let me *go*," the tied up Catra snarled, ineffectively trying to swipe with her claws at the Crimson Waste thug who held her by the scruff of the neck.

"We give up!" the archer cried the moment Mermista rose over the railing. "You'll have the Pearl back." He waved with a bag. Shadow Weaver could feel the power radiate from it. "Just let us all go."

"She'll never let you go," Catra cried. "You have to fight her or she'll drown you all."

"Shut up!" Huntara grumped and increased the strength of her grip. To her great delight, Shadow Weaver saw Catra's eyes fill with fear and impotent rage.

"You have come to see the futility in opposing me, then," she said through Mermista's mouth, arms crossed.

"Please!" the archer pleaded. "All we want is for everyone to survive this. We'll do whatever you say."

Shadow Weaver shifted her gaze at Micah's daughter, unconscious on the deck.

"Really, is that what she wants you to do as well?"

"You have to let her go as well," the archer quickly said.

"DON'T DO IT!" Catra cried, voice full of panic.

"I said, shut up," Huntara gruffed and - to Shadow Weavers great satisfaction - tossed Catra into the railing. She sank down, unconscious.

"I must say I'm impressed," Shadow Weaver said and let Mermista step into the boat. "Finally recognizing the futility of following that unworthy a creature..." She took the bag from the trembling archer and opened it with a triumphant smile - which soured immediately as she saw the decoy emitter inside it.

"Unworthy or not, I'm not the one stupid enough to fall for the same trick twice," Catra -now notably not tied up- hissed by her ear. "*GET HER*!"

"INFERNAL BRAT!" Shadow Weaver cried, but then they were all over her. She managed to toss Catra backwards, into the archer, but then Huntara was over her, and the Scorpion princess. She desperately tried to summon a wave but the Salinean princess seemed distracted, only able to focus on the idiotic pirate who stood over her with an axe, babbling something or the other about 'power of love'.

"Why don't you look your beloved in the eyes as you strike her down," Shadow Weaver snarled through Mermista's mouth, and as Sea Hawk hesitated, the shadows in her eyes suddenly lifted, and it was the real Mermista staring back at him, hurt and afraid.

"Mermista..." Sea Hawk whispered.

"What are you doing, you fucking idiot?" Mermista yelled with panic in her voice and wrestled the axe from him. "Just fucking

put me down before she makes me *drown* you." With both hands she grabbed the axe and brought it down upon her own tail. She screamed in agony as the shadows welled back into her eyes.

"I love you so much," Sea Hawk whispered and punched her in the face.

"Do you think she'll be interested in a threesome?" Double Trouble asked Catra with clear admiration in his voice.

"I think she'll feed you to the fishes," Catra yelled as she desperately tried to hold the slippery mermaid down.

"Do you mean that in the literal sense or as a metaphor?" Double Trouble asked, "because..."

"Be useful instead!" Catra cried.

"When have I ever been anything else?" Double Trouble drawled and took Sea Hawk's guise.

"Hey, toots," they said and bent down towards the struggling Mermista. "If you're a good girl and break free of the mind control, me and your boy toy here have a *special* celebration in mind for you."

For a moment Mermista glared at them in utter loathing, eyes completely free of shadows. Then she shadows slammed back and Mermista regained her attempts to reach for the water surrounding them.

"I think I got through to her," Double Trouble said happily.

"Entrapta! Any time now would be great!" Catra cried, ignoring the changeling.

With a shriek of excitement, Entrapta flipped a huge switch.

The Pearl flared up, and tendrils of light emerged from it, trailing over the ship. Catra felt a tickling energy as one of the tendrils -

for a moment - stuck to her face. Then one of them found the still struggling mermaid and latched on to her.

Mermista screamed as a stable tentacle of light emerging from the pearl, held her like some sort of gigantic lamprey. She struggled in vain as Entrapta furiously hammered at a keyboard with both hands and hair.

"BOW! CHECK THE CAPACITORS!" she cried as Bow franticly tried to keep the smoking contraption they had built together.

"HOLD HER DOWN!" Catra snarled to Sea Hawk and Scorpia who struggled to keep their grips on the wildly trashing princess of the sea. Shadows tried to emerge from every opening in her head like a trapped animal, but the light pushed it back.

"The flower princess is coming back!" Huntara warned.

"Fire grenades," Catra yelled. "Force her under the surface again. Without the mermaid, she'll never catch up with us." Octavia nodded and gave the order. Soon, the explosions boomed over the ocean as a shower of burning phosphor rained from the sky.

"Found it!" ENTRAPTA cried, her hair boiling with excitement. "I found the neural node Shadow Weaver uses for interference."

"Great," Scorpia said, "Um, if it's not too much trouble, do you think you could..."

"Aaaaaaaand, access denied!" Entrapta happily said, and with a last press of a button, the Pearl became completely inert.

After all the excitement, the silence was almost deafening.

Mermista opened her eyes, free from shadows, and looked around without really seeing until she identified Sea Hawk.

"You fucking idiot," she whispered, and fell unconscious in his arms.

"Now what?" Octavia asked Catra who slumped down next to Glimmer.

"Get us to the Fright Zone," Catra mumbled. "We should have smooth sailing from now on."

She snuggled closer to Glimmer, close enough to feel the smell of sea water in her hair, and closed her eyes. She barely registered when Scorpia lifted them and carried them both to their cabin.

- - -

In Brightmoon, Shadow Weaver stared with hatred at her smashed mirror.

It was long overdue she finally put an end to that annoying cat.

Chapter End Notes

Shut up, ships totally work like that.

The kids are all right

Chapter Notes

> Warning: A bit of violence and endangerment of ~~kids~~ bratty teenagers out on an adventure of their own.
>
> Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Come *on*," Jack urged, glancing at the path behind them with eyes full of fear.

"Just... just get out of here," Frosta mumbled, holding a hand pressed against a nasty wound in her side. "I'll..."

"You'll shut up and keep walking," Jack hissed, adrenaline fuelling them to more or less hold Frosta upright. "They will not get you, and I will not leave you, so you better keep it up."

"I... can hide," Frosta whispered, white in her face. "You go... get help."

"I'm *not* leaving you," Jack hissed.

"Sssssh!" Frosta interrupted, eyes wide as the sound of a drone rapidly came closer. They both threw themselves to the ground, Jack wincing as they saw Frosta's pained grimace.

They pressed themselves against a tree trunk, barely daring to breath as the drone whirled by.

Frosta took a long, shivering breath and closed her eyes for a long moment, leaning heavily at Jack as she did.

Jack wrapped their arms round her and held her, burrowing their face in her hair. Despite all they had been through, she still

smelled good. Must be some kind of weird princess power, Jack reflected.

"How bad is it," they asked as the moment passed.

"Bad," Frosta admitted through clenched teeth. "That bot almost got me."

"Can't you just magic it better?" Jack whispered in desperation.

"Why don't you just kiss it and make it better, Jackrabbit," Frosta said with a grin that managed to be snarky despite the obvious pain.

"Not funny, Snowball," Jack said, and despite their best effort their voice cracked and tears formed in their eyes.

"Sorry," Frosta urgently said. "I'll heal, eventually, but right now I don't think magic is a good idea."

"I hate those magic detectors," Jack spat.

"Can't let us magical princesses have it too easy, eh?" Frosta teased, trying to hide her pain and fear under bravado.

"You think anything of these past weeks have been *easy*?" Jack snorted, not able to resist a smile.

"I don't know," Frosta said flippantly and gave Jack a somewhat impish look. "There've been some bright spots..."

Jack blushed.

They looked tenderly at each other for a few moments, but then their smiles faltered.

"Jack," Frosta said, voice serious. "We need to get out of here. I can't run. You might have to..."

"So then we don't run," Jack interrupted her. "We sneak."

"I can't sneak all the way to the Fright Zone," Frosta said with an apologetic expression.

"That's quitters talk," Jack said, slightly more aggressive than needed. "And besides, you don't have to sneak to the Fright Zone." They nodded at a hollow just a few steps away. "All you have to do is sneak there. You can do that."

"OK...?" Frosta hesitantly answered. "And then?"

"And then you sneak to the threes over there," Jack said with a nod at the dark treeline.

"...and then?"

"And then we carry on like that. Short steps, keep your heads down, eventually we'll be out of the woods and then we'll... think of something."

"Just like that, huh?" Frosta said with a tender smile.

"Just like that," Jack confirmed. "I get this is news to you, but this is how you do it in the Waste. You don't have to worry about every single thing that can go wrong. You just focus on surviving the moment."

"What do you do after that?" Frosta said.

She already knew the answer, but she liked hearing Jack say it.

"Then you survive the *next* moment, of course," Jack said. "Now enough jabbering. Get sneaking, princess."

They gave Frosta a little smack on the butt.

"Watch it, ruffian," Frosta laughed.

They gave each other a tender look, that quickly turned more somber.

"We'll get through this," Jack said.

"Of course we will," Frosta answered.

They squeezed each other's hand.

Then they sneaked over to the hollow.

- - -

"Make sure they don't slip past us," the mercenary said to the rest of the unit. "That ice bitch is slippery."

She waited hopefully to see i someone would pick up on the pun, but to her great irritation, no one did.

"Nothing on the detectors," one of the team mates reported after having consulted her comm pad for a little while.

"They haven't got far," the squad leader gruffed. "Laying low somewhere, more likely."

"So, we flush them out?" another asked with a blood thirsty grin.

"We flush them out," the squad leader confirmed, taking a grenade from her bag and pulling the sprint. She tossed it into the dark lump of trees in front of them, where it caused a satisfying amount of bang.

"Nothing," the mercenary with the comm pad sad after a few moments.

"We'll find, them," the squad leader gruffed. Fan out. Send the bots first. The moment the ice princess makes her move, I want all guns on her. Don't give her time to get sneaky.

"You are good at hunting princesses," another member of the group said admiringly.

"The Horde taught us well," the squad leader modestly said. This was met with a raised eyebrow.

"Yeah, I meant to ask you about that. The Horde seems to do pretty well these days. So why did you leave?"

"With the fucking Shining Princess calling the shots?" the squad leader snorted. "Fuck that. I'd rather go freelance."

"Well, we're doing pretty well so far," the mercenary grinned. "Lots of little towns free for the taking these days."

"And that's small fry, compared to what the Shadow Queen in Brightmoon will pay us for the ice bitch," the squad leader grinned. She tossed another grenade into the undergrowth.

"Shouldn't we try to take her alive?" the other mercenary objected.

"These are just flash-bangs," the squad leader said dismissively. Unless I get a direct hit, they won't do too much damage. Besides, the Shadow Queen can do wonders with just a scrap, or so I've heard."

"Those kids must really have pissed off the Shadow Queen for them to be worth all this effort," the mercenary mused. "What did they even steal from her?"

The squad leader stopped dead in her tracks and gave the mercenary a long look.

"That's a very dangerous questions," she said with even voice.

The mercenary held up her hands in a pacifying gesture.

"Hey, just curious."

"Well, maybe if you ask just a few less questions you'll live a whole lot longer," the squad leader said, voice menacing.

"Got it, boss. Sorry," the mercenary quickly said.

"Hey!" the mercenary with the comm pad said. "I just lost the signal from the drone."

"Where did you last see it?" the squad leader quickly asked.

"South end of the grove," the mercenary answered. The squad leader grinned in return.

"Two of you check it out. Three of you, with me. The rest of you, keep the perimeter around the grove.

"We aren't going to the drone?" The mercenary asked as she hurried after the squad leader, to the north of the grove.

"Nah, this whole thing has a stink of diversion. They want us to look to the south while they sneak away."

"But you think you know where they're going?"

"There are some caves to the north of here. Perfect place to loose pursuers."

"Or to trap themselves like rats,"

"Exactly," the squad leader grinned and checked her blaster.

- - -

"I think the coast is clear," Jack whispered. "We have to run the last bit to the caves, but.."

"I'm right behind you," Frosta whispered, not quite managing to keep the pain out of her voice.

Jack gave her a look full of pity, but couldn't think of anything to say.

"OK, here goes..." Jack muttered, and sprinted across the clearing, silent as a shadow. They dove in cover next to a huge rock and turned around to see how Frosta was doing.

Frosta was limping as quickly as she could, but it was clear that every step was hurting. Halfway through the clearing, she had to stop and take a few deep breaths. Jack stared at her full of anxiety, willing their pursuers to stay away for just a few more moments.

After what felt like an eternity, Frosta steeled herself and started limping forward again. Jack held her breath as Frosta came closer to the hideout. Five steps left... four... three...

A high pitched whirling of a bot could be heard, just on the other side of the treeline, and Jack spun around. Through the trees crashed a round horde-bot, aiming a blaster right at Jack. Biting off a scream, they jumped to the side and tried to dodge the bot. With mechanical precession it moved closer, preventing Jack from getting around it. Jack took a quick step back, but doing so, their foot got stuck in a root, and they fell backwards.

"Jack!" Frosta cried, and before the bot had time to move, it was smashed by a huge block of ice.

"Frosta!" Jack gasped, staring at the ice princess.

"I... I couldn't let it..." Frosta cried. "I couldn't let you..."

"It will be OK," Jack said, desperately looking around. They could hear voices shouting, feet running.

"I'm so sorry," Frosta sobbed. "I'm so..."

"It will be..." Jack took a deep breath and tried to put on a brave face despite the sinking feeling in their stomach. "Frosta..." they said with gentle voice. "I will protect you."

"What are you...?" Frosta gasped, her face a rigid mask of fear.

"You'll have to hide," Jack whispered. They nodded at a hollow just by the boulder. "Crawl down there. Stay put. Don't use magic, whatever you do. I'll... I'll be back for you, OK."

"Jack!" Frosta protested. "You can't..."

But Jack had already weaved the spell, and with a last apologetic look at Frosta, they covered her in a blanket of invisibility.

"They shouldn't find you as long as you lay still. Just get under the rock as quick as you can!" they whispered. "I... I love you."

And without giving Frosta time to answer, they cast another spell, mixing ice magic with some of the tricks they had learned from Glimmer, and thus having made themselves a beacon for the magic detectors, they ran as fast as they could towards the caves, hoping beyond hope that they would be able to lure all of their pursuers away from their wounded princess.

- - -

"They're in the cave," the mercenary reported, eyes glued to the magic detectors.

"Really?" The leader said with suspicious voice. "First nothing, and then a giant flare like that. You're *sure* there's no magic registering anywhere else.

"There's some background magic from the woods, but..."

"Yeah, I don't trust it," The squad leader interrupted. "I'll take some of the gals to root out the princess or her little companion from the caves. The rest of you keep watch out here."

"Got it, boss," the mercenary said.

The squad leader walked up to the caves and lit her Horde-issue flash-light. A bright beam of light penetrated the shadows.

"You keep watch over the entrance," she told one of the mercenaries. "The rest of you, with me. Let's net that bitch."

"The magic signal has stopped," one of them reported, watching the detector.

"Yeah, they're trying to be sneaky," the squad leader leered. She took a tighter grip of the blaster and peered into the darkness. Her grin broadened as she heard a faint rattle of stones. "This way!"

They slowly crawled forward in one of the tunnels. They made no rush, making sure to check every nook and cranny.

"I think it closes up," the mercenary with the comm pad reported. "If she's in here, she'll be near."

"Well then," the squad leader smirked and drew her knife. "Come out, come out, little bitch. Preferably we'll take you alive, but we're willing to compromise. Give up now or I'll stab you an extra time just for good measure."

She took another few step forwards, every sense alert, ready to strike at any moment. Suddenly, she saw a blue and a yellow eye that looked at her with malice from the darkness.

"Found her!" the squad leader cried!

She lashed out with her knife, but it didn't connect. A clawed hand caught her wrist.

"Hands off my *kid*," Catra snarled.

- - -

Jack stared with beating heart as Catra killed the last of the mercenaries.

"Catra," they sobbed and flung themselves in Catra's arms. "Frosta is..."

"Safe," Catra finished the sentence for them.

From outside the cave, a bright, pink light suddenly emerged from nowhere. It lasted for several seconds, and as the light died down, so did the sound of screaming.

"I can't say the same thing for the rest of them, though," Catra said grimly and held Jack close.

- - -

"I'm so sorry for running away," Jack said with a nervous glance at Catra. They sat by a camp fire a bit from the cave, sharing some ration bars. Catra had just finished patching up Frosta's wounds.

"Don't worry about it," Glimmer said.

"Yeah, like we haven't done the same thing," Catra shrugged.

Jack and Frosta breathed out.

"It's not like we made the Fright Zone the nicest of place..." Glimmer said, a bit apologetic.

"We were total bitches," Catra clarified. "We'll try to do better."

"We talked it through," Glimmer explained. "we kept the collateral damage to a minimum," she quickly said when she saw Jack's look.

"We got our people from Beast Island," Catra grinned. "Well... most of them, at least."

"And we freed Mermista!" Glimmer said, glancing at Frosta.

"So we should have free way to Brightmoon now," Catra went on. "Lonnie is doing the preparations."

"But then there were some reports of some of our units picking up ice powers on the magic detector," Glimmer smiled at Frosta, "and we thought that... we obviously respect your wish to be on your own, but we... um..." she glanced at Catra.

"We thought we.. maybe should just drop by," Catra said a bit lamely. "You know, see how you were doing, see if you needed

something."

"Good thing you did," Jack said with heartfelt voice, and Glimmer and Catra breathed out.

"Who were those jerks anyway?" Catra asked.

"Mercenaries," Jack said with a shudder. "Working for Shadow Weaver."

"Why were they after you?" Glimmer asked.

Jack and Frosta gave each other a quick look. Frosta nodded.

"We were going to tell you," Jack said a bit sheepishly. "We just wanted to... make sure first."

"Make sure of what?" Glimmer asked.

"We... found something," Jack carefully said. "In Entrapta's notes."

Frosta looked Glimmer in the eyes. "It's about the Heart of Etheria."

Glimmer tensed, but she forced herself to remain calm.

"Go on..." she said.

"It was just a little doodle in the margin of one of her notes," Jack explained. Apparently she tried to figure out just how the connection between the princesses and the runestones worked, and stumbled upon the Heart."

"Yeah," Frosta filled in. "And she calculated what would happen if we all hooked up at the same time, and... well, apparently she figured the whole thing would blow up."

"The *whole* thing," Jack said gravely, doing a small gesture at the surrounding landscape.

"So then it seemed like Entrapta tried to figure out exactly *why* the First Ones had been so sloppy," Frosta went on, "and if we read her notes right, they hadn't been sloppy at all. It had been by design."

"So that lead us back to that margin doodle," Jack said.

"What did it say?" Catra said, intrigued.

"'Weapon'," Jack said bluntly.

Catra nodded.

"So, given how we all tried to hook up with the Heart back in Brightmoon," Frosta said with a glance at Glimmer, "you can see how I got a bit... nervous."

Catra and Glimmer glanced at each other.

"Yeah, you got it right," Glimmer said. "Entrapta told us the same thing when we finally... met up with her on Beast Island."

"Also, well done reading her notes," Catra filled in with a proud grin at Jack. "Not an easy task."

"I suppose my only question is," Glimmer said with the air of someone who knows the answer but doesn't like it "why you didn't come to us with it. Why bail?"

Frosta looked at her hands.

"Well..."

"It was my idea," Jack quickly lied. "I wanted to..."

"*I* wanted to talk to Netossa and Spinnerella first," Frosta firmly said.

"I see," Glimmer said - blissfully unaware how much like her mother she sounded. "So you *did* know how to contact them after all."

"Yeah," Frosta sighed. "Sorry."

"It's OK," Glimmer said gently. "I get it. I haven't really given them a lot of reasons to trust me."

"Mermista spoked them real bad," Frosta explained. "And... um... whatever you told them when they visited you in the Crimson waste... they just wanted to be sure..."

"...that Shadow Weaver hadn't got to me," Glimmer sighed. "Yeah, I get it."

Catra gently put a hand on her arm.

"Anyway, they suggested we talk to your aunt," Frosta quickly said, "and she had an idea where we could learn more, so we went to find an old ruin in the east part of the Whispering Woods."

"But apparently Shadow Weaver had the same idea," Jack filled in. We came to the ruins at the same time as her goons."

"We totally fooled them, though," Frosta proudly interrupted.

"You should have seen Frosta," Jack said, voice getting more energetic. "She was *amazing*. There was this hallway full of traps..."

"And then there was a giant monster-machine-thing," Frosta eagerly said. "Jack was *so cool*. They climbed up over the monster and..."

"And then there was some kind of guardian system which was all 'who goes there' and Frosta was all 'The fucking Queen of Snow! Who's asking?' and it let us through, just like that."

"If you got it, you flaunt it," Frosta grinned.

"And then we found, um..." Jack said, searching for the right words.

"Some kind of... hideout?" Frosta said.

"There apparently was this... splinter group," Jack said. "They called themselves 'Friends of Mara'."

"*That* Mara," Frosta said, looking Glimmer in the eyes. A wind ruffled her hair.

"They thought the First Ones would use the Heart for something bad," Jack said.

"*Really* bad," Frosta said for emphasis.

"So it seems like they built a back door to the Heart," Jack explained.

"Seems like there's some kind of... off switch to it. Hidden under Mystacor of all places!" Frosta said.

"And Shadow Weaver *really* wanted their manual," Jack said, holding up a data crystal.

"So we grabbed it and ran," Frosta finished. "We were trying to get back to you, but, well..." she nodded at one of the burnt out bots that had gotten in the way of Glimmer.

"Good thing we found you, then," Catra said.

"And good thing you looked into this," Glimmer said, carefully accepting the data crystal from the relieved Jack. "I have no idea what Shadow Weaver wanted to do with this, but I have an idea how it could be useful for..."

"Glimmer," Frosta said with serious voice and put her hand on Glimmer's just as she took the crystal. "Will you open the Heart of Etheria?"

Glimmer hesitated. Frosta waited in silence.

"Frosta," Glimmer said at last. "I really hope it won't come to that, but..."

"Um, Glimmer...?" Catra said, ears suddenly perking up.

Glimmer quickly stood up, looking around in every direction. Wordlessly, Catra pointed upwards. Glimmer followed her finger the same moment as what looked like a miniature tornado crashed towards them through the woods, tearing up trees and rocks as it went.

"FUCK!" Catra cried and jumped to her feet. Jack jumped forward, covering Frosta with their body as well as they could. Glimmer summoned her black, crystalline staff and firmly planted herself in the path of the tornado.

Then, just as quickly as it had came, the tornado disappeared and in it's place stood Spinnerella and Netossa, crouched and ready for a fight, power glowing around their hands.

"Glimmer!" Netossa cried, voice full of fear and anger. "Step away from them."

"Netossa," Glimmer said, voice even. "Spinnerella."

"We mean it, Glimmer," Spinnerella said. "If you don't let Frosta and Jack go, we will..."

"They were on their way to *us*, air-head," Catra hissed. "So why don't you dial it down with the attitude."

"It's true," Frosta piped. "We were on our way back to the Fright Zone."

"You can't trust her," Netossa cried, webs forming around her hands. "We talked about..."

"Glimmer!" Spinnerella repeated, voice high pitched with fear as she took in Frosta's obviously wounded appearance. "If you don't step away from them *right now*, I will..."

"If you think..." Catra begun, fangs barred, but Glimmer interrupted her by placing a gentle hand on her shoulder.

She looked Spinnerella in the eyes.

"Glimmer..." Frosta begun, voice full of fear.

"Of course," Glimmer said, voice calm. She handed the data crystal to Jack and then took five quick steps backwards, steering Catra with her.

Frosta and Jack were suddenly alone, standing between Netossa and Spinnerella on one side, and Catra and Glimmer on the other.

Glimmer tossed her staff to the ground. She calmly sat down in an unthreatening manner. After a moment of hesitation, Catra followed her lead.

"Let's talk," Glimmer said. "We have a lot to catch up on."

Chapter End Notes

Frosta and Jack are so fun to write

Princess alliance 3.0

Chapter Notes

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It took some work and some shouting. There were some false starts. But some time later, Netossa and Spinnerella sat by the camp fire together with Glimmer and Catra, and a nervous looking Jack and Frosta between them.

"It's not that we don't think you're sincere..." Spinnerella said.

"But you can't be sure how much influence Shadow Weaver have over me," Glimmer finished her sentence. "I understand."

"You have to admit that a lot of your actions seem to have played right into her hands," Netossa said, not without heat.

"Now wait just a..." Catra begun, but Glimmer put a hand on her arm.

"Shadow Weaver rules Brightmoon, because of me. She has access to the Moonstone because of me. I'm aware of how that must look from the outside."

"And unlike *some* people, she's doing something about it," Catra spat.

"We *did* free Mermista," Glimmer pointed out, voice mild but with an edge to it.

"So you claim," Netossa said with suspicious voice.

"So I claim," Glimmer echoed.

"Guys," Frosta protested. "I already told you, Glimmer is one of the good guys. "She saved me too."

"That could have been because..." Netossa begun.

"Even good people can do bad things," Spinnerella said with careful voice.

"Let's cut to the chase," Glimmer said and sat up straighter. Netossa's body language shifted ever so slightly, making her more prepared to jump to her feet if needed. "You can't be certain that I'm not influenced by Shadow Weaver, playing some sort of long game," Glimmer went on in business-like tone and looked Spinnerella in the eyes. "There is no proof I can produce. There is no logic I can appeal to that would conclusively prove me guilty or influence free. When it comes down to it... if that's the case, I might not even be aware of it myself."

"I for one can tell you that *if* that witch had been calling the shots, you wouldn't have married me," Catra growled.

"Fine, that's one point in my favour," Glimmer smiled. Her face grew serious again and she looked at Netossa. "But in the end you only have two choices. Join me or keep your distance. Whichever you chose, I will do my best to be accommodating, to make sure that if you suspect me of wrongdoings, we can talk before we resort to... other tactics."

"We tried that," Spinnerella said, voice more sharp now. "In the Crimson Waste. Castaspella came to you in the Frightzone. The leaders of the free cities pleaded with you on their bare knees. Did you do 'your best' with them too?"

"No, I didn't," Glimmer said and looked down at her hands. "But now I try to do *better*."

"And just how sure are you that *you* are the one trying to do 'better'?" Spinnerella said.

"I have made mistakes," Glimmer said. "Plenty of them. But they are all *mine*. No one coerced me, no one is playing trick with my mind." She smiled a vry smile. "Believe me - if Shadow Weaver

were influencing me, I wouldn't feel this shit about every decision I've made."

"Give that you're right, what do you intend to do about *your* mistakes?" Netossa asked.

"What I should have done from the start," Glimmer sighed. She put a hand on Frosta's shoulder. "I will listen to my friends" -she glanced at Netossa and Spinnerella- "...if they still are willing to talk to me."

"And what if you don't like what you hear?" Spinnerella asked, and the hurt behind her words was undeniable.

Glimmer hesitated, clearly choosing her words. She looked Spinnerella in the eyes. "I am not my mother," she said. "I do not play by her rules any longer, and we will win this war *our* way" - she put a hand on Catra's leg - "not hers."

"You have made *that* abundantly clear," Netossa said with a pointed look at the Horde logo on Glimmer's chest.

"I know you're not Angella," Spinnerella said. "And if you worry about not being taken seriously..."

"Look at me," Glimmer said, not quite able to keep a little shiver from her voice. "*Really* look at me and tell me what you see."

"I see a brat badly in need of a trashing," Netossa immediately quipped.

"She's not wrong," Catra said out in empty air. Glimmer ignored them, instead keeping her eyes locked on Spinnerella.

"Glimmer..." Spinnerella begun with low voice.

"I think you still see the precious little baby girl who was left fatherless when your best friend died," Glimmer said with low voice. "I think you see the girl left motherless when her own recklessness got her mother killed - thereby destroying the last

remnants of the old princess alliance - *your* princess alliance." She blinked a few times, and then looked at Spinnerella again. "Tell me that I'm wrong."

Spinnerella and Netossa said nothing, but the look they gave Glimmer spoke plainly enough.

"Whatever else you see me as," Glimmer said, "whatever else I *am*," I'm also a Queen. The Queen of Brightmoon and the leader of the princess alliance."

"So you keep telling us," Netossa muttered.

"Yes," Glimmer said, voice hard. "I am." Her voice softened. "And now I'm going to ask you a question I should have asked the two of you a long time ago: What queen would you want me to be? Do you want me to be like my mother? Or do you want me to be *me*."

"That's what this is all about, is it?" Spinnerella said with tired voice. "You still trying to get out of your mother's shadow."

"It's not *her* shadow I'm worried about right now," Glimmer sharply said.

"Then maybe that's the shadow you should try to get out of," Netossa shot back.

For a moment Glimmer glared at her, but then she lowered her gaze.

"Yes," she admitted. "And believe me, I'm doing my best."

"That's a start," Netossa said with sad voice.

"You look at me, and you see a piece of my mother," Glimmer said, voice sincere. "The last piece, which it is your duty to protect." She sighed. "My mother is gone. It took me a long time to get to grips with it, but it's true."

"The piece of my mother that remains to be protected is not here," she said, indicating her entire self. She put her hand over her heart. "It's here." She looked Spinnerella in the eyes and pointed to first her, then Netossa's heart. "And there."

"Glimmer..." Netossa said, voice breaking.

"I miss mom too," Glimmer sighed. "And I get it if you feel guilty. But I made my choice, my mistakes, and I really don't think there was anything you could have told me after her death that would have changed things."

"We could have slit the throat of the fucking witch the moment she showed up in Brightmoon," Netossa mumbled.

"I like her!" Catra exclaimed. Netossa gave her a look that started angry, but after a moment morphed into a cheeky grin.

"Well, I suppose Glimmer could have done worse," she admitted.

"I'll take it!" Catra grinned.

"We're taking down Shadow Weaver," Glimmer said with serious voice - not entirely hiding the trembling - looking Spinnerella in the eyes. "We are saving the rest of the princesses under her thumb. We are taking back my runestone, my castle and my kingdom. And to do that I need the princess alliance. The *whole* princess alliance. Personally I think you'll be of most use if you help me. But if it helps, coming with me will put you in the perfect position to stop me, if needed. If you still suspect Shadow Weaver of pulling my strings - or me to fail in my queenly duties all by myself."

"Please?" Frosta said, and for a moment she sounded like a little girl again, begging her parents not to fight.

Spinnerella and Netossa traded a long look. Then Spinnerella looked to Glimmer again, and it was uncanny how much liked Angella she looked in that moment.

"Glimmer..." she said, and her tone of voice said it all.

"Spinny..." Glimmer sobbed as her facade broke down, and without even walking the two steps that separated them, she teleported into the older woman's arm. Spinnerella held her tenderly as Glimmer cried with her face buried in her chest.

For a moment, Catra met Netossa's eyes. Then both of them looked away.

- - -

It took yet some time for Glimmer to finish crying. Catra and Netossa took help of Jack and Frosta to cook up a light meal (turns out the mercenaries had some supplies they no longer needed). They sat together by the fire and talked. Both Spinnerella and Glimmer had so much to tell each other of the adventures and misfortunes they had been up to during their time apart. Frosta and Jack huddled closely together, processing the last days of trauma and fear. Netossa and Catra shared an uneasy silence.

"You really think you can repair the princess alliance?" Spinnerella said. Glimmer nodded.

"We're already well away," she answered. "We have Scorpia, Entrapta, Frosta..." (Frosta pumped her fist in the air.)

"What about Mermista?" Netossa sharply interrupted. "What does *she* have to say about the way the 'new' princess alliance has treated her?"

"Actually, um, we... might have a solution for that," Glimmer quickly said.

"A solution for *trading away Mermista's kingdom?*" Spinnerella said, arms crossed.

"Me and Catra had a little talk with Mermista and Sea Hawk," Glimmer said with guilty voice, "and we came up with a plan."

"The way I hear it," Catra said "everyone in Salineas is not happy with how Scurvy runs things."

"There are some who say things were better with the Horde around," Glimmer said.

"And then people remind each other how much better it was with the royal family in charge," Catra went on.

"And, as it turns out, there might be some pretty strong factions that are loyal to Mermista," Glimmer grinned. "And they have amassed quite a bit of... influence."

"Tragic, really, how corrupt everyone on that island is," Catra sighed with fake concerned voice.

"We figure, it wouldn't take much to kick Scurvey out." Glimmer said.

"We might have mentioned this to Double Trouble," Catra said. "They had some... ideas." Catra said.

"Very *detailed* ideas as it turns out," Glimmer muttered.

"And with Scurvey out, with Mermista turning up in the harbour, runestone in hand, and with key officials already loyal and ready for her return, she could be back in the palace in a day," Catra said.

"Mermista would have a most *dedicated* entourage," Glimmer said and put a hand on Frosta's shoulder. Frosta sat up straighter with a proud grin.

"It might also so happen, that some of the other wanna-be candidates for the throne would find themselves in... logistic difficulties," Catra smirked.

"The Horde, naturally, wouldn't *dream* of interfering in the affairs of the *independent* kingdom of Salineas," Glimmer sweetly said.

"Of course, if Scurvy kicks up a fuss and tries to return with an armada, we might just 'happen' to keep Octavia and her fleet around to keep order of the oceans," Catra grinned.

"That is, if he's even stupid enough in the first place to *try* to get through to Mermista, with her runestone back and with the Sea Gate up and running," Glimmer commented.

"Obviously we need to take down Shadow Weaver first," Catra said.

"But... once we've done that Mermista will have her kingdom back," Glimmer said and gave Spinnerella a downright scared look. "So... um..."

Spinnerella and Netossa gave her a long look, concern and anger mixed with weariness and just a tiny hint of admiration.

"Just like that, huh?" Netossa said.

"It's not perfect," Glimmer quickly said, "but Mermista actually looks forward to invade her own city. She says everyone else had a shot and now she wants in."

Netossa couldn't help smiling at that.

"I can see her say that," she admitted.

"She was brainstorming an 'Evil Queen Dress or whatever' together with Double Trouble when we left," Catra grinned.

Netossa chuckled. Even Spinnerella couldn't help smiling.

"So that's how this will work if you manage to beat Shadow Weaver?" Netossa said acquiescingly. "You grant kingdoms just as much freedom as it suits you, replacing leaders at will when they are no longer of use to you.

"You heard of Plumeria, I take it," Glimmer said guilty.

"And Thaymor," Spinnerella said sharply. "We have spent quite some time cleaning up your messes, young lady."

"I'm sorry," Glimmer mumbled. "I... It won't be like that," she quickly said. "We'll do better."

"Better how?" Netossa demanded, arms crossed.

"We'll call a... meeting," Glimmer said, then frowned. "No, that sounds lame. We'll call a peace conference. *The* peace conference. In Mystacor."

"Mystacor, huh," Spinnerella said, a little smile lurking in the edge of her mouth.

"Yeah," Glimmer sighed. "Castaspella will be so smug when she receives my messages. But she has more than earned it. She was right all along."

"She can have *one* 'I told you so'," Catra said primly.

"And who will get to come to this 'peace conference'?" Netossa asked suspiciously.

"Everyone," Glimmer said earnestly. "Representatives from all the free cities. The merchants. The farmers. The makers. The scholars. The travelers. The people of the Whispering Woods. The princesses. The pirates - and not only Scurvy - the minor captains as well. The Horde. Both Lonnie and her boys and the Force Captains. My ladies in waiting. Our gals from the Crimson Waste. Mystacor, of course. The rebellion. Sea Hawk will have his own spot - that should annoy Mermista. Bow... you guys, if you want to come... the important part is that this time around, everyone has a seat by the table. Everyone gets to take part in deciding what happens next."

"And what *will* happen next?" Netossa pressed.

"Peace," Glimmer said simply. "A hard won, brittle peace build by compromises and kept in place by enough people being invested

in preserving it and actively working for it."

"You really have thought this through," Spinnerella said with a little sigh.

"We're trying as good as we can," Glimmer sighed and took Catra's hand. "It won't make up for everything bad we have done... but at least it will give us a chance at a future that's better than what we grew up with."

"All this is fine and good," Netossa said, "but it all hinges on you actually being able to take down Shadow Weaver."

"We can take her," Glimmer said, an edge to her voice.

"She snatched the Moonstone from right under your nose," Netossa unkindly reminded her. "She has grown her strength ever since."

"So have we," Catra growled. "Unless you missed it, me and Glimmer rule half the fucking world."

"And one single princess under her command was enough to stop your advance," Spinnerella said with low voice, looking directly at Glimmer. "We know you freed Mermista, but she was not the only tool in Shadow Weaver's arsenal."

"I'm well aware," Glimmer said. "But we *did* free Mermista. We *have* regained control over the ocean - and with it we have cleared the path to Brightmoon for the Horde. We *have* brought Entrapta and Scorpia and Bow from Beast Island and we have the Queen of Snow with us" -she reached out to put a hand on Frosta's shoulder. She looked Netossa right in the eyes. "Not to mention that we have the two of you. We are pushing Shadow Weaver back. This time she won't have anywhere to run."

"I hope you know better by know than to underestimate her," Spinnerella said with serious voice. "You know she has cards that haven't hit the table yet."

"So have I," Glimmer said.

For a moment something dark passed over her features.

Netossa and Spinnerella exchanged a long look.

"You truly are your father's daughter, Glimmer," Spinnerella finally sighed. "I just hope you know what you're doing."

"Spinny..." Glimmer said eyes full of tears.

And then, they hugged again.

"Oh yeah," Glimmer said in the middle of the hug. "Speaking of dad, there's something you should know..."

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Eventually, they started to pack up and prepare to move out. As Glimmer and Spinnerella helped Frosta and Jack to put their things in order after the flight from the mercenaries, Netossa stepped up to Catra.

"How did you do it?" Netossa asked eventually with low voice.

"Do what?" Catra asked, forcing herself to keep her voice civil.

"The Horde..." Netossa said. "We all figured that once Hordak finally croaked the whole thing would fall apart. All those soldiers turning into bandits and mercenaries over night, forced to pillage to survive. That didn't happen."

"We threatened to beat them up if they left," Catra shrugged. Netossa chuckled but shook her head.

"No, that isn't it," she said. "You don't keep an army that size together by threats alone. You had to offer them something."

"Well, you know her," Catra said and nodded at Glimmer. "She's good with speeches." Netossa chuckled again.

"You should have heard her when she started up the second princess alliance," she said.

"I was in the receiving end of that, remember," Catra drily said.

Netossa smirked at her, but then her face grew serious.

"What did you offer them?" she said with low voice.

"The Horde?" Catra asked. Netossa nodded.

"A seat by the table," Catra muttered, glancing at Glimmer.

Netossa nodded slowly.

"And what exactly does that mean, for the Horde?"

"Hey, I'm the thug," Catra protested. "Ask Glimmer."

"I will," Netossa said evenly. "And she will give me one of those speeches she's so good at. I want to know what 'a seat of the table' means to *you*. What does it mean to the Horde? What do they hear when she says it?"

Catra poked at the fire with a stick for a few moments as she pondered the question.

"Princess Prom," she said eventually. "An invite when all the posh people gather to decide stuff." Netossa raised an eyebrow.

"The Horde *were* at princess prom," she said. "Remember? It was a whole thing."

"The princess of Fright Zone was invited on a technicality," Catra answered with dry voice. "That's not what I'm talking about."

"What, then?" Netossa asked. "Salineas? You stomping in and putting flags everywhere?"

"Touché," Catra answered. "Something in between, I suppose. Legitimacy. Being able to take part when the big girls talk about

big-girl stuff, without having to beat people up first."

"You never seemed have a problem with that," Netossa remarked.

"Of course not," Catra shrugged. "I'm the boss. But you didn't ask about me. You asked about them."

"Yeah, I did," Netossa said with a frown. "The Horde has had the entire world by the throat for two generations. Are you saying they feel 'left out'?"

"Any reason we shouldn't?" Catra said with low voice, not looking at Netossa. "Nowhere else for us, is there?"

"With a world full of pirates and bandits, with the Horde flag flying over half the cities of this world, there is *everywhere* for you," Netossa snapped.

"Yeah, because we could grab it," Catra snapped back. "It's not like you princess types would let us have *anything* if we hadn't the muscles to take it from you. It's not like we would have been allowed to fucking exist if you guys had been the winners, is it?"

For a moment Netossa looked furious, but the moment passed, and then she just looked tired.

"That's what they have let you believe, huh?" she asked with sad voice.

"What's that supposed to mean?" Catra asked.

"You must just have been a kid back then," Netossa sighed. "No wonder they didn't tell you... but back in the days of the first Princess Alliance Angella DID try to negotiate. She offered territory. She offered trade - Salineas was only too happy to open the Sea Gate for that. She offered riches... magic... whatever she could think of. Frosta's mother was outraged. But Hordak refused. Most of the time we never even got an answer, except for the thunder of canons."

"Yeah, sounds like Hordak," Catra admitted.

"Hordak's not calling the shots anymore," Netossa said, watching Catra intently.

"Hordak lied to us," Catra said flatly. "Much as it galls us to admit it, all the bullshit he fed us about 'fighting against the oppressors' was just that. Bullshit. All he wanted to do was earn points in space daddy's book."

"Is that how the rest of the Horde sees it?" Netossa asked, almost gently.

"Some do," Catra said with a sour frown. "Most don't care. It's not like it matter. Once the first blow has landed, whatever came before it doesn't really matter."

"Some would say it matters," Netossa said, just a bit of an edge to her voice.

"Sure, if you like keeping scores," Catra shrugged.

They watched each other in silence.

"Can you do it?" Netossa said with a nod at Glimmer. "Can the two of you reign them in?"

"She did it to me, didn't she?" Catra shot back with a grin. Netossa smiled back at her.

"So her big peace conference thing..."

"She's the boss," Catra interrupted. "They are scared shitless of her, but as far as they are concerned, she's *their* scary princess. If she takes Brightmoon, if she calls the conference... the Horde will count it as a win."

"And then?" Netossa asked.

"And then what?" Catra shrugged. "Then we have peace and spend the rest of our lives haggling about the details. Or if some people disagree they can have a little war until the big players grow tired of them and stomp it up. That's what you princesses have been all about these last thousands of years, isn't it."

"And the rest of the Horde will be happy with that?" Netossa asked. "No force captain who will feel nostalgic for the old ways and go back to conquering?"

"Sure, but when that happens we will just have another pirate on our hands," Catra shrugged. "We can deal with those."

"But most of the Horde will take the deal they get?" Netossa pressed.

Catra glanced at Glimmer.

"That's up to you guys, isn't it? Make the deal sweet enough and they will."

"At this point, you're the ones calling the shots," Netossa said, not without heat.

"Yeah, it is," Catra said, matching her tone. "Maybe I'm the one who should ask you all these pointed questions. Will the *rebellion* be happy with the peace conference?"

"Yeah," Netossa said immediately. Catra raised an eyebrow.

"Really? What makes you so sure?"

"Because unlike the Horde, we remember what Etheria was like before Hordak," Netossa said with low voice. "We know that things can be better than this."

"All right, we are ready to poof out," Glimmer said and held out her hands. With a long look at Netossa, Catra took Glimmer's hand and grabbed Jack in the other, with Frosta clinging to them just a bit too tight for decency. Netossa and Spinnerella took

Glimmer's other hand, and in a cloud of sparkles, they returned to the Fright Zone.

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"They're back! They're back, they're back!" Entrapta cried as Glimmer and the others teleported back to the Fright Zone. She was hanging upside down in her hair in one of the big machine halls, working on a round bot together with Rogelio. Scorpia stood beside them, proudly holding a tray of tools. Bow stood next to them, wearing and apron and stirring in a bowl with cake batter, because of course he was.

"Scorpia!" Frosta cried and tried to run over to hug the princess. She immediately winced of pain and stopped in her tracks.

"Frosta!" Scorpia cried and dropped the tray with a clang. She ran over to the tiny queen and carefully scooped her up. "You're hurt!"

"You should have seen the other gals," Glimmer said modestly. "Rogelio, these are princesses Spinnerella and Netossa. Spinny and Netty, this is Force Captain Rogelio. I'm sure you have met in the field, occasionally, but for now I want you all to play nice."

Rogelio growled and gave the princesses a nod, which they returned.

"Hey, 'trapta, Scorpia," Catra said with just a hint of trepidation. "This is Jack. I picked them up in the waste. They're a great kid."

"And I'm their *girlfriend*," Frosta proudly said from Scorpia's arms, which caused a pandemonium of 'ooooh'-ing, and some confusion when Emily insisted on highfiving both of the teens.

Bow walked over to Glimmer.

"You made peace, then," he said with low voice and nodded at Spinnerella and Netossa, who were trading quips with Lonnie who had joined Rogelio. Mermista and Sea Hawk - arm in arm - had also strolled over together with Double Trouble. Mermista still

looked like something dredged up from the bottom of the sea, and she walked with a limp, but her eyes were full of life again.

"It worked like a charm, just like you said," Glimmer sighed. She grinned at him. "It's very annoying when you're right, you know."

"It's because friendship is always right," he said with a cheeky grin.

"Fine," she laughed. She looked around and sighed happily. "I have missed this so much," she confessed.

"Everyone being together?" he not quite asked, fondly looking at Scorpia dragging in everyone within reach in a huge hug.

"Yeah," Glimmer said. "You know, like the first days of the princess alliance... *our* princess alliance, when we went around to gather everyone together with..."

Her voice trailed off.

"We'll get her," Bow assured her with gentle voice and gave her a side-hug. "We'll get all of them."

"Yes," Glimmer said with conviction. "And if everything works like I hope, we are closer than ever."

"I believe in you," Bow said simply, which made Glimmer having to take a long, shuddering breath.

"And I believe that I won't have to do it alone," she said and hugged him back.

"You know it," he said, and then scuffled to the side as the leader of Glimmer's ladies in waiting rolled up to them in her wheelchair (now apparently motorized, which Glimmer strongly suspected she could thank Entrapta for).

"My Queen," the lady-in-waiting said and bowed deeply.

"Um, yeah. Hello, Sandy. Please sit up," Glimmer said slightly embarrassed.

"I take it your expedition was successful, My Queen?" the woman named Sandy went on. She was about the same age as Glimmer, but a rough life made her look much older.

"Very successful," Glimmer said and looked thoughtfully at the data crystal still sticking out of Jack's pocket. "I need to talk to you and Entrapta. Some new avenues have just opened up."

"Just say the word, My Queen," Sandy answered with a bow.

"...please say Glimmer," Glimmer mumbled without looking at Bow. She clapped her hand to get everyone's attention.

"My friends!" she said, which made Sandy and Lonnie slightly uncomfortable. "We have a lot of planning to do. Let's meet in the throne room and discuss the next phase of the war."

"Didn't we used to have, like, a meeting room for things like that?" Mermista grumped.

"Ah, you're in the Horde now, my aquatic aquamarine," Double Trouble leered. "Here it's less 'discuss' and more 'they shouting orders at you'."

"I try to move away from that leadership style," Glimmer said, with embarrassed voice as they all filtered through the doors that led them to the corridors to the throne room.

"My cake is soon ready," Bow reported. "Emily, can you please remind me in ten minutes?" Emily beeped in affirmation.

"Want me to gather the Force Captains, boss?" Lonnie asked.

"Might as well," Glimmer said. "And see if you can get some chairs or something?"

"Not as fancy as ours, though," Catra smirked.

"I'm coming," Entrapta muttered, head deep inside the inner workings of the bot. "I'll just..."

"You can bring it with you," Bow soothingly said, as Scorpia and Emily together lifted both Entrapta and bot and carried them after the rest of the group.

"So, what's the big deal with the thing the kids found?" Catra asked Glimmer with low voice.

"Shadow Weaver has direct access to the Heart of Etheria," Glimmer explained. "I figure that if we can cut it off, or at least muddle the signal for her, then we could..."

Her voice trailed off as they filtered into the throne room. The room, as always when it wasn't in used, felt too big, too empty, all that space to get lost in.

But it wasn't empty now.

A lone figure sat on the throne, a tall, muscular woman with her hands on a sword. Shadows clung to her like a second skin.

"Welcome home, 'my queens'," She-Ra said, dark pits where her eyes should have been. "I've been waiting for you."

Chapter End Notes

The old gang back together

She-Ra

Chapter Notes

Warning: An excessive amount of violence in this chapter

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Adora..." Glimmer whispered, staring with white face at the tall, strong woman on the throne.

"Princess," Shadow Weaver said through She-Ra's mouth with a mocking little bow

"...fuck," Catra said, taking a quick step to Glimmer's side.

"Are we, like, going to die?" Mermista asked, trying her best to hide her fear.

"The fuck we are," Catra snarled.

"SOUND THE ALARM!" Lonnie yelled to Rogelio as She-Ra stood up, sword in hand. "PRINCESS ALERT!"

"RUN!" Glimmer yelled and teleported, emerging just above She-Ra and then immediately teleporting away again as She-Ra swiped at her.

"EMILY! NO!" Entrapta yelled as Emily dropped her and scuttled forward, blaster ready.

"Adora!" Bow yelled "WE'LL HELP YOU!"

"Don't fear!" Sea Hawk said and drew his sword, cracking with power, in one flourished motion. I will..."

"CHAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAARGE!" Frosta cried, ignoring the pain as she summoned an enormous block of ice that hurled through the

air towards the princess on the throne. With a snort of disdain, She-Ra cut through it, and the web that Netossa hurled over her, and when the huge wave that Mermista sent her way died down, she walked down the stairs completely unaffected.

"Her hair isn't even wet," Mermista complained. "Completely unfair."

She-Ra took another step. She knocked an arrow from the air. She deflected a laser shot back to Emily, forcing the bot to retreat. She stepped through a wind that Spinnerella conjured up that forced the rest of them to take cover, like it had been a little spring breeze.

She smiled.

"The days of your bewitchment are at an end," Sea Hawk yelled as he sprinted up the stairs, the tip of his sword dancing like a firefly "Because this is the day you met with Sea Haaaaaaaaa..."

Unceremoniously, She-Ra grabbed him by the cuff of his neck and threw him over her shoulder without looking. She then deflected a jet of water, knocking Mermista backwards in the process.

"That's quite enough of that," Netossa said. She ran two steps forward and then - without any communication with Spinnerella - jumped straight up in the air. The moment she would have started descending, a gust of wind picked her up and hurled her up the stairs. Netossa unleashed a magic web, hit the stairs, rolled and then came to her feet just behind She-Ra, who was still struggling to get out. Netossa quickly engulfed She-Ra in another web and jumped to the side. She spun a third web and - throwing herself down the stairs, heaved at it with all her strength and weight.

She-Ra took a step to the side, firmly planted her feet and tore through the web as easily as if at it had been ordinary spider's web.

"Oh come on!" Spinnerella whispered.

"Adora!" Bow yelled, swinging down from a rope fastened by an arrow to the distant ceiling. "I'm really sorry about this, but..." he made a grabbing motion for the sword, but before he got it, She-Ra jabbed her elbow in his side, causing him to swing away like a child's toy on a string.

"Oh no you don't," Glimmer snarled as she emerged from nowhere, unleashing a ball of sparks in She-Ra's face. She immediately teleported out again, only to re-emerge a moment later with her hands around the sword.

"You can't hope to defeat me," Shadow Weaver snarled through She-Ra's mouth. "You don't have the guts to do what it takes."

"FOR THE QUEEN!" the lady-in-waiting Sandy cried, rapidly firing her blaster towards the tall figure.

She-Ra made a quick slashing motion, knocking Glimmer backwards just as she disappeared again and deflected the blaster shots towards the crowd. Then she punched her fist upwards, crushing another block of ice that hurled towards her.

She took a step down the stairs.

The whole fight so far had only been a few seconds.

"...I don't care if you blow the whole chamber to dust," Lonnie snarled at her comm badge. "Get all available firepower here *now*."

"Disobedient children," Shadow Weaver said through She-Ra's mouth as she let her eyes travel over the crowd and land on Frosta. "I believe you have something that belongs to me."

"Yeah, I think not," Catra said as she sauntered a few step up the stair to the throne, hands in her side, placing herself between She-Ra and the ice princess. "You, on the other hand, can fuck right out of Adora's head."

"You never could abide my influence on her, you ungrateful brat," Shadow Weaver snarled.

"Funny," Catra quipped back. "I could say the same to you."

"At the very least," Shadow Weaver said as She-Ra took a step closer. "I will finally have the great satisfaction to see Adora do what she should have done a long time ag..."

And that was the moment she was hit in the face by a pillar of pink magic, bright as the sun. The magic threw her backwards, up to the throne, with a force strong enough to make her cause an indenture in the metal.

"*No*," Glimmer said and stepped up to Catra's side, skin glowing. Another ball of lighting formed between her hands.

"Such wasted potential," Shadow Weaver sighed as She-Ra stepped up from the dented throne as carefree as if she just had stumbled slightly. "I could have lead you to greatness, instead you rut with the most unworthy of creatures." She-Ra deflected the lighting ball, forcing Glimmer to grab Catra and teleport in the last moment. The ball detonated against the huge doors to the throne room (newly repaired), sending them flying outwards.

"Language!" Glimmer taunted as she emerged just to the side of the doors. "There are children present."

"I'm *actually* a teenager," Frosta said with a snide voice that didn't quite hide her fear and pain. Ice formed around her fist. "And you can..."

"Undoubtley," Shadow Weaver sighed. "Spare me the bravado."

Without any effort, She-Ra sliced loose a large chunk of the metal from the throne and hurled it at Frosta with one hand.

Jack screamed in fear and pulled Frosta to the side, the metal chunk missing them by a hairs' width. She-Ra took another step down the throne, ignoring Frosta in the same way you ignore a fly

you just tried and failed to swat. She looked around the room, at the panting, trembling people spread out around the walls.

Her eyes stopped on Jack.

"You," Shadow Weaver said with brisk manner. "Give me the crystal."

"If you want it, come and get it," Jack said with high pitched voice.

She-Ra regarded them in silence for a moment.

"All right," she said, and without making any haste she started to walk down the stairs from the throne.

"If you hurt them, I will..." Frosta begun.

"Yes, yes," Shadow Weaver said absent-mindedly and a beam of pure energy shot from She-Ra's sword, right at the princess.

"Frosta!" Scorpia cried in panic and tore a solid steel plate straight from the wall, holding it up in the way of the beam. Meanwhile, She-Ra's sword followed its arc down to the floor and sliced through the throne as if it had been butter, sending a shock-wave that made the walls shake and everyone in the room stumble.

Calmly, She-Ra kept walking down the stairs.

"Run, Jack," Frosta cried, voice full of fear.

"I'm not leaving you!" Jack hissed back, but they took a step backwards, towards the crushed door.

"I think not," Shadow Weaver said with sardonic tone. A quick blast from the sword hit the roof, and a pile of debris fell down between the group and the door.

"Grab the kids and run," Catra panted. Glimmer gave her a look full of fear.

"Catra..." she begun.

"Fuck you!" Catra yelled. "Just do it!"

Glimmer swallowed, then she gave Catra a quick nod and teleported away. The moment after she reappeared just next to Jack and Frosta.

"Wha..." Frosta begun.

"I'm taking you to..." Glimmer begun and grabbed their arms.

"I think not," Shadow Weaver repeated in a laconic tone of voice, and a wave of pure energy rolled from She-Ra's sword. Glimmer, Frosta and Mermista cried and clutched at their ears, as if trying to block a loud sound. Glimmer's already bright glow increased, making her hard to look directly at, as all three elemental princesses fell to the ground, unconscious.

"Enough of this tiresome charade," Shadow Weaver said as She-Ra walked up to the fallen princesses. Jack took a terrified step back, feeling the metal of the wall against their back.

"NOW, ENTRAPTA!" Catra cried, and Entrapta - who had crawled up to the cables in the wall exposed by the panel Scorpia had tore off - flipped down her welding mask and pressed two cables together.

Immediately light started to flicker and a loud, electric screech was heard as systems for communication, environmental control and weaponry all cross-interacted in a rapidly increasing crescendo.

"Jack," Catra urgently hissed as the momentarily distracted She-Ra covered her ears with her hands. "Through the vents, get *out* of here."

Jack gave her a scared look, but obediently scampered up the wall. Small explosions were heard as the tortured electrical systems started to give in.

With her hands pressed hard against her ears, Catra struggled to get closer to the still incapacitated She-Ra.

"Get out of her head *now*," she snarled.

"Catra..." Adora whispered eyes pleading, but then shadows flickered through her eyes, and with an annoyed expression, she held up the sword.

A wave of force flooded out, drowning the sounds. With a little yelp of fear, Entrapta fell from the the wall as the circuitry she worked on exploded.

"Adora!" Bow gasped and stepped in front of the advancing warrior. "Stop!"

"You better run, little archer," Shadow Weaver taunted and moved She-Ra's arm backwards in a huge gesture to strike him down. "Bow! Please run!" she whispered with Adora's voice - full of fear and worry.

"Adora..." Bow whispered, eyes full of hope, and then abruptly fired an arrow towards the ceiling and was yanked away by his grappling-repeller-arrow just before She-Ra's sword hit.

For just a moment, everything was in a lull. The people scattered throughout the room stared at She-Ra, while She-Ra let her shadow-filled gaze sweep over the room.

It landed on a seemingly empty ledge just next to the entrance to vents.

"I'm insulted you think such a feeble illusion will hide you from me," Shadow Weaver said in disdain, and a beam of power from She-Ra's sword destroyed the ledge. With a frightened cry, Jack dropped the invisibility spell they had hidden under and scurried along the wall like a mouse.

"EVERYONE BACK!" Lonnie bellowed. "TAKE COVER!" She caught Catra's eyes. "Now we do things *my* way."

"Be my guest," Catra gasped, and the moment after, the debris that covered the door shot inwards in a huge explosion. Horde soldiers ran into the room.

"Fire," Lonnie said, and the weapons of the horde soldiers thundered. As the sound died down, the scratch of multiple metal legs against stone floor was heard. "Fire at will," Lonnie repeated between gritted teeth as bots poured into the room, shooting nonstop towards the tall figure on the throne.

"If you put a scratch in my throne, it's coming out of your pay," Catra panted, eyes wide with fear as smoke and debris filled the room.

"You're giving me a raise anyway," Lonnie said, staring unblinkingly into the smoke.

"Yeah, we are," Catra said with heartfelt voice.

"Look!" Sea Hawk yelled as She-Ra's glowing powers increased in intensity throughout the gloom.

"Very well," Lonnie snarled. She pushed her comm badge. "Do it, Kyle."

"If you think your toys..." Shadow Weaver begun, but her voice was completely drowned by an enormous explosion. The entire room shook. Debris from the ceiling fell everywhere. The scattered princesses, soldiers, heroes and scoundrels hid as good as they could under the rain of concrete and metal fragments.

"Fuck," Catra whispered with small voice when the noise level eventually allowed for any other sounds. She had leapt to cover the unconcious Glimmer from the falling debris. Next to her, Scorpia shielded Frosta and Mermista in a similar manner.

"Is everyone alive?" Bow asked trying to see through the dust and debris that filled the air. A few more or less hesitant answers were heard. Catra's eyes sought Lonnie.

"I distinctly remember Hordak making sure the artillery couldn't be turned against the throne room," Catra panted.

"Really?" Lonnie loftily said. "Someone must have removed those safeguards."

"I think it did the trick," Catra said, worry in her voice, looking at the huge pile of debris in the middle of the room. "Dig out Adora and we'll see how badly she needs to be patched up. Hopefully the princess powers protected her against the worst..."

Rogelio, his eyes glued to his comm pad, suddenly growled an urgent warning.

"...no..." Bow whispered, staring at his own pad.

"What is...?" Catra begun, but then she heard it.

Metal scraping against metal as something stirred inside the pile of the fallen roof.

"She can't have..." Lonnie begun.

"RUN!" Catra yelled. "EVERYONE GET OUT OF HERE!"

That moment, She-Ra exploded out of the pile, metal fragment hurling in every direction. She landed just in front of Lonnie, who stared at her with eyes full of fear.

"NO!" Bow cried and managed to tackle Lonnie out of the way before She-Ra's sword hit. Then he followed his momentum and dropped to the floor the moment before her follow-up punch connected with him.

She-Ra didn't waste any time on them as they scurried away. Instead she jumped straight up in the air, landing in front of Jack who was running for the freshly unblocked door.

Jack ducked the initial blow and managed to slip past She-Ra, but as they kept running, She-Ra turned the sword to a whip and

snagged Jack's feet. They fell to the floor, but as they did, a net caught them. The next moment, a gust of wind send them flying toward the door.

With an angry snarl, She-Ra spun around, punched Netossa in the face and sent her crashing to the floor, and then descended on Spinnerella on her other flank. Spinnerella flew straight up, carried by a miniature tornado.

When She-Ra turned around again, facing the fleeing Jack, Catra stood before her.

"No," she simply growled and feinted with a dagger. As She-Ra tried to block, Catra jumped out of reach before she could retaliate, and when She-Ra stood up again, Sea Hawk lunged towards her like a ballet dancer.

She-Ra parried, her sword slicing straight through the power blade he carried. Then she punched the pirate hard enough to send him flying. Only a quick net-arrow prevented him from crashing into the wall full force. She-Ra turned to Jack again, just as Catra's whip caught her leg.

"No," Catra snarled, staring at the being behind Adora's eyes with an expression full of undiluted hatred.

- - -

"Glimmer," Bow urgently whispered to the unconscious princess. "Wake up!"

To his great relief, Glimmer stirred. Even now, power was radiating off her, making her almost hot to the touch.

"Catra?" she whispered.

"Safe," Bow quickly said. He shot a worried glance at the feline, jumping around the still advancing She-Ra. "...for now," he amended. "Glimmer, we can't stop She-Ra, you know that."

"Don't have to," Glimmer mumbled. "Just... have to stop Shadow Weaver."

"Adora can stop her," Bow said slowly. "If she gets the chance."

"Right," Glimmer said and managed a smile. "If she gets some help..."

"...from the best friends squad," Bow filled in.

She smiled at him.

"Can you manage it?" he asked.

"If Adora can survive having that fucking witch in her head, I can deal with some excess magic," Glimmer snarled. She forced herself to her feet. "Let's get her."

- - -

"Catra!" Jack cried in full panic as She-Ra towered over them, sword ready.

"No," Glimmer hissed, teleporting in, grabbing Jack and teleporting out before the sword hit.

"Again you insist on making this harder than it has to," Shadow Weaver sighed.

She-Ra held up her sword. Power started building around it...

"Hey, Adora! Watch out!" Bow cried as he fired an arrow towards her.

"Another annoyance," Shadow Weaver sighed as She-Ra easily cleaved the arrow in the air. She then took a mighty stride towards Bow and aimed a blow with the sword. In the last minute, he misdirected the blow with a piece of cloth and jumped to the side, desperately grasping for a new arrow. She-Ra gave the piece of torn cloth a perplex look.

"Of all pathetic..." she begun, but then - just for a moment - her voice died out.

"No..." Adora whispered in absolute horror with her own voice as she stared at the destroyed blue blanket by her feet, the one she had worn the day they first met. "Bow..." she went on, tears streaming down her face. "I'm so sorry... I..."

"Sorry!" Bow cried with genuinely regretful voice. "We know it's just Shadow Weaver that forces you. We'll save you, I promise."

"Pathetic *child*," Shadow Weaver snarled as she regained the control of Adora's mind. "I spent a life time training you to reach your full potential and the moment Angella crooks her finger you ran off to..."

That was the moment the smoke bomb hidden inside the arrow that She-Ra had knocked from the air exploded. Thick, black smoke billowed all around her.

"It was acceptance, friendship and the opportunity to help those in need that did it, actually," Bow said as he darted from the smoke and made a dash for the sword.

"*Pathetic!*" Shadow Weaver snarled as She-Ra gave him a hard kick. He rolled with it and jumped out of the way. "You are a complete nobody with delusions of grandeur. I have tolerated *your* influence on her for far too long."

"Remember how much you loved it when we did our morning runs?" Bow said, evading She-Ra's attack. "I promise you that once this is over, we'll have a full gym day."

"When this is over you will be *dead*," Shadow Weaver snarled.

"Really?" Bow said and fired a grappling hook arrow towards the other side of the room. "And how will you do that when you can't even... oh poodle!"

He fell to the ground as the rope that carried him was severed by the Sword of protection - transformed into a razor sharp golden disc. It returned to She-Ra's hand and turned into a sword again.

"Like this," Shadow Weaver said as She-Ra towered above him, sword in hand.

"Stop it, Adora," Glimmer cried, voice full of fury as she emerged from the smoke. "Throw the sword away right now or I'll kill your fucking cat."

She held Catra in a tight grip, a small, efficient looking dagger pressed against her throat.

"Please do," Shadow Weaver laughed mockingly through Adora's mouth. "You'd do me a favour to finally get rid of that..."

"Suit yourself," Glimmer snarled and slit Catra's throat.

With a scream of pure panic, Adora hurled herself forward, letting go of the sword to catch the gurgling catgirl, blood spewing from her throat. As she did, she turned into Adora again, eyes full of horror, but for the moment free of shadows.

"Catra...." she whispered.

"If it makes you feel any better, toots," 'Catra' said with a smirk as Double Trouble took their own guise, "That was a top of the line fake dagger."

At the same time, the real Catra darted out of the smoke, aiming for Adora's back. Bow, meanwhile, grabbed the sword and tossed it up in the air.

"Catch!" he cried, and a bag of net caught the sword and - propelled by a gust of wind - flew away to the opposite side of the room.

"Got it!" Entrapta yelled and scampered into the vents with the bag.

"I'll kill you all!" Shadow Weaver cried.

"Not with Adora as a tool, you won't," Catra snarled, having forced the princess to the ground. She held up a clawed hand. "Now, get the fuck out of Adora's mind or I'll..."

"Catra..." Adora gasped. "Please, don't let her..."

At that point, something huge emerged from above, knocking Catra over. Adora quickly scrambled to her feet. Catra did a new attempt to grapple her, but the being unfurled large wings.

"Come, Adora!" Swift Wind cried, shadows pouring out of his eyes, mouth and nostrils.

Adora - eyes full of shadows again - threw Catra to the floor, ran over to Swift Wind and and swung up on his back. She placed a kick at Glimmer who just emerged from a cloud of glitter and the winged horse leaped into the air.

"DON'T LET HER GET AWAY!" Glimmer cried, but the horse was already in the air, dodging nets, arrows, wind and blaster shots. Glimmer made a futile attempt at teleportation, with the only effect that she started to throw up.

The next moment, Adora and Swift Wind were gone.

Everyone stood in the ruined throne room, staring at each other.

That was the moment when Emily started to beep, signalling that Bow's cake was ready.

Chapter End Notes

Did someone say Swift Wind?

Before the storm

Chapter Notes

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The throne room was completely wrecked. There was a huge hole in the roof, and two of the walls bent in a worrying fashion. Debris were everywhere.

"That was a refreshing tussle!" Sea Hawk said with carefree voice.

"*NOW* can I maim him?" Catra asked.

"Dream on, catgirl," Mermista snarled and took a limping, protective step in front of the suddenly starry-eyed pirate.

Glimmer put a soothing hand on Catra's arm and gently nudged her with her as she climbed up on top of the wrecked throne. She looked around at the assembled people.

"That's what we're up against," she said with solemn voice, nodding at the hole in the roof where Adora and Swift Wind had left. "That's what we are putting an end to. Today."

"Strong opening," Double Trouble muttered.

"Friends," Glimmer went on, putting emphasis on the word as Bow made a soppy little sound. "Allies, enemies, flunkies..." she let her eyes play over the assembly as she spoke. "...wife," she ended with a long, loving look at Catra.

She took a deep breath.

"You have all, at one point or another, put your trust in me. Out of loyalty - to me or to my mother - out of respect, out of fear or" - her eyes stopped on Bow for a long moment- "out of love."

"*Or*," Double Trouble interrupted, "because we think you can get the job done."

"Yeah," Frosta cried from Jack's arms. "Enough with the speeches, Glimmer. "Just tell us what to hit!"

"Guys..." Glimmer said, somewhat flustered. "You have all, at some point, had that trust betrayed. I have not been the leader you deserved - neither of the Horde nor the Princess Alliance. I have no right to ask you to trust me again..."

"Glimmer," Bow interrupted. "I know you like to think of this as *your* responsibility, but this is on all of us. We *choose* to be with you because we trust you to do the right thing." Spinnerella nodded.

"I thought you had got it by now, *wife*," Catra leered. She made a show of gesturing around. "*No one* is worthy of ruling over this dump because this dump - the Horde - is a piece of shit. Us queening here is not because we deserve it, it's because we're the ones stupid enough to angle for the job."

"And you got it," Lonnie pointedly said. "And since we just about got crushed but you still sent the enemy packing, I'd say it's time for retaliation. I've got an army for you, primed and ready. Just tell me where to send it."

Glimmer gave her a thankful smile. She moved her eyes to Mermista.

"What do you say, Mermista?" she said, smile growing more blood-thirsty. "Will the Horde ships have a clear way to Brightmoon?"

"They sure fucking will," Mermista said with a smug smirk. "I might even give you a lift to the Brightmoon lake."

"Then ready the fleet," Glimmer said to Lonnie and Octavia. "You sail with the moon. I trust Shadow Weaver's mercenaries won't be a problem?"

Rogelio snorted.

Glimmer grinned at him and moved her eyes to Spinnerella and Netossa.

"Aunty Spinny, aunty 'tossa," she said. "How fast can you get to Brightmoon?"

"As fast as the wind blows," Netossa said with a proud look at her wife.

"Then get as many of the possessed people out of there as possible. You might have to subdue them," she said and glanced at Netossa.

"We can do that," Netossa said.

"Thank you," Glimmer said with heartfelt voice. She moved her eyes to Frosta and Jack, who sat together on the floor.

"The two of you," she said with solemn voice, "I need you to go to Mystacor."

"What?" Frosta said with outraged voice. "I want to fight."

"Of course you want to," Glimmer said with a smile. "And you will. But if the off-switch to the Heart of Etheria lies in Mystacor, we can't relay solely on the sorceresses to keep it safe. Shadow Weaver know all their tricks. She won't be able to get past the two of you."

"And what are you doing?" Catra asked, a bit of a challenge to her voice.

"You know what I have to do," Glimmer said, looking Catra in the eyes without blinking. "I will go to Brightmoon to reconnect with the Moonstone," She quickly held up her hand as both Catra and Bow cried out in outrage.

"I need to do it myself," she said. "Anyone I bring with me, Shadow Weaver can use against me. I can handle anything she throws at me, but I need you to attack her other flanks."

"Such as?" Catra frowned.

"Shadow Weaver think she has She-Ra in her pocket. We will show her she's wrong."

"We got the sword, though," Catra protested. "Adora can't turn to She-Ra again, right?"

Glimmer shook her head.

"Normally I'd have say yes, but with Shadow Weaver having access to both Light Hope and the Heart of Etheria... I wouldn't trust it. Therefore, you're going for She-Ra's weak point."

"Adora?" Catra asked, slight trepidation in her voice.

"Fuck that," Glimmer snarled. "She's the *strong* point. We're attacking that stupid First-Ones interface."

"She's getting sneaky," Double Trouble said with glee and elbowed Sea Hawk in the side.

"Can we do that?" Bow asked.

"*We* can't do it," Glimmer said to Bow with a little smile.

"Pause for effect," Double Trouble said under their breath as Glimmer paused for effect.

"But the Super Pal Trio can," Glimmer finished and looked straight at Scorpia, who opened her eyes wide.

"Punchline!" Double Trouble cheered. Mermista gave them an annoyed eye-roll.

"Sparkles," Catra protested. "I am..."

"Still one of us," Scorpia said with voice crackling of emotions.

"Super pal trio!" Entrapta said with enthusiastic voice and Emily beeped agreement.

"Guys..." Catra said, desperately and unsuccessfully trying to hold back tears.

"What do you say, Entrapta?" Glimmer grinned. "Are you ready to hack the planet again?"

"You had me at 'hack the planet'!" Entrapta enthusiastically answered.

"Good," Glimmer said and handed Entrapta She-Ra's sword, which Entrapta accepted with a little 'squee'. "Because this time we have the master key." She nodded to Jack, who handed Entrapta the crystal they had found. "Two of them in fact. Make good use of them."

"Ehehehehehehh!" Entrapta said as she examined the crystal, apparently enjoying what she saw.

Glimmer's expression grew more serious.

"We know that Shadow Weaver will stop at nothing to get those back, so you three better watch your back." She squeezed Catra's hand. "So you see, you're not letting me face her alone. You're keeping her off my back. Buy me as much time as you can, but don't die, OK?"

"If I survived fucking Beast Island, I'm not letting a second rate witch get to me," Catra snarled. "I'll give you as much time as you need."

"There we go," Glimmer said, voice satisfied.

"I'm still coming with you," Bow said with determined voice. I was with you to that chamber last time, remember?"

"I appreciate it," Glimmer said with apologetic voice. "But you are needed elsewhere."

"I've been 'not with you' for far too long," Bow protested.

Sea Hawk put a hand on his shoulder.

"Far be it for me to keep a lad from his beloved maiden," he rumbled, "but you and me have work to do."

"Oh?" Bow said, blushing slightly.

"No bro leaves their bro behind to be possessed by an evil witch," he said with solemn voice. "Bro-code."

"Bro-code?" Bow asked with slightly bewildered voice.

"We need Adora," Glimmer said simply, "and for that we need Swift Wind. If you can get him free from the witch, I can use their 'sacred bond' to get to Adora."

"Also, as soon as we have our bro back, we can help getting people out of Brightmoon," Sea Hawk said cheerfully.

"And I don't need to tell you that I'd prefer if as many people as possible are out of there before Lonnie and Octavia gets in position," Glimmer said with wry voice.

Bow gave her a long look.

"All right," he finally said. "But if this is you trying to talk yourself into being 'unworthy of friendship' again, I'm hugging you for a *year* without letting go."

"Duly nodded," Glimmer laughed, and for a rare moment she sounded just like the old Glimmer again.

She looked around the room, her voice shaking slightly.

"This is it. It's the final battle. I'm scared."

"Pause for effect," Double Trouble muttered under their breath.

"I'm scared," Glimmer continued after a brief moment. "Not only for what I will have to do to win. Not only for what happens if we lose. Not only for what this final battle will cost us." She took a deep breath. "I'm scared for what happens after we win. I'm scared that the hard won unity we're sharing now will dissolve. I'm scared that minor squabbles will blow up and leave us all defenceless once Horde Prime finds us. I'm scared that everything we built will be obsolete once the final enemy falls."

She did a little helpless gesture.

"I'm afraid I won't be of any use to you, once the war is won... I suppose what I'm telling you is that I'm afraid that I will turn out not to be my mother after all..."

About half of the people in the room opened their mouths. Glimmer quickly held up her hand.

"*But* the fact that I'm scared doesn't mean I won't do what it takes to get there, and I *know* that whatever happens next, I won't have to face it alone."

She smiled.

"We are all in this together. We will fight together and we will win together."

They all cheered.

"Care to add anything, Kitten?" Double Trouble leered.

Catra shrugged.

"Yeah, I think I'll leave the speeches to my wife, so let me just add..."

Her claws popped out, she let her gaze travel over the room.

"...let's go kick the witch bitch in the ass."

They all cheered again.

Glimmer and Catra descended from the throne, there were some hugging (because with Bow and Scorpia back, that was now a fixed point of the agenda) and some more instructions, and then they broke up in groups to make the final preparations.

"Your majesty," Octavia said to Frosta, with mock-respectful tone, even bowing a little. "Might I be so bold to ask you for a favour,"

"What do you want?" Frosta said suspiciously.

"I wonder if I might ask you for the kindness of meeting me in the ring," Octavia leered. "Because once I deck you, I'll have fought every single elemental princess bitch and lived to tell the tale."

"Hah! I'll gladly kick your ass," Frosta smirked.

"Don't break anything," Glimmer said absent-mindedly and studied the map.

"No promises, boss," Octavia leered.

"I wasn't talking to you," Glimmer countered and turned to Frosta. "I need her to lead the fleet to Brightmoon."

"She doesn't need *both* her legs to drive a boat, does she?" Frosta snarked.

Together they disappeared towards the gym with Jack in tow. Lonnie walked up to Glimmer.

"Given that our admiral does not get her head bashed in, the fleet will be ready in time."

"Good," Glimmer said. "Scurvey is still on our good side, so the pirates shouldn't be a problem. I don't think Shadow Weaver will

try to position Perfuma in your way, but if she does, Mermista should be more than capable of taking care of it."

"Whatever," Mermista said with an eyeroll as she limped towards the door. "Right now I really want someone to show me where the showers are in this dump. It'll take forever to get the shadow gunk out of my hair. Sea Hawk, are you coming or what?"

"I will help, my darling dolphin!" Sea Hawk quickly said and sprinted after her. Double Trouble took a few quick steps in their direction, but a stern look from Glimmer stopped them. Lonnie nodded to Kyle instead, who walked with them towards the exit.

"I'm not leaving you entirely without princess tricks, after all," Glimmer said with smug voice. Lonnie rolled her eyes.

"I take it you're not coming with me?"

"No," she answered with sincere voice. "Shadow Weaver's attention should be focused on Catra and the sword, but her secondary target will be me. The fleet will have it's best chance if you travel without us."

"Duly noted," Lonnie said with dry voice, not entirely hiding the worry in her voice. "And what will our attack signal be?"

Glimmer gave Bow a quick, guilty look.

"You attack at first opportunity," she said.

"But we might not be finished getting her hostages out by then," Bow protested.

"You might not have the chance until she's distracted by the attack," Glimmer shot back. "Perfuma didn't make it, and she ended up possessed herself. We need to throw everything we have at Shadow Weaver if we'll have any chance to get through."

"I know the attack plan," Lonnie said. "Your 'ladies-in-waiting' claim to have tricks that should take care of at least some of the

magical defences. The rest of them we wear down the usual way - bots and soldiers."

"Bots and cannons first," Glimmer corrected her. "We don't want to give Shadow Weaver more people to possess until we already have her full attention elsewhere.

"Got it, boss," Lonnie said and scribbled something on her clipboard.

"Oh," Glimmer said and pointed at the Brightmoon map she studied. "Place an incendiary shell here, will you?"

"Can do," Lonnie grunted. "What's there? Doesn't seem to be that much of a strategic position.

"It's a garden," Glimmer explained. "Shadow Weaver finds it cheerful."

"That will catch her attention," Double Trouble agreed as they joined the group. "Also, may I suggest lobbying a few shells towards the Moonstone?"

"That's the most heavily defended place in all of Brightmoon," Glimmer objected.

"That it is," Double Trouble agreed. "It is also the centre of her power, which means that for someone like Shadow Weaver, she will be acutely aware of any threat against it."

"That's good," Glimmer mused. "In fact," she turned to Bow. "Once you and Sea Hawk have freed Swift Wind and got enough people out, you could start make some noise in that part of the castle as well.

"As soon as we've freed the hostages I'm going to *you*," Bow said with determined voice. "You'll be in the chamber, right?"

"I will," Glimmer sighed. "I suppose there is no talking you out of it?"

"None whatsoever," Bow said with determined voice.

"Thanks," she said, suddenly looking very vulnerable. "If I haven't finished down there by myself by the time you're done with the hostages... yeah, I might need a hand."

Then it was time for hugs again.

- - -

The afternoon went by, everyone busy with their preparations and with patching their wounds. Entrapta squealed in delight as she explored the first one's crystal Jack and Frosta had brought her. Bow did his best to assist her with Scorpia and Emily anxiously trailing after them. Glimmer laid plans with her ladies-in-waiting and did some final preparations with Scorpia. Lonnie yelled at the force captains and Double Trouble 'kept an eye on things'.

Eventually Frosta and Octavia returned, both bruised but both in a great mood. Frosta had won, but Octavia had got a few good hits in which satisfied her criteria for bragging right. Octavia limped off to yell at her crew and Glimmer sat down with Jack and Frosta to tell them the message they should give to Mystacor. After that, Catra and Glimmer got a rare moment, just the two of them, sharing a ration bar in their bed room.

"Just to be clear," Frosta hissed to Jack as they left the throne room. "That thing with Mystacor is just Glimmer doing that stupid-adult-thing where she tries to keep us safe, right?"

"Of course it is," Jack hissed back.

"So we're totally sneaking on board the ship, right?" Frosta pressed.

"Of course we are," Jack grinned and weaved an invisibility spell around them.

Catra passed Glimmer the ration bar.

"You know the kids will sneak onboard the ship, right?" she said.

"Of course I know," Glimmer sighed. "Casta doesn't need me to tell her how to guard Mystacor. She told me all the way back during the audience that she knew Shadow Weaver was coming for them. She has it covered."

"So why tell the kids to go there?" Catra asked.

"If I had told them to get on the ship they'd just gotten in their head to join Bow and Sea Hawk or something like that," she shrugged. "They'll be safest on the ship so I thought it best to dangle it in front of their nose and tell them they mustn't go there."

"You're good with kids," Catra said admiringly.

"The secret is to remember that you once were one," Glimmer said with a grin.

They looked at each other and their smiles faltered.

"Scared?" Catra asked.

"A little," Glimmer admitted. She took in Catra's expression and laughed, a little bashfully. "Fine, I'm scared shitless," she amended. "If things go wrong..."

"I trust you," Catra said seriously.

"I know..." Glimmer whispered. "Everyone does. But what if I'm wrong? What if I can't do it? What if..."

"You can do it," Catra said and took Glimmer's hand. "Just... don't die, OK?"

"I won't," Glimmer promised. "You too?"

"I won't," Catra agreed.

"No, I mean it," Glimmer pressed. "Don't die even if it looks like doing so would save the woman you love all noble-like."

"Fuck that shit," Catra smirked. "I'm not dying on you, Sparkles. I'm *surviving*. We'll have that whole, messy 'happily ever after' to deal with, after this is over."

"We sure will," Glimmer smirked. "Together."

They held each other's hands.

"Why does that prospect makes me more anxious than the fight?" Catra said after a moment.

"You're used to fighting," Glimmer said offhandedly. "You are not used to happily ever after." She smiled impishly. "Don't worry, I'll ease you into it."

"Oh, goodie," Catra muttered with a little blush.

"Hey," Glimmer said gently and sought Catra's eyes. "We'll figure it out."

"Of course we will," Catra agreed. "We made it this far."

They looked at each other in silence for a moment.

"Isn't it bullshit, though?" Catra said, nodding at the door.

"*Totally* bullshit," Glimmer agreed with heartfelt voice.

"Why can't they just hate us like normal people," Catra said with an eyeroll.

"'You are always worthy of friendship'," Glimmer said with a passing facsimile of Bow's voice.

"'I know you betrayed us and sent us to die, but I'll just hug you and hope it won't happen again'," Catra said with a pretty good impression of Scorpia.

They shook their head.

"Idiots," Glimmer muttered.

"*Our* idiots," Catra corrected her.

"Well, not *all* of them," Glimmer added in dark voice.

"We'll get Adora back," Catra said with determined voice.

"Fuck yeah we will," Glimmer agreed.

"But neither of us will leave the other for her, we won't sacrifice ourselves for each other and no one will die," Catra counted off her fingers.

"Yeah, and for whatever stupid reason, people won't hate us," Glimmer finished the list.

They laughed, a bit sheepish.

"Sounds simple enough," Catra shrugged.

"I can't imagine why it took us this long to figure it out," Glimmer shrugged.

"Yeah, because we are *so* well known for our emotional maturity," Catra leered.

"Oh, I don't know," Glimmer said and fingered the ear ring Catra had given her. "I think we're learning."

They hugged each other then, a hug that went on for a long, long time until Entrapta and Sea Hawk set fire to two completely different parts of the building complex and they had to sort it out.

- - -

"Best of luck," Glimmer said as Entrapta, Scorpia and Catra together with Emily entered the small vehicle that would take them at least to the edge of the Whispering Woods. "And be

careful. We don't know where Perfuma is, but as soon as Shadow Weaver figures out what you are up to, she'll be sure to send her against you."

"Don't worry about us," Sparkles," Catra growled. "We can take care of the flower princess. Watch your own butt."

"Why, do you think it's underappreciated?" Glimmer said loftily and wriggled slightly, causing Catra and Scorpia both to blush.

"Then we take our farewell as well," Sea Hawk said. "Come with me, my boy, I have secured a vessel for us from our lovely hosts."

"Don't set it on fire the first thing you do," Glimmer said drily as Bow - after a last goodbye hug - let Sea Hawk lead him towards the docks, where the Horde Fleet were busy setting sails.

"I can't hear you over the stiff breeze, my magnificent monarch," Sea Hawk cheerfully said.

"Don't die, idiot," Mermista called after them and limped towards the Horde ship together with Rogelio.

"We'll be off too," Spinnerella said. She looked Glimmer in the eyes. "Best of luck, *My Queen*."

"Yeah, knock her dead," Netossa leered.

"Thank you," Glimmer said with momentarily faltering voice.

And then they all left.

Glimmer watched them go. A lone figure in the very empty machine yard.

She sighed and draped the cape more firmly around her, suddenly cold.

She walked with slow steps through the echoing corridors of the Fright Zone, past the destroyed throne room, past the empty

sleeping quarters and back to the Black Garnet chamber.

There was someone standing outside it. A short person with black cape and pink hair.

"Finally I have lured them all away," the woman said. "No one's here to stop me anymore."

Glimmer stopped and crossed her arms.

"I know what I need to do," the woman continued, talking out in thin air without taking any notice of Glimmer. "But it scares me. I'm not sure if I will have the courage, when the moment comes."

"And what if I don't?" Glimmer said with low voice. The other Glimmer turned and looked at her with lavender eyes full of sparkles.

"Then you die, or worse, together with all those you love and try to protect," she said with eerily calm voice.

"What if I'm wrong?" Glimmer pressed. "What if I lead everyone down a path to death and destruction?"

"You mean like mommy used to worry about?" the other Glimmer said with a sarcastic smirk.

Glimmer couldn't help to laugh.

"Mommy issues might not be the best basis for a military strategy."

"Sure it is," the other Glimmer offhandedly said. "Just look how far it took the Kitten."

"I'm not sure either of us had the best role models for how to command an army," Glimmer said with dry voice.

"That's why you complement each other," the other Glimmer said. "That's why you made such a mess of things on your own, but

together..."

"I swear," Glimmer laughed. "You're just as soppy as Bow."

"Your boytoy knows what's up," the other Glimmer said offhandedly. She turned more sombre and looked Glimmer in the eyes.

"You told me once that Shadow Weaver asked you a question, back when you held her prisoner in Brightmoon."

"She asked me what kind of queen I wanted to be," Glimmer confirmed. "My answer was 'not my mother'."

"A heartfelt answers, I'm sure," the other Glimmer chuckled. "And now? What's your answer now?"

"Not Shadow Weaver either," Glimmer said without hesitation.

The other Glimmer nodded with a content expression.

"Then you'll end up a good queen, Glimmer," she said. "Even more, you will end up just the queen this world needs."

"Thanks, Double Trouble," Glimmer said with low voice. She raised an eyebrow. "I supposed I should be flattered for you putting on a private show for my benefit. But might I ask what brought it on?"

Double Trouble took their own guise and regarded her with serious expression.

"I know what you're going to do, Glimmer," they said.

She looked at them without blinking.

"Here to talk me out of it?" she asked, voice almost hopeful.

"Of course not," they scoffed. "I'm here to remind you that you can take her."

"You really have that much faith in me?" Glimmer asked with a sigh.

"Of course I do, my Queen," they smiled. "I've known from the start what you're capable of. You *and* the kitten."

"Well, for whatever it's worth - thank you," Glimmer said. She leaned forward and gave Double Trouble a light kiss on the cheek. "Thanks for believing in me. Thanks for believing in *us*."

"Think nothing of it," Double Trouble smirked and lightly touched their cheek. They bowed slightly and took a step back, leaving Glimmer with free passage through the door. "Now go and show her who's the boss."

"You better catch your ship," Glimmer said and entered the Black Garnet chamber.

The gem stood tall and imposing. It was cleared free of all the instruments and machines Hordak had connected, and which Glimmer and Jack later had repurposed. Equipment was flung around and there were scorch marks along the walls. Only the Black Garnet itself seemed unharmed.

Glimmer gave the runestone a long look, then she walked over to one side of the room, where a large mirror was covered by a piece of cloth. She took a deep breath and removed it.

From the mirror, her image looked back at her. A little princess playing at being a queen, clothes torn, skin bruised, but with fire in her eyes. Glimmer tilted her head back and forth, catching herself from different angles. She looked back at herself from the mirror. Covered by black cloth. Tall. Imposing. Shadows swirling around her. The mirror image smiled at her.

"It's high time for the two of us to talk, Queen Glimmer," Shadow Weaver said from the mirror.

"Yes, it is, Queen Shadow Weaver," Glimmer answered.

Chapter End Notes

Turns out, your kids *do* call you even if you're an evil bitch. Another win for Shadow Weaver.

The Shadow Queen of Brightmoon

Chapter Notes

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

Edit: This fic has a tvtrope page now, thanks to the amazing SanaNaryon. Don't hesitate to add to it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer watched the form of Shadow Weaver in her mirror.

Shadow Weaver watched the tiny queen, dwarfed by the towering form of the Black Garnet.

"So, you finally dared to make use of the connection between us," Shadow Weaver said. "You have worked so hard to kept it closed all these months."

"Yes. But now things are coming to an end," Glimmer noted.

"Perceptive, little Queen," Shadow Weaver answered from the mirror. Glimmer made a tired gesture at her eyes.

"Don't belittle me, please. Not you of all people."

"My apologies," Shadow Weaver said, and somehow managed to sound sincere. "I do hold you in the deepest respect."

"Really?" Glimmer said with a sceptical voice.

"Really," Shadow Weaver answered. "Your powers and your potential I have always known. I did however underestimate your resilience. What you have achieved with just the dregs you scraped from the bottom of the barrel is admirable."

"The dregs you left me with when you ran off with my barrel, you mean," Glimmer drily noted.

"Please," Shadow Weaver said in disdain. "If you don't want to be treated like a child, then don't whine like one. I took your power because I could, and because you didn't do what was needed to stop me."

"I'm not done yet," Glimmer said, the threat in her voice obvious.

"Yes, yes," Shadow Weaver sighed. "Spare me the bravado. We have more important things to discuss."

"Yes," Glimmer agreed after a moment of hesitation. "We do."

They regarded each other in silence.

"I turned out to be more than you could chew," Glimmer said after a little while.

"Yes," Shadow Weaver said without preamble. "I had expected you to die at the hand of Octavia or any other of Hordak's dogs. Or to perish in the wilderness. You proved me wrong."

"Me and *Catra* proved you wrong," Glimmer corrected her.

Shadow Weaver rolled her eyes but didn't comment.

"We forced you on the defence," Glimmer pressed. "We took back the sword. We took back Mermista. We freed the people stranded on Beast Island. We have the Horde in our pocket."

"You can't seriously tell me you see anything of value in that band of ruffians," Shadow Weaver snorted.

"You stayed with them for decades," Glimmer countered.

"And I dropped them the moment they stopped being useful to me," Shadow Weaver shot back.

"Well, they're still useful to me," Glimmer said with a smile full of teeth. "As you will notice when they tear down your castle wall."

"I thought you regarded it as your castle," Shadow Weaver said with snide voice.

"So what?" Glimmer laughed. "You expect me to beg? 'Pretty please, Shadow Weaver, can I please have my castle back."

"Yes," Shadow Weaver calmly answered. "You can have it back."

Glimmer gave her a sharp look.

"Just like that?" she said with voice dripping of suspicion.

"Yes," Shadow Weaver repeated. "We both know there are more important things at stake than this vanity of your mother's. If it hold such a sentimental value for you, by all means. You will have it back."

"You yield, then?" Glimmer asked.

"Of course not," Shadow Weaver snorted. "I have no further need for it."

"And the Moonstone?" Glimmer pressed. Shadow Weaver shrugged.

"You want your runestone back? I will give it to you."

Glimmer regarded Shadow Weaver in silence.

"What's the matter?" Shadow Weaver taunted. "Don't want it?"

Glimmer said nothing.

"Then you know? You know what will happen once all the runestones are connected, if the hologram of the first ones get her way," Shadow Weaver said, voice sincere.

"I've always regarded 'Balancing Etheria' to be a good thing," Glimmer said with low voice. "I suppose I should thank you, for keeping the Moonstone away from her."

"Everything is a matter of perspective, I suppose," Shadow Weaver said. "Apart from the Moonstone, the Black Garnet would be the last thing she needs. But then you know why you and me can't waste time on silly bickering. Not when there is bigger fish to fry."

"Can we stop her?" Glimmer asked, voice sincere. "Can we stop Light Hope?"

"I already have," Shadow Weaver answered, and her features flickered in the mirror.

Glimmer regarded her in silence.

"I see," she said eventually.

"Good," Shadow Weaver said, and a smile played over her lips. "There are times when I think you might not be a disappointment, after all."

"You say the nicest things," Glimmer muttered.

"Surely it does not come as a surprise," Shadow Weaver said.

"Not really," Glimmer sighed. "Not after I saw that you had opened the Heart of Etheria. I... I assumed that you had tricked Light Hope somehow, or maybe that you worked together, or..."

"Glimmer," Shadow Weaver chided. "Always thinking too small."

And with a crackle of electricity she stepped out of the mirror and towered over Glimmer. She seemed to grew taller, her features flickering like a hologram.

"You and me want the same thing," she thundered. "A balanced Etheria. The magic of this world under control of the elemental princesses, and the princesses under control of a single will. But not coded in hard crystals, a mere echo of long forgotten words of the First Ones. A living, worthy will. *My* will."

"The thumb on the scale," Glimmer said with weak voice. "I can see why that would appeal to you.

"Then you can see why this is necessary," Shadow Weaver said and held out her hand. "And why, even now, there is a place for you by my side. Join me, Glimmer. Help me balance our world."

- - -

Glimmer stared at the holographic Shadow Weaver that towered over her. Shadows flickered around her, and she was somewhat transparent.

"You have *become* Light Hope?" Glimmer asked, not able to keep a shiver from her voice.

"The hologram did a poor job to fulfil its function," Shadow Weaver said with disdain. "Now, will you finally end this foolish tantrum and take your rightful place as the elemental princess of the Moonstone?"

Glimmer took a shuddering step away from the outstretch hand.

"For the small, small price of becoming your slave, you mean?"

"You know better than that, Glimmer," Shadow Weaver tutted. "Mind control only gives you thugs. You are far more useful as a free, willing agent."

"And why would I be a 'willing agent'?"

"For the same reason as always," Shadow Weaver smiled. "You and me share the same goal."

Glimmer regarded Shadow Weaver in silence for a few moments.

"Yes," she eventually concurred.

"The enemy is at the gate," Shadow Weaver said. "Now as always. The Heart of Etheria holds the power to stop him for

good, but Light Hope would tear our world apart wielding it."

"And you?" Glimmer asked.

"I'd find better use for it than one, grand blast," Shadow Weaver said, voice proud.

"Given that you had full control of our world and it's people, I take it," Glimmer said.

"Naturally," Shadow Weaver shrugged. "I will keep them safe."

"You'll defeat our enemy, you mean," Glimmer shot shot back.

"What's the difference?" Shadow Weaver asked.

Glimmer regarded her in silence for a moment.

"That, at least, is a question I've always known the answer to."

"Semantics," Shadow Weaver snorted. "I *will* defeat Horde Prime."

Glimmer nodded.

"You might be able to do it," she said with small voice.

"Then, don't you think it's high time we set our differences aside and focus on the defence of our world?" Shadow Weaver asked.

"Catra is to remain free and unharmed," Glimmer immediately shot back.

"Why you all get so hung up on that wretched girl I'll never understand for the life of me," Shadow Weaver sighed. "But fine. If you truly find her of use, I will not stand in your way. Just keep her out of my sight."

"And Adora," Glimmer pressed.

"Adora has made her choices clear," Shadow Weaver sniffed. "Sadly, there are more important considerations to be made."

"Such as?" Glimmer asked suspiciously.

"She-Ra is an integral part of the magic flow of this planet. I cannot allow the lynchpin of our defence to hang on the whims of a foolish girl."

"And my father?" Glimmer said, voice small.

"Your father will join you as our agent," Shadow Weaver said. "Eventually. Once his loyalty has been ensured."

"You haven't broken him yet," Glimmer said and couldn't hide the sliver of hope in her voice.

"He's most stubborn," Shadow Weaver sniffed. "I've come to regard it as a family trait."

"I want to see him," Glimmer demanded.

"Nice try, little queen," Shadow Weaver smiled. "You will see him soon enough, but only if you give up this foolishness first and join me."

"I suppose that was to be expected," Glimmer sighed.

"You will come with me, then?" Shadow Weaver pressed.

"Of course not," Glimmer said in disdain. "Allow me to make you an counteroffer instead."

"Oh the confidence of young people," Shadow Weaver sighed. "By all means, little Queen, make me an offer I can't refuse. I'm all ears."

"Let Adora go," Glimmer said with serious voice. "Let Perfuma go. Let my father go. Let all the people you have bewitched in Brightmoon go. Renounce your claim on the Heart Blossom and the Moonstone and She-Ra's sword. Leave the Temple of the First Ones to Light Hope and close the door on your way out." She looked the hologram of Shadow Weaver in the eyes. "Walk into

the guest room. Pull up a cushion. Sit down with a book and wait until I come for you. Do all that and I will let you live."

"And why would I do all that?" Shadow Weaver scoffed.

"Because for all your machinations, you are not a conqueror," Glimmer calmly said. "You are no ruler, and for all you try to pretend otherwise, you are even a poor puppet master. How long did you hole up with Hordak, working fruitlessly on the Back Garnet? How long would you have been content with the status quo as my prisoner in Brightmoon, had not Scorpia and Double Trouble tipped your hand? You are letting your every advantage slip through your grip while you fruitlessly strive for a perfection you will never achieve. Even now, those of us that you thought of as your tools are working on your downfall. You will loose, Shadow Weaver, and soon. I offer you an alternative."

"As your prisoner?" Shadow Weaver said, scorn dripping from her every word."

"As my teacher," Glimmer calmly said. "As my guide and my warning example as I work to understand and contain the Heart of Etheria, and as I prepare our defences against Horde Prime."

"You can't be serious," Shadow Weaver flatly said.

"Why not?" Glimmer asked with sincere voice. "That was the offer I gave you from the start, wasn't it? It still stands. You are no ruler, Shadow Weaver, but you *are* a teacher. I'm giving you the chance to live up to the potential of the Light Spinner that once taught my father, rather than squander it as you've done all these years."

Shadow Weaver regarded her in silence, her mask giving away even less of her emotions than usual.

"I respectfully must decline," she said eventually.

"I know," Glimmer said. "But I wanted to give you a chance even so. Out of respect and as thanks."

Shadow Weaver arched an eyebrow.

"'Thanks'?"

"For being there," Glimmer said, voice suddenly small. "For listening to me. For taking me seriously. I needed that, when my mother died."

Shadow Weaver regarded her in silence for a few moments.

"You're welcome," she said with low voice.

Glimmer bent her head slightly.

They stood in silence, both of them waiting for the other to break it.

Neither of them breaking it.

"Can I ask you a question?" Glimmer said after a long moment.

"Yes," Shadow Weaver answered, voice gentle.

"What would you have done, were you in my place?" Glimmer asked, glancing almost bashfully at the hologram that towered over her.

"You are asking me for advice," Shadow Weaver said, slightly amused.

"Why wouldn't I?" Glimmer said with sincere voice. "You never hesitated to advice me before."

"If only my advice where actually received, this sorry world would be in a much better state," Shadow Weaver sniffed.

"Well, then advice me," Glimmer said with earnest voice, looking Shadow Weaver in the eyes. "I'm listening."

"Yield," Shadow Weaver answered immediately. "Come back to me, allow me to help you balance your connection to your

runestone. Stand by my side as we prepare the blow we will strike against our enemy together."

Glimmer shook her head.

"No, that's what you'd *have me do*. I asked what you would have *done*, were you in my place. You can't expect me to believe that you would bend your neck to anyone."

"I bent my neck to you, your majesty," Shadow Weaver said, with no mocking inflection of the last word.

"You betrayed me," Glimmer said without heat.

"Yes," Shadow Weaver answered without preamble, "because you left yourself vulnerable. I expect nothing less of you, should you find me in such a sorry state."

"That's all there is, then?" Glimmer said with just a shiver to her voice. "The rulers of the world climbing on each other's corpses, just like the thugs of the desert."

"I'm sure your little sabbatical in the dessert has been most educational," Shadow Weaver sniffed. "And of course that's all there is. The strong devouring the weak, the old trees falling for the storm to make way for the new. Power feeds on power. What else could there be?"

"Love?" Glimmer said with almost pleading voice. "Friendship? Loyalty? Responsibility? Shared causes? Shared burdens? Trust? Promises unbroken? A helping hand? A shared throne?"

"Surely you are not that native?" Shadow Weaver smirked.

"...I guess I am," Glimmer said, looking down at her feet. She took a deep breath and looked Shadow Weaver in the eyes again - the earlier vulnerability replaced by steel. "...but that doesn't mean I won't do what's needed to take you down."

"You have grown," Shadow Weaver said after a long moment, voice low. "Ironic, that it would be when I forced you off your throne you truly came into your own as a queen."

"Am I supposed to thank you for that?" Glimmer said.

"People rarely do," Shadow Weaver said. "One of many challenges motherhood offers."

Glimmer raised an eyebrow.

"'Motherhood'?" she asked.

"In a manner of speaking," Shadow Weaver said with a dismissive shrug. "Out of the four children I have found reason to invest myself in, you are the least disappointing one."

Glimmer gave her a bleak smile.

"I love you too, mommy," she said with a little girl's voice.

The hologram of Shadow Weaver flickered.

"You mock me," she said with silent voice.

"I guess I do," Glimmer said, not completely able to hide the tears in her eyes. "My offer stands, though. You and me *could* have a relationship based on other things than fear and force."

"Fear and force are the fundament respect is build on," Shadow Weaver said, slipping into her teaching voice. "'Love' or whatever you like to call it can bloom only once those fundaments are in place."

"That you think that explains so much," Glimmer shuddered.

"Young people tend to be sentimental," Shadow Weaver shrugged. "I don't hold it against you. It's one of many shortcomings you'll eventually outlive, given that you live."

"You do want me alive," Glimmer said with low voice.

"Yes," Shadow Weaver agreed.

"Yet you're stalling," Glimmer noted.

"I see no reason to rush this interaction," Shadow Weaver said. "Even if the conclusion is inevitable."

"Is it, now?" Glimmer said and took a step backwards. "You have tried and failed to get to me before."

"That is true," Shadow Weaver said. "But that was before you connected to the Black Garnet."

Glimmer gave the runestone behind her a quick, guilty look.

"You knew," she accused, voice slightly bitter.

"Of course I knew," Shadow Weaver said with a humourless smile. "I knew you wouldn't be able to resist the temptation, in the end. And I have positioned myself as the guardians of the runestones, after all. Did you truly think a princess would connect to the runestone of Arachnida without me knowing about it?"

"I guess not," Glimmer said. She held up her hand, electric lighting crackling around it. "Then you also know that I finally have the power needed to take you out."

"On the contrary," Shadow Weaver cried. "I have studied the Black Garnet for decades. I know all its secrets. By connecting to it, you have given me exactly the access to your brain I need to end this defiance once and for all." She stood impossibly tall, having to bow her head not to crash into the ceiling. She stretched out an enormous hand towards the small queen by the glowing gem.

Glimmer smiled.

"Have I?" she asked. She dropped a crystal rod out of her sleeve. "Have I really?"

Shadow Weaver frowned.

"What's the matter?" Glimmer mocked. "Can't find the entry-point to my brain? I thought it would be an easy feat for someone as versed in it's secrets as you."

"Whatever trick you think you might have..." Shadow Weaver begun, probing the smirking Glimmer with tendrils of shadows.

"No trick," Glimmer said, smile widening.

"The Black Garnet is connected," Shadow Weaver stated, talking more to herself than Glimmer.

"Not by me," Glimmer smirked.

Shadow Weaver gave her a look of utter loathing.

"If this is another attempt by that irksome meddler from Dryl..."

"Not by Entrapta either," Glimmer said, smile broadening.

Shadow Waver suddenly looked up and sharply turned to the mirror. The images seen in it flickered, and displayed the First One's temple. Red lighting trailed over the guard spiders, collapsing them.

"You can't seriously expect me to believe that you had all that power by your fingertips, and gave it to *her*," Shadow Weaver said, her voice quivering with fury.

"Oh, but I did. And I made you waste enough time on me for her to get into the temple. Tell me, Shadow Weaver," Glimmer said with a sweet smile. "After all of your 'decades of studies', how easy do you think it will be for you to gain access to the brain of the true princess of Arachnida, fully connected to her runestone?"

"Insolent child!" Shadow Weaver bellowed and threw herself back into the mirror, followed by Glimmer's mocking laughter that was

abruptly cut short by a shower of pink sparks as Glimmer teleported away.

- - -

"Wow," Scorpia said over in the First One's temple, looking at the power dancing over her claws. "That sure packed a punch." She turned to Catra and Entrapta who stared with mouths opened at the pile of dead spiders in front of them. "Let's go, besties!" she beamed. "Super Pal Trio, 'mIright?"

Chapter End Notes

> Dear readers, I want you all to imagine a perfectly bitchin' electric guitar solo at this point.

Super Pal Trio

Chapter Notes

> Warning: Fighting, suffocation, spiders and lots of property damage.
>
> Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.
>
> This fic has a tvtrope page now, thanks to the amazing SanaNaryon. Don't hesitate to add to it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Faaaaaascinating," Entrapta said, looking around with huge eyes at the crystals that shone from every direction.

"Yeah, fascinating," Catra muttered, looking around the First One's temple, ill at ease. "Let's hurry up before she..."

"WHY MUST YOU CONSTANTLY VEX ME!" Shadow Weaver cried as she materialized in front of them in a cloud of pink sparkles.

"...finds us," Catra sighed.

Shadow Weaver stood nearly twine as tall as usual. The shadows that surrounded her flickered on and off like a hologram. Catra frowned.

"Hey, where's the usual lady?" Catra quipped, making an urgent gesture to Entrapta to run - which Entrapta naturally ignored in favour of gaping at the new threat in fascination.

"Light Hope has served her purpose," Shadow Weaver drily remarked, as the shadows that surrounded her expanded throughout the room.

"Ominous," Catra remarked, walking slowly backwards (and dragging Entrapta with her) in order to get away from the

shadows.

"I will deal with you later, you infernal waste of space," Shadow Weaver hissed. "Where is the Arachnidan brat who has *dared* to befoul *my* runestone.

"You know Scorpia's name," Catra shot back - filing the fact that apparently Shadow Weaver did not automatically know the whereabouts of the people in the temple under 'interesting'. "And she is currently engaged elsewhe..."

"Hi guys," Scorpia said happily as she strolled down the corridor, electricity playing along her claws. "I cleaned up the spiders. Boy, were they mad. Is this Light Hope? I heard so much about... oh, hi Shadow Weaver."

"Scorpia," Shadow Weaver snarled, turning to the newcomer with a crackle of electricity. "You *dare* attach yourself to the Black Garnet?"

"Um.... yeah," Scorpia said, looking self conscious. "Glimmer said that I could... and it kinda *was* my mommies'...?"

She looked down on her claws with a bashful expression.

"THE ONLY THINGS THAT ARE YOURS ARE WHAT I TELL YOU ARE YOURS YOU UNDESERVING..." Shadow Weaver begun.

"Hey, 'mom', let me interrupt you right there, because there's something I need to tell you," Catra said with casual voice. With an underhand throw she tossed a little metallic cylinder towards the holographic figure.

"*What?*" Shadow Weaver snarled.

"FUCK YOU!" Catra cried at the same time as the electric shock grenade went off, frizzling the connecting and shutting down the hologram.

"Wow, that worked like a charm," she said and gave the giggling Entrapta a warm grin. "Well done, Entrapta."

"Awww," she said with bashful voice. "I simply hypothesized that the holographic emitters would be susceptible to..."

"Yes, yes, you're very clever," Catra interrupted. "But right now I need you to get working on getting access." She turned to Scorpia. "Bring Entrapta wherever she needs to be. And bash any spiders in the way. I'll keep Shadow Weaver occupied."

"How are you going to do that?" Scorpia frowned. "Isn't it me and Entrapta she wants?"

"I've had a life time learning how to get on her nerves," Catra smirked and grabbed She-Ra's sword from Emily's back. "Now RUN!"

And she sprinted down the corridors, with red light blinking and warning sounds blaring.

- - -

Children truly were not worth the effort. Shadow Weaver stalked through the Temple of the First One's, her consciousness firmly embedded in the holographic visage of herself. She had yet to master the omniscience she felt her status required, but that was just a temporary setback. More importantly was to get She-Ra's runestone back, and to do that she had to deal with...

"What's the matter?" Catra taunted, sprinting around a corner. "Too slow?"

"I control the environment of this facility," Shadow Weaver countered, causing a door to close just in front of Catra. "Your juvenile tantrums are - now as always - not the grand gesture you'd like to think."

"Yeah that's not how you made it sound when I landed you in a cell," Catra countered and slid through a small opening originally

designed for spiders. "Remember, when me, Scorpia and Entrapta stole the rock just in front of your nose. Happy memories."

"I do remember your inability to leverage the situation into a sustainable gain, as always mistaking spite for an actual achievement," Shadow Weaver replied and melted through the door."

"Are you saying that my mommy should have taught me better?" Catra mocked, scrambling down a corridor.

"I'm saying you were not worth the effort," Shadow Weaver replied and - reaching out her mind - found the correct node for activating the ancient temple defence system. She had the great satisfaction of hearing Catra yelp and then come running back the corridor, several biomechanical spiders in hot pursuit.

"So sad to have inconvenienced you," Catra panted and jabbed a stun baton towards Shadow Weaver. She felt the electricity interfere with her holographic emitters and quickly took a step back.

"As if there is anything in this world you derive more joy from," Shadow Weaver snorted and glided after Catra down a dark hallway.

"There is, actually, but you always seem to try to take it from me," Catra snorted back.

"You always aim beyond your station," Shadow Weaver sniffed. "Just imagine, you thinking you are good enough for Micah's daughter."

"She has a name, you know," Catra pointedly said.

"An uninspired name given her by a foolish father and an unworthy mother," Shadow Weaver countered. "I suppose I shouldn't be surprised of her choice in rutting with you, given the example her father set. At least he had the good taste of

projecting his romantic follies on a partner in possession of a power worthy of his own, however undeserved."

"Are you saying I'm marrying up?" Catra asked, "because I'm totally there with you, mommy."

"I'm saying that out of all the mistakes Micah's daughter have made, you are the worst," Shadow Weaver snarled. "The good news is, you, at least, I can do something about." From her hands, a stream of blue, electric light flew.

Catra just evaded the stream and slipped through a small service duct.

"Joke's on you," she mocked. "Turns out, Glimmer kinda like it rou... hey!"

An impossibly long arm stretched through the duct, grabbing her. She was dragged back to a find the corridor she just had fled to be full of spiders.

"Got you!" Shadow Weaver snarled.

"Enjoy it while it last," Catra snarled back, desperately trying to avoid the large number of pinchers that tried to reach her.

"I can't convey," Shadow Weaver said, leaning over the furiously struggling Catra, "how satisfying it is to finally get rid of y..."

Then Shadow Weaver said nothing, on account of her holographic form being torn asunder by a forceful blast of electricity.

Well, not only Shadow Weaver's holographic form. The lighting bolts also tore through the spiders, short-circuiting them or outright ripping them to pieces.

Well, not only Shadow Weaver's holographic form and the spiders. The very structure of the corridor exploded with pieces of debris flying everywhere, crystals smashing and plate from floor and walls crashing into each other.

Catra looked around at the destruction, mouth gaping open.

"Oooopsie, sorry," Scorpia said, lowering her claws. "I still don't really know how to find the stun setting of this thing... um, Entrapta asked me to get the sword, so I just wanted to check if you're busy or if I can...?"

"We're good, Scorpia," Catra managed to get out. "Thanks."

Painfully she got to her feet and limped after Scorpia, who after a moment simply lifted Catra up and carried her, as easily as if she had been a rag doll.

- - -

Thrice cursed that girl! And the Scorpion king's grand daughter. Not for the first time Shadow Weaver regretted not simply poisoning her when she had the chance.

Both of them, really.

Well, at least the Scorpion girl was a problem she could do something about. Shadow Weaver - her consciousness temporarily back in her Brightmoon self again - stalked over to the Heart Blossom.

"Get to the temple of the First One's" she snarled at the Plumerian Princess through the mental connection. "Kill the scorpion princess!"

- - -

"I have located the main interface node!" Entrapta reported, beaming with her entire face. "There is a crystal matrix that uses an unusual command structure and the overlaying networking solution is archaic at best, but..."

"Just tell me if you can do it," Catra cried, prepared to duck spiders at any moment.

"What? Of course!" Entrapta happily said. "All I have to do is to insert the sword aaaaaaand..."

Everything went black.

"Oooops," Entrapta cheerfully said from the darkness. "Well, that's the fun part of the scientific process, eh?"

"I can make light now," Scorpia helpfully said.

"NO!" Catra cried - a moment too late as Scorpia released an electric spark that bounced along the corridor and ended up smashing a crystal.

"Sorry..." Scorpia said bashfully.

"Of all the fucking..." Catra begun, but then she took in Scorpia's hunched posture and scared eyes. She took a deep breath

"...sorry," she said between clenched teeth. "I appreciate that you're trying to help, Scorpia, but I think right now, light is more of a job for..."

Suddenly the corridor was bright lit by an industrial torch. Emily proudly bobbed back and forth, holding up her torch.

"...yeah, well done," Catra said. She turned to Scorpia again.

"Look.... this is a stressful time, for all of us," Catra said again, "and I realize that we all... some of us more than others... have bad habits we try to unlearn. What I mean to say is that I do appreciate your contribution, and..."

"DIE, WRETCHED CHILD!" Shadow Weaver bellowed as she materialized out of thin air.

"Oh thank the stars," Catra muttered and fired an electric gun (thanks, Entrapta) at the hologram, disrupting it. "I'll keep her occupied," she yelled and scampered away down the corridor. "You keep Entrapta safe!"

"Of course!" the seriously flustered Scorpia yelled. "You can count on me, Wildcat." She took a protective step closer to Entrapta, who was typing on a terminal, seemingly oblivious to anything else.

The temple of the first one was creepy, with weird sounds and light and smell coming from everywhere. Scorpia very sternly reminded herself that she was a princess now. Well, she supposed she had always been a princes, but now she was connected to her runestone. *She* was the scary one, not whatever creepy crawlies lied hidden away in the corners of this weird ruin.

She clacked her claw once to reassure herself. A spark emerged and earthed itself in Entrapta's hair, causing her to giggle.

"Sorry, sorry," Scorpia quickly said.

"It's fiiiine," Entrapta said and flipped up her welding mask, giving Scorpia a friendly grin. "Hey, look at this!"

Scorpia and Emily leaned over her to get a closer look at the weird symbols on her terminal.

"Um.... pretty?" Scorpia ventured.

"I know, right!" Entrapta enthusiastically answered. "I made it a feedback loop so I don't manually have to maintain the data input."

"Oh! Um... good?" Scorpia loyally answered.

"Thaaaaaanks," Entrapta said. "Only, the system keeps firewalling me."

"Oh... that's bad," Scorpia said, glancing nervously at the walls.

"It doesn't have to be," Entrapta answered and typed a few commands. "Not if I can find the connection points and reroute... hm... but then I'd have to..." as she spoke, her hair started to pull crystals out of their sockets and quickly rearrange their order. The

light flickered and Scorpia could swear she heard something move in the corners.

"Can... can you do that?" she ventured.

Entrapta gave her a surprised look.

"Do what?" she asked.

"Um... that re-route thing you talked about?"

Entrapta stared at the crystal connections for a moment, as if only now becoming aware of what her hair was doing.

"That's brilliant!" she whispered.

"It... is?" Scorpia asked, determined to hold her own in the conversation.

"I'd need to account for the changed refraction," Entrapta mumbled, "and I'd have to increase the power level to compensate for... hm...."

She looked up at Scorpia.

"Hey, Scorpia," she breathed. "Could you unleash a continuous high-frequency electrical current into the crystal matrix?"

"Um... do what?" Scorpia asked, bewildered.

Entrapta flipped on her mask again. Emily recognized the signs and hastily scrambled away.

"ZAP THE CRYSTALS!" Entrapta shrieked.

"Oh... OK, I can do that," Scorpia said and unleashed the tiniest spark she was capable, mindful of the destruction she usually caused.

The crystals lit up like firework. Scorpia could see bright light of multiple different colours travel along what looked eerily like veins

in the ceiling.

"Yeeeees!" Entrapta breathed from her terminal, typing furiously with both hands and hair. She flipped open her mask again and gave Scorpia a maniac grin. "Again! *More*!"

"Are you sure...?" Scorpia asked.

Entrapta's grin grew wider.

"*Much* more."

"If you're sure..." Scorpia said and held up her claw again.

She unleashed her powers. It felt... strange. Like having walked slowly your whole life and then one day learning that she could run.

Entrapta's laughter echoed through the corridors as the magic of Arachnida streamed into the crystals of the First One's temple.

- - -

"I would have given you everything, you spoiled brat," Shadow Weaver hissed.

"What are you talking about? You gave me shit and nothing," Catra countered, scrambling along the ceiling.

"I took you in. I raised you. I clothed you. I fed you."

"Nuhu, the *Horde* clothed and fed me," Catra pedantically corrected her. "Ration bars and standard issue child uniform."

"I took you under my wings," Shadow Weaver shouted as she stalked after Catra. "I made you strong."

"*I* made me strong," Catra countered. "You were just a shit parent. Don't confuse the two."

"You would not have survived a day in the Horde without me," Shadow Weaver snarled.

"Look who's talking," Catra taunted. "You spent decades doing Hordak's drudge work just to stay relevant. And the minute we threw you out, you ran to the next gal you could leech on. Administrator with an illusion of grandeur, that's what Hordak called you. Still beats being a private tutor in Brightmoon, I suppose."

"As undignified as playing to little girls' egos might be," Shadow Weaver said as she stalked closer, "at least in the second case I did not have to deal with you."

"Well, joke's on you," Catra laughed, "because I'm totally fucking your star pupil."

"As seemingly have been your ambition all along," Shadow Weaver hissed. "I hope you are happy."

"You know..." Catra said, pensively, stopping to look the approaching Shadow Weaver in the eyes, "I actually am. Isn't it weird?"

"You are not the first young person to mistake hormones for happiness," Shadow Weaver snorted derisively.

"Well, you're not the first old hag to try to stop me from being happy... oh, wait - you were," Catra answered. "And you're remarkably bad at it."

"Well then," Shadow Weaver hissed, voice like poisoned honey, "maybe we should bring this conversation to the *other* one of my protégés you lusted over. See how she feels about your newfound martial bliss while I deal with the Arachnidan brat."

"Wait, what?" Catra said, suddenly uncertain, as steps were heard in the corridor, and Adora walked straight through Shadow Weaver's holographic form and towards Catra, a staff in her hands, eyes full of shadows.

- - -

"Do you want me to continue, or...?" Scorpia asked.

"You're doing fiiiiiine!" Entrapta shrieked, rapidly moving crystals around with hands and hair, as electrical currents flooded the corridor.

"Oh, that's good," Scorpia said with a little chuckle. "Only, there are more spiders coming, so I thought maybe I should... deal with that?"

Still continuously emitting electricity from her claws, she held out her pincher and pointed it in the direction of the approaching spiders. She released another stream of sparks through her stinger - oh, she didn't know she could do that - and several of the spiders fell to the ground, twitching.

"Emily is on it," Entrapta ensured, and without waiting for any further signals, Emily trotted down the corridor, waving a blaster and a chainsaw.

"...good," Scorpia said as the enthusiastically beeping robot went loose on the spiders.

She glanced at the ceiling.

"Only, maybe we should hurry, because there's a lot of noise coming from the crawl space, and usually I'd have thought it were you but seeing as it isn't you maybe we should... oh!"

A panel burst loose and a moment after, Scorpia and Entrapta were both engulfed in plant tendrils emerging in a never ending flood from the crawl space.

- - -

"Um, I suppose it wouldn't help to ask you to snap out of it?" Catra asked and took a few step backwards from the steadily approaching Adora.

Instead of answer, Adora jabbed hard with the staff towards Catra's face, and immediately changed the direction of her blow downwards when Catra brought up her arms to block the blow. Catra just barely managed to jump backwards to avoid being hit in the stomach, and that gave Adora time for a follow-up blow, forcing Catra on the retreat again.

"Didn't think so," Catra muttered and took a leap against a wall, aiming to slip up in the vents (thanks for the idea, Entrapta).

Before she got that far, however, Adora had taken two big strides and - using her staff as a pole vault - kicked Catra hard in the ribs, causing her to fall to the floor with a snarl. She quickly scrambled to her feet. But as she did, Adora was over her again.

She fought hard, efficiently and in deadly silence.

With raising apprehension, Catra realized she had forgotten just how fast and strong Adora could be when she didn't hold back.

- - -

"Um, sorry," Scorpia said and cut another vine with her claws. "Sorry... these are really nice vines... um, just don't want you to kill us, no offence."

"Scorpia!" Entrapta cried, half encased in leaves. "I'm getting a branching error!"

"I'm on it!" Scorpia said and quickly cut the vines that snaked into the cable ducts the tech princess worked on. A few more snips with her claws, and Entrapta was free.

"Ooooh, that hurt," she cheerfully said.

"Sorry about that," Scorpia said bashfully. "I don't want to hurt her."

"It's OK," Entrapta said. "I'm sure she's more bark than byte." With a snicker at her own joke, she returned to her comm pad. It

was connected to a series of outlets in the temple wall by several thick cables. Writing flicked down the screen faster than Scorpia could read.

Scorpia glanced around with a worried expression. Vines snaked in from all directions, but she still hadn't seen Perfuma. The thought made her anxious for reasons that didn't only have to do with defending her friends (and herself) against a horribly powerful foe that wanted them dead.

"Entrapta...?" she said with hesitation in her voice.

"Mmmmm?" Entrapta asked, typing furiously with hands and hair at two different keyboards.

"Have you ever... um... you know...?"

"I might," Entrapta cheerfully said. "I've done tons of stuff."

"I was thinking on..." Scorpia blushed. "Um... have you ever felt you wanted to... get to know anyone... better?"

"You mean like making friends?" Entrapta brightly asked. "I have so much data on that. Do you want to see diagrams?"

"Maybe later," Scorpia quickly said. "I think more of like... when you... *like* like someone."

Entrapta look up from the screen and gave Scorpia a *very* knowing look.

"Are you asking me about *interfacing*?" she asked with a downright teasing tone to her voice.

"Um...." Scorpia blushed.

They were interrupted but a rapidly beeping Emily, and a moment later an entire section of wall was torn away and a flood of vines flowed towards them.

"Go tell her!" Entrapta smirked.

- - -

"Hey, just so you know," Catra said, "We're getting you out of this shit."

Adora didn't answer. Instead she made a quick series of blow that ended with Catra getting a painful strike at her leg.

It wasn't dangerous in itself, but it slowed her down - which in a fight like this could be completely lethal.

"I've seen it before," Catra went on, aiming with her whip at Adora's legs. "With Huntara and the mermaid princess. Sparkles really knows her stuff."

Adora quickly blocked the whip with her staff - making it twist around it - and pulled, forcing it out of Catra's hand.

"So what I'm saying," Catra said, glancing at the walls and trying to figure out if her legs would handle another jump - we've got your back. Shadow Weaver wont' mess with your head for much longer."

"You couldn't just let us be happy, could you?" Adora asked as she closed the distance between them and lashed out with her staff.

"What? You and Shadow Weaver?" Catra said bewildered. "You ran away from us first, remember? And we will save her from you again."

"No, not Shadow Weaver," Adora hissed. "*Glimmer*."

She jabbed with her staff towards Catra's face, but feinted in the last moment and hit her in the ribs instead. Catra cursed and quickly moved backwards, partly rolling with the punch.

"Oh..." Catra said, a sinking feeling in her stomach.

- - -

"Entrapta!" Scorpia cried in fear as she tried to force herself past the branches that tore at her from every direction, to help her friend.

"Getoffmegetoffmegetoffme!" Entrapta cried, scrambling furiously to finish her work as her hair tangled with the vines.

"I will try to..." Scorpia begun, but her voice trailed off as a large flower suddenly budded from the nearest vine. Before she could react to it, a cloud of pollen was released right in her face.

"Ooooh..." she mumbled, suddenly feeling light-headed. "I think this is bad..." She severed the flower from it's stem, but as on cue, several more flowers opened, releasing more pollen. Scorpia saw the air shimmer in front of her eyes and had a hard time to stay upright.

"It's beautiful..." she whispered as another large flower emerged. "*You're* beautiful," she added as the flower opened and revealed Perfuma sitting in it, pale green tendrils growing from her veins and connecting her to the flower stamen.

The Plumerian princess was much thinner than what's healthy, and black veins all over her body were clearly seen through her pale skin. Her eyes were full of shadows, but as she heard Scorpia's words, she blinked a few times, her eyes regaining her normally dark colour.

"You really think so?" she asked with coquettish voice.

"Uuuuuurgh!" Shadow Weaver cried in disgust through Perfuma's mouth and the Shadows poured into her eyes again. Plant tendrils shot out towards the Scorpion princess who stilled smiled a dumbfounded smile at Perfuma.

A furious beeping brought her back to the fight. She realized that Emily was entirely ensnared in vines, and that they were rapidly crushing her.

"Not good..." she mumbled. She held up her claw and unleashed a lighting bolt towards the vines. Some of them let go, but most of them kept their grip as the majority of the electricity was absorbed by Emily, the round bot freezing completely.

"Oooops," Scorpia said. "Sorry about that."

"Your childish attempts at magic is a mockery of..." Shadow Weaver begun, but her voice trailed off Emily started to vibrate faster and faster.

"Yeeeeeeeeeees!" Entrapta laughed, upside down with her hair entirely entangled in vines.

"Oh, um, what did I do?" Scorpia said with guilty voice.

"You super-charged her!" Entrapta shrieked, at the same time as Emily violently started to spin around, beeping like a bomb set to explode, slashing vines right and left.

"Oh... that's good, right?" Scorpia said hopefully.

"It's eeeexcellent," Entrapta ensured her as the robot tore through the vines, slashing left and right with her legs. Some of the faster vines tried to ensnare her, but as they did, a little hatch opened and a muzzle emerged. Scorpia stared at it, her brain desperately trying to make sense of the scorch marks around the opening. In the end, a reflex honed by spending time with Entrapta kicked in, and she threw herself to the floor at the very last moment before Emily started to spew fire in every direction.

- - -

"I loved her," Adora snarled, a venom in her voice Catra had never heard before. "She took me in when I had *nothing*. She believed in me when *you* didn't. She showed me that things could be *better*."

"Better than with me," Catra said with low voice, carefully walking backwards, not taking her eyes off Adora's staff.

"Better than the Fright Zone. Better than the *Horde*," Adora shot back. "Better than *all* of it. She worked so hard to stop it. To make things better for *everyone*. I wanted so much to bring you with me. To share it all with you. But you wouldn't let me. You would rather have everyone be *miserable* than for me to be happy with someone who wasn't you."

She smashed her staff towards Catra's chest. Catra just managed to jump to the side.

It still felt like it had connected.

"Yeah, that pretty much sums it up," she admitted. "For what it's worth... I'm sorry."

"Not sorry enough," Adora snarled, shadows dripping from her eyes. "But you will be."

She charged again.

- - -

"...wow," Scorpia said, staring after the wrecking ball that was Emily and the trail of destruction she left in her wake. It was easier to think now that the fire had burnt away most of the pollen.

"Making mommy proud," Entrapta proudly said.

"I'll go after Perfuma," Scorpia said. "Do you need anything for that hack thing?"

"I'm all set!" Entrapta said, already reconnecting up her comm pad to the crystals surrounding the sword.

"And... if I save Perfuma I'll..." Scorpia said, hoping against hope that an end to that sentence would present itself.

Entrapta looked up and gave her a coy smile.

"Hey, Scorpia," she said with warm - although slightly teasing - voice.

"Y-yeah?" Scorpia said.

"Girls like a gal who can swoop them off their feet."

She blinked at her.

Heavily blushing, Scorpia fled the room.

- - -

"For what it's worth," Catra panted, having kept one step ahead of Adora's onslaught, "Glimmer loves you too."

"As if you'd know," Adora snorted.

"She's pretty shit at hiding it," Catra said with mock flippant voice. "And, hey, it's not like I don't get her. I mean..." she gestured at Adora and ducked another blow.

"You took her from me," Adora said, voice full of bitterness.

"Yeah," Catra admitted. "Sorry. It wasn't really planned but... hey, it's not like I don't get you too." She gave Adora a conspiratorial little wink. "That ass, am I right?"

For a moment - just a moment - Adora gave her a surprised look, and then a little goofy smirk. There was even a hint of a blush on her face.

Catra took a little jump forward.

"So, let's not overcomplicate this," she said, feinting a blow and gently poking Adora in the ribs when she failed to follow up in time. "I took your girl. Big deal. I've been stealing your shit since we were kids, and you always kicked my ass for it in the ring." She gestured around at the trashed temple corridor. "This is just

as good a ring as any. Let's blow off some steam. Come kick my ass. This time you have *really* earned it."

Adora grinned at her, through the shadows.

"You're on, Kittycat," she smirked.

- - -

"Um... Perfuma?" Scorpia said, looking nervously around the empty corridors. There were plants everywhere - more often than not badly burnt by Emily's rampage, but she couldn't see the flower princess herself.

"I... I just wanted to say that you were really nice to me in Brightmoon..." Scorpia hopefully went on. "That salad you gave me was very thoughtful, and I really liked it by the way, now when I've had time to think of it (and have lived on bugs for months). You listened to me and gave me a chance and I'm sorry for stinging you and... um..." Scorpia peered around another corner. "Um... what I mean to say is that I think I..."

"DIE, URSURPER!" Perfuma cried with Shadow Weaver's voice as she hurled herself towards Scorpia, plant tendrils exploding from every part of the corridor.

"Sorry..." Scorpia squealed as she waved desperately around her with claws and pincer, doing her best to avoid hitting Perfuma herself. She felt the vines snake around her, and despite her struggles she felt herself get more and more entangled.

- - -

Adora pushed Catra roughly backwards. Catra instinctively brought her hands up, caught the blow, feint left... she could have followed up with her claws, but she didn't.

They must have roughed around like this a thousand times when they were kids. Next Adora would...

Adora grabbed her hands in a pretend attempt to hold her down, while she in reality allowed Catra to use her momentum to flip her around, so they could tumble together...

Catra looked up in Adora's open, friendly *blue* eyes. There were no sign of shadows. Only her.

Only Adora.

"...hey Catra," Adora said with a goofy grin.

"...hey Adora," Catra answered. She felt Adora's weight on her, but she made no attempt to wriggle free.

"...I'm sorry," Adora said.

"What for?" Catra asked, not entirely sure what new kind of deception this was, but not entirely unwilling to let it play out.

"I don't know," Adora sighed. "Must have been something, the way you tried so hard to hurt me,"

Ah. *that* kind of deception.

"Yeah, about that," Catra sighed and moved slightly to be able to tear loose when she needed to, "I really didn't take rejections all that well."

"I didn't reject you," Adora protested. "I just..."

Catra watched her in silence.

"I just... had something I had to do," Adora finished lamely.

"Did you?" Catra said with low voice. "Really?"

"The Horde... has to be stopped," Adora mumbled. "It's evil."

"I'm evil, I get it," Catra sighed.

"No!" Adora protested. "Not you. You're just misguided or... confused or..."

"Hey, big talk from the girl who's literately mind-controlled by an evil witch," Catra snorted.

She smiled at Adora.

"Hey..." she said with gentle voice.

"...hey," Adora answered after a moment of hesitation.

"I get it," Catra said gently. "I've run away with the pretty princess too, you know."

"It wasn't like that," Adora blustered, suddenly red in the face.

"Suuuuuuure it wasn't," Catra grinned, the her voice grew gentle. "It's OK," she said, somewhat wistful. "I kinda wish you'd have brought me with you, but - hey, I was a bitch. Not much you could do about it."

"Don't call yourself that," Adora protested.

"It's true and you know it," Catra smirked. "And you were totally right - the Horde is shit and the Fright zone sucks. You were better off leaving."

"Not without you," Adora whispered, and tears formed in her eyes. "I never wanted to..."

"Yeah, yeah," Catra interrupted. "I know. It's OK."

Adora stared at her, eyes huge.

"Is it?" she whispered, voice barely audible.

"Yeah, it is," Catra answered with warm voice. "Fuck if I know how, but... it can all be OK. Me and Glimmer..." she saw a moment of panic flicker through Adora's features "...love each other," she quickly went on and saw an all too familiar pang of

rejection in Adora's face. "And we love you. We will... sort it out, somehow," she added a bit sheepishly.

"...me to?" Adora said with little girl's voice.

"You too," Catra promised. "There's just one thing we have to do first..."

"...what's that?" Adora said with scared voice.

"We need to defeat Shadow Weaver," Catra firmly said. "And you can help us."

"I don't think I can," Adora whispered, glancing behind her in fear.

"Always the goody-two-shoe, eh?" Catra teased.

"No," Adora protested. "It's..."

"Yeah, yeah, I get it," Catra said with gentle voice. "The mind control."

She crawled up and sat next to the trembling Adora.

"It's OK," she whispered. "This is the way it's always been, hasn't it? You, trying to do good with Shadow Weaver pulling your strings. Me, being a little shit to distract you from it, to give you some space to be *you*. Nothing has changed, she's just tightened the screws now, that's all." She leaned closer, right into Adora's field of vision.

"I can still be the bad girl you need," she whispered. "Me and Glimmer. We will get you out. Even Shadow Weaver won't be able to stop us."

- - -

Plant tendrils were everywhere. Scorpia lashed out with claws and tail in every direction, but every time she cut a tendril there always seemed to be another. She felt them tangle around her

legs, her arms, her neck. In desperation she unleashed a bolt of lighting and saw with slight guilt how the vines burnt away. But they were immediately replaced. Buds opened up on the burnt husks and new sprouts filled the room. And all the time, the scent of flowers and pollen made the air hard to breath.

"Perfuma!" Scorpia croaked between coughs. "I'm sorry..."

"You will be sorry," Perfuma hissed and stepped into Scorpia's field of vision. The vines that held Scorpia tightened their grip hard enough felt her chitin plates starting to buckle.

"Now die," Perfuma said, voice almost gentle. Scorpia stared into her shadow filled eyes and shuddered as the vines tightened around her throat again. This time she was unable to fight them off.

"Um..." Scorpia said as the vines choked her. "I'm not sure if this is a good time, but I have this friend named Bow... of course, he's your friend also, sorry about that... anyway, I thought maybe it would be to forward but he said I should just go for it and..." Scorpia took a deep breath and casually broke some of the vines holding her down so she could look Perfuma right into the shadow-filled eyes. "Um... I just wanted to ask if... um, if you don't mind... if you'd like to... go out with me, some time?"

She gave Perfuma a hopeful, anxious little smile as the vines closed in around her windpipe.

Perfuma blinked, all shadows gone from her eyes.

"I... I'd like that very much," she said with a coquettish little blush.

That was when Emily's grappling arm smashed into Perfuma's head from behind, knocking her out cold.

She beeped a long sequence of sounds that meant she was very sorry, I'm sure.

- - -

Hormonal teenagers! Would it that Shadow Weaver could redesign this entire, sorry excuse for a species so they reproduced asexually, perhaps then things would progress in a sane and rational manner for five minutes at the time.

She was vaguely aware of activity in the Brightmoon Castle. Her defences activating, her prisoners being removed from her control, even that annoying horse being mercifully quiet in her mind for once; but she ignored it. She could deal with all that later.

Fuming, she let her conscious slip away from the now worthless Heart Blossom. She would reconnect the Plumerian brat later. Let the Arachnida usurper think she had gained something for now. She didn't matter. *None* of them mattered.

All that mattered now was to kill the infernal tinkerer from Dryl before she did lasting damage to *her* temple.

- - -

"Glimmer..." Adora whispered, voice full of fear.

"She's safe," Catra promised. "I'll not let anyone hurt her."

"Not even me?" Adora said with small voice.

"I promise," Catra said, looking Adora firmly in the eyes. "And she won't let your hurt me, and neither of us will let anyone hurt you. It'll all work out."

A shiver went through Adora's body, and Catra saw the shadows melt away, like frost in sunlight.

"Thank you," she whispered.

Then she fell to the ground, completely spent.

- - -

From nowhere, Shadow Weaver manifested and towered over the furiously typing Entrapta.

"I will finally end your infuriating meddling, you little nuisance," Shadow Weaver snarled. "What do you have to say about *that*?"

Entrapta pressed a final button and looked up at Shadow Weaver with a happy smile.

"Reboot" she chirped.

"What?" The spectral witch hesitated. "What do you mean with 'reboot'?"

At that very moment, the crystal cavern became pitch dark. Shadow Weaver stumbled to the floor as the powers she swam in abruptly turned off.

"Reboot!" Entrapta happily repeated. "*And* original user privileges restored."

From nowhere, as if someone had flicked on a light switch (which in many ways was a fitting analogy), Light Hope stood among them, tall, imposing and glaring at Shadow Weaver.

"Intruder detected," she said, and from every corner of the temple, the sound of chitin against stone could be heard.

"We had a deal!" Shadow Weaver shouted.

"There is no data of a 'deal' in my memory banks," Light Hope coldly answered.

"Hah," Entrapta said with a smug little smile.

"You have not won yet," Shadow Weaver snarled and disappeared. She rematerialized next to Adora and grabbed her arm. Pink light started to play around her.

"Oh no you fucking don't!" Catra yelled and leaped forward. She grabbed the hem of Shadow Weaver's robe, and together with them, disappeared in a cloud of pink sparkles.

- - -

Deep below the castle, illuminated by glittering crystals, was the royal chamber. Glimmer entered the chamber with even steps.

On the floor laid the beast of the crypt, the ancient guardian of the Royal Line of Brightmoon, slain, clear blood oozing from a long cut along its belly.

A trail of blood went from the dead monster to some low stairs. Glimmer's eyes followed the trail, to the man sitting on the steps, watching her with eyes full of shadows.

"Hello, 'pumpkin'," Micah smirked.

"Hello, daddy," Glimmer said with steady voice.

They regarded each other in silence for a moment.

Then the chamber flooded with magic as the duel began.

Chapter End Notes

COULD I have written the final fight without flirting? I suppose so. But why would I ever want to do that?

Siege of Brightmoon

Chapter Notes

Warning: Brainwashing and fighting

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

This fic has a tvtrope page now, thanks to the amazing SanaNaryon. Don't hesitate to add to it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The night was dark and the shadows deep. Two lone, cloaked figures moved in silence from hiding place to hiding place until they reached a small hill overlooking the dark city before them.

"Brightmoon," Bow said with sad voice. Sea Hawk put a hand on his shoulder.

The once so shiny city was covered in darkness. *Things* moved between the empty houses, hidden by mist. Bleak light from the moonstone made the shadows deeper.

"We need to be absolutely silent," Bow whispered as they started to sneak down towards the city.

"Of course," Sea Hawk answered.

"Naturally," Jack said.

"Wouldn't dream of anything else," Frosta agreed.

"AAAAAAH!" Bow cried, jumping and turning at the same point, which didn't end well.

"What are you two doing here?" Sea Hawk cried, for once taken aback.

"Following you," Jack explained.

"Duh," Frosta added, rolling her eyes.

"You can't be here," Bow gasped, getting to his feet. "It's too dangerous."

Jack, Frosta and Sea Hawk all gave him severely unimpressed looks.

"Don't deny youth their adventure, my lad," Sea Hawk said with a disappointed head-shake.

"*We* are dangerous," Frosta bragged.

"We will just sneak in by ourselves if we can't come with you," Jack pointed out.

Bow couldn't hold back a smile.

"You've spent time with Glimmer, haven't you," he said with warm voice, not entirely devoid of nostalgia.

"How could you tell?" Jack said with a cheeky grin.

Bow chuckled and ruffled their hair.

"Fine," he amended. "You can come." He smiled at Frosta. "I have to admit I'll feel a lot better if you're here to protect me."

She grinned at him, and together they sneaked down what once had been one of many quaint little sideways into the city centre.

The formerly so vibrant city was silent as the grave. The windows were dark, the doors gaped open, showing empty houses, seemingly abandoned on a moment's notice. Dark fog slithered along the streets.

"This is creepy," Frosta said in low voice.

"I'll keep you safe," Jack said with more bravado than they felt and took her hand, earning themselves a thankful smile.

"Nary a soul walking these empty streets," Sea Hawk commented. "It reminds me of a ship I once found in the southern oceans, sails in tatters and hull covered by molluscs. My crew didn't dare to set foot on it, but ghost or man, Sea Hawk fears no..."

"Shhhhhh!" Bow said and held up his hand. They all pressed against a wall.

On the street in front of them a man walked. His eyes were completely black with shadows. His steps were slow and confused, like a sleep walker. Darkness clung to him like slime.

"Who was that?" Frosta whispered when he had disappeared in the gloom. "I kinda recognized him."

"That was mister Balvak," Bow said with sad voice. "The baker who used to work by that little square by the lake."

"Ooooh, the one with the honey butter cakes?" Frosta said.

"The same," Bow sighed. He pulled an arrow from his quiver. "He might not be able to make those yet for a while, but we can at least keep him out of harms way."

- - -

"What will we do with him?" Frosta asked as they, a short time later, stood in a circle around the tied up, shadow-possessed baker.

"We need to keep him out of the line of the fire," Bow answered. "I had Lonnie assign the blocks by the old cattle market a no firing zone. If we can get him there, we'll keep him out of the Horde bombardment at least."

"Won't he break free?" Frosta objected as the baker struggled against the rope.

"I think I can do something about that," Jack said with slightly shy voice. "Glimmer taught me a trick for situations like this."

They took a deep breath and drew a glyph in the air in front of them. The clumsy lines crafted by a young bandit in a dessert all those months ago had evolved into confident, delicate lines of magic; shining bright without any loss of power, as strong as any student from Mystacor would be able to produce. Bow looked visibly impressed but didn't comment.

Jack took a small step forward and kneeled by the side of the baker. With calm movement they placed the palm on his forehead. His body spasmed once, and then his eyes glassed over and his body immediately became limp.

"What did you do to him?" Sea Hawk asked.

"I put his mind where Shadow Weaver can't get to it," Jack answered, with a voice eerily similar to Glimmer's. "I can't remove her influence, but I can cut him off from the moonstone until Catra and Glimmer are done with the witch."

"You can do that?" Bow asked, mouth open.

"I have the *coolest* joyfriend," Frosta said with a cheeky look at the suddenly extremely flustered Jack.

"Do... don't call me that when we're with people," Jack mumbled, looking down at their shoes.

"Whaaaaat, you *are* my joyfriend because you bring me joy," Frosta said with a smirk and gave Jack a hard side-hug.

"Never deny love, my young friend, whatever form it might take," Sea Hawk said and put a hand on Jack's shoulder.

"You're dating a princess," Bow said with a warm smile - although with a hint of sadness in his eyes. "You can just as well get used to it - they are like this all the time."

"Darn straight we are," Frosta confirmed and gave the embarrassed Jack a kiss on the cheek.

"Either way, I think this will do the trick," Sea Hawk said and lifted the unconscious man as easily as if he had been a bunch of rags. "Now let's go. I fear we will find more opportunity for to you to use that trick before we get to the cattle market."

They sneaked on through the street. Two more times they happened upon wandering citizens, possessed by Shadow Weaver. Both times they quickly apprehended them so Jack could put them to sleep. Sea Hawk had acquired a wheelbarrow to be able to transport all three of them.

Bow peered into the shadows in front of him and waved to the others to come closer.

"We have to cross the parade avenue to get to market district," he whispered. "I can't see anyone. If we hurry we'll make it."

"Of course," Sea Hawk said.

"We're right with you," Frosta agreed.

"I can be fast," Jack pointedly said.

"We won't slow you down," Netossa said.

"Fast as the wind," Spinnerella bragged.

"AAAAAAH!" Bow cried and turned around to stare at the princesses. "Where did YOU come from?"

Netossa and Spinnerella gave him a seriously unimpressed look.

"We've been sneaking around Brightmoon since before any of you were born," Spinnerella said as if it was an explantation.

"Especially when Micah got in his head to court the Brightmoon princess," Netossa smiled in fond memory.

"Anyway, we've lured some of the hostages out of town and knocked them out," Spinnerella said, but it's slow work."

"We got three!" Frosta piped up and pointed at the wheelbarrow.

"Good work there, sport," Netossa said and ruffled her hair.

"But it's too slow," Frosta said mournfully. "We can't save them all one at the time."

Jack squeezed her hand.

"There might be another way," Netossa said, frowning in thought as she listened to the rumble of canons. "If the Horde were to tear down the north wall, that would pull Shadow Weaver' puppets that way to defend the breech."

"...and once there, we can trap them in that part of town by destroying the bridge over the river," Spinnerella finished for her, forming a mini tornado between her hands.

They grinned at each other.

"What do you need us to do?" Bow asked.

"Find the groups furthest from us and pull them our direction," Netossa said.

"We will," Bow promised. "We're going by the cattle market to leave the people we have subdued, then we we'll double back towards the palace."

"Good luck," Netossa said. She put a hand on his shoulder. "We'll manage this."

"Thank you," he whispered.

"We'll activate the trackers Lonnie gave us in about minutes," Spinnerella said. "That should give everyone time to get in position."

"All right. You kids watch your back," Netossa said, and together with Spinnerella she sneaked back into the shadows. Bow, Sea

Hawk, Frosta and Jack hurried on over the avenue.

"The cattle market is right ahead of us," Jack whispered a few minutes later. "I think the coast is clear."

"Right," Bow whispered and aimed a rope-arrow upwards. "I'll keep lookout. The pen is just around the corner. Let's put them in there for now."

Jack nodded once and quickly darted forward. They opened the door and glanced inside.

"It seems empty," they whispered, "but there's a strong smell. There've been animals here recently."

"Shadow Weaver wouldn't keep any cattle around," Sea Hawk objected. "And no one is trading with her."

"Other then the mercenaries hunting princesses for her," Frosta muttered with a voice that clearly held a grudge.

"We'll have to chance it," Bow said from the roof-top. "Until the bridge is down, we won't have a better place to keep people safe, so we... LOOK OUT!"

Even before the last syllable left his lips, Jack had darted out of the doorway and down the street. Sea Hawk, half the way to the pen, dropped the wheelbarrow. Bow had nooked an arrow and stared in horror and fear at the creature that emerged from the pen, eyes yellow, mane blue-tinted and shadows clinging to him like a coat.

"I thought you'd get here, eventually," Swift Wind said with a cruel smile. Then he charged right at Sea Hawk.

"Aaaaah!" Sea Hawk cried, moving like a dancer to keep away from the sharp tip of Swift Wind's horn.

"BACK!" Bow yelled and fired a net arrow, ensnaring the horse's wings.

"You will have to try better than that, *bro*," Swift Wind snorted in derision and - with a stretch of his wings - tore the net to shreds. He reared on his hind legs - causing Sea Hawk to fall backwards - and heaved himself up in the air. He lounged straight towards Bow who struggled in vain to nook another arrow in time.

"ICE WALL!" Frosta yelled and stretched out both her arms, forming a barrier of ice between Bow and the oncoming horse. Swift Wind quickly veered to the side and continued upwards.

"We will save you!" Bow yelled, voice high pitched with fear. He nooked another net arrow and carefully took aim.

"Oh no you won't," Swift Wind said with gleeful voice, twisting and turning in the air to make Bow's aim harder. "You couldn't even save me and Adora at Beast Island. So what makes you think you can do it now?"

"Because now we are not just *one* bro," Sea Hawk answered for him and drew his power sword. "And we will save the day with a rousing soooong!"

His attempted shanty was cut short as Swift Wind turned downwards and unleashed a stream of shadows from the horn. Sea Hawk only narrowly avoided them by throwing himself to the side, but then he did a little roll and jumped to his feet with a cheeky grin.

"Do not think you can horseplay yourself out of this one, my four-footed friend."

A glimmer of a smile could be seen in the edge of Swift Wind's mouth as he abruptly turned upwards, causing Bow's arrow to miss."

"That's right," Sea Hawk yelled after him. "Run! You cannot *whinny* this."

"Any victory will be neighlible," Bow cried, emboldened by Sea Hawk's bravado.

"What are the two of you doing?" Swift Wind said suspiciously, flying in circle over them.

"What's with the long face?" Sea Hawk mocked.

"He can't help it, he was barn with it," Bow quickly quipped.

"Are the two of you stalling?" Swift Wind said with a grin.

"Maybe we should rein it in," Bow suggested in relief and swung down from the roof with a rope attached to a hastily fired arrow.

"Are you kidding?" Sea Hawk laughed. "This is the mane event."

"What are you three dorks doing?" Frosta asked in bewilderment.

"Don't worry about my condition," Swift Wind laughed and landed in front of her. He leered. "I'm *stable*."

"HELLO, STABLE!" Bow and Sea Hawk cried in unison. "WE'RE YOUR BROS!"

They stared at each other. Swift Winds blue eyes were clear from shadows.

"Run!" he said with trembling voice. "She might take me back at any moment, and then..." as he talked, Shadows started to fill up his eyes again.

"Don't worry," Jack said, emerging from their hiding place in an alley, hands already preparing the spell. "By the time Shadow Weaver focuses on you again, I'll make sure you can't..."

"Step back from the horse," a cold voice said.

They looked up, into the dark, shadow-filled eyes of Juliet, the Royal Guard standing behind her.

"Fuck," Frosta said to no one in particular.

"...Juliet," Bow whispered, staring at the shadows that surrounded the captain of the guards. "You recognize me, right?"

"I recognize you as a threat to my queen," Juliet said with a snarl. Bow blinked.

"Juliet..." he carefully said. "Glimmer is..."

"Don't mention that name," Juliet snarled.

"What?" Bow said, taken aback. "Why...?"

"Silence!" Juliet snapped. "And put down the bow. She turned to the guards. "Take the traitor princess. The Queen will..."

"EAT MY BUTT!" Frosta cried, voice full of bravado that almost hid the fear. She detonated a cascade of ice magic, right in front of the guards. For a moment, everyone's field of vision was nothing by sharp shards of ice and snow. Then everyone started screaming and running at the same time.

"ANYONE WHO SEEKS QUARREL WITH THE QUEEN OF SNOW WILL HAVE TO GO THROUGH SEA HAWK!" Sea Hawk yelled, power sword crackling.

"JACK, FROSTA, RUN!" Bow yelled as he fired a net arrow towards the guards.

"I HAVE THEM!" Swift Wind bellowed, his eyes full of shadows again as he bore down on Frosta.

"Don't touch *my* princess!" Jack yelled and unleashed a ball of sparks in Swift Wind's face. As the horse blinked in an attempt to reorient himself, Jack took Frosta's hand and dragged her towards one of the empty houses.

"We can't leave them," Frosta protested.

"We can't let Shadow Weaver possess you," Jack firmly said.

"SWIFT WIND, REMEMBER FRIENDSHIP!" Bow yelled in desperation.

"DON'T LET THE PRINCESS GET AWAY!" Juliet cried and stabbed at Sea Hawk with her glave, forcing him to duck and then quickly do a series of sidestep. She mercilessly followed and prevented him from regain his footing.

"Hands off my *friends*!" Frosta snarled and forced the guards backwards with another burst of ice. She formed large ice-gloves around her hands.

"Don't hurt them!" Bow cried. Frosta hesitated.

"We'll be OK," Bow pleaded. "Really. Just get out of here."

"Come *on*," Jack urged, and reluctantly Frosta followed towards the house.

"Not so fast!" Swift Wind cried, pouncing down on them, only to stare in confusion as the two teenagers melted away into nothing.

"Gotta hand it to Glimmer, she's a good teacher," Bow said in conversational tone and fired a net arrow, ensnaring the horse. "That was a first class illusion."

"This is no illusion," Juliet snarled. She threw her glave right towards Bow. He ducked at the very last minute, and the glave neatly severed the net that held Swift Wind.

"Aha! There was your mistake," Sea Hawk said. "Because now you'll... ouch."

Juliet landed in a crouch, her kick having sent Sea Hawk flying backwards. Before Bow had time to fire another arrow, she had thrown a punch he only managed to divert with his bow in the last possible moment. Juliet bore down on him without mercy, forcing him to walk backwards as she perfectly engaged a routine he knew only too well from endless hours of sparring with the Brightmoon guards.

"Juliet, you don't have to do this," he panted and ducked from a kick that would have smashed his teeth.

"I serve my queen," Juliet said with ice cold voice and gripped his bow, forcing him to aim a kick of his own to get it free.

"Your..." Bow said with confusion. "Shadow Weaver is not your queen. Glimmer..."

"DO NOT MENTION THAT NAME!" Juliet snarled. She took a threatening step forward. "I couldn't protect the princess, but I *will*, protect the queen."

"Glimmer is safe," Bow protested. "She's on her way here."

"Glimmer is *dead* because *I* couldn't protect her," Juliet said, voice full of anguish, shadows dancing in front of her eyes. "I couldn't protect my queen's daughter. I couldn't protect her husband. Her alliance fell apart and now the Horde is coming to take her too from me." The shadows in her eyes flared up. "I WILL NOT ALLOW IT!" she bellowed.

"Um... Bow, a little help?" Sea Hawk cried, desperately fencing with several guards at the same time, his back against a wall.

"Shadow Weaver is attacking," Juliet snarled. "She killed Hordak and took over the Horde, but she has never lost sight of her true goal - she glared at the cloudy moonstone. "She has always envied my queen. She will never rest until she takes everything that belongs to her."

"Juliet..." Bow said as gently as he could. "Angella is dead."

"SILENCE!" Juliet shouted and kicked him hard in the chest. "My Queen is not dead," she yelled. "I will not fail her. I WILL KEEP HER SAFE!"

"*Glimmer* is your Queen," Bow said urgently. "She's alive and she's coming here, with the largest army Etheria has ever seen, to free Brightm..."

For just a heartbeat, Juliet's own eyes could be seen through the shadows. Then the moment was gone and she grabbed Bow in a hard grip, forcing the rest of the sentence to get lost in a pained yelp.

"I've got him," she hissed. "Bring the pirate and let's go."

"What about the princess?" one of the guards asked.

"Swift Wind will find her," Juliet answered with a direct look at the horse, who stood to attention.

"She won't be able to foal me," Swift Wind answered and trotted down the street. Bow blinked and stared at the retreating horse, but then Juliet abruptly shoved him forward.

"Let's move," she spat.

With the guards ushering them forward, Bow and Sea Hawk walked towards the pedestal the carried out the dark glowing moonstone. Every step they took made the shadows around them cling tighter around them.

"Juliet..." Bow said with low voice. "The Horde is on their way."

"We are prepared," Juliet coldly.

"The people of Brightmoon will die," Bow pleaded. "We have to get them out of the way. Outside the walls, if the civilians gather there..."

"The people of Brightmoon are ready to die for our queen," Juliet snarled. "And so am I."

"Angella would never want you to die for her," Bow pleaded. "She'd want you to *save* her people."

Juliet stared at him for a moment, then she quickly looked away.

The reached the moonstone. The guards forced Bow and Sea Hawk down on their knees. Juliet stared at the clouded moonstone for a few moments, then she nodded at the guards.

"Hold the perimeter. Guard the prisoners."

In eerie synchrony, the guards nodded and spread out. Juliet glared at Bow and Sea Hawk.

"Glimmer is dead," she suddenly said.

"Glimmer is alive. She's coming here," Bow answered.

"You're lying," she hissed.

"You know I'm not," he said with low voice. "You know that Shadow Weaver isn't your queen."

"Angella is my queen," Juliet said, voice strained.

"Do you remember Glimmer's coronation?" Bow said, eyes full of compassion. "Remember how Glimmer told you about Angella's message from the crypt? How proud she was of us - how proud she was of *her*."

Juliet closed her eyes, seemingly trying to force herself not to look at Bow. Her fists were clenched.

"We lost her," Bow said, and gently stretched out to touch Juliet's hand. "*You* lost her. I'm so sorry. I... I know what it means to lose someone like that." He sighed.

"Be silent..." Juliet mumbled, her fists trembling.

"But Angella didn't leave us alone," Bow pressed on. "She didn't leave us defenceless. Glimmer took control of the moonstone before, and she can do it again, as soon as..."

"Stop her," Juliet hissed, obviously having to force the words out. "I won't be able to protect her. Not against the *Shadow Queen*."

"You don't have to protect her," Bow said with compassion in his voice. "When she gets here, *she* will protect *you*. All you have to do is to keep her people safe until then."

A loud boom was heard from the city wall. Debris and stones were flung in all direction. An enormous cloud of smoke formed.

"What's that?" Juliet cried.

"Glimmer," Bow answered. "She's coming back."

Another boom was heard.

Juliet looked at Bow for a long moment.

"Onwards!" she yelled at the guards. "To the breech."

The guards hesitantly looked at her and the prisoners.

"I'll deal with the prisoners," Juliet said, steel in her voice. "Now go do the bidding of your queen!"

She waited as the guards hurried off.

"Bow..." she said, forcing the words to leave her lips.

"Juliet!" he said, taking a small step forward to put a hand on her arm.

"Go to my queen," she hissed. "Make sure she doesn't have to face Shadow Weaver alone." Then she quickly started to run. "FOLLOW ME!" she yelled, bringing the rest of the possessed people with her.

In the throne room, high above, a bright, pink flash was seen.

Chapter End Notes

Just one more chapter to go, and then some mop-up in the epilogue.

Queens of Brightmoon

Chapter Notes

Warning: Violence and mild body horror

Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support.

This fic has a tvtrope page now, thanks to the amazing SanaNaryon. Don't hesitate to add to it!

The placeholder name of this chapter was 'Kicking the ass of the witch bitch' and I was dearly tempted to keep it.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra, Adora and Shadow Weaver emerged in the Brightmoon Throne room in a cloud of sparks. Adora sank down to the floor, white in her face.

Outside the window, cannons thundered.

Shadow Weaver spun around and glared in fury at Catra.

"You think you have achieved..." she begun, but Catra interrupted her by jumping her, claws first.

"FOR ONCE IN YOUR FUCKING LIFE, SHUT UP!" she snarled, shredding Shadow Weaver's cloak and barely missing the flesh underneeth her. She jumped to the side as a shadowy tentacle reached for her.

Shadow Weaver gave her a look of utter loathing.

"Your pathetic attempts at..." she said, but Catra bounded against the wall and jumped back, aiming for Shadow Weaver's head.

"SHUT UP!" she screamed and gave Shadow Weaver a hard enough kick to shatter her mask. As the pieces fell to the floor,

Catra was flung backwards as if she had received an electric shock.

"You worthless parasite," Shadow Weaver snarled, voice full of venom. Shadows boiled around her scarred face. She teleported away from Catra's next attack and re-emerged on the top step of the throne floating outside the castle wall.

"Look who's talking," Catra snarled back, dodging a shadow that reached for her. "You've never done anything but mooching on some kid or another. Or did you plan to give back my *wife's* rock anytime soon?" She nodded at the Moonstone through the window, shadows churning and boiling around it and the pedestal it resided on.

"You are not worthy of her," Shadow Weaver snarled. She made a gesture, and the mask re-formed over her face. She sat down on the throne. "And I'm done wasting my time on you." She nodded at Adora, who still sat on the floor, staring at them with eyes full of fear. "Kill her."

Adora jerked like if she had been a marionette doll who suddenly received a tug of the strings. With obvious effort she forced herself to sit down.

"No..." she whispered.

Shadow Weaver gave her a hard look.

"What did you say?" she asked, voice sharp as eyes. Shadows poured from her, surrounding the woman on the floor.

"I... I don't want to hurt... her," Adora whispered, pale in her face. Tears emerged in her eyes. "Please... don't hurt..."

"You ungrateful slip of a girl!" Shadow Weaver hissed. "I have a destiny for you more grand than anything you can imagine."

Adora struggled to get away from the shadows, tears running down her cheeks.

"Please," she wept. "All I want is... my friends... not hurting..."

"Your mind has been utterly poisoned," Shadow Weaver snarled. She made a gesture, and the shadows poured over the crying woman. "Luckily, I have no need for it. Your body is enough to suffice to unlock to the Heart of Etheria."

"Please!" Adora sobbed, but her voice died out in a gurgle as shadows poured down her throat and entered through her nose, her ears and her eyes. For a moment she spasmed, then she stood up, moving jerkily like a marionette doll.

"Let her go!" Catra snarled, evading the shadows that reached for her.

"I will not," Shadow Weaver sniffed. "If she's too weak to get rid of you by herself, I will *make her* do it. Maybe that will finally put her foolishness to an end."

And with that, Adora leapt and landed right in front of Catra, staff in hand and face full of shadows.

"You fucking bitch," Catra snarled at Shadow Weaver and jumped backward as Adora - tears still streaming down her face, expression a mask of terror - struck the staff at her chest.

"Your juvenile insults will soon be as irrelevant as your entire life has been," Shadow Weaver said in calm fury.

Adora moved jerkily, but she was fast and horribly strong. It was clear that the shadows that possessed her body strained the muscles to their limit. Catra avoided the next attack and scrambled towards a wall and up a tapestry. With narrow eyes she estimated the distance to Shadow Weaver's throne, but before she had time to jump a half-strangled croak from Adora warned her to abandon her position, and the moment after, the spot where she just had clung to was hit by Adora's staff, flung with force enough that it would have shattered her skull had she been one moment slower.

"Catra, run!" Adora managed to hiss before her mouth was clamped shut.

"I'm not leaving you!" Catra snarled and made a jump towards the steps to the throne, but yet again she had to abandon the effort when Adora rushed forth and aimed a kick at her. Catra walked two quick step backwards blocking Adora's blows as she did.

"I should have done this a long time ago," Shadow Weaver said from the throne, clearly amused.

"I hate you," Adora whispered through gritted teeth, glaring at Shadow Weaver. She managed to get Catra out of balance, and her fist shot forward as if fired from a canon. Catra tried to block but was to slow. She felt the fist connecting, but in the very last moment, Adora forced her arm to the right, her fist only glancing Catra's face. Adora cried out in pain, white in her face.

"There's no use fighting it," Shadow Weaver mocked. "You *will* kill her, and then perhaps we can steer you towards a worthwhile goals.

"Won't hurt her..." Adora whispered, her entire body trembling as she tried to force herself to stop the vicious attacks.

Catra sought her eyes, and gradually she slowed down, stopped trying to get away, focusing only on dodging and blocking.

"You won't hurt me," Catra said with soothing voice.

"I can't help it," Adora sobbed, forcing her mouth to form the words.

Catra shook her head, blocking a blow aimed for her face.

"You won't hurt me, because I won't let her use you any more," she said with warm voice. "You won't hurt me, or anyone, because I will stop you."

Adora stared at her, her whole body trembling.

"Promise?" she asked in a little girls voice.

"Promise," Catra calmly answered.

Adora closed her eyes for a moment, and when she opened them, they were completely blue, without any trace of Shadows.

"Catra," she whispered. "You and Glimmer..."

"Yeah?" Catra said, not entirely without trepidation.

"Get that bitch!" Adora said with a grin, and when her fist shot forward, she strained against it.

"What are you doing?" Shadow Weaver spat as shadows welled up in Adora's eyes again.

"Fuck you," Adora hissed between gritted teeth. Her fist shot forward again - Catra did no attempt to block or evade it - and this time Adora successfully held against it, her fist trembling a few inches from Catra's face.

"KILL HER!" Shadow Weaver yelled from her throne.

"NEVER!" Adora yelled back. Her legs moved in a kick, but Adora strained against her own muscles, until suddenly she yelled in pain as muscles pulling against ligaments snapped.

"What are you *doing*?" Shadow Weaver yelled in bewilderment as Adora sank to the floor.

"Not hurting..." Adora mumbled, the shadows fighting uselessly to regain entry into her head. "...not hurting anymore..."

And she closed her eyes.

Shadow Weaver stood up from her throne, staring at the unconscious woman on the floor.

"What have you done?" she asked, the cold fury in her voice not entirely hiding the confusion and fear.

"Would you look at that," Catra taunted. "Seems like not even your golden child want to play your games any more."

Shadow Weaver took a hard step down the steps, a dome of light rushing forth and knocking Catra over.

"What it *seems like*," Shadow Weaver snarled walked forward down the steps, a sphere of lighting forming around the palm of her hand, "is that I have to do everything myself, as always."

"Take your best..." Catra begun, but at that moment an arrow whistled right between two fingers of Shadow Weavers hand. She gasped in surprise and stared at Bow who stood in the doorway to the throne-room with two arrows nooked to his bow and pointing straight at Shadow Weaver.

"You missed, archer," she hissed.

"That was a warning shot," he calmly said. "The next one won't be."

"Hah!" Shadow Weaver laughed and took another step forward, preparing another ball of lighting. "You don't have the..."

Bow fired. Shadow Weaver quickly formed a protective shield, but the arrows flew far over her head. They neatly severed the velvet ropes holding a heavy drapery. It fell towards Shadow Weaver and knocked her to the ground, covering her completely.

"Go, go, go!" Bow yelled as he and Sea Hawk ran past Catra and the cursing Shadow Weaver. They hurriedly threw the content of the buckets they carried on the throne.

"What do you two imbeciles think you are *doing*?" Shadow Weaver spat as she teleported out from under the drapery. She stared nonplussed at Sea Hawk who had produced a torch. "The throne is made of *stone*."

"Ah, my shadowy adversary," Sea Hawk said with a grin and casually tossed the torch at the throne, causing the liquid to catch

flames. "But there is one thing you have failed to consider."

"And what would that be?" Shadow Weaver asked, voice dripping with scorn.

"We don't aim to *burn* your stolen throne as such," Sea Hawk went on, casually kicking the drapery towards the flames.

"Then what *are* your feeble attempts?" Shadow Weaver asked with furious voice, another ball of lighting forming around her hands.

"Distracting you," Bow grinned and nooked a grappling hook arrow. "Worked like a charm."

"What are..." Shadow Weaver begun with a suspicious look at the the bewildered Catra, then she spun around with a curse.

Behind her, Swift Wind - free from the shadows - had managed to get the unconscious Adora to his back and started to run through the room, towards a large window.

"HOW DID YOU GET FREE?" Shadow Weaver snarled and tossed the ball of lighting after them.

"Sacred bond!" Swift Wind yelled, ducked the lighting and threw himself through the window, immediately flying out of line of sight.

"GO, BRO!" Sea Hawked cheered.

"I suppose it doesn't need saying," Bow said with casual voice, firing his grappling hook arrow, "but Angella was a way better queen then you."

And with that, he grabbed Sea Hawk and they quickly grabbled upwards, away from the enraged Shadow Weaver.

"You know," Catra said with taunting voice, "I start to get what Adora sees in those dorks. They kinda grow on you, don't you

agree."

"Those ingrained trouble makers will not..." Shadow Weaver snarled, light playing over her fists.

"Don't you get it?" Catra shot back, walking up to Shadow Weaver. "You lost your hold on the temple hologram, you lost Adora *and* her sword. You've lost the princesses, and we have the entire fucking Horde coming for your gut." As to put emphasis on her point, a huge explosion was heard as a section of the wall exploded. "You have lost." She gave Shadow Weaver her most infuriating smirk. "'mom'."

Shadow Weaver opened her mouth, but before she had time to answer, a huge explosion was heard and flames flared up from the garden, below the throne room. Shadow Weaver stared at the burning inferno, face locked in a mask of fury.

"Nice night for a little camp fire," Catra taunted. "Isn't it *cheerful*?"

For a moment it looked like Shadow Weaver would rush Catra and strangle her. Then she forced herself to remain under control.

"You are right," she said with forced calm voice. "You are completely right, Catra. I have over-reached. I have put an overly high stock in the rationality of *children*, and now I pay the price in the form of yet another tiresome tantrum."

She sighed.

"It will be... troublesome to realign the conditions. I have a lot of regrouping and rethinking to do."

She gave Catra a look of pure, undiluted hatred.

"In the meanwhile, I think it's time I take some time off, blow some steam..." A pink glow of energy formed around her hands.

"I will kill you, Catra," she said with almost gentle voice. "I will kill you, like I should have done from the very start. It has always

seem like slightly more bother than it's worth, but this time... this time it's time I do something for *me*."

Catra managed to jump in the last moment as the ball of lighting exploded, just where her head had been.

"Don't run," Shadow Weaver hissed and teleported to just behind Catra, forcing her to scramble madly to get away. "We both knew it would end like this. I just wished I had done it sooner."

- - -

"Tell me, Glimmer, why are you here?" Micah asked in conversational tone as he slowly scanned the chamber around him for his daughter's whereabouts. In his hand was a sphere of pure darkness.

"You know why," Glimmer's voice echoed from her hiding place. "To regain my throne."

Micah took two quick steps and detonated the sphere down a small nook that turned out to be empty.

"Missed me," Glimmer's mocking laughter could be heard. Micah spun around just in time to shield a pink sphere hurling his way.

"But it's not really your throne, is it?" he continued, quickly regaining his composure. "By right of succession, after Angella's death, her *husband* stand to take the throne."

"*Only* until the crown princess is fit to take the power of the Moonstone," Glimmer answered with pedantic voice.

Micah grinned, a devilish grin on his shadow tainted face.

"Well, there's the rub then, isn't it, 'baby girl'. You are nowhere fit to yield that power.

Glimmer emerged from thin air, right above him. A beam of power emerged from her hands, but before they connected, Micah had

melted into the shadows.

"We will see about that, won't we?" Glimmer snarled as she turned around, the beam scorching the walls of the chamber.

"Yes, we will, 'pumpkin'," Micah's voice said from nowhere.

- - -

"Do you know what my problem is?" Shadow Weaver said with conversational tone.

"Do you *really* want me to answer that?" Catra panted, running down the corridor.

"I'm way too sentimental," Shadow Weaver answered and fired a bolt of energy towards the hastily fleeing Catra. "I hold on to things for too long after they have served their purpose."

"And with 'things' I assume you mean 'people'?" Catra asked, jumping out through a window and clawing herself down the wall to the next floor.

"People, things, mindsets, what's the difference?" Shadow Weaver said as she emerged out of thin air and fired another bolt.

"If you knew the answer to that question, a lot of things would have been different," Catra cried and ducked behind a corner.

"No, I have been way to lenient," Shadow Weaver sighed. "I simply should have murdered a lot more people from the start. I can't believe such a simple solution has been staring me in the face this long."

"Stand down!" Netossa cried as she jumped through a window, engulfing Shadow Weaver in a magical net.

"Like you, for example," Shadow Weaver said and teleported out of the net. She emerged right next to Netossa. "A little non-

elemental princess with one little trick. Completely inconsequential for the big picture. Why should I keep you alive?"

Before Netossa had the time to answer, Shadow Weaver touched her arm, teleporting both of them away. Catra saw how they emerged far above them in the sky.

"There, a much more tidy solution," Shadow Weaver said with satisfaction as she formed a cloud of shadows for herself to float on, with Netossa falling screaming towards the ground far, far below. She quickly summoned a net held above her as a parachute.

"Let go of my w..." Spinnerella begun as she bore down on Shadow Weaver carried by a typhoon.

"How tiresome," Shadow Weaver sighed and teleported away, emerging just behind Spinnerella. She detonated a huge ball of energy and teleported away as Spinnerella desperately tried to get control over her winds.

"See," Shadow Weaver said happily as she teleported back to Catra. "My life is already simpler."

"I hate to be the one to tell you," Catra cried and ducked another lighting ball, "but murder tends to make things more complicated in the long run."

"Only if you're a quitter," Shadow Weaver sniffed. She perked up as Frosta rushed towards her, ice fist ready. "Like this impudent child, for example. I went to so much trouble bending the minds of the spoiled royal brats. I'll simply murder every single elemental princess and wait for the runestones to attach themselves to a new royal line instead. Then I can mould the offspring as I please."

Frosta yelped with fear as shadowy tendrils engulfed her and constricted around her throat.

"Why is your solution to every problem child abuse!" Catra cried and rushed forth to attack Shadow Weaver.

"*And* murder," Shadow Weaver pedantically added, teleporting to the other side in the room. She sighed in heavy disappointment as Jack emerged from behind a veil and shattered the magic that was suffocating Frosta with their staff.

"Another complication," she moaned. "It's really long overdue to tidy up around here." She caught Jack in a purple force field, but a moment later she stumbled backwards to avoid Catra's claws in her face, the feline seemingly having teleported herself by the power of sheer rage.

"Hands. Off. My. *Kid*!" Catra snarled.

"Oh?" Shadow Weaver said pleasantly after having teleported to the other side of the room. "I was going to kill you first, but perhaps I'll do it in the opposite order." She turned to Jack, who just slipped under another magical veil and rolled her eyes. "Please, do not insult me with such shoddy work," she said and scattered the illusion.

"DON'T TOUCH THEM!" Frosta yelled hurling a block of ice the size of the Brightmoon throne towards Shadow Weaver, who simply teleported away.

"This is turning tiresome," Shadow Weaver said and lifted her arms towards the moonstone. Immediately shadows started to boil and churn.

She caught Catra's eyes.

"I tell you, Catra. I should have murdered a lot of people a long time ago." She smiled. "Time to make up for lost time."

- - -

Magical energies swirled and churned in the small chamber. In the middle of them, Glimmer and her father glared at each other, the

fight at an impasse.

"Face it, 'darling daughter'," Micah mocked. "Shadow Weaver has a better claim to the throne than you ever did."

"You *must* be kidding me," Glimmer panted.

"Why?" Micah said with insincere voice. "She holds the castle, she's connected to the runestone. What claim for legitimacy do you have that she lacks?"

"I will do what's right for our people," Glimmer snarled. "*All* of them."

"Oh, Shadow Weaver will do that too," Micah smirked. "Just you wait. She'll do what's right for all of Etheria!"

And the duel raged on.

- - -

"You see," Catra, Shadow Weaver happily said as tendrils of shadows coiled around Catra's throat. "Such an elegant... eh?"

An explosion was heard, and the large doors leading into the main hall of the castle was blown from its hinges. A moment later, Rogelio was through the door, blaster in hand. He quickly looked around, growled and was joined by the rest of his squad, fanning out in all directions. Catra managed to break the grip of the shadows and slipped away.

"Another distraction," Shadow Weaver sighed and teleported right in front of the force captain. "I simply have to..."

The moment she appeared, Rogelio and the rest of the squad threw themselves to the floor. The next moment a huge detonation was heard and the middle of the main hall had turned into a smoking crater.

"*Now* what?" Shadow Weaver whined as she appeared next to Catra.

"That would be a little gift from Kyle, manning the cannons over by the ships," Catra panted.

"I really never thought that boy consequential enough to kill," Shadow Weaver mused. "Still, one live and learn - except all of you that is, because I will kill you."

"FOR THE QUEEN!" a group of ladies-in-waiting screamed rushing forth, each with a glyph shimmering in the air before them.

"Yes, yes," Shadow Weaver said with uninterested voice and made a gesture that scattered the glyphs and sent the ladies-in-waiting flying, smacking into the walls.

She turned to Catra again, only to realize that the infernal feline had scampered down the corridor. Shadow Weaver furiously stalked along the corridor, blowing up everything that moved and quite a lot of things that didn't.

"You're just prolonging the inevitable," she sneered.

Then, through the smoke she spotted a lonely person, much too small to be her prey. She walked closer, and then narrowed her eye in suspicion as she recognized a little kitten she hadn't seen in a long, long time.

- - -

"Shadow Weaver really is scraping at the bottle of the barrel if she thinks this tired old spiel will stop me," Glimmer snarled, taking a moment to extinguish the flames in her cape.

The chamber was completely wrecked. The walls were singed by magic. Glimmer's skin was shining like she had been a tiny star. Micah stood in the other side of the chamber, darkness swirling around him like a miniature tornado.

"Oh," Micah said, forming another glyph in the air. "And why is that?"

"Because I've heard it all before," Glimmer said scornfully and dismissed Micah's glyph with a gesture. "How I'm not good enough for the throne. How I have no right to decide the fates of others. How my transgressions and mistakes will forever disqualify me from the throne of my mother."

"And it's wrong, is it?" Micah said, tentacles of darkness reaching out for his daughter.

"Of course it isn't," Glimmer snorted. "I *have* done horrible things and I *am* not any more rightful as a ruler than anyone else. The only reason me and Catra are in any position to order people around is that we beat up anyone who tried to stop us."

"Then what's the difference between you and the Shadow Queen?" Micah leered.

"Well, for one *I* don't need to literately mind-control people to make my case," Glimmer said sweetly. She teleported away from the approaching tentacles and unleashed another ball of lighting towards her father.

"Mind control, threat of violence, coercion; I fail to see the difference," Micah said and deflected Glimmer's attack.

"You will," Glimmer said. "Once the battle is won and *I* have taken back my runestone, *everyone* will know who has the power to rule this world - and who hasn't."

"It all comes down to power then," Micah said.

"Of course," Glimmer said. "How could the control of our planet NOT be about power. But what Shadow Weaver has never understood is that power runs in both directions."

"And just what is that supposed to mean?" Micah mocked. Glimmer watched him intently.

"If you of all people have to ask that, Shadow Weaver has really failed to get into your head."

"Really?" Micah said, eyes narrowing as he drew his power around him - a malestrom of darkness.

"You know," Glimmer mused. "All this time I've had to be so *careful*."

"That's just another way to say 'coward'," Micah taunted.

"All the power in the world, and no outlet," Glimmer went on like if he hadn't spoken. "It's eating me up."

Glimmer grinned, power radiating from her entire being.

"Auntie Casta likes to say that you are the world's most powerful sorcerer. That's quite a claim. Should be able to take quite a bit of magic, don't you think?" She smiled softly. "I just want you to know, daddy, that I love you. And I *promise* to patch you up afterwards."

For just a moment, Micah gave Glimmer a proud look, through the shadows in his eyes. Then he screamed in pure anguish as magic flooded into him from his daughter in a never-ending torrent of power.

- - -

"I only wanted your love," the kitten said with small voice, looking at Shadow Weaver with almost comically huge eyes.

"I provided for you," Shadow Weaver snorted. "But it was never enough."

"*I* was never enough," the kitten angrily retorted. "You only had eyes for Adora."

The creature morphed in a cloud of blackness, turning to an image of a young Adora.

"I loved you, mommy," the little girl said. "But I loved her too. Why couldn't you allow me and Catra to be happy?"

"Adora had potential the like you can never understand," Shadow Weaver calmly said. "Catra was in her way,"

"The fuck I was," the creature snarled and stood up. As they did, their body changed again, and a moment later the adult Catra stood in front of Shadow Weaver, her red mask framing a furious scowl.

"I would have done anything for you," she snarled. "I would have taken Brightmoon for you and handed you the princesses on a silver platter for a pat on the head if you had just let me."

"You greatly overestimate your capabilities," Shadow Weaver answered, strangely transfixed by the display. The creature changed again, this time taking the guise of Micah's daughter.

"You are one to talk," 'Glimmer' said. "For all your talk about teaching me magic, all you did was scheme and plot and stab me in the back as soon as an opportunity presented itself.

"And a most valuable lesson had it been too, if you only had applied yourself rather than letting your hormones do the talking."

"I applied myself," the creature said, this time in young Micah's guise. "And you threw me away. You betrayed us for the enemy."

"You were a lazy, spoiled brat, completely undeserving of your gifts," Shadow Weaver said with sharp voice. "Much like your wife and daughter."

"I gave Micah what you never could," the creature said, turning into Angella. "I gave Adora what you never would."

"Spare me the sordid details of you wasting their potential," Shadow Weaver sniffed. "You were given it all, but far too craven to ever wield what you had."

"Unlike me?" a new voice said, rich and deep, and for just a moment Shadow Weaver's heart skipped a beat when she looked at a face she thought she would never see again.

"I have worked with unparalleled determination for decades," Shadow Weaver said, unable to completely hide her voice wavering. "I have walked paths unknown to my peers, and I have reached heights that none but me have ever dared."

"You have achieved nothing," 'Light Spinner' said, her veil not hiding a scornful smirk. "You found a rat hole to hide in, sucking like a tick on stolen runestones and removing yourself from any position of actual influence, all because of your pride."

"I have sacrificed everything!" Shadow Weaver shouted.

"And gained nothing," 'Light Spinner' mocked. "You could have had it all. Fame, prestige, a seat by the power. You saw the Horde for the threat it was, you could provide aid and advice unparalleled. The people and the princesses both would have loved you and followed you, but you squandered it all for a desperate, ill advised dash for power and for being too proud to turn to others for help."

"They turned from me," Shadow Weaver said between gritted teeth.

"*You* turned from *them*," 'Light Spinner' taunted her. "Big surprise. If you ask me, you just waited for an opportunity, because - let's face it," -'she' leaned forward, an insincere smirk behind 'her' veil- "That's just the kind of bitch you are."

Shadow Weaver regarded the creature in front of her with hatred in her eyes. Then she took a deep breath visibly calming herself.

"Yes," she said, voice steady. "I *am* that kind of 'bitch'. I *am* the person who refused to comply when those stuck in their limited worldview sought to hold me back. I *am* the teacher who offered excellence and accepted nothing less. I *am* the one worthy person

in this world of wielding its magic, and I *will* save our planet, regardless if anyone will thank me or not."

She made a disdainful gesture, detonating a ball of sparkles large as her head at the feet of the creature who yelped and jumped backwards. "So cease your jabbering, changeling," she snarled, detonating another ball, flinging Double Trouble into the stone wall, causing them to regain their own shape as they fell unconscious. Shadow Weaver spun around.

"And as for you," she sneered, catching the real Catra who hurled herself towards her, claws first, "I hope this little melodrama was to your liking, because it will have to count as your last word.

"Fuck you," Catra whispered, fighting uselessly against the pink force field that pressed her towards the floor, pressing the air out of lung, crushing her.

"The sheer gall of you has never changed," Shadow Weaver hissed, walking up to her, a sphere of power in her hand to bright too look directly at. "To presume you could best ME!"

Catra - held immobilized by the magic force that crushed her like it had been a snake - started to chuckle.

"Oh no, mommy dearest," she smirked with the last air in her lungs. "I never tried to *kill* you. I just tried to *distract* you. Worked like a charm, too."

Shadow Weavers eyes narrowed.

"What do you..."

And that was the exact moment when the light from the Moonstone changed.

Although 'changed' does really not convey what happened. The Moonstone under Shadow Weavers regime was clouded in shadows, like an overcast night sky. Now, without any warning

whatsoever, the shadows shattered and the light turned bright white.

But again, that does not really convey the magnitude of the light.

Imagine staring at the dimmest of diodes in an otherwise pitch dark room and suddenly having it replaced with a 1000 Watt halogen light.

Imagine spending a year underground and stepping out in the bright sun.

Imagine emerging from the darkness of space to see the stars for the first time.

Imagine wrapping your very essence in shadows, and then one day see Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon, radiant and furious, wings spread wide, stepping out of the runestone that's belongs to her by birthright to challenge all that you have built.

Well, Shadow Weaver didn't have to imagine that last part.

Catra could see the light moving like - well - lighting through the air, through the connection that Shadow Weaver had forged between herself and the Moonstone. It crashed into her like... well, lighting again and made the witch fly through the room and painfully smash into the opposite wall. The magic lost it's grip on Catra and she landed on all fours on the floor. as she stood up, Glimmer stood beside her, glowing like the sun with seemingly no ill effects. Catra took her hand. She could *feel* the power flowing through her wife.

Who's a looser now, mommy?

"The Moonstone is *mine*," Glimmer said, voice deadly calm.

"You can't..." Shadow Weaver gasped, quickly forming a glyph. Glimmer snorted in disdain and shattered it with the smallest of gestures.

"You have no idea what you have set in motion!" Shadow Weaver gasped, staring at the first-ones writing forming in Glimmer's skin. "With the Arachnidan brat connected to the Black Garnet... without the hologram under my control... and now with you re-connected to the Moonstone, you have given Light Hope everything she needs."

"A balanced Etheria," Glimmer said calmly as first one's writing spread over her body and face. "That was the plan, wasn't it?"

"You have to give me back control!" Shadow Weaver yelled, her voice cracking with fear. "Light Hope will cast us out of Despondos. She will unleash the Heart of Etheria, dooming us all, and even if you could stop her, that will deliver us to *Horde Prime*."

"No," Glimmer said in calm fury. "I won't allow it."

She held up her hand as a fist, silhouetted by the light streaming from her runestone.

Then she squeezed.

The impression lasted for a moment, just a fleeting moment, and then all that light were sucked up, back into the Moonstone.

And it cracked.

There was not a single sound. Even the thunder from the Horde cannons seemed completely muted.

Fragments of glitter fell like snow to the ground, no piece larger than a thumbnail.

When they could see clearly again, Glimmer stood before them. Only Glimmer. Her skin free from light and first one's writing. No power, no pain.

"What have you done?!" Shadow Weaver cried, clawing after the last, fleeting strands of light as they slunk out of her grip.

"I have taken *my* runestone off the grid," Glimmer said with light voice. "As is my right. Without it, Light Hope can not access the Heart of Etheria, and neither can *you*."

"You are mad!" Shadow Weaver snarled. "You'll be completely powerless. Completely *useless*."

"A price worth paying," Glimmer said with a cocky smile.

"What it *means* is that there's finally no reason for me not to kill *you*, little brat," Shadow Weaver hissed and rushed forward, hands held before her like claws, surrounded by shadows.

The temperature in the room sunk several degrees.

That's not a metaphor.

That's what happens when you piss off the Queen of the Kingdom of Snow enough and she decides to register a complaint.

"YOU BIG JERK!" Frosta yelled, and with a very satisfying, crunching sound punched Shadow Weaver so hard she flew across the room and smacked into the wall. She was promptly encased in ice.

"You are still the leader of the princess alliance," Spinnerella said as she entered the room. "That has never been about power."

"And you will always be *my* queen," Catra said - no trace of sarcasm in her voice. Glimmer gave her a thankful look and hugged her hard.

They just stood there, holding each other and listening to the Horde canons, as it slowly started to sink in that they had won.

Chapter End Notes

> For the longest time, I intended this to be a simple power fantasy which ended with Glimmer recovering her awesome magical might to beat the crap out of Shadow Weaver. Then

stupid Catra started angsting about Glimmer going to the dark side and thus I ended up ending this - the crown jewel of my Evil Glimmer series - with the power of friendship saving the day.

Bow is most smug, I'm sure.

Ah well.

Thanks for sharing this journey with me. Only the epilogue to go.

Epilogue

Chapter Notes

> Thanks as always to The Frank for help and endless support and for being with me throught this entire work.
>
> Don't hesitate to add to this fic's tvtrope page. Thanks to the amazing SanaNaryon.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"So this is Brightmoon," Lonnie said and looked around with an unimpressed look, clipboard in hand. "Hardly worth all the bother, if you ask me."

"Just wait till we show you the indoor waterfalls," Glimmer smiled as she sat on the floor and leaned against the least destroyed wall.

"Do I want to know?" Lonnie asked with dry voice and made a little note on her clipboard.

"You have to let go of us eventually, you know Adora," Catra said, voice slightly strained as Adora clung to her and Glimmer in a tight, two-armed hug.

"I do NOT know that," Adora firmly said, voice slightly muffled from her mouth being pressed against Glimmer's hair. "The way I see it, it's the moment I let either of you out of my sight that things go to shit. Now I'll just hold onto you forever and everything will be fine."

Catra rolled her eyes,

But she leaned in to get more comfortable in the hug.

Jack and Frosta sat in a corner, holding each other's hand and talking with low voices.

Perfuma was pale and thin, but she looked happy and herself as she rested in Scorpia's arms, apparently having no intention whatsoever to let the severely flustered scorpion princess put her down any time soon. Emily trotted around them, with Entrapta tripping after her, trying to adjust a damaged gyro.

Micah was put on a Horde stretcher, badly damaged but alive. He looked around with eyes full of wonder, clearly debating whether or not to believe his eyes. Next to him stood Spinnerella and Netossa together wtih Juliet and the royal guard, pale but themselves.

Mermista and Sea Hawk stood leaning against a wall, with Double Trouble standing just a bit too close to them for decency. Bow brushed Swift Wind. The horse was thin as a skeleton but beamed with joy and talked with loud voice about the virtue of apples to recover from possession.

A group of Horde soldiers and ladies-in-waiting stood by the door, congratulating each other on being alive.

Glimmer let her gaze travel over the assembly. She let out a shivering sigh.

"Welcome home, my Queen," she said with low voice to Catra. "I just wish it had been under more romantic circumstances."

"Are you kidding," Catra happily said. "Beating the shit out of a place and everyone in it is how we got our last two cribs, isn't it?"

"Well, this time we're staying!" Glimmer firmly said. She stood up a bit wobbly and held out her hand. Adora very reluctantly let go of them and sat up against the wall, as much as her damaged leg allowed.

"My Queen?" Glimmer said.

"My Queen," Catra answered with warm voice and took her hand. For a moment nothing happened, then Glimmer let out an annoyed sigh.

"Not being able to teleport will take some getting used to," she muttered.

"You'll do great," Bow loyally said.

"I'll do better than great," Glimmer smiled. "With all of you in my corner."

She took a few, slightly hobbling steps and stepped up together with Catra on the first step of the throne.

"My friends," she simply said, addressing the room. "We won."

"Huzza!" Sea Hawk bellowed. Mermista fondly smirked at him.

"The world has been at war for as long as any of us have lived," Glimmer went on. "As of today, that war is over, and we stand as the winners."

"Go us," Mermista said and rolled her eyes.

"Now we will do something much harder," Glimmer went on.

"And what is that, my Queen?" Double Trouble smirked, never one to deny someone a straight line.

"Peace," Glimmer said.

She eyed the assembly with serious expression.

"It will be more difficult than anything any of us has ever done. Old injustices need to be addressed, grievances aired, inequalities bridged; a new future built."

"Or, hear me out," Catra drawled, "we could just go back to be bandits again."

"We are not running from our responsibilities any longer," Glimmer smiled. "This time, we put in the work, and we do it right."

"Sure, if you're going to be all cute about it, I might tag along," Catra shrugged, her flippant tone not entirely hiding the very warm love in her voice.

Glimmer moved her gaze over the assembly.

"We *all* need to build this new future. Together. When Horde Prime finally finds his way here, he will face something this world have not seen since the days of the First Ones. He will find a united Etheria."

"You know we're with you," Bow said with heartfelt voice to various cheers from the others.

Glimmer squeezed Catra's hand. Catra smiled at her, a tender, proud smile.

Together Catra and Glimmer ascended the throne of Brightmoon.



Art by [Lorvikk]

Chapter End Notes

Aaaaaand Scene.

Please click here for the tumblr exclusive final curtain call with the cast

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!